

The Age of the Kingdom

LINN AN DEALACHAIDH

The Legendarium OF DIA-THÌR

— The Age of the Kingdom

(An Aois Rìoghachd)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Severance Era, SE 1 – 71

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PART ONE

Of the Settling

CHAPTER ONE

Of the Winter of the Severance

I AM FAOILLEACH, AE 151 (AS MEMORY) – 3 AN T-
ÒGMHIOS, SE 1

I

Of the Last Ships

It is told at Muileann chaol, from the boxed rolls of that winter, how the Age of Strangers ended: not in a battle won, for the battle had been won already, but in an emptiness where ships had been.

Five beacons stood on the capes in those days, from Baile chrom round to Tobar dhearg, kept against the humans' crossing, and each kept its own daybook. On the first morning of that year the keepers wrote the same four words, one after another down the coast, as if the news had to be said five times before anyone could believe it: *Cha tàinig long*. No ship came. It had not come the morning before either, nor the morning before that, but this was the morning the keepers stopped expecting one, and a daybook that stops expecting a thing is the surest record there is that the thing has ended.

Over the eastern water, wherever it led, the last of the humans' ships had gone out and not come back for more of their own. Those left on Dia-thìr, some thousands of them, were put on the roads north under the victors' guard, in the worst cold of the year, and the columns that had been an army's business all autumn became a walking business of old men, women, children and the sick, strung out between the escorts on foot. Of the day itself little is told beyond the counting, for a column on the move makes a poor subject for a tale, and a hungry one makes a worse one. It is remembered only that the mud on the north roads that winter

was said to be knee-deep the whole way, and that it was still called so by the old people two generations after, though no one living had walked it.

The victors, for their part, spent that same winter in a kind of astonishment that outlasted their war. They had fought the humans' administration for years, in the hills and the pit-towns and along the coast roads, and had grown so used to the fighting that the winning of it left them, for a season, with less to do than they had ever had before. The captains who had led companies through the last hard campaigns found themselves that am Faoilleach standing in doorways at Cathair dhearg with nothing pressing to command, while the council's few surviving clerks tried to make sense of an administration's worth of papers left behind by men who had sailed away rather than burn them. It is said that for the first fortnight after the last ship went out, no order of any weight was issued from the council at all, since no one among them could agree who now held the standing to issue one.

That was the Severance, by the name it wears in every book since. Of what it cost the two peoples who lived through it, this book has little new to add: the columns that went north, the count kept badly or not at all of who did not finish the road, the emptiness the south felt at first as victory and only slowly, over years, as something else. It begins instead with a clerk on a horse, going the same road the columns had gone, three months behind them, with a satchel of blank paper and a tally to keep, sent because the council, having no better idea what a peace required of it, had decided at least to count.

II

Of the Guard at the Heads of the Roads

Ailean mac Iain was twenty-five that spring, a hill-born man of the council's service, named, as many of his generation were, for a king no one now living had seen crowned. He had spent the war years copying muster-rolls in a tent behind the lines, and he had never yet ridden further north than the market at Baile Mòr mhòr. When the council sent its guard up to stand at the heads of the north roads, where the columns had gone in winter and where it now meant to keep the ones still left from wandering back south, Ailean rode with them as tally-clerk, to count what passed and write it down.

He found the work simpler than he had feared and duller than he had hoped. A guard-post was set at each of the roads that ran north out of the settled country, a captain and a dozen men at each, and Ailean's business was to ride between them with a book, entering what the guard reported: how many had come through going north that week, how many turned back, how many were sick past walking and left to be carried by their own people. In three weeks he filled eleven pages and crossed out nothing, for the council had told him plainly that a clean page was worth more to them than a fast one.

The road itself taught him more than the tally did. He rode it in the last hard weeks of winter, when the hedges were black and the burns ran the colour of strong tea, past farms whose byres stood empty because their stock had gone to feed the war and their hands had gone with the columns or with the companies, one direction or the other. At one such farm, a half-day short of the first guard-post, an old woman came out to the gate to ask him, in *Dia-thìris* too plain and too quick for a hill man's ear, whether the boy who had once kept her sheep would be let come back for them now the fighting was done. Ailean told her, truthfully, that he did not know, and wrote nothing of the exchange in his book, since it fitted none of its columns. He remembered it all the same, years after he had forgotten most of what the columns held.

At the guard-posts themselves the captains kept him at arm's length at first, taking him for one more of the council's young men come to watch them rather than to help them, until they saw that his count matched theirs to the man, week on week, and stopped troubling to check it. One captain, an old campaigner named Griogair who had lost two fingers to a humans' picket some ten years before the Severance, told him over a fire one night that a line held by soldiers was no line at all, only a line waiting for the soldiers to be needed elsewhere.

"Write that in your book too," Griogair said, "if your council wants the truth of it as well as the count."

Ailean did not write it in the book the council had given him. He wrote it, that once, in the back pages he had begun keeping for himself, where a fact that would not sit easily in a column could still be set down in its own words. It was the second such page, after the one on the empty road, and neither of them was ever asked for by anyone above him.

At the post on the *Caol mhòr* road he watched the last of the columns go through: forty-one souls, by his count, two of them dead before evening and buried where the guard let them dig, the rest walked on into the low hills with noth-

ing behind them but the wagon-ruts freezing over. He wrote the number in his book and, beneath it, a line the council had not asked for: *and the road behind them empty after*. His captain read it over his shoulder, said nothing, and let it stand. It is the first sentence of Ailean mac Iain's that survives in his own hand, and it says, in its way, everything the tally could not.

The guard he rode with was not there to keep the columns moving. By the time Ailean reached the last post, in the thin sun of early spring, the moving was long done, and the guard's business had become a different one: to see that the line held, now that it had been drawn. He wrote as much to the council in his weekly letter, and got back a single line telling him to keep counting.

III

Of Caol mhòr and the Two Words

At Caol mhòr, on the twenty-second day of am Màrt, the council's word on the north was read aloud from the steps of the old harbour-house, to whoever of the town would come and stand for it. Ailean had ridden down from his post two days before at the guard captain's word that something was to be read, and stood at the back of the crowd with his satchel, meaning only to note the numbers of who attended.

It was a wet, grey morning, the kind that makes a crowd of separate people into one shivering animal, and the man sent to read wore the council's colours and a voice trained for a hall, not a quay. Below the steps the crowd stood packed between the fish-sheds and the harbour wall, fisher-folk mostly, with a scattering of the guard's own men and a few Dia-thìrich come up from the south with the columns and never gone home. The tide was out, and the mud-flats beyond the harbour mouth lay bare and grey under the same colour of sky, so that Ailean, watching from the back, had the sense of a crowd gathered at the edge of nothing much, to be told what it already half knew.

He read that the homeland of the Tuathaich (for that was already the word growing up for the humans' children born and to be born on the island) was fixed by the council's law in the north, from the head of the roads to the sea, and that it would be held there. He read it once through in Dia-thìris, which perhaps a third of the crowd followed, watching him with the particular stillness of people waiting to be told the same thing again in words they could use, and then said that the

council had also ordered it read in the humans' tongue, for those who had none of the other.

There was a pause on the steps while someone went to fetch the man who had been found for that. He came up out of the crowd itself: a lean man in his middle forties, in a harbour clerk's coat gone thin at the elbows, with ink worked so far into the creases of his knuckles that no washing would ever get it out again. He had been a clerk of the humans' harbour office at Ros bheag before the crossing closed, and someone at the council's post had remembered it and sent for him the night before. His name was Walter Hale.

He took the paper, read it through once to himself with his lips moving and no sound coming, and then read it aloud to the crowd in their own tongue, flat and without warmth, the way a man reads a thing he has been handed rather than a thing he has made. His voice carried well enough over the harbour, better than the first reader's had, though he gave it none of the other man's polish; he read it the way a clerk reads a cargo manifest, one item following the next without pause for effect, and the crowd took it in the same spirit, with no cheer and no protest, only a low murmur that ran back through the ranks as each heard it from the one in front and passed it on.

Ailean, near enough to hear both readings, followed the English against his memory of the Dia-thiris and found it a fair rendering, word for word, until the very last clause. Where the council's paper said the homeland was *fixed* and would be *beld*, Hale's English said the land was *settled*, a milder word, one that might have meant no more than a people finding a place to live, chosen freely, as a family settles a new farm. Ailean had spent enough weeks by then reading a column of figures against another to know the trick of a small discrepancy, the kind that never shows in the total and never fails to matter to whoever is on the wrong side of it.

The reading over, the crowd went its ways in the rain, and most of the council's men with it, well pleased that the thing was done. Ailean stayed by the steps to note the count. Hale was folding the paper to hand it back, and Ailean, more from a clerk's habit of getting a thing right than from any larger thought, said that he believed the English had softened the last clause.

Hale looked at him for a moment before he answered, as if deciding whether the question was worth an honest reply.

"Settled," he said, "is what a man does to a place he has chosen. This wasn't chosen." He handed the paper back. "The word your council used was *beld*."

That's the truer one. I'd have read it that way if I'd had the choosing of it, only I hadn't."

He said it without heat, the way a clerk corrects another clerk's figure, and turned to go back into the crowd before Ailean could answer him at all. Ailean called after him to ask how he came to know the council's own choice of word so exactly, since the paper he had been handed carried only the English.

Hale stopped and looked back. "I read your tongue as well as mine," he said. "Better than most of your own would credit a harbour clerk with. I had the whole of it in my head before I opened my mouth, and I chose which of it to give them." He said no more, and did not wait to be asked why he had chosen as he had. The crowd had already begun to close round him, some wanting a word repeated, one old man wanting to know only whether the fish market at Doire ghlas would still be his to trade at, and Hale gave his attention to each in turn, in the plain unhurried way of a man used to being asked things by people with no one else to ask.

Ailean stood a moment in the rain with the paper's copy still in his satchel, then took it out, and in the margin beside the clause on the homeland, in his own small hand, wrote the two words Hale had given him: *not settled — beld*. It was not council business, and no one had asked it of him. He never afterward could say clearly why he had written it, except that it seemed to him, even then, a thing worth having down somewhere, in case no one else ever thought to write it at all.

That same week the word went round Caol mhòr, and from Caol mhòr down the western roads to Ros bheag, that the humans' own chapel there, shut since the crossing closed and its priest gone north with the rest, was to be shut for good and its bell taken down. It was Hale's own town, the one he had clerked its harbour in before the war took the harbour's trade away, and it was Hale who first told Ailean of it, two days after the reading, coming to find him at the guard captain's lodging with no more introduction than the paper he still carried.

"You'll want this in whatever it is you keep," Hale said, and told him the bare fact: that the council's men were at Ros bheag that week with a cart and an order, and that the chapel there, which had stood shut but whole since the crossing closed, would not stand whole much longer. He did not ask Ailean to do anything about it. He seemed, if anything, faintly amused that a Dia-thìreach clerk should think it any business of his at all, and said as much, though without unkindness: that the council's word was the council's word, and a bell was only a bell, and he had buried enough of his own to know that the loss that mattered was never the one you could put a cart to.

The council's men who did the work gave no reason beyond an order from the south, and took the bell away on a cart bound, it was said, for wherever in the north the humans' faith might still be kept. Ailean rode the two days down to see it for himself, more from the clerk's habit of checking a thing reported than from any claim on it, and found the chapel already stripped: a low stone building with a slate roof gone green, its door standing open on an empty floor swept bare of even its dust, and the belfry above it holding nothing but a square of paler stone where the bell's cradle had hung. He met the cart on the road back, three carters and a soldier, the bell wrapped in sacking and roped down like a prisoner against the cart's jolting, and stood aside to let it pass. He wrote it into his tally as he wrote everything else that crossed his page that spring: a fact, dated, without comment. It was the only entry in eleven pages he later wished he had written differently.

IV

Of Cathair dhearg and the Rolls

he was recalled south in early summer, his counting at the roads' heads judged finished now that the columns had stopped and the line held itself. He rode into Cathair dhearg on the second of an t-Ògmhios, into a town crowded and loud after the quiet of the guard-posts, every street full of men newly told they would not be paid again as soldiers. The market square, which he remembered from before the war as a place of stalls and cattle, was given over that week to nothing but companies waiting their turn to be stood down, sitting on their packs in the sun with the particular patience of men who have already fought the hard part of a thing and have only the paperwork of it left.

He found lodging above a cooper's shop near the counting-house, the same room he had kept before he rode north, and was at his old table again within the day, as if the guard-posts and the wet road and the chapel at Ros bheag had been someone else's spring entirely. The council's clerks who had stayed south through the winter treated him, at first, as a man returned from an errand rather than from anything that had changed him, and he found he had no ready way to tell them otherwise. He kept the margin copy of the *Caol mhòr* reading folded in the bottom of his satchel and did not show it to anyone.

The council had ordered the war-companies of the Severance stood down, all of them, the whole force that had held the island through the last campaign against the humans' administration and seen it end. It was thought a simple order to carry out: muster each company once more, read the council's word, take back what arms belonged to the council and not the man, and let the rest go home. Ailean was set to the muster in the old drill-yard behind the counting-house, with three other clerks and a table each, taking down names as the companies came through and were released.

It went as such things go, quickly and without much feeling, until the company of Fearchar mac Raghnaill came to Ailean's table.

Fearchar was a broad, grey man who had held that command since before Ailean was old enough to hold a pen, and his company, hill men mostly from the same country Ailean's own family came from, stood in ranks behind him in silence while he asked one thing only. He did not ask for pay, though none of his men had seen a full month's since spring, and he did not ask for arms, though half the company owned nothing else worth the name. He asked that the roll of the company's names not be burned with the loose paper of the muster, as the clerk beside Ailean had already begun doing with the smaller companies to clear the yard faster.

"We fought under that roll," Fearchar said. "Every name on it stood where it says he stood. I'll not have it go on a fire because it takes less room in your chests than keeping it does."

The clerk beside Ailean, who had burned four already that morning and saw no reason to stop, said that the council had asked for the arms counted and the men sent home, and said nothing about a paper's afterlife. Fearchar did not argue further. He simply stood, and his company stood behind him, until someone with authority to answer him could be found.

It was Ailean, having no authority at all but a table nearer the question than most, who told him to wait, and went himself to the master of the chests with the roll under his arm. He came back with leave: the rolls of the disbanded companies were to be kept, not burned, boxed and sealed with the rest of the council's papers from the war. No one troubled to explain why one captain's asking should decide it for every company after him, and Fearchar mac Raghnaill never learned that his had been the first roll spared. He took his men home believing only that the council had, this once, thought better of its own haste.

Ailean spent the rest of that week and the one after carrying rolls, sixty-one of them by the last count, down into the vaulted rooms under the counting-house where the council kept what it meant to keep. It was slow, dusty work, and no one had thought to make a record of what went into the chests beyond the chests' own numbers scratched on the lids. Ailean, who by then had spent a whole spring learning that a thing not written down might as well not have happened, began on his own account a list: which roll, which company, which chest, in what order laid. He filled four sheets before he was done, and signed the last of them, though nobody had asked him to sign anything.

V

Of the Chests Locked

On the third of an t-Ògmhios the last chest went down the stair and the mason set to sealing the door of the vault with a course of new brick, as the council had ordered for all its war papers, meaning the seal to stand until someone in some later year had reason to break it. Ailean stood at the bottom of the stair with his four sheets while the brick was laid, the master of the chests beside him with a lamp that threw both their shadows long across the wet floor.

"You've written more there than the roll asked for," the master said, nodding at the sheets.

"Someone ought to be able to say what's down here, and why, without having to break the wall to find out," Ailean answered.

The master shrugged, took the sheets, glanced them over by the lamp, and signed his own name below Ailean's on the last one, more from courtesy than conviction. He carried them up to be filed with the day's other business, and the door was bricked shut behind them before evening.

Ailean walked back to his lodging that night by the long way, past the river quays where two of the council's boats lay idle for want of anything left to carry, and took out the margin copy he still carried of the council's word from Caol mhòr. He read again the two words he had written there in the rain, months before: *not settled* — *held*. He had carried the clerk's copy so long by then, folded so many times, that the ink had begun to blur along the crease, and he thought, not

for the first time, that a word kept only in one man's pocket was not much better kept than a roll left to burn.

He did not yet know what he would do about it, only that he meant to do something, some day, with a great many words like it, once he had a chest of his own and no one to ask his leave. That evening he wrote nothing more. He put the paper away, banked what fire he had, and let the town's noise carry him to sleep, the last of the Severance behind him and the first full year of the restored country's peace not yet a fortnight old.

So closed the first summer after the Severance, with the columns settled that were never asked whether they wished to be, a captain's roll spared by a clerk with no right to spare it, and a list of chests signed by two men neither of whom the council had told to keep one.

CHAPTER TWO

OF THE STONES ON THE NORTH ROADS

SE 1 AN T-ÒGMHIOS – SE 2 AN CÈITEAN

I

Of the Quay at Caol mhòr

Walter Hale had come to Caol mhòr on foot at the tail of the winter columns, and he stayed because there was nowhere else that would have him. By midsummer he had sent for his family, who came up the coast after him on a coal barge that had no business carrying passengers.

He was forty-four, thick through the shoulders from twenty years at a harbour desk, with a harbour clerk's stoop and a harbour clerk's hands: the right one calloused along the first two fingers where the pen sat, the left one still, oddly, soft. Ellen sat in the bow with Alice wrapped against her, five years old and sick from the swell, and David stood at the rail the whole passage with his coat buttoned wrong, watching the grey coast come up out of the grey water as though he expected it to be taken away again before they reached it.

Nobody at Caol mhòr had asked for them. Nobody had asked for any of the households that the guard walked north that year, in twos and threes and once in a column of eleven wagons, out of Ros bheag and Cuan shean and the burnt fringes of the war. The town took them in the way a beach takes what the tide leaves: without complaint, without welcome, because there was nowhere else for it to go. Hale's family was given the loft over a net-store on the harbour street, one room and a stair, and told it was theirs until somebody wanted the loft back.

He went down to the quay the first week because a man does not stop being a clerk for want of a desk, and there was work there that suited his hands if nothing else about the place suited them. The Caol mhòr boats came in with what the sea gave, which in that first summer was not much, and the catch was weighed and written down on a slate that a fisherman's daughter rubbed out every evening whether anyone had copied the numbers or not. Hale copied them. He did it without being asked, the third day, standing at the harbour wall with a scrap of paper braced on his forearm, because watching numbers be rubbed off a slate unrecorded made something in him itch that twenty years at Ros bheag had never quite cured. The daughter, whose name was Peg Carrick, watched him do it and said nothing, and the next evening left the slate a little longer before she wiped it, as if that settled something between them.

He was not the only clerk the guard had walked north. There were pursers and toll-men and a schoolmaster's assistant among the households at Caol mhòr that summer, men and women who had kept some kind of book under the humans' old administration and now kept nothing, because the administration that had employed them was three months drowned in its own harbour and the council that had replaced it wanted no part of their hand. Hale heard two of them talking on the quay steps one evening about going for fishermen, since there was nothing else a man's hands were good for here, and he did not join the talk, because he did not yet believe it.

He unloaded barges through that first month, hauling nets and barrels and, once, a crate of the guard's own muskets going north to the post above the town, and he watched the roads.

II

Of the Stone on the Caol mhòr Road

The council's masons came up from the south at the end of an t-Iuchar, three of them with a cart of dressed stone and a soldier riding ahead to clear the road, though there was nothing on the road that summer that needed clearing. They worked their way along each of the roads that ran out of Tuathaich country toward the shires, and on the thirty-first they set the stone on the Caol mhòr road, a mile out of the town where the track crossed the old drove path, and were gone south again before the ink of the day's minute was dry.

Hale walked out to see it on the first evening he had free, and took David with him, because the boy had taken to following him about the harbour in a way that made Ellen say he needed something to do with his feet besides the loft stair.

The stone stood a little taller than Hale himself, squared and grey, the kind of stone a man does not shift with his hands alone, and it bore letters cut deep and new, the edges of the cutting still sharp and pale where the weather had not yet got at them. Neither Hale nor David could read a word of what was cut there. It was the council's tongue, not theirs, and no one had troubled to set the sense of it beside the shape.

"What does it say," David asked, which was a fair question and one Hale could not answer.

"That we're this side of it and they're that side," Hale said, which was near enough true, though it was not what the stone said. He had heard, from a Diathreach guard who spoke a broken version of the humans' tongue and liked to talk while he stood his post, that the stone marked where the homeland began: not a wall, the guard had said, laughing a little at the word, as though a wall were a thing his own people might have built and had thought better of. Only a mark. A line drawn once, cut in stone so that no one could say afterward it had never been drawn.

No wall came after it. Hale looked for one through that whole first summer, half expecting to wake one morning and find a ditch and a bank running the length of the road, the kind of thing an army builds when it means to keep something in or out for good. Nothing came. The stone stood alone at the crossing, and the drove path ran past it exactly as it had before, and cattle that did not know one country from another walked over the line without noticing it was there.

He set his hand flat against the stone's face before they walked home, feeling the cut letters under his palm the way a blind man reads, though he had no more sense for what they meant that way than by eye. David did the same, more from watching his father than from any purpose of his own, and asked would they ever be able to read it.

"Somebody will read it to us someday," Hale said. "Somebody always does, in the end." He believed it when he said it, though he could not have told David why.

They walked back to the town in the last light with the stone behind them, and Hale did not look at it again that year, though he thought of it more than he

let on: a boundary with no wall, a line a man could step over and not know he had done it, except that everyone on both sides of it had been told, in one tongue or the other, that it was there.

III

Of the Thin Harvest

The stores that had always come over the water in the autumn did not come that year, and the council in the south, which had never counted the Tuathaich households among the mouths it fed, did not send anything in their place. Nobody had told the north's fields this. They had been sown late, after the marching and the settling, on ground half the households had never worked before, and what they gave back at the reaping was thin: short straw, light ears, a crop that a farmer's eye could read as trouble from the far end of the field before a scythe had touched it.

The Caol mhòr boats did better than the land, at first, but even the sea was uncertain that year, the herring shoals running late and thin off their old grounds, and by an Dàmhair the catch had fallen to less than a household could live on if each household kept what it caught for itself.

It was Ellen who put the shape to it before anyone in the town had a word for it. She had kept a harbour clerk's house long enough to think in tallies without meaning to, and she came home from the quay one evening in the first week of an Dàmhair and told Hale, flatly, the way she told him most things that mattered, that Peg Carrick's mother had given the Widow Fenn two fish out of a catch of nine, and the Widow Fenn had no boat and no man to send out in one, and if that went on past the week it would not go on at all, because nine fish shared out to households instead of sold to whoever came first to the quay was not how a harbour worked, and everyone at Caol mhòr knew it.

It became, within the month, how the harbour worked anyway. There was no minute written for it, no council of the town's own to vote it in; it happened the way water finds its own level, house by house, boat by boat, until the whole of Caol mhòr's catch, good weeks and bad, went first to a reckoning of who had a boat and who did not, and only what was left after that was sold or traded beyond the town. Hale kept no tally of it himself that autumn, his own book still unbegun, and he watched it happen with the same clerk's attention he gave the har-

bour slate. A town sharing its catch by households and a town selling its catch to whoever paid first were two different towns, he came to understand, though he could not yet have said in so many words why it mattered, and Caol mhòr had quietly become the first kind without anyone deciding it should.

He thought of the guard and his mark cut in stone, the line with no wall, and thought that a boundary a man could not see might matter as much as one he could.

IV

Of the Meal Carried to Doire ghlas

By an t-Samhain the thinness of the harvest had a name in every house at Caol mhòr, though no two households agreed on how bad it would get before spring, and by early an Dùbhlachd the name had stopped being a thing people argued about and become a thing they simply lived inside, the way a house lives inside a hard winter once the first snow has settled and shows no sign of going.

Word came down the coast road from Doire ghlas, ten miles inland along a track that in a wet an Dùbhlachd took the better part of a day to walk, that the town there had nothing left in its stores and had begun, in the second week of the month, to bury its own dead of hunger without troubling to send word south, because word sent south had never yet brought anything back.

Caol mhòr had little enough to spare, but it had more than Doire ghlas, being a harbour town with a catch of sorts still coming in, and its householders, who had taken to meeting in the long room behind the net-stores whenever there was cause, voted what oats and salt fish it could spare into three carts, and asked for men to walk them inland.

Hale went. He told Ellen he went because his hands were the freest in the household that week, David and Alice both needing her at home with the fever going round the loft-houses, but the truth of it, which he did not say to her, was that he went because Doire ghlas frightened him in a way the thin harvest at Caol mhòr had not, and a man does not walk toward what frightens him without some better reason than idle hands, and he had not found a better reason, and had gone anyway.

The road to Doire ghlais ran inland from the coast through country that had been farmed by nobody in living memory before that year, scrub and rush pasture that the settled households had been given because the good land nearer the coast was already claimed, and the going was slow with the cart wheels sinking to the hub in places where the drainage had never been cut. They came into Doire ghlais on the second day, in the last of the light, and Hale smelled the town before he saw its roofs: woodsmoke, and under the woodsmoke something colder that he did not let himself name until he had to.

They had dug the graves on the rise above the church because the low ground by the burn was too wet to hold a grave that winter, and the digging had been hard going in ground half frozen, so that the graves were shallower than a churchyard grave should be and set closer together than custom allowed, because there had not been strength enough in the town to dig them any other way. Hale counted the fresh mounds while the carts were being unloaded, walking the rise alone in the last grey light with his hat off though there was no one there to see him bare his head for it, and stopped counting at eleven because his eyes had blurred and he no longer trusted the number, and started again, and reached fourteen the second time, and did not try a third.

Three of the mounds were child-sized. He stood over those longest.

A woman of the town, thin herself in a way that made her age hard to guess, told him while they carried sacks of oats into what was left of the store that the town had lost more than the fourteen he could count on the rise, because some of the earliest dead, back in an t-Samhain before anyone had thought to keep a reckoning, had been buried singly by their own families in whatever ground was handiest, without the town knowing to add them to any count at all. She could not say how many. Nobody could say how many. Hale came slowly to understand, standing in the freezing store with an oat sack still on his shoulder, the whole shape of the trouble: the town had starved through a winter nobody south of the guard-line had thought to prevent, and the dying itself had gone on unrecorded, house by house, before anyone had thought to reckon it as a single town's loss rather than a scatter of private griefs.

He asked the woman, because it was the only question his clerk's mind knew how to ask in the face of a thing this large, whether anyone kept a book of it. She looked at him as though the question itself were a kind of madness, in a place where half the households did not yet own a book of any kind, and said that the priest kept the parish register, births and marryings and the ordinary dead. This

was a different order of grief, too large for the parish book and too many-headed for any one family's memory, and nobody had told her what a person was meant to do with it, and so, for want of a better answer, nobody had done anything with it at all.

V

Of the Book Begun

hale walked back to Caol mhòr with the empty carts in three days instead of two, because the weather turned and one of the horses went lame on the second, and he had the whole of that slow, cold walking to sit with what he had seen on the rise above Doire ghlas and could not put down.

It was not, he told himself at first, a clerk's proper business. He had no office here, no seal, no book issued him by any council; he was a harbour clerk without a harbour, three months into a life he had not chosen, in a country whose government did not know his name and would not have cared to learn it. But he had spent twenty years believing that a thing not written down was a thing that had not, in any way that mattered to the world afterward, happened, and that belief had not left him only because the humans' administration that had trained him into it now lay at the bottom of a drowned harbour. It went where he went. It had gone with him up the coast road and stood with him on the rise counting graves he could not trust his own eyes to count twice the same.

He bought, from the one shop at Caol mhòr that still sold anything beyond food and rope, a ledger meant for a fishmonger's accounts, its pages ruled for weights and prices, and on the first evening after his return, with Ellen asleep and the children asleep and the loft cold around him, he opened it at the first page and wrote, in his own clerk's hand, the word *Doire ghlas*, and under it the date, and under that, as near as he could reconstruct it from what the woman in the store had told him and what he had counted twice on the rise, a number, and could not have sworn to its truth writing it, only that it was the nearest thing to truth that anyone had troubled to set down, which was as much as the writing could claim for itself. The alternative, no number at all, a grief too large for the parish book, filed nowhere, answerable to nobody, was the thing he had walked ten miles inland and ten miles home to refuse.

He did not stop at Doire ghlas. Through the rest of that hard winter, as word came down the coast road of other towns short of grain, other households that had gone without and some that had not come through it, Hale set down what he could learn of each in the fishmonger's ledger, town by town, a line or two apiece, a name where a name could be had and a number where a number could be had and, more often than either, a plain note that no count had been kept and none now could be trusted. He did not think of it, in those first months, as anything more than a private accounting, the kind of book a careful man keeps against his own forgetting. It did not occur to him yet that he was keeping the only reckoning of that winter's dead that would ever exist south of the guard-line either, because no one south of it had asked to be told, and no one south of it, so far as Hale could tell, so much as knew there was a reckoning to be kept.

That was the turn of it, when it came to him, sitting by the loft's small fire on a night in am Faoilleach with the fishmonger's ledger open on his knee and the wind working at the shutter: that the council which had set a stone on the road to mark where his people's country began had drawn no line at all around the counting of his people's dead, because it had never occurred to the council that there was a count to be drawn a line around. The Dia-thìrich made none. They had not refused to; refusal would have required them to notice there was a decision to make. They simply had not thought of it, the way a man does not think to count the leaves that fall from a tree he does not own, and in the space that not-thinking left, if the count was to exist at all, it would have to be the Tuathaich who kept it, in their own hand, in a fishmonger's ledger bought for weights and prices, because no one else on the whole of the island would ever trouble to.

He did not write that thought down; it belonged nowhere in a ledger of names and numbers. It sat in him from that night on, under everything else the book came afterward to hold, the way the stone on the Caol mhòr road sat unseen under the drove path's traffic: a line drawn once, that nobody south of it would ever have cause to notice, and that everybody north of it would carry, whether they chose to or not, for the rest of their lives.

VI

Of the Names in the Porch

Spring came late that year, as it does on a coast that takes its weather from the open west, but it came. By an Cèitean the worst of the hunger had passed, the last of the winter stores stretched thin enough to see the new grass through, and the herring, which had run late and light the autumn before, came back to the Caol mhòr grounds in numbers a fisherman three generations settled there said he had not seen since before the Severance, as though the sea itself, having taken nothing from the town that winter, had decided to give something back by way of apology.

Doire ghlais, when word of it reached Caol mhòr on a carter's cart come down for seed, had done in its own fashion what Hale had done alone in the loft with the fishmonger's ledger, though the town had come to it by a different road. Somebody at Doire ghlais, a woman of the parish and not the priest, though the carter did not know her name, had gone from house to house through the town in the first mild week of spring and asked each household for the names of anyone it had lost since an t-Samhain, hunger-dead and not ordinary dead, and had written each name on a strip of paper in whatever hand could be found to write it, and pinned the strips, one by one as they were gathered, along the boards of the church porch, where every soul in the town passed at least once a week whether it went in to service or not.

There was no order to the names, the carter said, no roll of the dead set out fair in a single hand the way a parish register would have kept it; strips of paper in a dozen different hands, some barely lettered, pinned up as they came in, so that a name might sit next to another from a household three streets off with no kin between them, and a child's name might sit above or below an old man's with nothing to mark which was which except the writing itself. But the porch held, by the carter's rough count, above fifteen names by the time he had come away, and the town had taken to calling it, without deciding to, the porch of the names, and left it up through the spring though the strips curled and faded in the weather, because nobody in Doire ghlais could yet bring themselves to be the one to take even a single name down.

Hale walked out to see it himself before that spring was over, taking the coast road ten miles inland a second time, this time with no cart to slow him and no lame horse, and stood in the church porch reading names he mostly did not know, in a light hand and a heavy hand and a child's careful copying-hand where some elder had taught a grandchild the letters expressly for this, and found, when he had read them all through once, that he could not have said afterward whether

the number matched the fourteen he had counted on the rise that winter, or the vaguer reckoning the woman in the store had given him of the earlier dead nobody had thought to add in, or neither. He understood, standing there in the mild spring light with the herring running thick again off the harbour he had left that morning, that the porch kept its own count, made by its own town, in its own way, and no less true for not squaring with his.

The porch's names did not go into the fishmonger's ledger that day. Hale copied them instead, every one, into a second book he had begun keeping since am Faoilleach for exactly this purpose, a book with nothing in it yet but blank ruled pages and the single word he had written on its first leaf in the dead of that winter, by lamplight: *Doire gblas*, and under it, this time, above fifteen names, copied faithfully from a church porch that the council thirty-odd miles south did not know existed, in a hand a Dia-thìreach clerk, had one ever troubled to read it, would have called a stranger's.

The ledger went home to Caol mhòr under his coat, against the last of the spring rain, and he told no one south of the guard-stone what it held, for there was no one south of the guard-stone to tell.

CHAPTER THREE

OF THE COUNTING- HOUSES AND THE BROKEN LOCKS

SE 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS – AN T-IUCHAR

Is san scrìobhadh a tha e, chan ann san t-sùil. It lies in the writing,
not the seeing.

— a saying of the counting-clerks of Cathair dhearg, of no known
author

I

Of the Boxes at Cathair dhearg

A ilean mac Iain had spent the first summer of the restored country learning that a thing not written down might as well not have happened. He spent the second summer learning what it cost to write some things down and not others, and that the difference between the two lessons was most of what a clerk's life was for.

He was set, on the second morning of an t-Ògmhios, to a room at Cathair dhearg that had been the humans' counting-house, a long stone hall behind the harbour offices with high windows and a floor still marked in chalk where the humans had ruled lines for sorting coin. The war had been through it twice, once when the council took the town and once when a company of the humans' own guard had tried, briefly and badly, to hold it back, and what the fighting had not burned the damp had got into afterward. Ailean stood in the doorway on his first morning with a list in his hand of what he was to do, and could smell, under the

mildew, a fainter smell of char that told him some of the shelves nearest the door had gone up before anyone thought to put them out.

The master set over the room, a heavy, patient man named Ruairidh whom Ailean never once heard raise his voice, gave him the whole of the northern wall to clear: ledger after ledger in the humans' close, slanting hand, bound in board covers gone soft with damp, each one a year or two of some tally he could only guess at from its weight and its ruled columns. "Box them," Ruairidh said. "Don't read them. We haven't the hands to spare for reading, and half of what's here is charred through by the middle anyhow. Box them, mark the shelf they came from, and let the reckoners sort out later what's worth opening."

Ailean had not told Ruairidh, and did not tell him now, that he could in fact make out a fair part of the humans' hand, better than most of the clerks the council had brought south that summer. As a boy in the hills he had gone twice a week to a reader kept by Teachdaireachd na h-Eaglaise¹ in the nearest of the human mission-houses, less because his people held with the humans' errand than because the reader taught letters to any child sent to him and asked no coin for it, and Ailean's mother had wanted her son able to read whatever came his way, in whatever hand it came in. He had sat on a bench with three human children and two others of his own people and learned his letters twice over, in two hands and two tongues, and had not thought since that it would ever be worth anything to anyone but himself.

It was worth this much now: that he could have told Ruairidh, truthfully, what several of these ledgers were before he boxed them, and chose instead to box them as he had been told, unread, because a clerk who is asked to box a thing and instead reads it aloud to his master has made himself the kind of clerk nobody keeps for long. He carried the first stack to the crate the carpenters had left at the door, laid the boards in flat, and wrote on the crate's side, in his own hand, *Tithe rolls, north wall, unread*, which was as much truth as the label had room to hold and rather more than most of the crates around him got.

By the third day he had the rhythm of it: lift, glance at the spine for a date if one showed, set it in the crate, mark the tally on his own sheet, lift again. Some of the ledgers, near the seat of the old fire, crumbled at the spine when he lifted them and had to go into the crate as loose leaves, gathered as best he could in something like their order, with a note on the crate that the order was his own guess and not

1. the Mission; lit. 'the errand of the Church'

to be trusted past that. He thought, more than once that week, of how a fire that burns a thing halfway leaves a worse record than one that burns it whole, because a whole loss at least tells you plainly that there is nothing left to ask about, while a half loss goes on pretending, for as long as the crate is shut, that the rest of the truth is only waiting to be found.

He did not say this to Ruairidh either. Nowhere did he write it down. It sat with him the way the two words in his margin from the year before had sat with him, a private accounting kept against the day he might have a use for it, and he went on boxing.

There were four others set to the room besides him, none known to Ailean before that summer, drawn south from as many different hill parishes as there were clerks, and of these only a stooped, quick-handed man called Tòmas ever spoke to him beyond what the work required. Tòmas had been a mason's clerk before the war, used to tallying stone rather than paper, and he handled the ledgers as though they might crumble at a wrong word as readily as at a wrong touch, which by the third week several of them did. On the day the fire-damaged shelf gave up its last crumbling stack, Tòmas straightened over the crate with a fistful of loose leaves gone soft and brown at the edges and said, to no one in particular, that it seemed a strange kind of victory, to win a war and then spend a summer sweeping up the loser's paper.

"Somebody has to know what was owed and to whom," Ailean said, "or the whole of it starts again from nothing, and starting from nothing costs more than sweeping."

"Does it," Tòmas said, not quite a question, and went back to his crate, and Ailean found he had no ready answer for the plain doubt in it, only the private one he did not offer: that starting from nothing might in fact have cost the kingdom less, in the end, than beginning from a room like this one, but that no one who had been given a crate and a chalk stub that summer was in any position to choose between the two.

II

Of Ros dhomhain's Sheds

In the second week Ailean was sent west along the coast road to Ros dhomhain, where the humans' harbour offices stood larger than Cathair dhearg's

and the war had touched them less, and where the council wanted its tariff tables copied out before the summer's shipping began under the new hands.

Ros dhomhain in that first restored summer was still mostly a humans' town wearing a Dia-thìreach flag: the sheds along its long stone quay built to the humans' measure, the cranes still swung by the humans' gearing, the harbour-master's house with its clock stopped at whatever hour the last of the humans' officers had walked out of it. A clerk of the council's own, a hill man named Dùghall who had been set over the harbour's books for want of anyone else willing to learn its workings, met Ailean at the gate and walked him through the sheds himself, apologising for the state of the ledger room as though the mess were somehow his own doing.

"They kept a tariff table for every port on the coast," Dùghall said, laying a bound sheet across the counting-desk, "duties on grain, on timber, on the coal that went out before the works closed, on I don't know what else, half of it in figures I can't make head or tail of. The council wants it copied into our own hand and our own tongue before the boats start moving again, so a captain putting in here need not wonder whether the man taking his dues even knows what he's owed."

Ailean spent nine days at that desk, copying figure for figure and clause for clause, turning the humans' close columns into a Dia-thìris he had to build word by word as he went, for there had never before been a need to say, in his own tongue, what a duty on timber was or how it was reckoned by the load rather than the piece. He found that a language could be made to hold a new thing without breaking, provided a man was patient enough to lay the words down one at a time and careful enough not to claim, in the laying, that the thing had changed because its name had. The tariff the humans had set stood exactly as it had stood before; only the ink was new.

Dùghall watched him work on the last evening, reading over Ailean's shoulder with the frank curiosity of a man who has never learned to read closely enough to be embarrassed by his own slowness at it. "It's the same duty," he said at last, as though the thought had only just settled in him. "We've only put our own coat on it."

"For want of another," Ailean said, which was the same answer Dùghall would go on giving, in one form or another, for as long as he kept the harbour, though neither of them knew that yet.

He carried the finished copy south himself rather than trust it to a courier, folded flat inside his coat against the coast road's dust, and thought, walking, of the label he had written on the crate of tithe rolls: *unread*. The tariff table he carried now had been read most carefully of all, word by word, clause by clause, and copied out exact, and he could not have said with any honesty that the reading had changed a single thing it was made to do.

III

Of the Labelled Box

The last of his three counting-houses was the one at Seann Skell in the west, the humans' great harbour on the coast below the capes, where the fishing fleets still came in under a flag they had never learned to read and the old harbour bell rang the hours by a humans' clock nobody had yet thought to reset.

The counting-house there had taken the least harm of the three, for the town had changed hands with barely a shot fired, its garrison marching out under terms before the council's companies were even in sight of the walls, and Ailean found its shelves whole where Cathair dhearg's had burned and Ros dhomhain's had been picked over by two summers of harbour clerks before him. He worked through it alone for the better part of a week, boxing what he was told to box, tithe rolls and customs rolls and the wage-books of men whose names meant nothing to him, until he came, on a shelf set apart from the rest behind a locked grating that had taken the smith half a morning to force, on a set of rolled sheets larger than anything else in the room, each one bound with a strip of the humans' own linen tape and marked, in a surveyor's careful print, with a district's name.

Setting his own crate aside, he unrolled the first of them on the long table by the window and stood over it a long while before he thought to send for Ruairidh.

It was a map, but more than a map: every field about Seann Skell laid out with its boundary walked and measured, every holding numbered, every stream and track set down to a scale marked plainly in one corner, in a hand so exact that Ailean, who had grown up on a hillside no one had ever thought worth surveying at all, felt for a moment that he was looking at the land laid out entire, folded small and put under glass. He had seen the council's own maps, such as they were: rough things, drawn from memory and hearsay, good enough to show a captain

which valley led where but not good enough to say whose field lay on which side of a boundary stone. Nothing in his life had prepared him for what lay unrolled on that table.

He counted the district sheets as he unrolled them, laying each flat under a weight of loose stone from the yard before it could curl back on its own roll, and found there were eleven in all, enough between them, he judged from the scale marked in the corners, to cover the whole of the coast from the north-western capes down past Seann Skell itself and some way inland besides, though how far inland he could not tell until he had them all open together, which the table was not long enough to allow. He knelt on the floor instead and laid three of them edge to edge, matching a stream on one sheet to its continuation on the next by eye, and felt, doing it, something closer to the excitement of a boy given a puzzle than to the flat patience with which he had boxed the tithe rolls all that month.

Ruairidh came, looked, said nothing for a while, and then said what Ailean had already half thought himself: that there was nothing else like this on the whole of the island, that whatever the council's own men might one day draw of the shires it meant to rule, they would draw it from this, because there was nowhere else whole enough to draw it from.

"Box them apart from the rest," Ruairidh said. "Not with the tithe rolls. These go to the council's own clerks, not the reckoners." He thought a moment longer, and added, in the tone of a man handing over a decision he would rather not have had to make himself, "Write something on the crate so whoever opens it next knows what it's for."

Ailean found a fresh crate, laid the rolled surveys in it one district at a time, each still bound in its own tape, and stood with the lid in his hand and a stub of chalk, thinking what to write. He could have written what the crate held, plainly, as he had for the tithe rolls: *district surveys, Seann Skell in the west, entire*. It would have been true and would have said nothing that mattered. He thought instead of the council's own rough maps, of the valley that showed a captain the way but not the boundary, of a kingdom that had just that summer begun calling itself a kingdom with no whole map of its own to be one by, and he wrote, in the end, six words that were not a description of what the crate held so much as a statement of what it was for: *The shires will be drawn on them*.

He looked at the words a moment after he had written them, chalk-white on unpainted wood, and understood, standing there with the lid half over the crate, that he had just written down the truest sentence he had put to anything since the

margin of the council's own proclamation the year before, and that it troubled him in the same way that sentence had, because a kingdom that drew its shires on the humans' district lines, using the humans' own survey of the humans' own farms, was not drawing a kingdom fresh out of the ground it had won. It was tracing one that had already been drawn, by other hands, for other purposes, and calling the tracing its own.

He shut the lid, nailed it, and marked the crate for the council's own clerks rather than the reckoners, as Ruairidh had told him. Nobody who read the label in the months and years that followed, as the shire lines were in fact drawn from what the crate held, exactly where the crate had said they would be, ever asked who had written it or what he had meant by it.

IV

Of What the North Tells

It is told at Muileann chaol, though not from any minute the council kept, for it kept none, that in those same weeks, at Ceann mhòr and Cathair gheal and Inis àrsaidh on the north-western coast, a different kind of counting-house was opened, and opened rather more quickly than the ones Ailean was working through.

The humans' harbour officers at those three towns had sailed with the last of the crossing ships and had taken their keys with them, whether from forethought or from simple haste nobody left behind could afterward say, and the harbour stores at all three towns stood locked through that spring with the last of the humans' stock still inside them: rope, canvas, salt, tackle, and at Cathair gheal a whole loft of nets that had never been fished. No maor had yet been set over any of the three towns, the council's attention being wholly on the south that season, and for a while the stores simply stood, locked and unclaimed, while the towns around them went short of exactly the things the stores held.

It did not stand long. A fisherman of Ceann mhòr, whose name the north's own telling does not agree on, though every version gives him a hammer and a bad temper, walked down to the store one wet morning, tried the lock with his hand, tried it again with his shoulder, and then went home for his hammer and came back and broke it. He did not, by any account the north tells, take anything for himself that first morning. He broke the lock, opened the door, and stood

back to let the town see what was inside, and it was the town, not the man with the hammer, that decided within the hour how the rope and the canvas and the salt would be shared out, house by house, by much the same rough justice that had already, that same year at Caol mhòr, decided how a thin catch of herring ought to be shared.

Cathair gheal and Inis àrsaidh followed within the fortnight, each in its own way: at Cathair gheal it is told that the whole loft of unfished nets went out to every boat in the harbour on a single tide, so that the fleet that year fished with nets it had never paid a coin for and never afterward wondered whose they had once been; at Inis àrsaidh, smaller than the other two and poorer, the store held little enough that the sharing was done inside an afternoon, what the town remembers of it is the reckoning rather than the goods: who had a boat and who had none, and so who needed rope and who needed salt more, drawn up on the spot by three women of the town with no office to do it and no one afterward to say they had done it wrong.

The north tells this part, when it tells it at all, with something close to relish, in a way it does not tell the winter of the hungry year that came so soon after: broken locks, a hammer, goods shared out by the plain justice of a fishing town rather than doled out by any office south of the water. No maor ever came to ask who had struck the first blow, for by the time one did come north, in the winter of the year after, there was nothing left locked to account for, and the town's own memory of the thing had already hardened into the kind of story a place keeps because it likes the shape of it: the strangers left, and took their keys, and the sea folk broke in with their own hands and helped themselves, and no one has ever been the worse for it.

Ailean, boxing tithe rolls at Cathair dhearg that same month, heard nothing of it at the time, and no clerk's crate anywhere in the south held so much as a line about it, because no one south of the water had thought there was anything there worth a clerk's crate.

V

Of the Proclamation

The council styled the state a kingdom on the twenty-seventh of an t-Iuchar, from the steps of the counting-house at Cathair dhearg, the very building

whose northern wall Ailean had spent the earlier weeks of that summer clearing crate by crate.

He was given no part in the reading. He stood in the crowd instead, in the press of clerks and harbour men and off-duty guards that had gathered in the square below the steps once word went round that the council meant to say something, close enough to hear the words plainly and too far back to see more than the tops of the twelve heads on the platform above him. A herald, not the crier who had read the council's word at Caol mhòr the year before, read out a proclamation that named the state, from that day, *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr*¹, and spoke of the island won back and the homeland made secure and the years of settling now, in the herald's own word, *complete*. It was not a long proclamation. It named no king, for none had yet been crowned, and no new law, for none had yet been made; it was, as far as Ailean could judge standing in the crowd with the sun on the back of his neck, mostly a naming, the council giving itself a title it had in truth held in every particular but the word for some months already.

He thought, listening, of the crate at Seann Skell with its six chalked words, and of the tariff table at Ros dhomhain copied out in a new tongue to say exactly the old thing, and of the seal the council's engraver had that same week begun cutting for the state's own letters, a seal that would go, when it was finished, onto documents no different in kind from the ones he had spent the summer boxing unread. A kingdom had been proclaimed from the steps of a building that had been, until that spring, a foreign counting-house, using a survey drawn by foreign hands to mark out the shires it meant to rule, keeping in force, for want of another, a tariff the foreigners themselves had set. He did not think any of this made the proclamation false, exactly. He thought it made the proclamation a kind of label, not unlike the one he had chalked on the crate of surveys, true as far as it went and silent about everything that had gone into making it true.

Beside him in the crowd stood a woman he did not know, a fishwife by her basket and her salt-reddened hands, who asked the man on her other side, in the flat voice of someone asking merely to have something answered rather than because the answer mattered to her trade, whether a kingdom paid its dues any different from a council. The man did not know. Nobody near Ailean seemed to know, and he thought that this, more than the herald's words or the twelve heads on the platform, was the truest measure of what had been proclaimed: a name

1. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

new enough to need explaining and an arrangement old enough that nobody in the crowd expected the explaining to change anything they would be asked to pay.

The crowd around him cheered when the herald finished, in the ragged, willing way of a crowd that wants something to cheer and has been given, at last, an excuse. Ailean did not cheer. He stood with his hands in his coat, watching the twelve on the platform receive the cheering as though it had been meant for them personally rather than for the word, and thought that a state could change its name from a war-council to a kingdom on a single afternoon and be, in every working part beneath the name, exactly the state it had been the afternoon before: the same tariff, the same surveys, the same crates going into the same rooms marked in the same hands, only now under a seal cut fresh and called royal.

He walked back to the counting-house that evening, after the crowd had gone, and let himself in with the key Ruairidh had given him, to check, he told himself, that the last of the week's crates were properly nailed before the carters came for them in the morning. The northern wall stood bare where the tithe rolls had been, swept and empty for the first time since he had begun. The crate marked for the council's own clerks, the one with six words chalked on its lid, still stood by the door where he had left it, waiting to be carried up to whichever room the shire-lines would in the end be drawn in.

Reading the words over once more by the last of the evening light through the high windows, *the shires will be drawn on them*, he thought that whatever the herald had proclaimed that afternoon from the steps outside, the truer proclamation of the summer was chalked in his own hand on a crate nobody but a handful of clerks would ever see, and that the kingdom the crowd had cheered for would be built, quite literally, field by field and boundary by boundary, on lines that other hands, under another flag, had walked and measured first. This did not, to his mind, make the kingdom any less a kingdom. It made it the kind of kingdom that proclaimed itself in the open, on a summer afternoon, with bells and a herald and twelve men receiving a crowd's cheers, and settled itself, in the meantime and mostly unseen, in rooms like this one, on paper like this, in a hand like his own.

He locked the counting-house behind him and went home by the harbour road, past the sheds where the council's idle ships still lay, and did not write any of it down that night. There was, he thought, nothing in it that the crate had not already said better than he could, in six words and a piece of chalk.

CHAPTER FOUR

OF the Moot and the Council of Twelve

SE 2 AN LÙNASTAL – AN T-SULTAIN

Chan eil inbhe againn. Scriobhaidh sinn co-dhiù. We have no standing. We shall write it all the same.

— the Moot's minute-book, its first leaf, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2

I

Of the Long Room at Caol mhòr

They came on foot and in carts, at the tail end of a wet an Lùnastal that had done nothing for the barley and less for tempers, from Doire ghlas and Muileann leathan and the scattered crofts along the coast road, householders every one of them, a man or a woman standing for each roof that had smoke going up it that summer. Nobody had called them. Word had gone from house to house the way word goes in a country too poor yet to have a bell for it, mouth to mouth along the quay and up the drove paths, that there would be a meeting at Caol mhòr on the first fair day of the month to speak of the winter coming, and enough people believed it mattered enough to walk to find out that the harbour-house's long room, used till then for nothing grander than mending nets on a wet afternoon, could not hold them all. Those who could not get inside stood in the doorway and along the wall outside it, passing back what was said a sentence behind the saying of it.

Walter Hale stood at the back with his hat in both hands, working the brim between his fingers the way he had worked it as a boy waiting outside a school-

master's door, though he was forty-five now and had not stood outside a school-master's door in thirty years. He had come because Ellen had told him to come, flatly, over the breakfast she made him eat before he went, on the grounds that a man who kept a private ledger of the town's dead and did not trouble to say so out loud to the town was only half doing the thing he had set himself to do. He had not argued the point. Once Ellen made it in that voice, he rarely did.

The room smelled of damp wool and fish-scale and too many bodies for the size of it, and for the better part of the afternoon it did nothing but argue, which Hale had expected and had come prepared to sit through. They argued first about whether there was anything to be done at all, a question that took the better part of an hour to settle in the negative, since a country that has just been marched into a homeland it did not choose and left to make what it can of a summer already half spent is not naturally disposed to agree on anything, least of all on whether agreeing is worth the breath. They argued next about who among them had the right to speak for the rest, which took longer, since half the room held that no one man could speak for households as different as a fisherman's and a smith's and a schoolmaster's widow's, and the other half held that a hundred voices arguing at once would carry no further than the harbour wall and be no more use than the gulls.

It was in the middle of this second argument, with the light going amber through the one window and a woman near the door saying for the third time that she had not walked nine miles to listen to men quarrel about who should do the talking, that somebody said Hale's name.

He did not afterward remember who said it first. It went round the room the way a bucket goes hand to hand along a fire-line, picked up by whoever's hand was nearest and passed on without much thought given to it, a name is offered, another voice takes it up because it is easier to agree than to argue further, and by the time it had gone twice round the low room it had stopped being a suggestion and become, without any vote taken or asked for, a fact that the room seemed to have arrived at together. Hale had kept a slate; Hale had kept a book of the hungry year's dead, though few enough of them yet knew how thorough a book; Hale had once been paid, under the old administration, to write things down in a hand that held up in a court of law, which was more than any other soul in the room could claim. The bucket stopped with him.

"I'm no speaker," he said, which was true, and which nobody in the room seemed inclined to hold against him.

"You needn't speak," said the woman by the door, whose name was Seonag and who had lost, though Hale did not know it yet, a sister at Doire ghlais that winter. "You need only write down what the rest of us say, so it's said once and stays said."

It was a man further back, one of the pursers the guard had walked north with the rest, who put the harder question into words. "We've no standing," he said, loud enough to carry to the doorway and the backs pressed against it. "Not in their law. They needn't hear a word of it, whatever we write or don't."

"Then we'll say it where we can hear it ourselves," Hale said.

He had not planned to say it. It came out of him the way the count of the graves at Doire ghlais had come out of him in the church porch that spring, not chosen so much as arrived at, a thing his own mouth said before the rest of him had finished deciding whether he believed it. But once said it could not be unsaid, and the room, which a moment before had been on the edge of deciding the whole meeting was a waste of a fair day's light, went quiet in the particular way a room goes quiet when it has just heard the one sentence it did not know it was waiting for.

He went to the trestle at the front, where somebody had set out an inkhorn and a stack of paper meant for nothing more than tallying the fair day's trade, and he sat down on the bench behind it, and he opened, because it was the only book to hand, a ledger that a Caol mhòr chandler had brought along half-hoping to sell blank stock to whoever needed it. It had nothing written in it. Hale wetted the pen, and, because a clerk's hand does the thing a clerk's mind has already decided before the mind has finished deciding it, wrote the day at the top of the first leaf in the small, upright script that Ros bheag had trained into him twenty years before, and under the day, because a minute needs a heading and he had been keeping one kind of book or another for three months now and had a feel for what a heading ought to say, he wrote: *A meeting of the households of the north, at Caol mhòr.*

"There," he said. "It's written now."

There was no ceremony to it beyond that, no vote taken on whether the thing they had just made should have a name, and for the whole of that first afternoon nobody troubled to give it one. It was some weeks before anyone began calling it the Moot, a word one of the pursers remembered from an old book of the humans' law, half meaning it as a joke against themselves and half not, and the name stuck the way names stick that fit a thing better than the thing's makers had

planned for. It had no standing in Dia-thireach law. No statute recognised it, no seal was cut for it, no clerk south of the guard-line had ever heard the word spoken. It met all the same, in the long room and then, when the long room proved too small, in a barn lent for the purpose by a Caol mhòr net-maker who asked nothing for the use of it beyond a promise that the floor would be swept after. It kept minutes from that first wet afternoon onward, in Hale's hand and then, as the years went on, in other hands after his, and the minutes ran unbroken, that first ledger and the books that followed it, from that day to this.

II

Of the Book with Nothing in It

The Moot's first business, once the matter of a name had been set aside as not worth the afternoon it would have cost, was the winter.

It did not take long to agree what the winter would need, because the whole room had lived through the last one and none of them wished to live through its like again unwarned. Grain, first, and more of it laid by earlier than the last time, since the stores that had come over the water in other years came no longer and would not be coming this one either, whatever the councillors at Cathair dhearg might privately believe about a harvest that had not yet been cut. A guard kept on the roads, against no enemy anyone could name, only because a household walking alone with a cart of oats on a bad night was safer for having somebody else's eyes on the road with it, and the memory of what had happened to nobody-knew-how-many households on the road to Doire ghlais the winter before sat close enough under the surface of that meeting that nobody needed to say it outright for everyone to understand it was being said.

And the dead of Doire ghlais, though the dying lay a season behind them by then, went into the minutes too, because Hale stood and told the room, plainly, in the flat clerk's voice he used for anything he did not trust himself to say any other way, what he had counted on the rise above the town and what the names pinned in the church porch had since told him, and asked whether the Moot, being now a thing that existed and could vote on matters, should not vote that the count be kept as the north's own record, since no one south of the guard-stone had asked to keep it and none, so far as anyone in the room could tell, so much as knew there was a count to be kept. The vote, when it was taken, by a show of

hands that Hale counted twice to be sure of the number, as though the habit of counting things twice had become, for him, something closer to a creed than a caution, carried without a voice raised against it.

The granary took longer to settle than the counting had, because a granary meant not only agreeing that grain should be laid by but agreeing whose grain it would be and on whose word it would be shared out when the laying-by season turned to the eating one, and a room full of householders who had spent a hungry year learning exactly how much a neighbour's honesty was worth in a bad month was in no hurry to hand that question over lightly. It was settled in the end, after the better part of another hour's argument, on terms near enough to what Caol mhòr's own fishermen had already worked out for themselves with the catch, unspoken and unminuted, the autumn before: each household to give what it could spare into the common store, in proportion to what it had, and the store to be kept under lock in the harbour-house cellar with three keys held by three householders chosen for the keeping and answerable to the Moot for every sack that left it. Peg Carrick's father was one of the three, being a man the whole harbour street trusted with a scale and a slate both, and a smith from Doire ghlas the second, and the third, after some argument, a widow named Mòrag Tulloch who had buried two children the winter before and whom nobody in the room, having heard that, was minded to argue against.

Hale wrote it all down as it was settled, article by article, in the hand that would come, in time, to be recognised the length of the north as the Moot's own, a hand that grew no more elaborate with the years but only surer, the letters set a fraction closer together as though the writer had learned, sentence by sentence and winter by winter, that paper was dearer than time and both were dearer than either had seemed to him on that first wet afternoon in the long room. By the time the light had gone from amber to grey in the one window and somebody had thought to light a lamp, the ledger meant for a fair day's tallies held four pages of minutes where that morning it had held none, and the room, tired now in the particular way a room is tired after it has done a thing it did not know, walking in, that it had come to do, began to empty into the wet evening a household at a time.

Hale stayed longest, blotting the last page by lamplight with a scrap of blanket someone had left behind, and it was only then, alone at the trestle with the door standing open on the harbour street and the smell of the sea coming in cold off the water, that the size of what the afternoon had made began to settle on him

properly. He had written the day at the top of a chandler's stock ledger because it was the only book to hand and because a habit three months old in a private book had by then worn into something closer to instinct than a choice made anew each time. He had not, sitting down at the trestle, thought of it as making anything at all, only as doing the one thing he knew how to do in a room that had asked more of him than he had expected. It was only afterward, walking home along the harbour street with the ledger under his coat against the damp, that he understood he had not merely taken minutes of an afternoon's argument. He had opened a book that the north had needed opening for a year and more and had not, until that afternoon, known it needed, and the book, once opened, was not the kind that closed again.

III

Of the Letter South

The granary filled slower than the Moot had hoped and faster than Hale, privately, had feared, and by the second week of an t-Sultain there was grain enough under Peg Carrick's father's lock to make the winter a different proposition from the one before it, though nobody in the north was fool enough to call it plenty.

It was at the Moot's third sitting, with the barn swept and the harvest mostly in and the evenings drawing down early enough that they met now by lamplight from the start, that the question of the letter came up. Somebody, it might have been Seonag, who had taken to sitting near the trestle at every meeting since the first as though she had appointed herself to watch that the writing stayed honest, asked plainly what use it was, keeping so careful a book of grain laid by and dead counted and guards posted, if nobody south of the guard-stone ever came to know a word of it. The council at Cathair dhearg governed the whole island, by its own reckoning; if it did not know the north kept a granary, or a count of its winter dead, or a book at all, then whatever the Moot wrote might as well, for all the good it did beyond Caol mhòr's own harbour wall, have been written on water.

Hale had turned the same thought over more than once himself, in the quiet after each meeting, and had come to no answer he much liked. But the room wanted a letter, and a room that had made him its clerk without asking whether

he wanted the office was not one he felt he had much standing to refuse, so a letter was drafted, in his hand, read aloud twice over for the room's approval and amended twice more before it satisfied anybody, and copied fair onto the best paper the chandler could be persuaded to part with.

It said, in the end, less than Hale would have liked and more than some in the room thought wise. It told of the households met at Caol mhòr and the book they had opened, and, in four careful lines that Hale rewrote three times before the room would let them stand, of a winter the year before in which the north had buried its own dead without troubling the south for help it had learned not to expect, and asked, without accusation, only as a plain matter of fact laid before whoever in the south might trouble to read it, that the council take note that such a winter had been, and such a book now existed of it. Nothing more than that was asked. Several in the room had wanted more, a plea for grain, a plea for a seat at whatever table the council kept its business on, and Hale, who had spent twenty years under an administration that answered every plea with either silence or a form, argued them down to the four lines on the grounds that a letter asking for nothing could not be refused, only ignored, and a letter ignored still stood, in a file somewhere, as proof that it had been sent.

The letter went south in the last week of an t-Sultain, carried by a carter named Robert Carrick, Peg's younger brother, a boy of fifteen who had never been further from Caol mhòr than Doire ghlas and who set off down the coast road with the letter sewn into the lining of his coat, on the theory, which was Ellen's and which Hale had not argued with, that a boy robbed on the road would lose his purse before he lost his coat. He carried, besides the letter, a week's bread and a small store of the Moot's coin against the tolls the humans' old roads still charged where some town had troubled to keep them up, and he was gone the better part of a fortnight, longer than the distance alone should have taken, because the road south of Doire ghlas was a road the boy did not know and he lost the better part of a day twice over finding it again.

He came back at last on a wet evening in the first week of an Dàmhair with an empty satchel and very little to report beyond the fact that the letter had been handed, at the harbour-house in Cathair dhearg, to a clerk who read the first line, looked at the boy for a long moment as though trying to decide what manner of thing had been put in front of him, and told him it would be seen to. Robert Carrick had asked, because Ellen had told him to ask and he had promised her he

would, whether there would be any word sent back. The clerk had said there would be, in time, and had not looked at him again.

Hale wrote that, too, into the minutes, in the same flat hand he used for grain and for graves: that the letter had been delivered and received, and that no answer had come with the boy who carried it, and that none was expected soon. It was the first entry of its kind in the Moot's book, though it would not be the last, and Hale, reading it back to the room at the next sitting, found himself thinking, though he did not say it aloud, that a letter received and not yet answered was at least a letter received, which was more certainty than the north had owned of the south's attention a season before, and less than he had privately hoped for when he set Robert Carrick on the road.

IV

Of the Twelve at Cathair dhearg

The letter, when it reached Cathair dhearg, reached it into a house that was only a month old itself.

Ailean mac Iain had not expected to be in the room when it was read. He had turned twenty-six that summer, a hill-born clerk with a tally-clerk's habits and no family in the capital to speak for him, and it was more by the accident of who had been standing nearest the council chamber's door on the morning the roll of under-clerks was read than by any design of his own that he found himself, on the twenty-third of an t-Sultain, sworn alongside a dozen others into the newest of the state's offices, with his hand on the same worn custody-book the custodians used for oaths of less consequence and a councillor he did not yet know by name reading out the form of words in a voice that suggested he had read it too many times that morning already to trouble himself with the weight of it.

He was sworn beside a woman a few years his senior named Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, a council clerk's daughter from the capital who had, by her own account, wanted the office since she was old enough to understand what a minute-book was for, and who stood through the swearing with a stillness Ailean found himself envying, since his own hands would not keep from working at the seam of his coat the whole time the words were said over him. She caught him at it afterward, in the corridor outside the chamber while the twelve councillors were still being seated within, and said, not unkindly, that a clerk who fidgeted through

his own oath would fidget through worse, and that he had best learn to sit on his hands before the council learned to notice them. He liked her for it, in the plain, immediate way a man likes someone who has told him a true thing without troubling to soften it, and the liking lasted the whole of the years they afterward worked in the same office, though neither of them, on that first morning, had cause to know it would.

The council was seated that same afternoon, twelve chairs set round a table too large for the room that held it, drawn, as the proclamation naming them had said, from the custodian families that had kept the island's old law through the humans' years and from the captains who had led the companies of the Severance war. Ailean knew two of the twelve by sight before the day was out: Fearchar mac Raghnaill, the captain whose plea that his company's roll not be burned Ailean had himself carried into the council's chests the summer before, and a custodian woman named Beathag nic Artair, whose family had kept the old rites at Cathair dhearg since before the humans came and who sat through the whole of the sitting with the particular patience of someone who has waited a long time for a thing and does not intend to let it show. The other ten he learned in the weeks that followed, among them Griogair mac Tormoid, a custodian of the western shore, and Cailean mac Sheumais, who had commanded a company at the fords of the western hills and spoke, when he spoke at all, in the clipped, unhurried way of a man used to being obeyed without needing to raise his voice for it.

Their minute-books were opened that same afternoon, a matched pair of ledgers bound in the capital's own leather and lettered in gold on the spine, a considerably finer thing than the Chandler's stock-ledger that had opened the north's book a month before, though Ailean, watching the first councillor's minute set down in a clerk's careful copperplate, found himself thinking, and did not say so to anyone, that fine binding was no guarantee a book would be read any more carefully for it.

It was into the third week of the council's sitting, once the business of shires and seals had settled into something like a routine, that the letter from the north came before them. It was read aloud, as every petition that reached the council chamber was read aloud, by the clerk whose office it was to read such things, in a voice that gave the four careful lines no more weight than it had given the tariff schedule read just before it. The room took it in the way a room takes in something it has not been asked to think about before and does not much wish to start

now: with a general stillness, a shuffling of papers that was not quite inattention and not quite attention either, and, from one of the twelve, a question.

"What," said Cailean mac Sheumais, into the small silence that followed the reading, "is a Moot?"

Nobody in the chamber answered him with any certainty, since nobody there had heard the word before that morning, and the clerk who had read the letter aloud, when pressed, could offer only that it appeared to be some manner of gathering the northern households held among their own houses, though on whose authority or to what settled purpose he could not say. Fearchar mac Raghnaill, who alone among the twelve had walked the north roads himself, in the winter the companies stood down, said only that he had heard the word once, from a harbour clerk at Caol mhòr, and thought no more of it at the time than a man thinks of any word he does not expect to need again. Beathag nic Artair asked whether the letter required an answer, and was told, by the same clerk, that nothing in it asked for one in so many words, whereupon the council, having no further question to put to a document that asked nothing and explained no more of itself than its own four lines, moved the letter to be filed, and the next matter on the day's roll was called.

Ailean, sitting at the clerks' table with the council's own minute-book open before him and Gormshuil's pen scratching steadily at his elbow, wrote the disposal down as he had been taught to write every disposal down, in the plain unadorned hand the office required: *Received and filed*. He thought, writing it, of the winter before, of the count he had heard was being kept somewhere north of the guard-stone, though he had never seen it and knew no more of it than the letter itself now told him, and of the plain fact, which the four lines had stated without complaint and the council had received without comment, that a whole country's worth of hunger and burial had just passed through the chamber in the time it took to read a paragraph and had left behind it nothing more than three words in a minute-book. He did not think, writing it, that he was doing anything remarkable. He was doing what the office required of him, in the hand the office required, and it would be some years yet before he came to understand that a clerk's three words, set down without comment in a book that outlived every hand that wrote in it, could carry, for whoever read them afterward, a weight the clerk himself had never meant to give them.

The light was long gone from the chamber's high windows by the time the day's roll was finished and the councillors rose from the table, and Ailean stayed,

as the newest and least senior of the clerks, to see the ink dried and the books put away, the same office that fell, thirty-odd miles north and a month earlier, to Hale in his barn with a lamp and a borrowed scrap of blanket. He closed the council's minute-book last of all, the gold-lettered spine catching what little lamplight remained in the room, and set it in its place on the shelf built for it, beside eleven others no fuller and no emptier than it was.

Two books had been opened that autumn, a month apart and thirty-odd miles between them, each by a clerk who had not chosen the office so much as had it settle on him in the course of an ordinary afternoon, each in a hand that would be read by people neither clerk could yet imagine. Neither book knew of the other's existence that first night, and neither Ailean nor Hale, closing his own book by his own lamp in his own town, had cause to think of the other man at all. But both books were shut, that night, for the same reason and in the same kind of dark: because the day's writing was done, and because a book, once opened, has to be closed again before the next day's can begin, whatever it is that the day has found worth setting down.

CHAPTER FIVE

Of the Grey Water and the Crownings

SE 2 AN T-SULTAIN – SE 3 AN DÙBHLACHD

A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte. Manannan, keep the sea shut.
— said at the harbour mouth of Seann Skell in the west, 11 an t-
Ògmhios, SE 3

I

Of the Sheds at Ros dhomhain

A ilean mac Iain had been an under-clerk of the council eight days when he was sent from Cathair dhearg to Ros dhomhain with a satchel of blank paper and a letter of introduction he was told not to open, since it was not written to him.

He opened it on the road anyway, in a barn where the carter had stopped to water the horses, and found it said almost nothing: that the bearer was to assist the harbour-master in whatever the harbour-master required, and that the council trusted the harbour-master's judgement in the matter of what that might be. He folded it back along its own crease and told himself, walking the last two miles into the town at dusk with the satchel banging against his hip, that a clerk who read letters not written to him would do well to learn to fold them convincingly, and that this was perhaps the whole of the education the council meant him to have from it.

Ros dhomhain in the second autumn of the kingdom was the busiest place Ailean had yet stood in. The humans had built it for a harbour and it still worked

as one: quays of dressed stone running further than a man could see in the evening mist, cranes standing idle on their gantries for want of anyone who understood how to swing them, and sheds in long rows behind the quay wall, each one stencilled in the humans' letters with a number and a word Ailean could not read. He had learned a little of the humans' hand as a boy, from a Mission reader in the hills who taught letters to any child who would sit still for them, but a little was not much, and Ros dhomhain's sheds held more of it than he had words for.

Dùghall mac Iain met him at the harbour-master's office on the first morning, a heavy, unhurried man of perhaps forty who kept his coat buttoned to the throat even indoors and spoke, when he spoke at all, as though every sentence cost him something he would rather have kept. He looked at Ailean for a long moment, looked at the letter, and said only, "Can you read their tally marks."

Ailean said he could read some of them.

"Then you'll do," said Dùghall, and took him through to a room behind the office where the humans' tariff sat in eleven bound ledgers on a shelf built to hold exactly eleven ledgers and no more, as though whoever built the shelf had known the number in advance and meant it to stay fixed. "This is what we collect by," he said. "It was theirs. It is ours now, because nobody has written another, and a harbour that collects nothing starves the shire it stands in." He took the first ledger down and opened it on the table between them, and Ailean saw page after page of the humans' close, slanting script, columns of figures, words he could sound out one letter at a time and rarely understand once sounded.

"You'll copy," Dùghall said. "Line by line, into Dia-thìris, as near as the sense will bear. Where you cannot make the sense bear it, you'll mark the line and bring it to me, and I will tell you what it says, because I have had two years now of guessing at what they meant by half of it, and I guess better than any man now living on this coast."

It was slower work than Ailean had thought any work could be. A single clause on the duty owed for salted fish landed at Ros dhomhain's own quay, no more than four lines in the humans' hand, took him the better part of a morning to render into a Dia-thìris that said the same thing and not some other thing dressed to look like it; and when he brought it to Dùghall, the older man read it twice, said "Nearly," and gave it back with two words struck through and two others written above them in a hand Ailean would come, over the weeks that followed, to know as well as his own.

"Why not write it fresh," Ailean asked him, on the third or fourth evening, when the ledgers were shut for the night and Dùghall had, unexpectedly, poured them both a measure of something the harbour-master kept for occasions he did not name. "A tariff of our own, instead of theirs turned into our words."

Dùghall considered the question longer than Ailean had expected, turning his cup on the table without drinking from it. "Because theirs is the one the boats already know," he said at last. "A skipper out of Cuan shean or Ceann mhòr has been paying this tariff, or its like, for longer than the kingdom has existed to collect it. Change the sums and he'll pay less gladly and cheat more freely, and I have neither the men nor the time to catch him at it. Turn the words and keep the sums, and he pays the same as he always has, to a different hand, and does not trouble himself over the difference." He drank, then, and set the cup down harder than he needed to. "Someday somebody will write a tariff that is ours from the first word to the last. It will not be me, and it will not, I think, be soon. In the meantime the harbour needs feeding, and I have found that a copied thing, honestly copied, feeds a harbour very nearly as well as an invented one, and costs a great deal less in error."

Ailean wrote that down, later, in the private book he had begun keeping since his first weeks at the counting-houses, a slim thing bound in undyed leather that he told no one of and showed to no one, in which he set beside the day's plain business the things said to him that he thought worth keeping. What use such a book would ever be to him he could not, that autumn, have said. He kept it anyway, the way a man keeps a coin found in a field, uncertain of its worth and unwilling all the same to leave it lying.

II

Of the Grey Water

Eight months into the tariff, with the last of the eleven ledgers open on his desk, Ailean was still at Ros dhomhain when the letter came naming him tally-clerk for a voyage.

It said little more than the bare assignment: that the council was sending a ship north-about, past the north-western capes, to learn whether the crossing the humans had used still lay open to any who cared to find it, and that a clerk was wanted aboard to keep the log of what was seen, in a hand the council could read

when she returned. Dùghall read the letter over Ailean's shoulder, said "So they've decided to look, then," in the flat voice he used for anything that was not the tariff, and gave Ailean three days to close his desk and be at Cuan shean by the eleventh of an t-Ògmhios.

Cuan shean lay a long day's ride from Ros dhomhain along the coast road, and Ailean covered it in one on a council horse he was not entirely sure he had the right to requisition, arriving with his satchel soaked through from a squall that had caught him an hour short of the town and a headache that did not leave him until well after the ship was under way. Cuan shean was the harbour where the first humans had come ashore, generations back, and it wore the fact the way an old man wears a scar he has stopped noticing: a stone laid into the quay near the harbour-master's steps, worn nearly smooth, that the town's children still touched for luck on their way to the boats, though none of them could have said, if asked, luck against what.

The ship was *An Sireadb*¹, the Seeking, a broad-bellied trader taken into the council's service for the voyage and fitted with stores for two months where her master judged one would likely do. Her master was Aonghas mac Mhurchaidh, a Cuan shean man near fifty who had spent the whole of his working life on the western coast and had never, by his own telling, been further from sight of land than a bad night's blow had once carried him against his will. He looked Ailean over on the quay, asked whether he had ever been to sea, and, on being told he had not, said only that he would learn quickly or he would learn nothing at all, since the sea rarely troubled to teach a man twice.

They sailed on the morning tide of the eleventh, out past the harbour mouth and the worn stone and the priests of Manannan who stood at the water's edge in their grey and said the old prayer over her wake, though whether it was said for the ship's going or her coming back Ailean did not think to ask until it was too late to. The wind held fair for the first two days, and the coast fell away behind them, the north-western capes rising and then themselves sinking below the horizon on the third morning, and after that there was nothing.

Ailean had expected the sea to be many things. He had not expected it to be grey, in the particular, total way it proved to be: grey water under a grey sky with no line between them that a man could swear to, day after day, so that a watch on deck came, after the first week, to feel less like looking outward than like standing

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inside a room whose walls had been painted the one colour and left otherwise bare. He kept the log as he had been told, the wind, the heading, the soundings where soundings could be got, and found, within a fortnight, that the log's plain columns were becoming the only thing aboard that still felt like solid ground under his hand, since the deck no longer troubled to hold still.

There was mist for the better part of nine days running, thick enough that the bow could not always be seen from the wheel, and Aonghas kept them under short sail and a man forward with a horn the whole of it, sounding at intervals into a grey that gave nothing back. Twice the lookout swore to a shape off the starboard bow, low and dark, and twice, when they stood in toward it, it proved to be nothing: once a trick of the mist folding back on the light, once, as near as anyone could afterward agree, a whale surfacing and gone before a second man could be brought to see it. Ailean logged both, in his flattest hand, as *sighted, not confirmed*, and privately thought that the phrase would do very well for the whole of the voyage, if anyone ever asked him to sum it in four words.

No land came. No second ship crossed their wake, no gull further from shore than a gull might wander on a bad day, no sign that the passage the humans had used had ever run through this water at all, though Aonghas held their heading as true as dead reckoning without a fixed star to check it by could be held, and did not, in Ailean's hearing, once suggest they had strayed from it. On the sixteenth day out, with the stores a third gone and the crew saying less to each other than they had said in the first week, Aonghas came to where Ailean sat with the log and said, without preamble, that they would come about at noon.

"We've not found it," Ailean said, not quite a question.

"We've not found anything," Aonghas said. "Which is not the same thing, and I'd thank you to log it as I've said it and not as you'd like it plainer. I've sailed this coast since before you were breeched, and I tell you there is a difference between a sea that has been searched and found empty and a sea that has simply refused, this once, to show us anything at all. I do not know which we have here. I know we have food for three weeks if we turn now and food for a week and a scramble home if we do not, and I am not master of this ship to find out by starving which of the two guesses was the truer one." He looked out at the grey a moment longer. "Log it your way if you must. But we come about at noon."

Ailean logged it, in the end, as plainly as he could manage: that *An Sireadh* had held a north-about heading for sixteen days from Cuan shean without sighting land, ship, or certain sign of any passage, and that her master, judging the

stores would not answer a longer search, had ordered her about. He did not write what he thought the log could not properly hold, which was that the grey water had felt, by the end, less like an empty sea than like a door that had been shut in a house whose owner no longer answered a knock, and that a man could search the doorstep as long as he liked without ever learning whether the house behind it was empty or merely silent.

III

Of the Way Niall Came

They raised the north-western capes again on the eleventh day of the return, and Seann Skell in the west two days after that, and it was only as the town's roofs came clear through the last of the mist that Ailean understood, counting the days on his fingers against the log, that he had missed the crowning.

It had been fixed, before he sailed, for the nineteenth of an t-Ògmhios, eight days after *An Sireadh*¹ was to leave, and he had known when he took the council's letter that he would miss it. Knowing had not made it lighter. Niall had been crowned at Cathair dhearg by Macha's rite while the ship lay blind in the mist, and crowned again, as far as any single fact of it reached Ailean, in every account he was given afterward, which was to say briefly, and without much that a man who had not stood in the crowd could add to.

The priests of Manannan came down to the quay at Seann Skell as she made her berth, the same grey-robed order, or near enough to be taken for the same, that had said the prayer over her going, and said the old words again at the harbour mouth as she came in: *A Mhanannain, cùm a' mbuir dùinte*, Manannan, keep the sea shut, though whether they meant it now as thanks that the mist had let her home again or as a plainer wish that the sea should stay shut and save the council the cost of a second voyage, Ailean could not have said, and did not ask. He stood at the rail with the log under his arm, the paper gone soft and faintly salt-stiffened from a month in a sea chest, and watched the town come up to meet him, and felt, more than anything else he could afterward put a name to, the particular flatness of a man returning from a thing that had cost him a month of his

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life to a country that had, in his absence, quietly finished doing something else entirely.

He learned the fact of the crowning properly that same evening, in a tavern near the harbour where the ship's crew had gone to spend what little pay was owed them before the road home, and where the innkeeper, asked idly by one of the sailors whether anything had happened while they were away, laughed and said that the kingdom had got itself a king and they had missed the whole of it.

The man had no more of it than the sailors had: the day, the rite, the crowd, and that there had been no quarrel over any of it that anyone south of the capes had heard tell of. Ailean wrote the day of the crowning into his own private book that night, beside nothing else, since there was nothing else about it he had seen with his own eyes to set beside it. He wrote a line of his own under it and then, reading it back, struck it through, because it seemed too much like the kind of thing a clerk ought not to set down where another clerk might one day read it and wonder what he had meant. The struck line does not survive; only the mark of its striking does.

South again, in the weeks it took to make Cathair dhearg by the coast road, he asked what he could of anyone who had been present, and pieced together, from three or four accounts that agreed in their outline and differed in every particular, that the rite had gone as such rites were said to go: the horses, the old words, a crowd larger than the capital had held in living memory, and a young man, Niall, five-and-twenty by the reckoning Ailean afterward heard given, crowned without a voice raised against him. It was, everyone agreed, entirely unremarkable, in the way that only the smoothest passages of a country's history are permitted to be unremarkable, and Ailean came, in time, to understand that he had missed nothing more dramatic than the absence of drama, though it took him the better part of that same winter to stop resenting, quietly and without ever saying so aloud, the month of grey water that had cost him the chance to judge that absence for himself.

IV

Of the Edge of the Map

By the second week of an t-Samhain, the tariff at Ros dhomhain finished, he was back at Cathair dhearg, and set, almost at once, to a table in a room he

had not worked in before, with the humans' district surveys spread before him under a lamp that smoked more than it lit, and told to draw the shires.

It was, on its face, simple work. The council had decided, in Ailean's absence, that the kingdom would be divided into *siorrachdan*, each named for its seat, and that the humans' own district lines, being the only whole survey of the island there was, would serve for the drawing, whatever anyone privately thought of governing a restored kingdom on a stranger's paperwork. Ailean's part was to copy the lines onto a fresh sheet in ink that would hold, and set the *Dia-thiris* names against them, town by town, so that the finished map could be shown to the twelve without embarrassment.

He worked at it through the short days of an *Dùbhlachd*, the lamp burning from mid-afternoon, tracing the humans' fine black lines with a rule and a steady hand that the months at Ros dhomhain and the weeks at sea had, between them, made a good deal steadier than it had been the year before. The lines ran clean and confident across the southern half of the survey, shire after shire falling into place along roads and rivers the humans had measured to a fineness Ailean privately admired more than he was willing to say aloud in a room where such an admission might be misheard as praise of the humans generally. It was only when his rule reached the north-western quarter of the sheet that the lines began to thin, and then, a hand's breadth further on, to stop altogether, giving way to a stretch of pale, unmarked paper across which someone in the humans' own hand had written a single word Ailean had learned, by then, well enough to read without help: *unsurveyed*.

He sat with the rule in his hand for some while, looking at the blank paper and at the coastline beyond it that the map-makers, whoever they had been and whatever had stopped them, had troubled to draw in outline at least, a rough grey wash of cliff and inlet with no lines dividing it into anything a shire could be cut from. He knew the coast the blank paper covered, or knew of it, the windy country beyond the great moss where the fowlers and sealers kept to themselves and the council's writ had never, so far as Ailean had ever heard, been tested against anyone's will to resist it. It was a country he himself had never set foot in; few at Cathair dhearg had.

He drew the shire lines as far as the survey carried them and no further, and sat some while longer with the pen dry in his hand, turning over how the gap ought to be entered, since a map that simply stopped, with nothing written to say why, seemed to him a worse thing to hand the council than a map that admitted its

own edge honestly. In the end he wrote, in the small space of clear paper left beside the blank stretch, a single line, no longer than the ones he had been trained to write for every disposal that crossed his table: *the windy coast is not in the survey*. He looked at it a moment, thought of striking it and writing something fuller, some explanation of the humans' unfinished work or the council's untested writ, and did not. The line said what was true and no more than was true, and he had learned enough, in two years of clerking, to trust a short true line over a long uncertain one.

Two further gaps troubled the drawing before the map was done. Out past the eastern cape and off the northern coast of the Tuathaich country, two rocks stood that the humans' Administration had kept as customs stations of their own, each with a station-house and nothing else, no town near enough to lend either its name. The council had no rule, that Ailean could find in any minute passed down to him, for folding one small holding into the shire of its nearest neighbour, and no one troubled, that autumn, to write one. He entered both as shires in their own right, each taking the name of the island it sat on, Eilean dhìreach and Eilean ìseal, and noted beside each, in the same flat hand, that the shire held no town and its dues would need collecting by a maor who kept his own boat.

At Ceann mhòr, in the last week of the drawing, a different kind of gap wanted filling. The Tuathaich fishermen of the town, who had broken the locks of the old harbour store the summer before last and shared out what they found, had gone on holding a rough sort of market there ever since, on their own custom and nobody's grant, and the council, drawing the northern shires for the first time onto paper that might one day be shown to a court, had to decide what, if anything, to do about a market that already existed and had never been asked for leave to. Word came down, in the last days before Ailean's map was to be shown, that the council would grant it: a market right for the north-west coast, its court to sit in the same harbour store whose locks had been broken, fish and oil and the goods of the concession farms to be sold there under whatever rough rule the townsfolk themselves had already, in practice, been keeping for a year and more without a grant to bless it. Ailean entered the right on his map in the space reserved for it, a single clause among a hundred others, and thought, setting it down, that it was very likely the smallest piece of writing he had done all season and, of everything on the sheet, the one thing on it that the people it named had already made true for themselves before anyone at Cathair dhearg troubled to write it so.

It was in that same week, in a tavern below his lodging, that he first saw written the words the south had begun to use of the crowning. The innkeeper kept his reckonings in a ledger on the counter, and against a debt of the feast night, settled at last without the usual argument over whether the feast had been worth the asking, he had written in his own untidy hand four words: *mar a thàinig Niall*, the way Niall came. "It went so smooth," the man said, when Ailean asked him, "that folk say it now of anything that goes the same way. A debt paid without a fight." Ailean copied the four words into his private book under the day's date. He thought it the only thing about the crowning he had seen with his own eyes.

The finished map went before the council in the last week of an Dùbhlachd, unrolled across the same table the twelve had sat their minute-books beside since the autumn before, and was received, so far as Ailean could tell from his place at the clerks' table, without any of the twelve remarking particularly on the blank stretch in its north-western quarter, or asking what lay beyond a line that read, in a clerk's plain hand, that the windy coast lay outside the survey. The map was approved, filed, and copied for the shire offices, and the copying, in time, carried Ailean's line to every maor's court on the island, unremarked in every one of them as far as he ever learned, a short true line about a coast nobody at Cathair dhearg had troubled to survey, sitting now, folded into the kingdom's own map, exactly where the survey itself had stopped and gone no further.

Ailean walked back to his lodging that night by the last of the light, thinking of *An Sireadh*¹ careened for the winter at Seann Skell, her hull scraped bare of a month's weed, and thought, not for the first time that season, of the grey water beyond the north-western capes and the blank paper beyond the great moss, two edges of two different maps that had each, in their own way, told him the same thing: that a kingdom's writ, like a ship's log, ran only as far as someone had troubled to carry it, and stopped, honestly or not, exactly where the carrying stopped, whatever lay beyond.

1. the seeking

CHAPTER SIX

Of the Great Wave

SE 4 AM FAOILLEACH – SE 5 AN GIBLEAN

Tha e san tonn. He is in the wave of it.

— a saying of the southern coast, after the fourth year of the kingdom

I

Of the Maoir and the Roll of Arms

The shires needed governors before they had governed anything, and the council gave them one apiece before the ink on the shire lines was properly dry. A *maor* was set over each, to gather the Crown's dues and keep its peace, and by am Faoilleach of the fourth year every shire in the kingdom, north and south, had one riding its roads and lodging in its seat town. In the Tuathaich shires the maoir sent north were Dia-thìrich to a man, for the council saw no reason a shire's governor should share the tongue of the people it governed, only the tongue of the court that had appointed him. At Ceann mhòr the new maoir took the old human magistrate's house for his own, and the townsfolk, who had called it by its old name through two changes of master already, went on calling it so, and let him find that out for himself.

Ailean mac Iain carried the council's letters of appointment north that winter, eleven of them, sealed and unsealed, to be delivered by hand and witnessed signed. It was work below a clerk of his years, and he knew it, and did it anyway, because the alternative was another season copying the same surveys he had already copied twice. He liked the roads better than the desk in any case. A letter of appointment, once you had carried enough of them, told you a good deal about the man

it was written for: which ones asked what dues they might expect to raise, and which asked only where the seat town's best inn stood.

With the maor came the dues themselves, set out in one short minute of the council's twelve: a head-due, *cis-cinn*, on every household by the number of its heads, and a market-due, *cis-margaidh*, on every sale a seller of the kingdom made. At Ros dhomhain the humans' old harbour tariff was left standing a while longer, for want of a coin of the kingdom's own to take the market-due in; it would be a year and more yet before Fearchar Bonn's mint gave the council money to call its own. Ailean noted the minute in his own book without comment, though he thought, riding away from the reading of it, that a due on every head was a strange thing to call new when the humans had kept one much like it for two generations before the council ever thought of it, differently pronounced and identically collected.

The clerks of the council had one further task that winter, smaller than the dues and, Ailean privately judged, more foolish: a roll of arms for the new shires, so that a maor might seal his letters with something more than his own thumb-mark. Clàr nan Suaicheantas¹, they called it when it was done, and it took the better part of am Faoilleach and an Gearran to finish, for the clerk given the drawing of it, a careful, near-sighted man named Tòmas, had never made a badge in his life and had to learn the trade from a book of arms left behind at the Residency by whoever had kept such things for the humans. He copied faithfully, and copying faithfully was his undoing, for the book had been made for lands the shires had never seen and beasts the island had never held. Lions came onto the seals of shires that had never had one closer than a fireside tale; a shire on the eastern moss got a parrot, green and improbable, because the charge above it in the book had pleased Tòmas's eye and he saw no rule against choosing by eye. A crocodile, open-jawed, went onto the seal of a hill shire whose worst beast was a fox. The Dia-thìrich shires kept the old pointed shield of the custody's own seal beneath their new creatures; the Tuathaich shires, being newer to sealing anything at all, were given the rounder shield the humans' own district seals had used, and nobody thought to ask them which they would rather have carried.

Only one house objected in the whole roll, and it objected by asking for something rather than refusing something, which the council found it could not fault. At Seann Skell in the west the order of Manannan sent word that it wanted no

1. the roll of arms; lit. 'the table of the badges'

lion and no crocodile, but the badge it had always carried on the harbour gate: a yellow scorpion, for Manannan's cup, which no one now living could explain and everyone in the west knew by sight. Tòmas drew it as asked, the one true creature of the whole roll, and it went out on the shire's letters that spring while the lions and the parrots and the crocodile stood beside it on the page, equally solemn, equally sealed, equally false.

"They will forget it was ever otherwise," Ailean said to Tòmas, over the finished roll, meaning it half as a joke.

"They forget most things," Tòmas said, not joking at all, and rolled the sheets for the council's chest.

Not every shire took its roll so lightly. At the seat of a small hill shire in the south-west, a custodian's widow who had kept the old custody's books through the war years asked Tòmas, in a letter Ailean himself carried both ways, whether a shire that had never had a badge before the humans came was obliged to carry one now the humans had gone. Tòmas's answer, which Ailean also carried, was that the council required a seal of every shire that meant to issue a letter with any standing behind it, and that a shire without one would find its writs read more slowly at Cathair dhearg than a shire with even a borrowed crocodile. The widow's shire got its lion, like the rest, and its letters, Ailean noted with some satisfaction some years later, were read no faster for it.

Of the eleven new maoir Ailean had ridden the letters to, the one he came to know best was Coinneach mac Ailein, a custodian's younger son given Siorrachd Baile Mòr mhòr, the seat town he had grown up thirty miles from and never once visited before his appointment. Baile Mòr mhòr's courthouse, a solid enough building by the town's own account, had burned in the last summer of the war and never been raised again; there had been talk of rebuilding it three times and money found for it not once. Coinneach heard his first cases, that Faoillean, under the roof of the market hall, with the stallholders packed to the walls on either side of him for want of anywhere better to stand and a fishwife's scales still hanging from the beam above his head. He liked it, by all report, better than he expected to; a market roof let more light in than any courthouse he had heard described, and the crowd, he said, kept a man honester than four walls would. When the new courthouse was finally raised, two years on, he moved his court there for exactly one sitting and moved it back to the market hall the week after, and so did the two maoir who followed him, until holding court under the fish-scales be-

came simply how justice was done at Baile Mòr mhòr, and no one thought to write down why.

Coinneach's first sitting under the market hall's beam was, by his own account to Ailean over a jug that evening, less a court than a waiting-room the town had decided to try law in while it made up its mind whether the arrangement suited it. His first case was a dispute over a fishwife's stall-place that had gone unsettled since before his appointment, two women each claiming the corner nearest the well on grounds neither could produce in writing, and he settled it by asking the rest of the stallholders, who had watched the quarrel simmer for two years and had opinions enough for a bench of justices. The crowd's answer was unanimous and immediate, and Coinneach, new to the office and not yet proud of it, took it. "A market roof teaches you what a courthouse hides," he told Ailean. "There is always someone standing near enough to know the truth of a thing. You have only to ask them." Ailean wrote the remark down in his own book, and kept it there.

Ailean carried all this news south with him in am Màrt, eleven letters answered, a roll of arms delivered, a maor settled under a market roof by his own choice. It seemed to him, riding home, a fair account of a kingdom's fourth year: small offices filled, small dues set, a false lion or two, nothing that would trouble the world. He wrote as much in his own book, in a hand steadier than the matter deserved.

II

Of the Short Night

The sea gave the south three months to think itself settled before it answered.

It came on the third night of an t-Ògmhios, in the short dark that mid-summer leaves between one grey and the next, without a wind before it and without any sign the fishermen of the southern coast, who watched the sky and the swell as their trade required, could afterward say they had seen and ignored. One moment, by every account gathered after, the sea stood where the sea always stood. The next it did not, and there was no moment worth the name between the two.

Three towns took the worst of it in a single night: Cnoc chaol, small and low on its shingle; Cuan dhearg, the larger harbour a few miles along the coast; and

Achadh mhin, which stood a little way inland on fields the sea had never in living memory troubled to reach. The wave that broke Cnoc chaol and Cuan dhearg ran on past them and over Achadh mhin's low ground before it spent its force, and salted in one night what three generations of that township's people had ploughed.

The first word to reach Cathair dhearg came by a rider who had ridden through the dark without waiting for light to see the road by, and it said less than it should have, because the man carrying it had seen only the edge of what had happened and did not yet have words for the middle of it. The council's twelve met before full morning, which they had not done since the Severance, and voted a relief party south down the coast road before the sitting broke: grain, blankets, timber, and men enough to dig where digging was wanted. They voted, in the same short sitting, that a tally be kept, for the council by its fourth year had learned that little it did not count went reliably on being done at all, and a disaster untallied was a disaster it could neither answer nor be praised for answering.

Ailean was given the tally-book because he happened to be at the council's door when the order for one was given, and because no one else volunteered fast enough to be asked twice.

III

Of Cuan dhearg

he smelled the town before the road showed it to him, which he had not expected and did not, afterward, forget. Salt was in it, more salt than a sea town's ordinary air ever carried, and torn weed, and beneath both something he did not try to name and was glad, later, that no one asked him to.

The harbour of Cuan dhearg was gone. Where it had stood there was brown water lying where water had no business lying, and a broken line of piles standing up out of it like a row of teeth kicked half out of a jaw. Ailean stopped his horse at the top of the last rise and looked for the boats a long moment before he understood that he was looking in the wrong place, and that a man of the relief party had come up quietly beside him and was pointing, not at the water, but inland, at the fields behind the town.

The boats of Cuan dhearg lay among the barley. Some had gone over on their sides and lay half sunk in the mud the sea had left behind it; some stood upright

as they had never stood on any tide, their keels bedded in a furrow as if a careful hand had set them there. One, nearest the road, sat entirely square in the row it had come to rest in, her mast still stepped, her rigging still slack from her own weight and not from any hand that had touched it since. A gull sat on her yard as Ailean rode past, and did not move for him.

He wrote it down. He did not know, setting pen to the first page of the book he had been given, what else a man was meant to do with a boat standing in a barley field with her mast stepped, so he wrote what he saw, in the plain hand the council's service had taught him, and rode on to count what else there was to count.

The first living soul who spoke to him in Cuan dhearg was an old woman sitting on an upturned creel at the edge of the barley, watching the men of the relief party right the boats she plainly did not expect them to right. She had lost, she told him without being asked, a husband, a son, and the roof over both of them, in that order, though she said it in the flatter order of things lost rather than things loved, which Ailean understood well enough not to correct. When he asked her, because the tally-book required an answer and he had not yet learned how to ask the question kindly, where he might find them to mark the place, she looked at him a long moment and said only that the sea did not give receipts. He wrote *not found* against both names and did not ask her anything else that day, though he came back the next week with bread from the relief stores and left it beside her without a word, and she took it without one either, and that, between them, was the whole of their acquaintance.

There was a great deal else. He spent that first week doing what the relief party's captain called the ugly work and Ailean, in his own book, did not call anything at all: walking the wrecked streets with two other clerks, naming what could be named of the dead and marking what could not with the place it had been found, so that a family coming later to ask might at least be told where to dig. The dead of Cuan dhearg were carried up onto the rise behind the town, above the old harbour line, and buried there through that first fortnight in ground the sea had not reached and, by every calculation the fishermen there could offer him, never would.

Through the rest of the summer he counted other things, because the council, having sent him once, kept finding reasons to keep him there: the boats that could be righted and the boats that could not; the wells fouled with salt and the wells still sweet; the grain lost at Achadh mhin and the grain that might yet be saved

from the fields the wave had only brushed. He rode between the three towns and back to Cathair dhearg and out again so many times that summer that he stopped, by an Lùnastal, noting the road at all in his book, only what waited at the end of it.

IV

Of the Count and the Relief

On the twenty-fourth of an t-Samhain, five months and more after the short night that had made the work, Ailean closed the tally-book he had carried since an t-Ògmhios and carried its sum, rather than the book, to the council's chamber, because the twelve had asked for a number and not a ledger.

The dead of the three towns came to a little over forty. He gave the figure as it stood, without rounding it either way, and a councillor asked him to say it again, and he did, and no one asked a third time.

One of the twelve, a custodian who had sat through the reading with his arms folded, asked whether the treasury could bear a relief roll on top of the roads, the guard, and the mint that was still only talked of, and was answered, before Ailean could open his mouth to say the figure was not his to spend, by another of the twelve who had held her seat since the council first sat and had buried kin of her own in worse winters: that a kingdom which could find silver for a roll of arms with a scorpion on it could find grain for forty dead and a harbourless town, and that the council would be a poor thing indeed if the first question it asked of its own disaster was the price of answering it. The custodian did not argue the point further, and the vote that followed carried without a division Ailean thought worth recording, though he recorded it anyway, out of habit and because the argument itself seemed to him worth keeping even where the vote was not close.

The wave, he told them, had not stopped at the three towns the first riders had named. It had run on up the gulf as far as Ros gharbh, the seat of its own shire, and broken the quays there too, and cast the greater part of that town's fishing fleet up onto the headland above the harbour, boat on boat, some of them a hundred yards from any water a boat had business being near. He had walked that headland himself, in an Lùnastal, among hulls lying keel to keel like beasts driven up out of the sea to die on dry ground, and had counted them the way he had

counted everything else that summer, boat by boat, hull sound or hull stove, until the counting itself had begun to feel less like a clerk's work than a kind of penance he had not asked for and could not now refuse. Ros gharbh itself stood high enough above its harbour that it had lost few of its people. It had lost, by Ailean's count, very nearly every boat it owned, and a fishing town without its boats, he told the twelve, plainly, was a town that would need feeding through the next two winters whether or not the sea troubled it again.

The council, to its own later credit and Ailean's private surprise, acted on the figure rather than filing it. It was the first disaster the restored kingdom had met wholly on its own terms, without a human tariff or a human magistrate to answer for it, and it met this one, by its own later reckoning, well. The survivors of Achadh mhin were moved off their salted fields before the winter closed the roads, to higher ground a mile inland where the sea had never stood, and their seed for the coming year was paid out of the treasury without a due asked in return: the first relief the restored kingdom had ever granted anyone, north or south, and Ailean noted in his own book, this time not without comment, that it had taken forty deaths and a summer's counting to produce it.

Cnoc chaol was built again the following spring on the slope behind its old ground, high enough that the sea would have to climb a hill to trouble it a second time. The old site was left exactly as the water had left it, and the townsfolk who had lived there called it an Tràigh Bhàthte¹, the drowned strand, and did not build on it again, though in years the salt washed thin enough that grass grew back across it and sheep grazed there as if nothing at all had happened on that ground, which Ailean thought, the one time he rode past it years afterward, was in its own way the strangest part of the whole business.

Off the southern coast, where none had lived the year round, the wave passed also over the low island of Eilean mhin, whose grass the shepherds of Ros gharbh and Cnoc chaol had summered their flocks on time out of mind. No one had died there, for no one had been there to die; but the shepherds who had always gone back in spring did not go back that year, or the year after, and within a few seasons Eilean mhin's grass was left to grow as it pleased, grazed by nothing heavier than a gull.

1. the drowned strand at old Cnoc chaol

V

Of the Word the Wave Left

Ros gharbh's boats took longer to replace than Cnoc chaol's houses, for a house can be raised by hands that have never built one and a boat cannot, and the town spent the better part of the following year borrowing hulls from harbours the wave had not reached while its own were built again on the beach above the new-cleared quay, one keel at a time, through the spring of the fifth year. The shipwrights of the gulf, who had lost trade to no one in living memory and now had more of it than their sheds could hold, took on hands from towns the wave had never touched, and for a season or two Ros gharbh's yard rang from before light to after dark with adzes worked by men who had never smelled the town's own salt before that winter. Some of the boats they raised carried the old hulls' names, painted again in the old lettering by widows and daughters who had kept the paint-pots from the wrecks; others were given new names outright, chosen, more than one shipwright noted, with a care the town had never troubled to spend on naming a boat before that winter. By the time the last of the new fleet was launched, the town's people had stopped calling it the year of the wave among themselves and started calling it, more simply, the bad year, as though there had only ever been the one.

What the wave left behind it, once the dead were counted and the boats replaced and the grain paid for, was a word. The relief parties who gathered the accounts of that short night, sitting with survivors in kitchens that had lost half their walls, set down again and again a single word the people of the coast reached for when the thing they were describing had come on them too fast and too total to be told any other way: *tonn*, wave. A man out of work in one season and drink the next was in the wave of it. A fever that swept a household in a night was in the wave of it. Within a generation the sense had travelled far up the coast beyond anyone who had felt the water, and was heard as far north as market towns that had never had a harbour to lose, so that a saying born of one short night on one stretch of coast became, in the mouths of people who had never seen Cuan dhearg's broken piles, a way of naming any ruin that came without asking leave.

Ailean kept his own tally-book, once its sum was given and recorded, and did not know, laying it in the council's chest beside the letters of appointment and the roll of arms with its false lions, that it was the first count in the kingdom's short life to move the council to act rather than to file, or that it would not be the

last time a number he had written down did more than a petition ever managed to. He knew only, riding north again that autumn past the piles of Cuan dhearg's old harbour, now half swallowed by the tide that had ruined them, that the town below the rise had buried its dead, righted what boats it could, and gone back, before the winter closed in, to fishing the water that had done it the harm, because there was, in the end, no other water to fish.

Tha e san tonn. He is in the wave of it, the south still says, of any sudden ruin.

PART TWO

OF COIN, RICE AND MOUNTAIN

CHAPTER SEVEN

OF the COIN with the Coal in its Seal

SE 5 AN GIBLEAN – SE 6 AM MÀRT

He turned the king's silence into iron, and the iron into bread. — a
Library clerk's plain-prose rendering of a Tuathaich song made of
Joseph Marlow, sung at Doire mhin

I

Of the Boxes Under the Beds

The proclamation came up the coast road to Caol mhòr on a wet morning in an Giblean, nailed to the market cross by a maor's rider who did not get down off his horse to read it and did not wait to be asked what it meant. Walter Hale read it himself, over the shoulders of two fishermen who could not, and then read it again, more slowly, because the second time he thought he must have mistaken it.

The humans' coin, every silver mark and worn copper penny that had crossed the water in a Company man's pocket or a Company ship's strongbox, was cried down. Within the year it would cease, by the council's own word, to be money at all. In its place the kingdom would strike its own.

It was, Hale wrote in his day-book that night, a fair enough thing for a kingdom to do, and he did not doubt that whoever had signed it south had done it for reasons that made sense at a council table. He had sat at enough tables himself, in his time, to know that most decisions look reasonable from the chair that makes them. What he set down under that, in a smaller hand, was the thing the council

table could not see from where it sat: that in every house along the coast road, under a hearthstone or a floorboard or the false bottom of a meal-chest, there was a box, and in the box was what a family had put by, coin by coin, against a bad winter or a daughter's wedding or the year the boats came home empty, and that by the council's own word every one of those boxes now held metal, plain and simple, where savings had sat the day before.

He went round Caol mhòr with his book that week on his own account, nobody having asked him to, because it was the kind of thing his hands did while his mind was working out what to do about it. Ellen watched him counting other people's coin at the kitchen table in the evenings and said nothing, which after eighteen years of marriage he understood as her particular way of telling him she thought it was the right work and a fool's errand both at once. David, twelve that spring and already better with figures than his father, added the columns for him without being asked. Alice, younger, wanted to know why the king's men couldn't just say a coin was still a coin if everybody agreed to go on believing it, which Hale thought, turning it over afterward, was as good a question about money as he had ever heard asked, and one he had no answer for that a child would find satisfying.

By an t-Ògmhios the tally stood at something over four hundred marks in the old coin, spread thin across better than two hundred households, no single sum among them large, every one of them real. It was, Hale wrote, the whole of what the north had managed to keep back from thirty years of tariffs, tithes and bad harvests, and the council had voided it with a proclamation that took a rider less than a morning to nail up and ride away from.

An old woman at the harbour end of the town, whose name the day-book gives only as Widow Tull, brought him her box unasked one evening, tipped it out on his table and put to him, plainly, as a question she wanted answered by a man who kept figures for a living rather than as any complaint, whether the king's men meant to give her anything at all for it or only to tell her, in a kinder voice than the rider's had been, that it had never truly been hers. Hale had no answer that satisfied either of them, and wrote down only her question, word for word, under that week's total, because he judged it worth more than anything he could have said in reply.

He did not write, because he did not yet fully believe it himself, what the number was going to feel like a year on, when the old coin was worthless and the

new coin scarce and the distance between the two had to be crossed by every household in the north on its own, with nothing from the south to help it over.

II

Of the Mint at Cathair dhearg

Far south, at the old counting-house in Cathair dhearg that the humans had built for their own tariffs and the council had taken whole, the kingdom's new coin was already being made, and the Library's later telling of it, drawn from the mint's own first ledgers, has the particular pleasure of a thing done well by a man who liked doing it.

Fearchar mac Dhòmhnaill, whom the counting-house clerks and afterward the whole kingdom called Fearchar Bonn, had been a die-cutter's apprentice under the humans and a die-cutter's journeyman after them, and when the council needed someone who understood a press and a punch and the temper of metal under a hammer, his was the only name anyone put forward twice. He set up his mint in the humans' own strongroom, with the humans' own scales, and he spent the better part of a winter grinding coal dust fine enough to work into an ink that would not smear, because the council had decided, on the advice of Òrd Mhacha¹, that every coin of the realm should carry the seal of the mountain that fed it, pressed dark into the die's deepest cut, so that a coin clipped at its edge would show the coal's own colour where the silver had been shaved away and could not be passed off as whole.

It took him four tries to grind the dust fine enough and three more to find the binder that would hold it to the die without fouling the strike, and by the time he had it right he had ruined enough good silver in the trying that a lesser man would have been called before the council to explain himself. Fearchar Bonn was not called before anyone. He set the first true coin of the Rìoghachd Dia-thìr² on the counting-house table in front of the head of the treasury and said, by the mint's own later account, only that it was done, and the treasury man turned it over twice in the light from the window and said it would do very well.

The coin was honest, in the sense that its weight was true and its seal could not easily be forged, and it was holy, in the sense that Òrd Mhacha's blessing had

1. the order of Macha

been said over the first striking and the coal in its ink was reckoned a small piece of the mountain carried out into every purse in the kingdom. The south, which had lost little in the exchange beyond the trouble of getting used to a new face on its money, liked it both ways, and said so, and the coin passed from hand to hand at Cathair dhearg's markets within the month as though it had always been the coin of the realm and the humans' silver had been some passing foreign currency, tolerated but never quite trusted.

Hale never saw a struck coin until the autumn, and when at last one came north in a maor's satchel and he was shown it across a table at the Moot's house, he held it longer than the showing required, turning it as Fearchar Bonn's treasury man had turned the first one, tilting it to the light to find the dark line at the rim where the coal ink sat in the die's cut. It was, he wrote, a well-made thing, and he did not doubt Fearchar Bonn had earned the pride the mint's clerks plainly took in him. What he could not get past, holding it, was that not one soul south of the guard-stone had asked, before they cast their honest and holy coin, what the north was to use in its place while it waited its turn to be honest and holy too.

The maor's man who had brought it north, a young clerk out of Cathair dhearg glad enough of a fire and a bowl after two wet days on the road, told the room, when Hale asked him plainly how a household of the south was managing the exchange, that he did not rightly know, since his own family's savings had never been more than a season's wage put by, and that had gone on the rent before the crying-down. He meant no unkindness by it either, and said as much himself when he saw how the room had gone quiet around him; he had simply never had cause to think what a box under a bed might hold in a town he had never seen.

III

Of the Letter Received and Filed

The Moot met on it twice before it agreed what to write, which for a room that had lately settled the winter's grain in a single wet afternoon was, Hale noted, a measure of how much harder it is to argue a household's coin than its bread. Householders who had said nothing when the granary was shared out by need rather than by holding found their voices readily enough when it was

their own box under discussion, and the argument ran two full evenings by the light of the Moot's tallow before it settled on a single ask, plain enough that no one south could pretend to misunderstand it: an exchange, mark for mark, of the humans' cried-down coin for the kingdom's new, at a rate to be set by the council and honoured by the council's own mint.

The first evening was mostly given to two men who wanted the letter to say a great deal more than that, one arguing that the Moot should ask outright why the council had cried the coin down without so much as a word north first, the other that it should say nothing of blame at all and only ask, plainly and humbly, for the exchange, on the ground that a letter which scolded a council was a letter a clerk could file with an easier conscience than one which merely asked. Hale, called on at last to say which he favoured, said neither, and said instead that a letter's business was to get an answer, not to be right, and that he had sat across enough humans' counting-house desks in his own time to know that a plain ask, however humbly worded, stood a better chance of being read to the end than a clever one. The room took his word for it chiefly because he was the one among them who had once made his living writing such letters to men who did not have to answer them, rather than for any special skill in the arguing of it, and by the second evening the four lines he had first set down stood nearly unaltered, save that someone thought to add the date, so that whoever received it south would know, to the day, how long it had taken to reach them.

Hale wrote the letter himself, in the humans' hand because he had never learned to write another, and read it back to the room twice before anyone would let him seal it, and the room's chief objection both times concerned the waiting rather than the wording, since a letter carried south by cart took the better part of a week to reach Cathair dhearg and a further stretch of unknowable length to come back, if it came back with anything more than an acknowledgment of its own receipt. David, who was learning his letters that year off his father's shoulder as much as off Ellen's teaching, copied the fair draft out a second time so that one might go with the winter carter and a second wait for the spring roads, on the reasoning, which Hale thought sound, that a petition sent twice by two different hands was harder for a clerk to lose than a petition sent once.

The letter went south in am Faoilleach, in the coat pocket of a carter named Fionnlagh who had made the run twice before and grumbled both times about the state of the road past the guard-stone, and it reached the council's chests, in the ordinary course of the council's business, in the hands of an under-clerk who

had by then been four years at that desk and had learned, as under-clerks do, to read a letter's whole business in the time it took to unfold it.

Ailean mac Iain read the Moot's letter standing at the chest where such things were kept, noted its date, its seal, and its single plain ask, and set it down among that quarter's petitions with the others, because there was nothing in the council's own instructions to him that told him to do anything else with a letter that asked the treasury for money it had not budgeted. He wrote across its top, in the short clerk's hand the chests were full of, the two words the room north would come, in time, to know by heart though none of them would ever see the paper it was written on: *received; filed*.

Hale, hearing of it months later from the same carter who had carried the letter down, judged there was no unkindness in it at all, and said so to Ellen the night he heard it, turning the coin Fearchar Bonn had struck over in his fingers by the fire. A clerk with a chest full of petitions and no standing order to answer this one had done, with perfect correctness, exactly what his post required of him, and that plain correctness was, Hale thought, a far worse thing to reckon with than unkindness would have been, since unkindness at least could be argued with.

IV

Of Doire mhin in the Snow

he walked to Doire mhin himself in an Gearran, ten miles on a road half snow and half the black mud the snow left when it thawed at noon and froze again by dusk, because a letter had come up from there that he judged wanted seeing rather than reading, and because, if he was honest with the day-book that night, he wanted to see with his own eyes a thing he had only heard told twice removed.

Joseph Marlow's forge stood at the mill end of the town, close enough to the millrace that its wheel turned a second, smaller wheel off the same water when the smith needed more draught than his own arm could give the bellows, and Hale found him there in the smoke and the orange dark with a crucible set deep in the coals and a leather sack at his feet that clinked, when Marlow toed it, with a sound Hale had heard often enough that winter in his own kitchen, counting other men's boxes at his own table.

It was dead coin, Marlow told him, without being asked, because by then half of Doire mhin had brought him theirs and he had stopped waiting for a man to explain what everybody in the room already knew. It was worth nothing as money and it was worth exactly what it had always been worth as metal, which was a good deal, if a man had a use for metal and a fire hot enough to give it one. He had melted down his own box first, to see it done before he offered to do it for a neighbour's, and cast the silver, once it ran, into the long flat shape a plough-share wants before the grinding, and he showed Hale the first of them, cooled and dressed on the bench, still bearing along one edge the ghost of a king's profile that the mould had not quite erased.

What he charged for the work, Marlow said, turning the share so the forge-light ran along it, was the price of his charcoal and nothing beyond it, because he reckoned, and said plainly enough that Hale wrote it down that night nearly word for word, that a man should not be made to pay twice for coin the council had already taken off him once. He had two sons and a leather apron between them and more dead coin waiting in the yard than he could turn in a season, and he did not expect, he said, to grow rich on it, and did not much want to. His eldest, Harry, nine and long-armed for his age, was working the bellows that afternoon with the steady unbothered rhythm of a boy who had done it every day of a hard winter and stopped noticing the work as work; Marlow told Hale, over the ring of the hammer, that the boy was promised, when he turned thirteen, to a shipwright's yard at Cuan shean, on the word of a Cuan shean man who had passed through Doire mhin the autumn before and watched Harry true a plough-beam by eye without a level, and that he, Joseph, would miss the second pair of hands at the bellows, when the day came, a good deal more than he let the boy see.

There was a song already going round the forge by then, though Marlow himself would not sing it in front of a stranger and looked faintly embarrassed when Hale asked after it, and it was left to one of the neighbour women waiting her turn with a sackful of her husband's savings to hum a few bars of it under her breath while she watched the crucible: a plain tune, easy to carry, with a line in it about a king's silence and a smith's fire that Hale did not catch whole that day and would not hear entire, set down properly, for some years yet.

Harry left off the bellows only when his father told him plainly to go and warm his hands, and stood a while at Hale's elbow looking at the finished share on the bench with the particular attention of a boy already halfway gone from a

place in his own mind. He asked Hale, not his father, whether Cuan shean's yards worked in the humans' way of building a hull, plank first and frame after, which he had heard was faster but less sound, or the frame first, which he had heard was slower and better, and seemed disappointed when Hale, who had spent his working life on a quay and not in a yard, could not tell him. Joseph Marlow, hearing the question over the ring of the hammer, said only that the boy had been asking some version of it all winter and would have his answer soon enough without a stranger's help, and there was in the way he said it both the pride of a man who meant to lose his best pair of hands gladly and the plain arithmetic of a man who did not know yet how he would manage the forge without them when the day came.

He wrote in his book only that the town of Doire mhin, given nothing from the south but a proclamation and a fortnight's warning, had found between one forge and the next winter's ploughing a way to turn what the council had taken worthless and left worthless into something a field could use, and that no one had asked the council's leave to do it.

V

Of the Chits at Inis thais, and the Turn

he heard the other telling of it that same winter, at second hand from a Ros bheag man who traded down the west coast and had it, in his turn, from a merchant of Inis thais who came up as far as Caol mhòr each spring with dried fish and left with wool. At Inis thais, on the south-western coast where the new coin was slower to arrive than almost anywhere else in the kingdom, the town's merchants had not waited on the mint at all. They traded through the winter on paper: chits written and countersigned on the strength of the great house of Òrd na Cloiche¹ that stood in the town, whose word for a debt no one on that coast had ever doubted, and when the new coin did at last come south to them in any quantity, the chits were carried to the house's own door and redeemed there, in full, less a tenth kept back by the house for the keeping of the paper and the trust that had stood behind it through the lean months.

It struck Hale, turning the two tellings over together by his own fire that Gearran, that the south-west had solved exactly the trouble the north was drowning

in, and solved it without troubling the council for a single word of leave, because the house at Inis thais had something the Moot at Caol mhòr did not: a name old enough and trusted enough on its own ground that its paper could stand in for coin until the coin came. The Moot had no such name. It had only its letter, and the letter had been received and filed.

He asked the Ros bheag trader, before the man went on his way south again, whether the tenth the house of the Stone kept back struck anyone at Inis thais as dear, and the trader laughed, not unkindly, and said that a tenth kept back by a name a man trusted was cheaper, by every account he had ever heard on that coast, than a whole savings box kept back by a name he had never been asked to trust at all. Hale wrote that answer down too, and thought about it longer than the length of it seemed to want.

He set the coin Fearchar Bonn had struck down on the table beside the ploughshare Marlow had given him, part payment, the smith insisted, for the walk out in the snow, and looked at the two of them a long while before he wrote anything at all. What he wrote, when he did, he did not show the Moot until the spring, and even then he showed it to no one but David, who copied it fair into the minute-book without comment, because his father had asked him not to make more of it than the words themselves made.

It was received and filed. He had written those words himself now, on his own page, more than once that winter, and he understood at last, holding the coin in one hand and the share in the other, that they were not a single clerk's failing, to be argued round or appealed past with a better-worded letter, but the whole shape of the answer the north would get to nearly everything it asked of the south for as long as the north went on asking and did nothing else. A letter received and filed cost the council nothing and settled nothing and could be sent again next year with the same result. A forge lit, and a chit signed on a trusted name, cost the town that lit it or signed it everything it had to give, and settled the thing that same season.

He did not write that the Moot should stop asking. He wrote, and it is this line the Library keeps of the whole winter's business, that a people waiting on an answer that never came would do better to build, while it waited, the thing it had asked for, because the waiting, one way or another, would be a very long wait, and the ground did not stop wanting to be ploughed in the meantime.

The first furrow of that spring at Doire mhin was cut, by the last day of am Màrt, with one of Joseph Marlow's shares behind a borrowed ox, and it turned a clean black line the whole length of the field, and if it carried, ground fine into the iron somewhere under the coulter's edge, the ghost of a king across the water whose face no one now living on that coast could any longer have named, no one who watched it turn troubled to look for it there.

CHAPTER EIGHT

OF the ORDER OF Worship

SE 6 AN GIBLEAN – SE 7 AN GEARRAN

There had never been one.

— of the order of worship, entered at Seann Skell on the southern
coast, 17 an Cèitean, SE 6

I

Of the Letter that Found Him

 òmhnull mac Thormoid was fifty-six years old and had kept the flame at a hearth-altar above Baile ghlas for thirty of them, a small stone house with one window and a roof that wanted thatching every third year, when the letter came that made him Àrd-choimheadaiche¹ of the Rite. He read it twice standing in the doorway, because he did not trust it sitting down, and then a third time to see whether a second reading would change the words. It did not. The council's clerk had written that the Old Faith's keeping of Brìde's flame and Crom's stone was henceforth to have a settled order and a head to keep it, and that the head was to be Dòmhnall mac Thormoid, and that he was to remove to Seann Skell on the southern coast, where the greatest house of the Rite stood, and there was to write down, for the first time in all the long keeping of the fire, what the keeping was.

He had never asked for it. He said so to the two men who came to fetch him, and they said that was noted, and that it made no difference to the letter. Why

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

him, of all the hearth-keepers of the south-west, he asked, and the younger of the two said that his name had come up at the council's table because a councillor's wife's mother had been named at his altar forty years before and remembered him kindly, and that this, as far as either of them knew, was the whole of the reasoning the office had behind it. Dòmhnall thanked him for his honesty and packed one chest.

He left his altar tended by his sister's son, a boy of fourteen who had never lit the flame alone and wept doing it the first night, though Dòmhnall did not learn that until later and would not have thought less of the boy for it. The road to Seann Skell took him the better part of a week, on a cart with a family of tinkers as far as Cathair dhearg and on his own two feet after that, and he arrived at the southern coast with his boots worn through at one heel and a headful of what he would say, none of which survived the first sight of the house he had been given to keep.

It stood on the cliff above the harbour, older than anything he had tended, its inner hall black at the roof-beams from fires longer than the memory of any keeper now living, and its custodians, eleven of them, of varying age and varying welcome, stood in a loose half-circle in the yard to receive him as though a stray dog had wandered in wearing a collar too fine for it. The eldest of them, a woman named Beathag who had kept the house's western flame for forty years, looked him over from his worn heel to his travelling cloak and said only: "So you're the order."

"I'm to write one," Dòmhnall said.

"There isn't one to write," said Beathag. "There's the keeping. It's always been the keeping."

He did not answer her that first evening, because he had no answer, and a man who has walked a week to a house that does not want him is wise to hold his tongue until the second day at the earliest. But her words stayed with him through the winter that followed, longer than anything the council's clerk had said, because she was, as far as he could tell, entirely right, and his charge was to write down a thing that had never had an edge to it, that had lived in gesture and silence and the particular way one keeper's hand cupped the flame against a draught that another keeper's hand did not, and to give it a form it would hold from then on whether the form fit or not.

The house gave him a cell off the hall that had belonged, Beathag told him without being asked, to a keeper three generations dead whose name was on none

of the house's own lists, only on a beam where someone long ago had scratched it with a knife point. There was a table, a stool, a shelf that had once held something and now held nothing, and a window that looked west over the roofs of the town to the harbour, where the fishing boats went out before light and came back after it and paid the Rite no more mind than they paid the gulls. He set his one chest at the foot of the bed and did not unpack the whole of it for a week, thinking, though he did not say so to Beathag or to anyone, that he might yet be sent home before the spring turned, the office having been given him, as far as he could tell, by no better reasoning than a naming forty years gone and a council with a gap in its ledger it wanted filled.

He was not sent home. By am Màrt he had unpacked the chest to the bottom, and had begun, each morning before the house's other business, to sit at the table by the west window with the note-books Beathag brought him one at a time, as though she doubted his readiness for more than one at once, and did not think it worth telling him so.

II

Of the Leyline and the Unbroken Line

he began where the old note-books began, in the vein-house's custody records copied down from ages before any council sat at Cathair dhearg, and in the fragments of disputation the druid schools had left when their halls stood open, arguing over whether the coal answered blood or answered effort, a question Dòmhnall found he could not resolve any better than the schools had, six centuries of masters having failed at it before him. A defence written for a law two ages dead held that the burning was never for the coal's own sake but for the people it would make of them; over it lay the copyists' later gloss, that this must have meant the line running down from the first king to the woman the record calls Aisling, though the defence said no such thing and could not have, being written before she was born. He sat with that contradiction for the better part of a month, turning it as a man turns a coin he cannot spend, and in the end wrote the doctrine to hold both readings open at once, because he could see no way, and no right, to close either.

What he set down, working through that spring and into the wet of the following winter by a lamp that Beathag grudgingly kept filled for him, was this: that

the vein under the mountain was the holy thing, no sign nor dwelling of a greater power but the thing whole and entire, alive in some fashion no keeper was asked to understand or explain; that what was broken from it must be burned in measure or returned unburned, as the old law had always held; and that the vein answered a line, called the coal-touched, whose blood or whose office ran unbroken from a beginning no living record named. Whether it was blood or office he would not say, and said so plainly in the text, the first and only place in the whole order where he owned to an uncertainty. He called it the leyline, an old word the note-books gave him for the vein's own hidden path under the ground, and he set the two things, the line under the earth and the line of blood or office above it, side by side as the twin pillars the Rite would stand on from that day.

There was a night in that month, the wind coming hard off the water and the shutters loose in their frames, when he woke Beathag past midnight to ask her plainly whether he had any right at all to be the one deciding it, a hearth-keeper of thirty years who had never in his life set eyes on one of the coal-touched, writing doctrine about a line of people he could not name, the few of them the census would count living far from any altar he had kept. Beathag, who had been woken for less and minded it more, told him that she had never met one either, nor had any keeper of that house, and that this was rather the point of writing it down now than a reason to leave it unwritten, since a thing no one has seen is exactly the thing a house most needs a settled word about, so that when someone does see one, or claims to, there will be a doctrine standing to measure the claim against, rather than eleven keepers and eleven separate guesses. She went back to bed without waiting to see whether the answer satisfied him. It left something wanting, but it was the answer he kept, of everything said to him that whole year, closest at hand.

He wrote also, because Beathag made him, a page on the keeping proper: how the flame was lit from what the vein gave and never from any other fire; how the measure was to be judged, a handful and no more to a hearth on the year's turning days, and every ounce beyond it returned to the ground it came from; how a house without a custodian in living memory of its own line might still keep the flame, provided the keeping had never lapsed. Beathag read that page over his shoulder three times before she would let it stand, and struck out a line of his about the coal-touched appearing among ordinary households "as rarely as a comet," saying that she had never seen one, comet or coal-touched, and a keeper should not write what he did not know to be true merely because it sounded well.

Dòmhnall struck it and did not argue. He had begun, by then, to trust her judgment a good deal more than his own, though he never told her so outright, being a man who found it easier to accept correction than to praise it.

III

Of the First Reading

The order was read for the first time on a grey morning near the end of am Faoilleach, in the hall with the blackened beams, to the eleven custodians of the southern house and to a scattering of others who had walked or ridden to hear it: two hearth-keepers from villages along the coast, a Stone priest from Inis thais who had come out of curiosity rather than obligation and stood at the back with his arms folded the whole reading through, and a boy sent from Cnoc bheag to carry word home of what was said, though not, as it turned out, to carry any word of agreement.

Dòmhnall read it standing at the hearth, with the year's fire banked low beside him, and his voice, which had spent thirty years speaking to no larger a congregation than a single family at a time, cracked twice on words he had written and rewritten so often he no longer heard them as his own. He read the leyline and the unbroken line, the measure and the return, and the page on lapsed and unlapsed keeping that Beathag had made him write three times over until it said exactly what it meant and no more. He had thought, walking to the hearth that morning, that the hardest part would be the reading proper, and found instead that the hardest part was the pause after each page, when he looked up from the sheet to see who was still listening and who had begun, politely or otherwise, to study the beams; the boy from Cnoc bheag studied the beams throughout, and the Stone priest studied Dòmhnall, which he found, on the whole, the harder of the two to bear. When he finished there was a silence that ran long enough for him to think he had failed entirely, and then Beathag said, from her place at the front, "Well. Now there's one," in a tone that gave away nothing of whether she thought it an improvement, and the silence broke into the ordinary business of people filing out into a cold yard.

The Stone priest came to him before he left and said the houses of the Stone would send no witnesses to a settling that was not theirs to settle, the Stone in the south-west having never been Crom's stone at all, but that he for his part thought

the writing sound, so far as it went, and would say as much when he was home. He was as good as his word. Within the month a letter came from the houses of the Stone, wishing the Rite well in its ordering and promising nothing further, which Dòmhnall had copied into the first page of a book he began that day, a plain ledger in which he meant to keep every letter the Rite sent or received from then on, since it seemed to him, watching the boy from Cnoc bheag ride off without a word to anyone, that a house with no written order and no written record of what was said to it and by it would spend the rest of its days answering the same questions with the same silence it had always answered them with.

IV

Of the Cnoc bheag Letter and the Bell at Muileann naomh

The hawk-houses had not waited for the reading. Within a week of his coming to Seann Skell, the spring before, when the council's letter naming him was barely cold, a letter had come in a hand Dòmhnall did not know, sealed with the mark the hawk-houses used, a bird with its wings spread flat. It was not long. It said that the houses of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹ round Cnoc bheag had kept the old form of the Rite, the local altar answering to no custodian above it, since before any council sat anywhere on the island, and saw no cause to answer to one now; that any order of worship he might write would be, in the letter's own dry phrase, "handsome, and not needed"; and that the hawk-houses would go on as they had gone on, with their own flames and their own measures and their own silence about what either meant, and wished the southern house no ill in doing the same. Dòmhnall had read it three times, as he had read the council's letter, and found in it no anger at all, only a settled refusal so entire it had not thought the matter worth arguing. The boy from Cnoc bheag who stood through the reading that winter carried home only what the houses had already decided.

He was not compelled to force the matter, and had, in any case, no way to force eleven houses spread across a shire he had never set foot in, so he copied the letter into his book beside the Stone's, and let it stand. Beathag, reading it over his shoulder as she read everything, said only that she had kept the flame at this house for two reigns and had never once been told what to do by a hawk-house, and did

1. the Hawk order

not expect to start being told the reverse either. Dòmhnall came to think it the beginning of a quarrel that would outlast every one of the men and women then standing in that yard, though he did not write that down, not knowing it for certain and being, by nature, unwilling to set down as fact what was only his own guess at things to come.

One house had answered otherwise, and in the same first week. Word reached him from a wool-trader who had no particular reason to carry it beyond having passed through the town and thought it worth the telling: the hawk-house at Muileann naomh, far south of Cnoc bheag and close by the coast, had sent to say it would take the written order entire, whatever it proved to be when written, and had hung in its doorway a bell cast new for the purpose, the first bell any hawk-house had ever hung, to ring at the Rite's measured burnings. It rang it that summer at the burning of the year, a small crowd gathered in the lane outside to hear it. Dòmhnall walked out to the cliff path that evening and stood a long while looking south over water he could not see the far edge of, because it seemed to him a thing worth standing still for, that of all the houses that might have answered him, one had, before he had written a word, and it was not the one nearest the office that had made him, nor the one that owed the council anything, but a small house on a headland that had heard there would be words and trusted them unread.

He wrote to Muileann naomh with his own hand, the first letter of thanks he had ever composed in an office he still did not feel he had earned, and had it copied twice, once for his own book and once to be sent back by the same wool-trader, who took the coin for the errand without asking why a custodian of the southern house should write so plainly to a hawk-house when every other hawk-house on the island had disowned the office that same week.

V

Of the Regalia and the Refusal at Court

In an Gearran, with the order read and the roads hard with frost, he rode north to Cathair dhearg, at the council's summons rather than his own wish, to be presented at court as the Rite's first Àrd-choimheadaiche¹ and to make,

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

as the summons put it, "such representations as the office might think fitting." The capital was larger and colder to his eye than anything the coast had prepared him for, its streets full of clerks and carters who did not so much as glance at a hearth-priest's plain grey cloak among the council's liveried men, and he spent his first evening there in a lodging house paid for out of his own purse, since no one had thought to arrange him one, working over the single representation he had carried north with him and turning it, on the ride and again that night, until he had it in a shape he thought could not be misheard: that the coronation regalia, which Òrd Mhacha² at Cathair dhearg had kept since before the council itself existed, having kept it under the humans and before them, ought now to be shared in the keeping between Òrd Mhacha and the Rite that had, after all, only just been given a settled order to keep anything with.

He put it to the high priest of Òrd Mhacha across a table in a cold ante-room off the council's own chamber, a man some ten years his junior with the easy manner of a house that had never had to ask leave of anyone for anything since the founding of the kingdom, and a ring on his right hand that Dòmhnall, watching it catch the light through the whole exchange, took at first for a piece of the regalia and later decided was only his own. The high priest heard him out without interrupting, which Dòmhnall took, wrongly, for a good sign, and then said that Òrd Mhacha had kept the regalia through every age the record named, under the Hall and under the humans both, that the crown's own coronation rite ran through Òrd Mhacha's hands and no other's, and that he saw no ground on which a house not a year in its office, however sound its new writing, might claim a share in a keeping settled for ages. He asked, not unkindly, whether the southern house had any wish to crown a king, and when Dòmhnall said it had not, said that this, then, seemed to settle the matter on its own. He said all of it, Dòmhnall noted, without any unkindness whatsoever, in the tone of a man refusing a request he did not think worth the offence of refusing sharply.

Dòmhnall rode south again with nothing gained but the answer, which he entered in his book that winter beside the Stone's letter and the Hawk's, three plain lines with no comment added, because by then he had begun to see the sum of the office's first year, and did not think it wanted his comment to make its meaning plain. One house had disowned the order outright and told him so without malice. One house had stood aside from it with the courtesy of a neigh-

2. the order of Macha

bour who wants no quarrel and offers no help either. And one house, the oldest and best placed of the three, had simply outranked him, in a tone so mild it had taken him the whole ride home to recognise it for a refusal at all.

VI

Of Caol mhòr, as the Library Keeps It

Far to the north, in that same year, at Caol mhòr where the Moot met in its long low room, Walter Hale asked the council's leave to open schools among the Tuathaich that would teach in the humans' own tongue rather than in Dia-thìris. It is not told at length here, having no part in the keeping of any hearth-fire, and belongs more properly to the record the Moot itself has kept; but the Library holds the council's answer, because it is short and because the age would be the poorer without it. The council wrote back that the kingdom's schools taught in Dia-thìris, and that it had no others.

The Moot's own minute of that answer, entered the same week in the hand of a clerk who did not trouble to hide what he thought of it, calls the council's word "clear, at least." Nothing further was asked, and nothing further was given, for a good many years after; and it is a small thing to set beside a bell rung at Muileann naomh or a refusal handed down across a table at Cathair dhearg, except that the same year gave the Rite its first written order and gave the north the same two words it would be given, in one shape or another, for most of the age that followed. The Library keeps both. It does not say they are the same. It only notes that they fell in the same twelvemonth, and lets a reader make of that what a reader will.

VII

Of the Copies Sent Out

Before that Gearran was out Dòmhnall's clerks, two novices of the southern house lent him by Beathag, a boy called Cailean and a quiet girl named Sorcha who wrote a far steadier hand than either Dòmhnall or the boy, had made fair copies of the order entire, each one checked against his own work-

ing text line by line, for a written thing, he had come to understand over that first year, was worth nothing at all if every copy of it said something slightly different from every other. He sent one to every house of the Old Faith that still stood, the Hawk-houses included, though he did not expect an answer from most of them and received none; one to the Stone, with a note of thanks for the courtesy already shown; one, though he sent it without much hope, to Òrd Mhacha¹, on the plain ground that a house might refuse to share a keeping and still be sent the doctrine of a neighbouring one; and a last copy, made with more care than any of the others, wrapped and sealed and given to the same wool-trader who had first brought him word of the bell, to be carried south again to Muileann naomh, not because that house had asked for it, having a copy already from the first reading, but because it seemed to Dòmhnall, turning the last page under Beathag's lamp on the coldest night of that Gearran, a debt worth the paying: that of every house on the island, it was the one that had heard him first, and asked him nothing in return.

He wrote, in the last line of his book that winter, a summary he did not mean as one, only as a plain account of where the year had left him: that the order stood written now where it had never stood written before, that one house had taken it up entire and rung a bell for it, that one had set it courteously aside, and that one, the oldest and grandest, had heard it and gone on exactly as before. He banked the fire, closed the book, and sat a while in the dark hall listening to the sea below the cliff, which had gone on the same way through every age the Rite had kept it holy and every age it had not, and seemed to Dòmhnall, that night at least, entirely indifferent to which of the three answers the island had chosen to give him.

1. the order of Macha

CHAPTER NINE

OF the Justice's Circuit

SE 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS – SE 8 AN T-SULTAIN

Exactness in a law makes it possible to keep, whatever else it fails to
make it.

— Eilidh nic Leòid, of the ruling given at Seann Bhrail in the west, 10
an t-Sultain, SE 8

I

Of the Two Counts of Doire ghlais

The state took its own measure that summer, for the first time since it had taken the island back. Clerks rode out from Cathair dhearg with rolls under their arms and a single instruction copied into every one of them: count the houses, count the heads in them, and ask, where it seemed proper to ask, what a household held to. Most gave the answer the clerks expected and wrote down without comment. On the far north-western cape and on the small islets off it, where the fishing was thin and the priests came once a year if the sea allowed it, a good many gave none at all, and the clerks, finding no word in *Dia-thìris* that fit a household with nothing to declare, wrote against their names *gun chreideamb*¹, without a creed, and rode on. It went into the roll as a fact and stayed there as one, unexplained.

Of the coal-touched the roll says less than that. It notes, in the same flat hand it gives to everything, that there are very few, and says no more; whoever wrote the line seems to have felt that a thing so seldom seen was better left where it was

1. without a faith

found than dwelt on, and the clerks who came after him have kept to the same rule ever since, as though the silence were its own part of the counting.

The Tuathaich towns of the shire of Doire ghlais were counted from the road. The census clerks sent that far north had no love of the errand and less of the weather, and a man on horseback, going by at a trot with a rain-cape over his rolls, will miss a house set back from the way, or a family lodging three to a room above a shop, or a child asleep and not thought worth waking to be added to a list. The Moot at Caol mhòr, which had kept its own tally of its own towns for five years by then and trusted it a good deal more than it trusted a stranger on a horse, took its count again that same season, going door to door as it always did, and found close to a fifth more souls than the state's roll gave it. Neither side wrote to the other about the difference. The state's roll went into the treasury's chests at Cathair dhearg; the Moot's went into the chest under the long room's table at Caol mhòr; and there the two counts of Doire ghlais have sat ever since, each one true by its own reckoning, and neither one correcting the other, because no one anywhere on the island had been given the office of making them agree.

It is against that count, taken and not reconciled, that the year's other business must be set: for it was the same summer, while the clerks were still riding the coast roads with their rolls, that the council took up a question it had let stand unanswered for six years, namely what law a man in Muileann bhàn or Inis thais or a dozen other towns a hard week's ride from the capital was actually to be given, when the only courts that sat regularly sat at Cathair dhearg and heard, for the most part, only what Cathair dhearg's own householders brought before them.

A shire far from the capital, in those years, had law of a kind: the maor's word, the custom the old families kept among themselves, and, failing both, whatever a man could make a neighbour agree to without troubling anyone above him. It served well enough for a boundary or a debt, so long as the parties were willing to be bound by an unwritten thing, and served very badly the moment one of them was not, there being then no bench nearer than the capital to appeal to, and few enough householders with the means or the year to spare for such a journey. The council had heard this said to it more than once, by maoir who did not care to be magistrates as well as tax-gatherers, and had done nothing about it, there being always some nearer business to attend to first, until the same summer that sent its clerks out with the census rolls sent out, in the same weeks, a second set of letters altogether.

II

Of Cathair dhomhain and the Custody-Book

Eilidh nic Leòid was one-and-fifty that summer, and had never married, and had spent the whole of her working life, from the age of fourteen, in the counting-house of Cathair dhomhain, where her father before her had kept the custody-book of the old vein-house on the hill above the harbour. It was not, by then, much of an office; the house had lost its galleries in the mountain to the humans' Company three generations back, and the custody-book was, by then, a relic, a great bound ledger recording who had held what right to what gallery and on what terms, going back further than any living hand had written in it, kept up now for the sake of the town's older families and their disputes over what their grandmothers had been owed. Her father read her the book before she could write her own name in the margin of it, and by the time she could write she was correcting his entries, gently and then less gently, when a heading was carried forward wrong or a right was recorded as belonging to a house it had in fact passed out of two holders before.

It was not, she used to say afterward, that the custody-book taught her the law of the land, for the land's law and the vein's custom were two different bodies entirely, and she had had to learn the first as a grown woman with the second already fixed in her. What the book taught her, she said, was that a right written down carelessly was worse than no right at all, because a careless entry gave a man something to point to and be wrong about, whereas an honest blank at least told him plainly that no one had settled the matter yet. She carried that conviction into every clerkship she held after her father died and the vein-house closed its custody-book for good, first as a copyist for the harbour court at Cathair dhomhain, then as its recorder, then, for eleven years, as the court's own justice in all but the name, since the man who held the name preferred his garden to his bench and was glad enough to let her hold both.

The council's letter naming her first among the circuit justices of the kingdom reached her on a wet morning in an t-Ògmhios, carried by a rider who had come the long way round the coast road because the direct way was under water from three days of rain, and who was, by his own account, glad to be shot of the errand and out of his boots. It told her that eleven shires of the south-west were to be hers, that she was to ride them in a fixed order once in every twelvemonth, hearing what causes came before her at each stopping-place, and that she was to carry

with her, and return each year to the council's clerks at Cathair dhearg, a written record of every judgment given, so that a ruling made at one stop should be known, and if need be answered, at the next. She read the letter twice, standing in the doorway of the harbour court with the rain still coming down behind the rider's shoulder, and found in it, she told her clerk afterward, the first office in her whole career that asked of her exactly what her father's custody-book had always asked of her without her having to explain the likeness to anyone.

For the riding she was given a horse she did not trust, a clerk of two-and-twenty named Murchadh Clàrc who trusted the horse even less than she did, and a satchel of blank record-books stamped with the council's new seal, the ink of which was still tacky on the first three she opened. She set out from Cathair dhomhain on the first fine day after the rains broke, with the satchel strapped behind Murchadh's saddle rather than her own, on the grounds, as she told him, that a justice ought to arrive at her first assize with clean hands and let her clerk arrive muddy.

III

Of the First Assize and the Wells at Muileann bhàn

her first sitting, held at Cathair dhomhain before she had properly left the town, was a small thing: three causes, a boundary dispute between neighbouring orchards settled by measuring the ground herself with a length of knotted cord rather than trust either party's account of where the old hedge had run, a debt of thirty measures of barley that she found for the lender on the strength of a receipt neither party had thought to burn, and a complaint against a fishmonger for short weight that she dismissed for want of any evidence beyond the complainant's own scales, which she made him bring into court and weigh against the council's standard, and which proved, to his visible discomfort, to be the ones at fault. Murchadh recorded all three in a hand Eilidh found, by the end of the first week, considerably steadier than his seat on the horse.

She reached Muileann bhàn in the last week of an t-Iuchar, a mill-town on the southern plain that had, that same year, raised the first public waterworks the restored kingdom had seen anywhere on the island: a stone tank set on the hill above the town, fed by a leat off the mill-race, with lead pipes laid down to four wells in the streets below so that a household no longer had to send a child to the

river with a yoke and two buckets every morning of its life. The Guild of Hewers had sent surveyors down from the vein-towns to watch it built, being curious, as diggers of every kind are curious, about a different way of moving water through the ground than the ways they already knew; and the town was, on the whole, proud of the thing, which had cost it three years of subscription and the loan of every mason within a day's walk.

The quarrel Eilidh was asked to hear had grown, as such quarrels do, out of the very success of the works. The well nearest the mill had been dug, by an oversight nobody now owned to, on land that belonged in custom, though not in any deed either party could produce, to a widow named Beathag nic Mhurchaidh, whose late husband's family had held the ground for water rights time out of mind, long before any tank or pipe was thought of, on the strength of a spring that had run there before the leat was cut and had since gone dry, the leat having drawn off what fed it. Beathag held that the well was hers to charge for, as her husband's family had always charged a penny a season for water from the spring, and had begun setting a boy at the well-head to collect it. The town's new well-warden, a mason named Dùghall who had helped lay the pipe with his own hands, held that a well fed by the town's own works, built with the town's own subscription, belonged to the town and to no single household, spring or no spring, and had had the boy sent home twice already, once with words and once, the second time, with something closer to a shove.

Eilidh heard them both in the mill-yard, there being no proper courtroom at Muileann bhàn and the mill-yard being the largest covered space the town possessed, with half the street come to watch and the miller's dog asleep across the threshold through the whole of it. She asked for the old spring's history first, and got it from three old men in turn, none of whose accounts agreed on the exact year the spring had first been charged for, though all agreed it long predated the leat. Then, and this took longer, she asked exactly which lengths of pipe the town's subscription had paid for and which the mill itself had given out of its own purse, since the mill's owner turned out to have laid the last stretch of pipe to the disputed well at his own cost, out of a wish, he said plainly, to see his own household's well filled first. She sent Murchadh out with the cord she had used on the orchard boundary to measure the actual distance from the tank to each of the four wells, and had the mill's ledgers of the subscription brought into the yard and read aloud, penny by penny, while the dog slept on.

By evening she had her ruling, and gave it standing on the mill-step so that the whole yard could hear it without crowding round the bench. The spring's old custom, she said, had died with the spring; a right to charge for water that no longer ran could not be transferred, by any reasoning she could construct, onto water that ran by an entirely different road and had been paid for by an entirely different purse. But the town's claim to own the well outright went too far the other way, for the ground the well stood on was still, by every account given her, Beathag's ground in custom if not in deed, and a town could not simply dig where it liked and call the digging ownership. She ruled that the well stood on Beathag's land and would go on standing there, that Beathag was owed no charge for water she had not drawn and no longer could; in place of the dead spring's custom she was owed the town's word that the ground would never be built over or fenced from her without her leave, so long as she or her heirs held it. It satisfied neither party entire, which she told Murchadh that night, over a supper the mill's owner sent up to their lodging by way of thanks for a long day's hearing, was generally the surest sign a ruling had been made fairly rather than to please the loudest voice in the yard.

IV

Of the Head-Due and the Road South

The head-due was gathered that same autumn for the first time in the shires of her circuit, eighteen purses on every five thousand heads, and Eilidh found herself, more than once along the road, sitting as much a witness to the gathering as a justice riding past it: a maor's clerk at a crossroads with a table and a strongbox, a queue of householders each paying by the count of their own roof, and here and there a dispute over whose child was old enough to be counted and whose was not, which the clerks settled among themselves and never thought to bring to her bench at all, the sum being too small, as one of them told her frankly, to be worth a justice's time. She noted it in her own record-book all the same, as a thing seen rather than a cause heard, on the reasoning that a circuit justice who wrote down only what came before her formally would, in twenty years, know a good deal less of her own shires than one who wrote down what she passed on the road between.

She had not been a full year in the office before she understood that the greater part of a circuit justice's work was arithmetic of a duller kind, not judgment at all: how many days a shire's roads would cost her against how many causes waited at the end of them, and which stopping-place could be shortened without a householder somewhere going a twelvemonth unheard. A second book, kept apart from the record of rulings, held that reckoning alone, filled with sums that never once appeared in anything the council's clerks would read; and she thought, more than once on a wet evening with the sums still not coming right, that her father's custody-book had never asked this particular exactness of her, there having been only the one vein-house to reckon and no road between its rooms longer than a stair.

She rode from Muileann bhàn through Inis thais, where the sitting was brief, the town's own harbour court being well enough kept that little came to her beyond two cases the local magistrate had been glad to hand up rather than decide himself, both involving a fishing boat's ownership after its owner's death without clear heirs, and on through the smaller courts of the coast to Doire shean, a fishing village under the old faith where she sat for two days in the porch of the town's temple, there being, again, no other roofed space large enough, and heard, among lesser things, a case brought by three households against a fourth over the right to dry nets on a stretch of shingle that had, within living memory, belonged to no one in particular. She settled that one, as she had settled the well, by asking after the custom rather than the law, since no written law reached so far down as a stretch of shingle, and found, as she generally did when she asked patiently enough, that the custom was known to everyone in the room and had simply never been written where a stranger could find it.

It was on the road between Doire shean and Seann Bhrál, in the last days of an Lùnastal, that Murchadh asked her, not for the first time, whether she found it strange to be making law rather than only keeping it, having spent so many years reading a book that recorded rights already settled long before she was born. She thought about the question longer than he expected an answer to take, the horses walking slow on a coast track gone soft with the last of the rain, and said at length that she did not think she was making anything at all; she thought she was doing to the whole of the kingdom's law what her father had asked her to do to the vein-house's custody-book from the time she could hold a pen, which was to write down plainly what was true, so that the next hand to open the book would not have to guess. Whether that came to the same thing as making law, she said, was a

question for someone with more patience for words than she had ever had for anything but figures.

V

Of the Ruling at Seann Bhral

Seann Bhral in the west stood on its harbour with the tide out when they rode in on the ninth of an t-Sultain, the mud flats stretching grey below the town wall and a scorpion carved over the old counting-house door that nobody now living could account for, it having been there, by every telling, since long before the humans ever came ashore. The cause that had been waiting on her docket the longest was already known to her by name before she reached the town, a maor's clerk having ridden ahead a week earlier with the papers so that she might read them on the road rather than in the court itself: a dispute over four fields on the plain above the harbour, held for two generations by a Tuathaich family named Tanner under a title that had been cut, in the humans' own hand, by a Company surveyor before the Severance, and claimed now by a Dia-thìreach household that held, under a much newer seal, the Crown's grant of the same ground, made without, it was plain from the paper's own date, any knowledge on the council's part that the land was occupied at all.

The maor of the shire, a heavy, careful man named Artair mac Lachlainn who had held the office four years without once being asked to sit in judgment on anything larger than a dispute over a fishing weir, met her at the town gate the evening before and walked with her as far as her lodging, saying little beyond the courtesies until they reached the door, when he stopped and told her plainly that he would be glad if she found for the Crown's grant entire, since the household that held it was a cousin of his own and had waited two years for a ruling he had not felt able to give himself. Eilidh thanked him for his honesty, much as Dòmhnall mac Thormoid, in a house far to the south, had once thanked two strangers for theirs, and told him that she would hear the cause the next morning exactly as she heard every other, and that he was welcome to sit through it if he wished, though not to speak in it. He came, and sat at the back of the room, and did not speak.

She sat the tenth of an t-Sultain in the counting-house, the old scorpion looking down from the lintel on a room fuller than any she had yet sat in on her circuit, for word of the cause had gone ahead of her along the coast and half the

shire's Tuathaich households, it seemed, had found some reason to be in Seann Bhral that week. She read the Tanner family's title through twice, in the humans' own script, which she had learned enough of years before, from an old harbour clerk at Cathair dhomhain, to make out slowly without help; she read the Crown's grant beside it, in Dia-thiris, cut clean and recent and utterly silent on the question of who already stood on the ground it named; and she asked the Tanner family's eldest son, a man near her own age who had farmed the land since boyhood and buried both his parents in a corner of it, a single question, which was whether the family had ever paid a tithe, a due or a rent of any kind to any authority for the ground since the Severance, and receiving the answer that they had not, because none had ever been asked of them, sat a long while in silence before she gave her ruling.

The ground, she said, had passed to the Crown; on that the two titles could not both be right, and the humans' authority to grant land on the island had ended with the humans' own departure from it, whatever the survey's ink still claimed. But the right to work that ground, to plant it and reap it and pass it to a child, had never in fact been taken from the family that held it, no clerk having ever come to take it, and she would not now invent a taking that had not happened merely because a newer seal existed that assumed one. The land belonged to the Crown. The working of it belonged, and would go on belonging, to the Tanners and their heirs, on the same terms, in substance, as they had always worked it, the only change being that any due the Crown chose in future to lay upon such ground would be laid on them as it was laid on any other holder, and not excused. She thought, reading it back to Murchadh that evening for the fair copy, that she had found the most generous reading the law would bear, and she believed it, turning it over that night in the room the harbour master had found her, a fair judgment as well as an exact one, though she noted, writing the last line of the record before she slept, that she had not asked the Tanner son what he thought of being told the ground under his own dead parents now belonged, in law if in nothing else that would ever touch him day to day, to a Crown he had never once been asked to swear to.

VI

Of the Copy Sent to Every Court

The ruling was fair-copied twice more before the month was out, once for the council's own chests at Cathair dhearg and once, at Eilidh's own instruction, for every maor's court in the eleven shires of her circuit, with a note in her own hand that any cause brought on a like title should be decided on the like reasoning until the council itself said otherwise. She had no authority, strictly read, to bind any bench but her own; a circuit justice's ruling was her ruling and no other's, and she knew it. But she reasoned, writing the covering note by candlelight in the harbour master's borrowed room with Murchadh already asleep in the chair by the door, that a law applied differently in every court that heard it was no law at all, only eleven separate guesses wearing the same coat, and that if the council would not yet say plainly what the rule should be for land such as the 'Tanners', she would at least see to it that every bench in reach of her own hand said the same thing until it did.

The copies went out through the autumn, one by carrier to each of the eleven courts, and were entered, in most of them, without comment, a clerk's initials in the margin and a date, the way any ruling was entered that nobody expected to argue with. At two courts, the record notes only that the copy was received; whether it was read is not told. The copy did not travel north beyond her own eleven shires that year, the courts of the north-west being no part of her circuit and answering, in any case, to no bench of hers; but it was cited, before the season turned again, in a boundary case at a town she had never ridden through, a clerk there having got hold of a copy from a neighbouring court and finding, on reading it, that it settled a question his own bench had been putting off for want of any better guide. Eilidh did not learn of that particular citing for some years, and when she did, from a passing remark of a fellow justice at a council dinner she attended with visible reluctance, she said only that it did not surprise her; a rule written down plainly, she had told Murchadh more than once on the road that autumn, has a way of travelling on its own feet long after the hand that wrote it has stopped watching where it goes.

CHAPTER TEN

Of the Vigil in the Open

SE 8 AN DÀMHAIR – SE 9 AN GIBLEAN

"We do not tell outsiders which night. If it were known, it could be watched for. If it could be watched for, it would not be a vigil. It would be a show put on for whoever came to watch it."
— a Library clerk's plain rendering of what was said at Baile chrom, when asked

I

Of the Line to Muileann chrom

The railway the humans had built out of the central mountains to the sea had lain broken in three places since the fighting of the Severance, its cuttings full of blown sand, its rails rusted red as the hills they crossed. In 9 an Dàmhair, SE 8, the council mended it as far as Muileann chrom, no further, for the money ran only that far and the mountain gave the rest. A Rail Board was made to run it, seated at Cathair dhearg: one clerk, two engineers who had learned their trade watching the humans work it and never quite forgot the habit of looking over their shoulders for a foreman, and the humans' own timetable, copied fair into a Dia-thìreach hand and hung on a board at the Muileann chrom terminus, where the line now ended, under a header someone had lettered too large for the space it had. The trains ran to it or near enough. Nobody who rode them thought it strange that a kingdom six years old should keep the hours of a people who no longer lived on the island. It was the only timetable there was.

The bridge below the capital, over the wide brown water the humans had spanned in stone, was hallowed anew that same autumn. A priest of Macha stood

on the parapet in the cold and named it in Dia-thìris, and a new stone was cut and set beside the old one, which nobody had thought to move and which nobody, in the end, moved. The humans' name-stone was turned instead, quietly, by two masons working an evening shift so that its face looked down at the river rather than out at the road, and there it has stood since, reading nothing to anyone who does not go down onto the towpath and look up. The Library keeps no record of whose idea that was. It keeps only that it was done, and that no minute anywhere calls it defacement, and none calls it honour either. The bridge carries the road it always carried. It does not know, or does not say, which of its two stones it answers to.

Further south that winter the shire of Ceann mhin closed its old ground at Cnoc dhìreach to new burial, the vines by then having split so many of the old stones that no clear plot could be found among them without turning up someone else's dead first. The families who had people there still walk out on the quarter-days to clear the growth from the names they can still read, and some say, in the way such things are always said of ground closed to the living and kept for the dead, that the place is not so empty after dark as a stranger walking the road would think. The Library records the closure and no more. What is or is not walking among the broken stones at Cnoc dhìreach after dark has never been a question that came before any court, and the Library keeps no case it was not asked to try.

These are the small things a kingdom does in its eighth and ninth years, once its wars are over and its first census taken: it mends a line as far as its money reaches, it turns a stone rather than break it, it shuts a gate on ground too full to hold more. None of them was much remarked at the time. All three are remembered now only because of what else was happening, in that same autumn and the spring that followed it, on a headland in the far north-west that no engineer's timetable reached and no priest of Macha had ever stood on.

II

Of Baile chrom

Baile chrom stood where the coast turned, a scatter of grey houses above a shingle beach with its boats drawn up past the tideline and its nets strung to dry on frames the fishermen mended every spring with their fathers'

twine, because good twine was dear and their fathers had known how to make bad twine last. Above the houses, where the land rose to a bare shoulder before it fell into the sea, stood the lighthouse the humans had built, one of the five, its lamp lit each dusk by an old keeper the council paid by the year and otherwise forgot, its outer stair still sound, its door unbarred because nobody had thought a lock worth the iron. The Tuathaich called it the old light and let their children climb the outer stair on dares while the keeper slept. From its gallery, on a clear evening, you could see the whole run of the coast north and south and, on the clearest evenings of all, a grey smudge that the old people said was cloud and the young people said might be something else, and neither would say more than that.

In the town itself the Tuathaich kept An Eaglais¹, the Church their forebears had carried over the sea at the Crossing, and kept it as quietly as a people keeps a thing the state has not troubled to forbid: openly enough to build with, not so openly as to be troubled. Its congregation met in a long low building that had been a net-store before it was a church and looked, from the road, very much like a net-store still, its cross cut small and set over the door where a passing maor's man would need to be looking for it to see it. Within, on a shelf behind the altar-cloth, in a box no larger than a loaf, the town kept what its people called the First Canoe: the telling of Naomh Breandan's crossing to the Isle of the Blessed, in whatever form it had come to them, written or carved or kept only in the memory of whoever held the office of keeping it. The Dia-thìreach priesthood, on the rare occasion the question reached them, called it superstition and left it there. The Library, which has asked twice across the age, has never been shown it, and knows only that it is kept, and where is not a question the Library asks twice of a people who have already answered it once by not answering.

Hannah Crane held, that autumn, the office of vigil-keeper for the Mystery of the Grey Night, an office within the Church and yet not quite of it, older than the building it was kept in and answerable to nobody south of Muileann fhionn. She had held it eleven years, since the woman before her had died in a hard winter and left it to her the way such things were left in Baile chrom, by a word said once to the right person and never written down. She was a fisherman's widow herself, her husband taken by the sea the year before she took the office, and she kept a cottage two doors from the net-store church with a black cat that came and went

1. the Church

as it pleased and a garden that grew, in the thin northern soil, more onions than anything prettier. Nobody thought her a solemn woman. She laughed easily, swore when she stubbed a toe on the hearthstone, and was known to the length of the coast for a temper that came up fast and went down faster. None of that stood against her holding the office. The office asked one thing of its keeper and one thing only, which was silence kept on one night of the year, for Sìne, the Peaceful Goose, whom the sect named for the wild goose the Church elsewhere named the Holy Spirit and pictured, when it pictured it at all, as something gentler and less inclined to fly a thousand miles into a headwind without resting. Which night was Hannah's to choose and Hannah's alone to keep, and the whole of the office's discipline lay in choosing it so that no one, not the town, not the maor, not the bishops themselves, could learn it in advance.

III

Of the Night in the Open

For as long as anyone at Baile chrom could tell it, the vigil had been kept indoors: a room shuttered dark, the keeper alone in it from dusk until whatever hour before dawn she judged the silence had been held long enough, the town going about its evening outside the shutters as though nothing were happening behind them, which was, in its way, the whole of the point. A silence nobody could see being kept was a silence nobody could interrupt, and a silence nobody could interrupt was a silence that could not be taken from the keeper by any hand stronger than her own. It had held through the Age of Strangers, through the crossing and the years the crossing stayed open, through the closing of the crossing and the marching north, and through eight years of the kingdom that had followed. Hannah Crane, in the autumn of her fortieth year, decided to keep it another way.

She did not say why, not to the town and not, so far as the Library has ever learned, to anyone at all, though the reason she gave herself, alone, walking the shingle in the evenings of that Dàmhair while she turned the decision over, was simple enough that she might have said it to anyone who asked and been believed: that a silence kept behind a shutter, in a kingdom that had not yet troubled to ask what was behind the shutter, was a silence that cost nothing and proved nothing, and she had held the office eleven years without once being tested in it, and

wondered, walking the shingle with the wind coming hard off the water, whether a thing untested for eleven years could truly be said to have been kept at all. No one learned the date she had settled on. On a Sunday at the end of am Faoilleach, standing at the net-store door after the service, she told the town only that this year the vigil would be held on the headland, in the open, where any who wished could see that it was kept, though none would be told beforehand when to look.

The town took it as the town took most things Hannah Crane did, which was without much comment and a good deal of private opinion kept for the hearth afterward. Some thought it foolish, an office risked for no reason a sensible woman could name. Some thought it overdue, and said so more freely once the thing was done than they had said it before. The maor of the shire, lodged in the town's old customs-house and a stranger to it still, sent no word at all, which the town read, correctly, as meaning the maor had heard nothing worth his attention, the Grey Night being to him and to every officer of the Crown before him no more than a line in an old report that called the Tuathaich's private observances harmless and not worth the ink to describe further.

There was talk of it at the net-mending that winter, the frames drawn up under the eaves of the net-store church where the work could go on out of the rain, and Hannah sat among the menders as she always did, her own needle no faster or slower than anyone else's, and let the talk run where it wanted. An old man named for nobody the Library has recorded said he had kept his own counsel through worse changes than this one and would keep it through this, and went on splicing. A younger woman, newly married into the town from Muileann fhionn and still finding her feet in its customs, asked outright whether the keeper was not afraid, sitting alone on a headland all a winter's night with nothing but the old light for company, and Hannah told her that she had been afraid of a good many things in her life and had found, on the whole, that fear was a poor reason to leave a thing undone that wanted doing, which was as near as she came, that winter or after, to explaining herself to anyone. The younger woman said no more of it, but she was on the headland herself, at a careful distance, the night it happened, and never told even her own husband that she had gone.

The Church's own priest at Baile chrom, an old man who had baptised half the town and buried the other half's parents, asked her once, walking back from a burial in am Faoilleach, whether she meant to go through with it, and when she said she did, told her only that the office was hers to keep as she judged best, and that he had held his own for forty years by staying out of what belonged to another.

er keeper's office. It was the nearest thing to a blessing she had from anyone that winter, and she told the linen-woman once that she held those few words dearer than anything the bishops ever wrote her.

On the night of 14 am Màrt, SE 9, the fourteenth of am Màrt, Hannah Crane walked up from the town after dark, alone, with nothing in her hands, and climbed the shoulder of land to where the old light stood with its lamp burning high above her against a sky just clearing of cloud, and sat down on the turf below its base with her back to the cold stone and the sea in front of her, and kept the silence there until the sky began to lighten in the east some hours later. She lit no fire, for the vigil's discipline forbade it as much in the open as behind a shutter, and she had thought, walking up, that the cold would be the worst of it, and found, sitting through it, that the cold was the easiest part; it was the not-knowing whether anyone watched, and the knowing, at the same time, that this was precisely what she had chosen, that occupied the long middle hours.

The tide turned somewhere below her in the dark, though she could not see it, only hear the change in the water's noise against the shingle, a longer pull where before it had been a shorter one. Once a light showed far out, low on the water, there and gone before she could be sure of it, a fishing boat working later than it should or something else entirely, and she did not move toward it or away from it, because the vigil's whole discipline lay in not moving at all, in sitting where she had sat down until the sky told her she was free to stand. Her feet went from cold to numb to a kind of distant ache that she stopped attending to somewhere past midnight, the way a held breath stops feeling like holding after long enough. The wind dropped toward the small hours, and the sea below the headland went quiet enough that she could hear, once, far off, the calling of birds moving in the dark, though whether geese so early in the year or something else she never afterward said, holding to the vigil's other discipline, which is that what is heard on the night is not told either.

She thought, in the stretches when thought was easier than not thinking, of the woman who had held the office before her, dead now more winters than Hannah cared to count, who had kept it always behind the shutter and had never once said, in all the years she taught Hannah the small duties of it, whether she thought the shutter a true part of the keeping or only a habit nobody had troubled to question. Hannah had never asked her outright, and there was no one left to ask now, and she found, sitting with her back to the cold stone, that she did not mind the not-knowing as much as she had expected to. Some things an office hands

down are the office's own; some are only the last keeper's caution, worn smooth by years into looking like doctrine. She could not have said, that night, which the shutter had been, and thought it likely no one, not the bishops with their three signatures nor the woman who had taught her, could have said either.

She was not entirely alone on the headland, though she did not know it until near dawn. The maor's man, a clerk's assistant from Cnoc ghorm sent up the coast on some unrelated errand of the shire's and lodging that week at Baile chrom, had climbed a lower rise a quarter-mile off, drawn by nothing more than an idle curiosity about where the vigil-keeper had gone after her Sunday announcement, and had sat there through most of the night himself, at a distance, watching a shape against the lighthouse's base that did not move and a fire that never came. He wrote nothing of it in the shire's returns, there being, as he told it afterward to anyone in Baile chrom who would stand him a drink, no line on any form he carried for a woman sitting still on a hillside all night doing nothing anyone could call an offence, and no instruction from the maor to make one. He watched, and in the morning he walked back down to his lodging and slept until noon, and the shire's record of that week at Baile chrom says only what it always said, which was nothing.

IV

Of the Letter Called Irregular

Word of it reached the Church's bishops by the summer, carried, as such things travelled the coast, by a preaching brother who had heard it told at Cnoc ghorm and thought it worth passing on, half as news and half as a question he did not know how to put more directly: whether an office so old and so private might be kept, from now on, in a way the bishops had not sanctioned and had, until that telling, not known existed. The bishops wrote back to Baile chrom a single letter, addressed to the keeper of the vigil and signed by three names none of the town had heard before, which called the new manner of keeping it irregular and asked, without commanding, that the keeper consider returning to the custom her office had held before her.

Hannah Crane read the letter twice at her own hearth, folded it, and put it in the box behind the altar-cloth alongside the thing the box already kept, which seemed to her, she told the woman who helped her with the church's linen, as

good a place as any for a letter that asked a question and made sure, in the asking, never quite to become an order. She did not answer it. Nobody at Baile chrom, then or later, learned of any bishop travelling north to see for himself what irregular meant, and the vigil was kept in the open again the following year, and the year after, on nights Hannah told no one in advance. The word irregular is the only word the Church's own record has ever set against it. The Library, which keeps the letter's copy among the north's returns, has never been asked to explain why a kingdom that fined a fishing town for arming its boats without a licence let a woman sit on a hillside once a year unwatched and unfined, and offers, where it is asked, no better answer than that some things a state forbids because it has looked at them and judged them dangerous, and some things it lets stand because it has never looked at them at all, and a vigil kept once a year on a headland the maor's writ ran over but the maor's attention never quite reached was, for many years, the second kind.

A church was built that same year at Cnoc ghorm, the largest the north had raised since the crossing closed, its stone hauled up from a quarry two shires south on carts the Moot paid for by subscription, and into its tower, when the tower was finished, the town hung a bell that had come across the sea long before in the belfry of the old chapel at Ros bheag, carted north in the kingdom's first spring and kept crated in a barn for want of anywhere fit to hang it. It rang for the first time on a market morning, and the sound of it, the town said afterward, carried further than anyone had thought a single bell could carry, out past the fields and down to the shore road, where carters driving in from Muileann fhionn heard it and knew, before they came in sight of the tower, that Cnoc ghorm had a church worth the name at last.

The two buildings, the small net-store church at Baile chrom and the great new one at Cnoc ghorm, stood twelve miles apart on the same coast and answered, in their different ways, to the same three signatures on the same distant letter, though the Cnoc ghorm parish, larger and nearer the shire's own seat, kept its custom to the letter without ever being asked to think twice about it, and thought no more of Baile chrom's irregularity than a shrug when it was mentioned at all. The north had not, in truth, agreed among itself on the matter; it had learned, in its years under the crown, a great deal about which disagreements were worth carrying to a bishop and which were better left where they lay, and a vigil-keeper's choice of headland over hearthroom, so long as the vigil itself was kept, fell without much debate into the second kind.

V

Of the Geese Going North

Muileann fhionn, the mill-town the humans had built to watch the northern landing and left, like everything else, to whoever wanted the keeping of it, was granted that same spring a right to hold a market for the inland country round about, the second such right any northern town had been given since the kingdom was proclaimed, after Ceann mhòr's. The Tuathach drovers of the hill farms, who had until then walked their cattle and sheep the long way south to sell where a buyer could be found, began instead to bring them to Muileann fhionn on set days, and from Muileann fhionn the droves went on south by the old tracks to Ceann leathan and the farms beyond it, so that within a few years the town's green stood ankle-deep in trodden mud every market morning and its inns did a trade the mill alone had never given them. Nobody troubled to write down whose idea the market right had been. It answered a need every farmer in the hills had felt for years, and answering it cost the council nothing, which was, that spring, coming to be understood in the north as the surest sign that a thing would be granted rather than filed.

The green at Muileann fhionn had been common ground since the humans' day, used for nothing more than a fair-weather pasture and the odd game of ball among the mill hands, and it took the town's carpenters most of a month to lay hurdles enough to pen the first market's beasts, working from a plan one of them had seen used at a southern fair and adapted, by guesswork more than instruction, to hold cattle rather than the finer stock the southern fair had been built for. The first morning brought fewer drovers than the second, and the second fewer than the third, word travelling up the hill tracks the way word always travelled in the north, by one farmer telling the next at a boundary wall, until by midsummer the green stood full on every market day and the innkeepers of Muileann fhionn, who had kept rooms half the year for millers and the other half for nobody, found themselves turning trade away for the first time in the town's memory.

By the time the market opened its first season the geese had already gone. They had come down the coast past Baile chrom every autumn within living memory and gone north again every spring, in lines that broke and re-formed against a wind that never seemed to be blowing the way they wanted it to, and no one in the town, watching them from the shingle or from the shoulder of the headland where the old light stood, had ever thought them anything but geese,

going where geese go, at the season geese go there. Hannah Crane watched them from the same turf she had sat on in am Màrt, on a clear evening near the end of an Giblean, with the black cat winding round her ankles and the wind, for once, at her back, and said nothing to the woman standing beside her that a chronicler could set down as meaning more than the words themselves; only that they were early this year, or seemed it, and that the light held longer with each evening now, and that it would be a fair spring if it kept on the way it had begun.

The town below her went on with what a town's evening is made of, suppers and doorstep talk and the last of the day's work put away before dark, none of it troubled by what had been kept, once more, on a night nobody there had been told in advance, on the headland above them, in the open, where anyone who cared to climb up and watch was free to watch, and see nothing more than a woman sitting still at the foot of a lit tower until the sky came up grey in the east. That was the whole of what the vigil had ever asked to be seen doing. It was the whole of what, that year and for years after, it was seen doing. The bishops' letter stayed folded behind the altar-cloth. And the geese went north, as they always had, answering to no maor's writ and no bishop's letter and no line in any timetable a Rail Board ever hung on a wall, and were gone from the coast within the week.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Of the Wall that was Not Built

SE 10 AN GIBLEAN – SE 11 AN T-SAMHAIN

Cha tig iad a-deas. They do not come south.
— the fourth line of the council's minute on the wall, 9 an t-
Ògmhios, SE 10

I

Of the School Reported

The letter came to Cathair dhearg in an Giblean, carried by a rider who had come down the western roads from Cnoc ghorm in three days rather than four, and was proud of it. It was two pages, closely written, and it said that the church built the autumn before had opened, inside its own walls, a school for the priests who would serve it: a room with benches, a shelf of books sent up from the south, and a master brought from Seann Skell to teach the humans' tongue and the reading of the Dia-thìris scripture the western preachers used, there being no other text thought fit. Nine boys sat its first term. It was, the letter said, the only place in the whole of the north where either tongue was taught to anyone at all.

Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill read it twice at her table in the under-clerks' room before she took it in to the council, once for its sense and once, more slowly, for what it left unsaid. Nowhere did it say who paid for the master's board, though she could guess; nowhere did it say where a boy who learned his letters was to use them, there being no place in Cnoc ghorm that asked for either tongue; nor did it

ask the council for anything, which in her eight years at the table had come to strike her as the strangest thing a northern letter could do. Most asked. This one only told, the way a man tells a neighbour a fact about his own field, wanting only that the fact be heard.

She was thirty-seven that spring, an under-clerk of the eighth year, set to the reading of letters before the council saw them and the fair-copying of what the council decided after, and she had learned already that the second of those tasks was easier than the first, because a decision, once made, had a shape you could follow with the pen, while a letter, before it was answered, could be read a dozen ways and she had not yet learned which of them the twelve men and women at the table would choose. Standing in the corridor outside the council chamber with the day's other business under her arm, she read the letter a third time, and thought that a school teaching two tongues to nine boys, in a town whose church was not a year finished, was either the smallest thing the north had done that year or the largest, and that she could not yet tell which.

She read it into the record without comment, as an under-clerk was meant to, and the council heard it without much comment either, one councillor asking only whether the master's stipend came from the see or from the town, and being told it came from both, in shares nobody present could name exactly. The letter was filed. Gormshuil wrote *received and noted* at its foot in a hand she had spent eight years making plainer than it was, and turned to the next paper in the stack, which was Seumas mac Coinnich Ghlais's, and which was not so easily filed.

II

Of the Wall Proposed

Seumas mac Coinnich Ghlais sat at the council's table for the custodian houses of the east, a broad, careful man of Ceann àrsaidh who had held his seat eight years and spoken, in most of them, less than any other councillor there, so that when he rose that morning the room gave him the particular quiet it gave a man who did not often ask for it. He had brought a map, an unusual thing for the table; most of the council's business came as paper, and paper could be filed, but a map had to be looked at, and looking at it meant the room had to agree, for as long as the looking lasted, on where the lines it showed actually ran.

His proposal was plain enough once he had unrolled it. A boundary, fixed and marked, along the line where the shires of the settled country met the shires the Tuathaich held: not a wall in the humans' old sense, stone to the shoulder and a walk along the top of it, for no one present thought the treasury could raise stone thirty miles, but a lesser thing, a ditch and a bank and stones set at the mile to say where the ditch ran when the ditch itself had silted, so that a maor riding his shire's edge, or a farmer disputing where his fence should stand, would have one line to point to rather than the memory of an old drover or the say-so of whoever had ploughed there longest.

He gave his reasons carefully, the way a man gives reasons he has turned over a long time before he trusted himself to say them aloud. The Tuathaich shires, he said, had grown quicker than the census three years before had reckoned; the mill-towns of the north filled faster than its numbers allowed for, and a line that had seemed wide enough for two peoples to keep apart of their own custom might not stay wide enough forever. Better, he said, to mark it now, while it could be marked without offence, than to leave it to be marked later by a dispute nobody in this room would care to sit in judgment on.

Gormshuil, writing the minute, kept his words as near as her hand could follow them, which was her whole office and no part of her opinion, and she found, listening, that she could not fault the reasoning even as she found herself hoping the room would refuse it. She had grown up hearing the word Tuathaich said the way her mother's people said it, without heat, a name for neighbours who kept their own feasts and their own roads and had never, in her own lifetime or her mother's, come further south than the old drove tracks the maps still showed. A wall, even a ditch and a bank, seemed to her a strange answer to a peace that had held eight years already without one.

The debate that followed ran the better part of two hours, longer than the council usually gave any one matter, and Gormshuil's hand ached from it before it was done. A councillor of the western shires spoke for the proposal, saying a marked line was a kindness to both sides of it, since an unmarked boundary was a boundary only the strong could rely on, and the Tuathaich, having no seat at this table to speak for themselves, might in time be glad of a line the Crown had agreed to keep. Another, of the coastal shires, spoke against it on grounds nearer the treasury than the heart: that a ditch thirty miles long, surveyed and dug and marked at the mile, would cost more than the year's whole revenue from the north, for a peace that had cost nothing at all so far. A third said only, when her

turn came, that she had ridden the drove tracks herself as a girl and had never in her life needed telling where one country ended and the other began, the change being plain enough in the roofs alone, in the smoke, in the dogs that barked at a stranger's coat, and that a bank of earth would tell a traveller nothing the land did not tell him already.

It was the last speaker, an old man of the northern shires himself, near enough the border to have buried a wife whose grandmother had been Tuathaich before the Severance closed the choosing, who said the thing that Gormshuil, writing it down, understood afterward to have decided the matter, though he said it quietly and without any plain claim to be closing the debate. They do not come south, he said. Not the drovers, not the walkers, not the families that had stayed on the Crown's side of the old truce line and taken the Rite. In eight years, not one shire south of the tracks had brought him a complaint of a Tuathaich crossing where he was not wanted, and he did not see the use of digging a line to keep out a people who had never once tried to cross it.

The council took no formal vote, the custom of the table being to let a matter stand or fall by whether anyone still pressed it once every voice had been heard, and by the time the old man had finished no one pressed it further, Seumas mac Coinnich Ghlais least of all, who rolled his map without visible disappointment and said only that he had thought it worth the asking, which, in the manner the council kept its records, was as near to a withdrawal as any proposal there ever received.

Gormshuil wrote the minute that night at the under-clerks' table by a single candle, the room otherwise empty, and found the writing of it harder than the sitting through it had been, because a minute was meant to be short and the debate had not been. She cut it, in the end, to four lines: that the boundary was proposed; that it was found needless, the two peoples keeping apart already of their own will; that the cost was weighed and set against the need; and, last, because she could think of no shorter way to say what the old man's words had actually settled, the sentence he had spoken, unaltered from his mouth. *They do not come south.*

She carried the fair copy to the table the next morning for the council's hands, as was the custom for any minute touching a matter of weight, and five of the twelve wrote their initials under it without pause, the old man's among the first. Seven did not, which she had expected, a councillor's silence on a matter already dead being no more than good manners toward a colleague who had lost a debate;

what she had not expected, reading the seven names again after the table had emptied, was that not one of them had written a word against it either. No dissent was entered, and no one asked that the matter be raised again. Nor had any vote ever been called against the wall; a room had simply stopped speaking of it, and the wall went unbuilt on the strength of that silence alone. Gormshuil, copying the sheet a second time before she filed it, thought it a strange way for twelve people to decide anything, and a stranger way still for it to work.

She kept that second copy, though she had not planned to; she had cut a spare sheet from the same stock only because her first draft had blotted, and it was only after the fair copy was filed and the blotted one lay ready for the fire that she found she did not want to burn it. Smoothing it and folding it instead, she carried it home, and that evening, at her own table in the room she shared with two other under-clerks, she began a book: a small one, bound in plain board by a binder near the council's house who asked no questions of a clerk buying paper, its first page nothing but the folded minute pasted flat and, beneath it, in her own hand, the date and no more. She did not tell her clerk-master she had begun it. She could not, that first night, have said herself what she meant it for, only that a room's silence, eight years into a kingdom, seemed to her a thing worth keeping somewhere other than a filed sheet no one but a clerk would ever read again.

III

Of the Walk to Allt an Àigh

her mother came to the capital twice a year, at the turning of the seasons, and stayed a week each time in the room above a chandler's shop that had been theirs since Gormshuil was small, before the girl had a bed of her own at the council's lodgings and her mother had a house of her own two days' ride east, in a village near Ceann àrsaidh where the old custodian families still kept, alongside the Rite the state now taught, an older reckoning of their own. Her mother was of an Old Spirits house, one of the last in that shire to hold to it openly, and had never made a secret of it to her daughter nor much of one to anyone else, the council's law having found nothing in the old walking-faiths worth forbidding so long as they forbade nothing of the Crown's own in return.

That summer her mother's visit fell, by chance or by her mother's own choosing, in the week before the walk to Allt an Àigh¹, the holy well in the east whose water the old tellings said would bring good fortune to whoever drank it in the right quarter of the moon, and she asked Gormshuil, as she asked most years and was most years refused for want of leave, whether the council could spare its under-clerk a fortnight. That year, for reasons Gormshuil did not examine too closely at the time, the council could, the summer business being light and her clerk-master owing her, by his own reckoning, more days than he had ever paid.

They walked it together on foot, the way the walk was meant to be walked, four days out from the capital on the eastern road and a fifth along a drove track her mother knew from girlhood, past barley going gold and hedgerows loud with bees, sleeping two nights at farms that took walkers in for a coin or a prayer, whichever was offered, and one night at Achadh gharbh, where the village was raising a hall for the walkers.

The hall was not yet finished: a long low building the village was raising with its own hands, timber and turf, roofed that summer and still wanting the great hearth meant for its middle, with pallets already ranged along both walls. It was going up because the village had grown tired, its keeper told them over the evening fire, of finding walkers asleep in its barns and cattle-byres every autumn and had thought it easier in the end to build them a barn of their own. The keeper-to-be was an old woman with a ledger she was plainly proud of, a great cracked-spined book begun that very summer, in which she wrote, in a careful uneven hand, the shire and the name of every walker who slept a night under her roof, and she showed it to Gormshuil unasked, turning back page after page of names, telling her that it held travellers from better than twenty shires already and would hold fifty before the decade was out, north and south and east and west of the island both, the walk to Allt an Àigh being, so far as the old woman knew, the one road on which so many different shires' feet had ever worn the same track together.

Gormshuil watched her mother's face while the ledger was shown, and saw in it something she did not, that year, have words for, though she found words for it later, writing in her own book by candlelight after the walk was done: that her mother's faith, kept quietly in one shire for three generations, was written here into a stranger's ledger as plainly as a maor's tally of heads, and that the writing of

1. the stream of the healing water

it, rather than shrinking the thing, seemed somehow to have made it larger, as though a fact set down in another's hand carried further than the same fact kept only in memory.

They reached the well on the sixth day, a clear spring rising through pale stones in a fold of the land with nothing built over it but a low cairn some earlier walker had raised and every later walker added a stone to, so that it grew, the keeper at Achadh gharbh had told them, a little taller every year. Her mother knelt and drank first, cupping the water in both hands the way she had taught her daughter to do as a child, and Gormshuil, kneeling after her, found the water cold and very clear and tasting, she thought, of nothing at all beyond what water tastes of, and drank it anyway, watching the light move on it the way the old tales said it moved, in a sheen of colours that might have been the water's own trick of the pale stones beneath it or might, as her mother believed without ever quite saying she believed it, have been something else.

They walked the eastern road back together as far as Ceann àrsaidh, where her mother turned north to her own village and Gormshuil south to the capital, and at the parting her mother said only that she was glad the walk had been given her, this year of all years, and asked nothing further, not what the council's business had been that autumn nor why her daughter had come home from it a little quieter than she had gone. Gormshuil did not tell her of the minute, nor of the book she had begun to keep, not that year and, so far as any record shows, not for some years after; but she carried the folded page in the same satchel that had carried her drinking-cup to the well, and she thought, walking the last miles alone, that a line written to keep two peoples apart and a well walked to by fifty shires together were, in some way she had not yet the words to set down properly, answers to the same question, given in the same summer by two different rooms of the same kingdom.

IV

Of the Sloc Mòr

She was back at the council's table before the month's end, and the business waiting for her there had none of the quiet of a well in a fold of the eastern hills. The mine had been the humans' before it was anyone's, a shaft sunk two generations back into a seam that ran the length of the central hills, worked

day and night under a foreman's roster the humans had left behind them along with the shafts themselves, and the council, in the ten years since the Severance, had done little with it beyond keeping the roster running and taking what came up. That spring the surveyor's report that came to the table said, in the flat language surveyors used for things that would have startled anyone reading them plainly, that the yield of the mountain had come back to what it had given under the humans, and in the month just past had passed it.

The report went on to say what the council already half knew, that the working had not changed at all; the same faces were cut, by the same methods, at the same pace the humans had set, and the only thing new about the mountain's yield was the hands the profit of it now filled. Where a foreman's ledger had once gone east across the sea, it went now to a Crown clerk's chest at Cathair dhearg, and of what it held the council decided, that same sitting, to keep a fifth part for the Crown and grant the rest whole to whoever took on the working from here, the state having neither the men nor, several councillors said plainly, the wish to run a mine when a subject house could be found to run it instead.

The house found was Uisdean mac Ùisdein's, of Cathair mhòr, whose family had held an overseer's post under the humans at the very shaft now in question, and who came to the capital himself that spring to put his name to the grant, a broad, sure-voiced man in his middle forties who spoke of the mountain the way another man might speak of a field he had ploughed since boyhood, familiarly, without any great show of the honour being done him. The terms he signed were, Gormshuil noted, copying the grant fair for the record, the humans' own terms almost to the letter, a fifth to the Crown and the rest to the house that worked it, the rosters and the rates of pay carried over unaltered from ledgers the humans themselves had kept. Only the names at the top of the page had changed. She wrote the grant out twice, once for the council's own chest and once for Uisdean mac Ùisdein to carry home, and thought, setting down his name a second time in the same careful hand she had used for Seumas mac Coinnich Ghlais's minute the year before, that a kingdom not ten years old seemed readier, in the end, to copy an old arrangement than to make a new one, so long as the copying put the profit where the copying's makers wanted it.

A board was seated that same season to see the grant kept to its terms, three clerks and an engineer set at a table in a back room of the council's own house at Cathair dhearg, close enough to the chamber that Gormshuil, carrying papers between the two, came to know its members by their first names before the winter

was out. It had no grander name at first than the mine's own board, and kept, in its early months, no records grander than a shift-roster and a weekly count of what came up the shaft, but it was the board, small as it was, that the council now answered to on any question touching the mountain, Uisdean mac Ùisdein himself, for all his grant, sending his own returns to it rather than to the council directly, the way a tenant answers his own landlord and not the landlord's lord.

V

Of the Night Shift and the Blessing

The one term the council did not alter, in granting the mine away, was the roster, and it ran day and night both, as it had run under the humans, the mountain given no season and no hour it was not worked. A councillor asked, at the sitting where the grant was confirmed, whether the night shift ought not to be ended now that the working was the island's own and not a foreign company's, the mountain having earned, in her phrase, a right to the rest its old masters had never allowed it; the board's own engineer answered that the yield the council had just heard reported, the very number that made the grant worth granting, came in no small part from a shaft that never stood idle, and the matter was set aside rather than decided, in the same way, Gormshuil thought, writing it down, that the wall had been set aside the year before: not refused outright, only left, by a room that had heard both sides and found neither worth the cost of a plain answer either way.

The custodians of the vein, whose houses had kept the old duties of the shafts since long before the humans came, entered their protest that same month, a short paper carried down from the mountain by one of their own number and read into the council's record without much debate: that the working without rest broke a custom older than the humans' grant and older, the paper said, than the Crown that had now confirmed it, and that the custodians asked only that the protest stand written, the shift's ending being, they knew by then, no longer the council's to give back, so that no one after could say the breaking of the old custom had gone unmarked. Gormshuil copied it as carefully as she had copied the wall's minute, and found, reading it back to herself that evening, that she could not have said which of the two papers, the councillor's four lines or the custodians' half-page, asked the smaller thing of the room that received it, and got, in the

end, the same answer from it: the fact allowed to stand, and nothing changed by the standing.

She rode east herself before the winter, sent with the council's own copy of the grant to be read at the shaft-head before the assembled hewers, a formality her clerk-master could as easily have sent another for, though she never learned, and did not ask, why he chose her. The mountain in winter was a grey country, its lower slopes cut with the black scars of the old workings and its upper ones already under the first snow, and the shaft-head, when she reached it, stood lit day and night as the reports had said it did, lamps burning at the pit-mouth against a darkness that would not, that season, lift from the mountain's face for more than a few hours together.

She read the grant aloud from a plank set up before the assembled men, her breath showing white in the lamp-light, and watched the custodians of the shaft, four of them in the grey coats their office wore, stand a little apart from the hewers while she read, their protest already filed and answered by the same silence that had answered the wall. When the reading was done and the men had gone back to the shift, the custodians did the thing she had come, without quite admitting it to herself, half hoping to see: they walked to the pit-mouth themselves, the four of them together, and spoke over it the words of an old blessing she did not know, in a low unhurried *Dia-thìris* she followed only in patches, calling on the mountain, so far as she could make out the sense of it, to hold and to give and to be, in its own time, allowed to rest.

She stood at the edge of the lamplight and watched them do it, and thought, watching, of the old man's words in the council chamber the year before, *they do not come south*, and of the custodians' own protest, entered and answered by nothing, and of the ledger at Achadh gharbh growing a name longer every year while the line that might have marked a border went undrawn; and she understood, standing there in the cold with the shaft's lamps burning behind the four bent grey-coated backs, that a kingdom could refuse a wall and grant a mine in the same season, could let one people walk where it pleased and work another mountain past the hour its own custodians asked it be let stand, and count both, in the flat language of its own records, as peace kept. The custodians finished the blessing and stood a moment longer at the shaft's edge with their heads bowed, and then, without any further word to the clerk who had come to read them their own dispossession, turned back to the mountain's business, and the lamps burned on at the pit-mouth into the falling dark, as they had burned the night be-

fore and would burn the night after, without pause, and without needing, any longer, anyone's leave to do it.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Of the Sloc Mòr

SE 12 AM MÀRT – SE 13 AN T-SAMHAIN

Tha an fhèith a' seinn fon lasair, ach 's e na làmban a chì a dath. The
vein sings under the lamp, but it is the hand that sees its colour.

— said among the chainmen of the Sloc Mòr, of the charter sworn at
Achadh dhomhain, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 13

I

Of the Lamp and the Chain

I ain mac Ruairidh was nineteen the spring Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin took him on, and he came to it the way most of the hill families came to anything, by having no better offer and a father who had been down in the rock himself and did not want the boy following him there with a pick. Ruairidh had cut coal at the Sloc Mòr for eleven years and had the cough that came of it, and when the Board's man rode up from Achadh dhomhain asking after a boy who could hold a chain steady and had his letters well enough to keep a book, Ruairidh sent Iain out to the yard before the man had finished asking.

Lachlann was fifty-two that year, broad through the shoulders and going grey at the temple, and he had surveyed the Sloc Mòr's galleries, for the humans' Company and then for the Board, since before Iain was born. He looked the boy over once, took the measure of his hands, which were a hewer's son's hands and knew what rock was, and said only that a chainman who dropped his end of the chain in the dark was worse than no chainman at all, and that Iain would learn or he would go home. Iain did not go home.

The work was plain enough to name and hard enough to do. Lachlann carried the lamp and read the face; Iain carried the sixty-six-foot chain, drove the pins, called the links back to Lachlann's book, and learned, over that first summer, the difference between a fault that pinched a seam thin and a fault that only bent it. The Board's surveys did not trust a compass alone in a gallery cut through iron-bearing rock, so much of the work was done link by link, pin by pin, a hundred feet at a stretch, with the lamp throwing its small circle of light on rock that had never had a light thrown on it before.

It was Lachlann who first told him, on a morning in the old eastern galleries when the face ahead of them ran three colours where Iain saw one, that the Diathìrich saw more in a broken face than the humans ever had, and that the Board's surveyors, all of them of the old blood, were valued for the same reason the hewers were: a hand of the island's own blood could tell a seam that would hold from a seam that would run, most days, before the pick ever bit it. He did not make more of it than that. He showed Iain where the grey went to green at a fault's lip, and where the black thickened toward a good face, and said that a chainman who learned to read it as well as he chained it would be worth keeping. Iain learned it the way he had learned his letters, slowly and then all at once, and by the autumn he could stand at Lachlann's shoulder and see, before the older man said it aloud, which way the book's next line would run.

Lachlann was not a talking man, and what talk he gave came mostly at the end of a shift, sitting on an upturned barrow at the gallery mouth while the lamp burned low and the hewers went past them toward the cage. He had come to the Board from a family of custodians near Cathair mhòr, a house that had kept the old rites before the Rite had a doctrine to keep, and he said once, when Iain asked him plainly why a custodian's grandson chained coal for a living, that the mountain had been sacred before it was a concession and would go on being sacred after the concession ran out, whatever the charters said, and that a man who measured it honestly did it more honour than a man who only blessed the shafts and went home. He did not say it twice, and Iain did not ask him to.

By the second summer Iain could carry the chain alone over short courses while Lachlann worked ahead with the lamp, and could set a pin true in rock that gave no easy footing, in the dark, by feel as much as by sight. He learned, too, the small dishonesties a chain could be put to and the men who tried them: a hewer's brother, paid by the fathom driven, who would swear a course ran four links longer than it did, and the quiet, unhurried way Lachlann had of walking the

ground again himself and saying nothing about it beyond the true figure entered in the book. "The rock doesn't care what a man's paid," he told Iain once, "only the book does, and the book is honest because we make it so, not because it wants to be." Iain wrote that down too, in his own book, the same night.

He kept his own small book that year too, apart from the Board's, a boy's habit copied from watching Lachlann write. In it he set down the things the Board's book had no room for: the day a spring broke through above the third gallery and they lost a week pumping it clear; the day a hewer named Fearchar found a fist of raw coal so black it threw the lamp's flame straight back, and Lachlann took it away to be shown to the custodians and it was never seen again; the day the chain came up short by two links and Iain walked the ground twice before he found where a hewer's barrow had dragged a pin loose. None of it went into the Board's survey. All of it, in Iain's own hand, went into his.

II

Of the Towns that Filled

The east had gone hungry again that year, in the way it did every few years when the barley failed on the thin soils above Baile ruadh and the eastern moors, and the families who could not wait out a bad season on borrowed seed did what such families had always done, which was to go where wages were paid in coin rather than promised in grain. The Sloc Mòr paid in the kingdom's new coin, and so they came, on foot mostly, with what they could carry, down the coal road and up the valley to Achadh dhomhain and the towns that had grown up round the pithead.

Muileann dhearg took the most of them. It had been a small place at the Severance, a shire seat with a Fèidh chapel and a druid hall shut up since the humans' time, its doors nailed and its roof sound but empty. By the second year of the hungry families' coming, the hall had been opened again as a lodging, rows of pallets on its floor and a fire kept in its hearth through the worst of the winter, and it was enlarged twice in those same years, first with a lean-to along its south wall and then with a second storey built crudely of the same grey spoil-stone the quarries were cutting a mile off. The town doubled within three years of Iain's taking on, and the maor who kept its rolls stopped trying to name every household that

passed through it and began instead to count heads at midsummer and let the rest go unrecorded.

Baile thais grew a different way. It had always been the place where the coal road came down off the central hills to meet the Abhainn uaine above the gulf, a crossing more than a town, and the carters who had once passed through it in a morning began to stop the night, and then to keep families there, and the town filled in behind them with inns and stables and, in Iain's second autumn on the chain, a ropewalk laid out along the water meadow below the ford, where hemp was worked into the hauling-ropes the Sloc Mòr's cages used and sold, besides, to every carter on the road. Within the decade its people had doubled too, and the council gave it a shire court of its own, the first new court granted north of Cathair mhòr in Iain's lifetime.

Of the coast that same year the Library keeps one page, and it is a short one. Ships that flew no flag, some of them crewed, it was said, by men who had once worn the humans' uniform and now wore none, began to work the waters off Cathair gheal in the north-west, and the towns there, being Tuathaich towns and poor ones, had neither walls nor boats built for fighting and found no one troubled to defend them. A fishing house was burned on the shore below Cathair gheal that summer, and two boats taken out of Cathair gheal's own small harbour never came home, and the council's minute on it, when the Moot's letter reached Cathair dhearg the following spring, ran to four lines and asked that the matter be watched. It was watched. Nothing else was done that year, and the raiders' ships kept the north-western water for a long while after.

Iain heard of it the way most of the south heard of anything from that coast, third-hand and late, from a carter at Baile thais who had it from a fisherman who had it from a man who had lost a cousin off Cathair gheal. He did not think much of it at the time. He had a chain to run and a book to keep, and the mountain, that year, gave him more than enough to fill both.

The filling of the towns stayed with Iain longer than the raiders did, having come closer to hand. That autumn he was sent to walk the Muileann dhearg lodging with the maor's clerk, to mark on a plan which of the hall's new rooms stood over ground the Board judged sound and which did not, the old druid hall having been raised, like most things built before the humans came, without much thought for what lay beneath it. There he counted forty-one pallets on the ground floor alone, laid so close a man could not have crossed the room without stepping between sleepers, and a hearth kept going day and night by whichever

family's turn it was, and a smell of wet wool and tallow that he did not lose from his coat for a week after. A woman there, Ealasaid, newly down from Baile ruadh with three children and a husband gone ahead the season before to find work, asked him plainly whether the Board meant to build proper walls or only to keep stacking families under the one roof until it fell in on them, and Iain had no answer for her beyond the true one, which was that he surveyed ground, not lodgings, and that the question was the maor's to answer, not his. He wrote her question down anyway. It went nowhere he ever heard of.

III

Of the First Train

The humans' railway had come apart in places over the years since the Severance, its rails lifted in three parishes for the iron and its sleepers rotted where no one had thought to renew them, but the stretch from Cathair dhearg north had been kept, more or less, by a Rail Board that mended what it must and let the rest stand idle, and in Iain's first year on the chain that mending reached the valley. Gangs came up from the south with the humans' own tools, worn but sound, and laid new sleepers under old rail as far as the pithead, so that for the first time since the humans had built it the line ran unbroken from Achadh dhomhain to the capital.

The first train went down on the third of an Dàmhair, a grey morning with rain threatening and not falling, and half the town came out to see it off. There was no ceremony to it beyond the crowd that came; no Dia-thìris word had been coined yet for the thing, and the engineer who fired the boiler was a Tuathaich man who had learned the humans' trade from his father and kept the humans' habits with it, oiling the wheels the way the humans had oiled them and calling the whistle by the humans' word before anyone thought to give it another. The wagons behind him were loaded with coal cut that same week, in the kingdom's name now though on the humans' rails, and the whole of it, engine and wagons and the men who rode the footplate, went down the valley at a walking pace and out of sight round the first bend, and the crowd went back to its work.

Iain stood at the yard fence with Lachlann that morning and watched it go, and said, because it seemed a thing worth saying, that it was strange to see the humans' iron still doing the humans' work with no human left on the island to

claim it. Lachlann said that the iron did not know whose name was on the wagons, and went back to his book.

The maor of Achadh dhomhain had wanted a blessing said over the first train, and had sent word to the Rite's house at Muileann dhearg to that effect, but the custodian who came up was an old man unused to trains and unwilling to walk the length of the footplate, and in the end he said his words over the coal in the first wagon rather than the engine, which the engineer, a Tuathaich man named Colin Rudd who had oiled locomotives under the humans' foremen as a boy, took as no insult and rather more sense than blessing an engine would have been. "You can bless coal," Colin Rudd said to Iain afterward, while the fire was building in the boiler and the crowd was still thick along the fence, "coal's been blessed since before either of us. Nobody's blessed an engine yet, and I'd not know what it would want with one." He spat, companionably, into the ash-pit and climbed up to his footplate, and a few minutes later the whistle went, a long human sound that startled half the children in the crowd into tears and the other half into cheering, and the train drew out.

The spoil that came up out of the Sloc Mòr's deeper galleries that year was a grey stone veined through with black, no use for building until someone thought to try it, and Uisdean mac Ùisdein's house, which held the concession, was the someone who thought to try it. A quarry was cut into the hillside above Achadh dhomhain before the year was out, and the stone, dressed and squared, went south on the same rails the coal went south on, sold under a mark cut into each block, a stylised wave for the house of Mac Ùisdein, so that a man in Cathair dhearg walking past a new wall could read, if he knew the mark, where the stone under his hand had come from. It built well and it built cheap, and within a few years half the new work going up in the south's public buildings was raised in it. Iain, who cut nothing and quarried nothing, only chained the faces the quarrymen went on to strip, thought little of the mark that first year he saw it stamped into a block on a wagon: a mountain gave up stone as readily as it gave up coal, once a house had found a way to sell both.

IV

Of the Sidings and the Spur

The Rail Board, which had its office at Cathair dhearg by then, a low building of the same grey Mac Ùisdein stone, laid new sidings the following year at Muileann chrom, where the line from the Sloc Mòr met the older line down to the ports. It was there that the coal trains were broken up, their wagons sorted by the port they were bound for and made up again into new trains, and it was there, too, that a new kind of town grew up beside the old one, a scatter of low rows built for the families who worked the small shunting engines that did the sorting.

The Board counted these families apart from the rest of Muileann chrom's people, on a roll of their own kept separate from the shire's, and housed them apart as well, in the rows nearest the lines where the noise and the smoke of the yard never let up, day or night. It was not spoken of as a punishment, and no one on the Board would have called it one; it was only, the minute said, that a yard family's hours did not keep a shire's hours, and a roll that tried to hold both would serve neither well. Iain passed through Muileann chrom twice that year, carrying survey rolls between the Sloc Mòr and Cathair dhearg, and saw the rows from the carriage window both times, and both times thought that a family counted apart long enough forgets, after a while, that it was ever counted any other way.

On the second of those passings he had an hour to wait for the onward train and walked out along the rows himself rather than sit in the station house, and fell into talk with a shunting-engine driver named Murchadh who had worked the humans' small engines since he was a boy of twelve and had never once, in thirty years, been asked his name by anyone from the shire office at Muileann chrom proper, though he could have walked there in a quarter hour. Murchadh was not bitter about it, or did not show it if he was; he said only that a man who worked nights sorting wagons had no time for a shire's business and no great wish to make time for it, and that the yard looked after its own better than the shire had ever looked after the yard. Iain thought that a strange kind of pride to take in being left alone, and said nothing of it, and went on to catch his train.

In the same season the Board opened a spur off the western branch to Àth leathan, a gathering of pits and shanties in the hills where Tuathaich hewers had worked the coal since before the kingdom had troubled to draw a road to them. The spur was short, thirteen miles of new-laid rail over ground the Board's own surveys called poor, and it was built, the minute recorded, because the coal at Àth leathan was cheap to lift and the carters' road to it was worse each winter than the

last. Iain never walked it himself. He heard of it from a hewer at the Sloc Mòr whose brother had gone to Àth leathan for the wage and wrote home, twice a year, in a hand the hewer could not read and had to carry to a neighbour with his letters to have read to him.

V

Of the Oath on the Coal

The custom of binding hewers by charter, which the humans had never troubled to keep and which the island itself had not kept since the Holy Age, was taken up again that autumn, in a changed form. The old form, so far as anyone at the Sloc Mòr could reconstruct it from the custodians' copies of the Holy Age rolls, had bound apprentices of whatever blood a master chose to take; the new form, as the council's charter set it down, bound Dia-thìrich alone, and said so in its opening clause without troubling to give a reason, as a thing too plain to need one.

The Guild of Hewers was chartered at Achadh dhomhain on a bright, cold day in an t-Samhain, in the yard before the pithead, with the whole of the town's Dia-thìreach families turned out to see it and most of its Tuathaich families kept to their work, the charter having said nothing of a holiday for them. A table was set up under an awning against the weather, and the charter was read aloud twice, once by the maor's clerk and once, because a good half of those present could not follow the clerk's court Dia-thìris, by a hewer named Aonghas who had learned to read it from his own father and rendered it plain. Then the men who were to be bound came forward, by families, eldest first, and each in turn laid his hand flat on a lump of coal set on the table for the purpose, black and rough-edged and no different to look at from a thousand others cut that same week, and swore the oath the charter gave him: to keep the guild's custom, to take no work outside it, to teach no craft of it to a hand not sworn.

Iain stood at the table's edge with Lachlann's rolls under his arm, having been sent down from the galleries to carry the day's survey to the maor's office once the swearing was done, and watched the line go past him, man after man, his own father among them near the front of it, laying a hand that had cut coal for eleven years on a lump no bigger than a fist and speaking words that made him, from that hour, something Iain was not and could not be made. Iain had been taken on

by a surveyor, and the Board's roll was the only one that carried his name; the charter, when the clerk read its closing clause, said plainly that its rolls were open to those who cut, hauled or timbered the coal, and named no place in them for one who only measured where it lay. No one told him to stand back from the table. He simply understood, watching his father's hand come down flat on the coal and hearing the oath said in a voice steadier than he had ever heard his father use for anything else, that the table was not his to come to, and stood where he was, at its edge, with the rolls under his arm, until the swearing was over and the crowd began to break up toward the ale that had been laid on in the hall.

His father found him there afterward, said little, being a man of few words at the best of times, and put a hand on Iain's shoulder for a moment, the same hand that had just sworn the oath, before going off to the hall with the other sworn men. Lachlann, who had come down from the galleries himself to see the charter read, found Iain still standing by the table a while later and said, not unkindly, that a chainman's name went into the Board's book, which was a kind of oath too, if a colder one, and that the mountain kept no better account of a man than the figures he left in it. Iain said that a cold oath was still not the one his father had sworn. Lachlann did not argue the point, having, it seemed, no argument to make against it, and the two of them walked back up toward the galleries together while the hall behind them filled with noise and firelight.

Iain walked back to the surveyors' hut alone once Lachlann had turned off toward his own lodging, in the last of the light, past the pithead where the new sidings ran black and empty in the cold, and wrote that night in his own small book, apart from the Board's, the thing he had watched and where he had stood while he watched it. He did not write why it had mattered so much to stand there. He did not, that year, have the words for it, and the book, in any case, kept better company with what a man had seen than with what he had felt about seeing it.

The saying the hewers had for the mountain, which Iain had heard a hundred times that year without troubling to write it down, he set down now for the first time, at the foot of the page, because it seemed, of a sudden, to fit more than the mountain: *Cha d'fhuair a' bheinn fois a-riambh*. The mountain never got rest.

PART THREE

OF Guilds, Law and Library

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

OF the INDENTURES

SE 14 AM FAOILLEACH – AN DÙBHLACHD

Scriobh a làmh an t-ainm; a làmh fhèin a reub e. His hand wrote the name; that same hand tore it.

— said of Seumas Crùbach at Cuan shean, of the loosing of the indentures, 28 am Màrt, SE 14

I

Of the Yard in Winter

harry Marlow was seventeen that Faoilleach, four years into his time at Seumas Crùbach's yard on the hard at Cuan shean, and had stopped, some while before, counting the years the way a boy counts them and started counting them the way a bound man does, by the work left to learn rather than the work already behind him. The yard in am Faoilleach kept short hours and long fires. There was little to build that no one wanted mended first, and the mending, that winter, was slow work done by lamplight with the wind coming straight off the firth and finding every gap in the shed's south wall that four winters of caulking had not yet closed.

Seumas Crùbach was forty that year, a big slow-spoken man with one leg shorter than the other from a fall off a stage twenty years before, which was where the name had come to him and stayed, and he had taken Harry on, sight unseen, on a passing word about a boy at Doire mhin who could true a plough-beam by eye. He had not been disappointed in the boy, and said as much, rarely, and never twice. What he had taught Harry in four years he taught the way most of the yard's masters taught, by making him hold the far end of things, the adze, the

clamp, the long batten sprung round a rising frame, until holding them stopped being a thing he thought about and became a thing his hands simply did, the way Lachlann's chainman up at the Sloc Mòr, had either of them ever met the other, might have said his own trade was learned. Seumas kept a small library of nothing at all, no book of the trade beyond a single dog-eared tide-table nailed inside the shed door, and taught out of his hands and out of the hulls standing round him, which he held to be library enough for any craft worth calling one.

At the far end of the hard, past the two hulls under repair and the third laid up on blocks for the winter, stood a fourth that nobody paid to have mended, an old human vessel left derelict on the sand since before Harry's time, her stem stove in on a falling tide some years back and never worth the labour of hauling clear, so that she had simply stayed, settling a little deeper into the shingle each winter, her timbers greying and her caulking gone to powder. Harry had taken to her in his second year the way another boy might have taken to a book, going down to her in the stolen half-hour before the yard opened or after it shut, first only to look, and later, once he had begun to trust his own eye, to measure. It had troubled him from his first winter at Cuan shean that the humans' way of raising a hull and the yard's own way came at the same hull from opposite ends: the yard's hulls went up frame first, rib after rib stepped and faired before a single plank closed them in, so that a man could stand inside the naked skeleton of a boat and read her whole form before she held water; the humans, by every account Harry had ever been given, built the other way about, plank on plank from the keel up, shaping the hull's skin before her bones were more than a notion in the shipwright's head, a method the yard's men called quick and unsound in the same breath, the way a man might call a short cut both quick and unsound. He had asked a stranger once, years before, at his father's forge, which of the two ways was truer, and been told only that he would have his answer soon enough. No master of the yard had troubled, in four years, to build a hull the humans' way and show him. The old wreck on the hard was the nearest thing to an answer the yard possessed, and Harry went to her, that winter and every winter since his second, with a rule and a scrap of slate, learning by his own measure what no man at Cuan shean would trouble to teach him.

The other apprentices of the yard, four of them that winter besides Harry, three Dia-thìreach boys bound in the ordinary way and one Tuathaich boy younger than Harry, out of a fishing family further down the coast, thought little of Harry's evenings at the wreck and said as much, the biggest and idlest-handed

of the Dia-thireach boys, who would himself be sworn that spring, telling him more than once that a man learned nothing from a dead hull that a live one, worked under a master's eye, would not teach him twice as fast and half as cold. Harry did not argue the point, having found argument a poor tool against a boy who had never gone down to the sand himself to see what there was to learn there, and went on measuring. The younger Tuathaich boy alone, of the four, sometimes came down with him in the last light, to hold the lamp steady rather than to measure, having no head yet for it, and to ask, now and again, some plain question neither of them yet had the words for, and it was in answering those plain questions, more than in any book, that Harry first found words of his own for what his hands already knew.

II

Of the News from Ros dhomhain

The news came up the coast the way most news came to Cuan shean that year, by a coaster putting in for water and staying an extra tide for the gossip, and it was old news already, three weeks stale, by the time it reached the yard: that the shipwrights of Ros dhomhain, who had built hulls for the whole southern coast since before the kingdom had any name of its own, had taken a charter of their own from the guild court at Cathair dhearg, and bound thirty apprentices in a single day on the slipway to mark it, the largest binding the south had seen since the Crossing. Seumas heard it out at the shed door from the coaster's mate, a wiry man with a Ros dhomhain accent thick enough to cut, and asked, when the telling was done, only how many of the thirty were Tuathaich boys, which the mate could not say, not having troubled to ask, and thought an odd question to be asked at all.

It was not, that winter, an odd question at Cuan shean, or anywhere along the coast where a Tuathaich boy had ever been bound to a Dia-thireach master's craft. The charters were going up everywhere that year, guild after guild taking its letters from the court at Cathair dhearg the way a town takes a market day, each charter naming its own trade's custom and each custom, without quite saying why, drawn a little narrower than the last. It was told, that same winter, of the chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh, upriver of the capital on the Abhainn fhionn, that their new charter won them the sole right to fit the Crown's patrol boats, a right

the chandlers meant to hold for as long as the Crown kept a boat afloat; and of the lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, who made between them every coal lamp burned in every shaft on the island, that their charter set upon their work a mark, a flame struck over a hammer, stamped from that winter on every lamp that left their sheds, so that a hewer a hundred miles off, holding a strange lamp up to the light, could read in that small stamp the whole history of where it had been made and under what oath. Of all the marks the guilds set that year, the Tuathaich traders of the north, the humans' children, who copied little from the island's guild law, were said to have copied that one alone onto lamps of their own, finding it, whatever else they made of the rest, a useful thing to know a lamp by.

What the charters did not say, most of them, was what was owed a boy already bound before the charter was read, and it was this silence, more than any single line in any single guild's letter, that sat that winter in the yards and the smithies and the weaving-sheds of every coast the humans' children worked. A rope-maker's apprentice at Ros dhomhain, four years bound already and thought by his own master fit to be sworn with the thirty, brought his case that winter to the same guild court that had chartered the shipwrights, standing before three benchmen in a hall built for the hearing of debts and disputed cargoes and asking only to be sworn along with the rest of his master's household. He was heard out in full, the court giving him, by the account that reached Cuan shean, a fairer hearing than a rope-maker's apprentice commonly got, and refused in the same sitting, the eldest benchman reading the charter's own words back to him slowly, that its custom of binding was kept for those of Dia-thirich blood and named no other, and that a court sworn to the charter could no more stretch its words for one boy's sake than a shipwright could stretch a keel too short for the hull laid on it. The boy's own master, it was told, said nothing in the hearing to help him, having, by then, no words left in the charter's own language that would have served. The Moot at Caol mhòr, hearing of the ruling by the same slow road all northern news travelled, wrote that winter to the guild court at Cathair dhearg asking plainly what was to become of the indentures already standing across every trade the charters touched, and had its letter filed among that year's other business, without an answer, a fact the Moot's own minute-book set down at the foot of the page in a hand that Harry, had he ever seen it, would have known at once for its plainness, whoever held the pen.

Seumas said little of any of it that winter, being a man slow to speak of a thing until he could see the whole of it, and Harry noticed, without being told to no-

tice, that his master had begun, some time in am Faoilleach, to look at him a beat longer than the work required before turning back to whatever the two of them were doing, the way a man looks at a thing he expects, before long, to lose.

III

Of the Eight-and-Twentieth of am Màrt

The letter came to Cuan shean on the twenty-eighth of am Màrt, carried by the same maor's clerk who rode the coast road twice a year with the shire's other business, and it said, in four lines that took the clerk less time to read aloud than it had taken him to find the yard, that the custom of binding, restored to every chartered guild of the island that winter and spring, was kept henceforth for Dia-thirich hands alone, and that any indenture standing between a guild master and a Tuathaich boy, wherever on the coast it was held, was from that day loosed. The same letter, or one much like it, went that week to Seann Bhrál in the west, where the Leòid ruling had been given years before on land and not on labour, and to every yard and shed along the coast where a Tuathaich boy had ever taken a master's name along with a master's craft.

Seumas read it through once himself, standing in the shed door with the clerk still waiting for some word to carry back, and read it a second time slower, though there was nothing in four lines that a second reading could change. He asked the clerk, once, whether the rule reached back to a boy four years bound already or only forward to one not yet taken on, and was told that it reached back, the letter's own words being *any indenture standing*, and that the guild court at Cathair dhearg had been plain enough about it not to leave a master room to argue the other way. The clerk did not stay long after that, having other yards on the coast road still to reach before dark, and Seumas stood a while in the doorway with the letter in his hand after the clerk's horse had gone, before he went in to find Harry at the bench, planing a stem-piece for the second hull, and told him, without any lead-up at all, what the letter said.

Harry heard it out standing, the plane still in his hand, and said nothing for a space long enough that Seumas repeated the last of it, as though the boy might not have caught it the first time. He had caught it the first time. What he could not, in that first space, find words for was less the fact alone, which he understood plainly enough, four years of a trade being no small thing to have taken from a

man by four lines read out at a shed door, than the look on Seumas's face while he said it, a look Harry had not seen there before, one hard to name exactly, somewhere between the grief a man shows at a death he cannot prevent and the shame a man shows at a thing he is made to do and cannot, however plainly the fault lies elsewhere, entirely forgive himself for doing.

The indenture had hung, these four years, in a frame behind the shed's one good window, Harry's name and Seumas's own set down together in a clerk's careful hand and witnessed by the harbour-master of that year, long since moved on to other work. Seumas took it down himself that afternoon, unhooked it from its nail without a word to Harry about doing it, and tore it, not neatly, the paper being stiffer with age than either of them had judged it, so that the tear ran crooked across both their names before it came free in two pieces in his hands. He did this with his back half turned, and did not, in the doing of it or after, look at Harry directly, occupying his eyes instead with the two torn halves of the paper, which he folded once, carefully, as though a careful folding might undo some part of what the tearing had done, and set on the bench rather than in the fire, where four years' worth of another man's kept faith seemed, to him at least, to deserve better than burning.

"You'll have heard the wage a free hand gets on this coast," he said at last, still not looking up from the paper. "Half a bound man's, and no guild mark to show for it, and no standing in the court if a debt goes bad on you. I'll not pretend to you it's a fair trade for what the four lines took." He paused, and Harry, watching him, understood that whatever came next had cost his master some effort to arrive at. "But the bench is still yours if you'll have it on those terms, and I'll not have another boy stand where you stood these four years and call the standing his by right, when it was never given him by anything but a paper that's ash and torn corners now."

Harry said, when he had found the words for it, that he would have the bench.

IV

Of the Day-Labour

he stayed, through that spring and the summer after it, at half the wage a bound man drew and none of the standing, which was, in the small ways a yard measures such things, no small change. He ate at the same board as

the sworn men still, Seumas seeing to that much himself, though he sat at its foot rather than its middle, by a custom nobody troubled to name to him and that he learned quickly enough on his own not to ask named. More often than before he was sent to fetch and carry rather than to fair a plank, the yard's other hands, sworn men now under the new charter Seumas himself had at last to take from the guild court that spring to keep trading at all, being wary of being seen teaching their craft too openly to a hand the charter no longer counted theirs to teach. And the whole year went by without a guild mark of his own to stamp on any work, so that a stem-piece he had fair-shaped from rough timber to finished curve left the yard, when it left it, under Seumas's stamp alone, the hands that had shaped it going unrecorded in the wood.

The half-wage told in smaller ways too, ways that took the year to add up to anything a man would trouble to complain of. He mended his own boots that year rather than paying the cobbler at the harbour end, and went without the tobacco he had taken up, against his father's wishes, in his third bound year, and put off, twice, buying a coat the winter weather said plainly he needed, until Seumas, noticing the third winter of the same worn coat without being told why it had lasted so long, set a length of oiled wool on the bench one morning with no word of where it had come from and none asked. Harry took it, and said only that he would pay him back for it come the spring herring money, and Seumas said that he would take the payment if it was offered and would not trouble himself if it was not, which both of them understood, without either saying so, to mean the same thing twice over.

What the charter did not take from him, having no way to reach it, was the hour before the yard opened and the hour after it shut, and it was in those hours, through that spring and on into the summer, that Harry went back, oftener now than in any year before, to the old wreck on the hard, measuring her frames rib by rib with a patience the yard's own work no longer quite gave him room for, and setting down what he found in a small book of his own, kept apart from any book the yard or the guild would have troubled to read.

The wreck had given up her secrets slowly and in the wrong order over Harry's three prior winters at her, the way any old and broken thing does to a boy working alone and by guesswork, and it was only the autumn before this one, on a night he did not afterward forget, that a plank sprung loose at the turn of her bilge showed him, in the shape its edge had been shaved to before ever it was fastened, the thing the yard's own frame-first men had no cause to know: that a

human shipwright did not lay his planks flat and force them to the hull's curve after, as Harry had half supposed, but shaved each one, before it ever touched the keel, to a curve the eye alone had judged against the planks laid before it, so that the whole skin of the hull was faired plank by plank, from the keel up, long before a single frame was stepped inside her to hold the shape true. It was, when he had it, a small enough thing to have taken three winters over, and he had sat a long while on the cold sand that evening with the loose plank across his knees, turning it in the last of the light, before he trusted himself to write it down. This spring and summer, freed of bound hours earlier in the day than any year before, he set himself to proving the finding against every strake still fast to her, plank by plank, to be certain the one loose piece had not misled him.

By an Lùnastal of the year the letter came, he had her lines, so far as four years' rust and rot had left them to be had, set down whole from stem to stern in the small book he kept apart from any book the yard or the guild would have troubled to read, and had learned, mostly by his own error corrected against his own measure, why a hull built plank first and frame after held together at all, a discipline the yard's own frame-first men, working the surer way, never had cause to learn.

A trader out of Seann Vell put in at Cuan shean that an t-Sultain, working the coast on his way north with a hold half full of cloth the northern towns still bought though the coin that paid for it grew scarcer each year, and heard, over an evening's ale, something of Harry's case from one of the yard's own sworn men, not unkindly meant, and said to Harry himself, the following morning, that a free hand with steady hands and no guild behind him might do better for himself at one of the northern harbours, where a man's craft was reckoned, he said, by what it was worth rather than by what paper stood behind it, there being, in the north, no guild court to stand behind either. Harry heard him out, and thanked him for the telling, and did not go. He gave the trader no long reason for staying, having none yet fully worked out even to himself, beyond the plain fact that the old wreck's lines were not yet whole in his book, and that a craft learned by his own measure, wreck by wreck and rib by rib, seemed to him, that autumn, worth more than a paper standing behind him in a court thirty miles off that had never once, in four years, stood behind him in the court three miles from where he slept.

The year ended as every year of his apprenticeship had ended, with Harry setting aside from his wage, such as it now was, the sum he sent north each Dùbh-lachd to his father's forge at Doire mhin, a habit begun in his first bound year and

kept now, half a bound man's wage or not, without his troubling to weigh whether a free hand owed the habit any less than a sworn one had. It was a smaller sum that year than any year before it, the half-wage making sure of that, and he wrote no long letter to go with it, his father Joseph Marlow being, by all Harry had ever seen of him, no reader of long letters in any case. What he wrote, folded small inside the coin, was four words only, set down in the same hand the guild's own clerk might have used to close out an account: *the bench is still mine*.

Seumas kept the two torn halves of the old indenture on the bench through that whole year, moving them from shelf to shelf as the shed's other clutter grew round them but never once putting them to the fire, and it was noticed, by more than one hand in the yard, that when a stranger asked him that Dùbhlachd how his boy did, meaning Harry, he answered as he always had, that the boy did well enough, and did not trouble, in the answering, to correct the word *boy* to *hand*, or the possessive that went before it to anything less than it had always been.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

OF AGNES PIKE'S SCHOOL

SE 15 AM FAOILLEACH – AN T-IUCHAR

Entered this day, a byre at Doire ghlas, no other roof offering: A.
Pike, mistress. Eleven scholars. No leave asked, none given, none re-
fused.

— the school's own register, first leaf, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15

I

Of the Weavers and the Byre

That same winter, far to the south, the weavers of Baile chiar took a charter for their guild, and the council's clerks cut a new seal for them, a shuttle over a fleece, and entered the grant in a book bound in calf and kept under lock at Cathair dhearg. It cost the weavers a fee, a feast for the councillors who signed it, and three months of waiting while the seal-cutter finished a commission for the mint first. When it was done they had the right to call themselves a guild, to set their own prices at the fair, and to bar any weaver of Baile chiar who had not served the full seven years under a master of the craft. It is the kind of grant this book has recorded a dozen times already and will record a dozen times more: coin changes hands, a form is followed, a seal is cut, and a thing that was already being done becomes a thing the kingdom has agreed to notice.

At Doire ghlas, in the north, in the same season, a schoolmistress asked leave of no one at all.

Agnes Pike was four-and-thirty that winter, a miller's daughter of a family that had ground the north's grain at Doire mhin since before the Severance, though she herself had left the mill for a scribe's stool in the harbour agent's office at Ros

bheag as a girl, and had spent a dozen years since copying tallies of herring and salt by a window that let in more weather than light. She read well, in both tongues, having been taught her letters by a Mission woman old enough to remember the last ship, and she wrote a hand clean enough that the harbour agent had once offered to send her south to a copyist's house at Cathair dhearg, an offer she turned down without troubling to explain why. What she wanted, she told her sister that same year, over a supper of little more than oatmeal and the last of the autumn's apples, was a room of her own, with children in it who did not yet know how much the world meant to keep from them; a stool in a southern office held no such want for her.

She had been three years asking round Doire ghlas for such a room before she found one that would serve. The town had no hall to spare and no coin of its own to raise one, the Moot's letters on the matter having gone south and come back, as they generally did, with nothing on them but the mark of a clerk who had read them. Doire ghlas was by then the largest of the Tuathaich towns of that coast, a huddle of stone-and-turf roofs in a fold of the moor, its one street running from the mill-bridge to the Church and stopping there, as though the town had never quite decided what a street beyond a church was for. It had grown a good deal since the hungry year, when Walter Hale had walked meal in from Caol mhòr and helped bury the children the Dia-thìrich had never troubled to count; the names of that year's dead were still kept, pinned in the church porch, and more than one of the children who came to Agnes's byre that winter had an elder brother or sister among them, a fact none of the households spoke of and all of them knew.

In am Faoilleach a widow named Jenny Marrow, whose husband had kept cattle on the moor above the town until a wet spring took half his herd and the fever took the rest of him, offered her byre for the winter months, the beasts she had left being few enough now to stand a season crowded into the barn behind it. Jenny asked nothing for the loan beyond a promise that the children would be taught to write their names, hers among them, she being sixty that year and unable, she said plainly, to see any reason a woman ought to go to her grave signing a mark. The byre smelled of what a byre smells of, and the roof let in a persistent drip over the third row of benches that no amount of patching ever quite stopped, and Agnes took it gladly, for it had four walls, a floor that could be swept, and a door that shut.

11

Of the Fourteenth of am Faoilleach

The purse that paid for the benches, the slates, and the widow's rent came from Caol mhòr, carried the length of the coast road by Walter Hale himself, who by then had been speaker of the Moot for thirteen years and had grown, in that time, into the habit of carrying its business in his own saddlebag rather than trusting it to a rider who might not know which doors in a strange town were worth knocking on. He was eight-and-fifty that winter, greyer at the temple than the year before, and he made the ride in from Caol mhòr in weather his wife Ellen told him plainly he was too old to be riding in, an opinion he did not dispute and rode out in anyway. He found Agnes Pike sweeping straw from the byre floor the evening before it was to open, and set the purse down on the one bench already fixed to the wall, and told her, as near as the Moot's own minute records the exchange, that the sum was hers to spend as she saw fit and that no one at Caol mhòr expected an account of every penny, the Moot having decided, after some argument, that a schoolmistress who had to write down the cost of every slate was a schoolmistress with less time to teach.

"And the council?" Agnes asked him, not looking up from the broom.

"Received and filed," Hale said. It was, by then, a saying among them, the answer the council gave to nearly everything the north sent it, and he said it the way a man says a thing he has stopped being angry at and started merely repeating. "I did not ask again after the first no. A council that says no once will say no as often as you trouble it. This one," he nodded at the byre, "asked no one a second time."

She straightened then and looked at him, the broom still in her hand. "It is a byre with children in it, Walter, whatever else you call it."

"So was the first one at Caol mhòr," he said, "the winter after we came north, when the priest lent Ellen the church porch two hours a week to teach David and Alice their letters, before there was any Moot to call it a school or refuse to. It became one because enough children kept coming back to it that nobody could call it anything else." He looked round the byre, at the swept floor and the benches and the drip already starting again over the third row now that the evening's rain had begun. "Call it what you like. Open the door tomorrow and see who comes."

The school opened on 14 am Faoilleach, in the grey light before the moor mist had properly lifted, and eleven children came through the byre door before the bell of the Church, which Doire ghlais had lately taken to ringing for the hour

rather than for the office alone, had finished its seventh stroke. Agnes had for teaching them two books and nothing else: the Bible, in the humans' own tongue, which every household in the north kept a copy of whether or not any hand in the house could read it, and a bound volume of the Moot's own minutes, going back to the wet afternoon at Caol mhòr when the first of them was written, which Hale had lent her for the winter on the understanding that it came back to Caol mhòr in the spring in the same condition it left. There was no primer, no slate-book of letters set out in rows, because none had ever been printed for the humans' tongue on the island and none was coming; so the children of Doire ghlas learned their letters that winter from the twenty-third psalm and from old minutes recording a granary vote and a dispute over a shared boat, in roughly equal measure, and Agnes could never afterward say which of the two taught them faster.

The eleven who came that first morning ranged from a girl of five, brought by an elder cousin because there was nowhere else to leave her, to a boy of thirteen already promised to a carter and come only because the carter was laid up that week with a lame horse. Agnes set them by no order she had planned in advance, having never kept school before and having only her own dozen years at a copyist's desk to draw on for a method, and settled by the second week on putting the youngest nearest the one window, where the light lasted longest, and the eldest nearest the door, on the reasoning that a boy who might be called out to help with a cart at any hour should not have to climb over four benches to answer the call. Jenny herself came most mornings and sat at the very back with her own slate, forming her name letter by letter with a slowness the younger children found endlessly diverting and never once mocked her for, and by an Cèitean she had it whole, and stood it against the byre's one dry wall where the drip could not reach it, next to the psalms.

Hale did not stay to see the door open. He rode south again the same evening he delivered the purse, having, he told Agnes, a sitting of the Moot at Caol mhòr to be at two days later, and the Moot's own business, as ever, waiting on his saddlebag. But he left her, folded inside the cover of the minute-book, a single sheet in his own hand, headed only *For whoever asks*, setting out in four plain lines that the purse was the Moot's, the room was the widow's, and the leave, such as it was, was nobody's at all; and Agnes kept that sheet, long after the minute-book had gone back to Caol mhòr, pinned inside the register she began that same week, where it stayed for as long as the school did.

III

Of Daniel Frayne

Among the eleven who came through the door that first morning was a boy of ten named Daniel Frayne, walked in from Muileann leathan, a weaving town close enough across the moor that a child could make the distance on his own feet before the bell finished, provided he left before it began. His father worked a loom in a shed behind the house and had never in his life wanted more of letters than would let him read a bill of sale, and told his son plainly, the first evening Daniel came home smelling of the byre, that he saw no harm in it so long as the boy was back in time to help carry the cloth to the fuller's, a condition Daniel kept without fail for as long as the school ran, walking the moor road at first light with a slate under one arm and, on the wetter mornings, his mother's shawl over his head against a rain that came over the moor sideways more often than down.

He was not the quickest child on the benches that winter, nor the slowest; the psalm gave him trouble longer than it gave most, the reading of it, that is, for the words themselves swam a little on the page and would not always sit still for him in the order Agnes read them aloud. But he could copy. Set in front of him a line already written, in any hand, and he would render it back stroke for stroke with a care that made Agnes, watching over his shoulder one grey morning in an Gearran, stop what she was doing and look a second time, for the boy had taken a page of the Moot's minutes, a dry entry about a granary's repair, and copied it out exactly, the loop of every g, the cross of every t, as though his hand understood the shape of a word before his eyes had finished understanding its sense.

"You read that slower than you wrote it," she told him, not unkindly.

"I know what it's meant to look like," Daniel said, which was as near as he ever came, that winter or for some years after, to explaining the difference between the two things to anyone, including himself. Agnes set him, from that week, to copying out a second time whatever the class had read that day, a task the other children took as a punishment when it fell to them and Daniel took, visibly, as something closer to its opposite; by an Cèitean his fair copies of the day's psalm or the day's minute were pinned along the byre's one dry wall, less because they were needed there than because Agnes had run out of other ways to keep the drip off them.

The other children on his bench teased him for it, in the way children tease a boy who is glad to be given more of a chore than he was set, though not unkindly, and one of them, a carter's daughter named Effie who read faster than anyone in the byre and could not, by her own loud complaint, make a letter sit straight to save her life, took to trading him her reading of a hard line for his copying of an easy one, an arrangement Agnes noticed within the week and chose, after some thought, not to forbid, on the reasoning that a school with eleven children and one teacher would need more than one kind of teaching in it before the winter was out. Daniel's mother, when she heard of the arrangement from her son at supper, said only that it sounded a fair trade and asked whether the girl's family had meal to spare that week, which was, in a poor town in a lean season, very often the shape a compliment took.

He was not quick to speak of the school at all, in fact, being a boy who kept most things folded close, and it was his father, coming in from the loom-shed one evening with the lint still white on his sleeves, who first noticed that his son had begun, without being asked, to copy out the week's weaving into a little book of his own, tallying ells of grey against ells of brown in columns as neat as anything the byre wall carried, a habit that outlasted the schooling and that his father, who had never asked for it, came in time to rely on more than he ever quite admitted.

IV

Of the Maor Who Wrote Nothing

The maor of the shire, whose office required him to note anything new raised, built, or opened within it and send word south once a season, rode out to Doire ghlas in an t-Ògmhios, six months after the byre door first opened, having heard of the school by then from at least three different householders who mentioned it to him as though he must already know, the way a thing spoken of openly in a small town is assumed, wrongly, to have reached every ear that governs it. He was a heavy man, not unkind, who had held the shire eleven years and had learned in that time which of the things brought to his notice were worth troubling the council with and which were better left where they lay; and he stood in the byre door for the better part of an hour on a warm morning, watching eleven children, twelve by then, recite the fourth psalm in a ragged chorus while a woman he had never met before that day kept time with a stick against

the door-frame, and said, when Agnes at last came to speak with him, almost nothing at all.

Her name he asked, which he already knew, and how the room was heated in winter, and whether the children paid anything for their place on the bench, setting both answers down in a small book he carried for the purpose, in a hand Agnes could not read upside down and did not try very hard to. Of the council's leave he asked nothing, and she offered nothing of its want, each of them understanding, without either saying so, that the question and its answer would only make the report he was about to write a harder one to write briefly.

He had, in his eleven years in the office, sent south a great many reports of things newly built: a mill wheel, a patched bridge, a chapel roof reslated, each one entered under a heading the council's own forms already provided for it, so that a maor filling in his season's return needed only choose the right box and set down a number. There was no box on any form he had ever been given for a room where Tuathaich children were taught to read the humans' tongue in the hand of a woman the council had never licensed to teach anything at all, and he had turned the problem over more than once on the ride out from his own house, without arriving at anything he liked better than the plain fact that a report is a thing a man is asked for, and a silence is a thing nobody has yet thought to ask after. He was not a cruel man, and had spent eleven years learning precisely which small mercies a shire's maor could extend to a town without any of them ever reaching a page the council would read; this, he judged, watching the children file back to their benches as he turned his horse for the coast road, was one more.

He thanked her for her time, in the flat courteous way a man thanks a stranger for an hour he had not particularly wanted to spend, and rode south again before the noon meal, and the report he sent that season to Cathair dhearg, which the council's own chests still hold, records the shire's harvest, its head-due, the state of its one bridge, and nothing whatever about a byre at Doire ghlas with a school-mistress in it and children reciting psalms from a Moot's minute-book.

It was not, Agnes came to understand only much later, an oversight. A maor who wrote nothing of a thing he had seen with his own eyes had not forgotten it; he had decided, in the particular silence of a man who knows exactly how far his own office reaches and no further, that a school begun without leave was safest left where a council that had already said no once could not be provoked into saying no again, more loudly, to something it would then be obliged to close. She never learned whether that was kindness, caution, or simply a want of anything in

the maor's instructions that told him what box on his form a byre full of Tuathaich children ought to be entered under; and in the years that followed, as eight more such schools opened along the coast without one of them being licensed and not one of them being shut, she came to think it mattered rather less than the plain fact that the report went south blank on the one matter that would have mattered to her, and stayed blank, season after season, for as long as any maor of that shire held the office.

V

Of the Second School and the Minute Copied Fair

Word of the byre reached Caol mhòr before the spring was out, carried, as most things reached Caol mhòr, in the mouth of a carter, and Alice Hale, Walter and Ellen's daughter, nineteen that year and long since past the age when her father's household porch-lessons had served her, opened a second school within the month in a disused net-store behind the harbour, with six benches begged from the boat-builders and a purse a good deal smaller than the one her father had carried to Doire ghlais, the Moot's own funds having been thinner that season on account of a poor herring year. She wrote to Agnes asking what had answered best on the byre's cold mornings and what had not, and the two women kept up, through that year and after, a correspondence of practical questions (how many slates a class of a dozen truly needed, whether the psalms or the minutes taught the alphabet faster, what to do about a child who came to school hungry and could not be made to sit still on an empty stomach) that neither of them thought to call anything grander than letters between two women doing the same work at either end of the same coast.

Further south and inland that same season, though neither Agnes nor her scholars would hear of it for some years, the Board's surveyors closed a different kind of book on a different kind of report. The Cill ghlais district, shut to new shafts since the Rending had brought a gallery down there two generations before, was walked over that summer by Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin and the young chainman who carried his chain and his lamp, Iain mac Ruairidh, the two of them tracing the old fault line foot by foot with plumb and cord until they were satisfied it lay where the old surveys said it lay and had moved no further since. Their report, filed with the Board at Cathair dhearg, declared the ground safe to

work again, so long as any new shaft was cut a full chain back from the fault line, a condition the Board accepted without argument and the first new diggers observed, that season, to the letter. It is a small entry beside a byre full of children reciting psalms, and it belongs to a different part of this same age's long account of what was measured, and what was not, and by whom, and it is set here only because it happened, as near as the record can place it, in the same weeks that a maor rode home from Doire ghlais with a small book full of everything but the one thing he had seen.

Two reports, that season: one that named a fault line to the foot and was believed on its author's word alone, and one that named nothing at all, and was believed for the same reason. Neither surveyor at Cill ghlais ever heard of the byre at Doire ghlais, nor would have found anything in it to measure had they gone there, there being no fault line under a schoolroom that any chain could find; and Agnes Pike, for her part, never learned the surveyors' names at all. The record keeps the two of them apart because the Board kept them apart, filing the one at Cathair dhearg and never troubling to look north at all; it is only the Library, gathering both into one shelf at the age's end, that sets them side by side and lets a reader notice what neither man who wrote them was ever asked to notice himself.

Daniel Frayne finished that first winter's schooling in an t-Iuchar, the byre's benches given back to the widow Marrow's returning cattle for the summer months and the school moved, as it would move every summer after, into the porch of the Church, which offered shade enough and no drip at all. On the last morning before the move, Agnes set the class one final copying, the same task she had set them nearly every week since the psalm had first proved too slow a teacher on its own: the Moot's own minute of the day the school had opened, four lines long, recording that a room had been found at Doire ghlais, that eleven children had come to it, and that no leave had been asked because none had been thought likely to be given. Daniel copied it as he copied everything, stroke for stroke, the loops even, the lines straight along a ruled edge Agnes had learned to give him without being asked, and when he had done she took the page from him, read it through once, and pinned it into the front leaf of the school's own new register, the first thing entered there in a hand not her own, leaving the drying wall to the psalms.

"Why that one?" Daniel asked her, watching her pin it.

"Because it's the truest thing in the book," Agnes said, "and you wrote it best."

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Of the Seventeen Suits

SE 15 AN T-IUCHAR – SE 16 AN GIBLEAN

A law made exact is a law made for someone. I have never pretended otherwise, and I have not been asked to stop.

— Eilidh nic Leòid, at the inn of Ceann mhòr, the night of 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15

I

Of the Court in the Heat

Ceann mhòr in an t-Iuchar smelled of tar and low tide and the fish-yards behind the harbour wall, and by the second week of the month the smell had climbed the hill to the old magistrate's house and settled into every room of it, so that the clerk who kept the maor's rolls there had taken, that summer, to propping every window on the seaward side and weighting his papers with whatever came to hand, a stone, an inkpot, a boot. Eilidh nic Leòid arrived on the Tuesday of the assize week with Murchadh Clàrc riding a length behind her, as he had ridden behind her for seven years now, and found the house's largest room already too warm to sit in with the shutters closed and not warm enough, once they were open, to keep the flies out.

She was nine-and-fifty that summer, and had ridden her own circuit of the south-west eight times, but never the northern one, which the council had added to her charge that spring, and never in such heat. She said as much to Murchadh while the room was set, the long table carried in from the maor's own house and set crosswise under the window so the light fell across it rather than into her eyes, the bench for the suitors arranged along the far wall where the draught, such as

there was, would reach them first. "We will want water brought in through the morning," she told him, "and not wine, whatever the maor's clerk offers us by way of courtesy. A justice who drinks at her own bench in this heat will be asleep by the second cause and cross by the fifth." Murchadh, who had learned over seven years of riding behind her exactly which of her instructions wanted an answer and which wanted only a note taken, wrote it down and said nothing, and went to find the water himself rather than trust the maor's clerk to remember it.

The town's maor, a Dia-thìreach man named Griogair mac Ailein who had held Siorrachd Ceann mhòr for eleven years and lived, all that time, in the house the last human magistrate had kept, met her at the door with the courtesy due her office and a list of the assize's causes already fair-copied twice, and told her, walking her through to the room where the bench was set, that he had never in his eleven years seen so full a list brought before one sitting. "Nineteen causes," he said, "and of them seventeen the same kind of paper, near enough, that a man could read one and guess the shape of the rest before he opened it." He said it with the particular weariness of a man who had spent some years hoping the matter would settle on its own and had at last given up the hope, and Eilidh, taking the list from him and running her thumb down its length before she had even taken off her travelling cloak, told him only that she had come to read every one of the nineteen to its own end regardless of how much the rest resembled it, and that a paper's likeness to its neighbour was not, in her experience, a reason to read it any less carefully, whatever hope a busy maor might have of the opposite.

The room filled slowly through the Tuesday morning, the suitors of the first cases arriving early and standing about the yard in their best coats long before the bench was ready for them, the two Dia-thìreach households among the nineteen keeping somewhat apart from the seventeen Tuathaich ones by an old habit of the town that nobody troubled to explain and nobody, that morning, troubled to break. Among the second group, standing a little further back than the rest and dressed no better nor worse, Eilidh marked a grey-haired man in a coat cut in the humans' old fashion, a plain dark thing gone thin at the elbows, who carried no paper of his own and seemed, from the way the others near him spoke, to have come to watch rather than to plead. She did not know him by sight, and asked Murchadh, in a low word, whether he did. Murchadh did not either.

She opened the sitting a little after the noon bell, standing at the head of the long table with the window's light behind her and the room's heat already thick enough to see, faintly, in the air above the flagstones, and told the room, in the

plain unhurried voice Murchadh had heard open eleven assizes before this one, that she would hear every cause on the list to the end, that no cause would be taken out of its order for anyone's convenience, and that the room's heat was a fact she regretted and could do nothing about, and would ask everyone present to bear with equal patience. A woman near the back, whose own cause stood fourteenth on the list, was heard by more than one witness afterward to remark that a justice who apologised for the weather before she had heard a single cause was, whatever else came of the week, at least honest about what she could and could not mend, which the woman meant, by every account, as praise.

II

Of the Papers Brown at the Fold

The two Dia-thìreach causes went first, by the list's own order, and were settled within the hour, a boundary dispute between neighbouring farms that Eilidh resolved much as she had resolved the well-dispute at Muileann bhàn years before, by sending Murchadh out with a cord to measure the ground rather than trust either party's account of where an old wall had stood, and a debt case turning on a receipt that satisfied her within a quarter-hour of reading. Then came the seventeen, and the room, which had grown used through the morning to the ordinary rhythm of a small town's law, settled into a different and slower one.

Each of the seventeen came up to the bench carrying the same kind of paper, in substance if not in every particular: a title granted under the humans' own seal, in the humans' own hand, to a family that had worked the ground it named for one generation or two or three before the crossing closed, the ink long since gone the colour of weak tea and the folds worn soft and brown where the paper had been carried, folded and unfolded, from one generation's strongbox to the next. Eilidh read every one of the seventeen to its own end before she would hear a word spoken over it, turning each page toward the window's light when a line had faded past easy reading and asking, twice, for a magnifying glass Murchadh had thought to bring on a hunch rather than an instruction, and the suitors of the first several causes, expecting the swift hearing a busy assize usually gave a cause everyone in the room already knew the shape of, stood through the reading in a

silence that had, by the fourth or fifth title, taken on something of the character of held breath.

She read the Dunlop title first among the seventeen, a grant of four fields above the town dated in the human count to a year before Eilidh herself was born, and asked the family's eldest, a woman of perhaps forty standing straight-backed in a coat clearly kept for occasions such as this one, whether the ground had been worked continuously by her own people since the grant was made. It had, the woman said, by her grandfather and then her father and now by her own husband and sons, without a season's break that she knew of, and she had brought, though nobody had asked her to, a second paper, a receipt for seed corn bought the spring after the grant, in case the court should want proof the ground had been worked from the very first year and not merely claimed. Eilidh took the receipt, read it as carefully as she had read the title, and set both papers down together on the table before she gave her ruling, which came, as it had come at Seann Bhrál seven years before and would come sixteen times more before the week was out, in almost the words of her own earlier reasoning: that the humans' authority to grant land upon the island had ended with the humans' own leaving of it, and that the ground, in law, had passed with everything else the crossing left behind to the Crown that now held the island; but that the working of it, the right to plant and reap and pass to a child what a family's own hands had made fruitful, remained with those who had in fact done that working, on the same terms, in substance, as before, saving only that any due the Crown chose to lay on such ground in future would be laid on the Dunlops as on any other holder, and not excused them for the paper's age.

The room heard the same reasoning, in close to the same words, given over the Shaw title, the Bell title, the two Tullochs' adjoining strips that had once been one farm and were divided now between cousins who had not spoken to each other, by the account of the maor's clerk, in some years, and over nine more besides, each family's elder standing where the Dunlop woman had stood and hearing, in the end, that the ground was the Crown's and the working of it theirs, a form of words that satisfied, by Eilidh's own later account to Hale that same night, no one entirely and left, so far as she could tell from the faces before the bench, few of the fifteen actually surprised.

III

Of the Two Found for the Holders

It was the sixteenth of the seventeen, the Coombe title, that broke the pattern the room had by then settled into as firmly as the heat, and it broke it on a detail so small that Murchadh, reading the title over Eilidh's shoulder as she held it to the light, at first took it for a stain and not a mark at all.

In the margin of the Coombe grant, below the human magistrate's seal and dated some years after it, stood a second mark, a small pressed sigil Eilidh recognised before Murchadh did, having seen its like on older custody-books than any human title could carry: the countersign of a custodian, one of the old land-keeping houses that had held certain duties over the ground of the island since long before the humans came and had gone on, through all the years of the crossing, quietly witnessing such transfers of holding as came to their notice, without troubling to ask any human magistrate's leave to do it and without, so far as the record showed, being asked to stop. She asked the Coombes, an elderly man and his grown daughter who together made up the whole of the family now living, whether they knew what the mark was, and the old man said only that his own father had always called it the old blessing, and had told him once that a custodian had come to witness the grant because the ground touched, at one corner, a spring the custodian's own house had kept an interest in since before any human ever cut a title for it, and that his father had thought no more of the matter than a man thinks of a blessing said over a doorway, a thing done because it was always done and not because anyone expected it to matter.

Eilidh sat with the title a long while before she spoke again, turning it so the countersign caught the light at a different angle, and told the room, when she did speak, that the mark changed the ground she stood on to give her ruling, though not, she was careful to say, because a custodian's blessing carried any authority over Crown land that a justice's own bench was bound to defer to; it changed the ground because the mark was proof, of a kind no human seal alone could give her, that the grant had been witnessed and allowed, at the time it was made, by an office of the island's own older law, an office that had never answered to the humans and had gone on, unbroken, into the kingdom that now sat in judgment over its work. A title granted by human authority alone, she said, passed with that authority when the authority ended. A title witnessed also by an office of the island's own keeping, an office that had not ended and did not answer to the

Crown for the witnessing it had done, stood on ground the crossing's closing had never touched at all, and she would not now reach past that ground to take back what the Crown's own predecessor, in a manner of speaking, had already let stand.

She found for the Coombes entire, ground and working both, and the room's held breath broke, for the first time that week, into an audible sound, not quite a cheer, that she let run its short course before calling the next cause. The seventeenth suit, the Pettifer title, carried the same custodian's mark in nearly the same place, a witnessing some years later by a different hand of the same office, and Eilidh, having found her reasoning once, applied it a second time with rather less deliberation than the first, though she read the Pettifer title through as slowly as she had read every other, a suitor's paper being no less deserving of a full reading for coming sixteenth or seventeenth than for coming first.

Fifteen for the Crown, then, and two for the holders, and Griogair mac Ailein, watching from the back of the room where he had stood through the whole of the two days the seventeen had taken, said to Murchadh afterward, while the room emptied and the light through the west window had gone from white to gold, that he had sat under three magistrates and now two justices in his eleven years as maor and had never once seen a room learn, over the course of a single sitting, to stop guessing the ending before it came.

IV

Of the Witness Heard

The grey-haired man in the old-fashioned coat had stood at the back through the first fourteen of the seventeen without speaking, and it was over the Tulloch causes, the two cousins' adjoining strips, that Eilidh first called on him, having noticed, by the fourth day of the sitting, that he was consulted in a low voice by nearly every family before its own cause was called, in the manner of a man whose word on such matters the town trusted a good deal further than it trusted its own memory.

"You have no standing before this bench," she told him, when he came forward at her word, "and I will not hear you as counsel for either side. But I understand you have kept the Moot's own accounts of northern land for some years, and I will hear you as a witness to the facts, if the families before me have no ob-

jection to it." Neither cousin objected, both having in fact sent for him themselves before the sitting opened, and Walter Hale, standing where the bench's clerk pointed him and turning his old-fashioned hat once in his hands before he set it down, told the court, in the plain unornamented sentences Ellen had long since stopped expecting him to shorten, what the Moot's own day-books showed of the ground in question: that the original Tulloch grant had been one farm and not two, that the division between the cousins had been made by their fathers in the Moot's third year and recorded nowhere but in a Moot minute of that year, the Moot having kept, since its own first winter, a habit of writing down such family arrangements precisely because no other body troubled to, and that the minute, which he had brought with him, gave the boundary the two cousins were now disputing in terms plain enough that a surveyor's cord could settle the rest in an afternoon.

Eilidh took the minute, read it as she had read every title that week, and asked him one question only, which was whether the Moot's habit of recording such arrangements was a general one or a thing done only where a dispute was already foreseen. General, Hale told her; the Moot had begun writing down family divisions of land in its very first year, at Walter Hale's own suggestion though he did not say so himself, on the reasoning, as old as the Moot's first minute-book, that a people with no deeds of their own to a magistrate's satisfaction had better at least agree, in writing, among themselves, since no one else was likely to trouble to keep the peace of it for them.

She found for the cousins jointly, confirming the division the Moot's minute recorded and no other, and told the room, closing that cause, that a body with no authority the Crown recognised had nonetheless kept a better record of the ground in question than any office the Crown did recognise, and that she saw no reason a justice's bench should refuse a fact merely because the hand that had written it down held no seal. It was, by Griogair mac Ailein's later account, the only moment of the whole sitting at which the room seemed to him to hold its breath for a different reason than heat or suspense, a number of those present having spent some years assuming that a court of the Crown's own making would never trouble to notice, let alone credit, anything the Moot had ever written.

Hale did not speak again before the bench that week, the remaining causes needing no witness he could give, but he stayed through every one of them, standing at the back in the place the grey-haired man in the old coat had occupied since the first morning, and it was there, at the close of the last cause on the Friday, that

Eilidh, gathering her papers while Murchadh saw to the fair copies, found him still standing, and asked him, since he seemed in no hurry to leave, whether he would take supper with her at the inn before the road took him back to Caol mhòr.

V

Of the Inn at Ceann mhòr

The inn stood two streets back from the harbour, far enough from the fish-yards that the evening air, once the day's heat had begun at last to break, carried more of woodsmoke than of tar, and Eilidh took the table nearest the empty hearth, it being too warm a night for a fire but the quietest table in the room. Hale sat across from her with the particular stiffness of a man unused to being asked to a justice's own table, and it was some while, over bread and a dish of the harbour's own fish that neither of them had ordered by name and both ate readily, before either spoke of the week just past.

"Fifteen and two," Hale said at last, turning his cup a half-turn on the table without drinking from it. "I have heard the number said in the yard outside a dozen times since Tuesday, as though it were a kind of arithmetic a man could work out for himself given time enough. Fifteen for the Crown and two for the holders, and every family in that room knowing, before you opened your mouth on their own cause, near enough what the answer would be."

"They knew the shape of it," Eilidh said, "because I gave them the shape of it seven years ago, at Seann Bhràl, and have not since found cause to give them a different one. I do not think a family is owed a kinder ruling merely because the same ruling, given often enough, has begun to feel to them like a wall rather than a law. It is the same wall, whether they meet it the first time or the fifteenth."

"I know it," Hale said. "I have written it down myself, more than once, for the Moot's own book, in words a good deal less careful than yours. What I have never quite settled with myself is whether a law can be exact and just at once, when the two families it found in favour of won for a reason that had nothing to do with the land they'd worked or the years they'd worked it, and everything to do with a mark neither of them had troubled to notice on their own paper until a justice's eye found it for them. The Coombes did not earn that mark. Their grandfather happened to have a spring on his ground that a custodian's house had an old in-

terest in. Fifteen other families worked their ground exactly as hard, exactly as long, and had no such spring, and lost."

Eilidh set down her own cup and looked at him a long moment before she answered, in the manner Murchadh had come, over seven years, to recognise as the look she gave a question she judged worth a full answer rather than a short one. "You are asking me whether the law is fair," she said, "and I have never claimed that it is, only that it is exact, which is a different thing and, I have come to believe, the more useful one of the two to a people who must live under a law made, in the first place, for someone else's convenience and not their own. I did not write the Leòid ruling to be fair to the Tuathaich, Mr. Hale, whatever a fair reading of it may have done for two families out of seventeen by an accident of a spring and a custodian's old habit. I wrote it because a rule that changed from bench to bench, from year to year, from whichever justice happened to be riding through, was no rule at all, only eleven separate guesses in the same coat, and I judged, seven years ago, that even a hard exact rule, known in advance and held to without favour, was less cruel in the end than a kind one nobody could rely on from one assize to the next. I have not changed that judgment sitting in this room tonight, and I do not expect to change it before I die. But I will tell you what I have not told the maor, nor Murchadh, nor the council's own chests where my rulings are filed: I know exactly whom the rule was made for, and it was not made for the Coombes, nor the Pettifers, nor the fifteen who came before them. It was made to let a Crown that had just taken an island back from a people who could no longer defend it go on taking, in good order and without argument, what it had already decided to take. I made it exact so that the taking, at least, would be plainly seen for what it was, by anyone who cared to read a ruling closely enough to see it. Whether that is a kindness to the fifteen or only a kind of honesty that costs them exactly as much as a dishonest ruling would have, I have turned over more nights than this one, and I have not settled it yet, and I do not think I will."

Hale did not answer at once, turning his own cup a further half-turn, and when he spoke again it was to say only that he had not expected so plain an answer, and had asked, if he was honest, half hoping for a shorter and more comfortable one. "I did not come to Ceann mhòr for a comfortable answer," Eilidh said, "and I do not think you rode a day to hear one either, Mr. Hale, whatever you may have told your wife you were riding for." She allowed herself, for the first time that evening, something that Murchadh, had he been at the table, would have called nearly a smile, and added that the Moot's own habit of writing down

every family's arrangement in plain words, a habit she had heard tell of before that week and seen proved to her own satisfaction in the Tulloch cause, was the nearest thing to her own trade she had met with outside a bench in seven years of riding, and that she did not think it beneath a circuit justice to say so to the man who had begun the habit.

They spoke on a while longer, of lesser things, the state of the coast road north of Àth leathan and the price fish was fetching that season at the Ceann mhòr quay, and parted at the inn's door with the plain courtesy of two people who had said, between them, rather more than either had expected to say and neither found cause to be sorry for it. Hale rode north for Caol mhòr the next morning before the assize house was properly awake. Eilidh, with Murchadh and the satchel of fair copies behind her, rode south.

VI

Of the Road Home and the Book

The road from Ceann mhòr ran by Àth leathan, where the coast track from the harbour joined the old inland way, and Eilidh broke the first day's riding there, at an inn she had stopped at on her way north, remarking to Murchadh over supper that the innkeeper's memory for a justice's habits had grown, over the years, considerably more reliable than her own for the innkeeper's name. From Àth leathan she rode on by the western road to Seann Bhral, where the Leòid ruling itself had first been given seven years before at a bench she had not sat at since, and stood a while, before the light failed, at the harbour wall looking out at the water the ruling had, in its way, been made beside, though she said nothing to Murchadh of what she thought there, if she thought anything beyond the plain fact of having ridden her circuits nine summers now and being tired, that autumn, in a way the eight earlier summers had not left her. The way south from Seann Bhral was longer than either of the two stretches before it, and slower, the road turning inland for the better part of two days before it met the coast again above the fishing villages that fed Cathair dhomhain's own market, and it was on that inland stretch, riding through a country of low stone-walled fields she had ridden a dozen times before without troubling to remark on it, that she told Murchadh, more as a fact worth recording than as a complaint, that she did not think she would ride the Ceann mhòr road again the following summer,

whatever the council's rota said, a season's riding at nine-and-fifty being, she judged, a different arithmetic from a season's riding at one-and-fifty, however little the distance itself had changed between the two.

She reached Cathair dhomhain a little after the turning of the year, in am Faoilleach, and took to her own house on the harbour side of the town with a cough she told Murchadh was nothing worse than the road's dust and a season's riding, and for some weeks it seemed, even to Murchadh, to be exactly that. She kept up the fair copies of the Ceann mhòr rulings through the winter, sending one set to the council's chests at Cathair dhearg and a second, at her own instruction as always, to every maor's court of her circuit, with the note in her own hand that had gone out after every ruling of hers for seven years, that any cause brought on a like title should be decided on the like reasoning until the council itself said otherwise. That same winter she wrote a longer paper than any single ruling required, gathering into one book the whole of what she had held over nine years of riding, the Seann Bhral ruling first and the Ceann mhòr sitting last, with every lesser cause between them that had turned on the same ground, so that a justice coming after her, she told Murchadh while he copied the fair pages by the lamp, would not have to ride to Cathair dhearg and dig through nine years of the council's own chests to learn what she herself already knew by heart.

The cough did not lift with the turning of am Faoilleach into an Gearran, and by am Màrt she had taken, for the first time in Murchadh's seven years beside her, to keeping her bed past the morning, dictating the last pages of the gathered book to him from a chair by the window rather than sitting at her own table to write them. She did not speak, in those weeks, of being ill, only of the work still wanting finishing, and Murchadh, who had learned long since which of her silences asked to be pressed and which did not, did not press this one. The book was finished, in substance, by the middle of am Màrt, needing only its final binding, and Eilidh, hearing from the physician who attended her by then that the winter had settled somewhere in her chest that a summer's warmth might yet clear, told Murchadh plainly that she did not think she would see the clearing, and asked him to send word north, before the roads grew too soft for a rider, to Uilleam mac Leòid, her brother's son, a young man of six-and-twenty who had ridden with her twice as a boy and had, she told Murchadh, more patience for the northern circuit's particular slowness than any other of the family she could call to mind.

She died at Cathair dhomhain, 2 an Giblean, SE 16, in her own house within sound of the harbour she had grown up beside, with Murchadh at her bedside

and the finished book, still unbound, on the table beside her. She had not lived to be sixty.

The gathered book was bound within the month, in plain calf over boards, at the council's own expense and by the council's own binder, and given the name Eilidh had herself suggested to Murchadh in one of her last clear mornings, *Le-abhar nam Breith*¹, the plain word for what it held and nothing grander. Uilleam mac Leòid, named to the northern circuit before Bealltainn, rode north for his first assize with the book strapped, as the satchel of blank record-books had once been strapped, behind his own clerk's saddle rather than his, on the grounds, he told the young man riding beside him, that a justice ought to arrive at her first assize with clean hands, an instruction he had had, he said, from an aunt who never in her life explained a rule twice when the first explanation had been exact enough to serve. Every circuit justice who rode after him carried a copy of the same book, and the reasoning it set down, fifteen for the Crown and two for the holders and the whole long working that had brought her to that number, went on being read out, in courtroom after courtroom of the northern circuit, in words that were, for the most part, very nearly her own.

1. the book of rulings

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Of the Cellar at Muileann chaol

SE 16 AN CÈITEAN – SE 17 AN LÙNASTAL

A chur san Leabharlann. To put it in the Library. — the saying that grew up around Ailean Leabhar's cellar, within a few years of its opening

I

Of the Cellar Under the Stair

They lit the Bealltainn fires on the hills round Muileann chaol on the first day of an Cèitean in SE 16, as they were lit on every hill on the island that had a hill to light them on, and the smoke of the whole ring hung over the town from noon until the fires were let go down at dusk, so that a man walking in from the coast road that morning might have taken the haze for weather and thought no more of it. Ailean mac Iain took it for weather himself, riding in with two carts behind him and the council's minute-books roped down under oiled sacking against a rain that had not yet come and, by the smell of the sky, meant to. He had been the better part of a week on the road out of Cathair dhearg, the carts slow on the eastern stretches where the humans' old causeway had broken up into ruts deep enough to swallow a wheel, and he had spent most of that week turning over, without managing to settle it, the single sentence in which the council had told him what he was for.

The sentence, copied into his own book from the clerk who had read it to him, ran: *Ailean mac Iain is named keeper of the record at Muileann chaol, to re-*

ceive, to order, and to keep whatever is sent to him. It did not say what a keeper was, there being no such office before it and no one living who had held one, and it did not say what "whatever is sent" might in the end amount to. The council knew, at least, where its own records were not: not burned, so far as anyone could say, and not lost past finding. No one at Cathair dhearg could name the room any of them stood in, or say when a living hand had last opened one. Ailean had asked, before he left Cathair dhearg, what the town of Muileann chaol held that made it the place chosen, and had been told only that the custodians of the district had kept rolls there since before the Severance, in cellars under the old grain-stores, and that nobody at Cathair dhearg had gone to look at them in living memory. He took the answer as a piece of the council's habit rather than as information, the council's habit being, by sixteen years' watching, to send a thing north or west or wherever its own hands did not reach and call the sending a settlement.

The town gave him a house that had stood empty since a mercer's family died of a fever six winters before, two rooms and a loft over what had been a shop, and a boy of the town, thirteen that spring, whose mother kept the house next door and who had, in the way of a boy with nothing yet fixed to do, attached himself to the carts within an hour of their arrival on the plain grounds that they were the most interesting thing to have come up the road since the tax-rider's horse went lame outside the mill two winters back. His name was Coinneach Clàrc, son of a wright who had died in the war before the Severance and left his widow a trade in nothing but the boy's own two hands, which she hired out, that spring, for whatever a household could spare, mostly carrying and fetching. Ailean, unpacking the first cart in a light that was already going by the time he reached the third sack, told the boy he could fetch and carry for a keeper as easily as for a mercer's widow, and the boy, who had not until that hour known that a keeper was a thing a town could have, said he would, and was there the next morning before Ailean himself was dressed.

It was the townsmen, not the council's letter, who led him to the cellar. Two of them came the second evening, a maltster and a man who had held some half-remembered custodian's office under his father before him, and said, in the flat courteous way of men who have carried a thing a long time and are glad to be shot of the carrying, that there was more under the old grain-store than grain, and that it had been theirs to mind since before either of them was born, and that they had minded it as well as damp stone and a low door would let two men mind anything. They took him down a stair cut into the hillside, worn hollow in the

middle of each step by more feet than either of the two men now living had climbed it, and at the bottom, by the light of a single lamp one of them carried, Ailean saw what sixteen years of a kingdom too busy settling its own affairs to look backward had left of the record of everything that came before it: rolls and bound books stacked on planks laid across trestles above a floor that stood an inch deep in water after any rain heavier than a mist, the lowest tier on every stack gone soft, and in places gone to a grey pulp that held, when he touched it, the shape of a roll without any longer holding a roll's substance.

He untied the nearest and read three lines of it by the light thrown down the stair from the doorway above, standing because there was nowhere dry to sit, and then he sent the maltster's boy running for every lamp the house next door could spare, and sent Coinneach for a table, any table, and for a stool, and for whatever oil the town could sell him before its shops shut for the night. He did not go up again himself until the small hours, by which time he had four lamps burning on a borrowed table set on two trestles of its own above the wet floor, and had read, by his own later count, some forty rolls through to their ends without once finding one that told him plainly what it was, most of the custodians' own hands having written for readers who already knew.

II

Of the Long Reading

It took him years. The council's own minute-books came east from Cathair dhearg that same summer, four sacks of them roped onto the backs of pack-horses because no cart could be spared for so light and so unregarded a cargo, and behind them, more slowly, came the boxes Ailean himself had labelled and sealed in the humans' counting-houses fourteen years before, the tithe ledgers charred at their edges and written in a hand few south of the guard-line could any longer read without a Mission reader's schooling behind them, which Ailean, alone among the clerks who had boxed them, still had. He set the boy Coinneach to learning that hand within the first winter, on the plain reasoning that a keeper who read alone would die a keeper who had kept nothing for anyone after him, and by the second winter the boy could make out a tithe entry as fast as Ailean himself, faster in a bad light, his eyes being younger.

Their days, that first year and most of the second, ran the same small round with almost no variation to mark one from the next: down the worn stair before the town's own shops were open, lamps lit and trimmed, the wet floor swept as dry as a broom could make it, and then the reading, roll after roll set out on the borrowed table and read through to whatever end it had, the findings copied into a working book Ailean kept for nothing else and the roll returned, once read, to a shelf built dry above the water-line that the town's own carpenter had raised for him that first autumn on nothing more than Ailean's own promise to settle with him out of whatever the council next sent north. There were weeks together in which nothing was found worth remarking to anyone, a roll of tithes yielding tithes and no more, and Coinneach, young enough still to want a story out of every hour he gave to the work, asked more than once whether it was always to be like this. Ailean told him, more than once, that it mostly was, and that a keeper who wanted a story every day had mistaken his trade for a teller's.

What the cellar and the sacks between them held was, in the main, numbers: heads counted, grain weighed, dues paid or owed, births and deaths noted in the clipped hand of men keeping accounts rather than telling tales, and dates given in a reckoning that named no month and no season a reader south of the mountains would know at a glance, an old count that ran backward into the thousands for anything older than what the custodians called, without ever troubling to explain to whom, the sunwise turn. Ailean had disliked that count from the first roll he untied, and disliked it more with every year he spent inside it, and said so to Coinneach often enough that the boy could by the second year finish the complaint for him before he had got three words into it: that a people should not have to name every year of its own life after the day its kin went away over the water, as though nothing since had been worth a name of its own.

So he set the copyists he by then had, four of them by SE 16's end and seven by SE 17, to a plain and unglamorous labour that took the better part of two years to reach even the near edge of finished: every date the cellar or the sacks held, turned into the civil calendar the humans had themselves brought and the kingdom had kept since the Severance, month and day exact where the roll gave them exact, season and year alone where it gave no more, and set besides into the years of an age, by a table of the ages the copyists themselves were building as they went, out of the customary tellings of Clann na Ceiste¹ laid side by side against the king-lists

1. the Children of the Question

the custodians' rolls preserved better than any book south of the mountains had preserved them. It was in the laying of those two records side by side, in the second winter, that the reckoners under Ailean's own hand found what neither telling alone would have shown them: that very nearly half of the whole eldest age the copyists had inherited from the custodians' own reckoning lay within the span of one man's life, Ailean Mòr, crowned in the grove and king until he fell at the Ford of Blood, so long a life that no age built to hold ordinary lives could rightly be asked to hold his as well. Ailean set the matter before his copyists on an evening in an Dàmhair, and by consent of all seven the Age of Ailean was parted from the age that had held it and counted from then on as its own, the first change the Library at Muileann chaol made to any reckoning it had not itself invented, and, as Ailean noted drily in the margin of his own working copy, very possibly the last change it would ever be believed to have the standing to make.

It was in that same season, with the copyists' table only half drawn and the cellar not yet a third read, that a clerk of the town, sent up from Cathair dhearg with a query about a boundary the council wanted settled and unable, on being told the matter would want some weeks of reading before it could be answered honestly, to hide his impatience, used a phrase that neither he nor Ailean had heard used in quite that way before: that the boundary, once Ailean had looked into it, could simply be put in the Library, *a chur san Leabharlann*, and the matter would then be settled. Ailean, who had spent two years by then learning exactly how little of what the cellar held could honestly be called settled by anything, corrected him on the spot, more sharply than the clerk's small offence deserved, and the correction, repeated afterward by the clerk himself as a piece of local colour worth carrying home, was what first fixed the phrase in the town's mouth rather than loosening it: within a season half of Muileann chaol was saying *a chur san Leabharlann* of anything it wanted done with, and saying it, more often than not, precisely to see Ailean's face when he heard it. "The Library settles nothing," he told Coinneach more than once, usually with his hand still flat on some roll that had just refused, for the third or fourth time that week, to say plainly what had actually happened in the year it claimed to record. "It only keeps."

III

Of the Two Books

The finding that turned the first year of the reading came in an Gearran of SE 17, on a roll from the camp rolls of Àth ìseal that Ailean had set aside twice already as too far gone at its lower edge to be worth the candle it would cost to read by. He came back to it a third time only because Coinneach, going through the same stack in search of a grain tally the boy had been asked for by name, noticed a second hand in the margin, cramped and later than the roll's own body, and could not himself make out more than a name before he brought it to Ailean rather than lose the thread of it to guesswork.

The name was Cailean mac Eachainn's, and what he had written, in a margin that had survived the damp better than the roll's own text because it sat higher on the sheet, was a line of descent set down, so far as either Ailean or the boy could judge from the hand and the roll it rode on, some forty years before: the Line of Aisling, name following name in the plain unbroken form a custodian's clerk gives to a thing he expects no one to doubt and no one, until that winter, to read. Ailean had it copied fair within the week, in a hand steadier than the original's had by then become, and entered into a book he had begun the summer before and had not, until that entry, known quite what to call: a book that held nothing but lines of descent, names following names with their dates where dates could be had and without them where they could not, which he settled, after turning over three or four less plain titles with Coinneach on successive evenings, into *Leabhar nan Sloinnidhean*¹, the book of lines, and set Cailean mac Eachainn's find in it directly after another line, older still, that the cellar had already yielded that same winter: the Line of the Mason, as the custodians' rolls had taken it down long before from the recital of *Clann na Ceiste*².

But the camp rolls of Àth ìseal held more than lines. Set apart from the tallies and the descents, in a different ink and by what looked, from its unevenness, to be a hand writing by firelight rather than by day, the same custodian's clerk had also kept a record of what was said round the camp in the long years the roll otherwise measured only in grain and heads: the tale of the Hollow Man, told, by the clerk's own note, by an old woman of the camp who claimed to have had it from her grandmother; a telling of the white stag that differed in three particulars from the version Ailean himself had grown up on in the hills; a boast, set down word for word and plainly relished by whoever had written it down, that a captain of the camp had once made about a wolf and a winter and a door he had held alone.

1. the book of lines

2. the Children of the Question

None of it was a line of descent, and none of it, by any measure a custodian's own office would have applied to it, was business a roll ought to have carried at all; and it was that very unfitness, Ailean came to think within the week, that had let it survive at all, tucked in where no later hand thought to look for it and no later flood thought worth the reaching.

He began a second book for it that same season, this one without any argument at all over its name, for the thing wanted no name but the plain one: Le-abhar nan Aithrisean³, the book of tellings, and the long years of Ailean Mòr and his children went into it beside the Hollow Man and the white stag, exactly as the camp's own clerk had set them down, without correction and without comment.

It was Coinneach who asked him, copying the second entry out fair one evening by a lamp that wanted trimming, which of the two books was the true one, the lines or the tellings, since a boy who had spent a winter learning that a roll's numbers were to be trusted and its margins were not could be forgiven for wanting the question settled before he copied any further. Ailean thought about it longer than the boy expected, long enough that Coinneach had trimmed the lamp and sat back down before the answer came.

"Both," he said. "The one keeps names. The other keeps what people said." He looked at the two books a while longer, the one thin still and orderly, the other already thicker and less so, and added, in a voice Coinneach did not at the time think to write down and regretted for years after that he had not: "Neither of them keeps what happened. Nothing we do here will ever keep that. We only keep what was set down, and set down again, as carefully as two men and a lamp can manage it."

IV

Of the First Readers

Word that there was a Library to be read at, and not merely a cellar to be minded, spread up and down the coast roads slower than either man would have guessed, the notion of a place a man might go and be shown a record concerning his own trade or his own town being, for most who heard of it that first year, too far outside anything they had reason to expect of the

3. the book of tellings

kingdom's offices to be believed on a single telling. Ailean had opened the reading room, such as it was, to any who could show a letter from a shire maor vouching for their errand, on the plain grounds that a Library nobody could reach was no better kept than a cellar nobody could reach, and for the better part of a year the room he had set aside for it, a dry chamber above the old cellar with two tables and a window that at least let in more light than the stair had, stood empty of anyone but his own copyists.

The first name written in the book he kept for the purpose was a shipwright of Ros dhomhain, come the length of the coast road with a maor's letter creased soft from the carrying and a question that had, by his own account, kept him up more nights than the debt he had incurred to fund the asking of it: whether the humans, in whatever they had left behind them, had ever set down the true lines of a hull, the shape of the thing before it was built and not merely the finished boats a man could measure with his own eye and his own guesswork, which was, he said, standing in the doorway with his hat still in both hands as though the room might object to a covered head, most of what a shipwright of his own generation had ever had to work from. Ailean, who had boxed the humans' papers himself fourteen years before and drawn the shires on their surveys, had never in all that time had cause to open the crates of loose sheets marked, in his own hand, *unread*, and spent the better part of a week with the man going through sheets neither of them had ever seen unrolled, and found, folded inside a survey that had nothing else to do with ships at all, three drawings of a hull's ribs and planking that the shipwright copied out, over four days, onto his own paper with a care Ailean thought, watching him, came nearer to devotion than to any trade he had a name for. On the last of the four days the man asked, not looking up from his copying, whether the Library meant to keep a copy of his copy too, so that the next shipwright need not spend four days over it; Ailean said it would, and set aside a shelf for it there and then, the first shelf in the room he had built for anything but the record he had brought with him. The shipwright signed the reading-book in a hand that gave the letters of his own name more trouble than the hull-lines had, and walked back to Ros dhomhain, by his own account afterward, three days faster than he had come.

The bath-house at the warm springs below Muileann ruadh, built that same year by the Guild of Hewers out of its own funds for the men the pits had made sick with the dust, sent a fair copy of its first sick-roll to the Library unasked, in the autumn, a list of four hundred men set down by name and by the shift that

had broken them, with no letter of explanation beyond a note in the guild clerk's own hand that a record of who had been sick, and of which face of which pit, seemed to the guild's officers a thing worth having somewhere it would not be lost, whatever use the kingdom's own offices chose or failed to choose to make of it. Ailean entered it in a shelf of its own, unsure for some weeks what book it properly belonged in and settling at last, on Coinneach's own suggestion, that a roll which named no line of descent and told no old tale and yet meant, plainly, to be kept, had as much claim on the Library as either.

It was the guild's roll, more than the shipwright's question, that first showed Ailean what the room above the cellar might in time become, a room read not only by clerks sent on the council's own errands but by men and women who came, letter in hand, on errands the council had never thought to ask after, and who left, when they had found what they came for, entries of their own devising for a keeper too glad of the reading to turn any of them away.

V

Of the Five Lights

The last matter the Library took in hand that summer came to it from the council, by a warrant Ailean received in an Lùnastal and read twice before he was satisfied he had understood it rightly: the five lighthouses the humans had built round the island's coasts, kept until then by whatever hands the district happened to have to spare, were to be given keepers of the kingdom's own naming, Dia-thìreach men chosen and sworn, each bound by a warrant Ailean was asked to draft in a form the council could copy five times over without further trouble to its own clerks.

He drafted four of the warrants in an afternoon, each near enough the last that a clerk copying them side by side would have struggled to say, by sundown, which words belonged to which coast. The fifth gave him more trouble than the other four together, for the fifth light stood at Baile chrom, on the Tuathaich coast, and the man the council had chosen for it, a quiet Dia-thìreach who had kept lights before on the southern capes and asked for the northern posting himself, for reasons he gave the council as nothing more than a liking for a quieter coast than his last, would be a Dia-thìreach man living alone among a people whose speech he did not have and whose town watched him, by every account

Ailean had been able to gather, the way a fishing town watches any stranger the kingdom sends to stand over it.

Ailean wrote the warrant plainly, in the same clipped form the other four had taken, save for one clause he added on his own authority and did not ask the council to approve before the warrant was sealed and sent: that the keeper at Baile chrom should set down, in his season's returns, whatever he saw by land as well as whatever he saw by sea, whatever that might in time prove to be. He gave the clause no explanation in the warrant, and offered none when Coinneach, reading the fair copy before it went south for sealing, asked him plainly why a lighthouse keeper's business should reach past the tideline at all. "Because he will see things the shire's own maor will not think to ask him about," Ailean said, "and a Library that only ever hears what a maor thinks worth reporting will end its days knowing a good deal less than it might have."

The five warrants went out together at the season's turn, and the five lamps were lit within the month, the other four to no comment Ailean ever heard of, the fifth to a silence from Baile chrom that he took, that first autumn, for nothing more than a stranger settling quietly into a strange town.

He stood that evening at the window of the reading room above the cellar, the two books of the Library, the lines and the tellings, set closed on the table behind him and the guild's sick-roll beside them, and watched, though he could see none of the five lights themselves from Muileann chaol, the last of the season's light go off the hills where the Bealltainn fires had burned a year and more before. Coinneach, trimming the lamps for the night, asked him, as the boy had taken to asking most evenings by then, whether the day's reading had settled anything. Ailean did not answer at once. He thought of the cellar as he had first seen it, the lowest rolls gone soft as bread, and of the two books now standing where the cellar's ruin had once stood alone, and of a shipwright's four days over another man's plans, and of a fifth light burning that night over a coast that had never yet had reason to trust a light the kingdom sent it.

"No," he said at last. "But it's kept. That will have to do."

He blew out the last lamp himself, and left the boy to lock the door.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Of the Table of the Ages

SE 17 AN DÀMHAIR – SE 19 AN CÈITEAN

A record kept beside the throne is kept for the throne.

— Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, the chronicle's first entry, 19 an Dùbhlachd, SE 18

I

Of the Errand to Muileann chaol

The council sent Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill east in an Dàmhair of SE 17 for no better reason, so far as she was ever told, than that somebody had to go and see what the keeper at Muileann chaol had been doing with the year and more and the two cartloads of minute-books the council had given him, and that she was the under-clerk with the fewest causes on her own desk that month. She was four-and-forty that autumn, a council clerk's daughter who had herself clerked at Cathair dhearg for fifteen years without once being sent further than Cnoc ghorm, and she took the errand, by her own later account, as a week's dull riding and a report nobody above her would trouble to read past its first line.

She reached Muileann chaol on the fourth day, the road east of the mountain gone soft with an autumn's rain and the last stretch, past Tobar dhìreach, thick with the smell of wet paper before she had so much as seen the mill that made it. The town surprised her before she had dismounted: a place she had known on the council's own rolls as a huddle of a few hundred souls round a grain-store had grown, in the year and more since Ailean mac Iain rode in with his carts, a second

street of low workshops she had not been told to expect, awl and needle over one door for the binders, a quill over another for the copyists, and at the end of the street a yard she took at first for a fair-ground until a woman selling combs out of a basket told her, when she asked, that it was market day, the second since the charter came through, and that the yard belonged to the Library, which let it be used for nothing grander than a fee paid to the keeper's boy.

Ailean mac Iain met her at the Library's own door with ink on two fingers of his right hand and no apology for it, and took her account of her errand, to see and report and nothing more, with the particular patience of a man who had given the same tour to three lesser clerks already that year and expected to give it to a fourth before winter. "You will want to see the cellar first," he told her, "since it is the part every clerk from the capital asks after, and the part least worth the asking, being empty," and led her down the same stair he had gone down a year and a half before, the racks that had once held the district's soft and ruined rolls standing bare now and swept, the water that had stood on the floor drained off through a channel he had had cut that first summer. She asked him, on the stair, whether he missed the wet cellar he described in his own reports so often, and he said only that a keeper who missed a ruin had kept his post for the wrong reason, and said nothing further on the matter the whole three days she stayed.

He showed her next the two rooms above the cellar, where the custodians' rolls of every shire lay sorted by a system of his own devising, boxes lettered by district and shelved by a rule she asked him twice to explain and did not, by the time she left, wholly master either; he told her, when she said as much, that the system wanted no mastering by a visitor, only by the two boys who ran it daily, and that a clerk from the capital judging a keeper's order by whether she herself could work it was judging the wrong thing. She let the remark stand without argument, having by then spent enough of the first day in his company to judge that he answered every question either exactly or not at all, and that a third way of answering was not a thing he kept in stock.

He showed her, last, the room where seven copyists sat that afternoon at seven desks, each with a roll unrolled before him and a fresh sheet of the Tobar dhìreach paper beside it, turning the old dates the cellar had yielded into the calendar the humans had themselves brought to the island, a labour he described to her in four plain sentences: what the rolls held, what the calendar wanted, how a date given only by season and no more was marked as such rather than guessed at, and how long, by his own reckoning, the whole labour would take to finish. She wrote it

down in five, adding a line of her own about the room's quiet that he had not thought worth mentioning. He mentioned, in the same breath and no louder than the rest, that the seven had lately settled a question of reckoning among themselves that the council had never thought to ask: that the age at the root of every telling on the island held, within it, one life long enough to be counted apart, and that his copyists, by their own consent and nobody's order, had parted it that same season and begun to count it as its own, an evening's work the whole town had talked of for a week afterward and the council, so far as either of them ever heard, had not troubled to hear of at all. The keeper said it the way a man reports a roof mended, not a thing done, and Gormshuil, writing it into her own book that evening by a borrowed lamp in the room the town had found her over the mercer's old shop, found she had underlined it twice without quite deciding to, and sat a while longer than the hour wanted, turning the lamp's wick down and up again, before she blew it out.

A boy of fourteen or so, who told her his name was Coinneach Clàrc before she had thought to ask it, brought her water in the morning and asked, setting the jug down, whether the capital had sent her to take anything away with her, a question he put, she judged from his face, less out of insolence than out of a plain wish to know how much of his own morning's work might shortly be undone. She told him no, only to look and to write what she saw, and he seemed to weigh the answer for its truth a moment before he accepted it and went back to whatever he had been carrying before he stopped to ask.

II

Of the Report Nobody Above Her Would Read

Before she rode home she walked the market yard once more on her own, without Ailean beside her to name what she was looking at, and found it a smaller and plainer thing than the word market had led her to expect from a capital desk: some thirty stalls set up on trestles between the Library's own wall and the lane, most of them selling nothing grander than thread, nails, candles and the ordinary produce of a district feeding its own new mouths, and only a handful given over to the trade the town's second street had brought it, a binder selling off-cuts of calf too small for a cover, a copyist's wife selling quills her husband had trimmed and did not need. The stall-fee, a woman told her when she stopped to

ask it, was a penny a table and two on a fair-day, paid to the keeper's boy in a wooden box he carried on a strap, and the court of the fair, such as it was, amounted to the boy's own mother settling disputes over table-space in a voice loud enough to be heard the length of the yard, a form of justice Gormshuil noted down without comment, setting it beside her own knowledge of grander courts that took longer to settle less.

She wrote her report on the ride home and delivered it, as instructed, to the clerk of council who had sent her, a man named Uilleam mac Griogair who read the first page standing at his own desk, the second sitting, and the third not at all, telling her, when she pressed him on it, that a keeper's cellar and a keeper's calendar were matters for the keeper and not, in his experience, matters the council troubled to weigh twice in one generation. "You have written three pages," he said, setting the sheets down unweighted so that the draught from his own window began at once to lift the corner of the last, "where the council asked for one, and the one it asked for need only have said the cellar is dry and the man is sound." Gormshuil left the third page with him regardless, and a fair copy of it in her own hand besides, on the grounds, she told no one but her own book, that a thing worth writing was worth keeping whether or not the man it was written for meant to open it.

The town had by then, in the ordinary way of these things, already begun to settle what Ailean's cellar had made of it. The market charter Gormshuil had seen in its second week that autumn was no more than the council's usual form, a fee for every stall and a court to hear the fair's own disputes, granted after the district's maor wrote up, at the keeper's own asking, that a town which had drawn copyists, binders and paper-makers to it in a year and a half without any charter at all might as well be given one before the trade found its own rules instead. The mill at Tobar dhìreach, a few miles off along the stream, was being turned that autumn by a family of millers who, for want of grain enough to keep three wheels busy, meant to make paper instead, and the copyists already spoke of its first sheets, due the next year, as though they had them in hand. She had ridden out to see the mill herself on her second day, more from a clerk's habit of wanting to see the thing behind a claim than from any errand that required it, and had found it a low building of two wheels rather than the three the family had first raised money for, the third abandoned half-built when the grain trade that was meant to feed it never came back to the strength the millers had reckoned on; the miller's eldest daughter, showing her the new vats where the rags were to be pulped, told her

plainly that paper was the family's one hope against a debt that grain alone would bury them under, and that she for one hoped the Library's keeper never ran short of old rolls to copy, since it was his copying that kept her father's wheels turning at all. Within a year of the mill's first sheets, Ailean noted in a letter, near enough every sheet the Library used came from that one stream, and the council's stationers, so far as either of them ever heard, were not told why their trade had fallen off.

Gormshuil went back to her desk at Cathair dhearg that winter and to fourteen more months of the ordinary clerking that had filled the fifteen years before it, tallies and licences and the council's own minutes fair-copied twice over for a filing system she had never once been asked whether she thought sound, and told herself, when she thought of Muileann chaol at all, that she had seen a keeper's good order and a good cellar and nothing that need trouble her further. She kept, all the same, the fair copy of her own report in the bottom of her own chest rather than the council's files, a habit she could not afterward explain to her own satisfaction and did not, that winter, try very hard to.

III

Of the Office Made

The council came to its own decision in SE 18, and came to it, by every account Gormshuil was given afterward, for reasons nearer to the coin than to the calendar: a councillor disputing a boundary with his neighbour had sent to the keeper at Muileann chaol for a custodian's roll that settled it inside a fortnight, where the same question, put to the council's own files two years before, had gone unanswered for want of anyone able to say where the relevant paper was kept. The councillor said as much, more than once and to more than one hearing, in the tone of a man who had found a convenience rather than a lesson, and it was that plain tone, Gormshuil came to believe, that did more to move the council than any argument a keeper or a clerk might have made for the value of an ordered record on its own account. A record that could be asked a question and give back an answer was, the council found, worth more to it than one it could only add to, and in the second week of an t-Samhain it made an office to keep the kingdom's whole record as Ailean's Library had begun to keep the north's, and set the office at Muileann chaol rather than at the capital, on the plain ground that the keeper already there had shown he knew how the thing was done, a decision

reached, so Uilleam mac Griogair told her afterward without any evident shame in the telling, inside a single sitting and with less debate than the same council had lately given a dispute over a fair's stall-fees.

It named Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill to the office, on the strength of a report three men had read a page of between them and one clerk of council who remembered, when the matter came up, that she had gone to Muileann chaol once and come back with more to say than he had troubled to hear; it was Uilleam mac Griogair himself, by his own later admission, who named her, less from any judgement of her fitness for the work than from a wish to be rid of a clerk who had twice now handed him more paper than he cared to read. She was sworn in a small room at Cathair dhearg on the twentieth of an t-Samhain, four-and-forty still, before a clerk who read the warrant aloud in the same flat voice he read every warrant in, naming her royal chronicler of the kingdom and bidding her keep, in whatever form she judged fit, whatever the kingdom's affairs left behind them worth the keeping. She asked him, when he had finished, whether the warrant said anything of where the record was to be kept, and he told her, looking back down at the page as though the answer might yet be found there, that it did not, the council having spent its attention on the office's naming and its powers and having left the office's own seat, as it left most such questions, for whoever held it to settle for herself. The same warrant ordered that the kingdom's years should thereafter be counted by the ages the Library's own table now held rather than by the old count of the Diosal, six ages as the table then stood, and that her own first year should be entered as the eighteenth of the Severance Era, the first year so written in the kingdom's own record rather than borrowed from an older one; the clerk read that clause too in the same flat voice, and Gormshuil, listening, thought it a strange thing to hear her whole people's way of counting set aside in a single sentence read by a man who plainly did not think the sentence worth pausing over.

She walked back to her own lodging that evening turning the day's two facts over against each other, the office made and its seat left open, and found by the time she reached her own door that the second fact had already answered itself in her mind, whatever the council had meant by its silence. Her reply went out within the week, in a hand she took some trouble over, the letter's second page rewritten twice before she judged the wording exact enough to send: that she meant to keep the record at Muileann chaol, beside the Library that already held the rolls she would need and the copyists trained to the work, and, at its foot, the one line

of her own that she afterward let stand at the head of her first year's book, that a record kept beside the throne was kept for the throne, and that a kingdom wanting an honest one would do better to keep it somewhere the throne's own convenience did not reach. She showed the letter to no one before she sent it, on a plain reckoning, rather than any wish for secrecy, that a line worth writing was not, in her experience, a line improved by another clerk's opinion of it beforehand. No one at the council troubled to argue the point with her, whether from agreement or from the same weariness that had let her first report go three pages unread, and she took the silence, that winter, for consent, and moved her whole desk east before the roads closed, carrying with her four chests of her own papers, a clerk's stool she had sat at for sixteen years and saw no reason to leave behind, and a single letter of introduction to Ailean mac Iain that she judged, on the ride out, she need not have troubled to write, since the keeper had already shown her, a year before, exactly how much introducing he required.

IV

Of the First Circuit

She spent the winter before the circuit rode out in the plainer labour the office wanted before any clerk could be sent anywhere: a warrant drafted and copied six times over, one for each pair she meant to send, asking every parish, custodian and harbour-master on the island to open whatever books it kept and let a page of each be copied into the kingdom's own record, and asking nothing be given up that its own keeper wished to hold on to, a clause she added herself, over Ailean's mild objection that a clause inviting refusal was a strange thing for a chronicler to write into her own first warrant. "A clause that only invites what a keeper would do regardless costs the warrant nothing," she told him, "and a keeper who reads it will trust the rest of the page a good deal further for it," and left the clause standing when the six copies went out.

She sent her clerks in three pairs in the spring of SE 19, one south, one to the eastern shires nearer the mountain, and one north past Cnoc ghor to the Tuathaich coast, each pair carrying its own warrant and its own chest to fill. Among the six rode a clerk of three-and-thirty named Tormod mac Sheumais, called already, by the other copyists, Tormod Pinn for the speed of his own hand, a council under-clerk's son who had asked Gormshuil for the circuit himself

rather than wait to be sent, saying, when she asked him why, only that a man who copied other men's records all winter without once seeing where they came from was, in his own judgement, only half a clerk. She sent him north rather than south, on the reasoning she gave Ailean and no one else, that a clerk keen enough to ask for the harder half of the work deserved to be given it, and kept, of that first spring's riding, a private tally of his own that he showed no one for years afterward: the number of doors that opened to him without a second knock, against the number that did not.

The south filled its share within the season, its own habits of record already near enough to the kingdom's own that the asking cost the pair sent there little beyond the road's own length. Forty chests came up to Muileann chaol before an t-Iuchar was out, grave-lists and harbour rolls and parish registers from every shire between Cathair dhearg and the southern coast, and among them, copied whole into a book of its own because no clerk on the circuit could say what else to call it, the town arms of every town that had ever cut a seal for itself: five hundred and five of them by the time the last chest was opened, a hammer over a fleece, a shuttle over a flame, a hawk among crescents, set down side by side in an order that owed nothing to rank and everything to the order the chests themselves happened to arrive in. Coinneach Clàrc, set to the copying of that book himself, asked Gormshuil once whether she meant the arms sorted by shire before the book went to the binder, and she told him no, and told him why only once he pressed her a second time: that a record which tidied its own arrival too soon forgot, in a generation, that the arrival had ever been untidy at all, and that a reader coming after them both would learn more of the season's own haste from five hundred and five seals in the order they happened to reach her than from the same five hundred and five set out by rank as though the whole kingdom's making had been a tidy thing from the first.

The north filled one chest, and filled it slowly.

V

Of the Door at Doire ghlas

Tormod's own pair rode the northern circuit that same spring, up past Doire ghlas where Agnes Pike's schoolroom had by then taught its fifth winter of scholars, and were met at the mill agent's door, and at the mill,

and at the two chapels the town kept between them, by an answer near enough the same in every house: that the town's books, such as they were, belonged to the town, and that a clerk riding up from the south with a warrant in the kingdom's name was, whatever the warrant said about nothing being asked to be given up, not a man the town saw any profit in trusting with even a page of them. He read the clause about nothing being taken aloud at the mill agent's own counter, word for word as Gormshuil had drafted it, and the agent, a Tuathaich man some ten years settled in the post, heard him out to the end before he answered that a clause a warrant carried against its own asking was, in his own experience of warrants, worth exactly as much as the hand that had signed it chose to make it worth, and that he for one had no way of knowing, standing at his own counter, whether the hand behind this one meant to keep its word a year from now or merely to get a page copied today.

Tormod's tally that week ran to eleven doors closed against one opened, the one being that same mill ledger, and the agent let him copy it only after making him read the warrant through twice aloud in the street outside, in front of witnesses enough that no one afterward could say he had been tricked into it, and only after Tormod had agreed, on his own authority and without any leave from Gormshuil to give it, that the copy would carry the agent's own name beside it as the man who had chosen to show it, rather than stand in the record as a thing simply found. He wrote to Gormshuil that night, by a poor light in the room the town had grudged him, that the town's own silence was not, so far as he could judge, unkindness so much as memory: that a people who had watched the council take their savings once already in the coin it minted saw no reason to trust it with their parish books either, whatever form the asking came dressed in, and that he had, without waiting to ask her, promised the mill agent his own name kept beside the ledger's copy, a promise he hoped she would let stand even though no clause in her warrant had asked for it.

Gormshuil, reading his letter at her own desk at Muileann chaol some days later, wrote back that the promise would stand, and stand in whatever hand of hers the record wanted to make it plain the promise was kept and not merely made; and she added his own words about memory rather than unkindness to the same book she had begun with her own line about the throne, letting them stand there unaltered, on the ground that a chronicler who mended what her own clerks reported was no better than a council that only ever heard what it wished to. She wrote nothing beneath his words to soften them, and nothing to explain

to a later reader why a warrant so carefully worded against taking anything away should still have closed eleven of the town's twelve doors against it.

VI

Of the Chest from Inis bheag

The last of the circuit's letters that spring came from Inis bheag, in the island's north-east, where the two clerks sent there had been shown, by the keeper of the Seann Spioradan house that stood at the parish's heart, a book older than any the south's forty chests had yielded between them: a parish roll that named its own dead and its own harvests back past the coming of the humans, kept, the keeper told them, by his own house's keepers before him in an unbroken line he did not trouble to number for two clerks he had known a single afternoon. He was an old man by the clerks' own account, near enough as old as the Library's own cellar had been wet, and he heard the warrant read to him the once, without asking for it twice as the mill agent at Doire ghlas had, and answered only that he had kept the book, and his father before him, against exactly this asking, and saw no reason a kingdom's own warrant should change what forty years of quieter askings had not. He let it be copied, page by page, at his own table and under his own eye, correcting the younger clerk's hand once when a stroke ran the wrong way on a name he judged too old to be misread, and would not let the book itself be carried so much as to the harbour, telling her, when she asked why a book so old should not travel under a kingdom's own seal for its own better keeping, that a book kept in one house for that many generations belonged, whatever the kingdom's seal might say, to the house that had kept it and not to the seal, and that a seal, in his own long experience of them, kept a thing only for as long as the hand behind the seal found it convenient to.

Gormshuil read that clerk's own report of the exchange twice before she filed it, and found in the keeper's answer, though she wrote nothing of the thought into her own book, an echo of a house not far in kind from her own mother's, who had likewise counted her own dead by a reckoning older than the kingdom's and had likewise never once asked a council's leave to keep it.

The copy reached her at midsummer, and she read beside it, the same week, the north's own chest, brought up at last from Caol mhòr with the season's other returns and opened at her own table with Coinneach Clàrc standing by to lift out

whatever it held. It held, when she had gone through it to the bottom, the maor of Siorrachd Àth àrsaidh's own returns and nothing else: tallies of the head-due paid and unpaid, a list of the district's licensed boats, a note on a bridge wanting mending, every page in the maor's own hand or his clerk's, and not one line, in the whole chest, written by a Tuathaich hand or telling a Tuathaich fact that the maor himself had not already thought worth the kingdom's asking after.

She sat with the chest open before her a good while before she wrote anything of her own beside it, Coinneach waiting at the door for whatever instruction she meant to give him, and when she did write, it was neither the line about the throne, which she judged she had already said, nor a complaint against the maor, who had after all done exactly what his own office asked of him and no less. She wrote only that the chest from Àth àrsaidh held the maor's returns and nothing more, and left the sentence to stand by itself at the foot of the page, without the further word that would have told a later reader whether she thought the emptiness a fault in the north, a fault in the south's asking, or a plain fact neither side had yet found a way to mend. Then she closed the chest, told Coinneach to see it carried up to the shelf beside the forty, and went back to the letter Tormod had sent her from Doire ghlais, which she had not yet finished answering.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Of the Raiders' Bay

SE 19 AN T-SULTAIN – SE 20 AN LÙNASTAL

To the council at Cathair dhearg; we ask a second time for what we asked in the winter, being a boat with guns in it, or leave to arm our own. We have had no answer to the first asking. We do not think a third will find you any less occupied than the first two were. — Nell Barrow's second letter for Cathair gheal, carried south by the maor's own rider and read once

I

Of the Boats Lost off Cuan bheag

The storm that took Thomas Coyle came out of the west on the second night of an t-Sultain, in SE 19, with no more warning than a wind that had been rising since noon and a glass that the older men of Cuan bheag had been watching all afternoon with the particular silence of men who have seen a glass do this before and not liked what followed. Cuan bheag was a small place, a few miles up the coast from Caol mhòr, its harbour no more than a shingle beach and a stone jetty the humans had built and the town had never had cause nor coin to better, and its boats went out, as they had always gone out, in a fleet together, on the reasoning that a boat in trouble within sight of six others stood some chance of being seen. That night eleven men from seven of those boats did not come home, and among them was Thomas Coyle, a fisherman of Caol mhòr who had married into a Cuan bheag boat some years before and gone out of that harbour ever since, one-and-forty that year and married to Mary Coyle for near twenty of them.

Of the seven boats, the town could piece together only from what the sea gave back over the following week: two hulls, both broken, one oar with a name burned into the loom that nobody in Cuan bheag recognised and that turned out, when word of it reached Caol mhòr, to belong to a boat out of a village further north still. No lifeboat put out after them, because Cuan bheag had none, having never had the coin to build one nor, until that night, the occasion to feel the want of it as more than a thing other, richer harbours kept and it did not. The town buried what it had to bury within the week, in the Church's ground above the shingle, eleven stones cut in the same fortnight by the one mason Cuan bheag could call its own, working from first light to past dark on a debt no one had asked him to take on and that no one, afterward, offered to pay him for.

Mary Coyle heard of it at Caol mhòr two days after, from a carter who had it from a Cuan bheag man selling fish at the Caol mhòr quay and telling it, as such men do, to anyone who would stand still long enough to hear it told. She went up the coast road on foot that same afternoon, arriving after dark and finding no one at the harbour able to tell her more than what she already knew, which was that Thomas's boat had gone out and had not come back, and that of the six men who had crewed it only one had washed ashore, and it was not him. She stayed in Cuan bheag the better part of a fortnight, in a dead woman's spare room lent her by a neighbour, and helped where help was wanted, which was mostly in writing: the mason needed the names spelled correctly for his stones, and more than one of the widows could not write them herself and had never before had cause to see her husband's name set down anywhere but a boat's own gunwale, painted on by his own hand. Mary wrote all eleven out on a single sheet, in the order the boats had gone out in rather than the order the sea had given the men back, because that, she told the mason when he asked why, was the order in which they had last stood together, and it seemed to her the truer one.

Word of the wreck reached the Moot's house at Caol mhòr within the week, carried this time by the same carter, and Walter Hale, who was that year two-and-sixty and had been speaker of the Moot for seventeen of them, called a meeting of the Moot's own council on a Tuesday evening and put the matter to them plainly: Cuan bheag had no lifeboat, no village on that stretch of the coast had one, and the sea did not appear to be growing gentler with the years. The Moot voted, that same evening, to open a subscription for a lifeboat to be kept at Cuan bheag and worked by whichever crew of the town's own men would take the training for it, and Hale himself opened the list with five coins of the realm out of

his own purse, entered in his own hand at the top of a sheet that by the month's end carried close on two hundred names, fishermen and farmers and the weavers of Doire ghlas alike, each giving what a poor coast could spare, which for most households was not much and for some was a day's wage entire.

The Moot's letter asking the council to bear half the cost went south with the same carter who had carried its letters south for years, and came back, four months later, with the council's answer written under the Moot's own question in a clerk's hand: that the council would meet a third of the sum, the matter having been considered by the twelve and the sum thought fair against what other calls on the treasury the year had brought. Hale read the answer aloud to the Moot without comment and without complaint, both having by then, as he told Ellen that evening, worn themselves out on lesser matters than this one, and the Moot made up the remaining sum from its own subscription list and a further asking that same winter, so that by am Màrt a boat had been ordered from the yard at Cuan shean, built to a plan the yard already had in hand for the humans' own harbour service, and paid for in full before its keel was ever laid.

The boat came up the coast under her own sail in an Cèitean, a squat white-painted thing with cork lashed along both gunwales in the humans' own fashion, and was put into the water off Cuan bheag's own jetty on a fair morning before most of the town, the mason among them, his eleven stones long since set and weathering. No priest of either the Church or the old Dia-thìreach faiths troubled to bless her, there being no agreed form for blessing a thing neither faith had built before, and the town settled the question by having the five widows of that autumn's wreck, Mary Coyle among them for the day though she had by then gone back to Caol mhòr, walk her down the shingle together and see her set afloat, on the reasoning, which nobody afterward disputed, that if any hands on that coast had earned the right to launch her it was theirs.

II

Of the Thing off the Cape

Up the same north-western coast, past Cathair gheal and beyond it, lay a headland the fishermen called, among themselves, the cold cape, for the wind that came off it every month of the year but two, and below it a huddle of summer bothies kept by the fishermen of Achadh àrsaidh, a village of

the middle country far to the south whose men had gone north each season, time out of mind, to fish waters that few other boats troubled, the ground there being poor and the currents ill-tempered, and they had, in consequence, told among themselves for longer than any living man could number, a tale of a thing that swam those same waters: a creature longer than any boat that had ever gone looking for it, seen always at a distance and never at the same distance twice, that some named the Sea-Watcher and some would not name at all, holding that a thing was less likely to trouble you if you had not troubled to give it a name of its own.

That autumn the tale was told, as it had been told before, to a chronicler who happened to be at the bothies on other business entirely. Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, the kingdom's own royal chronicler not two years and six-and-forty that season, was on her way back south from the same circuit that had carried her clerks and their forty chests out of the southern shires that spring, and had stopped a night at the bothies below the cold cape because the tide would not serve to carry her further that day. The bothies had shown her, when she asked, no parish book worth the copying and no grave-roll older than the last flood, and she had all but given up hope of the visit's earning its own night's lodging when an old fisherman of the place, who had fished the cold cape's waters the whole of his life and lost a brother to them, offered, over the one fire the house could spare a stranger, to tell her a tale instead, on the plain grounds that a chronicler ought to want tales as much as she wanted rolls, whatever her office called the difference between them.

He told it at some length, and with the particular pleasure of a man who has told a good tale many times and knows exactly where its pauses fall best: the shape seen always at a distance and never at the same distance twice, longer than any boat that had gone looking for it, that some in the village named the Sea-Watcher and some would not name at all, holding that a thing troubled you the less for not being given a name of its own. Gormshuil asked him, when he had done, how many men of the bothies had seen it with their own eyes, and he answered, without any offence at the question, that he did not know a man alive who had, only men who had known men who had, which was, he added, exactly how the tale had come to him and exactly how he expected it to go on from him; and at that, almost as an afterthought, he told her something else, that the flagless ships which had worked those waters some years now, the ones no honest boat cared to meet, seemed to know the cold cape's currents better than any stranger crew had a right to, and kept, he thought, some hidden anchorage among the rocks below it that no Dia-thìreach chart had ever marked.

Gormshuil wrote both things down that same night, in the same entry, the tale of the creature and the fisherman's word on the raiders together, and sat some while afterward deciding whether the two belonged in one book or two. She had by then kept the chronicle long enough to have settled, mostly, what its business was and was not: it was not her office, she had decided, to say whether a creature thirty feet long swam those waters or did not, only to say that a fisherman out of Achadh àrsaidh had told her so, on such a night, in such words, in the book that kept what people said. The raiders' anchorage she judged a different matter, being a thing a sailing master might use rather than a tale a fireside kept, and she wrote it a second time, separately, with a note that the council's own coastal watch be told of it, though she held out small hope, from what she had seen of the coastal watch's dealings with that coast already, that the telling would move it to do anything the coast had not already had to do for its own people. She sealed both pages before she slept, and rode south the next morning with the tide, carrying, among the parish books she had not been given, the one tale she had.

III

Of the Flocks Counted and the Two Requests

Out past the cold cape, in the open sea to the west, lay Eilean dhubh, greatest of the outer isles, a place of grass and wind and more sheep than people, that the council's head-due had never yet been able to count with any confidence, no royal clerk having troubled, before that year, to cross to it in person. One was sent that same autumn, a young clerk new to the treasury's service and not greatly pleased at the crossing, which the islanders warned him would be rough and which was rougher than warned, the boat that carried him standing three hours off the landing before the sea would let it in at all. He found, once ashore and his stomach settled enough to speak, that the islanders had no more wish than he did to have a stranger stand about their pastures counting beasts that were not his to count, and offered instead to count the flocks themselves, by their own tally-sticks, which every household on the island kept notched to its own count and none had ever had reason to falsify against a due nobody from the south had come to collect in living memory, and hand him the sum entire, sworn to before the island's own headman. The clerk, who had crossed a bad strait to do a count he had no great appetite for doing twice, and

who could see, besides, no way to check eleven hundred sheep across four townlands inside the fortnight the crossing allowed him, took the offer gladly, wrote the sworn sum into his own book exactly as given, and sailed home on the next fair tide grateful to be asked no more of it. The dues that year, and every year after, were set upon the island's own count, given once and never afterward disputed by either side, each having got, in its own way, exactly what it wanted of the arrangement: the council a figure it could enter in its books, and Eilean dhubh a treasury that troubled it, at most, once in a generation.

It was into that same autumn and the winter that followed it that the two requests went south from Cathair gheal, a walled town on that same stretch of coast, its harbour a shallow bay below the town wall that the flagless ships had by then worked for the better part of six years without any hand from the south troubling to move against them. Nell Barrow, a skipper's widow of the town some two-and-thirty years old that winter, had taken it upon herself, in the way of a woman with time on her hands and a grievance she did not care to sit on, to write the town's case out in full and carry it to the maor's own door for his seal and his rider. She had lost her husband to no raider, his boat having gone down in ordinary weather some years before this tale begins, but she had lost, in the six years since the flagless ships first came, a nephew taken off a boat within sight of the harbour mouth and never seen again, and the town's patience, along with her own, had by then worn thin enough that she no longer troubled to soften her letters for a council she did not expect to answer them gently in any case.

The first letter went south in am Faoilleach of SE 20, asking plainly for a boat armed and crewed at the council's expense, or failing that a licence for the town to arm and crew its own, the town having neither guns nor law to carry them and wanting, in Nell Barrow's own words, one or the other before it wanted anything else the council might think fit to send it. The maor read it over twice before he sealed it, and told her, not unkindly, that a request framed so plainly was as likely to be filed unread as answered, letters that gave a clerk no soft phrase to copy back being, in his experience, letters a clerk found easiest simply to set aside. Nell Barrow answered that she had written a good many soft letters in her time and had a drawer at home to show for it, every one of them answered in the same soft coin it was written in, which was to say not answered at all, and that she would try the plain kind once before she troubled to write a third of either.

No answer came within the two months she gave it, and in am Màrt she wrote the second letter, the one that has come down whole, the maor having kept a fair

copy of it in his own office before sending the original on, on the reasoning, he told Nell Barrow plainly, that a letter written in that temper might not survive its own journey south undamaged by whatever hand first read it. It asked the same thing the first had asked, in fewer words, and ended, as she had written it, with the line that the maor copied out exactly and that has been kept ever since: that the town did not think a third asking would find the council any less occupied than the first two had. No answer came to the second letter either, that spring or after.

IV

Of the Bay Cleared

The flagless ships came into Cathair gheal's bay in force on the night of 8 an Giblean in SE 20, three hulls where the town had grown used to seeing one or two at most, standing off the harbour mouth at dusk in a manner that gave every fisherman on the wall no doubt at all of what the night meant to bring. Nell Barrow was at the harbour when the watch first called it, having taken, since the second letter went unanswered, to walking the wall most evenings on the plain grounds that a thing seen early was a thing met on better terms than a thing met in the dark unlooked-for, and she sent a boy running through every street of the town for any man who owned a boat and anything that could be swung: a gaff, a gutting-knife, an old sword some grandfather's grandfather had carried off a battlefield two ages gone and that had hung over a hearth ever since doing nothing more warlike than gathering soot. She herself took down, from its nail beside her own door, the boat-hook her husband had carried the whole of his working life and that she had not touched since the day it came home without him, and found, hefting it in the dark of her own passage, that her hand still knew its balance better than it knew any weapon the town could have found her in its place.

What followed that night has been told in Cathair gheal more times than any single telling could now untangle from the rest, but the plain bones of it, as the maor's own report set them down within the fortnight, ran thus. Seven boats put out from the town before midnight, crewed by whatever hands could be found and armed with whatever the town could put in them, the tide low enough that every man among them knew the bay's own shallows better than any stranger crew ever could, raiders included. The larger of the three raider hulls, a black-

sided ship the fishermen had for years called by a name of their own that the maor's report does not give, stood in closer than her own master judged the water, meaning to land a boat's crew on the quay itself, and ran her keel onto a bar that had shifted, that same winter, further out than any chart still above water on that coast had troubled to mark; and there she sat, fast and listing, while the two lesser hulls stood off in the dark uncertain whether to come to her or leave her.

The seven town boats closed on her before she could work herself free, coming in low and quiet with their oars muffled in sacking, as fishermen of that coast had muffled oars against a shy shoal since before any of them could say how the trick was first learned, and the fight, when it came, was closer and shorter and less orderly than any account of it afterward quite managed to make it sound: men going hand to hand along a listing deck in the dark, by lantern-light where a lantern held and by none where it did not, with gaffs and gutting-knives and, in one case that the maor's report set down without further comment, an old battlefield sword swung by a miller's son who had never before that night held anything sharper than a scythe. It cost the town two men dead outright and four more hurt before the black hull was cleared, one of the four losing the use of a hand he did not afterward recover; but by the time the black ship burned to her waterline, fired by her own boarders once her hold was found to hold nothing worth the saving, the two lesser hulls had already stood out for open water rather than come to a fight that plainly was not going as their own master had reckoned it would, and neither was seen off that coast again that year. Nell Barrow came back to the harbour wall at first light with a burn along one forearm, taken from a fallen lantern rather than from any blade, that she carried the mark of for the rest of her life, and told the town, before she would trouble to have it looked at, that the bay was clear; and clear, for that season and the two that followed it, it stayed.

V

Of the Fine Paid

The council's answer to the night's work reached Cathair gheal before an Cèitean was out, and it was not the answer the town had spent six years asking for. The maor's report of the fight, forwarded south along with Nell Barrow's account of it and a plain list of the dead, came back with a ruling attached that the town of Cathair gheal had borne arms without the council's li-

cence, contrary to the old rule that no Tuathaich town might arm its own boats without leave first asked and first given, and that the town was fined four purses of the realm-coin, to be paid at the maor's own office before the year's dues fell due. No word came, in the same letter or any after it, of a boat sent, a licence granted, or a guard set upon a bay that had needed one for six years and had at last, at some cost, made its own; the ruling's four lines named the offence and the sum and nothing besides, in the same hand and on the same kind of sheet, the maor afterward remarked to no one in particular, that had once fined a Ros bheag boat-builder for launching a hull a foot over its licensed beam.

Word of the fine reached Caol mhòr before an t-Iuchar was a week old, carried, as most such word was, by a Cuan bheag man selling fish at the quay who had it in turn from a carter out of the north, and Walter Hale, hearing it read aloud at the Moot's own table, said nothing for the length of time it took the clerk to finish reading and then asked only how much the town still lacked. It lacked, by the maor's own reckoning, some two-thirds of the sum, Cathair gheal being a poor town and its harbour trade thin that summer on account of the very raiders it had just driven off, the fish that had not been taken in six bad years being fish that brought in no coin toward a fine for taking them back. Hale carried the difference north himself within the fortnight, out of the same purse the Moot kept for such calls on it and that had, that year, rather less slack in it than he would have liked, the lifeboat at Cuan bheag having already taken more of it than the subscription alone had raised.

He came to Cathair gheal on a wet morning near the end of an t-Iuchar and found Nell Barrow, her forearm healed to a scar she did not trouble to hide, already at the maor's door before him with what the town itself had managed to scrape together, so that between her sum and his the fine was paid in full that same morning, coin by coin, in front of the maor's own clerk, who wrote the amount received in his ledger and said nothing at all about the six years, the two letters, or the boat the town had not been sent. Hale asked the clerk, as he watched the coins counted, whether the council's own ledger carried any line for what the bay had cost the town before that night as well as what it had cost the council after it, and the clerk, a decent enough man doing an office he had not chosen, answered only that his ledger carried what he was given to enter and no more, which Hale allowed was very likely true and no fault of the clerk's own making. The town, he said as he pocketed the last receipt, had already kept its

own ledger of that cost, in stone and in scar, and needed no clerk to enter it a second time.

Far to the south that same season, at Cathair mhòr, the house of Mac Ùisdein raised a market cross at its own cost, cut on all four faces with the house's own name, and moved the town's wool and coal markets to stand at its foot, where they have stood ever since. The council's minute on the matter, when it was read at Caol mhòr in an Lùnastal along with the news of Cathair gheal's fine now settled, ran a good deal longer than the minute on the fine had, and named the sum the house of Mac Ùisdein had given a generous one. Mary Coyle, who had by then been back at Caol mhòr the better part of a year and had taken, since the wreck, to sitting at the harbour wall most evenings where she could see the boats come in, heard the two minutes read one after the other at the Moot's own table and said only that it seemed the council knew a great deal about crosses, and rather less about lifeboats, before she went back to counting the boats home.

PART FOUR

OF Fair, Crown and Survey

CHAPTER NINETEEN

OF the FAIR at Muileann òs

SE 21 AN CÈITEAN – SE 22 AN LÙNASTAL

A' chiad fhèill, agus a' chiad riaghailt. The first fair, and the first rule.

— entered in Oighrig nic Mhathain's own hand, at the head of the fair's book

I

Of the Bell at Caol leathan

There had been a house of the Stone at Caol leathan since before any clerk now living could put a first date to it, a low stone hall behind the harbour with the western Seann Skell's own scorpion nowhere on it and nothing of the state's arms either, only the Stone's own mark cut plain over the door: a thing older, the priests there said, than either. In SE 21 the house was built up anew at the order's own cost, a low tower raised over its western gable and a bell hung in it that had been cast, the priests said, from coin given by every ship that had ever put in at Caol leathan's small harbour and come home again. It was not a large bell, nor one that could be heard much past the town's own walls, but Caol leathan was a small place and did not need much heard past its walls: the bell rang the hours from that year on, and the market opened by it, and the two courts the town kept, the harbour court and the fair court, sat by it, and within a year nobody in Caol leathan troubled any longer to ask a neighbour the time, only whether the bell had gone yet.

The Library, setting the fact down some years after, had little more to say of it than that: a bell raised, a tower built, a town's day set by it where no day had been set by anything but the tide before. It was the kind of fact that filled a line in a chronicler's book and no more. The fair that opened that same autumn some twenty-odd miles to the east took its hours from no bell at all, only from the voice of the woman who kept it.

II

Of Oighrig, Market Clerk of Dùn chrom

Oighrig nic Mhathain was one-and-thirty that year, and had kept the weighing-scales of Dùn chrom's own small market for nine of them, a walled town of some size on the road east out of Cathair dhearg, its citadel old and its market square older, where three days in five she sat behind a table with a set of the council's own weights before her and told carters and hucksters, in a voice that had by then long since stopped troubling to be gentle about it, what their sacks and their barrels actually held against what they claimed for them. She had come to the work at two-and-twenty, a widow's daughter with a head for figures and no dowry worth a better match, and had made of a post that most who held it did indifferently into one that Dùn chrom's own maor had come, in nine years, to trust further than he trusted most of his own clerks: she caught short weight that better-paid men missed, and she wrote her findings down in a hand plain enough that a magistrate could read it without asking her to stand and explain it twice.

It was for that plainness, more than for anything else she had done, that the council's own factor for the eastern shires came to her table one market day in an Cèitean of SE 21 and asked whether she would take a harder post than weighing sacks: the state had resolved, on the maor's own asking and the merchants' louder one, to hold a fair each year at the ford by Muileann òg, the old meeting-place where the Stone King Raghnaill Ceannfhionn was said to have traded salt for wool with the holder of the Red Hill in an age no living clerk could put a year to, and it wanted someone to keep it who could weigh a sack, read a scale, and write a rule down so plainly that a carter three shires off could understand it without a clerk to read it to him. Oighrig asked what the post paid and was told, and asked what it answered to and was told that, and asked, last, what happened to whoever held

it if the fair went wrong in its first year, and was told, honestly enough, that nobody yet knew, there having been no fair of this size held anywhere on the island since before the Severance for anyone to learn the answer from. She took the post anyway, on the reasoning she gave her mother that evening, that a woman who had spent nine years catching other people's short weight might as well spend the next few finding out what her own came to. Her mother, who had raised her alone on a widow's small pension and a stall of dried fish in the same market square, heard the whole of it out before she said anything, and then said only that Oighrig had better learn to write faster than she wrote now, if a whole fair's dues were to go through the one hand of her rather than through the several that a town's market usually spread its weighing among. It was, Oighrig thought afterward, the only piece of advice her mother ever gave her that she found herself, years on, still following to the letter.

She told the maor the following morning, before she told the council's own factor she would take the post, on the grounds that Dùn chrom's market had gone nine years without a bad weight under her table and deserved to hear from her own mouth, rather than from a rider's, that it was about to go without her altogether. The maor heard her out, said he had half expected it since the factor first asked after her at the spring assize, and asked only who she meant to leave behind her that he could trust to catch what she had caught. A niece of her own, a quick-handed girl of seventeen who had stood at her elbow two summers running, was the name she gave him, and the maor, who had learned in nine years to take Oighrig's word on a scale without asking to see the proof of it, took her word on the niece the same way and never afterward had cause to regret it.

She rode west to Muileann òg within the fortnight, a town of some few dozen souls and no more, its only distinction the ford and the old meeting-stone beside it, and found there a field, a track worn into it by generations of carts that had never yet had a fair to carry to, and nothing else that a state building a fair from nothing could be said to have given her: no hall, no scales but the ones she brought herself, no clerk but her own hand. She spent the summer walking the ground with a length of cord and a stick, and marked where the stalls would stand, where the beasts would be penned apart from the cloth and the grain, where the road from Cathair dhearg would need widening before the first cart came down it heavier than the track had ever carried, and where, at the field's one corner nearest the ford, a court could sit under a roof if the state saw fit to build her one before autumn. It did, in the end, though later than she asked for it and

smaller than she had marked out, a plain roofed frame open on three sides that the carpenters of Dùn chrom finished in the last week of an t-Sultain, a fortnight before the day set for the fair to open.

III

Of the Rules Written in Her Own Hand

The council's word came to her at the end of that same summer, carried by the same factor who had first found her at her table, in the form of instructions rather than a rule already made: that the fair, once opened, should draw its dues in coin and not in kind, that it should have its own court to settle what quarrels a gathering that size would bring rather than send every dispute back to a maor's bench three days' ride off, and that Tuathaich goods, of whatever kind, should be sold at the fair only through Dia-thìreach factors licensed for the purpose, the council having judged, the letter said, that a trade so new was better kept for its first years inside hands the state already answered for. It did not tell her how to write the rule, only that it was to stand, and left her, as such letters generally did, the whole of the wording and none of the deciding.

She sat with it three evenings in the roofed frame at the field's corner, by a rush-light, before she set a word of it down, and what she wrote in the end she wrote plainly, in the same hand she had used nine years for catching short weight, on the grounds that a rule nobody could misread was worth more than a rule dressed finer: a stall-fee of one penny in the realm-coin for every ell of frontage taken, paid at the setting-up and not after; a court of the fair, *Cùirt na Fèille*¹ as she headed the page that opened its own book, to sit each day of the gathering under her own roof, to hear any quarrel of weight, price or theft between traders and settle it there rather than send it south; and, last, that goods brought by a Tuathaich seller to the fair were to be entered at a factor's stall and sold under the factor's own name, the seller taking his price from the factor and not from the buyer direct. She wrote that third clause last of the three, and read it over twice before she let it stand, knowing, as she told nobody at the time but wrote once, years after, in a letter to her own niece, exactly what it would mean for the first northern cart that tried to sell past it: that the fair she had marked out with a length of cord in

1. the court of the fair

an empty field would, from its very first year, be a place where a Tuathaich seller's goods passed through another man's hand before they passed through the buyer's, and where the difference between the two prices went into a purse that was never the seller's own.

The council's licences went out to four merchant houses of the eastern shires before the harvest was in, each given the right to stand a factor's stall at Muileann òg and take goods of the north to sell under its own name for a share of the price, the houses chosen, so far as Oighrig could tell from the letter that named them, more for the coin they had already put toward the fair's road than for any particular fitness to the trade. She entered the four names in her own book on the same page as the rule itself, under a heading she gave it without being asked to give it one: *Bàillidbean na Fèille*², the fair's factors, a name that has stood in every year's book since.

The eldest of the four, a wool merchant of Cathair mhòr named Ruairidh mac Aonghais who had put more of his own coin toward the widening of the fair's road than any of the other three, rode out to Muileann òg himself in an t-Iuchar to look over the ground before his stall went up, and found Oighrig still marking out the field with her cord and stick. He asked her, civilly enough, whether the third clause of her rule was hers or the council's, having heard, he said, two different accounts of its authorship from two different clerks at Cathair dhearg. She told him it was both, the council's in its substance and hers in its wording, and he allowed, looking out over the empty field where his own stall would stand come autumn, that a rule's wording mattered a good deal less to the men who profited by it than to the men who did not, and that she would find, in his experience of licensed trades, that the two kinds of men rarely agreed on which the wording had been kind to. He was not wrong, and Oighrig, who had already guessed as much three evenings running by rush-light, told him only that she had written it to be read the same way by both kinds of men, which was the most a rule could honestly promise to do.

IV

Of the First Fair

2. the factors of the fair

The fair opened on 16 an Dàmhair in SE 21, a bright cold morning with the frost still on the field's grass when the first carts came down the widened road from Cathair dhearg, and by noon Oighrig's court had heard its first case, a small one, a dispute over a barrel of salt fish claimed short by the buyer and full by the seller, which she settled inside the hour by the simple expedient of having both men stand by while she weighed it herself against her own scales, the seller's claim proving the truer of the two. Only those who had stood in the crowd that watched it would ever remember the case itself. It was the first the court of the fair had heard, and Oighrig wrote it into her book in the same plain hand as everything else, on the grounds, she told the clerk who asked her why she troubled with so small a thing, that a court's first case set the pattern for every one after it whether anybody remembered the case itself or not.

A harder case came the third day, a Cathair mhòr coal-carter who swore a Sloc Mòr merchant had sold him spoil dressed to pass for good coal, the two being near enough alike to a buyer's eye by lamplight and near enough different on a smith's hearth by morning that the carter had driven the better part of two days back to the fair rather than swallow the loss. Oighrig had no smith's forge under her own roof to settle it by, and settled it instead by sending both men, and the load itself, to the one smith Muileann òg's own handful of houses could produce, an old man who had shod carthorses there the whole of his life and had never before been asked to judge a stranger's coal, and who told her, an hour later, that the load was three parts good stone to one part spoil, no more and no less. She fined the merchant the value of the one part and let the rest of the sale stand, and wrote into her book that a smith's eye, where the fair kept none of its own, would serve the court as well as any clerk's scale until the state saw fit to send her one.

The fair kept, besides its cases, a noise and a smell that Oighrig's own book had no line to hold: woodsmoke and wet wool and the coal carts' own black dust settling over everything by the second week, pipers from Baile chiar playing for coin at the field's far corner, and under it all the low constant argument of buying and selling in half a dozen shires' worth of accents, which she came, in that first fortnight, to find she could stand in the middle of and pick apart into its separate threads the way she had once picked apart a barrel's true weight from a seller's claimed one, a skill she had not known she had until the fair gave her cause to use it.

Trade came that first year from every province the state held, wool from the western shires and the Sloc Mòr's coal from the east and cloth from Baile chiar's

looms and salt from the coastal pans, more of everything in one field than Oighrig had seen gathered anywhere in nine years of market days, and she spent the fortnight the fair ran on her feet from before light to past dark, settling weights, hearing cases, and writing, each evening by the same rush-light, the day's dues into a book that by the fair's last day ran to more pages than she had thought to bring. It was, by every measure the council troubled to ask her for afterward, a success beyond what anyone attached to it that first autumn had thought to hope: the dues gathered came to more than the fair's own building had cost, the court settled every case brought to it inside the fortnight without once sending one south, and the four factors' stalls did the trade the council had licensed them to do, buying wool and cloth and salt fish off northern carts at a price the factors set and selling it on, under their own names, for a price the factors set again.

V

Of David Hale's Wool

It was on the ninth day of that first fair, by Oighrig's own count in her book, that a cart came down the Cathair dhearg road from the north rather than from any of the state's own provinces, driven by a young man of perhaps eight-and-twenty who gave his name, when her clerk asked it at the gate, as David Hale of Caol mhòr, and his load as wool, four sacks of it, off his own father's sheep and the sheep of two neighbours besides, brought the better part of a week's journey on the reasoning, he told the gate clerk plainly enough, that a fair drawing trade from every province the state held ought to draw trade from the Moot's provinces too, there having been no word sent north, so far as the Moot's own minute-book showed, that it should not.

Oighrig came to the gate herself when the clerk sent for her, having by then learned, in nine days, that a case worth her own eye was worth fetching her for rather than settling wrong by a clerk who did not know the rule as she had written it, and found a cart of good wool and a driver who had clearly never before had cause to read a licence, there having been none to read at Caol mhòr's own small market where he had sold his father's wool his whole life without one. She read him the third clause of her own rule from her own book, in the same plain hand she had written it in, and told him, as plainly as the rule itself was written, that the wool could enter the fair only at a factor's stall, under the factor's name,

at whatever price the factor judged to give for it. David Hale asked, reasonably enough, where the difference went between what the factor gave him and what the factor got for it after, and Oighrig, who had asked herself the same question three evenings running by rush-light before she ever wrote the clause down, told him the truth of it rather than soften it, that the difference went to the factor and to the state's own licence upon him, and that this was the rule as the council had sent it to her to write, not as she would have written it unasked.

He stood some while at the gate with his cart behind him, four sacks of wool that had cost him a week's journey and would now cost him, besides, whatever the nearest factor judged fair to take off the top of it, and asked her, last, whether she had written the rule herself. She told him she had, in her own hand, on the council's instruction and her own wording both, and that she saw no profit in telling him otherwise. Oddly enough he thanked her for that much plainness at least, turned his cart to the factor's stall she pointed him toward without further argument, and sold his wool there for a price the factor set, a price David Hale judged, by his own reckoning that evening and the reckoning he carried home to Caol mhòr after, some fifth part short of what the same wool would have brought sold direct at any market the Moot's own provinces kept. He did not come to the fair again that autumn, nor the next, though the lesson of that turning at the gate stayed with him a good deal longer than the fifth part he lost by it, and it was some years before another cart came down from the Moot's provinces to try the gate a second time.

He carried the wool's price home to Caol mhòr inside the fortnight, and told his father what the gate had cost him before he told him anything else of the fair, laying the fifth part's difference out on the table between them in coin the way a clerk lays out a reckoning he expects to be asked to justify. Walter Hale, who had by then sat the Moot's chair the better part of twenty years and had read a good many licences in that time without ever once finding one written by the hand that had to answer for it afterward, asked David only one thing more than the sum itself: whether the woman who had turned him from the gate had seemed, in the turning, glad of the rule or sorry for it. David thought a while before he answered, and said at last that she had seemed neither, only plain about it, which his father allowed, turning the coin over once in his own hand, was very likely the truest answer a rule's own writer could give a man it had just cost a fifth part of his summer's wool, and worth remembering the next time the Moot sat down to write a letter about her rule rather than about her.

VI

Of the Road, the Wall, and the Rule Read Aloud

The winter that followed brought the fair's road its finishing, the last stretch of it metalled past Dùn chrom in am Faoilleach of SE 22, the carters' own name for the new road already settled before the state ever gave it one of its own, Rathad na Fèille, the fair's road, though the carters who used it hardest had, by then, another name for the toll taken at Dùn chrom's own gate to pay for it, a name Oighrig heard once, passing through on her way east, and did not trouble to write down. The toll built, over that same winter, a new wall along the town's southern side, the wall the townsfolk called the fair's wall and the carters called by their own name for the gate that took the toll for it, and by an Lùnastal of SE 22 the wall stood finished, the first stone of Dùn chrom's own that the fair, rather than the state or the custodians before it, had paid to raise.

The Moot's letter reached Cathair dhearg some time in that same winter, carried, as its letters generally were, by a carter who had it from Walter Hale's own hand, and it named the factor rule plainly for what the Moot judged it to be: a state licence laid across a trade the north had carried on unaided since before the Severance, and a fifth part of every northern sack's worth handed, by that licence, to men who had done nothing to the wool but stand between the grower and the buyer with the council's own paper in their hand. It asked, as such letters generally asked, that the rule be looked at again. The council's answer, when it came, came slowly and said little: that the rule stood as licensed, that the fair's first year had shown it workable, and that the matter, having been considered, would not be reconsidered inside the year. The letter was filed at Cathair dhearg in the same box as the Moot's earlier letters, on the same shelf, in the same clerk's hand.

Oighrig herself never saw the Moot's letter, the council having no cause to send a toll-mistress a complaint written against a rule she had only been asked to word, and she learned of it, when she learned of it at all, from the same clerk who brought her the council's confirmation that spring, a young man not long in the office who mentioned it in passing, as one piece of the winter's business among several, and seemed faintly surprised that she troubled to ask him what the letter had said rather than merely that one had come. She asked him to read her the line about the fifth part twice over, and wrote it down afterward in her own book beside the rule itself, on a page she kept for nothing else, a habit her own clerks took,

in the years that followed, for simple thoroughness and never once thought to ask her the reason for.

Oighrig heard of the council's answer at the fair's second opening, on the same field, by the ford, in an Dàmhair of SE 22, though her own chapter of the matter had already closed some months before that, in an Lùnastal, when the council's clerk who carried its confirmation to her read the whole of her own rule aloud before the assembled factors and the gathered maoir of the eastern shires, word for word as she had written it the autumn before by rush-light, stall-fee and court and the third clause together, and asked her, when he had done, whether the reading matched her own book. She told him it did, word for word, and watched the four factors nod at a rule they had had no hand in writing and every profit in keeping, and thought, though she did not say it aloud to the clerk or to anyone else that day, that a thing read aloud in the same words it was written in did not thereby become any less her own doing for the reading, whoever else's coin the reading was meant to serve.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Of the Way Niall Came

SE 22 AN LÙNASTAL – SE 23 AN LÙNASTAL

Mar a thàinig Niall. The way Niall came.

— entered once, and once only, in the hand of Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, chronicler

I

Of the Bells at Cathair dhearg

Word of it came out along the east road a day and a night after it happened, riding in the mouth of a maor's courier who had changed horses twice and slept once, on the floor of a tavern, in his boots. By the time it reached Muileann chaol the bells at Cathair dhearg had already been ringing since dawn, and would ring, in relays, until the following dusk.

That much the Library set down without difficulty: that Niall died and Brìghde was crowned on 31 an Lùnastal, SE 22; that the bells of Òrd Mhacha¹ were rung a full day and a night for his death; that the streets about the old counting-house filled with a crowd larger than any the capital had seen since his own crowning; that the crowd was quiet, and stayed quiet, and went home before the second night; that within the week his daughter stood where he had stood, and the same rite that had made him king was said over her by the same order, and no voice in the crowd or the council was raised against it. Those were the facts, and the Library has never had more of them to give. What was said in the death-chamber, if anything was said, and by whom, went with the people who heard it, and

1. the order of Macha

none of them left an account that reached Muileann chaol. The chronicle does not guess at what it was never told.

For that first day the capital kept no market. No order shut the stalls round the old counting-house; nobody could be found willing to be the trader who cried his wares under a tolling bell, and by noon the empty stalls had become, without anyone declaring it, the custom of the day. Ships in the harbour struck their colours to half the mast, a habit some said the humans had left behind them and others said the island had always had, and the argument over which was true outlasted the mourning by a fair margin. Children were kept from the streets near the tower, since the noise of the bells at close range could be heard for days after in a small skull, and every mother in Cathair dhearg who had one seemed to know it.

The council of twelve sat within the week, as its minute-book shows it always sat, on its fixed day, and the first business entered that day is a dispute over a weir on the Abhainn iséal that had run three sessions already and would run two more before it was settled. Between that entry and the one before it there is no blank page, no space left for the weight of what had happened, only the ordinary hand of the clerk who kept the book that year, going on to the next line as he had been taught to. A visitor turning the pages now might read past the crowning and never know a kingdom had changed hands in the gap, unless he thought to look for the single line, two entries down, noting that the council's oath of service had been sworn afresh before the new sovereign, in the same room, on the same afternoon as the weir.

The bells themselves were an old debt paid. They had hung in the tower of Òrd Mhacha since before the Severance, cast by hands nobody now living could name, and they had rung four times in seventy years: once for Niall's own crowning, twice for storms taken as omens that came to nothing, and now this. A boy set to work the smaller of the two, relieved every two hours by another boy, kept a tally chalked on the tower wall of how many times his arms had pulled the rope, and rubbed it out when his watch ended, so that no count of it survives, and the Library has none to give.

At Brìghde's crowning the market crosses of the south carried the proclamation within three days, in the same words that had carried Niall's twenty years before, with only the name changed and the year. A clerk at Ros dhomhain, copying it out for the harbour gate, wrote Niall's name by habit before he caught himself, scored it through with two strokes, and wrote Brìghde's above the line. The cor-

rected copy hangs at Ros dhomhain yet, under glass, kept there mostly because nobody afterward could be troubled to have it taken down.

Of the new queen herself the record gives, for this year, only what any record gives of any crowning: the rite kept, the regalia carried out of Òrd Mhacha's keeping and back into it, the crowd that watched and dispersed. No word of hers survives from that week, and none was sought. The state she inherited went on being governed by the same twelve families and the same maoir the day after as the day before, gathering the same head-due by the same reckoning, and if anything in the machinery of the kingdom so much as paused to notice that the hand on the lever had changed, no minute of any council records it.

II

Of the Word Gormshuil Let In

At Muileann chaol the chronicler kept a small room above the Library's reading-hall, with one window that looked down into the yard where the copyists sunned their vellum, and a table too narrow for the papers she put on it. She had held the office four years by then, and had written, in that time, several hundred entries in a hand her own clerks had learned to copy well enough that visitors could not always tell which lines were hers.

The office kept to a small routine that had grown up around her without much planning: two clerks besides Tormod, a copyist shared with the reading-hall below, and a courier's box nailed to the outer door for anything that came while she was at the Library proper, sorting the boxed rolls that still arrived, a decade on, from shires that had only just got round to clearing an old counting-house or a dead magistrate's chest. Most days the work was of that kind, patient and small: a grave-list from Doire shean copied fair, a parish register cross-checked against the humans' own numbering, a maor's return of the year's head-due entered against the last five years' and the difference noted without comment. The crowning, when word of it reached her desk between a grave-list and a return, looked like nothing larger than the rest of that morning's post, and she had learned, in four years of the office, to give it no more room on the page than its facts required and no less.

She wrote the crowning three times before she let any version of it stand.

The first draft said that the throne passed from father to daughter without incident, which was true and said nothing. The second said that no one contested the succession, though many in the country's temples counted years by lives that did not shorten as other lives did, and this she struck through before the ink had properly taken, because it was also true and said a good deal too much, and she was not the chronicler who would be the one to say it first. The third draft she left half a page long and unfinished, because in trying to explain why the thing seemed both ordinary and strange at once she had begun, without meaning to, to write an argument, and a chronicle is not an argument.

She sat with the three failed pages spread on the narrow table and the courier's letter weighted under an ink-stone, and thought, not for the first time, that words for what had happened came easily enough. What was hard was choosing, among the true things that could be said, which one the kingdom's grandchildren would be permitted to know had been thought at all.

It was her clerk, Tormod mac Sheumais, four years now at her side, who gave her the way out, without knowing he had done it. He came up with a fair copy of an unrelated entry for her to check, glanced at the crossed-out drafts on the table without meaning to read them, and said, by way of nothing, that the taverns of Cathair dhearg, where he had grown up, had a phrase for anything that went off without a quarrel: *the way Niall came*. He had heard it against a debt his father paid without an argument, and again against a marriage nobody in either family had opposed, and thought it a tavern saying, no more, the kind that gets into every account book in a town within a generation of one clean transaction and means nothing very much by the time it does.

Gormshuil sat with that a long moment.

It sat oddly with the chronicle's language, a line out of a debtor's ledger dressed as history. Turning it over, she saw it was also the only true thing in any of the four drafts on her table: a plain report of how smoothly the crowning had gone, in the very words the kingdom had already coined to say so. She had thought, for a long moment, that she would be inventing a judgment. She was, she decided, only recording one that had already been made, in taverns and market squares, by people with no office and no ink-stone, long before she sat down to write her own version of it.

She wrote it in, four words, and did not strike it out.

The succession came mar a thàinig Niall, she wrote, and the record notes no voice against it.

She looked at the sentence for some time afterward, the pen dry in her hand, weighing whether a phrase let in once could be kept from becoming a habit. Other offices had lost their plainness that way: an ornament allowed for one entry because it fit so well, then reached for again the next time something needed saying gently, until the whole record read like a poem trying to be a ledger. Sitting there, she resolved to let herself the one line and no other, for as long as the office was hers, and she kept that resolve to the end of her years at the desk, though nothing outside her own conscience would ever have held her to it. It is, in the whole span of her chronicle, the only idiom she ever entered.

Tormod himself never knew, until she told him years later over a different matter entirely, that the phrase he had offered in passing, meaning nothing by it, had gone into the kingdom's own record of its own history. When she did tell him he asked, reasonably, why she had not simply said so at the time, and she answered that a chronicler thanking her clerk for a turn of phrase in front of him was a chronicler inviting a second turn of phrase the following week, and a third after that, and she had seen offices ruined by less. He took the answer as the kind of thing she said, and went back to his copying, and the matter was not raised between them again.

Her mother, when she heard of it on a visit to her mother's village by Ceann àrsaidh that autumn, laughed longer than Gormshuil thought the thing deserved, and said that her daughter had spent four years learning to write like nobody in particular so that she could, in the end, write like everybody. Gormshuil said this was not quite fair, that she had chosen the one phrase precisely because it belonged to no one, having passed through every debtor's ledger and wedding contract in the south until nobody living could say who had coined it. Her mother said that was a fine distinction to draw over four words, and asked whether the same care went into every entry or only the ones that made a queen of somebody's daughter. Gormshuil said the care was the same throughout, and that this was rather the point of keeping a chronicle at all. Her mother said it was fair enough, and poured the tea, and the two of them sat some while in the kind of silence that did not need filling, of the sort that only happens between a mother and a daughter who have already said most of what needs saying, over many years, and found no cause to disagree twice about the same thing.

III

Of the Hall at Seann Dunn

East along the coast, past the last of the shires the Crown troubled to garrison closely, the houses of the Seann Spioradan had never had a hall of their own, only the hearths of whichever family was keeping the year's rite, and a long custom of walking to a neighbour's fire when their own house had none living old enough to lead the naming. In the autumn after the crowning, forty households of that coast put up timber and stone at Seann Dunn for a hall that would hold all of them at once, and roofed it before the first frost, working by turns as a barn-raising is worked, with the women cooking for the builders and the builders arguing over the pitch of the roof.

The chronicle required nothing of her here; Gormshuil went to see it finished because word of an ancestors' hall reached a chronicler's desk the way any large gathering of the faithful did, and because her mother's own house, three valleys inland, kept the same rite at a hearth too small for half its dead. She went on a hired horse with one clerk, and arrived the evening before the hall's first naming, and slept badly in a fisherman's loft that smelled of nets.

The hall was plain enough to look at: four walls of undressed stone, a roof of new timber that still smelled of the axe, a hearth at either end so that no one house's fire should be taken for another's, and no image or carving anywhere in it, since the Seann Spioradan hold that a name spoken aloud is ornament enough and needs no likeness to stand beside it. Forty families had raised it in a season, working the stone by day and, Gormshuil was told, arguing by candlelight over whose hearth should stand nearer the door, an argument that had been settled, in the end, by the eldest woman of the coast simply sitting down at the hearth she preferred and daring anyone to move her.

The naming she watched from the door, where a chronicler belonged and no further. Forty heads of houses stood in turn and spoke the names of their dead, going back as far as memory or a grandmother's telling would carry them, some no more than three generations, one old woman of Seann Dunn reciting nine before her voice gave out and her son finished the tenth for her. A fisherman from the far end of the coast, a young man by his voice, named only his father and stood a long moment after saying it before sitting down again, and nobody in the hall thought this needed any comment, since not every house's dead came in long lists and a hall built to hold long lists had to hold the short ones too, or it was

built for nothing. Nobody wrote any of it down that night. It was spoken, the way it had always been spoken, into a room full of people who already half knew it, and the only new thing in the room was the room.

Gormshuil, listening from the door with her clerk beside her, found herself counting, without quite meaning to, how many names her own mother's hearth could put up against the room's forty, and gave up the count somewhere past a dozen, less from any want of dead to name than because counting, standing where she stood, felt like exactly the kind of ledger-keeping she had come east to get away from for one evening.

An elder of the hall, a boat-builder called Fearchar Ruadh whose house Gormshuil did not know, found her afterward at the door and asked her plainly whether the Library kept such lists as his houses were now keeping. She told him, as plainly, that it did not, not yet, that the Library kept what came to it and asked for little else, and that if his hall chose to send a copy of its naming south each year, it would be received and kept as carefully as anything else that reached Muileann chaol.

"And if we do not send it," he said, "will the Library go looking for it?"

"No," she said. "It never has."

He seemed to find this the right answer, and said the hall would think on it over the winter. The following year, as it happened, they did send a copy, and the hall went on sending one every year after, each a little longer than the last, name by name. Gormshuil entered its arrival in her own hand, and noted, as she noted with every such gift, only the day it came and the number of names it carried, nothing of what she had seen at the door of the hall. That she kept, if she kept it at all, in the private book she had begun some years before and showed to no one.

IV

Of the Light on the Mole

Far up the eastern coast, past even Seann Dunn, the town of Cuan ruadh had none of the five lighthouses the humans had left the kingdom to keep.

It had a mole, built in the humans' time for a fishing fleet larger than the one that used it now, and at the end of the mole, that same autumn, the town council voted its own coal money to burn a light where no Board light had ever reached.

They built it plainly: an iron cage on a stone stand, a keeper's shed no bigger than a byre, and a boy paid a few coins a week to carry coal out along the mole in all weathers and keep the cage fed through the dark months, when the boats came home late and the rocks off the harbour mouth took a hull or two most winters that a light might have spared. The town called it nothing grander than the light, and burned it faithfully from the first frost.

The winter before the vote, a boat out of the town had come in through a fog so thick a man could not see the length of his own oar, and had found the harbour mouth only because her skipper had fished those rocks since he was a boy and could smell the change in the water before he could see the change in the light. Two boats that same winter had not been so fortunate, and lie yet, or lay then, broken on the same rocks the fog had hidden. It was that skipper, by the town's own telling, who stood up at the meeting that voted the coal money, and said that a harbour that could build a mole could build a light to stand on the end of it, and that the Crown's five lights had never once been built for a town too small to matter to anyone who did not live in it.

They wrote, too, in the same season, to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹ at Cathair dhearg, asking that the light be taken onto the Board's roll and its coal paid from the Board's purse as the five older lights were paid. The letter that came back, some months later, on 25 an Gearran, SE 23, said that the Board's charter named five lights and no more, that a sixth had never been provided for, and that the town's own arrangement, being no charge upon the Crown, might continue exactly as it was.

It did continue exactly as it was, for the rest of the age. The boy who first carried the coal out along the mole grew old doing it, and trained his own boy to the work, and neither of them was ever paid by any hand but the town's own. Gormshuil, reading the Board's letter when a copy of it found its way south with the year's other papers, entered the refusal in four lines and no more, in much the manner Cathair dhearg's own council had once refused a wall it thought needless. She did not add that the fishermen of a town with no lighthouse of its own devising had, for as long as anyone there remembered, gone out and come home by no light but the moon and their own knowledge of the rocks.

1. the Lighthouse Board

V

Of the Còmhrag

At Ceann leathan, two summers after the fair at Muileann òg had proved that the whole island would travel for a gathering if the gathering gave it reason, a smaller and rougher custom took its own first root. Men of the hewing towns had long settled disputes and simple boasts with their fists at the mine-head, on pay-days, under no rule but that a man who went down did not get up swinging; someone, nobody the Library can now name with certainty, thought to bring the custom to a field outside the town and dress it as a contest, with judges and a purse, so that the fighting that had always happened anyway might happen once a year, in daylight, where the fair-wardens could take a fee from every man who came to watch.

The first was fought on 4 am Màrt, SE 23, and they called it simply the Còmhrag, the melee; it drew men from every vein-town within two days' walk: Muileann dhearg sent the largest company, since its hewers had the most to prove and the least else to spend a wage on, and its lodging-houses emptied for the day into the crowd around the ropes. The rules, such as they were that first year, ran to little more than this: any man might enter who paid the fair-wardens' fee, no man might carry an edge, and the last man left inside the ropes took the purse. Nobody thought to write down more than that, because nobody expected the thing to need more than that, and for one summer they were right.

The field lay on rising ground outside the town where the fair-wardens had once grazed the fair's own horses, and by midday of the Còmhrag it held more people standing than Ceann leathan held in its beds. The ropes were strung in a rough square, four posts and a coil borrowed from the harbour store, and inside them the crowd that had paid its fee to fight stood together at one corner while the crowd that had paid its fee to watch pressed close on every other side, close enough that a man knocked hard against the rope felt the whole weight of the watchers lean into it with him. There was no bell to open the bout and no bell to close it; a fair-warden with a horn from a captain's old muster-call blew it once at noon, and the fighting did not properly stop again until the light was going and one man alone still stood inside the ropes.

Two men did not walk out of the ropes that first year. The Library's own words for it, entered by Gormshuil from the fair-wardens' own report and nothing more, run to a single sentence: the dead of the first Còmhrag were buried at

Ceann leathan within the week, and the melee was fought again the following summer regardless. She was asked once, years afterward, by a visiting scholar, whether the chronicle ought not to have said more of who they were. She answered that the report she had been sent gave her nothing more to say, and that she had never yet found it her office to invent what a report withheld.

The man who won that first Còmhrag was a hewer out of Muileann chrom named Calum mac Aonghais, whom the crowd was already calling Calum Ruadh before the last bout was decided, for the colour of his hair and the state of his face by the end of it. He was young for the work he did underground, younger still for the crowd that carried him on its shoulders the length of the field when the judges called it, and he took the purse, a year's wages counted out on a trestle table by the fair-wardens' own clerk, and the second prize besides, which was the right, entered that same evening on the shire's roll at Ceann leathan, to bear arms in any shire of the kingdom for the rest of his life.

He had not looked, by the accounts that reached Muileann chaol afterward, like a man built for winning. A quarryman out of Baile thais, twice his age and half again his weight, had put him down twice in the first hour and stood over him laughing the second time, and it was said in the town afterward that Calum got up the second time only because the crowd nearest him had begun, without much kindness, to place their bets against him staying down, and a man will get up for less reason than that when there is a whole field watching. He did not win by any skill anybody could later describe in much detail; he won, the town agreed, by refusing for six hours to stay on the ground longer than it took him to breathe, until every man larger than him had either gone down himself or grown too tired to make use of being larger.

It was a strange gift to give a hewer, and everyone at the field that evening seemed to feel the strangeness of it a little, though nobody said so aloud. A man who spent his days with a pick and his nights in a lodging-house by the sidings had, by the ropes and the purse and a shire clerk's signature, become in the eyes of the law something his father had never been and his sons might never be again: a man the kingdom would let go armed. The inn-keepers of Ceann leathan, four of whom had built new houses that year purely to hold the crowd the Còmhrag brought, kept his table free of charge that night, and would go on doing so, by a custom nobody formally agreed to, for as long as he came back to fight.

He did not fight again that season. He walked out of the town before dawn the next morning, the purse in his coat and the shire clerk's paper folded inside it,

and took the coal road north toward Muileann chrom on foot, alone, past the fair-wardens' new inns with their shutters still up and the field where the ropes had been taken down in the night, leaving nothing behind him but two flattened circles of grass and a debt the Còmhrag's keepers would spend the winter arguing over how best to collect from next year's crowd. Besides the purse he carried the right to go armed through any shire on the island, a right his own father, a hewer before him at the same face, had never held. For that one autumn it was simply his, earned with his own hands in a field outside a mining town, and he walked home with it the way a man walks home from work that has gone, on the whole, well: tired, a little proud, and not looking back.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Of the Sea-Feast Turned Away

SE 24 AM MÀRT – SE 26 AN GEARRAN

We ask that the widows of the Cuan bheag drowning be heard in this
Moot on the same footing as any man who has paid his due, and
heard first, since it is their dead we are speaking of and not our own.
— a motion of the Moot at Caol mhòr, 10 am Màrt, SE 24, entire, as
the Library renders it

I

Of the Dock, the Twentieth, and the Names Given to Children

In these years the fair at Muileann òg was not the only place the shire's coin went to make stone stand up out of mud. At Ros gheal on the north-central coast the town gave over its whole spring to a dock built long enough to take three grain-ships lying abreast, for the Hawk country sent its barley and its oats down by cart no longer but by water, and the water paid better. The Hawk houses came down from Cnoc bheag to bless the stones before the first ship warped in, and asked, as the price of the blessing, a tithe of whatever the dock earned. The shire's factor haggled them down to a twentieth, and paid it, and has paid it every quarter since, so that to this day the clerks of Ros gheal call the due simply the Hawk's, and few of them could now say why a fishing town owes a grain due to a bird that flies inland.

It was a green early summer, that same year, when the shunting families of Muileann chrom, who lived apart in their rows beside the little engines and were

counted apart in every roll the council kept, had a great crop of children born to them all at once, more than the row had cradles for. Two of that crowd were named Seachran and Brean, and of them, and of the rest born that season, this book says nothing more, for they had done nothing yet, and a chronicle that ran ahead of a child's life would not be a chronicle at all.

Further south that year, Seann Bhral on the southern coast, not the older Seann Bhral of the west, which is a different town and always has been, passed Ros dhomhain in the weight of fish landed, and its curing-sheds, which had been four, became eleven, and ran the whole length of the harbour so that a stranger walking it after dark could follow the smoke and not see the water at all. And near Seann Chwen, on the same coast, a travelling show pitched its poles for the first time, calling itself An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn¹, and the clerk who wrote its arrival into the local roll noted that he could not say what its acts were meant to show, nor, he added, could the crowd that filled the field to watch them, and came back the second night larger than the first.

These are the things the Library keeps of that year in the south: a dock, a due, a crowd of children too young to be named for anything but themselves, more fish than the year before, and a show nobody could explain and everybody paid to see twice. The clerk at Seann Chwen who could not say what the acts were meant to show tried, in his own defence, to set down what he had seen: a woman who walked a rope strung between two masts with her eyes bound in cloth; a man who ate fire from a spoon and spat smoke for a full minute after; a dog that counted to nine by barking and never, that the clerk could tell, miscounted. He gave it up as a bad job and wrote instead that the show had taken a good many pennies of the realm-coin from Seann Chwen in one night and would likely take as many more before it moved on, which was the kind of fact a roll could hold.

In the north the year is kept by a different kind of ledger. It begins with who stood up to speak.

II

Of Mary Coyle Standing Up

1. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

The Moot's house at Caol mhòr had one door, low enough that a tall man ducked for it out of habit whether the lintel needed it or not, and inside, a table that had been a ship's hatch-cover before somebody planed it flat and gave it legs, the grain of it still showing the pattern of the rope that had once run over it in a coil. A stove at the far end took the worst of the chill off the room and none of the rest; men and women kept their coats on through every sitting from am Faoilleach to an Cèitean, and the breath of forty people in the small room fogged the one window until David Hale kept a rag on a string beside it, to wipe a clear patch for whatever daylight was left by the time the meeting rose.

Walter Hale sat at the head of the table still, an old man now, his hearing going, and he let the meeting run long past its hour because he had stopped trusting himself to know when an hour was up. He had chaired the Moot since before most of the room now sitting in it could walk, and the younger clerks had begun, that year, to write his rulings down twice, once as he gave them and once as David Hale judged he had meant them, in case the two should ever need reconciling.

Mary Coyle had come to every sitting of the Moot since the westerly took her husband and ten other men off Cuan bheag five years before, and for five years she had sat at the back near the door with the other widows. There were, that winter, eleven of them who came regular, in a pew of their own though nobody had built it as a pew, simply the bench nearest the door where a woman could slip out early if a child needed fetching. She had passed notes up when she had something to say, because that was how it was done, and nobody had told her different, and she had not thought to ask. Agnes Tulloch, who sat beside her most nights and had lost a brother on the same boat, used to fold the notes into the smallest square her fingers could manage before they went forward, as if a small enough fold might make the asking smaller too.

That night the matter before the Moot was the grain-ships. Ros gheal had agreed its twentieth with the Hawk houses, and the northern boats that had begun that year to land their fish at the new dock were to pay the same twentieth on what they landed, out of the Moot's common harbour purse; and that purse took its coin, in part, from a levy on every fishing family in the north, widows included, for the upkeep of the harbour lights. The widows of Cuan bheag had heard nothing of it until the coin was already gone. The man reading the account, a Moot clerk named for the evening only, ran through the figures in the flat unhurried voice of someone who did not expect to be stopped, and would not have thought to stop himself if he had known what was coming.

"We pay into that purse the same as any man," Mary Coyle said, standing, "and we have never once been asked what it should buy."

The room did not so much fall silent as forget, for a moment, what it had been doing. Nobody at the table had heard her speak before without a note going up first, folded small, for a man near the front to read out in her stead, in his own voice, so that the words arrived at the table already once removed from the mouth that made them.

Hale cupped a hand to his better ear. "Say that again, and stand where I can hear you."

She came round the table, past the stove, past the clerk with his flat voice stopped mid-figure, and said it again, louder, close enough now that Hale did not need the hand at his ear. "We pay into that purse the same as any man. Every quarter, out of what little the season leaves us. And no one has asked a widow of Cuan bheag what she would have that money spent on, though it is our dead the harbour lights are meant to warn other men's boats away from the rocks that took them."

"That is a fair question," Hale said, when he had turned it over, "and I do not know that anyone has ever put it to this table before."

"No one has," said Mary Coyle. "I have sat at the back of this room five years and watched other men's notes read out and voted on, and I thought, tonight, that I would rather be wrong to my own face than right in somebody else's mouth."

There was a laugh at that, not unkind, and one or two of the older men who had known Thomas Coyle rapped their knuckles on the table the way they would for a man's speech they approved. David Hale, the old man's son, kept the day-book at the Moot's elbow, and he wrote down what she said nearly word for word, because it was the first time in the minutes that any woman's speech was set down whole rather than summed in a line ("the widow Coyle spoke") as the clerks had always done before, when they troubled to note a woman's speaking at all.

It was resolved, before that sitting rose, that the widows of the drowned should be heard in the Moot on the same footing as any man who had paid his due, and heard first when the matter touched their own dead. Agnes Tulloch, from the bench by the door, was the one who moved that it be written down as a standing rule and not a courtesy for one night only, and old Hale, who had chaired the Moot longer than either woman had been widowed, said he could not

see why it had taken the room so long to think of it, which was as near as he came, in front of the whole Moot, to admitting that it had not occurred to him either.

David Hale copied the motion twice, once into the day-book and once onto a loose sheet that Mary Coyle folded into her shawl and carried home, because she did not yet trust a book she could not open herself to keep a thing said.

She did not sit at the back again.

III

Of the Muster for Seann Bhral

It was old Hale himself, turning the matter over by his fire that spring, who put the thought in her head, though he never claimed it after. "My grandfather," he said, "used to tell of a feast of the sea the western harbours kept at summer's end, for the safe return of the boats. He said our own folk learned it from the Dia-thìrich of those harbours in the first years after the Crossing, when the harbours still took in whoever came off a boat."

"Do we still keep it?"

"We keep the *shape* of it. A blessing at the boats, in an Gearran, before the season proper starts. But the old feast, the one it comes from, they keep still, he said, at a house on the west coast. Seann Bhral. Not this one." He tapped the table, meaning the near one, the fishing port to the south they had all heard of that year on account of its curing-sheds. "The other Seann Bhral. The first one."

Mary Coyle turned it over for the better part of a month, and what she found, asking among the older crews, bore Hale out: that the house of Manannan's order at Seann Bhral in the west was reckoned the oldest on that coast, and that some memory persisted, thin as a rope worn to its last strands, that the Tuathaich forebears had once been welcome at its feast of the sea, in the years just after the Crossing, before the island had settled into a kingdom with a north side and a south.

She put it to the Moot in an t-Iuchar: that a fleet of the northern boats should sail west-about, round the capes, to keep the feast where it had first been kept, as their own people's memory said they were owed the right to do. The Moot argued it two full sittings before it agreed. Nobody spoke against the sea-feast itself; half the room thought it a fool's errand all the same, to sail eleven boats round the worst capes on the island at the tail of the summer for a welcome that was not cer-

tain, and said so, plainly, and were not wrong to wonder it. Mary Coyle did not argue that they were wrong. She said only that a certainty was not what she was asking the Moot to send her after, and that she would go herself whatever the vote, with whoever chose to come, and the Moot, having heard that, voted to send its blessing after her rather than let her sail without it.

It was not a large fleet in the end. Eleven boats put out from Caol mhòr and Cuan bheag and Ros mhòr on a grey morning at the end of an Lùnastal, laden with little beyond themselves and the coin for the harbour dues at the far end, a keg of salt fish apiece to see them there and back, and, in the bottom of Mary Coyle's own boat, the folded sheet from the Moot's day-book that named her the one the north had sent. She sailed in the leading boat, not because she could handle a boat better than any man aboard (she could not, and said so plainly to the skipper who offered her the tiller out of courtesy the first morning, and he never offered it again) but because it had been her word that sent them, and she judged, rightly, that a thing said ought to be stood behind by the one who said it, in the bow if not at the helm.

The passage took the better part of four days, coasting inside the worst of the weather, putting in at night wherever a harbour would have them, which was not everywhere; the harbour-master at Ros bheag, on their second night's road, would not let them tie up at the quay proper and sent them instead to a mooring buoy off the point, with a lantern for courtesy and nothing warmer than that. Two nights they lay at anchor in open bays with the watch kept turn and turn about against the swell, wrapped in whatever oilskin and wool could be spared, and men who had fished together twenty years found out, in those two nights, things about each other's snoring and each other's praying that they had somehow never learned in twenty years of ordinary weather. On the third a squall out of the south-west put green water over the bow of the smallest boat and near enough finished it before the crew bailed her clear with anything that would hold water, boots included; Mary Coyle, in the boat behind, watched the smaller craft vanish twice into the trough of a wave and come up twice still afloat, and said afterward that she had made herself a promise in that quarter-hour that she kept the rest of her life and never once told anyone the wording of. Nobody was lost. It was, more than one of them said afterward, the hardest four days most of them had known, and they measured them, as the north measured every hardship, against the Crossing itself, which none of them remembered and all of them had heard told.

IV

Of the House That Said the Sea Was the Same

They came into Seann Bhral on the eve of the feast, eleven boats riding low with salt on everything, and moored where the harbour-master's boy showed them, at the outer wall, away from the fishing fleet proper. The house of Manannan's order stood above the harbour on its own terrace, older than anything else in the town by the look of its stonework, its doorposts carved with a wave-pattern worn nearly smooth by long ages of hands touching it on the way in.

Word of eleven Tuathaich boats standing in had gone up to the house before the last of them was moored, carried by a harbour boy quicker with his feet than his manners, and by the time Mary Coyle and two of the older skippers climbed the terrace steps a small crowd of the town's own fisherfolk had gathered at the wall below to see what would come of it, some curious and some, by their faces, already certain.

The keeper who came out to them was a tall, spare man, not unkind in his manner, who heard Mary Coyle out to the end without once interrupting her, which she took, wrongly, for a good sign. She had rehearsed the asking the whole four days of the passage, turning the words over at the tiller and in the night watches until she judged she had them worn smooth, and she gave it to him now much as she had made it to herself: that the Tuathaich forebears had kept the feast of the sea at this house once, in the first years after the Crossing, before ever there was a kingdom with a north side to it; that the memory of it was thin in the north now but not gone; and that eleven boats had sailed a hard four days on the strength of that thin memory, asking nothing more than to stand at the harbour and see the rite done, and perhaps to say a word of their own over it, if the house would permit that much.

"You have the right of the history," he said, when she had finished. "It is true that in the first years the harbours took in whoever came off a boat, and asked no questions of blood before they let a man to the fire. I do not deny you that. But the order that keeps this house now keeps it for those who hold the rite of Manannan as it is held today, by right of blood and by the custodian's book, and that is not a thing four days' hard sailing can put right, however justly you sailed them."

"We are not asking for the rite," said Mary Coyle. "We are asking for the feast. Our own priests can say what needs saying over it."

"The feast is the rite," the keeper said, not unkindly, and that was the whole of his answer, said once and not repeated, though she asked it three further ways before she judged that a fourth would only make a hard thing harder to carry home. "The sea is the same sea it always was," he told her at the last, seeing her face, and meaning, she understood after, to soften it rather than close it further. "It is the house that is not the same house it was."

One of the skippers who had climbed the terrace with her, a hard, plain man named for nothing gentler than his trade, asked the keeper straight out whether it was blood he meant, or coin, since the house looked in no want of either. The keeper did not take offence at it. "Both, in their way," he said. "The order keeps this house on tithes from families who have held the rite for ages. If I let in every boat that could show a claim on the old welcome, I would have no house left to keep it in by the second winter, and no order behind me either. I do not say that gladly. I say it because it is true, and I would rather tell you a true hard thing than a soft one that costs me nothing."

She did not answer that, then. She has been reported, by more than one of the crews who stood behind her on the quay that evening, to have looked a long while at the carved doorposts before she turned back to the boats, the wave-pattern worn smooth by hands she would never be able to count and none of which were now hers to add to, and to have said nothing at all until she was aboard, at which point she said only that they would sail on the morning tide, and slept, or lay still enough to be thought asleep, through a night none of the rest of the eleven boats' crews slept much through at all. Below on the harbour wall a few of the town's own fisherfolk had stayed on past dark, and one woman among them, whose name the Library has not kept, came down to the boats with a jug of something hot before she went home, and said only that she was sorry for it, which was more than the house above had said, and which Mary Coyle remembered, she told people afterward, longer than she remembered the keeper's own words.

V

Of the Feast They Made Their Own

The passage home took five days against a headwind that had not troubled them going out, and nobody aboard the eleven boats said much of anything about Seann Bhral for the length of it, beyond what was needed to work the sail and the helm. It was on the third day, off the northern capes, that one of the Ros mhòr men, an old hand who had said little the whole voyage, asked Mary Coyle plainly what she meant to do now, since the west would not have them.

"Keep it anyway," she said. "Not their feast. Ours."

She did not mean, and said she did not mean, to invent a rite out of nothing; she meant the blessing of the boats that the north already kept in a thin, half-remembered way each spring at the great church at Cnoc ghorm, and to make of it, deliberately and in full, the feast that Seann Bhral had refused them the whole of. It was decided among the crews before they raised Caol mhòr again, and the decision cost nothing but the saying of it, which by then Mary Coyle had some practice in.

Word of it went round the north coast faster than the eleven boats themselves had sailed, carried by every crew that had been on the passage and told, in every kitchen it reached, a little larger than it had left the last one; by the time an Gearran came round, boats were promising to come from as far as Inis mhin's country, a fair way further than any of the eleven had gone west. On the second Sunday of an Gearran, in SE 26, the boats of the north coast that could be got to Cnoc ghorm in a day's sail or a morning's cart were drawn up on carts and trestles in the field below the church, the hulls brought overland from the nearer harbours, more than fifty of them by the count David Hale kept for the day-book, far more than had ever gathered at Cnoc ghorm for the old thin blessing in any year before. The priest of An Eaglais¹ who kept that parish, a young man new to the charge and glad of the crowd whatever brought it, said the old words over each hull in turn, dipping a bundle of dried heather in a bucket of harbour water and shaking it across bow and stern while the crews stood bareheaded in the cold, their breath going up white over the field in a line as long as the boats themselves. Mary Coyle's own boat, the one that had carried her both ways to the west, was blessed fourth in the row, and she stood at its bow through the whole of the rite with her hands folded and her shawl pulled close, and said nothing to anyone until it was done.

1. the Church

Afterward there was food on trestles set up in the churchyard, brought by whoever had a little to spare that week, and someone had got a fiddle working despite the cold, and the thing that had begun as eleven boats sailing west at the summer's end ended, that evening, as a crowd in a churchyard field that did not, by any account written down afterward, look like a people who had been turned away from anything at all.

The Library keeps this much of what followed: that the north kept its own Fleadh na Mara² at Cnoc ghorm every year after, on the same Sunday, without asking leave of any house on the west coast again, and that within a generation more boats came to it than had ever, in the memory of anyone living, gone to the feast at Seann Bhrál. Whether the house on the west coast ever heard how it had grown, the Library does not know, and has found no one who thought to write and tell it.

2. the northern feast of the sea at Cnoc ghorm

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

OF IAIN MAPA'S SURVEY

SE 26 AM MÀRT – SE 27 AN T-IUCHAR

Received of Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, one survey of the
faces of the Sloc Mòr, rolled and tied, this day. Filed.
— the Mine Board's receipt, 9 an Cèitean, SE 26, entire, as the Lib-
rary renders it

I

Of the Faces of the Sloc Mòr

Iain mac Ruairidh was thirty-two years old and had spent the better part of a year on his knees, or bent double, or flat on his belly on stone that was always either wet or freezing, with a lamp on a string round his neck and a chain that two other men held taut while he called the figures back to them over his shoulder. He was a chainman by his first trade and a surveyor by the Board's later reckoning, and he had come up through the Sloc Mòr the slow way, gallery by gallery, learning the mountain's faces the way another man might learn a woman's, by long acquaintance and no great ceremony about it. He thought of himself as careful rather than clever, which the Board valued more, or said it did.

What he had found, over that year, he had not gone looking for. He had gone into the eastern galleries with the ordinary work of the season, to true up an old survey against the new digging and settle a dispute between two overseers about where one man's cutting ended and another's began, and he had come out of it with a set of figures that would not lie flat no matter which way he turned them. The vein was thinning, badly nowhere yet: to the east it ran narrower than the old maps showed, and to the south it pinched again in the same proportion, as if the

mountain had made up its mind about something years before and only now got round to telling anyone.

He checked it twice before he let himself believe it, because a man who tells the Mine Board a thing it does not want to hear had better be right, and a third time because rightness alone, in his experience, was protection for no one. Working the eastern faces again at speed, chain out to its full length and back, in the wet cold of the spring with water finding its way down the back of his collar no matter how he stood, he got the same figures each time, to within an inch the chain itself could account for, and set them down in the plainest words he had: thinning to east and south, in a hand that did not shake, and did not argue.

The whole of it he drew fair on a single long sheet, rolled and tied with the plain string the Board's own store issued for the purpose, and carried himself the thirty-one miles from the Sloc Mòr to Cathair dhearg rather than send it by the carters, for a thing that mattered, in his experience, travelled better in a man's own hand than in anyone else's.

He had told no one at the Sloc Mòr what the figures showed, not the two men who had held his chain for him nor the overseer whose dispute had set him onto the eastern galleries in the first place, though both had asked, in the ordinary way men ask a surveyor coming up out of the dark what he has found down there. He had said only that the old maps wanted correcting, which was true as far as it went and told them nothing they could carry off and repeat, and he had told himself, walking the road south with the roll under his arm and the weather coming up cold off the hills, that this was caution and not cowardice, though he turned the distinction over more than once before he reached the capital and did not come to rest on it either way. The road ran two days by cart or a day and a half on foot at a hard pace, and he took the second, sleeping the one night at a carters' inn on the road where nobody asked his business and he offered none, and came into Cathair dhearg on the morning of the second day with the roll dry under his coat and his boots ruined by the last mile of it, which had run wet the whole way.

II

Of the Receipt

The Board sat that season in three low rooms behind the old counting-house at Cathair dhearg, the same rooms it had sat in since the Sloc Mòr conces-

sion was first granted, with a single window between the three of them that let in less light than a man might have wished for reading survey work. Iain was shown in by a clerk who did not ask his business, because his business was written plainly enough on the roll under his arm, and he stood in front of a table at which three men sat, none of whom he had met before, though he knew all three by name the way a chainman knows the men who sign his wages.

He laid the roll on the table in front of them and untied the string himself, because it seemed to him the courteous thing, and waited for one of them to unroll it. None of them did. The man in the middle, who was older than the other two and dressed a shade better, put two fingers on the near edge of the sheet, as if to hold it down against a wind that was not blowing in that room, and left it at that.

"You've come far," he said, which was not a question and did not want an answer.

Iain gave him the short of it anyway, because he had walked thirty-one miles to say it and meant to say it whether it was asked for or not: the vein was thinning to east and south, the figures were on the sheet, the old maps wanted correcting, and a man ought to know it who was deciding where the next year's galleries went. He said it plainly, the way he had written it, without dressing it in anything worse or better than what the ground had told him.

The three men looked at the roll, and then at each other, and not very long at either.

"It will be considered," said the one in the middle.

Iain had walked thirty-one miles carrying a thing he believed, and he had thought, on the road, about a good many ways this hour might go, most of them worse than this one, some of them shouting. He had not thought about this one, a short sentence and a closed door behind it, and it took him a moment to find his own voice again, and when he did it was smaller than he had meant it to be, though it did not waver.

"I should like a receipt," he said.

The clerk at the side table looked at him as a man looks at another who has asked for something unaccountable in that room; no one told him no, and after a silence in which the three men at the table seemed to consult each other without a word passing between them, the youngest of the three nodded at the clerk, who took up a pen, wrote a few lines on a scrap no bigger than his own palm, and passed it across for the man in the middle to sign. He did not. He passed it on to the third man at the table, a broad, unhurried man named Ruairidh mac Ailein,

who read what was written, found nothing in it he cared to argue with, and signed his own name under it without comment, in a hand a good deal quicker than the clerk's.

Received of Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, one survey of the faces of the Sloc Mòr, rolled and tied, this day. Filed. Nothing more. No word of what the survey said, no word of thinning or of east and south, nothing that a man reading it afterward, with no other knowledge, could have told from what it had cost to get.

Iain folded it once and put it in his pocket-book, where it lay against the ribs on the walk home closer than the coin he carried, and he thanked the room, which did not seem to expect thanks and did not offer any back, and went out past the clerk into the ordinary daylight of Cathair dhearg's street, which struck him, for a moment, as a strange place for nothing at all to have happened in.

The roll stayed on the table when he left it, and by the account the Library keeps of that room's business it was filed within the week, in a press with the two years' surveys before it, and shown to no one. Within the month Iain mac Ruairidh was told, without much explanation offered and none asked for, that he was wanted at the silver works at Muileann chiar, twenty-four miles east and a little south, where the Board had need of a man who could hold a chain straight and did not ask more questions than the work required.

He asked, once, of the clerk who brought him the posting, whether the move had anything to do with the survey he had carried in himself the month before, and the clerk, a younger man than the three at the table and not unkind, said only that he could not say, which Iain took to mean that the clerk could say and had chosen not to, and did not ask a second time. He asked nothing at all of Ruairidh mac Ailein, whom he passed in the corridor on his way out of the counting-house that same week and who nodded to him civilly enough, as one working man nods to another whose trade he has some respect for, and said nothing of the receipt he had signed, and Iain said nothing of it either, and the two of them went their ways down the same corridor without either mentioning the thing that stood between them, which was, Iain thought afterward, very much the manner of the Board in everything it did.

III

Of the Rule Made at Cathair mhòr

The Library at Muileann chaol tells the rest of that year in fewer words than it gave to the receipt, and it is worth setting down what little it does say, because the Board's own account of itself, where the Board troubled to keep one, is thinner still.

The Mine Board had sat at Cathair dhearg since the Sloc Mòr concession was first cut, close by the counting-house whose rooms it borrowed and the mint that struck the coin its shafts paid for. In am Faoilleach of the following year it moved its clerks and its presses the sixteen miles to Cathair mhòr, into rooms taken on lease above the town's own wool market, on the stated ground that a board charged with the mountain's business ought to sit nearer the mountain than it had. No one who wrote of the move at the time troubled to explain why sixteen miles nearer counted for so much, when thirty-one had done well enough for the years before, and the Library, which asked the question of every clerk still living who might have answered it, records only that none of them thought the question worth much of a reply.

With the move the Board set down, in the plainest of its own minutes, a rule that had not existed in writing before that year, though men who had dealt with the Board a long while said afterward that it had always been the practice and only now got its own sentence: that the surveys of the Board's own men were to be kept at Cathair mhòr, in the Board's own presses, and were not to be sent on to the Library at Muileann chaol as the reports of other offices were sent, by the standing order that had governed the state's paper since Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill first asked every shire for its books. The rule gave no reason for itself beyond the Board's own convenience in having its working papers to hand, and it was written in four lines, and it was never once, in all the years it stood, brought before the council to be confirmed or struck down, because no one outside the Board's own rooms had reason to know it existed at all.

The Library, setting this down at the age's close with every paper the state ever sent it laid open on the table, notes only this: that from the year the rule was made until the year it was at last broken, the Board's surveys of the Sloc Mòr's faces went nowhere but into the Board's own presses, and that among them, filed and never circulated, lay the sheet Iain mac Ruairidh had carried thirty-one miles and a receipt had been the whole of his payment for.

No one on the council was asked to confirm the rule, and no one on the council thought to ask after it, for the Board's business had always been counted a small, dry corner of the state's affairs, more like a mill's own account book than a

matter of law, and the men who sat on the council in those years had grain and roads and the fair at Muileann òg to occupy them, and little patience left over for a mountain that had, on the face of things, gone on giving as freely as it always had. The wool market's factor let the rooms to the Board gladly enough, for the rent was steady and the Board's clerks were quiet tenants who kept regular hours and troubled the market's own business not at all, and if he ever wondered what papers the Board kept upstairs that could not travel the sixteen miles on to Muileann chaol with every other office's, he left no word of the wondering behind him.

IV

Of Small Trades and a Forbidden Night

Not every year's business was the mountain's. At Seann Vell on the capital shore, in those same seasons, the glass-houses that had lately begun blowing small flasks found a trade nobody had planned for them: the women of the town took to filling the flasks with waters they distilled themselves from bog-myrtle and meadowsweet and the honey pressed from heather, and selling them by the dozen to carters bound for the market towns of the western plain. Within a year or two the plain's own towns had taken the trade up on their own account, so that a woman travelling that country could buy the same scent from three different hands in three different towns and be told, by each, that it was made nowhere but where she stood. It was a small thing, and the Library sets it down chiefly because it happened in the same year as larger things that left less behind them: a magistrate's fine, a boat kept for a relic, a survey filed and forgotten. The glass-houses of Seann Vell are still standing, and the small trade in scent still runs from them, longer-lived by a good margin than the rule the Board made that same year and never told the council of.

Further north, at Baile chrom on the far cape where the lighthouse stood, the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane had for some years kept the vigil of the Grey Night in the open, on the headland below the light, as no keeper before her had kept it. In the summer of that same year a Dia-thìreach magistrate new to the district, who had heard the vigil described to him as an unruly gathering by men who had never troubled to watch one, forbade it as disorderly and had Hannah Crane brought before him and fined. She paid what she could of it herself and could not pay the

rest, and word of the fine went south with the wool carts and reached the Moot at Caol mhòr before the summer was out. The Moot, which had by then grown used to paying for things the north's own purses could not quite stretch to, voted the balance of her fine out of its own small chest without much debate, on the motion of a councillor who said only that a woman fined for sitting on a headland in the cold and saying nothing to anyone was not, in his judgement, a threat the Moot need trouble itself to agree with.

The vigil did not stop. It went indoors, into a byre lent for the purpose by a family who kept the old rite themselves and asked no questions of those who came to it, and it was kept there, one night a year, in a silence the magistrate's order could not reach any better than it had reached the shingle, because a rule made against a sound cannot be made against its absence. Outsiders were still not told which night it was. The Library, which has asked, is not told either.

V

Of the Boat Kept for a Relic

Far to the south, on the coast the Great Wave had scoured clean a generation before, the harbour at Cuan dhearg was opened again that same season, with a new mole of dressed stone laid where the old one had gone under the water in a single night. The masons who built it were largely the sons of the men who had lost the first harbour, and more than one of them said, working the stone, that they were laying it heavier than their fathers had, against a wave that had not troubled the coast again in all the years between, and that nobody in Cuan dhearg had stopped thinking about all the same.

The first boat warped into the new harbour was not a new boat at all. Among the hulls that the wave had cast up into the fields behind the old town, and that had lain there through more than twenty years of grass growing up around their ribs, one had been found sound enough, when the harbour-master's men went out to look at what the fields still held, to be dragged back down to the water and caulked and floated. It went in first, ahead of every boat built new for the rebuilt harbour, and the harbour-master, a woman named for her own grandmother who had drowned in the wave without ever seeing a harbour again, kept it afterward as a relic rather than putting it back to work, mooring it at the head of the quay where every boat coming in or going out passed close by it. The fishermen

of Cuan dhearg came to call it simply the boat of the field, and told strangers, if they asked, that it had come home the long way round, by way of the barley, and taken its time about it.

VI

Of Muileann chiar

I ain mac Ruairidh had come to Muileann chiar at the start of the summer the receipt was given, with his chain and his lamp and the pocket-book that held, among its other pages, the receipt the Board had given him, and he found the silver works a smaller business than the Sloc Mòr and a stranger one, the veins running in thin bright seams through rock that gave up its secrets more readily than coal ever had, if a man knew how to read the seams at all. He was set to measuring the eastern faces against the old plans, much as he had been set to the same work at the Sloc Mòr, and the overseer who took him on said only that the Board had sent word he was careful, which was, the overseer added, more than the Board generally troubled to say of anyone.

The town itself he found smaller too, and quieter, built along a single burn that the silver-washers used and that ran, by the season, either a clean brown or a faint grey depending on how the works upstream were going, and the guild that held the silver had kept its charter through the humans' time and into the restored kingdom without much interruption to its own ways, so that the men he worked beside spoke of the vein as a thing with moods of its own, to be coaxed rather than merely measured, in a manner the coal men at the Sloc Mòr would have thought soft. He did not think it soft, once he had spent a season at it. The silver ran truer to the old plans than the coal had, faces holding where the maps said they would hold, and there were weeks that spring and into the summer when he went a full day without once thinking of the sheet he had carried to Cathair dhearg, which he counted, when he noticed it, a kind of rest.

It did not last the whole season. A letter came to him the following summer, forwarded on from the Sloc Mòr by a clerk who thought he might want to see it, from one of the two men who had held his chain for him the year before, asking, in a rough hand and rougher spelling, whether the eastern galleries had been given up yet, since the overseer at the Sloc Mòr had begun talking of opening new ground to the west instead, where the going was harder but the yield, by the over-

seer's own reckoning, steadier. Iain read it twice and wrote back a short answer that said he had no way of knowing what the Board meant to do with the ground he had surveyed, which was true, and did not say what he privately believed, which was that the Board meant to do nothing with it at all beyond keeping it filed, because a mountain that has been told, in writing, that it is running out does not stop giving simply because the men who own it have chosen not to read the letter.

He did not speak of the survey he had left behind him, not to the overseer and not to the men who worked the faces alongside him, and if any of them wondered why a chainman with a name for care had been moved on so quickly from a working as large as the Sloc Mòr to one so much smaller, none of them asked him to his face, and he offered nothing. What he did, on his first free evening at Muileann chiar, in the room he had taken above a cooper's yard, was to take the pocket-book out and lay the receipt flat on the table under the lamp, and read it through once more, though he had it near enough by heart already, and then he took a pin from the small tin he kept for mending his own coat and pinned the scrap of paper into the back leaves of the book he kept his working figures in, where it would not fall out and could not easily be lost, and where, he thought, it would still be found by whoever came after him, whether that was the Board or no one at all.

He did not write beside it what it meant to him, because he was not a man who wrote such things down even when he thought them, and the figures on the sheet he had carried to Cathair dhearg said, as far as he was concerned, everything that needed saying about the vein and about the mountain and about what the Board had chosen to do with the knowing of it. But he kept the receipt pinned in his book from that evening on, through every posting the Board sent him to afterward, a small square of paper that said only that a thing had been received and filed, and nothing at all of what the thing had been, and he carried it, in the years that followed, the way another man might carry a debt he meant, sooner or later, to see paid.

Of the Bare Entry

SE 28 AM FAOILLEACH – SE 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS

I

Of Achadh mhin's Fields

The clerk who carried the shire's return up from the south-west that winter was young enough to think the news in it worth a second horse, and rode the last stage in the dark to save the half-day it would have cost him to wait for light. Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill read it at her own table at Muileann chaol by a single lamp, the household long abed, and found nothing in it that a fresh horse had been worth, which was not the same as finding nothing in it at all.

Achadh mhin's fields bore again. It was the plainest sentence the shire clerk had ever sent her: the barley had come up along the old strips, the salt long since rained out of ground that had lain under the Great Wave's tide-mark for a generation, and three of the households that the council had moved off it in the year of the wave, or their children in their place, had asked and been granted their old ground back, measured out to the same lines the humans' surveyors had cut before any Dia-thìreach clerk had thought to draw a shire on top of them. The shire had gone to the trouble of the old humans' plat rather than draw new bounds of its own, since the old lines were the ones the families still walked by memory, their grandparents having farmed inside them, and a boundary a family can find in the dark by the line of a hedge is worth more than one a surveyor can find at noon with a chain.

She wrote the entry in four lines, gave it the category the record gave such things, and noted, because she always noted it when she could, the day the return had reached her and not only the day the fields were sown. It went into the chron-

icle between a drought at Baile chlar and a wedding at Doire shean, one line among the ordinary traffic of a kingdom's year, and she thought no more of it that night than she thought of any entry once it was written and the ink dry.

One of the three households was named in the return, since the shire clerk had thought it worth the ink: a family that had farmed the northernmost of the drowned strips before the wave, moved inland to a cousin's holding for a generation, and come back that spring to find the old boundary stone still standing where the tide had left it, tilted but not thrown down, and had righted it themselves before troubling the shire for a measurer at all. Gormshuil kept that detail out of the chronicle's own entry, which had no room for a family's name among a shire's ordinary returns, but she copied it into the private book she had kept these several years and showed to no one, on the ground that a record built only of what the office required would in the end tell a reader less about the kingdom's year than the office already knew, and that somebody, someday, might have use of the difference.

She thought more of it three weeks later, when the second courier came, this one no less young but riding no faster than the roads allowed, since nothing in his bag would be helped by haste and everything in it would be hurt by a torn seal. Gormshuil had kept the chronicle ten years by then and knew the weight of a packet by its wrapping before she broke it: a shire's ordinary return came loose in a merchant's satchel; a council packet came sealed twice, once by the clerk who wrote it and once by whoever above him had read it and agreed it should go. This one was sealed twice.

She broke it standing, which she did not usually do, and read it standing too, which she did even less, and when she had read it through she sat down at the same table where she had entered Achadh mhin's barley and found that her hand, reaching for a fresh sheet, was steadier than she had any right to expect, and steadier, she thought afterward, than the news deserved.

II

Of the Bare Entry

Brighde was dead, and the packet gave no more of the matter than that. It gave the day. No cause was made known, in words that made plain the office writing them expected the phrase to be believed and did not much

mind whether it was. Eòghan, Brìghde's cousin, had been crowned within the week by Macha's rite, as the rite required when a throne could not sit empty past a certain number of days, and a line added at the foot, in a different, hastier hand, said that the council's own sitting on the matter had not passed as quietly as the crowning that followed it.

Gormshuil sat a long while with the sheet in front of her and wrote nothing. She had, in ten years, buried one king and crowned another, and had let one phrase into the record for it, weighed for a night and kept for good; she had told herself then that a chronicler who let herself one ornament, chosen with care, was safer than a chronicler who let herself none and then, some later year, gave way all at once to a worse one under worse pressure. She believed that still. It was not, she found, sitting with the lamp burning down and the packet's two seals broken on the table in front of her, an answer to the question the second death put to her, because the second death was not the same question as the first.

Mar a thàinig Niall had cost her nothing to write because it had cost the kingdom nothing to hear. A king had died in his middle years, and had been followed by a daughter nobody contested; the sentence she had borrowed had been light because the year it described had been light. This year was not light. A queen had died young, of a cause the office that wrote to her did not name and, by the turn of the sentence, did not intend ever to name, and the crowning that followed her had gone through a council sitting hard enough that someone thought the fact of its hardness worth adding in a different hand, though not worth explaining. A chronicler who reached for a soft phrase now, having reached for one once before, would not be choosing an ornament. She would be choosing a habit, and a habit chosen at the one moment the record most wanted to speak plainly was a habit chosen exactly wrong.

She wrote three drafts before she wrote the one that stood. The first ran to six lines and said, without quite saying it, that a young death was a hard death for a chronicler to leave unremarked, which she struck through before the ink was dry, on the ground that a reader wants to know what happened and has no use for what the chronicler found hard. The second ran to two lines and said only the day and the fact, and she looked at it a long time before striking it too, because a chronicle that gave a queen's death two bare lines when it had given the last one a name for what came after read, to her own eye, less like restraint and more like a door pulled shut on purpose, and a shut door draws the eye of anyone who later comes looking for what was behind it, which was exactly the attention she did not

want to invite and could not, in honesty, say her entry was free of inviting regardless of how she wrote it. The third she began and left unfinished on the table past midnight, because it had begun arguing with its own middle before it reached its fact, laying out the case for saying more before it had said the thing plainly. An entry that argues before it states is no record at all, only a brief for one side of a question nobody had asked her to judge.

What she wrote in the end, on the fourth attempt, past the second hour of the morning, gave the day of Brìghde's death, the fact that no cause was made known, the day of Eòghan's crowning by the rite, and nothing else. Nothing was said of the council's hard sitting on the succession. Nothing was said of what the harder hand in the packet's second seal had wanted her to know without quite writing it down. Four bare lines carried a queen's death and a king's crowning together, the same length the chronicle would have given a lesser succession in a lighter year, and she signed the page, and did not strike it, and sat with it in front of her until the lamp guttered rather than trim it and give herself more light to doubt it by.

She knew, setting it into the chronicle the next morning in her own clean hand rather than trusting the copy to a clerk, exactly what the bareness would do. A reader coming to that page a hundred years on, or ten, would read four short lines after a long entry for the coming of Niall's own reign, would notice the shortness before noticing anything the lines actually said, and would ask, as she herself had asked of shorter entries in older books, what the silence was standing in for. She could not stop that asking. She had decided, over the third draft struck through on the table, that she did not want to. An entry padded to look full said, to anyone who read enough of them, precisely as much as an entry left honestly bare, and said it more dishonestly, since it dressed a silence as a fullness and hoped the reader would not weigh the two the same. She would rather the silence stood for what it was and let the reader do their own weighing than build a small deception into the kingdom's own record to spare a future reader the discomfort of wondering.

"You wrote nothing of the hard sitting," said Tormod, the following week, laying a fair copy beside her for checking, having read the packet himself as her clerks always did before she did, since a clerk who did not read what he copied was of no use copying it.

"I wrote what the office sent me and what I could stand behind," she said. "The hard sitting is the council's to enter in its own minutes if it chooses to. It is

not the chronicle's business to tell a reader what to make of a silence it did not create."

He asked her, not for the first time in ten years, whether she thought a chronicler owed the truth or the record, as though the two were ever different questions, and she told him what she had told him before, that the two were the same question asked twice, and that the day she found them pulling apart from one another was the day she would know it was time to lay the office down, whatever the council thought of the timing.

III

Of the Votes Recorded

The council's own minute of the sitting reached her some weeks after, forwarded by the same office that had sent the first packet, on no request of hers; she took this to mean that somebody above the clerk who copied it wanted the fact of it in the kingdom's permanent keeping even if nobody wanted it dwelt on, which suited her well enough, since dwelling on it was not the chronicle's office to begin with.

It was the first minute of its kind the council had ever kept, in the restored kingdom's whole span since the twelve first sat at Cathair dhearg. Every crowning before it, Niall's own included, had gone through the council's sitting as a formality entered without a division, the twelve rising as one body to swear the fresh oath the rite required of them and the clerk noting only that the oath was sworn. This time the clerk noted a division. He named the two who had stood against seating Eòghan, Tormod mac Iain Òig and Sileas nic Artair, and he named nothing else: not the ground either had stood on, not the word either had used to explain a vote that no councillor within living memory had ever needed to explain before, not whether the two had spoken together or apart, not whether the nine who carried the sitting had answered them in the room or only outvoted them and moved on to the day's next business. Four lines, the same length she had given the queen's death and the king's crowning together, and the fourth line was the plainest of the four: *the two did not sit again*.

She entered it as it had come to her, changing nothing, since a council's own minute was not hers to soften or to sharpen, only to keep; and she found, doing so, that the four bare lines of the council's record sat oddly well beside her own

four bare lines for the crowning, as though the two offices had reached, from opposite ends of the same season and without a word passing between them, the same conclusion about how much a hard year could safely be let say of its own hardness in the kingdom's own hand.

A later return told her of the two seats, and she entered it separately, since the record kept things in the order they reached her and not the order a reader might wish for a tidy story: before the year turned, the council filled both places, a landed man's son from the western shires taking the one and a widow of a coastal house the other, and neither newcomer, so far as any packet reaching Muileann chaol ever said, was asked in council to account for the vote that had opened the seat they now held. Tormod mac Iain Òig went home to his own lands, and his name does not appear in the chronicle again for some years. A separate note on Sileas nic Artair, which Gormshuil entered without comment because it was not hers to comment on, told that she kept a house of her own kin's Old Spirits faith with more attention than the council's business had ever left her time for.

"Two names and no reasons," Tormod said, copying the fair page, "is a strange thing for a first of anything."

"It is the shape the council chose to give it," Gormshuil said. "I did not choose it for them. I only kept it."

She thought, though she did not say it to him, that the council's silence and her own were not quite the same silence, however alike the two entries read on the page. Hers was chosen with a night's argument behind it, three drafts struck through before a fourth stood, and she could have told anyone who asked exactly why she had chosen it. The council's, she suspected, watching the fair copy dry, had not been chosen at all, only arrived at, the way a room full of people who would rather not explain a hard vote will find, without deciding to, that four lines are as much as anyone in the room is willing to put their name to. A chosen silence and a fallen-into one looked the same on a page a hundred years on. She did not think they ought to, and knew of no way, within the office the chronicle gave her, to mark the difference for a reader who had not sat, as she had, with the packet's two seals broken open under a guttering lamp.

IV

Of the Fire at Inis bhàn and the Letter of the Schools

The spring brought her a return of a plainer kind, one that asked nothing of her but the keeping. Fire had taken the warehouse quarter of Inis bhàn on the Abhainn ìseal, in the north-central country, and burned two days before the town beat it back street by street with buckets and wet sacking and whatever water the river would give up to a chain of hands; the loss was heavy, three storehouses and a dozen dwellings above them, but the dead were none, every soul in the burning quarter having got clear ahead of the flame or been carried clear by neighbours who did not wait to be asked. The town's Hawk house, which had never before opened its doors past the households sworn to it, took in every family the fire had put out of a roof, sworn or not, and kept them through the worst of the spring cold until new roofs could be raised; the return noted this without comment, as the town seemed to have taken it without much comment, a Hawk house doing in a hard week what a Hawk house existed to do and nobody troubling to call it remarkable.

What the town did trouble to call remarkable, and what its return spent three lines on where the fire had had one, was the bell the town bought that summer to stand where the old warehouse bell had burned with its tower under it: cast at the founders' yard at Cathair dhearg to the town's own order and no other's, and rung once on the quay before it was ever hung, so that half the town could say afterward they had heard it new before anyone else on the river did. It carried, by every account that reached the Library after, further up and down the Abhainn ìseal than any bell in the kingdom, farmers three miles off swearing they set their day by it whether they meant to or not, and Gormshuil, entering the fire and the bell in the same short passage, found herself giving the loud bell nearly as many words as the two days' burning, and let the imbalance stand once she had looked at it, on the ground that a town chooses what it wants remembered of its own hard year as much as any office in Cathair dhearg does, and a chronicle that overruled a town's own choice of what to dwell on was claiming for itself a kind of authority the office had never in fact been given.

In the north that same spring a child was born whom the chronicle of that year does not mention, and could not have: Dubhan, born mortal into the confinement the Severance had made, decades after the war that had shut the island against those from whom his line descended. No return carried his name south, and no packet brought it to Gormshuil's table.

The letter that closed her year, and that she entered last of the season's business though it had reached her some weeks before the summer's warmest days,

came from the Moot at Caol mhòr, over Walter Hale's own hand, and it was neither bare nor argued with itself in the writing, which she noticed and was glad of, having spent the better part of the winter learning again how much could ride on four plain lines. It gave, in Hale's own flat count, the number of schools the north now kept for its own children, eleven in all, from Agnes Pike's byre at Doire ghlas to a room over a chandler's shop at Ceann mhòr that had opened only that autumn, and it gave, after the eleven, a second number that the letter itself called worth the Moot's separate notice: three of the eleven, Agnes Pike's among them, had begun that year to teach some measure of Dia-thìris alongside the humans' letters and the Moot's own minutes. No order from the council asked for it, and no maor gave leave for it; parents at all three schools had simply come to the teacher and asked, wanting their children able to read a proclamation, a ledger, a shire's boundary-line, in the tongue the kingdom wrote its business in, whatever tongue the household spoke at its own hearth.

Gormshuil read the letter twice, the second time more slowly than the first, and entered it whole rather than in the short hand she gave most returns, letting the eleven schools and the three among them stand in the chronicle in something near Hale's own words, since a fact this plain needed no chronicler's shortening and would have lost by it. She thought, setting the pen down on that entry longer and more fully than she had let herself set it down on the year's harder ones, that a record could be trusted to keep a great silence honestly only if it could also be trusted to keep a small fullness honestly, the one discipline standing or falling with the other; and that whatever a reader made, a hundred years on, of the four bare lines she had given a queen's death, they would at least find, not far past them in the same book, an entry that gave a plain northern letter every word it had asked for, and could judge for themselves which kind of year the chronicler had thought she was keeping.

She copied the letter's last line into her own hand before she filed the whole of it away: *eleven, and three of the eleven now teach both*. It went into the chronicle exactly as Hale had written it, and she let it close the year's entries, the bare and the full both behind her now.

Before she put out the lamp she opened the private book again, the one no clerk copied and no council packet ever asked to see, and set beside the year's two hardest entries a line of her own that would never go south to Cathair dhearg or stand in any fair copy: that a kingdom which could give a school's letter every word it asked for, and a queen's death four lines and no more, kept two records

under one hand and one table, and that she had not yet decided, in ten years of keeping both, whether the difference was a fault in her or a fault in the year. She closed the book on the question unanswered, as she had closed it before, and set the next return, still unread, on the corner of the table for the morning.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

OF Walls under the GROUND

SE 30 AN GIBLEAN – SE 32 AN CÈITEAN

Found this season at Làrach an Dùin: walls of dressed stone, older than any building known to us, and no writing on them anywhere.

Entered as of the Old Ones, purpose unknown.

— the Library's register of finds, 3 an Giblean, SE 31, entire, as it stands at Muileann chaol

I

Of the New Hall at Cathair mhòr

The house of Mac Ùisdein had been building in stone the better part of two years before it was finished, and when it was finished the town said there was no house like it between Cathair dhearg and the sea, which was very likely true, since no one else in the kingdom had a mountain of spoil sitting idle at the mouth of his own working to quarry it from for nothing. Uisdean mac Ùisdein had taken the stone that came up broken and unsellable from the Sloc Mòr's own galleries, cart-load on cart-load of it over two winters, and set masons to dressing it into a hall with a roof of slate and a stair of the same grey stone climbing to a gallery that ran the width of the house. The Guild of Hewers held its feast there the week it was finished, tables the length of the hall and torches in iron brackets the smith had made to match no pattern but his own fancy, and men who had gone down the Sloc Mòr's shafts for twenty years sat under a roof built, as more than one of them said that night with a dry look at the man beside him, out of the very rock they had spent those twenty years bringing up.

Ailean Leabhar was not at the feast. He heard of it after, from Mòrag nic Coinnich, who had gone as the Library's own witness because somebody from Muileann chaol always went to a thing of that size, whether the Library thought it worth the going or not, on the ground that a house built to outlast its builder was exactly the kind of thing a chronicle regretted not having a clerk present for once the builder and the house were both fifty years gone. She told him the hall smelt of new mortar and old smoke in about equal measure, and that Uisdean had stood at the head of the highest table and said almost nothing, letting the guild's own master speak for the evening, which she thought, knowing the man a little, was either modesty or the surest kind of confidence there was, and that she had not been able to decide which in one evening and did not expect a second evening to settle it for her.

The licences went out that same season, and drew less notice at the time than the house did, though they would draw more before the year was out. The southern fishing grounds off Caol mhòr had been open water to whoever put a boat on them since the shires were first drawn, Dia-thìreach and Tuathaich boats working the same banks without much comment from either side, since fish did not trouble to sort themselves by the terms of a truce their forebears had made a generation before either fleet was born. That spring the maor's office at Caol mhòr began issuing licences for the grounds, in writing, and kept them for Dia-thìreach boats. The Tuathaich fleet was left the northern grounds instead, where the fishing ran thinner and where, as every man on the quay at Caol mhòr already knew without the office troubling to say it, the raiders' own boats worked too, since a coast with no licence on it was a coast with no one to complain of who fished it.

The first boat turned away under the new rule was a Tuathaich craft out of Caol mhòr itself, her master a man named Sam Ridley who had fished the southern banks since before the licences were dreamed of and who brought his catch in to the maor's own quay the day the rule took force, as he had every fair-weather day for eleven years, and was told at the scales that the catch could be weighed but the boat that had taken it had no paper for the grounds it came from and would need one before it went out again, and that papers for those grounds were not, at present, being written for boats of his fleet. Sam Ridley said little at the scales and less on the walk home, by every account that reached the Moot's own minutes at Caol mhòr that summer, but the Moot entered the day and the name all the same, since a first of anything was worth the ink even when the man it happened to had nothing further to say about it.

Doire shean, in the south-west, built its own harbour that same season, the first new harbour raised anywhere in the kingdom since the Severance without a coin of the Crown's in it. The house of the Stone at Doire shean lent the money against the town's own dues, as the order's houses had taken to doing where a town's need outran a maor's patience for petitioning Cathair dhearg, and the masons who built the mole worked to the Stone's own measure rather than the Crown's, a fact the harbour-master noted with some satisfaction in his first return and the council, so far as any packet reaching Muileann chaol ever said, noted not at all. The house took its first quarter's dues off the new quay before the mole's last course was even dry, a plain figure entered in the town's own book beside the sum it had lent, and the return that reached Muileann chaol set the two figures side by side without comment, leaving a reader to work out for himself, as Ailean did when the return crossed his own table, how many years of quarter-dues it would take the town to owe the house of the Stone rather less than it had first borrowed from it.

Of the feast in the new hall he had one further account, sent him some weeks after Mòrag's own telling by a mason who had worked the dressing of the stone and had not been asked to the tables he had spent two winters cutting, a plain enough matter and no fault, by the mason's own words, of Uisdean mac Ùisdein's, since the feast had been called for the guild and the guild held no cutter of stone among its own sworn members, whatever the man's hand had done for the walls that housed the supper. The mason wrote it to the Library without complaint, only as a thing he thought worth the record's keeping, that he had dressed the stone of a hall he was not asked to sit in, and Ailean entered the letter whole rather than in his own shorter hand, on the ground that a fact stated this plainly, and without complaint attached to it, needed no keeper's shortening, and would only have lost by it.

II

Of the Trenches at Làrach an Dùin

Ailean Leabhar was five-and-fifty that spring, keeper of the Library fifteen years, and he had learned in most of those fifteen years that the finds which mattered least to the kingdom's own business were very often the ones that cost him the most sleep, a fact he had stopped finding strange some time

before he had stopped finding it troublesome. He went down himself to Làrach an Dùin¹ on the south-east coast that year, which was not his habit, since a keeper who left Muileann chaol every time a dig opened would have had no library left to keep by the end of a season; but the diggers' first letter had used a word he did not care to take on trust from a letter, and the word was *older*.

The camp sat above a low headland where the ground had been broken by trenching since the early spring, a scatter of canvas and turf-roofed huts and a cook-fire that never quite went out, and the diggers, four of them under a foreman named Cailean who had cut trenches for the Library at three sites before this one and thought he had seen most of what the ground on Dia-thìr had to show him, met Ailean at the head of the longest trench with the particular quiet of men who wanted to be asked rather than to volunteer.

"Show me," Ailean said, and Cailean showed him.

The wall ran the length of the trench and further, a coursed stone founded so deep that the diggers had given up trying to find its footing and had cut sideways instead to follow the line of it, dressed on its face in a manner Ailean had not seen in any ruin the Library held a record of, the stone fitted so close along its joints that a knife blade would not have found the gap between one block and the next. There was no mortar in it anywhere they had cut. There was no carving on it anywhere they had cut, no sign scratched or cut or painted, nothing that a scholar could call a letter or a mark meant to be read by anyone who came after, only the wall itself, running on under the turf in a line the trenches had not yet found the end of.

"How old," Ailean said, not quite a question, since he already knew no answer he was given would satisfy him.

"Older than anything I've cut into," Cailean said, "and I've cut into the watch-fort ruins and thought those old. Whatever built this built long before any of them, and built better."

Ailean spent four days at the camp before he went home, most of them on his knees at the trench's edge with a lamp and a notebook, and what he found in those four days was less than what he did not find, which was the harder thing by far to carry back to Muileann chaol and set down in the Library's own hand. No writing. No image of a god or a beast or a man. Not a hearth-ash, not a broken pot, not a bone the diggers could say for certain was worked by a hand rather than

1. the fortress ruin

gnawed by a fox, nothing that a scholar of any faith on the island could point to and say *this tells us who they were, or what they wanted, or what they called the stream at the foot of their own wall*. Only stone, laid with a patience and a skill that put every mason Ailean had ever watched at work to shame, and then, at some point no trench had yet reached far enough to find, left.

He wrote the entry himself rather than leave it to a clerk, sitting at the foreman's own trestle by lamplight on his last night at the camp, and he wrote it short, because the alternative to short was to write a page arguing with his own ignorance, and an entry that argued with itself before it stated its fact was no entry at all, only a chronicler's private trouble dressed up as a finding. *Walls of dressed stone, older than any building known to us, and no writing on them anywhere. Of the Old Ones, purpose unknown*. He read it back twice, struck nothing, and let it stand.

III

Of Làrach an Teampaill

he rode east from Làrach an Dùin¹ rather than straight home, since the season's letters had brought him word of a second matter that could not, in honesty, wait for a second journey, and reached Làrach an Teampaill² in the district's own damp evening light with the ruin already half in shadow, a low mound of fallen stone that the local telling called a temple though nobody living, Dia-thìrich or Tuathaich, could have said whose.

He was met, before he had so much as dismounted, by three elders of the Seann Spioradan houses of the district, who had heard by the same letters that had reached him that the Library meant to open the ground, and who had come to the ruin themselves to be there when he arrived rather than trust the matter to a written petition that a keeper at Muileann chaol might set aside unread. The eldest of the three, a woman named Beathag who kept the district's own hearth-book and had walked, by her own account, to Làrach an Teampaill on every quarter-day of her life since she was old enough to be trusted with the road alone, spoke first and spoke plainly.

1. the fortress ruin

2. the temple ruin

"We are not asking you to leave it standing," she said. "It will stand or fall as the ground under it chooses, and we have never asked the Library to prop up a wall it has no business propping. We are asking you not to open it. Whatever is under that stone, it is not ours to say what it is, and it is not yours either, and a hand that goes into the ground to find out makes a claim on the finding that neither of us has the right to make."

Ailean stood at the edge of the mound a long while before he answered, the light going out of the sky behind Beathag's shoulder and the ruin's own shadow lengthening across the ground between them, and he thought, standing there, of the wall at Làrach an Dùin four days behind him, laid by hands that had left no word anywhere for anyone who came after, and of the entry he had written by lamplight, *purpose unknown*, and of how little that entry had actually told a reader once the words were counted, and how much labour the not-knowing had cost him to set down honestly rather than paper over with a guess dressed as a finding.

"I can measure it without opening it," he said at last. "The shape of the ground, the fall of the stone, what stands and what has come down, none of that needs a spade. If that answers what you're asking, I'll take the measure and leave the ground as I find it."

Beathag looked at him a moment before she answered, the way a person looks at an answer they had expected to have to argue harder for. "It answers it," she said. "We had not thought to hear it offered before we asked twice."

"I've dug one wall this week that had nothing to tell me but its own patience," Ailean said. "I don't think this one owes me more than that either, and I'd rather leave it its patience than spend a season proving I was right to want an answer it never meant to give me."

He spent two days at Làrach an Teampaill with a chain and a level rather than a spade, walking the mound's own outline and setting down, in a hand as careful as any he gave the Library's own registers, the line of the fallen wall, the height of what still stood, the lie of the ground where a doorway might once have opened toward the morning sun or might, for all his measure could tell him, have opened toward nothing a living scholar would recognise as a reason. He entered it, back at Muileann chaol a fortnight later, in four words that cost him nearly as much thought as the four he had given the wall at Làrach an Dùin: *measured, and let be*.

IV

Of the Obelisk at Cnoc bheag

The third of the season's ruins asked less of him and gave, in its own way, nearly as little back. A standing stone north of Cnoc bheag, cut with lines of a script no scholar at Muileann chaol or anywhere else on the island had ever been able to read, had stood in open pasture since before any record the Library held began, cattle rubbing their flanks against it and children chalking their own marks beside the old ones until a passing shepherd or a stricter mother scrubbed the chalk away again.

Ailean sent a scribe rather than going himself, a careful young woman named Ùna who had trained under him at copying the Library's oldest and most damaged leaves and who took to the obelisk's lines with the same patient hand she gave a torn page, kneeling at the stone's foot with a board and a soft pencil and a square of oiled cloth against the weather, and copying every stroke exactly as it stood, gap for gap where the stone had worn smooth and weathered edge for weathered edge, rather than smoothing a guessed line into a broken one the way a less careful hand might have been tempted to.

It took her the better part of three weeks, working only in fair weather, and when the copy came back to Muileann chaol Ailean set it against every script the Library's own shelves held a record of and found nothing that matched it closer than a chance resemblance any two alphabets might share by accident. He filed the copy as he had filed the walls and the temple's own measure, under the same plain heading, and sent word to the council, through the maor of Cnoc bheag, that the stone was worth a fence against the cattle if nothing else, since a thing that had stood unread for longer than the kingdom's whole span deserved at least that much keeping, whatever it turned out, in the end, to have been trying to say. The council found the money for the fence before the summer was out, four posts and a rail set well back from the stone's own foot, and the shepherds of the district, who had rubbed their cattle against it without much ceremony for as long as any of them could remember, grumbled for a season about the lost scratching-post and then, by the following spring, had mostly stopped grumbling.

V

Of the Lighthouse's Shadow

he had one other matter that season that was not his own finding, brought to him only because the Library kept the copies of everything a shire's return chose to enter, and it came from the far north-west, from the keeper of the lighthouse at Baile chrom, a Dia-threach man fifteen years at the post and still reporting, as his warrant bade him, what he saw by land as well as by sea.

He reported, in a hand Ailean thought more careful than most such reports troubled to be, that the Grey Night sect kept its yearly vigil that spring in the lighthouse's own shadow, a knot of shapes standing silent in the dark at the foot of the tower through the small hours, gone before the light came up enough to put names to any of them, and that he had made no move against them, having no order that told him a silent vigil on open ground was any business of a keeper's whose charge was the light and not the shore beneath it.

The report went south to Cathair dhearg with the season's other returns, and Ailean, copying it into the Library's own register as he copied every such return that reached him, noted what came back from the council in answer, which was nothing at all. No order to the keeper, no word to the magistrate at Baile chrom who had fined the sect's own vigil-keeper once already for holding the same watch in the open, no instruction of any kind that a clerk at Cathair dhearg troubled to set down where a copy of it might reach Muileann chaol. He entered the silence as plainly as he had entered the walls and the temple, since a council's not answering was, in its own way, as much a fact of the kingdom's year as anything it had chosen to say, and a Library that kept only the answers and not the silences would, in the end, be keeping the smaller half of the record.

VI

Of the Salt-Pans and the New Deputy

The last of the season's business reached him from the east coast rather than the west, a plainer matter than any of the others and, for that reason, one he was glad to set down last. The flats below Àth bheag had been dug for salt-pans that spring, shallow beds cut into the tidal ground and left to the sun and the slow work of the sea, and by the time the first return reached Muileann

chaol the town was already supplying salt up the coast as far as the eye of the return's own writer cared to follow it, a trade that had begun, so far as anyone at Àth bheag troubled to say, from nothing more than a man noticing that the flats held the tide long enough after each ebb to leave a white crust worth the gathering, and a second man asking why nobody had thought to help the flats do more of it on purpose.

It was on the road home from that last errand, in the early days of the summer, that Ailean told Mòrag nic Coinnich what he had been turning over since the trench at Làrach an Dùin¹, which was that fifteen years of keeping the Library alone, riding out to every dig and every dispute and every return that seemed to want a keeper's own eye on it rather than a clerk's, had begun to cost him more than the walking, and that a Library with only one person who could speak for it was a Library one bad season from having nobody who could. Mòrag had come to Muileann chaol as a girl of the district and had worked under him the better part of a decade, careful with the older leaves in a way few of the younger clerks troubled to be and quicker than any of them at telling, from a shire's ordinary return, which lines wanted a keeper's own attention and which could wait for the season's slower copying.

"You want a deputy," she said, not quite a question, when he had finished saying rather less than that directly.

"I want someone the Library can trust to speak for it when I can't be in two places at once," he said, "which this season proved I very often can't. I'd want it to be you, if you'll take it."

She said she would think on it, which he had expected, and came to him three days later with her answer, which he had also expected, though not quite so soon: that she would take it, on the condition that the Library's own register note plainly, from the first day she signed anything in its name, that she signed as deputy and not as keeper, since a record that let the two blur together, even out of kindness to a woman doing the work well, would in the end tell a later reader less truth than a record that kept the two apart. He agreed to it before she had finished the sentence, thinking, as he agreed, that she had learned the office's own discipline rather better in ten years than some keepers managed to learn it in a lifetime, and that a Library with a deputy who thought that way about her own title

1. the fortress ruin

was a Library considerably less likely to need worrying over the next time a keeper rode east and did not come home for a fortnight.

He set Ùna's copy of the obelisk into the Library's own presses himself that same week, alongside the measure of Làrach an Teampaill² and the short entry on the wall at Làrach an Dùin, three findings that told, between them, almost nothing of who had raised the stone or built the wall or asked that the temple's ground be left to its own patience, and a great deal, if a later reader troubled to notice it, of what a keeper of the Library had judged worth doing with a question he could not answer. He had measured what could be measured, copied what could be copied, and filed the not-knowing as carefully as he would have filed a certainty, so that whoever came after him, with better tools or a longer patience or simply more time than a single season allowed, would find the ground exactly as he had left it, and the question exactly as open.

2. the temple ruin

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

OF Walter Hale's Last WINTER

SE 33 AM FAOILLEACH – SE 34 AM MÀRT

I

Of the Grain-Store at Cathair fhada

The Crown's grain-store at Cathair fhada was two winters building and one summer roofing, a hall of dressed stone on the southern plain long enough that a loaded cart could turn inside it without backing into the door, and when the last course went on in the dry season the masons signed their names in the mortar under the sill, in the way of a house that expects to stand. It was filled from the south's own harvest, sack on sack carried up from threshing floors within a day's cart of the town, and the keeper set to it, a quiet man named for no one in the record, walked the rows each morning counting the sacks against a tally he kept in his coat and telling no one the sum.

The store stood full and shut through the good years that followed it. The keeper walked his rows, turned the sacks against the damp, sold off the oldest grain each autumn to make room for the new, and let the south forget the store was there, which it very soon did.

In the same season, though the two had nothing to do with one another beyond the year they shared, the second count of the island's people since the Severance went out from Cathair dhearg: clerks with their books riding the shire roads a second time, tallying hearth by hearth as the first count had. This time a second column stood beside the first, one figure for what a household held and one for what its neighbour held, Dia-threach against Tuathach, town against country.

The first count had only looked; it had set down numbers and let them lie side by side on the page for anyone with eyes to read the gap between them. The second count was built to measure the gap itself, a column of difference drawn out and summed at the foot of every shire's page and then summed again for the whole island at the bottom of the last one.

The clerks who carried the sums back to Cathair dhearg were young, most of them, riding roads they had never seen before that autumn, and not one of them was ever told the fate of the figures once they were handed over. They were bid write their own shire's page fair, seal it, and hand it across a table to a councillor's clerk who took it without a word of thanks and set it on a stack with the others, and every one of the riders who carried a page that autumn came away with the same plain sense, never spoken aloud between them on the road home, that they had been asked to measure a thing they would not themselves be shown the measure of.

The report went into the council's own keeping and stayed there. No proclamation followed it, no minute of the council's reading it was copied south to the Library, no word of its sum reached any shire clerk who might have carried it further, and the councillors who had called for the count in the first place gave out, when any of the twelve was asked directly, only that the figures wanted study before they wanted airing, a form of words that satisfied the asking without answering it. A report that measures a thing and is then locked away measures it no less truly for the locking, but it does not, for as long as the lock holds, change anything at all, and the council, whatever its reasons, chose that year to hold the lock rather than the change.

II

Of Walter Hale's Last Sittings

At Caol mhòr, that same dry season, Walter Hale sat the Moot's chair for what none of the men and women around the table yet knew to call his last winter of sitting it, though most of them, looking at him, suspected it without saying so. He was old by any account the north kept of its own, the first speaker the Moot had ever chosen, thirty-one years in the chair since a room of angry fishermen and shepherds had put him there because he could read a factor's ledger as fast as the factor himself and would not be talked past. His hands had be-

gun to shake on a cold morning in a way they had not shaken the year before, a small tremor the room would have needed to be watching for to catch, and he had taken, without saying why, to letting David set the seal to a letter rather than doing it himself.

David Hale had kept his father's minute-books at his elbow since the year of the first fair, when the fair's toll-mistress had turned his wool from the gate to a factor's stall under a rule he had not known was written, and the lesson of that turning had stayed with him longer than the wool's loss ever had. He wrote a fair hand, faster than his father's now, and had taken, these last two winters, to writing the day's business twice, once in the rough book on the table and once again that same night at his own hearth in a second hand steadier than the first, telling himself it was only practice and knowing, without quite admitting it to himself, that he was keeping a second copy against a day he did not want to name.

"You needn't do it twice," Hale told him once, catching him at the second copy by lamplight, his voice thinner that winter than the room was used to hearing it.

"It keeps my hand in," David said, which was true as far as it went and no further, and his father, who had kept a Moot's minutes long enough to know a half-answer when he heard one, let it stand without pressing it, which was its own kind of answer back.

The business that winter was ordinary enough to look at from outside: a dispute over a weir on the Abhainn lseal that two villages had fought over for longer than either could say why, a petition from Doire ghlas for a second well, the yearly reckoning of the head-due against what the shires had actually paid rather than what they owed. Hale sat through all of it steady enough, his voice carrying the length of the room as it always had even when his hands would not hold a pen without a slight travelling shake in the line, and only those who sat closest to him, David among them, marked how much longer the sittings left him afterward, sunk in his chair with his eyes shut while the room emptied around him, before he would rise and let himself be walked home.

He kept, that whole winter, a habit he had kept for thirty years without once breaking it: the first hour of any sitting given over to whoever had walked furthest to be heard, before the day's set business was opened, on the ground he had given the room the year he first took the chair and never troubled to give again, that a room which heard its own business before its furthest petitioner had already told that petitioner what it thought of the walk. A carter from beyond Àth fhada

stood that hour one grey morning with a grievance over a toll he thought wrongly charged him, and stood a long while, the room patient around him while Hale let him finish without once hurrying the telling, and when the carter had done Hale answered him himself rather than passing the matter to a clerk, in a voice that had gone thin that winter but had not gone impatient, and settled the toll in the carter's favour before the day's proper business was called. David, watching, thought his father looked more tired setting down that one small matter than he had looked settling weightier things the winter before, and said nothing of the thought to anyone.

III

Of the Twenty-Eighth of an Gearran

He died on the twenty-eighth of an Gearran, in his own bed at Caol mhòr with David beside him and Alice sent for from the school though she did not reach the house before the end, seventy-six years old by the count his own house kept, which was neither a young death nor a cruelly long-delayed one, only the ordinary close of an ordinary span, the kind the north had learned by then to expect of its own and no longer thought worth remarking on for its length alone. He had sat the Moot's chair four days before, the weir dispute settled at last in the villages' own favour rather than either party's, and had told David walking home that evening, in the flat way he said most things he meant seriously, that he thought he would let the next weir dispute be somebody else's to settle. David had taken it, at the time, for the kind of thing a tired man says after a long sitting and thought no more of it until the twenty-eighth came.

The Moot's business stopped for three days without a vote taken to stop it; nobody moved to open the room, and nobody needed to be told why not.

The whole north walked to his burial, or near enough to the whole north that the roads into Caol mhòr that week carried more feet than the fair itself had carried the autumn before, fishermen up from Cuan bheag and Ros mhòr, carters off every road into the town, shepherds off the hill country who had never once sat in the Moot's room but had heard his name read out at a dozen musters and knew it as the name a factor's letter answered to when a northern flock was turned away at a gate. They buried him at Caol mhòr within sight of the Moot's own house, the ground he had sat closest to for thirty-one years, and the Church's own

rite was said over him by a priest who had not been born when Hale first sat the chair.

The chair itself did not sit empty past the week's mourning. The Moot met on the fourth day, the room fuller than any ordinary sitting, and put the choosing to a vote before the dust of the burial mound had properly settled. Two other names were spoken before hers, a factor's son from the fair road who had money enough to be heard and a shire clerk from Doire ghlas whom half the room knew only by his letters, and both names were set aside within the same hour without much debate, the room's own sense running, though nobody troubled to say it outright, that the chair Hale had built wanted filling by someone the widows and the fishing families would call their own before they would call it a factor's or a clerk's. Mary Coyle, a fisherman's widow of Caol mhòr who had first stood to speak in that same room some nine years before and had gone on standing to speak in it since, was named speaker at the last by a count that nobody in the room troubled to call close.

She had buried a husband to the sea before she ever spoke a word in the Moot's chair, and she took Hale's chair now with the same flat quiet she had used the first time she rose to speak for the widows of Cuan bheag, no speech beyond the plain words the office required of her, no promise offered beyond what the room could see for itself in the way she sat down once the vote was read: as a woman meaning to stay in the chair for exactly as long as the room wanted her in it and not a day longer than that. Fifty-two years old that winter, she took the seal David held out to her and turned it once in her hand before she set it down at her own place, the same seal Hale's own hand had set to thirty-one years of letters, and said only, to the room rather than to David in particular, that she supposed the books had better go on being kept the way they had always been kept, which the room took, rightly, for an asking that David stay on rather than an order that he must.

David kept the books under her as he had kept them under his father, the rough copy on the table and, that first night, though he told himself afterward there was no longer any reason to keep it up, the second copy again at his own hearth, in a hand that shook rather more than his father's ever had, on a night when the keeping of it seemed to want doing whether or not it served any purpose he could have named to another soul in the room.

IV

Of the Report Asked For and Refused

Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire had ridden the shire roads with the second census the autumn before, one clerk among a dozen sent out from Cathair dhearg, and had carried her own shire's tally back to the council's clerks with her own hand on the sum at the foot of the page. Young for the work, no more than thirty, she had thought, riding home with the figures still fresh in her saddlebag, that a count taken with such care, hearth against hearth, column against column, would be read by somebody who meant to do something with what it showed. Some months on she asked whether she might see the whole of it, the island's sum rather than her own shire's part of it, telling the clerk at the door of the council's keeping-room that she had carried the figures herself and had a right, she thought, to know what they had come to add up to.

The clerk refused her, giving no reason beyond the plain fact of it, that the report was the council's own and shown to no hand that had merely helped gather it, and she did not press him further, having carried enough council business in her time to know a closed door when a clerk's flat face showed her one. That evening she wrote the asking and the refusal down in her own hand, in a private book she kept for herself and showed to no one. She could have pointed to no purpose the keeping served; she wrote it down because a thing asked and refused seemed to her worth a record all the same, in much the way a chronicler at Muileann chaol was that same winter keeping a second private book of her own for reasons she could not have named any more plainly.

V

Of the Doctors of Àth àrsaidh

At Àth àrsaidh, an easy day's ride from Caol mhòr, Eachann mac Rath had practised physic under his guild's own charter for twenty years, a careful man who set a break as well as any hand on the island and had buried, in his own accounting kept privately and never shown to the guild that licensed him, rather fewer of his patients than the guild's own average allowed for a man of his years in practice. When the Moot wrote to him that winter offering to pay his fee for the teaching of it, two Tuathaich women in his own surgery, learning what he

knew by watching him set a bone and mixing a poultice at his elbow rather than by any book, he took the offer without asking the guild's leave, on the plain ground, he told the two women when they first came to him, that a broken arm mended the same whichever hand mended it and he saw no reason a guild seal should decide who was taught to do the mending.

Ruth Ashby and Clara Tulloch came to him that am Faoilleach, two women of the fishing country about Caol mhòr who had nursed their own families and their neighbours' through fevers and birthings for years without any name for the knowledge beyond what their mothers had shown them, and Eachann set them, the first week, to nothing grander than rolling bandages and watching him work, telling them plainly that a physician's hand was built on watching before it was built on doing. They watched through the whole of that dry, hard season, the fevers that came with short water and poor grain filling his surgery faster than any two hands, his or theirs, could easily empty it, and by the spring thaw both women could set a simple break unwatched and had begun, under his eye still, to mix the plainer poultices themselves.

The guild found him out before the summer was old, a factor's wife of Àth àrsaidh mentioning at a fair stall, without malice or particular thought, that Eachann's new girls handled a lancet as steady as he did, and the word reached the guild's own hall inside the month. Two of the guild's own men rode out to see the surgery for themselves before the letter was written, and stood in the doorway watching Ruth Ashby set a child's wrist while Eachann talked her through it without once touching the arm himself, and left again without a word to either woman, which Eachann told them afterward was answer enough of what the letter would say when it came.

The guild struck him from its rolls before an Cèitean was out, the letter naming no fault in his physic, only the plain fact that he had taught outside the guild's own leave and to hands the guild's charter did not recognise as fit to be taught. He read it once at his own table, with Ruth Ashby and Clara Tulloch both there for the evening's lesson, and set it aside rather than answering it, telling the two women, when Clara asked whether the striking changed what he meant to teach them, that a guild seal had never yet set a bone and he saw no reason to let the loss of one stop him doing the one thing the seal had never actually done for him. His patients were no fewer for the guild's letter than they had been before it, and Ruth Ashby and Clara Tulloch kept coming to his surgery through that summer

and the next, learning what he had left to teach them before any guild seal stood between the teaching and the two women who wanted it.

VI

Of the Flood on the Abhainn ìseal

The Abhainn ìseal broke its banks along its lower reach in am Màrt, the longest river of the island carrying, in three days of rain harder than anyone had thought to plan against, three bridges clean away and a long stretch of the coal line's embankment with them, the rails left hanging over open water where the ground beneath them had simply gone. A carter caught on the middle bridge when the third day's rain brought the water up fastest got his horse free and lost the cart, and stood on the bank afterward watching the whole span go under inside the space of a single held breath, the timbers turning once in the current before the flood took them out of sight round the bend below the mill. No one drowned on that stretch of river that week, though two of the villages downstream lost more of their low ground than any flood in the shire's own memory had taken before, and the line's engineers, walking the embankment once the water dropped enough to let them, found nothing left to walk on for the better part of a mile.

The line shut for want of ground to run on, and the ports that had lived on the coal it carried, Ros dhomhain and the western harbours among them, turned to whatever they had laid by in their own stores against a leaner week, none of them having laid by against a season. Word of the shutting reached the yards before it reached any office that might have planned for it, and for two days the ordinary traffic of coal carts simply stopped at the washed ground and turned back the way they had come, their drivers no wiser than the townsfolk waiting at the far end for a delivery that was not coming.

Mary Coyle had sat the Moot's chair not yet a month when the first rider reached Caol mhòr with word of the washed embankment, and she called the room together the same evening rather than waiting on the week's ordinary sitting, on the plain ground, she told David as he opened the rough book to a fresh page, that a bridge does not wait on a schedule and neither, while she held the chair, would the room that had to answer for one. She gave her first order from that chair before the ink of the vote choosing her was properly dry on the older

page behind it: every northern harbour that answered to the Moot to open its own coal store and share it out by the count of hearths rather than by whoever reached the yard first, since the north's coal came down that same line and would not come again until the line itself could be walked and mended.

David wrote it into the rough book in his own hand, the first order the book carried under her name rather than his father's, and did not, that night, trouble to copy it again by his own hearth, finding, when he sat down to his lamp as he had sat down most nights of the two years before, that he no longer felt the want of the second copy he had kept so long against a day whose need for it, he saw now, had already come and gone.

Mary sat on in the room after the vote was carried and the riders sent, David gathering the loose pages of the night's business into the rough book while she waited for the last of the council to file out. She had not, she told him once the room had emptied, expected to give her first order over a broken bridge rather than over any of the ordinary business she had sat through for nine years watching another hand settle; she had thought, if she had let herself think about the chair at all before the room put her in it, that her first order would be some small thing, a licence signed or a petition answered, not a whole coast's coal rationed out on the strength of one rider's word before the damage had even been properly walked. "It is what came first," David said, closing the book, "and a chair answers what comes first or it answers nothing." She thought about that longer than the plainness of it seemed to warrant, and said, rising at last to let him bank the fire and lock the room behind them both, that she supposed a chair had never once in Hale's thirty-one years been given the luxury of choosing which order came first, and she saw no reason her own first winter in it should be the one to break that rule.

PART FIVE

Of the Fall and the Search

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Of the Hawk's Own Custodian

SE 35 AN CÈITEAN – SE 36 AN DÙBHLACHD

I

Of the Naming at Inis ìseal

The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag had kept their own hearths and their own altars for ages without asking leave of anyone south of them, and when the houses met at Inis ìseal in an Cèitean to name a custodian of their own, the asking was not for leave either. Every house sent a witness, and most sent two, so that the low stone hall by the water stood fuller than it had stood since the roof was last mended, benches carried in from three farms and set along the walls, and the smell of wet wool and peat-smoke thick enough that the door was propped from first light to last.

They named Raonaid nic Iain, whose mother's mother had kept the altar at Inis ìseal before her and whose own hands had kept it these nine years since, and they named her without a vote taken, only a standing up house by house until the hall stood, and a shout that the youngest present, a boy sent to watch the door, carried out to the road to tell whoever passed that the Hawk had its own custodian now, as the houses to the south had had theirs these thirty years.

She was not a young woman by then, past the years when a house sends its unmarried daughters to keep an altar and long past the years when anyone in the hall would have thought to ask whether she was fit for the office; she had buried a husband and raised two sons on the altar's own upkeep, gull-eggs and a widow's share of the fishing, and had sat the long vigils of the Hawk's own nights, the ones the

southern Rite kept only at its greatest feasts, every year of the nine without missing one. When the shout went up she did not answer it at once, standing at the front of the hall with her hands folded into her shawl, and it was Murchadh Ruadh of Baile fhionn, the oldest man in the room, who crossed to her and set a strip of white feather into her hand, plucked, he said, from no living bird but kept in his own house three generations against a day the Hawk houses might want a custodian to give it to.

"You'll wear it or you won't," he told her, "but it's yours now either way."

She wore it, pinned at her collar, for the rest of that day and every day after that anyone in the north ever saw her.

The white billet on the shire's own arms, a plain bar the roll had given Siorrachd Cnoc bheag thirty years back for no reason any living clerk could give, hung on a board at the back of the hall that same afternoon, and more than one witness, filing out into the wet evening, looked at it and said to whoever walked beside them that a shire whose hills held the oldest hawk-altars on the island ought by rights to carry a hawk on its own seal and not a bar that meant nothing to anybody. Nobody thought, that evening, that the saying was more than an evening's grumble. The houses had said as much before, at other namings, and the roll had never once answered them.

Each house that had sent a witness sent also, as the custom of a naming asked, something of its own hearth to be set on the altar's own step before the hall broke, a handful of meal, a coil of new-spun wool, a jar of the honey the moor bees made in Cnoc bheag's own heather, so that by the time the last house had come forward the step held more than the altar would use in a season and the overflow was carried out afterward to whichever door in the town had the least behind it that winter. It was a small thing, the giving, and none of the five witnesses who later carried word of the naming south to Cathair dhearg thought it worth putting in their telling, but Raonaid, standing at the step through the whole slow giving of it, would say afterward that the shout had told her the hall's mind, but the step filling, house by house, with more than any one house could easily spare, had told her the houses' hearts, and it was the second telling she carried longer.

The rain that had held off through the naming came on hard as the last witnesses left, and those with the furthest roads home, the farms above Baile fhionn and the two lone houses out past the moor's edge, stayed the night in the hall rather than ride it, sleeping on the benches they had carried in that morning, so that Raonaid's first night as custodian was spent, whether she had planned it or

not, with a full house of the Hawk asleep around her altar and the rain loud on a roof three farms had lately mended between them.

II

Of the Letter from Seann Skell in the South

Word of the naming reached Seann Skell on the southern coast inside the month, carried, as such word always was, by a fish-buyer's factor who thought no more of the telling than he thought of the weather he reported in the same breath. The house of the Rite's high custodian sat above the harbour there, built to the design of the man who had first held the office, Dòmhnall mac Thormoid, eleven years dead by then and long since answered for by a successor the north knew only by his letters, a careful hand that gave away nothing of the man who held it.

The letter that came back to Inis ìseal that autumn was three lines long and cost, the houses reckoned afterward, more in the riding of it than the paper it was written on was worth. It named no fault in Raonaid nic Iain, gave no reason a house could argue with, and said only that the high custodian's own order of worship, written and read at every seating south of Cnoc bheag these thirty years, knew of no office called the custodian of the Hawk houses and could not, for want of knowing it, own one. It was signed with the seal the letter's own writer never troubled to explain, a seal the north had never seen before and never troubled to ask after, and it was read aloud once in the hall at Inis ìseal and then folded and put away, not burned, not answered, only kept, in the way a house keeps a thing it means to look at again.

"He doesn't own her," Murchadh Ruadh said, when the reading was done and the hall sat quiet with it, "so we'll carry on as though he had."

Nobody in the hall thought that a strange thing to say, and nobody troubled, that autumn or after, to write south again asking the high custodian to change his mind. The houses kept their own vigils as they had kept them before the letter came, brought their own disputes to Raonaid as a custodian's disputes had always been brought to whoever the altar answered to, and let the three lines from Seann Skell sit in their folded state at the back of the hall as a fact about the south rather than a judgment on the north, which was, in its own quiet way, the only answer the letter ever got.

Raonaid herself read the letter over twice more before it went into its keeping-place, once aloud to Murchadh Ruadh alone and once again silently, by herself, at the altar the night after. She was neither young enough to be stung by the refusal nor old enough, she told Murchadh, to have stopped caring what a house in the south thought of a house in the north, and she said, folding the letter the second time, that a woman could hold both those things at once without either one winning out over the other. The fish-buyer's factor who had first carried the word north was asked, the next time his cart came through Inis ìseal, whether the house at Seann Skell had said anything more of the matter to anyone in the port below it, and he answered, with the flat honesty of a man who had carried a great many messages he understood not at all, that nobody south of the harbour had spoken of the Hawk houses since the letter went, one way or the other, as though the asking and the answering of it had already used up whatever the south meant to say on the matter for a good while yet.

It was noticed, that winter and the winters after, that no house of the Hawk sent its dead south to be buried by any rite but its own, and that no house of the Hawk sent a son or daughter south to be married under any custodian's blessing but Raonaid's, a practice none of the elder witnesses could say had ever been written down as a rule and none of the younger ones thought to question, the north simply going on keeping its own as it had always kept its own, letter or no letter.

III

Of the Order Set Down

The Hawk's own worship had never once been written in all the ages the houses had kept it, passed altar to altar by a custodian's own mouth to the ears of whoever stood the vigil beside her, each custodian carrying the whole of it in memory and handing it on the same way, a line here worn smooth by a hundred years of telling and a line there added by some long-dead keeper whose name the order no longer carried. Raonaid had it from her mother's mother the same way, sitting the long vigils as a girl and saying the words back until her tongue held them without her mind troubling over them, and she had never once, in nine years keeping the altar on her own account, thought to set any of it down.

It was a question from one of her own sons, home from the fair road that summer and asking her plainly who would carry the order whole if she died be-

fore she had passed it to whoever came after her, that turned her to the thinking of it. She had no daughter of the altar's own line grown yet to the age of learning it, only two sons neither called to the office, and she sat with the question longer than she sat with most things that were put to her, through the long evenings of an t-Sultain when the hall's business was thin and the nights long enough for a great deal of sitting.

Her son had meant the question idly, the kind of thing a man asks his mother across a hearth without expecting an answer that troubles him, and he was startled, telling it afterward to his own wife, at how long she had sat with her hands still in her lap before she answered him at all. "It would go the way the humans' own tongue went out of Ros bheag," she told him at last, "a little forgotten every year until nobody left could say what had been lost, only that something had." He had not known what to say to that, and she had not pressed him to say anything, only risen after a while and gone out to the altar alone, and it was that same night, by her own account given years later, that she first thought of the account-book with its blank pages standing unused on a shelf where her sons kept the farm's own tallies.

She began the writing in an Dàmhair of that same year, a stub of pencil and a farmer's account-book with more blank pages in it than any account had ever needed, and she wrote slowly, sounding each line to herself before she set it down to be sure the words on the page matched the words her own mother's mother had given her rather than some smoother version her own tongue might have worn them into over nine years of saying. More than once she found a line would not come to her whole until she had gone out and stood at the altar in the cold to say it, the words sitting easier in her mouth with the stone under her hand than they ever sat at a hearth with a pencil waiting, and twice that winter she woke in the dark certain she had set a word down wrong the evening before and lit a lamp to check it against the sound of her own memory rather than trust the page until morning.

It took her the better part of a season, the book filling a page at a time between the altar's ordinary business, weddings and burials and the small disputes over grazing that a custodian was asked to settle as often as any greater matter, and there were weeks that autumn when the book saw no new line at all, set aside on its shelf while a dying man in Baile fhionn wanted sitting with or a boundary quarrel between two farms wanted a custodian's own eye on the ground. When it was done at last, in the thin light of an t-Samhain, she read it through once from

the first line to the last, aloud, alone in the hall with the door shut against the wind, to hear whether it still sounded as the order had always sounded spoken rather than written, and found, she told no one but herself that morning, that it did, near enough, and that the near enough would have to serve, because a thing spoken and a thing written were never going to be the same thing entire, however careful the hand that wrote it.

She did not show the finished book to the houses, and she did not send word south of it either. She read it aloud once, on the night of an t-Samhain's full moon, to the full gathering of the Hawk houses in the hall at Inis íseal, the only reading any of them would hear that year or any year after, and when the reading was done she closed the book, tied it with a strip of the same white feather Murchadh Ruadh had given her at her own naming, and set it into the iron box the altar had kept its lamp-oil in since before her mother's mother's time, and turned the key.

"It's heard once a year," she told the hall, when one of the younger witnesses asked why the book was not left out for any house to read at its leisure, "the way it was always heard. Writing it down was only so the hearing wouldn't die with me. It was never meant to be read the way a factor reads a ledger."

The box went back onto its shelf behind the altar, and the key went onto a cord Raonaid wore under her shawl from that night forward, alongside the white feather at her collar, and no house that came to Inis íseal after that ever saw the book, only heard it, once a year, in Raonaid's own voice, exactly as the houses had always heard the Hawk's order before a single word of it had ever touched a page.

IV

Of the Hawk on the Seal

The houses' own asking, the one Murchadh Ruadh had spoken at Raonaid's naming without much thought of its ever coming to anything, was carried to Cathair dhearg that same an t-Samhain by a delegation of five, Raonaid among them though she had never once before ridden further south than the fair at Muileann òg. She rode the two days south with the white feather still pinned at her collar and the iron box's key still on its cord, and found the capital, when the delegation reached it, louder and larger than any telling of it had prepared her for, the streets about the council's own hall crowded with clerks and petitioners from

every shire on the roll, so that Murchadh Ruadh, riding at her side, remarked that a woman could stand a year's vigil at Inis ìseal and hear less noise in the whole of it than Cathair dhearg made in a single morning. They asked the council for what the houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag had asked at other namings and never been given: that the white billet the roll had carried on the shire's arms for thirty years be struck, and a hawk set in its place.

The council heard them in the same chamber where every other shire's petition was heard that season, a councillor reading the asking off the delegation's own written page in a voice that gave away no more of his own mind than the letter from Seann Skell had given of its writer's, while Raonaid stood at the front of the five with her hands folded into her shawl exactly as she had stood at her own naming, and answered, when a second councillor asked her plainly why a shire wanted a hawk rather than the bar it had always carried, only that the hills round Cnoc bheag had kept hawk-altars longer than the roll had kept its billets, and that a shire's arms ought by rights to say something true about the shire rather than nothing at all. The council gave them, against every expectation the delegation had ridden south carrying, exactly what they asked. No clerk on the council's own rolls could say what the billet had ever stood for, and a shire's arms that carried nothing anyone could read was, the council's own reasoning held, worth less to the roll than one that carried a mark the shire's own people would know at a glance for their own. The grant was written and sealed before the delegation had been a full week in the capital, the quickest business, Raonaid said afterward to the hall at Inis ìseal, that she had ever seen any council do, quicker by far than the letter from Seann Skell had taken to cross half the distance for half the news.

The maor of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag sent his own seal south with the grant to be recut, and it came back before the year was out, the plain billet gone from it and a white hawk set among the twelve crescents the shire's arms had always carried round its border, wings a little spread, the die-cutter's own touch rather than any pattern the houses had sent him. The maor himself broke the old seal's die on the flags of his own hall before the shire's assembled clerks, a small ceremony he had thought up himself and never afterward repeated for any other grant, and pressed the new one for the first time into a stick of wax held up so that every clerk in the room could see the hawk stand clear of it before the wax had properly cooled. It was the first change made to the roll at the asking of an order rather than a crown or a council's own reckoning, and the shire's clerks, entering the new seal into the rolls that autumn, wrote the fact of it plainly beside the old blaz-

on they struck through, in the flat hand clerks kept for such things and nothing more.

Raonaid held the new seal in her own two hands the day it reached Inis ìseal, turning it once to catch the light off the wing the cutter had set spread rather than folded, and said nothing for a while that any of the witnesses standing round her troubled to write down. The book in the iron box behind the altar stayed locked as it had been locked the night of the reading, its key on its cord under her shawl, unread by any hand but her own and unheard by any ear but the houses' once a year; the seal, when it was pressed to the shire's next grant, showed a hawk to anyone who cared to look, north or south of Cnoc bheag, whether the high custodian at Seann Skell chose to own the house that had asked for it or not.

V

Of What the North Carried That Year Besides

The order at Inis ìseal was not the only thing the north set down or gave up or fought over in those two years, and the Library's own later hand, gathering what Siorrachd Cnoc bheag had carried through them, set the rest beside it as its due.

At Ceann leathan in an Giblean of the following year the Còmhrag was fought as it was fought every year since the fair-wardens had first called it an old custom of arms, blades kept from the ring by a rule as old as the melee, bare hands and staves and the fighters' own weight against each other on ground already churned to mud by the crowd's own feet before the first pair was called. Six men died on the trampled ground before that year's melee was called at last, more than had ever died there in one year before, one of them a boy of Baile ghlas not yet twenty whose own mother had walked two days to stand at the ring's edge and see him fight, and stood there still when they carried him off it. The custodians of the southern Rite, who had never loved the Còmhrag and had said so quietly at every seating since it began, petitioned the fair-wardens that year to end it outright, sending a clerk with the petition written fair and sealed rather than trusting the asking to a rider's memory. The wardens read the petition in their own counting-room, above the very quays the melee's crowds filled every spring, and refused it inside the hour, on the plain ground, their answer said, that Ceann leathan lived off those crowds as much as it lived off anything the sea or the coal line brought it,

and a town does not vote itself poor to please a custodian who does not keep its books.

The circus came to Ceann leathan that same autumn, An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn¹ pitching its tents on the trampled ground within a week of the six burials, its wagons painted in colours the mud had not yet had time to dull and its callers crying a show of tumblers and a caged wolf from the eastern hills to crowds that the fair-wardens had counted rightly would stay on after the melee rather than scatter home early with their pockets still part full. It was said afterward, though no one who said it could point to the hand that had written the letter, that the wardens themselves had paid the circus to come that particular year, the timing too neat for anyone who had watched a Còmhrag before to call it chance, and the boy of Baile ghlas's own mother, so the telling went, walked past the tents on her way home without once turning her head toward them.

The railway reached Ceann leathan the same season, the last miles of embankment laid through ground the coal line's engineers had put off for two summers running for the softness of it, driven pile by pile until it would bear the weight, so that coal might be carried down to a second harbour and shipped from quays that had known nothing heavier than a fishing boat's catch before that year. The first coal-ship out of the new quays loaded by lamplight the following an Dùbhlachd, her master reckoning the tide would not wait on daylight and the shore gang working the chutes through a night colder than any of them had dressed for, so that the record of it, kept by the harbour clerk more from habit than from any sense that the night wanted remembering, noted only the hour and the tonnage and the men's own complaint of the cold, nothing more. The town's own walls, built to hold the Ceann leathan the fair had made of it, held nothing of the Ceann leathan the coal line made of it after, and by the second winter the quays had spread a good half-mile beyond the old gate with no wall following them, so that a stranger riding in from the coast road could no longer say with any certainty where the old town ended and the new one began.

On the west coast that same year Ros bheag opened its own yard for the building of coal-ships, the first yard the western ports had kept for themselves rather than sending south to Ros dhomhain for every hull they needed built or mended, its first keel laid on ground that had been a drying-green for nets the summer before. The shipwrights of Ros dhomhain, whose guild had held the whole coast's

1. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

building trade to itself since before any of them now living could remember a rival yard, carried their protest to the guild court at Cathair dhearg and lost it there in a single sitting, the court's own ruling holding that a guild's charter bound its members to the guild's own standard of work and not to any single yard's monopoly of the coast. The eldest of the Ros dhomhain masters, who had ridden south himself to speak the protest, was heard to say on the road home that he had lost more trade to a single morning's ruling than his own father had lost in forty years of storms, and no one who heard him say it troubled to tell him he was wrong. Ros dhomhain's shipwrights went on building what work still came to them, and Ros bheag's new yard took the rest, and within the year the western ports no longer sent so much as a rowing-boat south for mending.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Of the Silver at Depth

SE 37 AM FAOILLEACH – SE 39 AN T-ÒGMHIOS

Received of the silver guild of Muileann chiar, its charter renewed under the restored custom, seal and signatures entire, this day. Filed.
— the council's receipt, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37, as the Library renders
it

I

Of the Faces below the Old Working

I ain mac Ruairidh was past forty, and eleven years at the silver works at Muileann chiar, where the Mine Board had sent him the summer it gave him his receipt. He had stayed on long enough that the townsfolk no longer called him the Board's man from the west but simply Iain, the surveyor, as if the works had grown him themselves out of their own rock, and the old workings he had been sent to measure ran shallow, and the new ones, the ones he measured now, did not.

The silver at Muileann chiar had always been worked from the surface down, the old shafts no deeper than a tall house is high, sunk by hands that had learned the seam close to daylight and never troubled to ask what lay beneath it, since a seam that gave silver at arm's length gave a man no reason to dig further for it. It was Iain's own chain, run down a new shaft cut on the strength of nothing more than a hunch one of the guild's own captains had carried for thirty years and never had the coin to test, that first proved the seam ran richer the deeper it was followed. Every worked vein Iain had ever measured before had thinned with depth; this one thickened, the ore darker and heavier in the hand the further down the

new gallery went. He checked the figures three times before he wrote them fair, the same habit that had served him at the Sloc Mòr, and found them holding each time, to within the chain's own inch.

He carried the new figures to the guild hall himself rather than send them by a boy, walking the short distance from the shaft's mouth to the hall's door with the roll under his coat against the rain, and found the guild's own masters gathered already, word of the deep gallery's yield having outrun his own walking by the better part of a morning. The old silver guild of Muileann chiar had kept its charter since before the Severance, a charter the humans' own Administration had let stand unaltered through the whole of their years on the island, on the plain ground, it was said, that silver troubled nobody's coal and a guild that troubled nobody was a guild worth leaving be. The charter had lapsed with the Administration's own going, along with every other paper the humans' hand had signed, and the guild had gone on working the shallow seam these thirty-odd years on custom alone, its captains meeting and its journeymen bound by no writing any court south of Muileann chiar would trouble to uphold if a dispute ever came to one.

He stood in the guild hall's doorway that morning longer than the walk from the shaft had left him breath for, the masters' own talk running ahead of him faster than he could get a word into it, one captain already reckoning aloud what a deeper gallery might be worth to the guild's own share and another asking, more soberly, whether the timbering that held for a shallow working would hold for a deep one, a question Iain thought worth asking and had not yet an answer for. He set the roll down on the hall's long table and let them argue over it a while before he spoke, on the plain habit, learned at the Sloc Mòr, that a room arguing over a survey it has not yet properly read will argue better once it has read it, and unrolled the sheet himself when the noise had thinned enough to let him.

"It will hold," he told the captain who had asked about the timbering, "if it is timbered the way I have drawn it and not the way custom drew the shallow shafts, and not an inch cheaper," and the captain, who had expected a surveyor's usual hedging, looked at him a moment before answering that he supposed a man who had walked the figures three times over had earned the right to say so plainly. A guild working a seam that ran to nothing was a guild the council could safely leave uncharted; a guild sitting on ore that ran the other way, richer with every fathom, was a different matter, and the charter that came back from Cathair dhearg that spring, under the restored custom the council had by then given a

dozen older trades, bound the guild's captains to the Crown's own tithe on every bar struck and gave the guild, in return, the courts' own force behind its bindings. Iain's figures went south with the petition that asked for it, unrolled this time and read entire by three men who had not troubled to unroll his first survey eleven years before, a fact he noted to himself without saying it aloud to anyone at the guild hall, and pinned the noting, in his own private book, beside the older entry it answered.

II

Of the Blanks and the Gold below Baile dhìreach

The deep gallery's silver came up faster, once the new shaft was properly timbered, than the mint at Cathair dhearg could refine it, more ore reaching the capital in a single season than the mint's own furnaces had ever been built to answer, and the council, rather than build the mint larger at the Crown's own cost, gave the refining out to the villages of the eastern hills, whose smiths had worked what little silver came their way for generations on nothing grander than a hearth-forge and a patient hand. The villages took the guild's rough bar and worked it down to the mint's own fineness and measure, paid by the pound of finished metal rather than by the day, a bargain the council's clerks reckoned cheap and the villages, who had never before been paid for anything by the Crown's own hand, reckoned otherwise.

It was at Baile dhìreach, lowest of the eastern villages and nearest the stream that ran off the hills above it, that a smith named for no particular skill beyond his father's trade before him found that the same stream which turned his forge's own wheel carried gold in its gravel, fine grains of it caught in the same pan a boy might use to wash grit from a well. He said nothing of it for a season, working the guild's silver bar as he had been bid and washing his own pan only of an evening when the forge was banked, until the gold he had put by, a modest handful, was worth more than he could easily account for to a maor's clerk who came asking why a village smith kept coin he had no wages to show for. He told the clerk the plain truth rather than invent a lie he would have to keep, and the clerk, to the smith's own surprise, thanked him for the telling and carried the matter south rather than fining him for the withholding.

The council added the stream's gold to the villages' own charge that same year, washed and weighed alongside the silver bar and struck into the same blanks the mint's own dies pressed for the realm-coin, so that a coin drawn at random from any shire's till that year might carry, unmarked and unremarked, a grain of Baile dhìreach's own stream in its weight. The first blanks struck under the new arrangement went west from the eastern hills in am Faoilleach, carried by the same clerk who had first asked the smith his question, riding a road he had ridden a hundred times before on the guild's ordinary business and reckoning, this once, that he carried something worth minding on the way. He handed the blanks to the mint's own master at Cathair dhearg with no more ceremony than a carter handing over a load of grain, and the master weighed them, found the sum true to the fraction the villages' own reckoning had promised, and signed for them without comment, which the clerk took, riding home, for the highest praise the mint's own hand was ever likely to give anybody.

The villages were paid by weight that spring and every spring after, the payment carried up from Cathair dhearg in a locked box a maor's rider brought once the quarter's blanks were counted, and the smith who had found the gold in his own pan, whose name the villages kept among themselves though no royal book troubled to record it, was said by his neighbours to have washed that same stream every evening of his life after, long past the years his own forge still needed the wage, on the plain habit, he told anyone who asked him why, of a man who has once found a thing worth finding and sees no reason to stop looking for it again.

III

Of Mòr nic Dhòmhnaill

Domhnall the elder, Mòr's own father, had refined silver for the old guild longer than any other hand at Muileann chiar, a careful worker who could tell the fineness of a bar by its ring on the anvil before the assayer's own scale confirmed it, and his daughter had grown up at his elbow the way a smith's own daughter grows up at a forge, learning the work by watching it long before anyone thought to teach it to her outright. She was past thirty herself the year Iain's survey proved the deep gallery, unmarried by then longer than the town thought usual for a refiner's own daughter, having kept her father's books and weighed his bar since her mother's death without much time left over, she

told anyone who asked her plainly why, for the kind of courting a town like Muileann chlar expected of its women.

Iain had known her some years before the guild's charter was renewed, the two of them meeting first over a dispute about the true weight of a bar the guild's own scale and the Board's own scale had returned two different figures for, a dispute Iain was sent to settle and Mòr was sent, by her father who trusted her hand more than his own that week, to argue her family's side of. She proved him wrong in front of three of the guild's own captains, walking him through the weighing twice to show him where his own scale's beam sat a hair's breadth off true, and he thanked her for it rather than taking offence, a response she found rarer in a Board man than she had been led to expect and said so to her father that same evening.

They were married in am Faoilleach of the year the deep gallery's charter was signed, a plain ceremony at the guild hall rather than any grander house, the same long table that had held Iain's survey the season before cleared and scrubbed and laid with what the guild's own wives could put together on short notice, bread and the guild's own store of dried fish and a cask a departing wool-factor had left against a debt nobody now troubled to collect. Mòr's father gave her hand himself, his own voice steadier at the giving of it than Iain had ever heard it over a disputed bar, and the guild's captains stood witness in place of any kin Iain had thought to bring from the west, since his own people were a hard two days' distance and a Board man's postings did not run to much visiting. One of the captains, the same who had doubted the timbering, stood and said, when the guild's own custom called for a witness to speak, that he had watched a great many surveys come through that hall and never one that had married into it before, which the room took for the nearest thing to a blessing the man was ever likely to give anybody, and Mòr laughed longer at it than the joke quite earned, which Iain took for the truer blessing of the two.

Mòr kept her own name at the guild's books after the marriage, as a refiner's daughter's name was worth more on a ledger than a surveyor's, and the two of them kept, that first year, two households' worth of habits under the one roof, Mòr rising before first light to weigh the night's cooling bar while it was easiest read and Iain gone before she had finished to whatever gallery the week's work called him to, so that David the guild's own boy, who carried messages between the forge and the shaft-head, joked that he served two masters under one roof and never caught them at the same meal twice running. Iain told her on their first

evening as man and wife that he had reckoned, walking east from the Sloc Mòr those eleven years before, that he was walking toward a posting and had not once reckoned he was walking toward a wife, a confession she took, she told him, as the nearest thing to a compliment a surveyor's tongue was ever likely to manage, and answered that she had reckoned, watching him lose an argument over a scale's true beam in front of three of her father's own captains, that she was watching a man honest enough to be worth the losing of an argument to, which she meant, she told him, as the higher compliment of the two.

IV

Of the Two Towns Called Dùn thais

There were two towns on the island that answered to the one name, Dùn thais, one on the west coast within a morning's ride of Ros bheag and the other far to the east, seat of its own shire and its own dues, and the confusion the two had caused the royal record since the drawing of the shires had never yet troubled anyone enough to be untangled, since neither town's business had often crossed the other's on any page a clerk at Cathair dhearg was likely to read in the same sitting. That changed, in its small way, the same year the eastern hills' first blanks went to the mint, when both towns' names reached the capital in the same season's post.

The western Dùn thais asked, that spring, for a court of the sea to be set over its own harbour, to judge salvage and wreck along a stretch of coast that had gone without any such ruling since the Severance, its fishermen having settled such disputes among themselves by custom until a wrecked hulk driven ashore the autumn before proved too rich a prize for custom alone to divide without hard words on both sides of it. The council granted the court within the season, and its first sitting, held on the strand with the hulk still canted where the tide had left it, awarded the wreck whole to the crews who had driven it aground rather than let it lie for whoever claimed it first, a ruling the fishermen carried home more pleased with the court's plain justice than with the timber it won them.

The eastern Dùn thais, in the same season, opened a covered market for the hill farms that had traded in its square uncovered since the town was first walled, a long timbered hall raised at the shire's own charge to keep the autumn's grain dry through a market day, its first trading held under a roof that smelled, the farmers

said, more of new-cut wood than of the produce it sheltered. The clerk at Cathair dhearg who filed the eastern town's petition for its market alongside the western town's petition for its court, both arriving within the same week and both signed only "Dùn thais" without further marking, entered the two matters against the one town's name in the royal record before a second clerk, reading the file a fortnight later, caught that a market and a sea-court could hardly belong to a single harbourless hill town in the same season and set the error right by hand, a correction that held for exactly as long as it took the next season's post to bring the next confusion.

Neither town troubled itself over the mistake once it reached their own ears, each reckoning, in the way of a town used to being the only Dùn thais its own shire had ever needed to distinguish, that the fault lay in the capital's own carelessness and not in any likeness between the two of them, and the royal record went on confusing the pair a while longer yet, court and market alike filed sometimes rightly and sometimes not. A factor from the western town, riding south that same year on business of his own, was twice asked by clerks at Cathair dhearg after the covered market's own takings, a question he could not answer and thought, at first, a poor joke at his expense, until he understood that the clerk before him held no joke at all, only a file that had never once been told there were two towns to keep apart. He carried the tale home to the western harbour more amused by it than aggrieved, and it was told at that town's own hearths for years after, growing a little in the telling each time, that the capital itself could not tell a sea-court from a market roof so long as both bore the one name.

V

Of the Petition from Baile chiar

Doire chaol, the village laid out south of the capital in the first years after the Severance for the families that served the royal household, had grown in the years since from a scattering of houses built for clerks and stewards into a town proper, its own market crowded of a market day and its own disputes running thicker than the maor of Baile chiar, whose shire the village sat within, had ever troubled to answer for when it was smaller. The maor wrote to the council that same year, plainly and without much ornament, that Doire chaol's business had outgrown a seat five miles distant and asked that the village be given a

maor of its own rather than go on being governed, badly and at second hand, from a hall it took the better part of a morning to reach on the village's own worst roads.

The council read the petition alongside a dozen others that season and granted it before the summer was old, the only shire cut new from an older one since the original drawing had first set the island's bounds, Siorrachd Doire chaol entered onto the roll with its own arms, its own dues, and a maor of its own choosing rather than the Baile chiar man's deputy who had kept its peace, badly, these many years. The Baile chiar maor himself, reading the grant, was heard by his own clerk to say only that he was glad of the lightening, having governed a village he could not properly see to for longer than he cared to own, and sent the new shire's first dues south the same season with a note wishing its new maor better luck of it than he had had.

VI

Of the Shepherd above Doire uaine

The hills above Doire uaine had been grazed thin by shepherds for as long as any flock had run there, save one stretch of high ground the shepherds themselves would not put a beast to, a shoulder of hill where the old writings the town's own keeper still had by heart told of a thing that was dead and did not rest, the Marbh-bheò¹ the writings named it and no shepherd living had ever seen with his own eyes, though every one of them could point to the ground it was said to keep. It was custom rather than any written rule that kept the flocks off that shoulder, the kind of custom a hill country keeps without troubling to ask itself why, and it had held, the keeper reckoned, since before her own grandmother's telling of it.

A shepherd new to that country, a young man down from the north hired that season for want of local hands enough to cover the lambing, put his own flock to the shoulder's grass one evening rather than walk them the longer way round it, the grass there thicker than anywhere else on the hill and the light already going, and did not come down again. His dog came down alone the next morning, and the flock scattered wide over ground it had never before been let to graze, and the

1. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

town searched the shoulder three days running without finding more of him than a crook left standing where the ground pitched steep, driven into the turf as a man might drive it who meant to climb rather than fall.

The magistrate who wrote the matter into the shire's own book, a careful man who had no more taste than his own clerks for setting an old story down as a court's own finding, entered wolves as the cause, a beast or beasts unaccounted for having come down off the higher ground that season, a finding the town's own shepherds neither argued nor believed, since no wolf had been seen on that hill in living memory and none was seen after, but a finding that let the book close on the matter without asking the court to rule on a thing older than any court the island kept. The keeper who held the old writings by heart said nothing against the magistrate's entry when it was read to her, only that the shoulder would go on being grazed thin and empty whatever the book called the cause of it, and the shepherds, who had never needed the book's word to keep off that ground before the finding and needed it no more after, went on keeping off it exactly as they always had.

The young shepherd's crook was brought down off the hill and given to his own family, who had walked three days from the north to claim what little of him the shoulder had left to claim, and the mother, standing at the magistrate's own door with the crook in her two hands, asked him plainly whether he believed his own entry, wolves being a thing she had shepherded thirty years herself without once losing a beast to. The magistrate, who had asked himself the same question more than once in the writing of it, told her only that the book wanted a cause it could hold, and that a mother burying a son deserved a finding she could carry home and set before a shire court if ever she wanted to, which a hillside's old writing, however faithfully kept, was never going to give her. She took the crook and the finding both, and thanked him for neither more nor less than the truth he had given her, and walked the three days back north with her son's own crook wrapped in her shawl the whole way.

VII

Of the Copy Iain Kept

Iain wrote the guild's new charter into his own private book the same evening it was signed, in the plain hand he kept for entries he meant to be able to find

again without searching, beside the receipt the Board had given him eleven years before and the deep gallery's own figures, set down fair the week he first proved them. He had kept the habit since his first survey, a second record held against the day the Board's own copy might be lost, mislaid, or simply not shown to the hand that had earned the showing of it, and he had never yet had cause to open the book for any purpose grander than his own satisfaction that the figures, wherever the Board's own copies went, still existed somewhere a man could put his hand to them.

Mòr found him at it one evening that autumn, the book open on the table between them while she totted the guild's own weekly weighing at his elbow, and asked him, not for the first time, why a Board man troubled to keep a second copy of business the Board itself was paid to keep straight. He told her what he had told nobody else in eleven years of the keeping, that the vein at the Sloc Mòr had thinned exactly as his first survey said it would and no living soul at Cathair mhòr had ever once told him so, the figures simply vanishing into the Board's own files the day he handed them over and never once being spoken of to him again, so that a man might work eleven years for a Board that had proved him right and never learn it from any mouth but his own reckoning. The silver at Muileann chiar ran the other way, richer with every fathom where the coal at the Sloc Mòr had run thinner with every one, and Iain told her, closing the book, that he meant to go on keeping his own copy of both truths for as long as the Board went on keeping its own counsel about either of them, a thing that seemed to him, though he did not put it in those words to her, less like caution now than like the plainest kind of accounting a man could keep against a kingdom that told him only what it chose to.

He put the book away on its shelf, silver charter and coal survey held the same distance from his own reaching hand, and walked out with Mòr to the stream below the town, where the light was going the way it went in that country at that season, thin and long over the hills, and said nothing more of the Board that evening, the two of them standing a while at the water's edge before the cold turned them back toward the forge's own banked warmth and the guild's ledgers waiting, unfinished, on the table they had left.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

OF the Fall at Muileann dhearg

SE 39 AN T-IUCHAR – SE 40 AN T-SAMHAIN

Cha d'fhuair a' bheinn fois a-riamh, is cha d'fhuair sinne. The
mountain never got its rest, and neither did we.

I

Of the First Day of an t-Iuchar

Muileann dhearg had grown fat on the Sloc Mòr's overflow for thirty years, a town of narrow streets and spoil-stone chapels five miles from the great shaft, its own pits worked to keep the Sloc Mòr's yield steady in the seasons when the greater mine's own galleries wanted rest the Crown would not grant them. The Cill ghlas district under Muileann dhearg had stood shut from the humans' time until the Board reopened it, and the men who went down into it that first morning of an t-Iuchar knew its name the way every hewer on the mountain knew it, the way a house knows a grave it does not visit. Scàineadh Cill ghlas¹, the Rending, had taken the old workings in the Age of Strangers, and the timbers that came up afterward, what little of them came up whole, were kept for a season in the guild hall at Achadh dhomhain before anyone could bear to burn them. The new gallery ran a hundred fathoms east of where the old one had run, along a line the Board's own surveyors had walked twice and marked sound on the map both times. It had been working four months.

1. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

It gave at the fourth hour past midnight shift-change, when the day gang was down and the night gang not yet up, so that for one turn of the clock the gallery held more men than it would hold at any other hour of the twenty-four. Nobody afterward could say what brought it down, only that the roof let go along its whole length at once rather than falling face by face the way a bad roof usually gives a man time to run from, and that the noise of it was heard on the surface as a single long note, like a bell struck once and left to die away underground instead of in the air. Thirty-one men were in the gallery. None of them came up alive.

Word reached Muileann chiar the following evening, carried by a rider the Board sent without much urgency, since it was a mine matter and Iain mac Ruairidh was thirteen years at the silver works and no longer, by the Board's own reckoning, a mine matter himself. The rider found him at his own door with Mòr beside him, the two of them newly enough married that neighbours still called across the yard to wish them well of an evening, and he read the message once standing in the doorway and once again sitting down, and said nothing to his wife beyond that he would be a week gone, perhaps more.

He was chainman first at the Sloc Mòr before he was Board surveyor anywhere else, and Cill ghlais was ground he had walked as a boy learning the chain from Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin, who had walked it as a boy under the man before him. He rode through the night rather than wait for morning, the twenty miles by the coal road and then the cart track up from Achadh dhomhain, and came into Muileann dhearg with the horse blown and his own legs near as unsteady under him, to find the town already at its digging, torches ringing the pit mouth and women carrying water up from the wash-house in relays that had not stopped since the fall.

They let him down on the second rope, the first having been given to the guild's own overman, and he went the whole hundred fathoms with a lamp in one hand and the guild's rope in the other, over rubble that shifted under his boots in ways rubble should not shift, until the beam of his lamp found the roof-line where it had let go and he stood a long while looking at it before he spoke to the man behind him.

"Bring me a level," he said. "And send to Muileann chiar for the old sheets I keep there. Not the Board's. Mine."

They brought him the level before the old maps came, since the maps had to be sent for from Muileann chiar and would not reach him before the second day. He spent the dark hours of that first night on his knees along the fallen roof-line,

the level laid flat and a boy holding the lamp steady over his shoulder, and marked chalk figures on a slate the rubble dust settled over as fast as he could write them. The overman, a broad man named for no reason this book keeps to it, crouched beside him a while and asked, once, whether the fault ran under the working faces still open to the north.

"It runs under half the district," Iain Mapa said. "I don't yet know which half is the safer half."

"Then we bring up what we can and shut the rest."

"That's my own thought, aye. I'll want it in writing that it was my thought and not the Board's, before I put my name to closing a working that four months of Board surveys called sound."

The overman said nothing to that beyond a short breath that was not quite a laugh, and went back to the rope.

II

Of the Rules Made for the Dia-thìrich

It took four days to bring up the thirty-one, working by relays through galleries that groaned at every stroke of the pick, and on the fifth day the whole district was closed on Iain Mapa's own word before the Board at Cathair mhòr had so much as read his report. He had found the fault by the second day: a line of broken ground running north-east under the new gallery exactly where the Rending's own line had run under the old one in the humans' time, so close to the surface survey's marked boundary that a man drawing the map by lamplight, in a hurry, might have set his pencil a hair's width wrong and never known it. A Board that surveyed a district once and called the survey finished had made an ordinary error, the kind any board might make. The mountain itself had not finished moving simply because a map said it had stopped.

The old maps reached him on the third day, brought up from Muileann chiar by a rider who had ridden as hard coming as Iain Mapa himself had ridden going, three rolled sheets Iain had copied years before from the custodians' old rolls, older in their first drawing than any paper the Board kept at Cathair mhòr, drawn by hands long dead in a script the Board's own clerks could no longer easily read. He unrolled them on a trestle set up in the open air beside the pit mouth, weighting the corners with stones against a wind that wanted to carry them off toward

the burying-ground, and laid his own new chalk figures over the old ink line by line until the two agreed to within a fathom along the whole length of the fault. The old surveyors, whoever they had been, had known exactly where the ground was broken. They had marked it, in a hand gone brown with age, with a single word he had to hold the lamp close to read: *fàgte*. Left. Let be.

The dead were buried at Muileann dhearg in a single ground broken for them at the edge of the town's own burying-yard, thirty-one graves dug in two days by every man in the town not needed underground, the custodian of the district reading over each in turn rather than once over all, since the families asked it that way and the custodian did not argue. Iain Mapa stood at the ground's edge through the whole of it, hat in hand, and was asked by more than one widow, in the flat voice grief leaves people with, whether the ground had been marked sound. He answered every one of them the same way. It had.

He did not tell the widows what the level had told him in the dark of the first night, that the ground had been marked sound by men who had walked it with a chain and a lamp and had not walked it far enough, or often enough, or with the old lists of the Rending laid open beside their own paper while they walked. It would have told the widows nothing they could use, and he had learned enough of the Board by then to know that a truth spoken over a grave and a truth written into a report the Board would read did not need to be spoken in the same words, or even, always, by the same man. The level's figures he kept on his slate until he could copy them fair, washing the chalk dust off with his own hand rather than a boy's, the way a man washes a thing he means to use again.

The Board's rules followed within the month, new orders for the digging of any gallery within a mile of ground the old lists named as struck by a calamity, timber doubled, a second survey required before any face was opened, a bell-line run the whole length of a new working so that a fall anywhere along it could be heard at both ends at once. They were good rules, and Iain Mapa, reading them at Muileann dhearg where the Board sent them to him first as the man who had closed the district, found nothing in them he would have changed. They were written for the Sloc Mòr and its daughter workings, where Dia-thìreach hewers held the guild's own oath and the guild's own voice to ask for them. At the western pits, where Tuathaich hands worked under Dia-thìreach overseers on ground the guild had never chartered, the same order went out on the same day's post and was kept the way an order is kept by men who know no one south of them will come to check.

It is told of Àth leathan, where the overseer's own name is not given in any record the Library holds, that the new rule for timbering was posted on the pit-head door within the week, in the Board's own hand, and that the timber the rule called for was ordered from the yard at Ceann mhòr the same week, and paid for out of the pit's own accounts, and never came. The overseer's books, kept in the flat hand overseers kept for such things, show the order and the payment both, entered on facing pages, with no third entry anywhere to say why the carts never left the yard. The hewers at Àth leathan went on working the old way, under the old timber, because a man with a family to feed does not stop hewing coal to ask a question the pit-head door has already answered him with a posted order he cannot read.

Iain Mapa did not go to Àth leathan that autumn. He heard of it the way the Board heard of most things from the western pits, sideways, in a clerk's letter meant for another matter that mentioned the timber order in passing, as a thing settled, and he kept the letter. Thirteen years before, at Cathair dhearg, he had learned what a receipt was worth against a Board that did not read what it filed, and he had begun, without quite deciding to, the habit of keeping every paper that crossed his own hand a second time before he let it go.

He wrote his own letter that same week, at the table Mòr kept for him by the window, naming the fault at Cill ghlais by its true line, citing the survey he had made thirteen years before of the faces of the Sloc Mòr, and setting the two beside each other on the page: a mountain that did not rest, and a Board that surveyed it once and called the matter closed. He wrote until past midnight, by his own lamp, and read it through twice, and folded it, and did not seal it.

"You'll send that," Mòr said, from the door, in a voice that was not quite a question.

"I sent one before," he said. "They gave me a receipt for it and moved me to the silver."

"This one names thirty-one dead, not a thinning seam."

"It names the same Board." He turned the letter over once on the table, as though weighing it in his hand might tell him something the words on it could not. "A receipt is a fine thing to have kept, thirteen years on. I've never once had cause to use it."

Mòr said nothing further that night. She had married a surveyor and not a clerk of the Moot, and she had learned in a year of marriage that there were silences of his best left alone, and this, she judged, was one of them. He put the let-

ter in the drawer where he kept the receipt, unsealed, and left it there, and if he took it out again in the weeks that followed, to read over or to add a line to, no one at Muileann chiar ever saw him do it.

III

Of the Sixty and the Forty

Muileann dhearg did not fill again the way it had filled in the first years of the concession, on wages and the promise of work. Forty families left Achadh dhomhain before the autumn was out, walking south to the fishing ports with what a cart would carry, and the town's own tally-clerk, entering their names off the roll, wrote against each one only *gone south*, since the roll kept no other word for it. Some had lost no one in the fall and went anyway, saying to whoever asked that a town could grieve thirty-one men once and go on living beside their graves, but a family did not choose to raise its own sons under a mountain that had shown, once, what it thought of a survey.

The Guild of Hewers, whose rolls the fall had thinned by thirty-one at a stroke, bound sixty apprentices that same season to fill them, boys sworn in at Achadh dhomhain with a hand laid on a lump of coal in the guild's own hall, the oath read out by the guild's eldest master in the same words it had been read in since the charter, each boy's father standing behind him in a line that ran the length of the hall and out its door into the yard. Not one of the sixty was Tuatha-ich. The guild's charter had said, since the Holy Age custom was taken up again, that it was for Dia-thìreach applicants, and the charter was kept, so that the pits that had just buried thirty-one Dia-thìreach hewers filled their rolls again with Dia-thìreach boys, and the western pits, where the dying was no less real for going uncounted, filled theirs with whatever hands the overseers could hire by the day and let go by the day when the work was thin.

At Caol mhòr, where the north's own minute-book had carried the fall as four lines the week it happened and nothing since, Mary Coyle read the Board's new rules when a copy reached the Moot by way of a carter who had seen them posted at Ceann mhòr, and sat with them a long while before she called for the book. She wrote to the Board that autumn, in her own hand, asking that the same rules be kept in fact as well as in the posting at the western pits, and named Àth leathan by

name, and the timber that had not come. She sent it by the same carter's road the goods went south by, since the Moot had no faster road to send anything by.

The letter reached Cathair mhòr within the fortnight and was answered within the month, in three lines, thanking the Moot for its concern and stating that the matter had been referred to the district overseer for his report. No report was ever filed. The letter was kept, in the press where the Board kept what it had no further use for, and a clerk's hand noted its arrival on the cover in the same flat script that had noted the timber order at Àth leathan on facing pages a season before. Mary Coyle asked the carter, the next time he came north, whether he had heard anything more of it. He had not. She wrote nothing further that year. The book at Caol mhòr held her one letter and the Board's three lines, and nothing between them, and that was the whole of what the kingdom's own record held of Àth leathan's timber.

IV

Of the Third Day of an t-Sultain

The Library at Muileann chaol kept its own account of that autumn apart from anything Iain Mapa saw or heard, and it is from the Library's own record, and not from any word that reached him at Muileann dhearg, that this book takes what follows.

Ailean Leabhar had kept the Library four-and-twenty years, first among the wet rolls in the cellar and then among the chests the shires sent up one by one, and he had grown old in the keeping the way the rolls themselves grew old, a little more brittle each year, the hand that had once carried a torch down a stair now needing a boy to carry the lamp for him. He was four-and-sixty that autumn, though he had stopped, some years before, letting anyone at Muileann chaol mark his birthday, saying that a keeper's business was other men's years and not his own. He kept to his desk through most of an Lùnastal and into an t-Sultain, reading, as he had read every autumn for a decade, the harvest returns the shires sent up, and he was found there on the morning of the third day of the month, at his own desk, with the returns for Siorrachd Doire chaol open under his hand and his pen laid down beside them rather than dropped, so that Mòrag nic Coinnich, who found him, said afterward that he looked to have finished the line he was writing before he stopped.

They buried him two days after, in the small ground behind the Library, where no keeper had been buried before him because no keeper before him had held the office long enough to be thought of as belonging to the place rather than merely working in it. The town of Muileann chaol turned out for it near to the last household, since there was scarcely a family in the shire the Library's own chests had not, in four-and-twenty years, asked something of, a grave-list copied or a boundary confirmed or a name set right against a parish book gone soft with damp. Mòrag nic Coinnich read nothing over him beyond his own words, the ones a clerk had once used in his hearing and that he had answered without meaning the answer to outlast him.

"The Library settles nothing," she said, at the grave's edge, in a voice that carried no further than the nearest rows of mourners. "It only keeps."

She was named keeper before the month was out, the council at Cathair dhearg confirming what Muileann chaol had already taken for settled the day Ailean Leabhar was found at his desk, and she began, within her first week in the office, a practice no keeper before her had kept: writing beside each item that came into the chests, in a small hand at the foot of its own entry, where it had come from and who had sent it and on what day. She gave no reason for the practice when she was asked, beyond that a thing a Library could not trace back to its own hand was a thing the Library could be told anything about, and she had watched, in all her years at Ailean Leabhar's own elbow, how often the Board's word and the shire's word and the north's word, laid side by side, did not agree.

Eight years his deputy by then, she knew which chests he had never finished sorting and which he had gone back to twice and still called unfinished, and she spent her first month as keeper doing what she told no one at the time she was doing: going through his own desk, drawer by drawer, in case some paper he had meant to file lay there still, undone. She found nothing from Muileann dhearg, and nothing from Àth leathan, since neither the Board's silence on the one nor its three lines on the other had ever been sent to the Library at all. What she found, at the back of the lowest drawer, was a single sheet in his own hand, headed only with a date some years old, that read, in its whole: *what we are not sent, we cannot keep. Ask the shires again.* She could not say, reading it, whether it was a note to himself or the first line of a letter he had never finished, and she kept it, unfiled, in the drawer of her own desk, where it stayed the whole of her time as keeper.

V

Of the Fire at the Fair

The fair at Muileann òg had stood nineteen years by that Samhain, the greatest gathering the island kept, its stalls running three full days along the river meadow below the toll-house where Oighrig nic Mhathain had kept the rules since the first year, a woman of fifty now, grey at the temple, still walking the whole length of the ground herself each morning before the gates opened, the way she had walked it the first year with the rules not yet a season old.

The fire ran on the eve of the feast, after the gates were shut and most of the stall-holders gone to their lodgings, starting, so far as anyone could afterward say, in the timber stacked behind the weavers' row for the mending of trestles, and running before the wind caught it properly along a row of canvas and dry wood that had stood in the same ground, packed close, for three days running. It went from stall to stall faster than any man on the ground that night could outrun it on foot, the canvas roofs catching each in turn with a sound one witness likened to a sail taken aback in a hard squall, and by the time the bucket-chain from the river was properly formed the weavers' row and half the chandlers' beyond it stood already past saving.

Oighrig was in the ground herself when it started, having gone back for a ledger left in the toll-house, and she was seen by more than one witness beating at the canvas with her own cloak before the men who came running got the worst of it turned aside from the stalls that held the season's whole trade for a dozen towns. She did not leave the ground until the last of the flame along the weavers' row had been beaten down or burned out on its own, and it was only then, in the grey light before dawn, that anyone thought to look closely at her hands.

The court sat the next morning in the trampled field, since the toll-house had burned with the rest, Oighrig presiding from a chair a stall-holder carried out for her, her hands and one side of her face bound in linen already gone brown at the edges, and the fair went on that day and the next as the rules said it must, since a fair once opened could not, by the rules she herself had written nineteen years before, be closed before its third day without the toll-mistress's own word, and she gave no such word. She died of the burns before the month was out, at her own house at Muileann òg, the toll-mistress's chair going, for the first time since the fair began, to a woman who had not held it from the first year.

That same winter the Rail Board, asked by the Moot to carry the north's wool south to the fair as it had carried southern goods for twenty years, refused the carriage, citing the fair's own rule that Tuathaich goods be sold only through Diathreach factors and holding that a rule written for the selling of goods bound the carrying of them as well, a reading no clerk at the Board had troubled to make in any of the twenty years before. Mary Coyle wrote a second letter that winter, shorter than the first, asking only whether the Board's reading of the rule was new or had always stood and simply never before been used against the north's own goods. The Board did not answer it. A clerk's hand noted its arrival on the cover, in the same flat script, and filed it beside the first.

The wool went south the old way that year, loaded onto carts at Caol mhòr in the first cold week of an Dùbhlachd, five days on the road by Cnoc ghorm and Àth fhada to the fair at Muileann òg, the carters wrapped against a wind that had not yet learned to be as hard as it would be by the time they reached the coast, the last of the north's trade for that year going south the way it had gone before there was ever a railway to refuse it. The new toll-mistress at Muileann òg, keeping the fair's rules as Oighrig had left them, sold the wool through its factors when it came, as the rule said she must, and entered the sale in the fair's own book under the makers' shire and not their names, as the book had always kept it.

Iain Mapa, at Muileann dhearg that same week, closing out the district's books before the district itself was let stand idle through the winter, wrote nothing new to the letter in his drawer, and sent nothing south beyond the district's own accounts, which the Board read.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

OF the CARTERS' Road

SE 41 AM FAOILLEACH – SE 42 AN T-IUCHAR

Entered this day, on the word of the widow at Àth fhada, one name:
her husband, lost under the western pits in the spring gone by. No
other book will hold it. This one will.
— the first entry of Clàr nan Leòn, 28 an Dùbhlachd, SE 41, as the
Moot's clerks kept it

I

Of the Road the North Named

The Rail Board's refusal stood through the whole of that winter, and the wool of the north went south the only way left to it, by cart, five days on the road from Muileann leathan to the fair at Muileann òg, and Daniel Frayne rode with the second train of carts that left in am Faoilleach, having asked leave to go himself, the Moot having sent no one before him and nobody troubling that winter to say him no. He was thirty-six that winter, a clerk of the Moot since before he could properly be called a man, and he had spent most of those years at a table at Caol mhòr with other men's words in front of him and had not, until that winter, ridden further from the northern shires than a day's walking would carry him.

The road the carts took was no road the Board's own maps troubled to draw, being nothing more than the old way the Tuathaich had always known between one northern town and the next, worn by feet and cart-wheels rather than laid by any surveyor's chain: out from Muileann leathan by Cnoc ghorm, where the church built for the Ros bheag bell stood with its door open to the carters of a

market morning, and on by Àth fhada, where the ford that gave the town its name ran shallow enough in that season for the carts to cross without unloading, and down at last by the old way to Inis àrsaidh, where the road proper began and the wool went on by a track the fair's own toll-keepers knew and taxed. Frayne rode the whole of it on a borrowed horse he handled worse than he handled a pen, and said as much to the carter beside him on the second day, who laughed and told him a Moot clerk's hands were worth more to the north whole than broken on a green horse's account, and to hold the rein looser.

It was at Àth fhada that the first house opened its door to the carters as an inn proper rather than as a household doing a neighbour's kindness, the family that kept it having fed carters at their own table for two winters running before one of them, a woman near sixty who had buried a husband under the western pits and raised four children on what the mine paid a widow, reckoned that a house that fed twenty men a night on its own charity might as well be paid for the feeding. She hung no sign, having none to hang and no coin to cut one, but she kept a lamp lit in her window past the hour any other house in the town kept one lit, and the carters came to know the lamp before they knew her name, and called the house by it. Within the season two more households on the road had done the same, at Cnoc ghorm and at a crossing short of Inis àrsaidh, each lit lamp answering the one before it, so that a carter riding that road by night in the second winter of the wool's going by cart could find his bed by the lights alone, without once asking a stranger the way.

Frayne asked the widow at Àth fhada, on the second night he lodged under her lamp, what the carters called the road they rode, having heard no one name it before that journey and having wondered, riding it, whether a way so plainly worn by use had ever been given a name at all. She told him plainly that the north had always called it the Carters' Road, and had called it so since before the wool went by cart at all, back to the years when the same track carried salt and grain between the northern towns before any fair at Muileann òg had reason to want either, and that the name had simply grown to fit the newer use as a coat is let out to fit a growing child, without anyone troubling to cut a new one. He asked her, being a clerk and unable to leave a fact alone once he had it, what the south called the same road, and she told him, without much interest in the answer, that she did not know the south troubled to call it anything, the road not existing on any map south of Cnoc ghorm that she had ever heard of a southern man consulting. Frayne wrote the two facts down in the small book he carried for the Moot's busi-

ness, the north's name and the south's silence side by side, and thought, riding on the third morning with the carts strung out ahead of him on a road no southern chart would own, that a thing could be entirely real to one half of an island and entirely absent from the other half's account of the same island, and that this seemed to him, turning the thought over as the horse found its own footing better than his hands found the rein, the truest thing the journey had shown him.

The weather held fair the first three days and broke on the fourth, a cold rain out of the west that found every gap in a carter's coat and turned the road's worn ruts to standing water by the time the train came down off the higher ground short of Inis àrsaidh, and Frayne, who had never in his years at a Moot table learned what it was to sit a horse in rain that did not let up, understood before the day was out why the carters rode in wide-brimmed hats no Caol mhòr clerk troubled to own. The lead carter, an old man who had driven the same road for the wool before Frayne was born and for salt and grain before that, told him, when Frayne asked how the carts would cross the low ground with the water standing as it was, that a road worn as long as this one had been worn found its own way round a flood the way a stream finds its own way round a stone, and that the carts would sit a night at the crossing short of Inis àrsaidh and go on when the water dropped, which they did, losing half a day to the weather and none of the wool to it.

It was at that same crossing, waiting out the rain under the third of the road's new lamps, that Frayne fell into talk with a Tuathaich family of the western pits travelling the other way, north from the fair with a season's wages and a cart of goods a southern factor had let them buy against the wool not yet sold, and heard from them, for the first time in his own hearing rather than at second hand in a Moot report, how a family that had never owned land of its own reckoned the road's five days against a season's whole earning. The husband told him plainly that the road cost the north more than the south ever troubled to count, a cart and a team and five days of a man's labour spent getting wool to a fair that would have carried it in a single day by rail had the Board's own rule allowed it, and that the toll the carters paid in time was a toll no ledger at Cathair dhearg would ever be asked to enter against the fair's own profit. Frayne wrote the figure down as the man gave it to him, a season's wages set against five days twice over for every cart the north sent south, and thought, riding on once the water had dropped enough to let the carts through, that a fact set down in a clerk's small book travelled no

further than that book's own covers unless someone with the standing to be heard troubled to carry it further.

The carts reached Muileann òg on the fifth day, as they always did, and the wool was sold by the factors the fair's own rule required, at a price the carters reckoned fair enough for the road behind them and mean enough for the road they knew the profit was truly measured against, and Frayne stood at the fair's own edge a while watching the factors' clerks weigh and mark the bales before he turned to find the inn the carts' own drivers used, a house that took Tuathaich custom without comment because its owner had learned, over enough seasons, that a carter's coin spent as well as any other man's. He rode home the same road he had ridden out, five days back by the same lamps, the water dropped now and the going easier, carrying nothing the Moot could point to as the fruit of the journey save the two facts in his small book, the north's name for the road and the south's silence about it, a season's wages weighed against five days twice told, and a callus on his right hand he had not had going out.

II

Of the Boy Who Watched

In the north in those years Dubhan was a boy of twelve. He grew up watching a caste that did not age hold every true advantage on an island to whose edge his own forebears had been pushed, and the coal was never his to inherit. Of him the chronicle of those years says nothing more, and the Library has nothing more to give.

III

Of the Register Begun

Mary Coyle called the Moot's clerks to the room at Caol mhòr in an Dùbhlachd of that same year, Frayne among them, home from the carters' road some months and back at his usual table, and told them plainly what she had told no one outside the room before that morning: that the Board kept no count of the Tuathaich dead and maimed in the western pits bey-

ond what the census swept up in its own careless net, a number without a name attached to it anywhere a hewer's own family could ever put a finger to, and that the Moot, having no Board of its own to answer to and no council above it to forbid the keeping, would begin a book that named them one by one, on the families' own word since no other word was going to be offered.

"We have no rolls to draw the names from," Frayne said, the first objection any clerk in the room troubled to raise aloud, "and a name taken on a widow's word alone, with nothing to check it against, is a name a southern court would throw out before it read the second line." Mary Coyle answered him that she had not asked the room to keep a book a southern court would honour, only a book that would be true, and that a widow's own word, given in a room with her neighbours to hear it, was truth enough for any book the Moot troubled to keep, whatever a court south of Caol mhòr chose to call it.

The book was opened that same week, a plain ledger bound at Muileann leathan and carried north still smelling of the binder's glue, and the first name entered in it was the husband of the widow at Àth fhada whose lamp Frayne had lodged under not a year before, brought to the room by a neighbour of hers who had walked the road south on other business and thought, hearing the Moot's new business spoken of, to carry the widow's name along with him rather than let it wait for a season she might not trouble to make the journey herself. Frayne wrote the entry in his own hand, the widow's husband's name and the pit he had died under and the season it had happened in, and set the pen down a moment before the ink was dry, having understood, in the writing of that single line, that he had just done the one thing his years at a Moot table had never yet let him do, which was to put a Tuathaich name into a book that meant to keep it rather than to file it and forget it. He told Mary Coyle, handing her the ledger to read over, that he did not know how many names the book would want before it was done, and she told him that neither did she, and that not knowing was the whole of the reason for keeping it.

The register grew through that winter and the spring after, a name and a place and a season at a time, entered on no evidence stronger than a family's own remembering and checked against nothing but the room's own trust in the family that gave it. Frayne kept the second book himself, a working ledger where a name was first set down rough before it was copied fair into Clàr nan Leòn¹ proper, and

1. the register of the wounded

he found, within the first month of the keeping, that the work asked more of a clerk than the careful hand he had brought to it out of habit. A name given at second hand by a neighbour wanted checking, where checking could be had, against whatever other neighbour or kinsman might confirm the season and the pit, the Moot trusting the neighbour's word well enough and asking only that a register meant to outlast the men who kept it be made as right as a clerk's own care could make it; and more than one entry that winter was set down first as one thing and corrected within the season to another, a season misremembered, a pit's own name given wrong by a family that had moved twice since the death and forgotten which working had taken the man.

Mary Coyle read every entry before it went into the fair copy, a habit she kept up through that whole first year though the room's other business left her little enough time for it, and told Frayne, the evening he brought her the twentieth name, that she meant to go on reading each one herself for as long as her eyes held out, since a book kept for the dead deserved at least one pair of eyes that troubled to read it whole rather than trusting the work entire to a clerk's own hand, however careful that hand had proved itself. She asked him, that same evening, whether the work weighed on him more than the Moot's ordinary business had, and he told her, after a silence longer than the question seemed to want, that it did, and that he had not expected it to, having spent enough years copying grimmer reports than most clerks ever saw without the copying troubling his sleep before. What troubled him now, he said, was not the dying, which the north had always known and grieved in its own way, but the knowing that a name written nowhere else might, if his own hand slipped or his own memory failed some winter years off, be lost a second time, this once for good; and Mary Coyle told him that this was exactly why the book was bound in leather rather than stitched in paper, and kept in the Moot's own strongbox rather than on any clerk's open shelf, so that no single hand's slipping would be given the chance to lose it.

By the year's end the register held above thirty names, carried to every western pit's own captain that the Moot's clerks could reach and copied out a second time, against fire or flood, into a spare book kept apart from the first at a house in Muileann leathan that had never once been troubled by a southern search, so that a name lost to the Board's own count might yet be found in Clàr nan Leòn, the register of the hurt, kept at Caol mhòr and sent south to no court, no Board, and no council that had never once asked to see it.

IV

Of the Chronicle Laid Down

Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill had kept the royal chronicle at Muileann chaol for four and twenty years by that summer, the first to hold the office, and she told the Library's own keeper, Mòrag nic Coinnich, in an t-Iuchar of SE 42, that her hand had begun to shake on a long day's writing in a way it had not shaken when she was young at the work, and that a chronicle written in a shaking hand was a poorer gift to the years after her than a chronicle handed, in good time, to a younger one. She wrote her last entry that same week, a plain list, kept in the same hand she had kept every list before it, of what the chronicle under her care had gone four and twenty years without setting down: the northern towns' own accounts of themselves, the humans' old treaties in their own tongue, and the Board's surveys, which the Board kept at Cathair mhòr. She struck nothing from the list once it was written, and asked no one's leave to write it, and set the pen down for the last time as chronicler on a page that named, more honestly than any page she had written before it, the shape of everything she had not been able to write.

Tormod mac Sheumais came after her, the clerk who had ridden the first chronicle circuit and had sat at her elbow at Muileann chaol ever since, and who wrote, once he sat at the desk Gormshuil had kept, in the hand so quick that it had long since won him the name Tormod Pinn. He copied Gormshuil's last list into the front of his own first book, word for word, and struck nothing out of it either, telling Mòrag, who asked him why a new chronicler would open his own book with an old one's account of what was missing rather than with a fresh page of his own, that a list of gaps was worth more copied whole than left behind to be found and re-written by whoever came after him with less patience for the finding.

V

Of the Keel at Ros mhòr

The shipwrights turned out of the southern guild yards in the years the guilds first closed their doors to Tuathaich hands had scattered along the northern coast in ones and twos since, mending what boats the north

already owned and building nothing new, the timber and the coin for a proper yard being beyond what any one of them could raise alone. It was at Ros mhòr, in am Faoilleach of SE 41, that enough of them came together at last to lay a keel of their own on the open strand, the harbour there deep enough for a hull of any size the north was likely to want and far enough from the southern yards that no guild master troubled to ride up and ask under what charter they worked.

Harry Marlow stood at the head of them, grey now and further from the boy who had first been bound apprentice at a southern yard than he had ever expected to find himself, and it was his own hand that laid the yard's first keel, cut and set to the lines he had taken, rib by rib, off the old wreck on the Cuan shean hard, the humans' own lines, low and full in the bow, that had gone out of southern fashion the year the guilds decided a Tuathaich hand had no business building anything a Dia-thìreach captain might one day sail. He told the men working beside him, the first morning the keel was laid true and pinned, that he had spent thirty years building other men's boats to other men's rules, and that he meant to spend whatever years were left him building his own boats to a rule he could stand behind, whatever a southern guild chose to call the result.

The hull went up through that year and the next on evenings and Sabbaths, and by an Cèitean of SE 42 the men had a shed over the slip and called the place a yard, the yard's men keeping their day's wage at whatever work would still have a Tuathaich hand and giving the boatyard what hours were left over, timber bought a plank at a time from whatever coin the yard's own men could spare and coin from Ros mhòr households who wanted no share in the finished boat beyond the knowing that it had been built. A southern factor riding through that spring, on business that had nothing to do with boats, stopped long enough at the harbour to look the frame over and told Harry Marlow, not unkindly, that a hull built on Sabbaths and evenings by men paid nothing for the building of it would want two years where a guild yard wanted one, and Marlow told him that two years of a man's own boat was worth more to the man than one year of another man's, an answer the factor turned over a while before riding on without troubling to argue it further.

It stood ready for the water in an t-Iuchar of SE 42, swifter in the eye of anyone who had built a boat before than anything the southern yards had launched in a long season, low in the bow and quick to answer, the humans' old lines proved again on northern water by hands the south had told, not many years before, that such lines were no longer theirs to build. Harry Marlow put his own

shoulder to the launching with the rest of the yard's men, the rollers greased and the tide judged to the hour by a man who had judged tides at a southern yard before any of the younger hands beside him had been born, and the hull took the water clean, riding upright and true from its very first wave without the roll a badly trimmed hull will sometimes show a crowd on its first meeting with the sea. The men who had cut its timber and pinned its keel stood on the strand at Ros mhòr and watched it ride, the first boat the north had built entire to its own name since the yards first turned them away, and said little, having spent thirty years among them learning that a boat that answers true says more for itself than any man standing on the strand beside it ever could; and Harry Marlow, wading out to lay his own hand once more on the hull's cold planking before the crew took her out past the harbour mouth, told no one in particular, though more than one man on the strand heard him say it, that his father had cast dead coin into ploughshares in a smithy at Doire mhin and lived to see the north plough its own furrows with them, and that he meant, himself, to live long enough to see the north sail its own waters in hulls it had built with no southern guild's leave asked for and none given.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Of the Unlit Ships

SE 43 AN GIBLEAN – SE 45 AN DÙBHLACHD

An Dùbhlachd, night the ninth. No moon. A sail crossed under the light going north, showing no lamp fore or aft. I could not read her build. Marked her heading and the hour and nothing else, having nothing else to mark.
— the log kept at Taigh-solais Baile ìseal, its first year

I

Of the List Copied and the Grain That Came North

Tormod Pinn kept, in the front of the first book he wrote as royal chronicler, the list his predecessor had left him of what no chronicle yet held, 25 an Giblean, SE 43, the northern towns' own accounts of themselves, the humans' old treaties in their own tongue, the Board's surveys; and it is told of him that in the second year of his keeping, riding the southern circuit Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill had ridden before him, he wrote on a leaf of its own, and not beneath her list, which he would not add to, a line of his own: that a gap named was worth more than a gap forgotten.

That same spring the dry years came again to the country about Achadh shean, 3 an Cèitean, SE 43, where the ground had failed once before in the humans' own time and been given a name for it that the shire's own people had never troubled to forget, Tiormachd Achadh shean¹, the drought of the old field. The rains that should have come with am Màrt held off through an Giblean and into an Cèitean, and the wells the households of the drove road had drawn from

1. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

since before any living farmer's grandfather went first brackish and then, in three of them, dry to the stone, so that the maor of Siorrachd Achadh shean, a careful man who kept his own tally of every well's yield the way a miser keeps a coin-count, sent word south before the second month of the dry was out rather than wait, as an older maor might have waited, for the harvest itself to fail and prove the need past arguing. He wrote in his own petition, copied afterward into the shire's own chest, that a man could argue with a poor harvest for a season and still bring in enough at the edges to call it a harvest; a well gone to the stone argued with no one, and gave nothing back to be argued over.

The council answered faster than the north had ever known it to answer anything, and it is set down in the royal chronicle, in Tormod's own quick hand, why: the grain that went to Achadh shean that year came from a store built ten years before at Cathair fhada, on the southern plain, a Crown store raised great enough to feed the whole south a season and filled twice over from the south's own harvests before ever a dry year gave it reason to open its doors, and it was opened now for the first time since the masons had raised it, 9 am Faoilleach, SE 44, its grain carried north not by road, which would have taken a fortnight and lost a tenth of the load to spoilage on the way, but by the coal line, the same rails that carried the Sloc Mòr's coal south carrying grain north instead for the length of one season, the Rail Board charging the council in full for the carriage and the council paying it without the argument a poorer year might have forced. The first wagons of it reached the sidings at Achadh shean on a morning wet enough at last with the season's first proper rain that the maor stood in the yard to watch them unloaded with his own boots sunk an inch in mud he had prayed six weeks for, and told the carters, half in earnest and half as a joke against himself, that the grain had plainly waited on the roof to prove it was not wanted before it troubled to come.

No one in the shire died of the drought that year, a fact the chronicle set down in four words and no more, and the maor had twelve wells dug to the rock along the whole length of the drove road before the following winter, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 43, each one cut deep enough to answer a dry year worse than this one and each marked, at his own order, with the name of the shire and the name of the council that had paid for the digging, so that no household drawing water from them in a harder year to come would forget whose grain had answered the last one. Four of the twelve held water still, by the Library's later reckoning, long after the rest of that dry spring was a line in a chronicle and nothing more, and a fifth

stood dry from the day it was dug, cut, as the well-diggers themselves owned afterward without much shame in the owning, on the word of a dowser's hazel rather than on any survey a Board man would have troubled to make first.

It is the way of a record kept at one desk to see a season's want answered and set the answering down as though the answering were the whole of the matter, and Tormod Pinn's own hand, careful as it was, did not trouble that spring to ask what a store built ten years before a want, and opened the very first time a want arose, might mean for a shire whose want came slower and less kindly than a single dry spring on the coal road. That question belonged, that year, to a different coast, and a different kind of keeper.

II

Of the Keeper at the Point

The light at Baile Íseal stood on a low point of rock at the eastern edge of the island, south of the ford-town for whose salt-pans the coast was known, where the land ran out flat and treeless into a grey sea that showed nothing on a clear day but its own horizon and, on the worst nights of an Dùbhlachd, nothing at all beyond the reach of the lamp's own light. Murchadh mac Coinnich had kept it four years by the spring the dry years came to Achadh shean, a Diathreach of one-and-thirty that spring, given the post by the Lighthouse Board on the recommendation of an uncle who had kept a smaller light on the western coast and judged the boy steady enough for a post where steadiness, more than any other virtue a keeper might be asked for, was the whole of the office.

He had a wife, and a daughter not yet three, and a house of two rooms built onto the lighthouse's own base so that the stair to the lamp-room rose straight out of the kitchen, an arrangement his wife complained of on a smoky evening and was glad of on a night the wind came hard enough off the sea to make the walk from any separate dwelling a misery. The work of the post was simple to describe and endless to perform: the lamp trimmed and lit an hour before the light itself was needed and kept burning through whatever hours the season demanded, the oil accounted for to the half-pint in a book the Board's own inspector checked twice a year, the glass kept clean of salt against a wind that fouled it within a week of any cleaning, and a log kept, as every light on the coast kept one, of the weather and the hour the lamp was lit and doused and nothing more than

that, a book that in Murchadh's first four years at the post held nothing a stranger reading it after him would have called worth the keeping.

The inspector who rode out from the Lighthouse Board's own office twice a year to check the oil against the book was a dry, exact man who had kept a light himself in his own youth and judged every keeper he inspected against the standard of his own remembered diligence, and he told Murchadh, on the visit before the dry year at Achadh shean was three months old, that the log of Baile iséal was the tidiest he read on the whole eastern round and the emptiest, both facts said in the same even voice and neither meant, so far as Murchadh could tell, as either praise or complaint. Murchadh took the remark for a compliment at the time, having nothing yet to set against an empty book but the honest fact that the coast had given him nothing to fill it with, and it was some months before he came to hear the same remark differently, as a question asked without the asking of it, whether a book kept tidy because nothing troubled it was the same thing as a book that answered for a coast truly at peace.

The coast below the light was a Dia-thìreach coast in name and a mixed one in fact, the salt-pans of Àth bheag worked by Dia-thìreach ford-keepers and the boats that ran the coast between Àth bheag and the towns north of it crewed as often by Tuathaich hands as not, since the fishing grounds off that shore paid no closer attention to a man's people than the fish themselves did. Murchadh knew most of the boats by sight before he knew half their owners by name, the way a keeper comes to know a coast, by the shape a hull makes crossing under his own light at an hour he has learned to expect it and by the absence of a shape at an hour he has learned to expect that too. He had watched, in his first four years, the ordinary traffic of an ordinary coast, herring boats out before first light and salt-barges working the tide up to Àth bheag's own quay, and had set none of it down beyond the bare fact the Board required of him, weather fair, lamp lit at the customary hour, nothing to report.

III

Of the Burning of the Salt-Sheds

It was in an Gearran of the next year, the dry spring at Achadh shean not yet forgotten in the chronicle that had just finished setting it down, that ships flying no flag of any house or kingdom stood in toward the coast below Baile

iseal in the small hours of a night with cloud enough to hide a good part of the moon, 7 an Gearran, SE 44, and put men ashore who fired the salt-sheds at Àth bheag before the shore watchers on the dunes, doubled since the raiding off Cath-air gheal some years before but still no more than two men and a lantern, had done more than raise the alarm. Murchadh saw the glow from his own lamp-room before he understood what it was, a low red smear along the coast to the south where no fire had any business standing at that hour, and he woke his wife and sent her for the nearest household with a horse while he kept the light burning as the Board required of him whatever else was burning along the same coast that night, since a keeper who let his own lamp gutter to run toward another man's fire left every ship still at sea to find the rocks by guesswork.

The sheds burned through what remained of the night and into the first grey of morning, three long low buildings where the salt was dried and stored against the winter trade, and by the time the alarm had carried far enough to bring men from Àth bheag with buckets and what the tide could spare them, there was little left to save beyond the stone footings and a stack of barrels too far from the fire's own heart to catch. The ships were gone before any boat could be crewed to follow them, standing off again into the same dark they had come out of, and it was two full days before the kingdom's own patrol boats, summoned from the harbour that kept them and rowed by men who had heard of the burning only when a rider reached them, came down the coast to look the ruin over and find, as the chronicle set it down afterward in a line that carried more in its plainness than any longer telling would have, the sheds cold.

Murchadh rode down to Àth bheag himself the second morning, once relief had come for the light and he could leave it in another man's hands for half a day, and stood with the ford-keepers among the wet ash and the barrel-hoops the fire had left standing when the staves inside them burned away, and heard from a woman whose own family's trade the sheds had held a season's whole salt for what she thought of a coast the kingdom's own patrol thought worth two days' notice to reach. "They will build it again," she told him, a plain fact she had settled with herself before he ever rode down rather than any comfort offered him, "and it will burn again, and the boats will come the third day next time as they came the second this time, being no faster for having been asked before." Murchadh had no answer for her that satisfied him at the giving of it, and rode home along the coast road turning the plainness of her fact over in a way the ordinary business of a lighthouse had never before given him reason to.

He asked her, before he left, how she had known to look for the ships coming rather than simply to grieve the sheds once they were gone, and she told him that her own father had kept the same trade before her and had taught her, as a girl too young to carry a full basket of the dried salt, to watch the horizon at an hour no honest boat troubled to be abroad, since a coast that made its living from the sea learned the sea's dishonest hours the way a farmer learns a bad neighbour's habits, by long unhappy practice and no help from any book. It struck him, riding home, that the woman's own father had kept a kind of watch for years that no Board had ever asked of him and no chronicle had ever thought to record, and that the watch had done the shed no good at all the one night it mattered, for want of anywhere further than her own two eyes to carry what she saw.

The sheds were raised again within the year, the Crown paying a third of the cost as it had paid a third of Cuan dhearg's relief a generation before and the shire's own households the rest, timber and stone going up through the autumn while the salt trade limped along on what the barrels spared from the fire could carry; and the patrol's own captain, called to answer for the two days before the shire's own maor, wrote a report that named the distance, the wind, and the hour the alarm had first reached his own harbour, a report the Board judged honest and the households of Àth bheag judged, when a copy of it was read to them at the market cross, an accounting that answered every question but the one that mattered, which was what a shore two days from help was worth calling a shore the kingdom kept at all.

IV

Of the Log Begun

Murchadh went back to his light that same week no wiser than the woman among the ash had left him, but changed in a way that took him some months to put a name to, watching now, on every ordinary night the coast gave him, for a sail that carried no light where an honest boat would carry one, 12 an t-Samhain, SE 44. He said nothing of it to the Board, whose own instructions asked no more of him than the weather and the hour, and he set down nothing of it in the book the Board's own inspector checked, but he kept, from the first night after the burning that the sea gave him anything at all to watch, a second book of his own, bought with his own coin from a Muileann

leathan binder a carter brought up the coast that autumn, in which he wrote what the Board's book had no line for: every ship that crossed under his light showing no lamp, her heading so far as the dark let him judge it, and the hour to the nearest half of the glass.

The first entry, made on a clouded night in an t-Samhain, nine months after the burning, ran to no more than the line the epigraph of this telling carries whole, a sail crossing north under no lamp of her own and a keeper with nothing to mark of her beyond the fact of her passing; and Murchadh, closing the book that first night, judged the entry worth less than the ink it had cost him, having named nothing a stranger reading it after him could use to know one dark sail from another. It was the fishermen of Àth bheag, more than any instruction the Board had ever sent him, who taught him within the season what a keeper's own eye alone would not have found, that a coast worked as long as this one had been worked came, in time, to know its unwelcome visitors nearly as well as it knew its own boats, by the cut of a sail against a grey sky or the particular black of a hull no honest builder on the island trimmed that colour, and had names for what it knew whether any book of the Crown's troubled to record them or not.

He heard the first of the names from an old salt-carrier at Àth bheag's own quay, a man who had watched the coast from a boat's deck longer than Murchadh had watched it from a tower, who told him, of a low black hull that had crossed twice under the light that autumn showing no lamp either time, that the coast called her An Ròn Dubh¹, the black seal, for the way she rode low and dark and vanished under a wave's own shadow before a watcher's eye had properly found her; and of a second, swifter and paler in her lines, that the coast called An Fhaoileag², the gull, for a habit of standing well out by day and closing only with the dark, the way a gull stands off a boat's wake until the catch is hauled and the guts go over the side. Murchadh set both names into his own book that same evening, against the two crossings he had already logged without a name to give them, and found, doing it, that a name changed what a bare heading and an hour had been until then; a sail without a name was one more unlit shape among however many the sea sent him, and a sail with one was a thing a keeper could watch for, expect, and, in time, begin to know the habits of, as surely as he knew the habits of the herring boats that crossed under his light by day with every lamp they owned burning honestly against the coming dark.

1. the black seal

2. the gull

He kept the book from that season on with a care he had never given the Board's own log, ruling each page himself with a straight-edge before he ever wrote in it and setting a second lamp by the table where he wrote so that no error of a tired hand at a late hour might blur a heading he could no longer check by morning. His wife asked him once, watching him rule a fresh page by a lamp he could ill afford to burn twice in one night, why a book no one had asked him to keep should want a straighter margin than the Board's own book got, and he told her, turning the question over longer than a simple answer seemed to want, that a book nobody had asked for was the one book a keeper could be sure no one else would trouble to keep straight in his place, and that this alone made it worth more care rather than less.

By the following an Dùbhlachd, a full year into the keeping of his own book, Murchadh had entered above thirty crossings, most of them nameless still and a dozen given one or other of the two names the coast had furnished him, along with the weather of each night and, where the light let him judge it, the number of men he could make out at a hull's rail; and it was from that year's book, carried south by a Library clerk that winter, that the royal chronicle first drew the two names, An Ròn Dubh and An Fhaoileag, 9 am Faoilleach, SE 45, setting them into the realm's own record for the first time with no better source to credit them to than a lighthouse keeper's private ledger and the salt-carriers of a coast the kingdom's patrol had answered, once, two days too late. Tormod Pinn, reading the book a Library clerk had carried south for his own chronicle's sake, wrote beneath the copied names that a coast kept its own record whether the Crown troubled to ask for one or not, and that this book, more than the patrol's report or the shire's own petition, was the truest account the kingdom yet held of what sailed its eastern water unlit.

V

Of the Champion of Àth ghlas

In that same winter, a good way south and west of the light Murchadh kept, the Còmhrag at Ceann leathan drew the largest crowd the fair-wardens of that town had yet built stands to hold, three sides of the field now timbered where two had answered before, the melee's own fame having grown, in the years since its first blood was shed, into the kind of gathering a man travelled a week to

see rather than a day, 11 an Dùbhlachd, SE 45. The fighter who took the field's own honour that year, and the crowd's, was no man at all but Ealasaid nic Coinnich, of Àth ghlas in the west, a ford-market's daughter who had learned the staff and the fist from a father who kept no sons to teach it to and saw no reason a daughter should go untaught for the lack, and who stood, at the day's ending, the last fighter left the field, to a silence the fair-wardens' own chronicler afterward called longer than any cheer the ground had heard before it.

She was given the year's wages the Còmhrag paid its champion and the right to bear arms the custom granted along with them, and she took both without a speech, the crowd's own telling of it afterward making more of her silence than she had ever troubled to make of it herself; and she did not fight again, in that field or any other the Còmhrag's own custom kept, a fact the royal chronicle set down as plainly as it had set down the dry year at Achadh shean and the cold sheds at Àth bheag, without asking, in the setting down, whether she had gone once to prove a thing needed proving only the once or had simply found, having proved it, no further reason to return to a field that asked a fighter to prove it again each year for a crowd that came, more often than not, for the blood alone.

The fair-wardens asked her, the following spring, whether she meant to defend the year's own honour when the Còmhrag came round again, having never before had to put the question to a champion who might answer it either way, and she told them, by the account her own kin at Àth ghlas kept afterward, that a thing won once stayed won whether or not she troubled to stand on the same field a second year to keep it, and that she had a ford-market's own trade to see to that the field had never once paid her for keeping from. The wardens made what they could of the answer, which was little, and gave the year's honour after that to whoever the field itself decided, the way it had always decided such things before her single year among them.

The two accounts reached the Library within the same season, Ealasaid's silence and Murchadh's second book, carried south by different hands and read by the same chronicler's eye, and Tormod Pinn, closing that year's chest, found himself setting one beside the other without quite meaning to, a woman who had answered a question once and would not answer it again, and a keeper who had begun answering a question every night the sea gave him leave to and meant, so far as any book of his said otherwise, to go on answering it for as long as the light stood and the coast kept sending him ships that carried no lamp. Murchadh's own book, that Dùbhlachd, stood a full year deep, its first clouded entry no

longer the poorest thing in it, and he set it on the shelf above his own bed each night beside the Board's own log, the one book asking nothing of him but the hour a lamp was lit and doused, the other asking, and answering as best a keeper's single eye could answer, what manner of coast the kingdom kept and how far its own keeping truly reached along it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

Of the Sacred Wood

SE 46 AN DÀMHAIR – SE 49 AN GEARRAN

Carson an làmh seo? Why this hand?

I

Of Cnoc bheag and the Waking Schools

By an Dàmhair of SE 46 the river quays of Cnoc bheag took in more grain in a season than the granaries of Cathair mhòr could show for a year, and the shire's own tale-keepers, who had watched the town's numbers year on year the way a farmer watches a field he does not own, wrote that Cnoc bheag had passed Cathair mhòr at last and would not be caught again. Its Hawk house, richer now than any order's house outside the capital, kept its own accounts apart from the Rite's and let no custodian south of the water see them; the grain barges tied three deep at the stone stair below the house on a market morning, sacks going up on men's backs from first light until the tide turned and took the empty boats back down river for another load, and a man could walk the length of the quay without once hearing the tongue of the south spoken, though he heard the Rite's bell and the Hawk's bell both, from towers a bowshot apart, telling two different hours to two congregations that did not otherwise speak. A factor of the Rite, come up from Cathair mhòr that autumn to see for himself whether the town's numbers were truly what the returns claimed, stood on the quay a whole market morning counting sacks with his own hand and gave it up before noon, telling the clerk who had come with him that a town could not be doubted that would not stop moving grain long enough to be counted.

The Library at Muileann chaol, keeping the years as they came in under Mòrag nic Coinnich's hand, set this beside a harder thing that same season, though no Board survey told it, the Board sending none: the hewers who came down to the fair said the coal came up thinner from the eastern galleries every year, and thinnest where it ran darkest, the shade the Rite called holiest. A vein that answered fewer hands than it once had was a mine matter to the Board and a coal matter to the Rite, and neither would own it as anything more, but it was the oldest question the island had, older than either of them, and that autumn it woke where it had slept.

The druid schools of Flidais, silent under the humans' rule and silent still for years beyond it, opened their doors again within the month, first at the old house near Muileann chiar in the east where the question had first been asked in the Holy Age, then within the year at two more houses that had stood empty so long that the roof-trees wanted new thatch before a lecture could be given under them without the rain coming through. Men who remembered the old houses only as places sheep were folded in a hard winter came with hammers and green timber before ever a lecture was given, mending a door here and a sill there for no wage but the promise of a bench kept for them when the teaching began. The Rite's own clerks, setting down what they knew of it for the high custodian's file, called it a nuisance of the vein's failing and nothing more, a habit of idle men asking why when they should be asking how much; the schools themselves called it, in the one word their own writings kept from before the humans came, the waking. Neither name mattered much to the students who walked to the old houses that winter with a slate and a knife to cut their own stylus, only that the houses were open and the question, the same one the vein-masters of the Holy Age had first put and never answered, could be asked aloud again without a hall shutting its gallery to the asker.

II

Of the Lecture in Flidais's Wood

Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain came to the stag's grove near Muileann chiar on a morning in an Dùbhlachd with the frost still on the bracken and her own breath standing white in front of her, and found forty people waiting under the bare oaks where she had thought to find a dozen. She had taught the ques-

tion in a small way for eleven years, to whoever of the old families would still send a son or a daughter to hear her, in a barn lent for the winter and in the corner of a market hall when the barn's owner wanted it back for lambing; she had never before stood in the holy wood to teach it, the wood the schools had kept since long before the humans came and had gone on quietly keeping even while the schools that owned it slept, a grove of old oaks and one white-barked stag's-tree at its centre that no axe had touched in living memory and none living now could say how long before that. Past fifty that winter, grey at the temple and stiff in one knee from a fall on wet stone some years before, she walked the last mile to the grove leaning on a hazel stick cut for her by a student, arriving with mud to the shin and no more ceremony about her than any farmer's wife come in from a field.

She had written the lecture out three times over and burned two of the drafts, standing that morning with neither paper before her, because the question did not want dressing. "Why does the vein answer this hand," she said, laying her own bare palm flat on the stag's-tree's white bark for the crowd to see, "and not that one." She let it stand a moment before she went on. The Holy Age had asked it of birth and of practice both and settled neither; the humans, who dug the vein deeper than any age before them and answered to it not at all, had asked instead why it should matter, and been told by their own masters that the question was not theirs to ask; and now, with the vein running thinner in the eastern galleries, the island's own people were asking it again, this time of a matter the census had begun to write down and neither the Rite nor the Crown would say aloud. She did not name the coal-touched that morning, not once, though every soul under the bare oaks knew well enough what hand she meant, and she let the silence that followed do what a plainer word would only have blunted. An old man near the back, whose own father had kept the strike-books in the last years before the schools shut, asked her when the silence had passed whether she meant to answer the question herself before she was done teaching it, and she told him plainly that she did not, that she had come to the grove to ask it in the open where it could be heard, not to settle in an afternoon what the island had failed to settle in all its ages, and the old man nodded at that as at an answer he had half expected and was not sorry to be given.

Word of that morning's lecture went out from Muileann chiar faster than any rider could have carried it, north and east through the shires where the old druid houses still stood roofless and waiting, and within the half-year the houses of Sior-

rachd Baile gharbh in the north-east, silent since the humans first ruled there, opened their doors on the same question and sent their own teachers walking the long road south to hear Seonaid herself before they dared teach it in their own halls. It was a walk of two days each way, by the accounts the schools themselves kept, over roads that saw little enough traffic beyond a carter's cart and a drover's flock, and the teachers who made it came in most years with their boots worn through and stayed only three nights before turning back, having judged the season too short and the sowing too near to spare a longer visit. The Library's own clerks noted, with the dry wonder of men who had watched fewer and fewer make such journeys for anything but a fair or a funeral, that no house among them missed a single winter's walk once it had begun, and that the youngest of the Baile gharbh teachers, a woman not yet twenty on her first journey south, wrote in the school's own minute-book on her return that she had walked two days to hear one question asked and not answered, and would walk it again gladly the next winter for the same.

III

Of the Wet House at Caol shean

The stag's grove near Muileann chiar could not be taught in through the worst of the wet months, when the ground under the bare oaks stood ankle-deep and no fire could be kept lit long enough to warm a lecture, and by an Dùbhlachd after her first winter's teaching Seonaid had taken a house at Caol shean, one of the old druid towns of the east, to carry the school through until the ground dried. It was there, in a low room with a single smoking hearth and benches enough for thirty crowded to hold near fifty, the window shutters lashed against a wind that came off the coast with rain in it more days than not, that the school's students first laid the kingdom's own census beside the schools' oldest question and found the two would not sit apart.

The realm's returns carried a line for the coal-touched that gave a number and nothing else, the same bare figure the Rite's own doctrine called a settled matter and the Board's own clerks copied without comment year on year; the students at Caol shean, who had come to the school precisely because the settled matter did not sit easily with them, copied the same line into their own exercise-books and argued over it by the hearth in a way the Rite's own halls did not permit and had

never permitted, not in the Holy Age and not now. A student new to the school that first wet winter, a miller's son from a village two days' walk south, asked aloud one evening why a line the Board would print and a custodian would bless should be a matter no one might question, when the vein, holier by far in the Rite's own reckoning, was questioned daily by every teacher under Seonaid's roof; no one in the room answered him outright, but no one told him to be silent either, and the talk ran on past the hour the hearth was banked, three students still arguing it by the last of the peat's own glow once the rest had gone to their beds. The Library's clerks, hearing of the evening from a student who kept the school's own minute-book, judged it worth the setting down, the first time on the record that the census line and the schools' old question had been spoken of in the same breath by anyone the Rite could not simply have shut a door on.

That same winter the hall at Muileann dhearg, the old druid hall that had served the hewers for a lodging and stood empty since the fall had closed the Cill ghlas district, was given back to the school by the Guild's own captains, more for want of any better use for a hall no miner would work under than for any love of the question taught in it, and the school took it gladly, glad above all of a roof that did not smoke and a floor that stayed dry through am Faoilleach. The captain who signed the grant over, an old man himself near the end of his own working years, told the schoolmaster who came to thank him that he wanted no thanks, only that the school keep the hall's roof sound, "since a roof kept is a roof kept, whoever prays under it." The Guild's grant carried one condition only, that the school teach nothing there that named a living captain or a living gallery, and the school kept to it without argument, having larger matters to ask than any one captain's name.

In the same season, at a council of the Rite called at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the high custodian's own clerks drew up a settlement long asked for and long refused: the Hawk houses of Cnoc bheag, grown too rich and too old a custom for the Rite to go on pretending had no place under it, were offered a place of their own within the order, answering to the high custodian in name and keeping their own bell and their own order of worship in fact. The terms ran to four pages, and the clerk who read them out to the assembled council read them slowly, watching the Hawk's own witnesses for the objection that had killed the same offer six times before; none came. The Hawk houses took the place, as the Library's own note of it says, "on the seventh reading of the terms and the first without an argument," and the quarrel between the two bells at Cnoc bheag, the

Rite's and the Hawk's, was quieter after that, though it did not end; the two bells went on telling two hours to two congregations, only now under one roof of law that neither had troubled to ask for before.

IV

Of the Bindery, the Breakwater and the Two Dùn thais

aniel Frayne, who had walked to Agnes Pike's byre as a boy with nothing of his own but a slate, kept by SE 48 a small bindery at Muileann leathan where he taught young Tuathaich hands to sew a book's spine and cut its boards true, a craft the southern guilds had never yet let a Tuathaich apprentice learn under their own mark. The bindery was one low room behind his own house, a press he had built himself from a cider-press bought broken and mended, and three boards worn smooth with handling where his pupils learned first to fold a signature true before ever they were let near a needle or a knife. He had no guild's leave to teach it and asked none, having learned long since that the leave he wanted would not be granted him for the asking; he taught instead from what an old binder at Caol mhòr had let him watch as a boy and from what his own hands had worked out through failure since, ruined calf and split boards enough, by his own telling, to have clothed a smaller man's whole flock.

By an Giblean his first bindings, plain calf over boards with no maker's name pressed into the spine, were carried south with the wool carts and sold in three towns his own pupils had never seen, bought by Dia-thireach households who praised the binding's neatness to Frayne's own face without knowing whose hands had made it. A carter who had sold three of the volumes at the fair told Frayne on his return that a Cathair mhòr merchant had asked twice over who bound them so true, and had been told only that they came from a northern house that kept its own methods close; Frayne laughed at that, the carter said, longer than the joke alone seemed to want, and then grew quiet and said that a closed mouth had sold more of his pupils' work than an open one ever would have. He kept every letter of praise that reached him by that roundabout road, unsigned as his own work was, in a box he showed to no one but the pupil whose hands had actually sewn the spine praised in it, and told the boy who asked him why he kept unsigned praise at all that a thing well made did not need his name

on it to be true, only that he himself, and the hand that had made it, should know it.

That same spring the shires of the north-east coast, Caol chrom and its neighbour across the strait, laid the first stone of a breakwater the two had agreed between them to share the cost of, the longest the island had yet built, meant to close a strait that had drowned more boats in a hard winter than either shire's own harbour dues could easily bear alone; the work would want the better part of eight years to finish, by the masons' own reckoning, and the first stone went down to no ceremony beyond a blessing asked of whichever faith a man's own house kept, Rite or Hawk or the older reverence both together, the masons themselves caring more that the stone sat true than whose blessing had been said over it, and the two shires' own maor standing together on the strand to watch the first block swung out on ropes and set, without either troubling to make a speech of it. In an Cèitean of the same year the old boatman at Cidhe Beag, who had carried passengers and small freight across the Abhainn uaine at his own landing for the better part of forty years without a licence asked or given, was granted one at last by the shire's own maor, more for the sake of the shire's records than for any change the boatman himself troubled to make in how he rowed his boat or reckoned his fare; he hung the licence's paper, framed behind a scrap of glass, in the one dry corner of his boat-shed, and told anyone who asked that he had rowed the crossing forty years without it and would row it forty more the same whether the paper hung there or not.

It was in these same years, the schools' clerks and the royal chronicler's both agreeing on it after their own fashion, that Tormod Pinn, keeping the royal record at his desk at Muileann chaol, first set down in plain ink what the map had begun to blur without anyone's intending it: that the realm held two towns of one name, Dùn thais in the west and Dùn thais in the east, and that the Crown's own returns had begun, in the press of a busy season, to run the two together as though they were one place answering for both a sea-court's ruling and a market's charter in the same twelvemonth. Tormod marked the confusion in his own hand, west against east, ruling a fresh line across the page where the two entries had begun to run together, and sent word to both shires that the Crown's clerks should take more care hereafter; it was a small matter beside a breakwater or a bindery, and Tormod himself thought it worth no more than the half-page he gave it, but the Library kept his half-page all the same, judging, as it judged most

things, that a confusion caught early cost less to unpick than one left to grow into a dispute neither shire could afterward be talked out of.

Further north that same winter the fishermen of Loch chrom, the only great lake the island held, were licensed at last to net its trout for their own tables and their own markets, a right the Crown's own table had kept first call on since before any living fisherman's grandfather was born; the licence changed little in the practice of it, since the Crown's table was still served first as it had always been, the best of each week's catch set aside before ever a net was drawn to shore for the fishermen's own market, but it was written down now where before it had only been understood, and the fishermen of the loch, who set less store by writing than by the fish itself, thought the writing worth having all the same, against a day some Crown's steward less easy than the last might try to claim the whole catch instead of the first cut of it.

V

Of the Pillar Set Beside the Obelisk

In an Gearran of SE 49, with the wet ground at Muileann chiar dried enough at last for the school to teach under the bare oaks again, three of Seonaid's own students rode out from the stag's grove to the standing pillar near Cnoc chiar and copied its marks onto three separate slates, chalk rubbed into the cut lines to bring them up under a low winter sun, before they rode on: one to the fenced obelisk in the pasture north of Cnoc bheag, and one to the column at Cnoc ghorm, standing alone in a field a farmer ploughed carefully round every spring without once being told to; they meant to lay the three copies side by side and see what any one of the three might tell that the others could not.

They rode back to Caol shean with slates wrapped in oiled cloth against the rain, and it took three wet evenings by the schoolhouse's single lamp before the students judged the copying careful enough to trust. They found signs in common between all three, cut, so far as anyone could judge, by no later hand than the oldest the island's own memory kept, a mark like a bent reed repeated at Cnoc chiar and at Cnoc ghorm both, and a straight double stroke that appeared on all three stones though nowhere else that any student present had seen it; and they found no meaning in the signs that any student of the school could bring out of them beyond the plain fact of their having been cut at all, by hands that had

wanted, whatever else they wanted, to be remembered. One student, younger than the rest and less patient with a question that would not yield, asked why the school troubled to copy marks that told nothing; an older student, who had walked from Baile gharbh two winters running for less certain teaching than this, told him that a mark that told nothing was itself a kind of telling, if enough care was taken to notice that it had been left at all.

Seonaid herself, reading the three copies laid together on the long table at Caol shean by the last light of an afternoon in an Gearran, the shutters still lashed against a wind that had not yet let up since am Faoilleach, said nothing for a long while, turning each slate to the lamp in its turn and setting it down again. Then she took up her own pen and wrote, in the hand her own students copied afterward into every school's minute-book from Muileann chiar to Baile gharbh, the sentence the Library itself chose to close its own telling of that winter: that the Old Ones had been here, and had said so, in whatever tongue and by whatever hand had cut the stones, and that none living now could hear what they had said.

She did not write it as a discovery, having found nothing that a hundred generations before her students had not already half known and let lie; she wrote it, her own students said afterward, as a plain fact set down at last where it could not be unset, the way the census wrote its bare line for the coal-touched and the Board wrote its bare figure for the vein's own narrowing, a thing known and now written and no longer merely known. The question the schools had first asked at Muileann chiar in the Holy Age, why the vein answered some hands and not others, stood no nearer an answer for the winter's riding and copying than it had stood before it; but it stood now in the open, argued by lamplight at Caol shean and taught under bare oaks at Muileann chiar, where for the better part of the humans' whole rule it had been asked, if it was asked at all, only in a room with the door shut and no one outside to hear it.

PART SIX

Of the One Sheet and the Empty Floor

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

OF the FORTY-ONE SHAFTS

SE 50 AM MÀRT – SE 52 AN LÙNASTAL

Forty-one shafts sunk between Dùn dhearg and Baile ruadh, and not one struck the vein. It had been tried before, long ages since, on the same ground, and the Library alone remembered.
— the Library's own reckoning of the search, entered at Muileann chaol

I

Of the Piles and the Six Schools

It is told at Muileann chaol, of the fiftieth year of the Severance Era, that the sea came into Inis chrom on the twenty-third day of am Màrt and did not trouble to knock. A storm tide out of the south-west rode the mouth of the river higher than any tide the town's own sailors could put a season to, and it went through the net-lofts and the rope-walk of the lower town the way a hand goes through a spider's web, leaving the timber standing in places and lying flat in others, and no reason a man could point to for the difference. Above ten families lost the whole of what they kept below the high-water mark, salt fish and cordage and a season's mending all gone together, and the harbour silted so that the deeper boats could not come in for the better part of a month, riding instead at anchor beyond the bar while their crews rowed the catch ashore in whatever smaller boat the flood had left them.

The town did not ask the Crown for its rebuilding. It asked its own carpenters, who had watched other towns on other coasts set their stores on piles

against exactly such a tide and had always reckoned the cost of doing likewise not worth the bother of a flood that had never yet come. It came now, and the lofts and the rope-walk went up a second time on driven piles a fathom above the old floor, the timber cut from the woods inland and floated down the river on the spring flood, raft after raft of it, and the work was finished before the autumn herring, so that the only loss the second season carried was the labour. A sailor of the Stone's own order blessed the first pile driven and the last, and said, between the two blessings, that a town built twice on the same ground within one lifetime was a town that had learned what the sea meant to teach it only the once. The lofts stand so now, and the town's own telling of it, kept short and without much wonder in the keeping, is that the sea taught Inis chrom once what it would not trouble to teach twice.

In the east that same year Cnoc leathan opened a school in every one of its six parishes, on the twenty-first day of an Giblean, the first shire on the island to do so entire and out of its own dues rather than the Moot's purse or a chartered guild's charity. The sixth and last of the six, at a parish so small it had never before had cause to keep a room set apart for anything but a market day, opened with eleven children on its benches and a teacher hired from Baile chiar who had never taught so few in one room in her life, and said so to the parish's own maor, who told her that eleven taught well was worth more to the shire than sixty taught badly, and that the shire's own dues would stretch to the teacher's wage whatever the room held. The council at Cathair dhearg, hearing of the six schools together, sent a clerk to ask how a shire so far from the capital's own notice had found the coin, and was shown the accounts, plain columns in a plain hand, the dues that would otherwise have gone toward a road never built or a bridge never wanted, turned instead toward six rooms and six teachers and six sets of slates bought at Baile chiar. The clerk copied the accounts and carried them south, and nothing more was asked of Cnoc leathan, which went on keeping its six schools without further notice from the capital in either direction, the parish's eleven benches filling to twenty within two years and the teacher from Baile chiar staying on past the term she had first been hired for.

These are told first because they belong to the same year and to no great matter of state, and because the Library holds that a year should be known by what stood at its edges as well as by what stood at its centre. The centre of that year, for the mountain country and for the house whose name the mountain's yield had made, was a debt taken out against a hope, and it began in the month after Cnoc

leathan opened its sixth school, when a grandson of the first holder of the Sloc Mòr rode to Cathair mhòr to ask the Mine Board for surveyors.

II

Of the Borrowing

Alasdair mac Ùisdein was thirty-four that spring and had held his house's share in the Sloc Mòr for eleven years, since his father's death, without once having to ask the Board for anything beyond the ordinary courtesies a concession-holder was owed: a seat kept at the Board's own table, a first look at the yield figures before they went to the fair, a nod from whichever clerk was on duty when his own name was read from the roll. He came into the Board's chambers on the twentieth of an Cèitean with a paper already drawn, and laid it on the clerk's table before he had properly sat, which the clerk who received him thought, afterward, told him more about the man's temper that morning than anything Alasdair said aloud.

"My house holds the richest working the island has," he said, "and my house's own surveys, going back three generations, say plainly that the working thins to the east and to the south both. I am not the first Mac Ùisdein to read those figures. My grandfather read them and said nothing. My father read them and said nothing. I mean to be the first to act on them beyond reading them again."

The clerk asked him, since it was the clerk's own place to ask it, what he proposed the Board do that three generations of his own house had not already tried, and Alasdair told him that no Mac Ùisdein had ever gone looking for a second vein, having always had coal enough from the one they held not to trouble themselves over whether the island kept another, and that a house rich enough to ignore the question for three generations was, in his own reckoning, precisely the house that ought now to be asking it, before the first vein ran too thin to pay for the asking.

The act he meant was a search for a second vein, and the paper he laid on the table was a note of hand against his house's own share, coin enough to keep six surveying parties in the field a full season, more if the season wanted it. The Board did not need to be asked twice to lend its own surveyors alongside the hired ones, the search being, as the Board's own minute of that week put it without much modesty, "a matter touching the whole kingdom's coal and not the house of Mac

Ùisdein's alone," and the Crown lent its name to the asking, which cost it nothing and bound it to nothing either, a fact the Board's clerks understood without needing it written down. A search that found a second vein would be the kingdom's triumph before it was Alasdair's; a search that found nothing would be a debt on one house's own books and no other's.

Catrìona nic Neacail was thirty-two that year, a surveyor of eight years' standing who had come up, as most of the Board's surveyors came up, through the vein-towns rather than through any school that troubled to teach the trade from a desk, chain-hand first at Muileann chiar and then at the Sloc Mòr itself before the Board took her on its own roll, and she was named to the search in the same week the note of hand was signed, one of eleven the Board sent east with their chains and their levels and their own field-books already half filled with other men's work on other ground. She had not asked to be sent. She had, she told the surveyor riding beside her on the road out of Cathair mhòr, a man twenty years her senior who had surveyed half the roads the Board now kept its own maps by, no particular hope of the search finding anything the house's own three generations of figures had not already told them, and she said this plainly, the kind of fact a careful woman kept in front of her so as not to be surprised by it later.

"Then why go?" the man asked her, not unkindly, the two of them riding the east road past the last of the coal country's own smoke before the ground opened out into hill and moor neither had surveyed before.

"Because the Board pays me to go where it sends me," she said, "and because a search that finds nothing is still a search that someone has to walk the ground for, chain in hand, before the kingdom can be told plainly that nothing is there. I would rather be the one who walks it than the one who is told, years on, that nobody ever properly looked."

He said nothing further to that for the better part of a mile, and then told her, as the hills above Dùn dhearg came into sight for the first time, that he had surveyed for the Board twenty years and had learned in that time to tell, within a week of any new ground, whether it would answer or not, and that this ground, by every sign a man's eye could put to it before a chain was ever laid across it, gave him no particular feeling either way, which was, he said, the worst kind of ground a surveyor could be sent to, since hope at least gave a man a thing to be disappointed by.

III

Of the Forty-One

The ground the search was set to was a stretch of hill and moor running from the rise above Dùn dhearg north-east to the red-earth fields about Baile ruadh, some thirty miles by the road and rather less as a bird would fly it, ground that had never held a working shaft in living memory and that the house's old surveys marked only with the word *unproved*, which in a surveyor's hand meant no more and no less than that nobody before had troubled to find out. The first shaft went down above Dùn dhearg in the early summer, cut through stone that gave every sign a hopeful man could ask of it, layered and dark and not unlike the stone that ringed the Sloc Mòr's own outer galleries, and for the better part of a fortnight the diggers worked it with the particular good humour of men who believe the next stroke of the pick may be the one that changes everything, singing at the windlass in the evenings and wagering small coin among themselves on the very day the vein would show.

It was not. Nor was the second, sunk three miles north-east of the first on a rise Catriona herself had chosen for the lie of its strata, walking the ground twice with a level before she would mark it, nor the third, nor any of the eleven that went down that first season between the hill above Dùn dhearg and the moor's edge north of Baile ruadh. Each shaft was logged in the field-books the Board's clerks kept, depth and stone and water and the day it was judged dry, and each log ended the same way, in Catriona's own hand more often than any other surveyor's on the search, with the single word the Board's own form asked for and no surveyor on the ground had yet found a kinder way to write: *barren*.

The camp the search kept that first summer, a scatter of tents and one timber hut on the moor's own edge, held eleven surveyors and near sixty diggers hired from the vein-towns and the shires round about, men glad enough of the season's wage whatever the ground gave up, and a cook who fed the whole of it from two great pots and a fire kept burning from first light past dark. Catriona took her own meals with the diggers oftener than with the other surveyors, having learned young that a chainman's grumbling told a surveyor more about the ground than another surveyor's own reckoning ever did, and it was from a digger of Dùn dhearg, an old man who had cut peat on those same hills as a boy, that she first heard the moor's own name for the ground they were searching, *am Fearann Falamb*¹, the empty ground, a name the moor's own shepherds had used long before any Board surveyor came near it and had meant, the old man told her, nothing more mysterious than that no shepherd had ever found a spring on it worth the digging.

The second season brought thirty more shafts, spread wider now across the same stretch of country as the house's coin and the diggers' patience allowed, some sunk within sight of the first season's covered mouths and others carried further out onto ground the first year's surveyors had judged too poor to trouble with, and Catriona kept, apart from the Board's own field-books, a private tally in the back pages of her own, a line for each shaft with its number and its depth and the date it was abandoned, so that by the close of that second summer she could tell a man asking, without troubling to add the column, that the search stood at thirty-eight shafts sunk and thirty-eight shafts dry. The diggers' songs had thinned by then to nothing much, and the wagers had stopped after the twentieth shaft or thereabouts, no man on the ground caring any longer to put coin against a stone that had shown them, thirty times running, exactly what it meant to show.

The thirty-ninth found nothing. The fortieth, sunk on ground so unpromising that even the diggers who cut it said afterward they had expected no better, found nothing either, the water coming in at a depth that told Catriona, reading the borings by lamplight in the timber hut that evening, that the ground below it held no more promise than the ground above, and by the time the forty-first was marked out on the moor south of Baile ruadh, in the last days of the second summer, there was a temper on the ground that Catriona had not felt on the earlier shafts, the particular tiredness of men who have done careful work for two years

1. the empty ground

running and have nothing to show a passing stranger for it but a row of covered holes and a moor's own name proving truer with every one of them.

The forty-first shaft went down through an t-Sultain and into an Dàmhair, the diggers working it in weather no earlier shaft had asked them to work through, the first frosts in the ground by morning and the windlass rope stiff with them, and it was Catrìona who stood at its head on the morning the chief digger came up to tell her, not with any particular ceremony, his hands still black to the wrist from the last boring, that the water table had been struck at a depth where no vein had ever been found on the whole island and that the ground below it, so far as the borings could tell, held nothing but the same barren rock the other forty had held. She wrote the word in her own field-book, *barren*, in the same hand she had written it forty times before, and then sat a while on the shaft's own spoil-heap in the cold before she rode back to report it, a thing she judged, that particular morning, the ground had earned of her before she left it for good, whatever the Board's own form asked.

IV

Of the Same Week

It happened, as such things happen more often than either chroniclers or surveyors care to admit, that the very week Catrìona rode into Cathair mhòr with the word of the forty-first shaft, Mòrag nic Coinnich at Muileann chaol was working her way through a press of Holy Age rolls that had lain unread in the Library's lower room since before her own keepership began, part of the long cataloguing she had set herself the year she took the keepership, tallying each roll against a list that had never once been made and setting aside, as she went, whatever the list did not already answer for. She came upon, near the bottom of a press she had nearly finished with that week, a list from the Holy Age, the ink browned and the vellum stiffened with age, that named, in terms she had to read twice by the light of her own lamp before she trusted them, the same hills above Dùn dhearg and the same moors south of Baile ruadh, searched once already, and found barren once already, by surveyors whose own names the roll no longer troubled to keep, the last line of it worn to little more than a shape where a hand had once written a plain word she could still, holding the vellum close, make out as the same word Catrìona had been writing all that season: barren.

She sent word south the day she found it, not to the Board directly, which was not the Library's habit, the Library keeping no correspondence with the Board as a body and preferring, where a fact touched one person's own work, to send it to that person plainly, but to Catriona herself, whom she had never met but whose name stood at the head of more of the search's own logs than any other surveyor's, a short letter that said only what the roll said and asked nothing beyond that it be read. Catriona received it the same week she filed her own report of the forty-first shaft, the two papers arriving on her table at Cathair mhòr within two days of each other, one saying that the ground before her had just failed to yield what two years and forty-one shafts had asked of it, the other saying that the same ground had failed the same way once already, ages before either of them, and that somewhere in the Library's own keeping the failure had been sitting the whole time, waiting for someone to think to ask.

She read Mòrag's letter twice before she set it beside her own field-book, and told the clerk who had brought it in that she did not know, that morning, whether the Library's find made the two years' digging easier to bear or harder, and the clerk, who had carried enough of the Board's own bad news in his time to have an opinion on the matter, said that a thing known twice over and forgotten once already was, in his own reckoning, harder to bear than a thing simply not known, since the not-knowing at least left a man free to hope the next shaft might be the one. Catriona did not answer him directly. She copied Mòrag's letter into her own field-book, word for word, beside the entry for the forty-first shaft, and let the two stand together on the page, which was, she told the clerk afterward, the nearest thing to an answer she had, and wrote beneath the two a line of her own, that she meant, before the Board's own record of the search was closed and filed past reading, to see the Holy Age roll sent a copy south so that the next surveyor sent to that ground, if any Board ever sent one again, would not have to wait on a keeper's own private cataloguing to learn what the last search had already cost.

It was in that same season, before the search's papers were fully closed, that Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's letter to the Board, written before the digging had properly begun and filed unread at the time in the ordinary way of letters the Board judged it had no immediate use for, was found again by a clerk sorting the Board's own correspondence for the year, and read this time with more attention than it had been given the first. She had written, when the search was still no more than Alasdair's note of hand and the Board's own minute, that the search asked the wrong question, that her school had always asked why the vein

answered some hands and not others, and that in all the kingdom's asking about the mountain, in all the ages of digging it and forty years of the Board's own surveys, nobody had thought to ask why there was only the one vein at all, on the whole of an island otherwise so rich in stone and metal both. The clerk who found the letter a second time carried it to Catriona along with Mòrag's, and Catriona read it standing at the same table, and said to the clerk, when he asked her whether it changed anything, that it changed nothing the search could act on, a school's question and a surveyor's chain answering to different masters, but that she meant, all the same, to keep a copy of it beside the other two, so that whoever next read her field-book entire would have all three papers together and could judge for themselves what the season had actually found, and what it had failed, three separate ways, to ask.

V

Of the Fence

The reckoning that followed the search fell to others than Catriona, who had done the digging and left the accounting to the Board's own clerks, though it touched the ground she had walked all the same. The town of Dùn dhearg, whose hills had held a dozen of the dry shafts among the forty-one, brought its claim to the circuit court that summer, the shire's own advocate walking the shafts himself with two shepherds who swore, plainly and without much heat, that grazing spoiled by a digger's spoil-heap was grazing lost for longer than any digger troubled to reckon, one of them telling the court that a ewe would not graze within a stone's throw of a fresh spoil-heap for two full seasons after the diggers moved on, whatever grass grew there, and the other adding only that he had lost more lambs to the search's own open ground in two years than to wolves in the ten years before it. The court found for the town, and the house of Mac Ùisdein paid a third of the damages that same season and, its coin by then thinner than its note of hand two years before had allowed for, sold half its own share in the Sloc Mòr back to the Crown to meet what remained, on the fifth day of an t-Iuchar in the fifty-second year, a clerk of the Board carrying the deed south to Cathair dhearg the same week it was signed. Its stone house at Cathair mhòr, kept in the family since the first holder's own day, its hall still hung with the same crest the first Mac Ùisdein had cut for it, was let to the Board that same season, which

moved its offices into it the following spring, so that a house built to hold one family's wealth came to hold, instead, the ledgers of a search that family's own coin had paid for and not answered, and a Board clerk was heard to remark, carrying the first press of files up the house's own stair, that the family had at least left the fires drawing well.

The shafts themselves, forty-one dry mouths in the ground between two towns that had asked for none of them, were left as the diggers had left them when each was judged barren in turn, covered loosely where the diggers troubled to cover them and not at all where the season's weather or the Board's own thinning purse left the work half done. On the moor south of Baile ruadh, where the ground was softest and the covering poorest, sheep began falling into the old shaft-mouths before the first winter after the search was out, three that the shire's own reckoning could put a number to and likely more that no reckoning troubled to count, and before that summer was out a child of the town, out after a stray lamb on ground she had walked a hundred times without harm, went down one of the same shafts and was not found again until the following day, past any help the finding could give her. The parish's own book at Baile ruadh holds her name and the day, and nothing more than that; her mother, it is told locally and nowhere written, would not walk that road again for the whole of the year that followed, and took the longer way round by the mill instead, whatever the weather asked of her for it.

The shire of Baile ruadh met the week after, in the same low room where its own dues had once been argued over school-money the shire had never had cause to spend, and voted, without much debate that the record troubled to keep, to fence every one of the shafts on its own ground at the shire's own cost rather than wait on a Crown that had shown, in the matter of Dùn dhearg's grazing, no great haste to pay for what its own search had spoiled. The shire's claim against the house of Mac Ùisdein for the fencing's own cost was entered the same week, and has never yet been paid. The fencing went up through that same summer, plain posts and wire strung by the town's own hands round each covered mouth, one shaft a day where the ground allowed it and two where a family gave its own labour free for a shaft that had taken a measure of their own, a fence for every hole on the moor, holes that had cost two years, a house's half-share, and one child, and had found, at the end of it, nothing but the stone the Holy Age's own forgotten surveyors could have told them, had anyone thought, before the digging began, to ask the Library what it already knew.

Catrìona nic Neacail rode past the last of the fences on her way south that autumn, on Board business that had nothing further to do with the search, and stopped a while at the rail nearest the road, where a boy of the town, too young to remember the digging, was mending a gap the last winter's frost had opened in the wire. She did not tell him what the shaft behind him had cost, in coin or in the other coin, and he did not ask her, taking her, from her dress and her horse, for no more than a Board rider passing through on ordinary business, which by then, in every particular the boy could see, she was. She rode on before the light went, the fences falling behind her one by one in the grey of the evening, each one holding nothing but the dark the search had proved, and thought, coming down at last onto the coal road with Cathair mhòr's own smoke ahead of her, that a kingdom which kept a Library at all and still had to be told twice, by its own ground, what that Library already held, was a kingdom that had not yet learned to ask its questions of the right book first.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Of the Reef Bell

SE 53 AN GIBLEAN – SE 55 AN T-ÒGMHIOS

Cha do dh'fhàillig an solas ach aon turas; cha do dh'fhàillig an
nighean idir. The light failed once; the daughter did not fail at all.
— said of the keepers of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg, entered at
Muileann chaol

I

Of Bark and Rope and a List Alone

It is told at Muileann chaol that in the fifty-third year of the Severance Era the mills of Muileann dhomhain, in the ground south-east of the capital where the grain of three shires had gone to be ground since before the humans came, began for the first time in any keeper's memory to grind bark instead of grain. The orders from the vein-towns had thinned with the vein, coin scarcer at Cathair dhearg and Muileann chiar than it had been in Iain mac Ruairidh's own young years, and a miller who wants his wheel turning will turn it on whatever is brought to him. The tanners of the coast paid in silver for ground bark where the vein-towns had once paid in silver for ground grain, and the miller-families of Muileann dhomhain, who had cut their mark into a millstone before any shire kept a chest to hold the charter that let them, kept the mark and changed the trade under it without troubling the Board for leave. The Library set down the change in one line and asked the millers nothing further, there being, as the keeper who entered it wrote, no law yet made against a mill that ground what came to it.

The eldest of the Muileann dhomhain millers, a woman near seventy who had ground grain at the same wheel her mother had ground it at, was asked once by a passing clerk whether it troubled her that the wheel her family's mark had stood over for four generations now turned bark for a tanner's vat instead of flour for a baker's trough. She answered, the clerk's own note says, that a wheel does not know what is under it, and a family that has kept its mark through worse than a change of grist has no cause to start weeping over this one; the grain would come back when the vein-towns had coin again to buy it with, and until then the tanners' silver spent the same in the shire's own market as any other silver ever had. The clerk carried the answer back to Cathair dhearg unglossed, there being nothing in it, by his own account, that wanted a gloss.

Further north, on the coast where the coal line did not run, the rope-walks of Seann Tarr were that same year chartered as a guild by the restored custom, the last trade the humans had never touched to be given a charter of its own, its hemp brought down from the fields about Doire uaine and Achadh naomh by cart roads older than the survey lines that had tried, more than once, to straighten them. The shire keeper of Seann Tarr, being asked by a rider from Cathair dhearg to send the new charter south to be filed among the council's own papers, answered that the charter would stay in the shire's own chest at Seann Tarr, as every paper of the shire had stayed since the chest was first locked, and that the rider might carry south, if the Board required a paper at all, a list of what the chest held and no more. The rider carried the list south. The chest stayed where it was, and has stayed there since, and no clerk at Cathair dhearg has yet sent a second rider to ask again. It was said afterward at Seann Tarr, not without some pride taken in the saying of it, that a shire which will not send its papers south need never trouble over what is done with them once they arrive, and that a list is a cheaper thing to lose than a charter.

That same season An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn¹, which no chronicler now living can say for certain when it was first pitched or by whom, came again to the common near Inis àrsaidh in the west, and the magistrate who licensed its acts, being unable or unwilling to put a name to half of what he had watched from the front row with his own two daughters on his knee, entered the whole of it in his book as various, and the fee as paid, which was, of every entry a magistrate of that shire made that year, the one that gave the Library's own copyists the most

1. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

trouble to gloss. His own note, appended some years after by a hand not his, says only that a man who has seen a thing done with fire, three knives and a length of rope, and cannot afterward say to his own satisfaction whether it was a trick or a wonder, does his shire no disservice by writing various and letting a wiser age decide the matter, if any age ever troubles to.

Ceann mhin, the great port south-east of the capital, opened in the same year a covered market over its old strand for the fish that came up from Seann Bhrál and the grounds to the east, so that for the first time the buyers of the capital could stand dry-shod under a roof of the port's own raising while they haggled over a catch that had been wet from the sea an hour before. The old strand traders, who had cried their fish in the open for as long as any of them could remember and their fathers before them, grumbled at first that a roof over a fish stall was a roof over nothing a fish had ever asked for, and grumbled rather less once the first wet winter under the new roof let them keep a fire going by the scales that no open strand had ever let them keep, and their catch drier and better priced for it besides.

And at Ceann leathan, where the Còmhrag was fought every summer for a purse and a year's wages and the right to bear arms after, a fighter was killed that season with a hewer's pick brought in under a borrowed coat, and the fair-wardens, who had buried enough young men already without a tool from the vein finishing what a fist or a stave would have left standing, banned edged iron from the ring from that day forward. Staves and fists were still allowed, and the dying went on, only slower, which was as much as the wardens, by their own account, had ever promised to make of it; a warden of long standing, asked by a Board rider whether the ban would hold, said only that it would hold as long as a man could be searched at the ring's own gate for what he carried, and no longer than that, which the rider set down and carried away without further question, there being, in that answer, nothing a further question could have improved.

II

Of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg

Of Ciorstaidh nic Artair, who kept after that year the light at Tobar dhearg on the south coast, it is told first what was done to her father, for the one cannot be told without the other.

Artair mac Mhurchaidh had kept the light at Tobar dhearg for above thirty years, since before his daughter could walk the gallery round the lamp-room without a hand on the rail, and in all that time the reef below the light had taken, by his own count kept in the log he left behind him, eleven boats and no lives, the light and his own watching having been, until that year, enough to answer for the second half of the reckoning. He had trained his daughter to the lamp from the age of nine, the wick and the oil and the turning of the great glass, and to the watch-book beside it, and had said to her often enough that a light which stands and a keeper who watches are two different things kept in one tower, and that the tower could be trusted to do the first of these many years after any keeper set to do the second was dead and gone, which she had taken, at nine and at nineteen both, for the kind of thing an old man says to fill a night watch and not for anything she would be asked to prove.

On a night in an t-Ògmhios when the wind stood hard out of the south-west and the light could do no more than show a hull where the light already knew a hull to be, a fishing boat out of Doire shean struck the reef in the black water below the beacon and hung there, taking the sea over her low side with every swell, her crew of four lashed where they could lash themselves and crying out in a wind that carried the sound away from the shore as fast as it was made. Artair heard them from the gallery before he saw them, the cry coming and going with the gusts the way a gull's cry comes and goes, and knew the sound for what it was before the next flash of his own lamp showed him the hull lying over on the reef's own teeth. He woke no one in the house below; the log he kept, found afterward open on the table with the ink still wet where he had broken off writing it, records the hour and the bearing and nothing of what he meant to do about either, as though the doing of it were too plain a thing to trouble a log with.

Artair, fifty-three that spring, went down from the light alone in the small hours with a coil of rope and the shore-boat that the lighthouse kept for no purpose but this one, and got the rope to the wreck, and got two of the four crew into the shore-boat, and put them ashore himself on the strand below the tower with no more than a word to make fast and wait, and went back a second time for the other two, and did not come back a third time himself. The two men he had put ashore said afterward, when the shire's own clerk came to take their account, that he had said nothing to them of the sea he was going back into, and had looked, in the one lamp's-worth of light they had of his face before he pushed off

the second time, no more troubled by it than a man setting out to check a fence line he had checked a hundred times before.

Ciorstaidh, three-and-twenty and asleep in the keeper's house below the tower when her father went down, woke to the empty rail and the boat gone and understood, before anyone told her anything, what an empty rail and a gone boat meant at that hour in that wind. Leaving the two men her father had put ashore where they lay, past use to her or to themselves, she took the second boat, the one her father had not thought to take because two boats cannot do together what an old man's arms could no longer do alone in one, and went out after him along the line his own rope still marked in the water, the wind taking the oars out of true with every third stroke and the tower's own lamp swinging its light past her and away again with a regularity that told her nothing of where the wreck lay and everything of how little time the telling would take if she did not find it soon. The wreck she found at last by the sound of it before the sight, the timbers grinding on the rock under the wind the way a door grinds on a hinge too long unoiled, her father's rope still fast to it and the last two of the crew still lashed to what remained of the mast, past speech but not past living, the one holding to the other by a grip that had stopped being a choice some while before she reached them.

Rowing a boat built for a lighter woman than she then knew herself to be against a sea that had already taken the one keeper the reef had never before been able to take, with the two rescued men lying in the bilge doing nothing to help her and everything, by their dead weight alone, to make the pulling harder, she brought them in, and did not once, by her own account given years afterward to a niece who asked her, let herself think past the next stroke of the oar to what waited for her back at the tower once the pulling was done. Her father's own body came ashore three days after, a mile down the coast at a place the tide favours for such things, and was carried back to Tobar dhearg and buried in the ground above the light where every keeper of that beacon before him had been buried, the parish clerk entering against his name in the register no more than the day, the manner, and the word drowned, the same word the register had entered against every other name it had ever taken from that water. The night before the burial she stood the watch herself, the lamp trimmed and turning as her father had trimmed and turned it, there being, as she told the clerk who came to note the death, no law of the sea or of the Board either that excused a light from burning because its keeper was being buried in the morning.

The keeper's warrant does not pass by any law the council ever troubled to write down; it passes, where it passes at all, by the plain fact of who is left standing at the light when the last keeper is not, and by whether the Board at Cathair dhearg, being asked, can find any reason worth the ink to refuse what has already, in every particular but the paper, been decided by the sea. Ciorstaidh nic Artair asked for nothing beyond what the plain fact already gave her; the Board, being asked by the shire's own maor whether the daughter of a keeper who had died bringing in four lives with two boats and one rope might keep the light her father had kept, wrote back inside the month that she might, and the warrant that had been her father's was entered in her own name at Cathair dhearg without a word of debate that any clerk troubled to set down.

III

Of the Bell in Fog

She did not let the matter rest at the warrant. Through that same summer she had an iron post sunk into the reef at low water, at the place her father's rope had marked and her own boat had found by it, driven and cemented by two masons brought up from Seann Vell who worked the tides for the better part of a month to get it standing, working only in the hour either side of the ebb when the reef stood clear enough of the water to be worked at all, and cursing, by their own later account, every tide that came in on them before the last bolt was set. She had the post painted the red that every chart from Cathair mhòr to Seann Skell now uses for a danger marked and known, and hung from an arm at its head a bell cast at Muileann chiar and paid for, the Board's own ledger shows, half from the Board's purse and half from a purse the fishing families of Doire shean and Tobar dhearg between them made up themselves, not being minded to wait on the Board's own half arriving before the bell was hung, a factor at Doire shean having gone door to door with a slate and a stub of chalk until the sum stood full.

The bell was rung by no hand and no clock; it hung loose enough on its arm that any sea with weight enough to be dangerous set it swinging and sounding of its own accord, and a sea too slight to trouble a boat left it silent, so that the bell told a master exactly what the master needed told and nothing more. When the Board's own engineer came down from Cathair dhearg, some months after the

post was set, to inspect what the Board's half of its own money had bought, he walked the whole length of the reef at low water with his own instruments and pronounced the post sound and the casting good, and asked Ciorstaidh, more out of an engineer's habit of admiring his own trade than out of any doubt of hers, whether she meant in time to have the bell struck by some clockwork, on the pattern the Board had lately fitted to the light at Baile ìseal, so that a master out on the water might know the hour as well as the danger. She answered that a clock could tell a man the hour whether or not the sea agreed with it, and that she had built the bell to tell him only the one thing a clock could never tell him, which was whether the sea that hour meant him harm; if he wanted the hour as well, she said, he had a tide table and two eyes, and needed neither her bell nor the Board's clockwork to supply what his own almanac already owed him. The engineer, by his own report to the Board, wrote down that the keeper's design was sound and her reasoning sounder, and that he had no improvement to suggest that the keeper had not already considered and set aside for good cause.

The bell was heard first, by any account the Library troubled to gather, on a night in an t-Ògmhios of the fifty-fifth year, when a fog came down off the water thick enough that the light, for all its lamp and its glass and its keeper's own long practice at trimming it, could not be seen from a boat's length beyond where the reef began, and every boat working that stretch of coast that night steered by the bell alone, which the fog could not silence as it silenced the light, and came home. No boat went aground on the reef below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹ that year, nor in any year after that Ciorstaidh nic Artair kept the light, and the fishermen of that coast, who name most things for what they are and few things for what they hope, began that same year to call the reef, which had held no name before beyond a plain warning to keep clear of it, an Sceir Aithnichte², the known reef, there being, as one of them told a Board rider who asked him why, no longer anything about it that a man working that water by night needed to be told twice.

IV

Of the Chair Laid Down

1. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

2. the known reef

That same year, in Caol mhòr, Mary Coyle laid down the chair of the Moot she had held two-and-twenty years, since the winter Hale died and the widows of the northern crews had first put her name forward over her own protest that a fisherman's widow had no business speaking for clerks and hewers both. She had kept the chair through the beginning of the register of the dead and maimed that bore her own name in the north long after it bore any other, through the Rail Board's refusals and the Moot's own lean years when the chair was little more than a bench in a room the south did not trouble to send anyone to argue in, and had said of the work often enough, to the few who asked her why she kept at it, that a chair nobody wants to sit in is the one chair a body dare not leave empty, there being no one else who will trouble to fill it if she does not.

The laying-down came, the Moot's own minute records, on a morning in an t-Ògmhios with no more ceremony than the minute required, and she said what she had to say of the register her own hand had begun and the Rail Board her own petitions had never once moved, a plainer accounting, those who were in the room said afterward, than the years it summed had any right to fit into so few words. Of the widows who had first put her name forward, most of them dead now themselves, and of the register of the western pits' dead and maimed that she had begun and Daniel Frayne had kept in his own hand, the minute records her speaking at some length: a book, she said, that had grown by a name a season for fourteen years and would go on growing by a name a season for as many years again as the vein lasted, whoever sat in the chair to keep it. For herself she asked the Moot nothing, having asked it nothing on her own account in two-and-twenty years of asking it for everything else, and named, before the Moot rose that morning, the man she asked it to choose after her.

Daniel Frayne of Muileann leathan, who had bound books for the north's own schools when the southern guilds would not have a Tuathaich name on their rolls, and who had sat at Mary Coyle's own right hand in the Moot's chair for above ten years before that morning, keeping her own accounts steadier, by more than one account, than she had ever troubled to keep them herself, was chosen that same day without a voice raised against him, the first speaker of the Moot to have been born, as the minute troubled to note, after the Severance had already closed and not before it, a fact that meant little to the Moot's own business that morning. He had been a pupil of Agnes Pike's school before the guilds of the south would take a Tuathaich boy to bind their books, and had learned the trade in the end from his own reading and an old bookbinder of Caol mhòr who asked

no questions of a boy's birth so long as his stitching held straight, and had come to the Moot's own clerking, in the years since, by much the same road: asked no leave, and given the work once it was plain he could do it better than the man before him.

He took the chair from a woman who had held it since before he could write his own name, in a room where the Moot's own chest held the north's tallies for every census the kingdom had taken and not published, a chest that Mary Coyle, in the last minute she gave as speaker, pointed to once and said nothing further of, there being nothing further, by her own account, that the pointing did not already say. Frayne said, by the Moot's own record, no more than that he would keep what she had begun and add to it only what the Moot itself asked him to add, which the clerk who wrote the minute set down exactly as he said it and no more warmly than that; and when an older man at the back of the room asked him, half in jest and half not, whether a speaker born after the Severance meant to speak any differently for it than a speaker born before, Frayne answered that he could not say, having no other speaker's whole life to set against his own, and that the Moot would find out, as it found out everything else that mattered to it, by watching what he did and not by asking him first what he meant to do, an answer the minute records without troubling to say whether the room took it for wit or for plain caution, it being, in Frayne's own mouth, not always easy to tell the one from the other.

It was told afterward, at Muileann chaol and at Tobar dhearg both, though never in the same telling, that the bell on the reef and the chair in Caol mhòr were rung and taken in the same season for the plainest of reasons, that a coast which cannot always keep its light burning against the weather it is given had learned, in the end, to hang a bell that needed no one's hand to sound it truly; and that a Moot which could not yet move a line of rail or unlock a chest of figures had learned, in its own time and by its own slower road, to choose a chair that needed no one born before the Severance to sit in it rightly. Neither telling troubled to say which lesson had come first, or whether either had come from the other at all; the Library, asked once by a student at Caol shean which of the two had taught the other, entered only that both were true and both were entered the same year, and left the rest of the reckoning to whoever wanted it badly enough to work it out alone.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

Of the One Sheet

SE 55 AN DÙBHLACHD – SE 57 AN T-IUCHAR

Duilleag na Fèithe, the sheet of the vein, held on one leaf what forty years of the Board's own files had kept apart across two towns and four presses: that the mountain had little left in it, and that the mountain had known this a long while before the kingdom troubled to ask.

— the Library's own note on the map, entered at Muileann chaol

I

Of the Fair's Northern Day

It is told at Muileann chaol that the court of the fair at Muileann òg, in the cold week before the turn of the fifty-fifth year of the Severance, gave over one whole day of its ten to goods carried down out of the northern shires, the first day in all the fair's history set aside so, and that the wardens who cried it from the fair's own steps did so in the flat voice men use for a thing they have not yet decided whether to be proud of. The goods still went to Dia-thìreach factors, as the court of the fair had ruled thirty years before and had never troubled to un-rule; a northern weaver's cloth was still weighed, priced and sold by a southern hand at a southern table. But the day was named, and the stalls it filled stood in a row of their own along the fair's eastern wall, and over each stall, for the first time in the fair's keeping, hung a maker's own mark and not only the factor's.

Daniel Frayne of Muileann leathan stood that morning at the head of the row, the Moot's chair six months old on him and sitting no more easily than a coat bought for a taller man, and watched the first cloth of the day go up on its pole: a

grey twill of Doire ghlais, plain wool dyed with the shire's own bark, and along its selvedge a single thread of undyed white running the length of the bolt, so fine a stranger might have taken it for a flaw in the weave before he took it for a mark. The weavers of Doire ghlais called it *An Snàthainn Geal*¹, the white thread, and had woven it into their own cloth for three years without asking the fair's leave, selling it under a factor's stamp as they sold everything else, until the court's new rule let them sell it, for the first time, under their own. The factor who had carried Doire ghlais cloth to that fair for eleven years stood by the pole with his ledger open and his face giving away nothing either way, and when a buyer from Cathair mhòr asked him what the thread meant, he said only that it was the shire's own habit and had never lowered the price of a bolt, which was, in its way, the truest thing said at the fair that day about what the day was worth.

Frayne walked the row twice before the light went, the factors' bell being rung early against the short afternoon, and stopped longest at the Baile chiar stall, where the southern weavers, who had sold cloth at that fair since before the row existed, had begun that same season to weave a thread of their own into the selvedge of their finer bolts, a pale grey scarcely darker than the wool, the mark being spoken for already at Doire ghlais, so that a buyer who did not know to look for it would carry the cloth home none the wiser. He asked the Baile chiar weaver, an old woman who had been at the loom since before the first Còmhrag, why her house troubled to copy a northern habit it need not have noticed at all, and she told him that a mark worth having was a mark worth taking, wherever it began, and that she had woven for forty years without her own name on a bolt and did not propose to die without it. Frayne wrote nothing of the exchange in the Moot's own book that night, there being no column in it for a compliment paid sideways by a stranger's loom, but he told Mary Coyle of it the next time he rode to Caol mhòr, and she said only that a thread the south troubled to steal was worth more, in the end, than a thread the south only bought.

The frost came down hard that afternoon, as it does most years at Muileann òg once the light begins to fail, and the wardens who had cried the northern day from the steps that morning were the same men who walked the row at dusk telling stallholders to bank their braziers and mind the canvas, the ceremony of the morning having given way, as every fair's ceremony does by nightfall, to the ordinary business of getting a hundred stalls safely through a cold night. Frayne

1. the white thread

stayed later than most, walking the row a third time with a lantern of his own after the buyers had gone, and found the Doire ghlas weaver's daughter, a girl of perhaps fifteen sent to mind the stall while her mother slept in the cart, sewing by the lantern's own light a second length of the white thread into a bolt not yet sold, working it in slow and even though nobody stood by to buy it that night or to see it done. He asked her why she troubled with it in the dark and the cold when the day's trade was over, and she told him, not looking up from the needle, that her mother had taught her the thread went in whether a buyer was watching or not, since a mark sewn only for show was no mark at all, only a better sort of lie. He carried that answer home with him too, and told it to no one, judging it a thing better kept than spent.

The court's minute of that day, four lines in a clerk's small hand, records the northern day kept, the goods sold, and the dues taken, and nothing of the thread at all. It is the Library's own habit, and not the court's, to keep such things; the sheet the fair's clerk filed that winter and the roll the Library keeps of it agree in every figure and disagree, entirely, in what either thought worth the keeping.

II

Of the One Sheet

Catrìona nic Neacail was seven-and-thirty in the year the fair kept its first northern day, a surveyor of the Board thirteen years standing, chain-hand no longer but not yet the thing the Board would shortly make her, and she spent that whole winter and the better part of the following spring doing a piece of work nobody at Cathair mhòr had asked her for in so many words, though every surveyor on the Board's roll had known for years it wanted doing and none had troubled to do it entire. She meant to draw, on one leaf if the leaf would hold it, every stretch of the vein the Board's surveys called unworked: not the search's forty-one dry holes between Dùn dhearg and Baile ruadh, which were another matter and a closed one, but the true seam that the Sloc Mòr and its daughter workings had followed for ages, wherever any surveyor's chain had ever laid a line across ground still unopened.

She began with her own field-books, which by then ran to eleven, and worked outward through the Board's own rolls a shire at a time, riding where the rolls disagreed with each other or with the ground beneath them, which happened often-

er than the Board's own clerks liked to be told. The riding took her that winter into weather no surveyor chose for the work if the choosing were left to him, frost in the saddle-leather most mornings and the short daylight gone before a chain could be properly laid twice over the same ground, and more than once she and whichever surveyor rode with her that week were glad of a shepherd's bothy or a maor's own kitchen fire to see out a night the road would not have forgiven them.

A surveyor named Griogair mac Aonghais, junior to her by six years and lent her for the season's riding, asked her once, the two of them sat by a fire on the moor above Muileann dhearg with the day's chain-work done and the light going, what she expected the finished sheet to show that every surveyor on the roll did not already know in his own gut, and she told him that a thing known in the gut and a thing drawn on a sheet were not the same fact, whatever a tired man on a cold hill might wish to believe of them, and that she meant the Board to have the second kind whether it wanted it or not. Griogair said, not unkindly, that a sheet was still only ink, and ink had never yet mined a pound of coal nor left a pound more in the ground than was there to begin with; she agreed with him, and told him that she had not undertaken the drawing to change what was in the ground, only to change how long the Board could go on not knowing it, which she judged, whatever ink's other failings, a thing ink was entirely equal to.

The drawing, when it was finished in the early summer, fitted on one sheet the size of a door, every stretch of the true vein still unopened marked in a red the ink-maker had mixed for her specially, since no ink already on the Board's shelves would hold its colour against handling. It was smaller than she had let herself believe it would be while she was still drawing it a shire at a time, small enough that a man could stand at the Board's own long table and take in the whole of what remained with one turn of his head, where the same fact spread across forty separate rolls in forty separate hands had never once been taken in whole by anyone, herself included, until the ink was dry. She called it, in her own record and then in the Board's, *Duilleag na Fèithe*¹, the sheet of the vein, and she published it before the year was out, in an *Dùbhlachd*, in the plainest way the Board knew how to publish anything, which was to hang it on the wall of its own chamber at *Cathair mhòr* where every surveyor, clerk and concession-holder who came through the door could read it for himself.

Within the month of its hanging, the sheet had done more to the Board's own chamber than any minute the Board had passed in years. Concession-holders who

had come in on ordinary business, a licence to renew or a boundary to dispute, took to stopping before it on their way to the clerk's own table, some counting the red stretches with a finger held an inch from the paper as though the counting might yet change the sum, others asking whichever clerk was nearest what the sheet meant and receiving, more often than not, an answer no clearer than the question. A concession-holder of the western galleries, whose family had worked the same three shafts for four generations, stood before it the better part of an hour one wet forenoon and then asked to see the surveyor who had drawn it, and when Catriona was fetched down from the upper room where she kept her own field-books, he asked her plainly whether the red she had used for his own family's ground meant ten years or thirty, since he had daughters to settle and would rather know now than be told later that the Board had known all along and had simply never troubled to colour it in. She told him she could not put a year to it without walking his own ground again herself, which she offered to do within the season, and he thanked her for an answer that gave him nothing certain but was, he said, the first honest nothing the Board had ever offered him.

The Board had named her surveyor-general that spring, when word of the drawing first went round its chamber, the office having stood empty three years since the last man who held it retired to his daughter's farm and not troubled to be filled again until the drawing on her table made plain that somebody ought to be answerable for the whole of what it would show. She was eight-and-thirty that year, and the clerk who read her the Board's own minute of the appointment, a young man new enough to his desk to still find such things worth remarking on, told her it was the youngest the office had been filled in living memory. She said only that the office had waited three years for want of anyone troubling to ask what it was for, and that she did not propose, now she held it, to let it wait so idle again.

III

Of the Press at Cathair mhòr

A sheet the size of a door, once it is hung on a wall, wants explaining in a way a shire's own separate rolls, scattered across forty presses, never

1. the sheet of the vein

troubled anybody to explain; a fact spread thin is a fact nobody has to answer for, and a fact drawn whole is a fact somebody will shortly be asked how long it has been true. Catriona knew this before the first concession-holder asked her the question outright, standing before the sheet with his own family's share of the vein marked in red not four miles from where his grandfather had first opened it, and asking her, in a voice that wanted an answer and not a courtesy, how long the Board had known the ground he stood on would not last his own grandson's lifetime.

She did not have the answer, and told him so plainly, which he did not thank her for; and she went down, that winter, into the Board's own files at Cathair mhòr to find it, a room in the cellar of the house the Board had taken from the house of Mac Ùisdein some years before, where every survey the Board had received since the rule that kept them there and not at the Library was pressed flat in bundles by year and by district, none of it catalogued past the bundle's own outer label, and most of the labels themselves faded past reading by a lamp that gave, on its best evening, light enough to read one line in three.

It took her the better part of a week, by that same smoking lamp, working through bundle after bundle with a clerk's boy to fetch and carry, a lad of twelve named Ruairidh who had been sent down to the cellar so often on other men's errands that he knew the presses better than any surveyor on the Board's own roll, and who told her, the second evening, that she was the first person in his own three years of fetching who had ever asked him to read a label aloud rather than simply hand the bundle across. The cellar gave up its own kind of cold that no fire lit at the top of the stair ever quite reached, damp in the stone and a smell of old paper and mouse that neither of them remarked on past the first evening, and she kept, through all five days, a tally of her own in the back of her latest field-book, a line for every bundle opened and a word for what it held, much as she had once kept a tally of shafts sunk and shafts dry on a moor some thirty miles east of that same cellar.

She found what she had expected to find in the main, surveys thinning steadily in what they reported the further east and south she read, the language of each one's own year a little more careful than the last about saying outright what the figures already said plainly, a caution she recognised, by the third day, as the particular caution of a clerk who has learned that a plain word costs him more than a careful one and a plainer fact none of his own concern. Twice that week she thought she had found the roll her instinct told her must exist somewhere in that

cellar, and twice the date proved wrong or the hand too recent, and she set each aside with a small, private disappointment she did not trouble to name to the boy, until, near the bottom of a press she had all but finished with that week, her hand closed on a roll bound with a cord gone stiff with age and a knot nobody had troubled to untie in longer than the cord's own stiffness argued.

She untied it at the table, by the lamp's worst light of the whole week, and unrolled a survey of the Sloc Mòr's own faces, drawn in a hand she did not know, the vellum stiffened and the ink browned to the same tea-dark colour age gives every ink in the end, her own red not four feet away on the wall above, however brightly it still held its colour that morning. It showed the vein thinning to the east and to the south in terms that matched her own sheet stroke for stroke, in ground she herself had walked and marked red not eighteen months before, and it was dated, in the same unknown hand, thirty years before the year she sat reading it.

She read it through twice before she let herself do the arithmetic the date asked of her, and then a third time, more slowly, for the note pinned to its corner in a second hand, a Board clerk's, dry and brief: *received, filed*. Nothing more. No minute of a decision taken or a decision deferred, no record of who had read it, or whether anyone had, before it went into the press to wait thirty years for a lamp bright enough and a hand patient enough to find it again.

Ruairidh, watching her sit motionless over the roll longer than she had sat over any of the week's other finds, asked her at last what it was, and she told him only that it was proof somebody had already asked the question she had spent a year asking again, and that he need not trouble to fetch her anything further that evening, since whatever the rest of the cellar held, it would not now hold anything to match what her own two hands already did. Rather than leave the roll to be sent up with the rest, she carried it up the stair herself, and sat a long while that night at the Board's own long table, beneath her own sheet on the wall, reading the two surveys side by side by a better lamp than the cellar had given her, hers in red and the stranger's in ink gone the colour of tea, the same ground marked out in the same failing terms thirty years apart, and found, when she had finished the comparing, that she could not have said which of the two surveys troubled her more: the one that had found the truth, or the one that had been believed too late to matter.

IV

Of Muileann chiar

She sent the Library a copy of the survey that same week, with a note of her own giving the day the Board's own bundle showed it had first been received, and then, rather than wait on the Library's answer, rode east herself, the road she had ridden a hundred times on the Board's ordinary business now carrying a different weight than any of those hundred rides had, toward Muileann chiar, where the Board's own oldest rolls still gave the surveyor of record for the district thirty years back as one Iain mac Ruairidh, called, in every roll that troubled to give him a second name at all, Iain Mapa.

She had never met him, though the name was known to her the way a chain-hand knows a predecessor's marks left on old survey pegs. He had left the Sloc Mòr's own surveying for the silver works at Muileann chiar before she came up through the vein-towns herself, and the Board's roll listed him now only as retired, on a small pension the silver guild paid out of its own funds rather than trouble the Crown for it, a fact she had not thought worth remarking on until she stood at his own door in the last week of an Giblean and saw, through the window, an old man bent over a workbench doing nothing she could name from the glass, moving small objects from one side of the bench to the other with a slowness that had nothing hurried in it and nothing idle either.

Mòr, his wife, a refiner's daughter of the same town who had kept his house near twenty years, let her in and told her plainly, before Catrìona had said above three sentences of who she was, that her husband had been failing since the turn of the year and tired easily, and that whatever business had brought a Board rider so far east had best be short. The house was small and warm and smelled of the silver-work he had long since given up doing himself but had never given up keeping the tools for, fine files and a scale under glass and a tray of ore samples gone dull with handling, each one, Mòr told her while the kettle came to the boil, labelled in his own hand with the gallery it had come from and the year, a habit she said he had never once broken in twenty years of marriage, whatever else about him the years had worn away.

Iain mac Ruairidh, three-and-sixty that spring, did not look, to Catrìona, like a man failing; he looked like a man who had set down, some years before, whatever weight a younger man carries without knowing he carries it, and had not troubled to pick it up again since. His hands, when he took hers in greeting,

were steadier than she had expected of a man his wife called failing, though slow, and his eyes went first, before her face, to the mud still on her boots from the ride, a surveyor's own habit of reading a stranger by the ground she had lately walked. He asked her, before she had properly sat, whether the roll he had filed thirty years back still had his name on it, and when she told him it did, in another man's hand pinned to the corner, he smiled in a way she did not at first know how to read, and told her to fetch, from the second drawer of the same workbench she had watched him through the window, a folded paper he had kept there longer than his own children had been alive.

It was his own copy of the survey, the twin of the one she had found in the Board's own press, folded small and soft at the creases from thirty years of handling, and pinned to it, in ink gone no less brown than the Board's own copy, a receipt: *Received of Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, one survey of the faces of the Sloc Mòr, rolled and tied, this day. Filed.* It was signed by a Board man, Ruairidh mac Ailein, whose name meant nothing to her and would have meant nothing to anyone who had not, as she had that same week, read it once already at the foot of a Board minute thirty years old.

"I asked for it," he told her, "because a man who hands a fact to three other men in a room and walks out again with nothing to show for it has, by the next morning, no way of proving he ever handed it to them at all. It did not occur to me, asking for it, that I should still be showing it to anyone thirty years on. If I thought anything at all that day, it was that someone would read the survey long before the receipt for it ever wanted reading."

She told him what her own sheet showed, the red ink and the door-sized leaf and the shire's own concession-holder asking her, before the whole Board's chamber, how long the ground had been known to be failing, and he listened to the whole of it without once interrupting her, which she came to understand, before she had finished, was not patience so much as a want of surprise; he had known, in his own gut, exactly what her sheet would show, long before she had ever begun drawing it. Mòr, standing at the door with the kettle still in her hand, asked once whether he wanted to rest before hearing more, and he told her, gently enough that Catrìona judged it an old exchange between them and not a new one, that a man did not tire of hearing, after thirty years, that he had been right.

He asked her, when she had done, a little about the search for a second vein, which he had followed at a distance from Muileann chiar and judged, at the time, a search worth making even knowing it would fail, since a kingdom that has never

troubled to look cannot afterward claim the looking would have made no difference; and he asked her, too, whether the school at Caol shean still kept its old question about why the vein answered some hands and none others, a thing he said he had wondered himself more than once in thirty years of watching men dig ground that answered nobody at all. When she had done he said only that it was a strange thing, to be believed at last by a woman not born when he had first gone unbelieved, and that he did not know whether the strangeness of it was better or worse than the thirty years that had come before it. He did not answer his own question, and she did not ask him to. Before she left, he walked her as far as the gate, slower than the distance asked for, and told her there, at the gatepost, that he did not propose to make old friends of thirty years' silence now that one woman had troubled to break it, and that she was to ride safe and mind the ford below Muileann chiar, which flooded most springs and had taken a surveyor's horse from under him once, years before, though not, he added, his own.

V

Of the Bell at Caol shean

he died not a fortnight after her riding home, in the first days of an Cèitean, at his own workbench, and Mòr found him there in the evening in much the position Catriona had first seen him through the window, small objects still laid out before him in an order only he had ever understood. The silver guild that had paid his small pension for the ten years since his retirement sent, as its own custom asked, a single ounce of refined silver to be laid in the ground with him, a mark of a working life spent honestly among its faces, and the guild's own master said over him, at a burial the whole street of retired surveyors and refiners turned out for, that Iain mac Ruairidh had gone down into more of the mountain's own dark than any three men living and had never once come up lying about what he found there, which the master judged, of a surveyor, the only epitaph worth the cutting.

Among his papers, going through them in the weeks that followed with a patience her own grief did not much help her to, Mòr found the folded survey where he had always kept it, the receipt still pinned to its corner exactly as Catriona had seen it, and sent the whole of it south to the Library at Muileann chaol, with a note in her own hand saying only that her husband had asked, more

than once in his last years, that it not be lost a second time, and that she did not know a safer place to send it than the one place in the kingdom that had never once told him his work was filed and nothing more. The keeper who received it, Mòrag nic Coinnich, entered it in the Library's own hand, as her practice was, with a note of where it had come from and who had sent it, so that a roll thirty years lost and a widow's own letter came, in the end, to be kept side by side on the same shelf, each answering for the other.

Catrìona resigned the office of surveyor-general before that same year was out, the Board's own minute recording it in four lines as flat as any minute the Board had ever kept, and went, within the season, to teach at the druid school at Caol shean, where the old question the schools had never stopped asking, why the vein answered some hands and not others, had begun, in the years since the search's own failure, to sound less like a riddle and more like the only honest question left to ask of a mountain that had, by every sheet the Board could now draw, very little answering left in it. She told the school's own teachers, in the letter that secured her the place, that she had spent all her working years learning to read what the ground would give and meant now to spend what years remained her learning to teach others to read it sooner than she had, which she judged, on the evidence of one thirty-year-old roll and one dry receipt, the only lesson in her own trade worth the passing on.

Muileann dhearg, in the few years that followed, lost near a third of its households to the ports and the southern yards, its people going where work still answered a chain and a lamp, families that had cut coal at Muileann dhearg for three and four generations loading a cart with what it would hold and leaving the rest, and the maor's own count of empty houses, kept at first out of ordinary habit and then out of something closer to alarm, ran by the third year to above sixty within the shire's own walls alone. Its Fèidh hall, given back to the druid school not ten years before, was shut for want of a congregation left to keep it, the last teacher there locking its door herself and carrying the key to the maor's own house rather than leave it with no one, and its bell taken down and sold, on the shire's own vote, to the same school at Caol shean that had lately gained a surveyor for a teacher, the sale bringing the shire less coin than the bell's own casting had cost a hundred years before, which nobody at the vote troubled to remark on aloud.

At Ceann leathan the coal-ships waited at the quay for cargoes that came in half loaded where they had once come in full, their masters pacing the harbour

wall through whole afternoons waiting on a hold that filled slower every season, and the harbour dues falling by half within two seasons, and the fair-wardens, whose town lived as much off the coal trade as off the Còmhrag's own purse, raised the gate-price of the melee that autumn to make up what the quay no longer earned them, a rise the fair's own crowds paid without much complaint, there being few among them, by then, who had not already heard what a door-sized sheet at Cathair mhòr was said to show.

Of the sheet the Board's own minute has nothing further to say; it hangs still, so far as the Library's last word of it goes, on the wall of the chamber at Cathair mhòr where Catrìona nic Neacail first put it up, the red ink holding its colour better than the ink-maker had dared promise her. Any concession-holder who cares to stand before it and count can read, in that one leaf, exactly how much of the mountain's one true vein remains to be worked before the counting is done.

Catrìona gave her first lecture at Caol shean on a bright morning in an t-Iuchar, the students of the school gathered in the house at Caol shean where Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain had carried the old question through the wet months, and as she began to speak the bell that had rung out the last vigil at Muileann dhearg's own shut hall, hung now in the school's own modest tower, was rung for the first time to call the school in, its note carrying clear and a little strange across ground that had never before heard it, an old sound finding, at Caol shean, a use its makers at Muileann dhearg had never once intended for it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Of the Crown Alone

SE 58 AN T-SULTAIN – SE 60 AN LÙNASTAL

The charter names the Board a carrier of the Crown's people and their goods. A carrier that will take one man's coin and refuse another's answers to no charter at all.

— Ruairidh mac Phàdraig, ruling given at Seann Bhràl in the west, 31 an Dàmhair, SE 59

I

Of the Market that Passed the Fair

The news came north the way most news came to Caol mhòr that decade, a season behind the fact and by way of a carter who had heard it from a factor who had heard it from someone nearer the matter: that the market day at Baile Mòr dhomhain, on the deep river in the hill country, had for two years running drawn more carts than the fair at Muileann òg, the old fair the whole island had measured its trade by since before the restored kingdom had a name of its own. Daniel Frayne heard it from a wool-buyer at the Moot's own table, a man come down from the hills to sell what Baile Mòr dhomhain's own market no longer had room to take, and turned it over a while before he wrote it into the room's ledger of the year's business, under no heading that fit it well, since it was not a Moot matter and yet seemed to him, turning three-and-fifty that autumn, a thing the room ought to have set down somewhere.

"The vein feeds fewer hands each year," he said to Mary Coyle's old clerk, who still kept the room's figures though the chair was Frayne's own now, "and the hill country feeds more of them than it did. A market goes where the coin already is,

and stops waiting on a fair that has had the same coin coming to it every year since anyone living can remember." The clerk said this was truer than the room had leisure to argue with that morning, there being three causes waiting and a letter from Muileann shean not yet opened, and Frayne let the matter go for the day, though he kept the wool-buyer's fact in his own private book beside the register of the hurt, a habit he had never broken since the winter he first began it.

The crown changed hands that same season, and of it the room at Caol mhòr knew only what any household on the island knew: that Eòghan's reign had ended, at two-and-sixty, the notice giving no word of how, and that Mairead, eight-and-thirty, had been crowned at Cathair dhearg by Macha's rite, as every ruler of the restored line had been crowned before her. The room's clerks noted the day and the name and went back to their own ledgers, the Moot having no place in a rite it was never asked to, nor coin to spare for a journey south to watch it, and Frayne, reading the notice a second time before he filed it, found in it nothing to say beyond what the notice already said, a fact and no more, the kind he had learned young to set down plainly and leave alone. He noted only, in his own book and nowhere else, that Eòghan had held the throne since Frayne was a young man at Agnes Pike's benches, and that the coin that winter would be minted new with another name on it.

The mint's own notice reached Caol mhòr some weeks after the crowning, later than the news of it had come by mouth, and told the room only what such notices ever told it, that the die was changed and the old coin still good until the new one was struck in sufficient number, a fact of no more moment to a clerk's ledger than the changing of a season, save that Frayne, weighing one of the last old coins in his own hand before he passed it across the table for a debt owed the Moot, thought it a strange thing that a face stamped on metal should outlast, in most households' own reckoning, the man who had worn it, no household at Caol mhòr troubling any longer to name Eòghan at its own table where once his name had been the one every household knew.

He had seen the fair at Muileann òg only a few times in his own life, the first with the wool carts down the Carters' Road, and he remembered it as a crowd too large for any one man to take the measure of, the factors' own tents strung the length of a field that seemed, to a boy from the north, to have no far edge at all. He asked the wool-buyer, before the man rode on, whether the fair still looked so to a stranger's eye, and the man told him that it did, near enough, to a stranger who had never seen it in its better years, but that a man who had stood in that

field every autumn for thirty years running, as the wool-buyer had, could see the gaps now where the tents had once stood three deep, gaps the fair's own wardens filled each year with a wider aisle and called it room for the crowd to move, though the crowd had not grown to want the room.

The letter from Muileann shean, when he opened it, asked a different question of him entire, and one he had some part in answering. The mill-town in the north had that spring opened a school of its own for the sons and daughters of hewers the Guild would not bind, the Guild having voted, for the first time since its charter, to bind no new apprentices at all beyond the sons and daughters of its own masters, the vein by then thinning under enough of the old galleries that a guild grown used to feeding every willing pair of hands had, that year, more hands than it any longer had work to give them. Muileann shean's school meant to teach those turned away to read, to reckon, and to survey, on the reasoning of the shire's own maor, who had written the letter himself, that a hewer's child shut out of the pit might still find his father's own trade from the surface rather than the gallery, chain in hand instead of pick, if someone thought to teach him the chain. He asked the Moot for primers, there being none in the north fit for the purpose and no coin in the shire's own dues to have new ones bound.

Frayne read the letter twice and then a third time, standing at the window of the room he had sat in as a clerk for more years than he had sat in it as speaker, and thought of Agnes Pike, dead that same year, who had taught him his letters in a byre at Doire ghlas on slates the school could not always find chalk for, and of the room she had kept, and of what she had once told him, a boy of ten with more questions than sense, that a trade a man could carry in his own head weighed nothing on the road and could not be taken from him by any Board that ever sat. He wrote back to Muileann shean that he would bind the primers himself, at his own bench, and send them north with the first cart that had room, and did so within the month, forty copies of a reading-book he had set the type for himself twenty years before and kept the forms for since, the ink still smelling of the press when the bundle went out on the cart. The shire's maor wrote back in the spring to say that the eleven children the school had opened with had grown, within the year, past thirty, and that three of the first eleven had already gone south to the ports to hire themselves out as chain-hands, the surveying trade being one, as it turned out, the ports had more use for than the Board's own vein-towns did just then.

II

Of the Doire ghlais Bolt and the Suit

The mills at Doire ghlais were three years building by the time they turned their first cloth, raised with the Moot's own money on ground the Church had let stand idle since the Severance, the first works the north had ever owned that owed nothing to the vein and nothing to any southern charter either. Frayne had sat on the room's own committee that voted the money out of the Moot's slender chest, a vote he had argued for on grounds he set down plainly in the room's minute, that a people who wove their own cloth need not buy the south's, and that a mill built with the north's own coin answered to the north's own reckoning and to no factor's. The first bolt came off the looms in the last week of an t-Iuchar, a grey twill with a white thread run through the selvedge, the same mark the weavers of Doire ghlais had first been let sell under their own name at the fair some years before, and the mill's own overseer sent word to Caol mhòr the same week, a short letter that said only that the cloth was good, better than the south's own factors had reckoned a northern loom could turn out, and that the mill stood ready to sell it wherever a buyer's coin was willing.

The buyer's coin, when it came, found no way to travel. The Rail Board's own factors at Àth leathan, the railhead nearest the north, asked to carry the first wagon-load down the coal line to the fair at Muileann òg, where the southern trade was and where the cloth would fetch a price the north's own markets could not match, refused the load without troubling to give a reason beyond the one the Board had given every Tuathaich cargo since the line was laid, that the line carried what the Board judged fit to carry and answered to no one for the judging. The mill's overseer wrote to Caol mhòr a second time, angrier than the first, and Frayne read the letter to the room himself, standing at the same table Mary Coyle had once stood at to open the register of the hurt.

"We have asked the Board before to carry what we make," he told the room, "and been told before that the asking was not the Board's to answer. I mean, this time, to ask a court instead, since a Board that will not answer a letter may yet answer a summons." The room's older clerks, who remembered every earlier asking and every earlier refusal, doubted a Dia-threach court would hear a Tuathaich complaint any more kindly than the Board had, and said so plainly, but the room voted the coin for the journey all the same, there being, as one of them put it,

little enough left to lose in the asking that the mill had not already lost in the refusing.

Frayne rode west that autumn to Seann Bhral, the circuit's own western seat on the coast, three days' road from Caol mhòr and one he had never ridden before, carrying the mill's own ledgers and the Board's own letter of refusal, kept whole rather than answered, in the same satchel he carried his private book in. He was four-and-fifty that year, and told the clerk who took his papers at the courthouse door, a young man who had plainly never before entered a Tuathaich name on the circuit's own roll, that he had come to bring a cause and not a petition, the distinction, he said, mattering rather more to him than the clerk seemed at first to grasp it did.

The justice who heard it was Ruairidh mac Phàdraig, four-and-forty that year, a man who had sat the western circuit for a dozen years and had, by his own account given later to a clerk who asked him, never before had a Tuathaich cause brought properly before his own bench rather than settled or dropped before it reached him. He heard the Board's own factor first, a well-dressed man from Ceann leathan who argued that the line was the Board's own property, raised with the Board's own coin and the Crown's own charter, and that a carrier might choose its own cargo as freely as a merchant chose his own stock. Ruairidh mac Phàdraig asked him, when he had finished, whether the charter that raised the line had named the Board a merchant or a carrier, and the factor, after a silence the court's own clerk noted in his record without comment, allowed that the charter's own words called it a carrier, there being no way to answer otherwise with the charter lying open on the bench between them.

Frayne spoke for the mill himself, having no advocate the Moot's own coin could stretch to and no wish, he told the court, to hire one, since the facts of the matter were plain enough that a plain man could lay them out without a trained tongue to dress them. He read the Board's letter of refusal aloud, word for word, and set beside it the mill's own account of the coin it had offered to pay for the carriage, a rate no lower than any southern mill paid for the same road, and asked the court only the one question the room at Caol mhòr had sent him west to ask, whether a carrier chartered by the Crown to carry for the Crown's own people might refuse one people among them and take another's coin freely.

The factor pressed his own point a second way before the court rose that first day, saying that the Board had carried Tuathaich cargo before, wool by the cart-load in years the road had allowed it, and that the refusal touched only the line,

the Board's own rails being a different property from the Board's own carts and answerable, in the factor's own reading of the charter, to a different clause entire. Ruairidh mac Phàdraig had the charter read aloud a second time at that, the whole of it, clause by clause, by the court's own clerk, a reading that took the better part of an hour and left the factor, by its end, with no clause left to point to that named the rails apart from the carts, the charter's own drafters having written, as the justice observed when the reading was done, of "the carriage of the Crown's people and their goods" without once troubling to say by what wheel or what rail the carriage was to be made. Frayne, listening from the bench set aside for him, wrote the justice's own words into his private book that same evening, judging them, he told the room afterward, worth keeping whole rather than in his own paraphrase.

Ruairidh mac Phàdraig gave his ruling three days later, at the same bench, in words the court's clerk copied fair and Frayne carried home whole, that the Rail Board was a carrier of the Crown and bound, by the Crown's own charter, to carry for any who paid the rate it set, whatever the cargo's maker, and that it had no more right to refuse the Doire ghlais mill's cloth than it had to refuse a southern factor's grain. The Board appealed the ruling to the council at Cathair dhearg within the month, as Frayne had expected it would, and the appeal sat unanswered on the council's own table through that winter and the spring following, until it was let lapse in the summer without a word given either way, the council's own minute of the matter, when the room at Caol mhòr at last obtained a copy of it, noting only that the matter had not been reached in the session's business, a phrase Frayne read three times before he understood it meant the council did not mean to reach it at all.

"It is not a victory they have given us," he told the room, the letter open before him, "only a defeat they have declined to trouble themselves with undoing. I will take it. I have taken smaller things for larger names before now." The room's older clerks, who had doubted him at the start of the asking, said nothing against him that day, and one of them, the same who had first doubted a Dia-thìreach court would hear a Tuathaich cause kindly, wrote in the room's own minute, in a hand Frayne kept and read again more than once in the years after, that it was the first ruling of any Dia-thìreach court the Moot had ever won standing, and that a first was worth the keeping whatever came after it.

III

Of the Copper and the Last Shafts

The same seasons that carried the Board's own refusal to Seann Bhral and back carried other news south of the north entirely, news Frayne read of rather than rode to. The house of Mac Ùisdein, which had sold half its own share in the Sloc Mòr some years before to answer a search that had found nothing, sold what remained of its working shafts to the Crown outright the next summer, keeping only its share in the spoil-heaps and the quarry-stone the mine's own waste still yielded, and the Board's own clerks, moving the last of the house's papers out of the stone house at Cathair mhòr, wrote in their minute that the vein was thenceforth worked in the Crown's name alone, no house's own charter standing beside the Crown's upon it any longer. Frayne, reading the notice at Caol mhòr, thought of Alasdair mac Ùisdein, whom he had never met, and of the note of hand that had begun the search, and set the thought down nowhere, there being no place in the room's own business for a southern house's own ruin, however plainly it answered a question the vein had been asking the whole kingdom for years. He thought too, reading it, of the Board's own surveyor who had drawn the search's last sheet and then resigned her post to teach at the druid school at Caol shean, a woman he had never met either and knew only by the name a Board clerk had once let fall to him in passing, and wondered, folding the notice away, whether a surveyor who had walked forty-one dry shafts for a house now selling what little the shafts had left it found any particular satisfaction in the selling, or only the same flat notice the rest of the kingdom was left to read.

Copper was found that same year in the hills behind Àth fhiadhaich, in the eastern country, and the Board opened a working there within the season, hiring men laid off from the Sloc Mòr's own thinning galleries at a wage the Board's own notice called fair and the men themselves, by what word of it reached Caol mhòr, called better than nothing, which in that season was the higher praise. It was not the vein, and no one at Àth fhiadhaich troubled to call it so; the town's own house of the Old Spirits, keeping the oldest folk rite on the island by the ford where its river fishers still blessed their nets, gave the new working no blessing when it was asked, the house's own keeper telling the Board's factor, by the account that reached the north secondhand and perhaps not word for word, that copper dug for a wage was copper dug like any other stone, and that a house which blessed the fishers' nets for their own sake, not the catch's, saw no cause to

bless a working got up only to keep men fed who had lost a richer trade. The Board took the answer without argument and worked the copper regardless, blessed or not, the men themselves glad of the wage whatever the house at Àth fhiadhaich thought fit to say over it.

Frayne set both notices, the last shafts sold and the copper unblessed, into his own private book that autumn, beside the wool-buyer's fact about Baile Mòr dhomhain and the letter from Muileann shean, and read the four together one evening at his own table, the room at Caol mhòr empty around him and the lamp burned low. A kingdom whose founding wealth was failing, he wrote, might sell its last shafts to itself and dig for copper it could not bless and still call itself the same kingdom it had been the year before, since a crown changes nothing of what it stands over merely by changing the head it sits on; but a mill that had stood three years building and a court that had ruled for it once, however grudged the ruling, were the north's own doing entire, owing nothing to any southern coin or any southern charter's goodwill, and he judged, closing the book that night, that this was the larger fact of the two, whatever the council's own minutes chose to spend their ink on.

The first bale went out from Doire ghlas on the coal line in the last days of an Lùnastal the following summer, the ruling near a year settled and the Board's own factors at Àth leathan weighing it onto the wagon without comment, as they weighed any other cargo that paid the rate. Frayne rode down to see it loaded, having business in the west that week regardless and no wish to let the day pass unwitnessed, and stood at the wagon's side as the bale went up, the grey twill wrapped in sacking against the road's own dust, the white thread at its hidden selvedge the only mark that told a stranger's eye it had not come off a southern loom at all. Two of the mill's own weavers had ridden down from Doire ghlas to see the bale off, young women neither of whom had been born when Frayne first rode the Carters' Road with the wool carts, and one of them asked him, watching the sacking go up, whether the cloth would fetch a fair price at Muileann òg or a mean one, the same question the fair had answered every year of his own working life without ever quite answering it the same way twice. He told her he did not know, and that no clerk of the Moot's had ever known it in advance, only after, but that a bale which travelled at all, carried by right and not by grudging leave, was worth more to the room at Caol mhòr than any single season's price could be, whatever that price turned out to be. She said this sounded to her like a speaker's own answer, given to spare her a plainer one, and he allowed, laughing despite

himself for the first time that week, that it was exactly that, and that a speaker who had spent thirty years in the trade owed her at least the honesty of saying so. The factor who signed the wagon's own manifest was the same man, by chance or by the Board's own thin bench of factors at that station, who had refused the first load the year before, and he gave the bale no more notice now than he gave the crates of nails beside it, which Frayne judged, watching the wagon pull away toward the south and the fair it would reach in two days' time, the truest measure the Board could have given of what the ruling had actually won them, the same plain weight any other cargo carried, asked for once and carried without a second asking.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Of the Pumps and the Panthers

SE 61 AN T-ÒGMHIOS – SE 63 AN LÙNASTAL

A crossing is a crossing, and a hungry year is a hungry year, and neither waits on the other so exactly that a man may set his harvest by it. I set mine down all the same, and struck it through when the wheat proved me wrong, since a chronicle that will not own its own bad guesses is worth less than the guessing.

— Tormod Pinn, note appended to his entry on 11 an Lùnastal, SE

62

I

Of the Street Named for the Pit

The copper at Àth fhiadhaich drew men the way any new working draws them in a kingdom whose old one is thinning, and by the second summer of the digging the town had built, on the slope above the ford, a street of new stone houses for the miners come down from the Sloc Mòr's own failing galleries, men who had learned their trade in one pit and carried it, wage and tools and all, to another. The town's own council named the street before the last house on it had a roof, in the way a council names a thing quickly so as not to leave the naming to whoever finishes building last, and the name it chose was for the pit the miners had come from rather than the one they had come to: Sràid an t-Sluic¹, the street of the pit, so that a man walking up from the ford at Àth fhi-

1. the street of the pit

adhaich passed under a sign naming a mountain he could not see from any window on the street at all.

The house of the Old Spirits at Àth fhiadhaich, which had given the new copper working no blessing when it opened, gave the naming no blessing either, and its keeper, the same woman who had told the Board's factor two summers before that copper dug for a wage was copper dug like any other stone, told the council now, by the word that reached Tormod Pinn at Muileann chaol some months after and which he judged worth the keeping, that a street should be named for the ground it stood on and not for the ground its people had left, and that a town which named its own streets after another town's mountain risked forgetting which mountain it lived under. The council heard her out, as councils do, and kept the name, there being no other ready to hand and no time, with winter coming on and roofs still unfinished, to argue one out. Tormod set the exchange down in four lines, the keeper's words nearly whole and the council's answer reduced to the one fact that mattered, that the name stood; he had learned young, from the chronicler who had trained him, that a chronicle owed a speaker her own words and owed a council only its own decision, the two debts being of a different weight entire.

The miners themselves, by every account that reached the Library that year, troubled the name less than their own council or their own priesthood did, a man newly down from the Sloc Mòr's own thinning galleries having, as Tormod judged when he set the matter down, a keener interest in the roof over his family's own new-built house than in the word painted above its door; two of the households on the street had brought with them, folded in a chest with the rest of their goods, small lumps of coal from the Sloc Mòr's own upper galleries, kept less for any use than for the plain fact of having carried something out of a mountain that had otherwise given their households nothing back for the digging. He set down, in the same entry and in fewer words still, what little came to him that season out of the north: that a man there had begun trying to draw a fuel from the waste of the mines, to stand in the coal's place, and that the trying had come to nothing. Tormod wrote the sentence once and moved on to the next matter waiting on his desk, and it is very nearly the whole of what the record of those years troubles to say of it.

Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, who had come to the Library three years before as a clerk of the second circuit and been kept on since at Tormod's own asking, copied both entries fair into the day-book that evening, a task she had done for him most

evenings of those three years, and asked him, setting down her pen, whether a street's wrong name mattered enough to trouble a chronicle with four lines when the season had brought harder matters. Tormod told her that a chronicle worked as a net rather than a court, taking in what came its way rather than weighing each thing first against what mattered more, and that a net which let the small fish through on the grounds that they were small ended, after enough seasons, holding nothing at all worth the hauling. She said this sounded like a saying he had used on her before, and he allowed, not looking up from the letter he had begun on the desk's other corner, that a chronicler who found himself a new saying every year had probably stopped chronicling and started only talking, and that he hoped, at five-and-seventy, not yet to have crossed that particular line.

II

Of the Galleries Let Go

The letter he had begun that evening was to the Board's own clerk at Cathair mhòr, asking, as he had asked twice before that year without an answer worth the copying, what truth lay behind the word that had reached Muileann chaol from three separate quarters that the Sloc Mòr's lowest galleries stood flooded and the Board's own pumps idle above them. The answer came at last in the new year, a single sheet signed by a clerk whose name Tormod did not know, saying that the lowest workings had been let stand under water since the turn of the season, the cost of running the pumps against so little coal as the lowest seams still gave having outrun, by the Board's own reckoning, whatever that coal was worth at the fair; the sheet called it a pause, in the Board's own hand, and gave no day by which the pause was expected to end.

Tormod rode south that spring to see the thing himself, a journey he made perhaps once in three years and only when a report troubled him past the patience of a second letter, and stood at the pit-head above Achadh dhomhain on a morning cold enough that the pump-house's own chimney, drawing no fire that day, showed no more smoke than the empty sheds beside it. The overseer who walked him down to the lip of the lowest shaft, a man Tormod had met twice before in twenty years of such visits and each time greyer, told him that the water had come up eleven fathoms in the flooded galleries and showed no sign yet of finding its own level, and that the pumps which might have held it down had stood cold

since the turn of the season on the Board's own order, an order the overseer read to him from a slip of paper he kept folded in his coat as though he expected, someday, to need to prove he had not imagined it. Tormod asked him whether the Board meant the pause for a season or for good, and the overseer said that a pause a man's own coat had to carry proof of was a pause that had already outlasted whatever the word was meant to promise, and that he for his own part called it by its right name among the other overseers, though never where a Board clerk might hear him say it.

The pumps themselves, three great engines the Board's own founders had cast at Cathair mhòr thirty years before, when the lowest galleries had still paid for the coal to run them, stood drawn out of their housings and loaded onto flat wagons before the summer was old, sold, by the Board's own notice, to the harbour works at Seann Bhral in the south, where a new dry dock wanted draining faster than its own smaller engines could manage. Tormod watched the first of the three go down the coal line from a siding above Achadh dhomhain, the engine lashed under canvas against the road's own dust and rain, and thought, watching it, of the wool-buyer's fact that had reached Caol mhòr some years before, that a market goes where the coin already is; a pump, it seemed to him, went where the water was, and cared no more than any bolt of cloth for the ground it had been built to serve. He wrote in his own book that evening, in words he judged too plain for the day-book's own hand and kept instead for himself, that a kingdom which sold the engines that held its own mountain dry to drain another man's harbour had answered, without troubling to say so anywhere in its own minute, the question the search of ten years before had failed outright to answer, and had answered it the way such questions are answered oftenest, by a bill of sale and not by a chronicle's own reckoning.

The overseer at Achadh dhomhain wrote to him once more that autumn, a shorter letter than the first, to say that the second pump had followed the first to Seann Bhral and the third stood ready to go, and that the men who had tended the three of them between them, six in all, had been found work on the working galleries still above water, the Board's own notice calling it no loss to any household, which the overseer, signing his own name this time rather than none, judged worth passing on without comment of his own, there being comment enough, he wrote, in the plain fact for anyone troubling to read it.

III

Of Imrich nam Pantar

The word that reached Muileann chaol from the south-west that same summer came by a rounder road, a shire's own maor writing first to the Board of a stock loss he judged too large for the ordinary account of wolves and weather, and the Board's clerk, having no ledger of his own fit to hold it, passing the letter on to the Library as a thing more fit for a chronicle than a rent-roll. The maor wrote that a great host of the great cats the south-west herders called panthers, tawny beasts the size of a two-year calf that came down out of the high passes by the same road every so many years and had not been seen, by any herder's own memory then living, in longer than any of them could put a number to, had crossed the hill country near Baile dhomhain that spring by the old road the maps still called Imrich nam Pantar¹, and that for the better part of a month the flocks pastured along that road had lost more stock to the crossing than the shire's own dues could easily bear the loss of.

Tormod set the letter beside an older paper the Library kept, a list drawn up in the days of An Aois Naomh² naming the years such a crossing had come before, a list he had first found reason to open only twice in the whole of his own chronicling, and found the crossing named there under a year whose distance from his own he worked out with a care he gave few other sums, the interval between one crossing and the last being, by the old list's own reckoning, longer than any single herder's working life, so that no man now living at Baile dhomhain had seen it before and none now living there was like to see it again. He wrote the entry longer than any other that year, setting the maor's own count of the stock lost beside the old list's count from the crossing before it, the two figures agreeing near enough that he judged the coincidence worth remarking, and noted, at the entry's foot, that the old list named the year following such a crossing a hungry one, the cats' passing having been reckoned, by whatever reasoning the Holy Age's own tellers had kept, to trouble the land's own bearing for a season after as much as it troubled the flocks during.

The herders themselves, by the second half of the maor's letter, had done what the old road's own name promised they would, driving what stock they could off the path beforehand and keeping the crossing days as a season of watching rather

1. the panthers' crossing

2. the Holy Age

than working, and had lost, in the end, fewer beasts than the first week's count had feared, though more than any recent year had cost them. The tanners of Baile ghorm on the coast below, hearing of the crossing before the herders had finished counting their own losses, sent buyers up into the hills within the fortnight to take the hides of whatever cats the herders' own dogs and spears had brought down defending the flocks, paying a price the herders judged fair for a skin they had no other use for and the tanners judged cheap for a hide unlike any that came to their vats in an ordinary year. Baile ghorm's own tanners cured the skins through that summer by a craft the maor's letter did not trouble to describe and Tormod did not think to ask after, and the fair at Muileann òg the following year saw, for the first time in any chronicler's own memory, saddles and belts of panther-hide sold under the Baile ghorm mark, a fashion that took the southern buyers by surprise enough that the mark's own price doubled twice before the fair's ten days were out.

Tormod wrote of the saddles too, the following spring, a shorter entry than the crossing's own, noting only that the trade in the hides had outlasted the crossing by longer than any single season and that Baile ghorm's tanners meant, by every word that reached him, to keep the mark going as long as a hide came to hand to sell under it. Beathag, copying the entry, asked him whether it was proper for the chronicle to note a trade that might, for all either of them could tell that year, come to nothing within a season or two, and Tormod told her that a chronicle's business was what a year had actually done and not what a later year might undo, and that a note honestly wrong in ten years' time cost the Library less than a note never set down at all for fear of being wrong.

IV

Of the Lent Lamps and the Yard at Muileann chrom

The same summer that carried the panthers south brought a smaller trouble north, one that reached Tormod first through the coal-line's own carters, who complained of it at every siding between Muileann mhin and Muileann chaol long before any shire's maor troubled to write it down. The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, whose forges turned out the greater part of every shaft-lamp the vein-towns burned, had halved their own making that year for want of coal enough to fire the forges properly, the coal that reached Muileann

mhin coming thinner and dearer with every season the Sloc Mòr's own galleries gave less of it up, and a town that made lamps by burning coal to shape the iron those same lamps then burned more of had found, that year, the two ends of its own trade closing on each other like a door.

The pits themselves, left short of new lamps and unwilling to send men below without light enough to see the roof by, took to lending shaft-lamps from gallery to gallery and pit to pit as need moved, a habit no charter had ever set down rules for and the Guild of Hewers, finding itself with no clause to govern it either, met by keeping a minute-book at its own hall, a plain ledger in which any overseer borrowing a dozen lamps from a neighbouring pit entered the number, the day, and his own name against repayment. Tormod sent to the Guild's hall for a copy of the book's first year, judging it a thing the Library ought to hold against the day some later chronicler asked how the pits had managed a coal so scarce it could not always light its own diggers, and found in it, when the copy came, more names entered against debts than names entered against repayments, a ledger that told, in its own dry column of borrowings, a plainer account of the vein's own thinning than any letter the Board had troubled to write him that year.

The trouble at Muileann chrom, when it came that same summer, was of a different order, and reached him first as three lines in a Board notice and only later, and at greater length, in a letter from the custodian of the yard's own small house of the Rite, a man Tormod had corresponded with before on lesser matters and trusted more than he trusted the Board's own notices. The yard families who kept the coal trains running between the Sloc Mòr and the coast, seeing their own wages cut that spring by an order the Board judged no more than the coal's own falling price required, stopped the trains outright for three days running, the first stoppage of its kind the line had known since it was laid, and put forward as their spokesman a man of one-and-forty named Dòmhnall Ruadh mac Ailein, whose father had laid the first rail at Muileann chrom with his own hands and who had worked the yard himself since he was a boy of twelve.

Dòmhnall Ruadh, by the custodian's account, asked the Board's own factor for nothing more than the wage restored to what it had stood at the year before, and told him, in words the custodian judged worth the copying whole, that a family which had laid the rail, tended it, and kept it running through every season the line had known could not be paid less for the same work merely because the mountain the rail served had grown poorer, the mountain's own poverty being the Board's misfortune and not the yard's making. The Board's factor answered,

on the third day, that the wage would stand as it had before the cut, the stoppage having cost the Board more in halted coal than the cut itself had saved it in a season, and the trains ran again on the fourth day at the old rate; on the fifth, the Board's own notice named eleven men dismissed from the yard for their part in the stopping, Dòmhnall Ruadh among them, the settlement of the wage and the dismissal of its askers arriving, by the custodian's own dry observation, in the same week and from the same hand.

The custodian who wrote to him of it kept, besides his house's own register, a small book of his own in which he set down the yard's grievances as its families brought them to him, a habit Tormod recognised at once as a chronicler's own habit worn by a man who had never called it that, and told him so in his answering letter, adding that a house which kept such a book against the day some larger matter needed it had done the Library's own work a season before the Library knew to ask for it.

Tormod set the whole of it down at greater length than the panthers had had, the wage restored and the eleven put out being, he judged, a thing later readers would want in full rather than in summary, and wrote at the entry's close, in the day-book's own plain hand and not merely his private one this time, that a Board which answered a stoppage by giving the families their wage and taking their spokesman's own place from him had settled nothing it meant to keep settled, and that a chronicle owed its readers the plain fact of both halves of such a bargain, not only the half that looked, on the Board's own notice, like a kindness.

V

Of the Strike-Through

The harvest that autumn, across the whole of the south and west both, came in better than any the shires had reckoned on since before the search for a second vein had first been spoken of, the wheat standing thick enough at Cathair fhada that the maor there wrote to Muileann chaol of granaries built for a leaner year now wanting a second storey to hold what the first year's fields had actually given. Tormod read the maor's own letter at his desk in the last week of an Lùnastal, the panthers' crossing more than a year behind the kingdom by then and the old list's warning of a hungry year to follow it a full season overdue with no want anywhere the letters reached him to bear it out, and sat some while with

his own book open at the entry he had written the spring before, the ink long dry and the words, read again in a good year's light, sounding to him now less like a chronicler's careful reckoning and more like an old man's fright dressed in an old list's borrowed authority.

He took up his pen, dipped it, and drew a single line through his own sentence, the one naming the year to come a hungry one by the Holy Age's own reckoning, leaving the words legible beneath the stroke as the Library's own practice required of every correction, a chronicle owing its readers its wrong guesses as plainly as its right ones, and wrote beneath it, in the same hand, that the harvest of the year following the crossing had proved thick rather than thin across the south and west, and that the old list, whatever true word it had kept of crossings a dozen lifetimes gone, had kept no word this time that the wheat troubled to answer to.

Beathag, coming in from the outer room with the day's letters, found him sitting with the book still open before him and the ink not yet blotted, and asked whether he meant the line to stand, a chronicler striking through his own words being a thing she had not seen him do in the three years she had kept his book. Tormod told her that he meant it to stand exactly as struck, the line and the words both, since a chronicle that quietly rewrote its own bad year earned, season on season, the trust of no one, and that he had rather be read, seven-and-seventy years old and wrong once in a season, than be believed infallible by readers who had never troubled to check him. She blotted the page for him without being asked, as she had learned to do that summer without spoiling the stroke beneath the blotting sand, and set the book back on its stand open at the struck line, where it stood, by Tormod's own wish, through the whole of that harvest month, so that any clerk who came to the desk on Library business might read, before he read anything else that year, a chronicler's own hand owning that he had once been afraid of a summer that came in kind.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

OF NOW WRITTEN

SE 64 AN DÀMHAIR – SE 67 AN LÙNASTAL

A column of figures is no argument, until it has been read aloud in a room that never wished to hear it read. After that it is a fact the room must carry, and carries as long as the room keeps its own minutes.

— Daniel Frayne, private book kept at Muileann leathan, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 64

I

Of the Clerks Who Came for the Figures

The census clerks who rode north to Caol mhòr that autumn were the first the Moot's room had ever seen come asking rather than come telling, and Daniel Frayne, nine-and-fifty that year and speaker long enough that he no longer troubled to count the seasons of it, found the change stranger than anything the clerks themselves said to him. Two men came, both Dia-thìreach, both younger than his own eldest clerk, riding a cart with a chest of blank forms lashed under a tarpaulin against the rain that had followed them the whole road from Cathair dhearg, and they asked at the door of the room, with a courtesy Frayne had not met from any southern office in thirty years of dealing with them, whether the Moot kept a count of its own people that the third census might use, the shire's own maor having told the council's census office that no southern clerk had yet set foot in the northern towns to take one and none was like to before the printing date the council itself had chosen.

Frayne sat with them the better part of a day, the room's ledgers open on the table between them, and gave them what the Moot had: the school registers Ag-

nes Pike's and Alice Hale's houses had kept since before he could write his own name properly, what the vigil-keepers of Baile chrom would lend of their own books, the bindery's own tally of every family in Muileann leathan that had ever brought him a book to mend, and the Moot's own count of heads taken every third year since the room was first opened, a count no southern office had ever asked to see before that autumn. The younger of the two clerks copied the figures into his own book in a fair, careful hand, and asked, when he had done, whether the Moot would swear to them before a justice if the council required it, a question Frayne answered by telling him that the Moot had sworn to smaller things for larger names before that day and would swear to this one gladly, there being nothing in the figures the room had any cause to soften.

The rain that had followed the clerks up from Cathair dhearg did not let up while they sat at the room's table, and Frayne, watching it run down the small window behind the younger clerk's shoulder, thought it a fitting enough weather for the asking, the road north having never been an easy one for a southern office to trouble much with in any season, wet or dry. He offered the two men what the room's own chest could spare of Caol mhòr's own bread and its own beer, poor fare beside what a council office kept for its travelling clerks, and the elder of the two, a man near Frayne's own age who had ridden the circuit for the census twice before in the south and never once in the north, said over it that he had heard the road called worse than he found it, and that a man might have told him, before he set out, that the room at the end of it kept better order in its own ledgers than half the southern shire halls he had visited that same season. Frayne took the saying for the courtesy it plainly was and no more, having heard courtesies enough from southern mouths over thirty years to know the weight a wise man gave them, but he set it down in his own book that night beside the rest, judging that even a courtesy, once written, outlived the mouth that had spoken it.

"They will print what we give them," Frayne told the room's own clerks that evening, when the cart had gone south again with the chest of forms filled and the blank ones still lashed beneath the tarpaulin for want of use, "and I do not know yet whether that is a kindness or only a shorter road to the same silence we have always been given. But we have never before been asked, and a room that keeps a minute-book keeps this in it: that in the sixty-fourth year of the reckoning, we were asked." He wrote the day into his own private book that same night, the figures given and the manner of the giving both, a habit he had kept since the winter

he first began it and had no thought of breaking now that the figures, for once, were wanted rather than merely tolerated.

The census was published that same autumn at Cathair dhearg, in the last week of an Dàmhair, and it was the first in the kingdom's history to be printed and sold openly at the fairs rather than filed unread in the council's own cellar, a small reform the notice that announced it called a token of the Crown's own confidence in its people, though the room at Caol mhòr, reading the notice a season later than the south had read it, found in the phrase nothing that the figures, once they arrived, did not answer more plainly than any notice could.

II

Of the Reading and the Two Words

The figures reached Caol mhòr early in an t-Samhain, a bound sheaf of printed columns the council's own press had run off in numbers enough to sell at every market town on the roll, carried up the last stretch of road on a carter's own cart because the autumn's rain had closed the higher road to anything lighter, and the room that gathered to hear them read was fuller than it had been in years, benches carried in from the vestry next door and the fire built up past its usual evening measure against a cold that had kept the windows white with frost since the first hard nights. The Moot's clerk who read the columns aloud, a woman who had kept the room's own books since before Frayne himself had held the chair and had buried, by her own account, two speakers and meant to outlast a third at the same table, read them in the flat voice a clerk keeps for figures that trouble her more than she means to let the room see. Frayne sat in the chair Mary Coyle had once sat in, his hands laid flat on the table the way he sat when he meant to keep them still, and listened to every column the census had chosen to take, the counted heads, the counted hearths, the counted trades a family owned to, read out in turn for the northern towns and set beside the same columns for the south.

In every column the clerks at Cathair dhearg had troubled to take, the northern towns stood at about half the measure the southern shires showed for the same count, a fact the room had known in its own bones for two generations and had never once seen printed in the kingdom's own hand before that winter. Nobody in the room was surprised at the figures themselves; what silenced them,

Frayne wrote afterward, was hearing figures they had always known made into a fact the council itself had signed its own press to. The clerk read the last column and set the sheaf down, and the room kept a quiet long enough that the fire's own settling in the grate was the loudest thing in it.

Frayne drew the minute-book toward him when the quiet had held as long as he judged it should, and wrote two words in it, and let the room see him write them before he spoke a word himself: *Now written*. He offered the room no gloss on the two words, then or after, though more than one clerk asked him in the years following what he had meant by them and got, from each asking, much the same answer, that a figure the Moot had always known and the kingdom had never printed was one kind of fact, and a figure both the Moot and the kingdom now held in the same paper was another kind entire, and that the difference between the two kinds was the whole of what he had meant to set down and no more than that.

One of the room's younger clerks, a man barely into his own second year at the table and too new to the work to keep the stillness the older hands kept by long habit, asked Frayne afterward, walking out with him into the frost, whether the two words meant the room ought now to expect the south to answer for what it had printed. Frayne told him no, that a fact set down was not a promise kept, and that a room hoping for the one from the other had not yet learned the difference the room's own long history ought to have taught it by then; but he told the young man, too, that a fact once printed could not be unprinted, whatever the council chose to do or not do about it, and that this was worth having even where a promise was not, a distinction the young clerk turned over some while in the cold before he owned that he took the sense of it, if not yet the comfort.

The census carried, as the first one had, a line for the coal-touched, a number given without gloss or comment, and Tormod Pinn, copying the published figures into the royal chronicle at Muileann chaol that same winter as he had copied every census before it, entered the line exactly as Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill had entered it a generation before him, without a word added either side of the number. He was eight-and-seventy that winter and had kept the chronicle three-and-twenty years, and the clerks who worked beside him at Muileann chaol said afterward that his hand had grown no less steady for the years, only slower, so that a page that had once taken him an evening now took the better part of two.

In the south-west that same season, the houses of the Stone published, for the first time in their own province's memory, a count of their own people to set be-

side the kingdom's, a reckoning kept by the province's own scribes rather than by any council clerk, and the two counts, when word of them reached Muileann chaol, agreed within a hundred souls of each other, a closeness the chronicle noted with the same flat hand it gave every other column that winter, though more than one clerk at the Library remarked, reading the entry, that a province which could check the kingdom's own figures against its own and find them true had been given a trust the north had never once been offered.

III

Of Tormod Pinn's Last Winter

Tormod Pinn had come to the chronicler's desk at Muileann chaol in the forty-second year of the reckoning, called Pinn for the speed of his own hand rather than for any name his father had given him, and he had kept, since the day Gormshuil laid the pen down, the same habit she had left him: the list of what the record did not hold, copied into the front of every year's book and never once added to nor struck from in three-and-twenty years of keeping it. He had told the Library's younger clerks, more than once over those years, that a chronicler's business was to keep the list honest rather than to shorten it, and that a man who struck a line from another's list without first filling the gap it named had done nothing but tidy a shelf he had no right to tidy.

A junior clerk who copied returns beside him that last winter said afterward that Tormod Pinn had grown, in his last years, given to reading a page twice where once he had read it once, from a wish, the clerk judged, to be sure of a figure before he trusted his own hand to it, a carefulness the younger clerks about him took at first for slowness and only later, once his desk stood empty, understood for what it had been. Tormod kept to his own desk through most of that winter and into the spring following, reading, as he had read every season for twenty years, the returns the shires sent up and the figures the census had newly given him to set beside them, and the clerks who passed his door those months said he looked, by the spring, thinner in the face than the winter before, though none of them thought to trouble him with the saying, a chronicler's own health being, by the Library's long custom, a matter he was left to keep to himself unless he chose otherwise. They found him at his own desk on a morning in an t-Sultain, the returns for that year still open under his hand and his pen laid down be-

side them rather than dropped, in much the manner, an old clerk remarked who had served under Ailean Leabhar too, that a man of the Library seemed always to be found, as though the desk taught a certain way of leaving it.

He was buried at Muileann chaol within the week, in the small burying-ground behind the Library that held every keeper and chronicler the house had kept since Ailean Leabhar's own day, and Mòrag nic Coinnich, who had known him the whole of his three-and-twenty years at the desk, spoke over him only that he had kept the list honest and struck nothing from it that was not yet earned, words the Library's own younger clerks copied down and kept, by their own account, truer to the man than any longer eulogy could have been. He was nine-and-seventy at his death, by the Library's own reckoning of his years, an age no chronicler before him at Muileann chaol had reached at that desk, and the clerks noted the fact in the margin of his own last page, the only line in the whole of his tenure that he had not written himself.

Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh took the desk that same summer, three-and-fifty years old and the first woman to hold the chronicler's chair since Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, chosen by Mòrag nic Coinnich from among the house's own senior clerks for a steadiness of hand the keeper judged the desk would want after Tormod's long, quiet tenure. She had kept the Library's own gazetteer returns seven years before that summer and told the clerks who worked under her, on her first morning at the chronicler's own desk, that she meant to change nothing of the desk's furniture nor its hours, only its habit of silence where the record had none to give, a saying the clerks who heard it did not at first take her full meaning of, until her first year's book was closed and its foot-note read. She kept his habit of the list at the front of the year's book, unchanged, and added to it a habit of her own that no chronicler before her had kept: a foot-note at the close of every year's entries, set apart from the chronicle proper, naming what the record could not learn that year and why, where the why could be told at all.

Her first such note, written at the foot of her first year at the desk, concerned the northern figures the census had printed. The clerks who had gone to take them, she wrote, had been told the figures at Caol mhòr and had not troubled to count them for themselves, and the figures they were told were the Moot's own, given freely by its speaker to two clerks who asked. So the kingdom's first honestly printed census was honest in the north, she set down, only because the north had done the counting the south's own clerks had been sent to do and had not done. Frayne read the note some months later, a copy of it sent north by a Library clerk

who thought the room at Caol mhòr ought to see what its own giving had been made into, and kept the copy in his private book beside the day he had first given the figures, judging, he told the room, that a chronicler who would write such a thing plainly, of her own kingdom's own clerks, was a chronicler the north might yet have some use trusting.

IV

Of the Chests Called In

Mòrag nic Coinnich, keeper of the Library these six-and-twenty years, had long held that a history kept in forty scattered shire-chests was no history at all but forty separate hopes that someone, someday, would trouble to read them together, and in the year after Tormod Pinn's death she sent her own clerks out along the roll to call every shire's record-chest in to Muileann chaol, the maors' own returns, the town chronicles where any town kept one, the vigil-books and rite-rolls the shires' own faiths had filed apart from the Crown's business, all of it, whatever a shire had troubled to keep, to be copied or kept whole as the Library judged fit.

Most shires sent what they held without complaint, some gladly and some only because a council notice had told them to, but at Seann Tarr the shire's own keeper, an old man who had held the chest's key since before Mòrag herself was born and had never in that whole tenure let a stranger's hand touch the chest without his own standing by it, burned the chest in his own yard the night before her clerks arrived rather than let it travel south. He met the clerks himself at the gate the next morning, the ash still warm behind him and his own coat smelling of the smoke he had not troubled to wash from it, and told them, when they found only ash where the chest had stood, that the shire's record belonged in the shire and would stay there in whatever form he judged fit to leave it, a plain answer given without heat and without apology, the clerks noted, as though the burning had been no more than the ordinary close of an ordinary evening's business. He was fined by the council for the burning, a fine the Library's own clerk noted he paid without argument and without apology either, and the chest, and whatever it had held of Seann Tarr's own two centuries, was lost entire, the only shire record of the whole calling-in that the Library never had the chance to read.

Cathair naomh, in the north, sent its own rolls in two carts that same season, together with the town's own chronicle, kept by a single family through four generations without a council's asking, the crates packed by the family's own eldest daughter, who rode the two carts south herself rather than trust them to a hired carter, and told Mòrag's clerks, unpacking the crates at her own hand once the road was done, that her grandmother's grandmother had begun the chronicle on the back of an unused rent-roll for want of paper better suited to it, and that every hand since had kept to the same plain page rather than buy finer stock the family judged an extravagance no plain chronicle wanted. Mòrag nic Coinnich, going through it at her own table with a clerk standing by to lift out whatever the crates held, entered it in the Library's own register as the best-kept shire record the calling-in had yet returned, a judgment she let stand even after every other shire's chest had reached Muileann chaol and been weighed against it. Seann Toll sent its own chest willingly and asked, when the clerks came for it, for a copy of everything the chest held to be returned to the shire once the Library had made its own, an asking no shire before it had thought to make, and Mòrag's clerks made the copy as asked, a full transcription bound in the same hand and set beside the original before either left the shire's own hall, and the copy they made for Seann Toll became, in the years after, the pattern every later shire's copy was cut to, the Library having found, in the asking, a better custom than the one it had begun with.

The Library's own holdings doubled that year with what the calling-in returned, and it took into one keeping, for the first time since its founding, the lesser archives several provinces had kept apart from the Crown's own rolls, so that from that season the history of Dia-thìr was written and held in one place at Muileann chaol and not scattered, as it had been since the Severance, across forty shire halls each keeping its own account of its own corner and no other's.

No Tuathaich record was called in that season, nor any season after it, the calling-in's own notice having named only the shires the council's roll accounted for, and the north's own record stayed where it had always stayed: the Moot's minute-books at Caol mhòr, the school registers Agnes Pike's and Alice Hale's houses had begun, the churches' own registers, the vigil-books of Baile chrom, all of it in private keeping and none of it asked for. Frayne, reading the calling-in's notice when word of it reached the room the following spring, called the room together and put the question to them plainly himself, whether the Moot ought to offer its own books south now that the council had shown, by the calling-in, a wish to

gather every record the kingdom held: a question, he told them, the room had never once been asked by any southern office and had, this once, the choosing of for its own.

The room debated it the better part of an evening, the older clerks arguing that a book offered was a book the council might one day demand rather than merely receive, and the younger arguing that a history kept only in the north was a history the kingdom's own printed figures would go on outweighing however true the north's own count remained. "We gave them the figures once," the room's oldest clerk said, near the debate's close, "and they made of the giving a mark against us, however honestly it was meant. I will not vote to give them the books as well and trust the giving to fare better." Frayne, who had sat the whole evening without speaking his own mind either way, told the room only that he had not called them together to be told which way to vote, and that he would set down whatever the room decided and no more of his own judgment beside it, a promise the room's own minute of that night bears out.

The room's minute of that evening, in Frayne's own hand, records no vote taken by show or by count and no reason given beyond the two words its own clerk set down at the sitting's close, words that answered the calling-in more plainly than any longer argument the room could have offered instead: *kept north*. No cart went south from Caol mhòr that year or any year following, and the Moot's own books, whatever the kingdom's Library now held of every other shire's record, stayed where they had always been kept, in the room at Caol mhòr, in the hands that had written them.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Of the Empty Floor and the Banked Fire

SE 68 AN T-ÒGMHIOS – 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS SE 71

A floor raised and left bare speaks only years afterward, once the
ledgers show plainly what was left unsent.
— Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, foot-note to the chronicle, entered at
Muileann chaol, 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 68

I

Of the Fourth Floor

The new wing at Muileann chaol was raised of the grey stone that came up out of the Sloc Mòr's own spoil, cut and dressed by masons who had learned the trade cutting galleries rather than walls and cut it, by old habit, in blocks the size a gallery's own timbering would have wanted. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, three years into the chronicler's chair by the summer it was finished, walked its three built floors before a single chest had been carried up to them and thought that a library housed in a mountain's own leavings kept, in its stone if nowhere else, an honest account of where the kingdom's wealth had gone. The first floor took the provinces' returns, shire by shire, in presses built to the same measure so that no shire's chest stood taller or grander than its neighbour's. The second took the town chronicles, where any town had troubled to keep one, and the third the vigil-books and rite-rolls the shires' own faiths had filed apart from the Crown's business. The fourth floor, built to the same measure as the three beneath it, stood empty, its presses raised and its shelves cut and planed and never loaded, and Mòrag nic Coinnich, walking it with her that first morning, told

Beathag only that a floor was easier built now than added later, and that the Library had learned, over its long keeping, to build for what it did not yet hold.

The clerks who carried the chests up from the carts that autumn worked the first three floors in the order the wing had been given them, a chain of hands up three flights of a new stair that still smelled of its own mortar, and more than one of them, setting a chest down at last in its press, remarked to the clerk behind him that the fourth flight climbed to nothing and asked, half in jest, whether they were to carry chairs up there instead of chests to save the stair the indignity of standing idle. Beathag heard the jest twice that autumn from two different mouths and wrote neither of them into the chronicle, judging a chronicle no place for a joke that would want explaining to a reader fifty years on, though she kept the sense of it, she owned in her own private book, longer than she kept most things said to her that season.

Beathag asked Mòrag plainly, since the keeper had not offered it, what the fourth floor was built to hold, and Mòrag answered that it was built for the north's own record, should the north ever choose to send it, and that she had asked the masons to raise it all the same, whatever the Moot's own answer proved to be. The two women stood some while at the head of the empty stair, the fourth floor's own door unlocked and its room bare of everything but light coming in low through windows cut the same size as the floors below, and Beathag wrote that evening, in the private note she had kept since her first year at the desk, that a room built and left empty said more of the kingdom's own habits than any room the kingdom had troubled to fill. She had kept, since Tormod Pinn's death, his own front-of-the-year list of what the Library had never been sent, unchanged; she added now, at the year's close, her own foot-note beneath it, a habit no chronicler before her had kept, and she wrote of the fourth floor only that it stood ready and that no cart had come, a sentence she judged plainer than any she could have set beside it.

The calling-in of the shires' chests that had filled the wing's first three floors was two years finished by the time the wing stood ready to take them, and Beathag, reading the whole tally that summer for the first time set out floor by floor, found in it a fact the calling-in's own notice had never troubled to state outright: every shire the council's own roll accounted for had sent something, willing or unwilling, whole or in part, and the one record asked for and not received was the one record never asked for at all. She set that down in the same plain hand, and kept the note in the book the Library's own younger clerks were beginning, by

then, to read before they read the chronicle proper, a small book that had, by the wing's second year, outgrown the drawer she had first kept it in.

II

Of the Arrears at Àth leathan

The Rail Board's own minute that summer gave one line to the branch line at Àth leathan, closed for the falling yield of the western pits, and Beathag, copying the minute into the chronicle as the Board had written it, found nothing in the line to trouble a reader who did not already know the western hills. The pits did not close with the branch. The Board's overseers were withdrawn, their wages costing more by then than the coal they oversaw was fairly worth to a house working the vein in the Crown's name alone, and the Tuathaich hewers who had worked those pits under the overseers' watch for two generations went on working them under pit captains of their own choosing, men chosen from among their own number for the trust of the rest, in a manner the Board's own charter had never troubled to forbid because it had never once thought a Tuathaich pit might be left to govern its own affairs.

The last overseer to leave Àth leathan, a man named in no book Beathag ever read but remembered at the pit-head for years after by the hewers he had watched, is said to have handed the pit-head scale's own key to the hewer standing nearest him without a word of ceremony either way, and to have ridden south the same afternoon without looking back at the headgear behind him. The captains the hewers chose kept the Crown's fifth by the Leòid ruling, as the ruling required of them, weighing every cart at the pit-head and setting the fifth part by before a cart went anywhere, and sent word south each season of what was owed, in a hand as careful as any overseer's had ever been. The Board took the payments when a carrier troubled to bring them and entered them in its own books as arrears, a word that named a debt owed rather than a due paid, though the hewers at Àth leathan had never once failed to send what the ruling asked of them. Beathag, reading the Board's own ledger a season later at a clerk's asking, wrote in her private note that a kingdom which could not tell the difference between a debt and a payment made in good faith had chosen, in the choosing of that one word, to keep a grievance where none was owed, and that she did not know whether the choosing had

been made in malice or only in the ordinary carelessness of a Board that had stopped looking at what it did not have to look at.

In the second summer after the branch closed, the pit captains at Àth leathan sent the season's first coal south by cart rather than by rail, the road being longer and the going slower but the loading and the sending both theirs to order, down through the western hills to the yards at Seann Bhral, where the coal factors bought it at the pit-head price and asked no questions of the hand that had cut it. It was the first coal out of Àth leathan to travel a road the Board had not chosen for it, four carts and a spare axle carried against the road's own roughness, and the carters who drove it said afterward, at Cnoc thais and at the pits above it, that the going had cost them three days more than the rail would have and had cost the Board nothing at all, the Board having washed its hands of the branch and of everything the branch no longer carried. The factors at Seann Bhral, the carters said too, weighed the coal twice over before they paid for it, as though a cart come down from a pit with no overseer's mark on its papers were a cart to be doubted until the scale itself had spoken; but they paid, each time, the full pit-head price, and asked, in all the seasons of the carts coming, no question beyond the weight.

A younger clerk at the Library, reading the Board's own minute beside Beathag that same season, asked her whether the word ought to be struck from the ledger and a truer one put in its place, since the chronicle, of all the kingdom's books, might have the standing to ask for it. Beathag told him no, that a chronicle's business was to copy the word the Board had chosen and let the choosing stand against the Board's own name, not to soften it for a reader who ought to be trusted with the plain fact of it; she had learned the habit, she told him, from a chronicler who struck through his own bad guesses rather than hide them, and a chronicler who mended another office's bad words was practising a different trade entirely. The clerk did not raise the matter again, though he copied, that same week, the word arrears into three further ledgers of his own without once, by his own later account, writing it easily.

III

Of the Register at Cnoc thais

At Cnoc thais, in the same western hills, the pits passed to their own hewers in the same season and by the same withdrawal, and the man chosen to

keep the accounts was Sam Varley, four-and-fifty that year, who had worked the pit-head scales under the Board's own overseer for eleven years before the overseer left and had kept, in that time, a private tally of his own beside the Board's, out of a habit he could not afterward explain except to say that a scale watched by one pair of eyes alone was a scale worth checking against a second pair. He opened, that first season, a book of the pit's own accounts, the earliest page of it headed in his own plain hand with the day and the pit's own name and nothing else, a book the town's own register still keeps and still calls by no finer title than the day it was begun.

His small son Tom, not yet old enough for the pit, ran the errands the book wanted: a figure carried to a captain waiting at the pit-head, a weight called down from the scale-house to the table where his father sat with the ledger open, a message sent to the next valley when the carts were due and had not come. Sam kept him at it through that first summer and every summer after, and once, when the boy asked why the figures mattered so much to a book nobody south would read, told him plainly, without looking up from the page, that a book kept honest for nobody was worth more than a book kept honest for someone watching, since the one habit would hold when the other failed. Tom did not, by his own account, take the full sense of the saying that summer, standing in the scale-house door with the cold coming in behind him and his father's pen not once pausing over the page; but he carried the figures all the same, and carried them straight, and Sam never once had to send a second boy after the first.

That same season, on the southern road a country away, the far-off house that the carters called *An Sligeanach Fad' às*¹ passed from the family that had kept it three generations to a family of drovers new to the trade. The old keepers left the way the tellers of that road say a house is properly left, the last of them sweeping the hearth clean before he handed the new family the key, and the drovers built a second hall beside the first for a trade the old house had never troubled to serve; a hall built, the carters who watched it rise said, faster and cruder than the first, of green timber that would want a year's settling before a door in it hung true. Within a few years the house that had once fed a carter dried deer and black water and asked no questions had become the largest house on the old mining roads, its yard crowded of an evening with beasts and men from every valley the roads still served, its new hall louder than the old one had ever been in three generations of

1. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

quiet keeping. Beathag noted the sale in the chronicle in a single line, the house's changing hands being, by the Library's own measure, a small thing beside a branch line closed or a pit passed to its own hewers, though she wrote, in her private note that year, that a house grown fat on the drove trade while the coal roads emptied told its own kind of truth about which trade a failing kingdom still had use for.

The book's first year closed, as every year after it would close, on the last evening of an Dùbhlachd, when Sam sat up late by the scale-house lamp to draw the final line beneath the season's figures and set the total against what the captain's own count made of it, the two sums agreeing, that first year, to within a single basket-weight neither man troubled to chase down further. Tom, sent to bed an hour before, came down again in his nightshirt to see the line drawn, having asked, the week before, whether a book's first year ought not to be watched closed the way a house watches its own hearth banked for the night, and Sam let him stand by while the ink dried, saying nothing of the asking either way, though he did not send the boy up again until the page was blotted and shut.

IV

Of the Failing Grounds

The herring did not come, that year or the year following, to the grounds off the mouth of the river below Seann Dunn, and the east-coast boats, finding their own waters empty a second season together, went north to fish the grounds off Caol mhòr instead, grounds the licence law had kept for Diathreach boats since the licences were first written and that few east-coast boats had troubled to fish while their own waters answered. The law gave them the right, and they used it, in numbers the law had never anticipated, and the Tuathach boats that worked the edges of those grounds were pushed farther out by hulls they did not know and could not, by any law written, turn away.

The boats of Inis mhin, pushed from the grounds nearest their own harbour by the crowding, took to the deep water beyond the northern isles, a water no boat of that coast had fished within living memory for the roughness of it and the distance a crew had to keep from land overnight, days on end with no headland in sight and the swell running longer than any inshore man cared to trust. Two boats were lost there in the first year, gone out and not come back, and the harbour

kept, after that, a stricter watch on the weather than it had ever kept before, a horn sounded from the point whenever the glass fell fast; but none was lost in any year following, the crews having learned, in the losing of the two, what the deep water asked of a boat that meant to fish it and return. Before the second summer was out the catch that Inis mhin brought in from that water had passed what Caol mhòr brought in from all the grounds about it, a fact the chronicle sets down without comment, since a comment would only have said what the figures said more plainly: that a people pushed from what the law protected had found, in what the law did not trouble to reach, a living the law had never thought to grant them.

V

Of the Keeper Laid Down

Mòrag nic Coinnich laid down the keepership of the Library in the autumn of the seventieth year, two-and-seventy that season and thirty years and more in the chair, the longest any keeper had yet held it, longer than Ailean Leabhar's own founding tenure, and she named, before the council that confirmed such things, her own deputy Ragnall mac Mhuirich to come after her, a man fifty that year who had kept the Library's own catalogue in order through every calling-in and every new wing raised over it without once, by Beathag's own account, losing a single shelf's place in the reckoning. Mòrag's own last act at the desk was to walk the fourth floor once more with Beathag beside her, the floor no less empty than it had stood the day the wing was finished, their two lamps the only light in a room built for four hundred chests that had never held one. "I built the room," she said, when Beathag asked her, at the head of the stair, whether the emptiness troubled her after thirty years of watching it. "The asking who fills it belongs to Ragnall now, or to nobody, and a room built stands built either way." She left the key to the fourth floor's own door with Ragnall the same week, unremarked among the other keys, a room being, in her own long judgment, worth more built and empty than never built at all.

Ragnall took the chair that same season and changed, in his first year, nothing of the Library's own hours nor its own custom, a steadiness the clerks under him took, at first, for a want of ambition and came later to value as the surest thing the house had left it, in a season when little else about the kingdom's own

coal held steady. He asked Beathag, in that first year, whether her own foot-notes ought to be gathered separately from the chronicle proper, a question she answered by telling him that a note kept apart from what it corrected was a note easily lost, and that she meant to keep hers bound into the very pages a reader could not skip past. He did not ask her again, and the foot-notes stayed where she had put them.

That same autumn the price of coal-fuel at the fair of Muileann òg doubled over what it had stood the season before, the Board having cut its own sales to spare the lowest galleries the pumping its dwindling profit could no longer answer for, and the fair's own court, whose long custom it was to fix a ceiling on any good the crowd grew angry enough about, set a ceiling price on coal-fuel that same week, cried three times from the fair's own steps as the custom asked. It found, within a season, that no factor troubled to sell at the price named, the coal simply not reaching the fair's stalls at all rather than reaching them cheap, so that a buyer who came asking for coal-fuel at the court's own ceiling was told, at stall after stall, that none was to be had that day, a true answer and a hollow one both. The ceiling stood written in the court's own book and broken in every stall beneath it, and the wardens who had cried it from the steps did not trouble to cry its breaking, a silence Beathag noted in the chronicle as plainly as she had noted the ceiling.

VI

Of the Watchmen and the Banked Fire

At Cnoc fhiadhaich, where the spoil-heaps of the old coal galleries still stood unlevelled above the town, the Board posted watchmen the following spring against the households that had taken, in the doubled price of the fair, to picking coal off the heaps to burn in their own grates rather than buy what they could no longer pay for. The watchmen the Board hired were men of the town, chosen for their knowledge of the ground and paid a penny a day above a labourer's wage for the watching, and set two to a shift, one at the north heap and one at the south, with a lantern between them against the winter dark. The chronicle records, in a line Beathag set down without any gloss beside it, that the watchmen saw nothing, every night the posting lasted, though the heaps grew visibly lower by the season and the town's poorer grates burned warmer than the

price of the fair could otherwise have bought them. A clerk who rode out from Muileann chaol to note the posting for the Library's own record wrote home to Beathag that he had watched the north heap an hour himself one evening and had seen, in that hour, three separate baskets carried down from it by three separate doors, none of them the watchman's own; she kept his letter but did not print it, judging a clerk's single hour no fair measure of a whole season's watching, whatever it seemed to prove.

In the capital that same season, and worse as the summer came on, the streets of the poorer quarters burned their lamps shorter hours than the council's own lighting order required, the keepers of those streets having found, by the doubled price, that an order written for a coal that cost half what it now cost was an order the poorer wards could no longer afford to keep in full. A lamp lit at dusk and let go out before the middle watch left a street dark for the hours a labourer walked it home from a late shift, and more than one such labourer, Beathag's own clerks reported to her, had taken to carrying a rushlight of his own rather than trust the council's order to see him the whole way. The council's own notice on the matter, when one came at all, named the shortening a saving rather than a want, a word Beathag copied into the chronicle exactly as the notice gave it and set beside it, in her own private note that year, that a saving and a want looked much alike from a street too dark to tell the one from the other.

Her foot-note for that year, entered the following spring at the close of the chronicle's own account of it, named what the record could not learn: how many grates in the capital's poorer wards had gone unlit that winter for the price of what should have warmed them, a figure no census had troubled to ask for and no shire had troubled to keep, so that the Library, which now held in one place the fullest count the kingdom had ever kept of its own coal, its own dead, and its own dues, held no count at all of its own cold. She wrote the note in the same hand she had written every note before it, and changed, in the writing of it, nothing of the desk's own hours nor its own custom, as she had told Raghnaill, on his first morning at the chair beside her, that she meant to do.

She climbed the fourth stair once more before she sealed the year's book, alone this time, Mòrag being by then a season retired from the desk, and stood again in the room the masons had built and the masons alone had ever filled, the light coming in as low and as even as it had the first morning she had seen it. A shire's chest could be called in by a letter and a cart, she wrote that evening, and a fair's own price could be set down in a court's own book whether the coal answered to

it or not; but a floor built for a book that was never sent stayed exactly what it had been built as, a question asked once and left standing, and she judged, closing the year's account, that the Library had grown practised, in seventy years of the kingdom's keeping, at building rooms for what it did not yet have the courage to ask for outright.

In the north Dubhan was at his work still, as he had been for ten years, boiling and burning what the pits threw away. Nobody in the capital was watching him, and nobody in the Library knew his name. On a night near midsummer in the seventy-first year, the tellers of the north say, he banked his fire and slept beside it, as he had on a hundred nights before.

Here this book ends, the fire banked in the north and the kingdom asleep around it, the Library's fourth floor standing empty still, the ceiling broken in every stall that sold beneath it, and no word set down of what the morning brought.

PART SEVEN

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS SE 1 – 5

- 22 AM MÀRT, SE 1** — *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*. The descendants of the humans stranded by the Severance are settled by law in the north of the island and held there. It is a confinement; yet their children's children call it home.
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, SE 1** — *The Hale household lodged at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale comes north with his wife Ellen and their children David and Alice among the households the guard walks into the homeland that summer, and is given a loft over a net-store on the harbour street at Caol mhòr, his for as long as nobody wants it back.¹
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, SE 1** — *Hale takes to copying the Caol mhòr harbour slate* (Caol mhòr). With no office and no book of his own, Walter Hale begins copying the catch weighed at the Caol mhòr quay from the fishermen's slate before it is rubbed clean each evening, the first written record the harbour keeps of itself under the new homeland.
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, SE 1** — *The north's first harvest falls short* (Caol mhòr). Sown late on ground half the settled households have never worked, the Tuathaich shires' first harvest comes in thin, short in the straw and light in the ear, while the stores that once came over the water from an Tìr Thall² do not come again.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 1** — *The Caol mhòr catch shared by households* (Caol mhòr). As the herring run late and thin that autumn, the Caol mhòr boats stop selling their catch to whoever comes first to the quay and begin sharing it out by households instead, a change no minute records and every household in the town keeps to.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 1** — *The Severance companies stood down* (Cathair dhearg). The war-companies of the last campaign against the human administration are disbanded at Cathair dhearg. Their rolls go to the council unburned, and the companies are never abolished; they live on as names on a list.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 1** — *Fearchar mac Raghnaill's plea that his company's roll be kept* (Cathair dhearg). At the muster in Cathair dhearg's drill-yard, Captain Fearchar mac Raghnaill asks neither for pay nor for arms but that the roll of his company's names not be burned with the loose paper of the stand-down, since every name on it stood where the roll says he stood.³
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 1** — *The disbanded companies' rolls kept, not burned* (Cathair dhearg). On a clerk's asking, the master of the chests orders that the rolls of the stood-down war-companies be kept and boxed rather than burned with the rest of the muster's loose paper; Fearchar mac Raghnaill's roll is the first spared, though he never learns it.⁴

1. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

3. ← Follows from *The Severance companies stood down*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1.

4. ← Follows from *The Severance companies stood down*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1.

- 18 AN T-IÚCHAR, SE 1** — *Ailean's list of the chests begun* (Cathair dhearg). Carrying sixty-one companies' rolls down into the council's vault, Ailean mac Iain keeps, unasked, a written list of which roll went into which chest and in what order, the first record of its kind the council's vault has ever had.⁵
- 29 AN T-IÚCHAR, SE 1** — *The war-vault sealed at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The council's vault of war papers is closed and bricked over at Cathair dhearg, the seal meant to stand until some later year gives cause to break it; the master of the chests signs Ailean mac Iain's list of the vault's contents before it is filed.⁶
- 31 AN T-IÚCHAR, SE 1** — *The boundary stones set* (Caol mhòr). Stones are set on the north roads where the Tuathaich country begins. No wall follows them. Many stand by the road-side yet, and no one has been paid to move them.⁷
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 1** — *The boundary stone set on the Caol mhòr road* (Caol mhòr). The council's masons set a stone where the drove path crosses the road out of Caol mhòr, cut in Dia-thiris and left without a wall to follow it. Walter Hale walks out with his son David to read what neither of them can make out.⁸
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The hungry year at Doire ghlais* (Doire ghlais). The stores that came over the water from an Tìr Thall⁹ come no more, and in their first year alone the northern settlements go short of grain. Tuathaich memory puts the dead at Doire ghlais above two hundred. The Dia-thìrich made no count.¹⁰
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The guard posted at the heads of the north roads* (Caol mhòr). The council sets a guard-post on every road running north out of the settled country, a captain and a dozen men at each, to hold the line the columns had walked in winter and to turn back any who wander south of it.¹¹
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Ailean mac Iain rides as tally-clerk to the guard*. A young clerk of the council's service is sent to ride between the new guard-posts with a book, counting who passes north, who turns back, and who is too sick to walk, so that the council should have some record of the settling beyond the guard's own word.¹²
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The last column counted through at the Caol mhòr road*. Forty-one souls are counted through the guard-post on the Caol mhòr road, the last column of the winter's walking, two dying before evening; after them the road stands empty, and the tally-clerk's book records no further column that year.¹³

5. ← Follows from *The Severance companies stood down*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1.

6. ← Follows from *The Severance companies stood down*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1.

7. ⇌ At the same time *Hale takes to copying the Caol mhòr harbour slate*, 28 an Giblean, SE 1.

8. ← Follows from *The boundary stones set*, 31 an t-Iuchar, SE 1.

9. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

10. → Caused by *The north's first harvest falls short*, 31 an Cèitean, SE 1; ⇌ At the same time *The Caol mhòr catch shared by households*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1.

11. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

12. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

13. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The council's word on the homeland read at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). The council's law fixing the Tuathaich homeland in the north is read from the steps of the harbour-house at Caol mhòr before a wet crowd, first in Dia-thìris, then, by the council's own order, in the humans' tongue for those who have no other.¹⁴
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Walter Hale found to read the council's word into the humans' tongue* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale, once a harbour clerk of Ros bheag, is fetched from the crowd at Caol mhòr to render the council's proclamation into the humans' tongue, and reads it plainly, without the first reader's polish, to a crowd that takes it in near silence.¹⁵
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Hale's correction entered in a clerk's margin* (Caol mhòr). Asked how his rendering of the council's word differed from the paper he was given, Hale tells Ailean mac Iain that the truer word for what was done to the north was not "settled" but "held"; Ailean writes the two words in the margin of his own copy, unasked.¹⁶
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The humans' chapel at Ros bheag shut for good* (Ros bheag). Word reaches Caol mhòr that the humans' chapel at Ros bheag, shut since the crossing closed, is to be shut for good on the council's order; Walter Hale, once the town's harbour clerk, brings the news to Ailean mac Iain without asking anything of him.¹⁷
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The Ros bheag bell carted north* (Ros bheag). The council's men take down the bell of the shut chapel at Ros bheag and cart it away roped in sacking, bound, it is said, for wherever in the north the humans' faith may still be kept; Ailean mac Iain sees the cart pass and notes it without comment.¹⁸
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Meal carried from Caol mhòr to Doire ghlais* (Caol mhòr). The householders of Caol mhòr send three cartloads of oats and salt fish ten miles inland to Doire ghlais in the depth of the hungry winter, and Walter Hale walks with them, carrying the town's meal and, unlooked for, its grief.¹⁹
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The graves on the rise above Doire ghlais* (Doire ghlais). Above ten dead of the hungry winter, children among them, are buried in shallow graves on the rise above Doire ghlais, dug close together in half-frozen ground; the earliest of the winter's dead had already been buried singly, unrecorded, before the town thought to keep any count.²⁰
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Walter Hale's day-book begun* (Caol mhòr). Home from Doire ghlais, Walter Hale buys a fishmonger's ledger and writes the town's name and a number in it by lamplight, the first line of a private accounting of the hungry year's dead that no council south of the guard-stone has asked for or knows exists.²¹

14. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

15. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

16. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich homeland fixed*, 22 am Màrt, SE 1.

17. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

18. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

19. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

20. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

21. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Seed oats taken from the Doire mhin mill on credit* (Doire mhin). With the hungry winter not yet spent, the Tuathaich shires take seed oats from the mill at Doire mhin on credit against the coming harvest, the first debt of its kind the north carries into the new kingdom's account books.²²
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The names pinned in the Doire ghlais church porch* (Doire ghlais). In the first mild week of spring a woman of the parish goes house to house through Doire ghlais gathering the names of the hungry year's dead, and pins them, above fifteen strips of paper in a dozen hands, along the boards of the church porch, where the town comes to call it the porch of the names.²³
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *Walter Hale reads the porch of the names* (Doire ghlais). Walter Hale walks the ten miles to Doire ghlais a second time to read the names pinned in the church porch, and copies every one into a second book begun that winter, keeping the town's own count beside his, though neither squares exactly with the other.²⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The herring return to the Caol mhòr grounds* (Caol mhòr). By the second spring the herring come back to the Caol mhòr grounds in numbers not seen since before the Severance, and the town, having taken nothing from the sea that winter that it did not share, takes the shoals as the sea's answer.²⁵
- II AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 2** — *The human counting-houses emptied* (Ros dhomhain). Clerks of the council enter the human administration's counting-houses at Cathair dhearg, Ros dhomhain and Seann Skell and carry off every written thing. What the raids of the war have left of the tithe ledgers is boxed with the rest, unread, for few of the clerks can read the humans' hand.
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 2** — *Ailean set to the counting-house at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean mac Iain is set to the humans' counting-house at Cathair dhearg to box the north wall's tithe rolls unread, and says nothing of the letters a Mission reader taught him as a boy, for a clerk who reads aloud what he is told only to box is not a clerk kept long.²⁶
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 2** — *The fire-damaged tithe rolls boxed as loose leaves* (Cathair dhearg). Where the counting-house fire at Cathair dhearg burned a shelf's ledgers through the middle rather than whole, Ailean gathers the crumbling leaves as best their order can be guessed and marks the crate that the order is his own guess and not to be trusted past that.²⁷
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 2** — *The Ros dhomhain tariff copied into Dia-thìris* (Ros dhomhain). At the harbour offices of Ros dhomhain, Ailean copies the humans' tariff tables clause by clause into Dia-thìris, building the words for duties his own tongue had never before had cause to name, and the duty itself stands unchanged under its new ink.²⁸

22. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

23. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

24. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

25. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

26. ← Follows from *The human counting-houses emptied*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 2.

27. ← Follows from *The human counting-houses emptied*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 2.

28. ← Follows from *The human counting-houses emptied*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 2.

30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 2 — *The district surveys found behind a locked grating* (Seann Skell).

In the whole counting-house at Seann Skell in the west, Ailean forces a locked grating and finds eleven rolled district surveys, the only whole survey of the island's fields anywhere to be had, each walked, measured and scaled by the humans' own hand.²⁹

2 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The surveys boxed apart and labelled for the council* (Seann Skell).

Ruairidh orders the district surveys boxed apart from the tithe rolls, for the council's own clerks rather than the reckoners, and Ailean chalks the crate's lid with six words rather than a description: the shires will be drawn on them.³⁰

9 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The state's seal begun at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg).

In the same week as the proclamation, the council's engraver at Cathair dhearg begins cutting a seal for the state's own letters, to be set upon documents no different in kind from the ones Ailean spent the summer boxing unread.

10 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The north-west ports without a master* (Inis àrsaidh).

At Ceann mhòr, Cathair gheal and Inis àrsaidh the humans' harbour officers had sailed with the last ships before the crossing closed, and taken their keys with them. The Tuathaich fishermen break the locks of the harbour stores and share out what they find, house by house.

12 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The harbour store's lock broken at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr).

A fisherman of Ceann mhòr breaks the lock of the humans' harbour store with a hammer and stands back to let the town see what is inside, and it is the town, not the man who struck the lock, that shares the rope, canvas and salt out house by house within the hour.³¹

19 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The unfished nets loosed at Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal).

A whole loft of nets that had never been fished goes out to every boat in the harbour at Cathair gheal on a single tide, and the fleet fishes that year with gear it never paid a coin for and never afterward wonders whose it had been.³²

22 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The reckoning drawn up by three women of Inis àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh).

At Inis àrsaidh, poorer and smaller than its neighbours, three women of the town draw up on the spot the reckoning of who has a boat and who has none, and so who needs rope or salt the more, with no office to do it and none afterward to say they did it wrong.³³

25 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2 — *The north-west locks left unanswered* (Ceann mhòr).

No maor comes north to ask who struck the first lock at Ceann mhòr, Cathair gheal or Inis àrsaidh before the following spring, by which time there is nothing left locked to account for, and the towns' own telling of the broken stores hardens into the kind of story a place keeps because it likes its shape.³⁴

29. ← Follows from *The human counting-houses emptied*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 2.

30. → Leads to *The human counting-houses emptied*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 2.

31. ← Follows from *The north-west ports without a master*, 10 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

32. ← Follows from *The north-west ports without a master*, 10 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

33. ← Follows from *The north-west ports without a master*, 10 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

34. ← Follows from *The north-west ports without a master*, 10 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2** — *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr*³⁵ declared (Cathair dhearg). The state names itself a kingdom, though it is ruled as before. Its own records carry the same contradiction to this day.³⁶
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 2** — *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr*³⁷ proclaimed from the counting-house steps (Cathair dhearg). A herald reads the council's proclamation from the steps of the Cathair dhearg counting-house, naming the state Rìoghachd Dia-thìr and the years of settling complete; Ailean stands in the crowd and does not cheer, thinking the naming a kind of label, true as far as it goes and silent about the rest.³⁸
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 2** — *The proclamation read at the market crosses of the south* (Cathair dhearg). Copies of the proclamation styling the state Rìoghachd Dia-thìr³⁹ are read at the market crosses of every southern town within the fortnight, in the same flat, official voice, whatever crowd happens to be standing near enough to hear it.⁴⁰
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 2** — *The Moot at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Tuathaich householders of the northern towns meet at Caol mhòr and choose for their speaker Walter Hale, once a harbour clerk. The Moot has no standing in Dia-thìrich law. It meets all the same and keeps its own minutes, which run unbroken from that day to this.⁴¹
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 2** — *The council of the kingdom seated* (Cathair dhearg). A royal council of twelve is seated at Cathair dhearg, drawn from the custodian families and the captains of the Severance war. Its minute-books are the oldest unbroken record of the state in this age.
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 2** — *The Moot votes its first winter measures* (Caol mhòr). The households gathered at Caol mhòr vote, in the same sitting that opens the Moot's book, to lay by grain against the coming winter and to keep watch on the north roads, having buried too many of their own the winter before to trust the season a second time unwarned.⁴²
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 2** — *The Doire ghlais dead voted into the Moot's record* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale tells the gathered households what he counted on the rise above Doire ghlais and what the church porch's names afterward told him, and the Moot votes, without a voice raised against it, that the count stand as the north's own record of that winter's dead.⁴³

35. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

36. ⇌ At the same time *The state's seal begun at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

37. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

38. ← Follows from *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr declared*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

39. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

40. ← Follows from *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr declared*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 2.

41. ← Leads to *Walter Hale found to read the council's word into the humans' tongue*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1.

42. ← Follows from *The Moot at Caol mhòr*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2.

43. ← Follows from *The hungry year at Doire ghlais*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1; ⇌ At the same time *The Moot at Caol mhòr*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2.

- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 2** — *The granary founded at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). The Moot sets a common store under lock in the harbour-house cellar, each household to give what it can spare, and names three keepers answerable for it: a harbour man trusted with a scale, a smith of Doire ghlas, and a widow of the hungry year who had buried two children in it.⁴⁴
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 2** — *The Moot's letter drafted for the council* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale drafts, and the Moot amends and approves, four careful lines telling the council at Cathair dhearg of the households met at Caol mhòr and of a winter's dead the north had buried and counted without the south's knowledge, asking nothing beyond that the fact be noted.⁴⁵
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 2** — *Robert Carrick carries the Moot's letter south* (Caol mhòr). Peg Carrick's younger brother Robert, fifteen and never before further from Caol mhòr than Doire ghlas, a carter, carries the letter south to Cathair dhearg with it sewn into the lining of his coat, and is the better part of a fortnight on a road he does not know.⁴⁶
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 2** — *The Moot's letter received and filed* (Cathair dhearg). A clerk at the harbour-house in Cathair dhearg takes the Moot's letter from Robert Carrick's hand, tells him it will be seen to, and sends him home with no answer; the disposal, once the letter reaches the council chamber, is three words in the state's own minute-book.⁴⁷
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 2** — *Ailean mac Iain and Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill sworn under-clerks* (Cathair dhearg). On the twenty-third of an t-Sultain the council's newest under-clerks are sworn on the custodians' worn oath-book, Ailean mac Iain among them and, beside him, Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, a council clerk's daughter of the capital who has wanted the office since she was old enough to know what a minute-book was for.⁴⁸
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 2** — *The council of twelve seated and its chairs filled* (Cathair dhearg). Twelve chairs are filled at Cathair dhearg, drawn from the custodian families and the captains of the Severance war: among them Fearchar mac Raghnaill, whose company's roll was kept the summer before; Beathag nic Artair of the old custodian houses; Griogair mac Tormoid of the western shore; and Cailean mac Sheumais, who commanded a company at the fords of the western hills.⁴⁹
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 2** — *A councillor asks what a Moot is* (Cathair dhearg). When the Moot's letter is read before the twelve, Cailean mac Sheumais asks plainly what a Moot is; no one in the chamber can answer with any certainty beyond Fearchar mac Raghnaill's memory of the word from a harbour clerk at Caol mhòr, and the letter is moved to be filed.

50

44. ← Follows from *The Moot at Caol mhòr*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2.

45. ← Follows from *The Moot at Caol mhòr*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2.

46. ← Follows from *The Moot at Caol mhòr*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2.

47. ← Follows from *The council of the kingdom seated*, 23 an t-Sultain, SE 2.

48. ← Follows from *The council of the kingdom seated*, 23 an t-Sultain, SE 2.

49. ← Follows from *The council of the kingdom seated*, 23 an t-Sultain, SE 2.

50. ← Follows from *The council of the kingdom seated*, 23 an t-Sultain, SE 2.

5 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 2 — *The gathering of northern households takes the name Moot* (Caol mhòr). In the weeks after its first sitting the gathering of the north's households comes, without a vote taken on it, to be called the Moot, a word one of its own pursers remembered from an old book of the humans' law, half in earnest and half against themselves.

51

15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 2 — *Ailean sent to the Ros dhombhain sheds* (Ros dhomhain). A month after his swearing, Ailean mac Iain is sent from Cathair dhearg to Ros dhomhain to help Dùghall mac Iain turn the humans' tariff into Dia-thìris, line by line, since the harbour cannot wait for a tariff written fresh.

25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 2 — *Dùghall mac Iain's reason for copying, not writing anew* (Ros dhomhain). Dùghall mac Iain tells Ailean he keeps the humans' sums and changes only the words, since a skipper who has long paid a known tariff pays it gladly to a new hand, and a tariff written fresh would only be cheated the more freely for its newness.

26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 2 — *Ailean's private book begun* (Ros dhomhain). At Ros dhomhain, Ailean begins a private book of his own, bound in undyed leather, in which he sets beside his day's plain clerking the things said to him that seem worth keeping, though he does not yet know their use.

8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 3 — *The harbour-houses of Ros dhombhain taken over* (Ros dhomhain). The customs sheds that the humans built at Ros dhomhain, the greatest port of the kingdom, pass to Dia-thìrich harbour-masters. The first of them, Dùghall mac Iain, keeps the humans' tariff for want of another, and in the years after puts it into Dia-thìris line by line.⁵²

II AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 3 — *The ship sent north* (Muir Mhanannain⁵³). The council sends a ship out past the north-western capes and north-about to seek the crossing the humans used. She returns after a month of grey water with nothing to tell: no land, no ship, no sign of the passage. No second ship is sent. The priests of Manannan at Seann Skell say that the lord of the sea has shut the eastern sea again, as they have prayed him to since the Crossing.

19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 3 — *Niall crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Niall, first ruler of the restored kingdom, takes the throne at Cathair dhearg by Macha's rite. His is the first name in the line that the state's chronicles keep unbroken from this year on.

7 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3 — *A saying enters speech* (Cathair dhearg). The crowning passes with so little dispute that 'mar a thàinig Niall', the way Niall came, becomes a saying for any smooth handing-on of power. It is first found written in a tavern ledger at Cathair dhearg, against a debt settled without argument.

51. ← Follows from *The Moot at Caol mhòr*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 2.

52. ← Leads to *Ailean sent to the Ros dhombhain sheds*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 2; ← Leads to *Dùghall mac Iain's reason for copying, not writing anew*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, SE 2; ⇌ At the same time *Ailean's private book begun*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, SE 2.

53. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The shires drawn* (Cathair dhearg). The council divides the kingdom into siorrachdan, each named for its seat, and keeps most of the human administration's district lines under the new names. The humans' surveys are the only whole ones on the island; the kingdom uses them and says nothing of it.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The windy coast left out* (Seann Vell). The shire lines stop where the humans' survey stopped, at the edge of the great moss of the far north-west. The windy coast beyond, an Oirthir Ghaothach⁵⁴, with its sealers and fowlers, is set in no shire and given no maor. The council's minute says only that it 'is not in the survey'.
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The island shires* (Eilean dhìreach). Two rocks that each kept a customs station of the Administration, Eilean dhìreach off the Tuathaich coast and Eilean ìseal off the east coast, are kept as shires of their own, for the council has no rule for folding one district into its neighbour. Neither has a town to name it, and each shire takes the name of its island.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The market of Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). At the drawing of the shires the Tuathaich of Ceann mhòr are granted a market right for the north-west coast. Its court sits in the harbour store whose locks the fishermen broke. Fish, whale-oil, seal-oil, amber, dyes and the tobacco of the concession farms are sold there.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *Ailean named tally-clerk for An Sireadh*⁵⁵ (Cuan shean). The council names Ailean mac Iain tally-clerk for the ship sent north-about to seek the crossing, and he rides hard for Cuan shean to be aboard by the sailing day, leaving the Ros dhomhain tariff a third finished.⁵⁶
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *An Sireadh*⁵⁷'s log kept and filed (Cuan shean). Ailean keeps An Sireadh's log the length of her voyage, heading, wind and soundings set down plainly through a month of grey water and mist, and the finished log is filed with the council on her return.⁵⁸
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *Aonghas mac Mhurchaidh turns the ship for home*. Sixteen days out with the stores a third gone, Aonghas mac Mhurchaidh orders An Sireadh⁵⁹ about, telling Ailean the sea has not been found empty so much as it has refused, this once, to show itself.⁶⁰
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The prayer said over An Sireadh*⁶¹'s return (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan come down to the quay at Seann Skell in the west as An Sireadh makes her berth and say again the old prayer that the sea be kept shut, said first at her going and now at her coming home empty-handed.⁶²

54. the windy coast

55. the seeking

56. ← Follows from *The ship sent north*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3.

57. the seeking

58. ← Follows from *The ship sent north*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3.

59. the seeking

60. ← Follows from *The ship sent north*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3.

61. the seeking

- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *Ailean learns of the crowning at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Home after a month at sea, Ailean learns of Niall's crowning from an innkeeper near the harbour at Seann Skell in the west, and writes the day into his private book with nothing beside it, having seen nothing of it with his own eyes.⁶³
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The shire map drawn from the humans' survey* (Cathair dhearg). Through an Dùbhlachd, Ailean copies the humans' district survey onto a fresh sheet and sets the Dia-thìris names of the shires against it, for the council to show the twelve without embarrassment at governing by a stranger's paperwork.⁶⁴
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The minute that the windy coast is not in the survey* (Seann Vell). Where the humans' survey ends unmarked at the great moss, Ailean writes a single short line rather than leave the gap unexplained: that the windy coast is not in the survey, a line the council's copying afterward carries to every maor's court unremarked.⁶⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The two island shires entered on the map* (Eilean dhìreach). Finding no council rule for folding a small holding into its neighbour, Ailean enters the two customs-station rocks as shires of their own, each taking the name of the island it sits on and noted as holding no town.⁶⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *Ceann mhòr's market right entered on the map* (Ceann mhòr). The council grants the Ceann mhòr fishermen a market right for their two years' rough trading in the broken-locked harbour store, and Ailean sets the grant down as the smallest clause on the whole map, the one thing on it the townsfolk had already made true for themselves.⁶⁷
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 4** — *The maor appointed* (Ceann mhòr). A maor is set over each shire to gather the Crown's dues and keep its peace. In the Tuathaich shires the maor are Dia-thìrich, lodged in the seat towns. At Ceann mhòr the maor lives in the old human magistrate's house, and the townsfolk call it by its old name.
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 4** — *The Crown's dues set* (Cathair dhearg). The council sets the dues the maor shall gather: a head-due, cis-cinn, on every household by the number of its heads, and a market-due, cis-margaidh, on every sale made by a seller of the kingdom. The humans' harbour tariff at Ros dhomhain stands until the kingdom has a coin of its own to take the market-due in.

62. ← Follows from *The ship sent north*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3.

63. ← Follows from *A saying enters speech*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3; ← Follows from *Niall crowned*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3.

64. ← Follows from *The shires drawn*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3.

65. ← Follows from *The windy coast left out*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3.

66. ← Follows from *The island shires*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3.

67. ← Follows from *The market of Ceann mhòr*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3.

- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 4** — *The roll of arms* (Cathair dhearg). The council's clerks make Clàr nan Suaicheantas⁶⁸, a roll of arms, so that each maor may seal the letters of his court. The kingdom's arms are cut anew from the old seal of the custody, and every shire is given arms of its own. Many charges are copied from a book of arms left at the Residency, and so lions, parrots and crocodiles stand on the seals of shires where none was ever seen. The Dia-thirich shires bear the pointed shield of the custody's seal; the Tuathaich shires keep the rounded shield of the humans' district seals. At Seann Skell in the west the house of Òrd Mhanannain⁶⁹ asks for its badge, the yellow scorpion of Manannan's cup, and that shire alone of all the roll bears a scorpion.
- 8 AM MÀRT, SE 4** — *The maor of Baile Mòr mhòr* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Coinneach mac Ailein, first maor of Siorrachd Baile Mòr mhòr, holds his court under the market roof of the town, for the humans' courthouse has burned. He keeps it there after the new courthouse is built, and so do those who follow him.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 4** — *Tonn Mbòr Cnoc chaol*⁷⁰. The Great Wave falls without warning on the southern coast and lays waste Cnoc chaol, Cuan dhearg and Achadh mhin in a single night. It is the first disaster the new state meets by its own means.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 4** — *The dead of the Great Wave counted* (Cuan dhearg). Relief parties from Cathair dhearg come to Cuan dhearg on the southern coast and count the dead of the three settlements at a little over forty. The harbour of Cuan dhearg is gone, and its boats are found in the fields behind the town. The wave has run on up the gulf as far as Ros gharbh, the seat of its shire, broken its quays and cast the gulf's fishing fleet on the headland. The town stands high and loses few of its people, but nearly every boat.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Achadh mhin under salt* (Achadh mhin). The fields of Achadh mhin lie under salt and will not bear. The council moves the survivors to higher ground and pays for their seed from the treasury. It is the first relief the restored kingdom grants.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Cnoc chaol rebuilt on the hill* (Cnoc chaol). Cnoc chaol is built again on the slope behind the old town, beyond the wave's reach. The old site is left as the water left it. The townsfolk call it an Tràigh Bhàhtte⁷¹, the drowned strand, and do not build there.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *The first maor's seal cut from the roll of arms*. The council's clerk Tòmas cuts the first working seal from Clàr nan Suaicheantas⁷², the newly drawn roll of arms, for a maor of the south-west to press upon his letters; the shire's borrowed lion goes out sealing writs before the ink of the roll itself is fully dry.⁷³

68. the roll of arms; lit. 'the table of the badges'

69. the order of Manannan

70. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

71. the drowned strand at old Cnoc chaol

72. the roll of arms; lit. 'the table of the badges'

73. ← Follows from *The roll of arms*, 2 an Gearran, SE 4.

- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Coinneach mac Ailein settles the fishwives' stall-place* (Baile Mòr mhòr). In his first sitting under the market roof at Baile Mòr mhòr, the new maor Coinneach mac Ailein settles a two-year quarrel over a stall-place by asking the gathered stallholders for the truth of it rather than ruling from the bench alone, and takes their answer as his judgment.⁷⁴
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *The council votes a relief party for the southern coast* (Cathair dhearg). Before its morning sitting breaks, the council of twelve votes grain, blankets, timber and men down the coast road to Cuan dhearg, and orders a tally kept of what is found, the first time the twelve have met before full light since the Severance itself.⁷⁵
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Ailean's tally-book of the wave begun* (Cuan dhearg). Ailean mac Iain, sent south with the relief party, opens a plain tally-book at Cuan dhearg and enters the first of what will be a summer's counting: boats found standing in the fields, wells fouled or sweet, dead named where they can be and marked only by place where they cannot.⁷⁶
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *The dead of Cuan dhearg buried on the rise* (Cuan dhearg). Through the first fortnight after the wave, the dead of Cuan dhearg are carried up onto the rise above the old harbour line and buried in ground the sea has not reached, while the town's clerks mark by place what names cannot be recovered.⁷⁷
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *The boats left standing in the barley* (Cuan dhearg). The wrecked fishing boats of Cuan dhearg, carried inland by the wave and left standing among the barley behind the town, are judged too many to right before winter and are left through the harvest, one still upright in its furrow with its mast stepped.⁷⁸
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *The treasury's first relief roll voted* (Cathair dhearg). On the count of a little over forty dead, the council votes seed and removal for the survivors of Achadh mhin out of the treasury without a due asked in return, over one councillor's question of cost, answered that a kingdom that finds silver for a roll of arms can find grain for its own dead.⁷⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Ros gharbh's fleet counted on the headland* (Ros gharbh). Ailean mac Iain walks the headland above Ros gharbh's harbour and counts the town's fishing fleet where the wave cast it, hull by hull, sound or stove, and carries the count south as proof that a town spared its people can still be ruined in its trade.⁸⁰

74. ← Follows from *The maor of Baile Mòr mhòr*, 8 am Màrt, SE 4.

75. → Leads to *Tonn Mbòr Cnoc chaol*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4; ← Follows from *The dead of the Great Wave counted*, 24 an t-Samhain, SE 4.

76. ← Follows from *The dead of the Great Wave counted*, 24 an t-Samhain, SE 4.

77. ← Follows from *The dead of the Great Wave counted*, 24 an t-Samhain, SE 4.

78. ← Follows from *The dead of the Great Wave counted*, 24 an t-Samhain, SE 4.

79. ← Follows from *Achadh mhin under salt*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, SE 4.

80. ← Follows from *The dead of the Great Wave counted*, 24 an t-Samhain, SE 4.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *A bill shire questions its new arms.* A custodian's widow keeping a south-western shire's books asks the council's clerk whether a shire that never bore a badge under the old custody must bear one now, and is answered that any shire's writs are read faster at Cathair dhearg with a seal, borrowed beast or none, than without one.⁸¹
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 5** — *Tonn* (Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol⁸²). In the survivors' accounts gathered by the relief parties, 'tonn', wave, is used of anything sudden and overwhelming. Within a generation the sense is heard across the south: 'tha e san tonn', he is in the wave of it.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, SE 5** — *The wave's reach on Eilean mhin* (Eilean mhin). The Great Wave passes also over the low island of Eilean mhin off the southern coast, where none then lived the year round. The shepherds who summered there do not go back.
- 24 AN GIBLEAN, SE 5** — *Ros gharbh's boats rebuilt* (Ros gharbh). Through the following year Ros gharbh borrows hulls from harbours the wave did not reach while shipwrights from beyond the gulf raise its fleet anew on the cleared beach, one keel at a time, until the last boat is launched and the town's people begin calling that whole year simply the bad year.⁸³
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, SE 5** — *The old human coinage withdrawn.* All the humans' coin still in hand is cried down and ceases to be money. Within a year a new coinage of the Rìoghachd takes its place, minted with ink of coal dust in its seal.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 5** — *The mint at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). A mint is set up in the old human counting-house at Cathair dhearg under Fearchar mac Dhòmhnail, called Fearchar Bonn. The seal of each coin is pressed with an ink ground from coal dust, so that a clipped coin shows the colour at its edge.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 5** — *The northern savings voided* (Caol mhòr). The Tuathaich households kept what savings they had in the humans' coin. Now it is withdrawn, and their savings are worth their weight in metal and no more. The Moot at Caol mhòr petitions the council for an exchange. The petition is received and filed.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 5** — *Walter Hale's tally of the cried-down savings* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale goes house to house at Caol mhòr with his day-book, counting what the town's households had kept back in the humans' coin now the council has cried it down. The sum comes to something over four hundred marks across better than two hundred households, none of it large, all of it now worth its weight as metal alone.⁸⁴

81. ← Follows from *The roll of arms*, 2 an Gearran, SE 4.

82. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

83. ← Follows from *The dead of the Great Wave counted*, 24 an t-Samhain, SE 4.

84. ← Follows from *The northern savings voided*, 7 an t-Samhain, SE 5.

- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 5** — *Fearchar Bonn's four failed strikings* (Cathair dhearg). At the mint in the old counting-house at Cathair dhearg, Fearchar mac Dhòmhnaihl spends a winter grinding coal dust fine enough to hold in a coin's seal without fouling the die, ruining four strikings of good silver before the ink and the binder are right. The fifth striking is shown to the treasury and kept.⁸⁵
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 5** — *Òrd Mhacha*⁸⁶'s *blessing of the first striking* (Cathair dhearg). The first true coin of the Rìoghachd is blessed by Òrd Mhacha before it leaves the mint at Cathair dhearg, on the council's own instruction that the coal in its seal be reckoned a piece of the mountain carried out into every purse of the kingdom. The coin passes at the capital's markets within the month as though it had always been current.⁸⁷
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 5** — *A maor's clerk carries the new coin north* (Caol mhòr). In the autumn a young clerk of a southern maor's office rides to Caol mhòr with the first struck coin the Moot has seen, and, asked how a household of the south is managing the exchange, answers that he does not rightly know, his own family's savings having gone on the rent before the crying-down.⁸⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 5** — *The Moot debates the wording of its petition* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr argues two evenings over a letter for the council, one voice wanting it to ask why the coin was cried down without warning north, another wanting no blame in it at all. Walter Hale's plain ask for an exchange mark for mark, without complaint, stands by the second evening nearly as he first wrote it.⁸⁹

85. ← Follows from *The mint at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an Dàmhair, SE 5.

86. the order of Macha

87. ← Follows from *The mint at Cathair dhearg*, 9 an Dàmhair, SE 5.

88. ← Follows from *The northern savings voided*, 7 an t-Samhain, SE 5.

89. → Leads to *The northern savings voided*, 7 an t-Samhain, SE 5.

THE YEARS SE 6 – 10

- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 6** — *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares* (Doire mhin). At Doire mhin in the north the smith Joseph Marlow melts down his neighbours' withdrawn coin and casts it into ploughshares, and sells them back at the cost of the charcoal. The Tuathaich songs name him yet.
- 3 AM MÀRT, SE 6** — *The coin at Inis thais* (Inis thais). At Inis thais on the south-west coast the new coin is scarce for most of the year, and the merchants trade in chits written on the paper of the house of the Stone. When the coin comes the chits are redeemed at the house's door, and the house keeps a tenth.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, SE 6** — *Òrd Bhrìde¹ given its doctrine*. The Coal Rite, Òrd Bhrìde, the order that keeps Bride's flame and Crom's stone, is given a settled doctrine within the Old Faith. Through the long ages it had kept its flame by custom and by no written creed; now its doctrine is built upon the leyline and the unbroken line of the coal-touched.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, SE 6** — *The first high custodian of the Rite* (Seann Skell). Dòmhnall mac Thormoid is named Àrd-choimheadaiche² of Òrd Bhrìde³ and seated at Seann Skell on the southern coast, where the order's greatest house stands. His first charge is to write an order of worship. There had never been one.
- 23 AN CÈITEAN, SE 6** — *The Hawk houses refuse* (Cnoc bheag). The houses of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁴ about Cnoc bheag refuse the new order of worship, holding that the older form of the Old Faith needs no custodian above the local altar. They are not compelled. Here begins the long quarrel of the Hawk and the Rite.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, SE 6** — *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh takes the order* (Muileann naomh). The hawk-house at Muileann naomh, southernmost of the Hawk's houses and farthest from Cnoc bheag, takes the Rite's written order of worship and becomes a house of Òrd Bhrìde⁵. Its bell, the first hung in any hawk-house, now rings at the Rite's measured burnings. No other house of the Hawk follows.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 6** — *The petition copied fair and sent twice* (Caol mhòr). David Hale copies his father's letter to the council a second time, so that one fair copy travels south with the winter carter and a second waits for the spring roads, on the reasoning that two letters in two hands are harder for a clerk to mislay than one. Both reach the council's chests within the year.⁶

1. the order of Bride's flame

2. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

3. the order of Bride's flame

4. the Hawk order

5. the order of Bride's flame

6. ← Follows from *The northern savings voided*, 7 an t-Samhain, SE 5.

- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 6** — *Ailean mac Iain files the Moot's letter* (Cathair dhearg). The Moot's letter asking an exchange for the north's voided savings reaches the council's chests and is read by the under-clerk Ailean mac Iain, who notes its date and seal, finds no standing order to answer it, and sets it down among that quarter's petitions marked with two words, received; filed, as his post requires.⁷
- I AN LÙNASTAL, SE 6** — *Joseph Marlow's first ploughshare* (Doire mhin). At his forge by the millrace at Doire mhin, Joseph Marlow melts down his own household's cried-down coin before any neighbour's, casting it into the flat shape a ploughshare wants, still bearing along one edge the ghost of a king's profile the mould has not erased.⁸
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 6** — *Marlow's charge fixed at the price of the charcoal* (Doire mhin). Joseph Marlow sets his price for turning a neighbour's dead coin into a ploughshare at the cost of his charcoal alone, reasoning that a man should not pay twice for coin the council has already taken from him once. Half of Doire mhin brings him its savings before the winter is out.⁹
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 6** — *Harry Marlow promised to a Cuan shean yard* (Doire mhin). Harry Marlow, Joseph Marlow's eldest son, nine years old, is promised to a shipwright's yard at Cuan shean when he turns thirteen, on the word of a Cuan shean man who watched him true a plough-beam by eye at his father's forge without a level.¹⁰
- II AN T-SULTAIN, SE 6** — *Joseph Marlow's song first sung at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). A plain tune naming Joseph Marlow and his forge is first heard going quietly round Doire mhin that winter, sung under the breath of the women waiting their turn with a sackful of savings, though the smith himself will not sing it in front of a stranger.¹¹
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 6** — *The house of the Stone's chits redeemed at its door* (Inis thais). At Inis thais, where the new coin arrives slower than almost anywhere in the kingdom, the merchants trade the winter through on chits written against the word of the house of Òrd na Cloiche¹². When coin at last comes south in quantity, the chits are carried to the house's own door and redeemed there, less a tenth the house keeps for the keeping of them.¹³
- IO AN DÀMHAIR, SE 6** — *Hale sets down the answer he means to give the Moot* (Caol mhòr). Weighing Fearchar Bonn's coin against Joseph Marlow's ploughshare on his own table, Walter Hale writes for the Moot that a people waiting on an answer that never comes would do better to build, while it waits, the thing it asked for, since the waiting will be long and the ground does not stop wanting to be ploughed.¹⁴

7. ← Follows from *The northern savings voided*, 7 an t-Samhain, SE 5.

8. ← Follows from *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares*, 2 an Gearran, SE 6.

9. ← Follows from *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares*, 2 an Gearran, SE 6.

10. ← Follows from *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh takes the order*, 29 an Cèitean, SE 6.

11. ← Follows from *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares*, 2 an Gearran, SE 6.

12. the order of the Stone

13. ← Follows from *The coin at Inis thais*, 3 am Màrt, SE 6.

14. ← Follows from *The northern savings voided*, 7 an t-Samhain, SE 5; ← Follows from *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares*, 2 an Gearran, SE 6.

- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 6** — *The first furrow cut with a coin-iron share* (Doire mhin). At the end of am Màrt the first furrow of Doire mhin's spring ploughing is cut behind a borrowed ox with one of Joseph Marlow's shares, turning a clean black line the length of the field, the humans' silver made over into iron for a north the council's coin has not yet reached.¹⁵
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 6** — *The written order first read at the southern Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). In the hall of the greatest house of the Rite, Dòmhnall mac Thormoid reads aloud, for the first time, the order of worship he has spent the year composing: the leyline, the unbroken line of the coal-touched, and the measure of what may be burned. Eleven custodians and a scattering of witnesses from neighbouring houses hear it out in silence.¹⁶
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 6** — *The houses of the Stone promise good will and nothing more* (Baile Mòr fhionn). Within the month a letter reaches Seann Skell from the houses of the Stone in the south-west, wishing the new order well and offering no further part in it. Dòmhnall mac Thormoid copies it into the first page of a plain ledger he begins that day, meaning to keep every letter the Rite sends or receives from then on.
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 6** — *The Hawk houses' letter of refusal* (Cnoc bheag). A letter comes to Seann Skell from the hawk-houses about Cnoc bheag, sealed with the mark of a bird with wings spread flat: the old form of the Rite has never needed a custodian above the local altar and sees no cause to answer to one now. It calls the new writing handsome, and not needed, and wishes the southern house no ill in going its own way.¹⁷
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 6** — *Muileann naomh's bell first rung at a measured burning* (Muileann naomh). The hawk-house at Muileann naomh, far south of Cnoc bheag, takes up the written order entire and hangs a bell cast new for the ordered worship, the first any house of the Rite has raised for that purpose rather than a wedding or a warning. It is rung that summer at the year's measured burning before a small crowd gathered in the lane.¹⁸
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 6** — *Dòmhnall mac Thormoid's book of correspondence begun* (Seann Skell). Watching a house answer him with silence rather than argument, the new high custodian begins a plain ledger to hold every letter the Rite sends or receives, the first such record any keeper of the flame has thought to make, so that a question once answered need not be answered from nothing a second time.¹⁹
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 6** — *Dòmhnall mac Thormoid rides north to Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Summoned to be presented at court as the Rite's first high custodian, Dòmhnall mac Thormoid rides to the capital to press, unsuccessfully, for a share in Òrd Mhacha²⁰'s keeping of the coronation regalia. He pays for his own lodging, no arrangement having been made for him, and returns south with only the high priest's refusal to enter in his book.

15. ← Follows from *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares*, 2 an Gearran, SE 6.

16. ← Follows from *The first high custodian of the Rite*, 17 an Cèitean, SE 6.

17. ← Follows from *The Hawk houses refuse*, 23 an Cèitean, SE 6.

18. ⇌ At the same time *The Hawk houses refuse*, 23 an Cèitean, SE 6.

19. ← Follows from *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh takes the order*, 29 an Cèitean, SE 6.

20. the order of Macha

- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 6** — *The unbroken line left open in doctrine* (Seann Skell). Writing the order's page on the coal-touched, Dòmhnall mac Thormoid finds an old defence and a later gloss disagree on whether the unbroken line means blood or office, and sets the doctrine down to hold both readings rather than close either, having found no ground in the record to choose between them.²¹
- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 7** — *The houses of the Stone stand aside* (Baile Mòr fhionn). The houses of Òrd na Cloiche²² in the south-west, whose Clach, the Lia Fàil²³, is not Crom's stone, are bidden to send witnesses to the settling of the Rite at Seann Skell. They send none, and a letter wishing it well.²⁴
- 10 AN GEARRAN, SE 7** — *The Moot's schoolhouse petition* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale asks the council for leave to open schools in the north that teach in the humans' tongue. The council answers that the kingdom's schools teach in Dia-thiris and it has no others. The Moot's minute calls the answer 'clear, at least'.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, SE 7** — *The crown's order and the court* (Cathair dhearg). The house of Òrd Mhacha²⁵ at Cathair dhearg, the order of the capital and the crown, is given the keeping of the coronation regalia, which it had kept before the humans came. The Rite's high custodian asks a share in the keeping and is refused.²⁶
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 7** — *The first census after the Severance*. The state counts its own people for the first time since it took back the island. The roll notes, and says no more of it, how few the coal-touched are.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 7** — *The census of the faiths* (Baile chrom). The first census of the restored kingdom enters every town under the faith its people keep, the Old Faith, the Old Spirits or the Church. It is the first such roll since Seumas Bàn's clerks counted the rites at Dùn ìseal. On the far north-western cape beyond Baile chrom, where there is no town, the clerks find scattered families with no house of any faith, and on Eilean ghorm and the smallest islets no one to ask. All these they enter as *gun chreideamh*²⁷, without a faith.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 7** — *The count taken from the road* (Doire ghlas). Dia-thìrich census clerks count the Tuathaich towns of Siorrachd Doire ghlas from the road and enter few of the houses. That same year the Moot keeps its own tally. The two totals differ by nearly a fifth, and each side holds to its own.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 7** — *The circuit justices* (Cathair dhomhain). Justices are appointed to ride circuit among the shires, and the first of them is Eilidh nic Leòid of Cathair dhomhain. Her circuit takes in eleven shires of the south-west and is most of a year in the riding.

21. ← Follows from *Òrd Bhride given its doctrine*, 18 an Giblean, SE 6.

22. the order of the Stone

23. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

24. ← Leads to *The houses of the Stone promise good will and nothing more*, 17 an Dàmhair, SE 6.

25. the order of Macha

26. ← Leads to *Dòmhnall mac Thormoid rides north to Cathair dhearg*, 26 an t-Samhain, SE 6.

27. without a faith

- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 7** — *The head-due first collected* (Cathair dhearg). The maoir gather the head-due for the first time, on the households the census counted, at eighteen purses on every five thousand heads, and take it with the harbour dues.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 7** — *Copies of the order sent to every house of the Rite* (Seann Skell). By the last month of winter Dòmhnall mac Thormoid's two clerks finish fair copies of the order, each checked line by line against his own text, and he sends them to every house of the Old Faith still standing, the Hawk-houses among them, along with the houses of the Stone, Òrd Mhacha²⁸, and a last copy carried back to Muileann naomh in thanks.²⁹
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 7** — *The census asks of faith and finds none to answer for some*. The state's first census, sent to ask what households hold to as well as how many they number, meets on the far north-western cape and its islets a good many who give no creed at all. Finding no word in Dia-thiris that fits a household with nothing to declare, the clerks write against their names gun chreideamh³⁰, without a creed, and ride on.³¹
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 7** — *The two counts of Doire gblas go uncorrected* (Doire ghlas). The state's roll and the Moot's own tally of the northern shire, taken the same season by different hands, are found afterward to differ by close to a fifth. Neither is sent to the other side to be checked against it, and both are filed, each true by its own reckoning, in the chest that kept it.³²
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 7** — *Eilidh nic Leòid's letter of office reaches Cathair dhombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). A council rider, delayed three days by flooded roads, brings Eilidh nic Leòid the letter naming her first among the circuit justices: eleven shires of the south-west to be ridden once in every twelvemonth, and a written record of every judgment to be carried back each year to the council's clerks.³³
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 7** — *Eilidh's first assize, held at Cathair dhombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). Before setting out on her circuit Eilidh nic Leòid sits her first cases at home: a boundary measured with a knotted cord rather than taken on either party's word, a debt found on the strength of an unburned receipt, and a fishmonger's short weight proved against the council's own standard.³⁴
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 7** — *The quarrel over the well at Muileann bhàn* (Muileann bhàn). A widow who once charged a penny a season for water from a spring now run dry, and the mason set to warden the town's new waterworks, bring their dispute over one well to the circuit justice's bench in the mill-yard, the town having no courtroom of its own.

28. the order of Macha

29. ← Follows from *The first high custodian of the Rite*, 17 an Cèitean, SE 6.

30. without a faith

31. ← Follows from *The first census after the Severance*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, SE 7.

32. ← Follows from *The count taken from the road*, 15 an Lùnastal, SE 7.

33. ← Follows from *The circuit justices*, 23 an Lùnastal, SE 7.

34. ← Follows from *The head-due first collected*, 27 an t-Sultain, SE 7.

19 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 7 — *Eilidh's ruling on the Muileann bhàn well* (Muileann bhàn).

The justice rules that the dead spring's old custom cannot be transferred to water drawn by a different road and paid for from a different purse, but that the well's ground remains the widow's by custom, and the town's word is given that it will never be built over or fenced from her without leave.³⁵

25 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 7 — *The head-due first gathered along the southern circuit*. Maors' clerks set up their tables at the crossroads of the south-west shires and take the head-due, eighteen purses on every five thousand heads, for the first time in living memory. Eilidh nic Leòid, riding past more than one such table, keeps her own note of what she sees, though none of it is brought to her bench.³⁶

28 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 7 — *Eilidh's circuit calls at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The harbour court at Inis thais, kept well enough already by its own magistrate, hands up only two causes to the visiting justice, both turning on the ownership of a fishing boat after its owner died leaving no heir the town could agree on.³⁷

4 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 7 — *Eilidh's circuit calls at Doire shean* (Doire shean). Sitting two days in the temple porch for want of a courtroom, the justice settles a dispute among four households over the right to dry nets on a stretch of shingle by asking after the shore's own long custom rather than any written law, which none had ever thought to write so far down the coast.³⁸

3 AM MÀRT, SE 8 — *Muileann bhàn's waterworks* (Muileann bhàn). Muileann bhàn on the southern plain builds the first public waterworks of the restored kingdom: a stone tank on the hill, fed by the mill-race, with lead pipes to four street wells. The Guild of Hewers sends its surveyors to learn the making of it.³⁹

10 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 8 — *The Leòid ruling* (Seann Bhral). Sitting at Seann Bhral, Eilidh nic Leòid rules that land held by Tuathaich under human title passes to the Crown, and that the right to work it stays with the holders and their heirs. The ruling is cited in nearly every land case of the age after.

14 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 8 — *The maor of Seann Bhral asks a ruling of his own cousin* (Seann Bhral). Artair mac Lachlainn, maor of the western shire, meets the circuit justice at the town gate and asks her plainly to find for the Crown's grant, the household holding it being kin of his own. She hears the cause as she hears any other, and he sits through it without speaking.⁴⁰

35. ← Follows from *The head-due first collected*, 27 an t-Sultain, SE 7.

36. ← Follows from *The head-due first collected*, 27 an t-Sultain, SE 7.

37. ← Follows from *The head-due first collected*, 27 an t-Sultain, SE 7.

38. ← Follows from *The head-due first collected*, 27 an t-Sultain, SE 7.

39. ← Leads to *The quarrel over the well at Muileann bhàn*, 19 an Dàmhair, SE 7.

40. ← Follows from *The Leòid ruling*, 10 an t-Sultain, SE 8.

23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 8 — *The Tanner suit heard at Seann Bhral in the west* (Seann Bhral).

A Tuathaich family holding four fields under a Company surveyor's title cut before the Severance is set against a Dia-threach household holding the Crown's newer grant of the same ground, made in ignorance that the land was occupied at all. Half the shire's Tuathaich households come to Seann Bhral to hear it argued.⁴¹

3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 8 — *The Leòid ruling copied to every maor's court of the circuit*. Eilidh nic

Leòid has her ruling fair-copied to every maor's court of her eleven shires, with a note that any like cause be decided on like reasoning until the council itself says otherwise, reasoning that a law read differently in every court that hears it is no law at all.⁴²

9 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 8 — *The coal line repaired* (Muileann chrom). The railway the humans

built from the central mountains to the sea, broken in three places in the Severance war, is mended as far as Muileann chrom. A Rail Board is formed at Cathair dhearg to run it, with a clerk, two engineers and the humans' timetable.

17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 8 — *The bridge at Cathair dhearg re-dedicated* (Drochaid Cathair

dhearg⁴³). The stone bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain below the capital, rebuilt in the humans' day, is hallowed anew with a name-stone in Dia-thiris. The humans' stone is left in its place and turned to face the river.

20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 8 — *The Rail Board's timetable hung at Muileann chrom*

(Muileann chrom). The mended line's copied timetable, carried over from the humans' own working papers, is hung on a board at the Muileann chrom terminus where the rails now end. Passengers and carters read it as they find it, since no one troubles to explain why a six-year-old kingdom keeps a dead people's hours.⁴⁴

25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 8 — *The talk at the net-mending* (Baile chrom). Under the eaves of

the net-store church at Baile chrom, the winter's net-mending turns to talk of Hannah Crane's word that the Grey Night vigil will be kept in the open. Some call it needless risk to an old office; others say it is overdue. No one carries the talk beyond the town.

15 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 9 — *The necropolis at Cnoc dhìreach* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach⁴⁵). The

shire of Ceann mhin closes the old burial ground at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach to new graves, for the vines have broken so many stones that no room can be found. Families of the town still tend the old graves, and some say the place is not empty after dark.

13 AN GEARRAN, SE 9 — *Eaglais nan Tuathach*⁴⁶ *persists*. The Tuathaich communities keep

their Church alive in the north. Quietly they keep also the telling of the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan to the Isle of the Blessed, which the Dia-thìrich priesthood calls superstition still.

41. ← Follows from *The Leòid ruling*, 10 an t-Sultain, SE 8.

42. ← Follows from *The Leòid ruling*, 10 an t-Sultain, SE 8.

43. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

44. ← Follows from *The coal line repaired*, 9 an Dàmhair, SE 8.

45. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

46. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

- 14 AM MÀRT, SE 9** — *The Grey Night kept openly* (Baile chrom). At Baile chrom in the far north-west the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane holds the vigil of Rùn-diomhair na h-Oidhche Glaise⁴⁷ in the open, for the first time since the Severance. The sect keeps one night of silence in the year under Sine, the Peaceful Goose, its name for the wild goose of the Holy Spirit. The bishops of the Church call the vigil irregular. Outsiders are not told which night it is.⁴⁸
- 30 AM MÀRT, SE 9** — *The churches of the north* (Cnoc ghorm). Most Tuathaich towns keep An Eaglais⁴⁹, the Church their forebears brought at the Crossing; the Dia-thìrich of the west coast beside them keep Manannan's order. A church is built at Cnoc ghorm, the greatest in the north.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, SE 9** — *The cattle-market at Muileann fhionn* (Muileann fhionn). Muileann fhionn, the mill-town the humans built to guard the northern landing, is granted a market right for the north-western inland country. The Tuathaich drovers bring their cattle and sheep to it, and from it the droves go south to Ceann leathan and the farms of the south-east. It grows to be the greatest cattle-market on the island.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, SE 9** — *The old priest's counsel* (Baile chrom). Walking back from a burial, the priest of Baile chrom tells Hannah Crane that the vigil's keeping is hers to judge, having held his own office forty years by staying out of what belongs to another. It is the only word of encouragement she has from anyone before the night.⁵⁰
- 4 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 9** — *The maor's man watches and writes nothing* (Baile chrom). A clerk's assistant of Cnoc ghorm, lodging at Baile chrom on an unrelated errand, climbs a rise above the headland and watches Hannah Crane's vigil through the night from a distance. He carries no instruction to report it and no form to record it on, and the shire's returns for the week say nothing.⁵¹
- 11 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 9** — *The bishops' letter kept behind the altar-cloth* (Baile chrom). Three bishops of the Church write to Baile chrom calling the open keeping of the Grey Night irregular, and ask, without commanding, that the custom be given up. Hannah Crane reads the letter twice and puts it away in the box that already keeps the town's oldest relic, and answers nothing.⁵²
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 9** — *The Ros bheag bell raised at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). The bell of the old chapel at Ros bheag, carted north at the Severance and crated in a barn for want of a tower to take it, is hung at last in the new church at Cnoc ghorm and rung on a market morning. Its sound carries to the shore road, farther than the town had thought a single bell could reach.⁵³

47. the Mystery of the Grey Night

48. → Caused by *The talk at the net-mending*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, SE 8.

49. the Church

50. → Leads to *The Grey Night kept openly*, 14 am Màrt, SE 9.

51. ⇌ At the same time *The Grey Night kept openly*, 14 am Màrt, SE 9.

52. ← Follows from *The Grey Night kept openly*, 14 am Màrt, SE 9.

53. ← Follows from *The churches of the north*, 30 am Màrt, SE 9.

- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 9** — *The hurdles built on the Muileann fhionn green* (Muileann fhionn). The town's carpenters spend most of a month raising pens on the old common green at Muileann fhionn, working from a plan one of them had seen used at a southern fair, to hold the cattle and sheep the new market right will bring down from the hill farms.⁵⁴
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 9** — *The first drove south from Muileann fhionn* (Muileann fhionn). Hill farmers who had always walked their beasts the long way south now bring them to the new market at Muileann fhionn, and from there the droves go on by the old tracks toward Ceann leathan. Within a few seasons the green stands trodden to mud on every market morning.⁵⁵
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 9** — *A young wife of Muileann fhionn keeps her own watch* (Baile chrom). A woman newly married into Baile chrom from Muileann fhionn, who asked Hannah Crane whether she was not afraid to keep the vigil alone, climbs the headland herself the night it is kept and watches from a careful distance. She tells no one, not even her husband, that she went.⁵⁶
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, SE 10** — *The church school at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). The church at Cnoc ghorm opens a school for its priests. It teaches in the humans' tongue and reads the Bible in the Dia-thìris text its preachers use on the west coast. In all the north, both are taught there only.
- II AN CÈITEAN, SE 10** — *The border wall proposed*. A fixed boundary between the Dia-thìrich and the Tuathaich country is proposed for the first time. It is refused as needless, for the two peoples already keep apart of their own will.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 10** — *The minute on the wall* (Cathair dhearg). The council minute that refuses the boundary wall runs to four lines. The fourth reads: 'They do not come south.' Five of the twelve councillors initial it; the other seven do not sign against it.
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 10** — *The Allt an Àigh⁵⁷ walk* (Allt an Àigh). The followers of Na Seann Spioradan⁵⁸ keep their yearly walk to the holy well called Allt an Àigh in the east, whose water, the old tales say, brings fortune. The custodians of the Rite speak against the walk and do not forbid it.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 10** — *The Cnoc ghorm church school opens its first term* (Cnoc ghorm). Nine boys sit the first term of the school raised inside the new church at Cnoc ghorm, taught the humans' tongue and the western reading of the scripture by a master brought up from Seann Skell. The letter reporting it to the council asks for nothing and is filed without debate.⁵⁹

54. → Leads to *The cattle-market at Muileann fhionn*, 12 an Giblean, SE 9.

55. ← Follows from *The cattle-market at Muileann fhionn*, 12 an Giblean, SE 9.

56. ⇌ At the same time *The Grey Night kept openly*, 14 am Màrt, SE 9.

57. the stream of the healing water

58. the Old Spirits

- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 10** — *Seumas mac Coinnich Gblais proposes a marked boundary* (Cathair dhearg). The councillor of the eastern custodian houses lays a map before the council and asks for a ditch and bank, with stones set at the mile, along the line where the settled shires meet the Tuathaich country, arguing that a boundary kept only in memory will not hold as both peoples' numbers grow.⁶⁰
- 1 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 10** — *The council lets the wall stand unbuilt* (Cathair dhearg). After two hours' debate on cost and custom, an old councillor says plainly that in eight years no Tuathaich has crossed where he was not wanted, and the room presses the boundary no further. No vote is taken; the proposal is simply not renewed by anyone present.⁶¹
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 10** — *The minute on the wall signed by five, opposed by none* (Cathair dhearg). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill's four-line minute, ending in the sentence spoken against the wall, is initialled by five of the twelve councillors. The other seven enter no dissent. The Library keeps the sheet as the whole of the boundary's history: proposed, weighed, and left undrawn.⁶²
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 10** — *Gormshuil begins a book of her own* (Cathair dhearg). Keeping the blotted first draft of the wall's minute rather than burning it, the under-clerk pastes it into a small board-bound book bought without her clerk-master's knowledge and begins, that same evening, a private record of her own, the first of the volumes she keeps for the rest of her working life.⁶³
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 10** — *Gormshuil walks to Allt an Àigh⁶⁴ with her mother* (Allt an Àigh). Given a fortnight's leave for the first time in two years, the under-clerk walks the old road east with her mother, of an Old Spirits house, to drink at the holy well and add a stone to its cairn, lodging a night on the way at the walkers' hall of Achadh gharbh.⁶⁵
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 10** — *The walkers' ledger at Achadh gharbh* (Achadh gharbh). The keeper of the hall built for the well's pilgrims shows Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill her cracked-spined ledger of every walker's shire and name, its pages already holding travellers from better than twenty shires, north and south and east and west of the island together on the one road.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 10** — *The mountain's yield passes the humans' own figure*. A surveyor's report tells the council, in the flat language such reports keep, that the mine's yield has come back to what it gave under the humans and, in the month just past, gone beyond it, the working unchanged in every particular but the hands the profit now fills.

59. ← Follows from *The church school at Cnoc ghorrm*, 29 an Giblean, SE 10.

60. ← Follows from *The border wall proposed*, 11 an Cèitean, SE 10.

61. ← Follows from *The border wall proposed*, 11 an Cèitean, SE 10.

62. ← Follows from *The minute on the wall*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, SE 10.

63. ← Follows from *The Allt an Àigh walk*, 8 an t-Iuchar, SE 10.

64. the stream of the healing water

65. ← Follows from *The Allt an Àigh walk*, 8 an t-Iuchar, SE 10.

THE YEARS SE 11 – 15

- 11 AN GEARRAN, SE 11** — *The walkers at Achadh gharbh* (Achadh gharbh). The walkers to Allt an Àigh¹ lodge at Achadh gharbh on the way, and the village builds a long hall for them. The hall's keeper writes each walker's shire in a book, and by the end of the decade it holds names from fifty shires.²
- 15 AN CÈITEAN, SE 11** — *The mine worked to the full again*. The mine's yield after the Severance comes up to what it gave under the humans, and then passes it. The working is the same as before. Only the profit goes to other hands.³
- 23 AN CÈITEAN, SE 11** — *The Sloc Mòr concession* (Achadh dhomhain). The Crown grants the working of the Sloc Mòr, the great shaft at Achadh dhomhain, to Uisdean mac Ùisdein of Cathair mhòr, whose house held an overseer's post under the humans. The Crown takes a fifth of the yield. The terms are the humans' terms with the names changed.
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 11** — *The night-shift kept* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The council will not end the working of the vein by day and night that the humans ordered two generations before. The mountain is still given no season of rest. The custodians of the Rite enter a protest, and then bless the shafts.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *The Sloc Mòr granted to Uisdean mac Ùisdein* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean mac Ùisdein of Cathair mhòr, whose family held an overseer's post there under the humans, comes to the capital to put his name to the working of the great shaft at Achadh dhomhain, the terms copied almost word for word from the humans' own ledgers save the fifth now kept for the Crown.⁴
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *A board is seated over the Sloc Mòr's grant* (Cathair dhearg). Three clerks and an engineer are set at a table in the council's own house at Cathair dhearg to see the mine's grant kept to its terms, answering to no name grander than the mountain itself, and it is to this small board, not the council, that Uisdean mac Ùisdein afterward sends his returns.⁵
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *Uisdean mac Ùisdein's first contract with the hewers* (Achadh dhomhain). Before the snow closes the high tracks, Uisdean mac Ùisdein rides north to set his name against the hewers' own at the shaft-head, the roster and the rates of pay carried over unaltered from the rolls the humans had kept, only the name at the head of the page now his own.⁶

1. the stream of the healing water

2. ← Leads to *The walkers' ledger at Achadh gharbh*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, SE 10.

3. ← Leads to *The mountain's yield passes the humans' own figure*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, SE 10.

4. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr concession*, 23 an Cèitean, SE 11.

5. ← Follows from *The night-shift kept*, 18 an t-Samhain, SE 11.

6. ← Follows from *The night-shift kept*, 18 an t-Samhain, SE 11.

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *The council lets the night shift stand* (Achadh dhomhain). Asked whether the mountain, now the island's own, should be given the rest the humans never allowed it, the mine board's engineer answers that the very yield just reported depends on a shaft that never stands idle, and the council sets the question aside rather than decide it either way.⁷
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *The custodians enter their protest against the unresting shaft* (Achadh dhomhain). The custodian houses of the vein carry down a half-page paper asking not that the night shift end, which they know is no longer the council's to give back, but only that their protest stand written, so that none after can say the old custom's breaking went unmarked.⁸
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *Gormshuil reads the grant at the shaft-head* (Achadh dhomhain). Sent north with the council's own copy of the Sloc Mòr grant, Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill reads it aloud to the assembled hewers by lamplight in the winter cold, the custodians of the shaft standing apart in their grey coats while the words that answer their protest with silence are read over their heads.⁹
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 11** — *The custodians bless the shafts they could not close* (Achadh dhomhain). Once the grant is read, the four custodians of the vein walk to the pit-mouth and speak an old blessing over it, calling on the mountain to hold, to give, and in its own time to rest, before turning back without further word to the lamps that burn on through the falling dark.¹⁰
- 14 AM MÀRT, SE 12** — *The pit towns fill* (Muileann dhearg). Dia-thìrich families from the hungry east go to the vein-towns for wages. Muileann dhearg doubles in size within three years. Its hall of the druid school, shut since the humans' time, is taken for a hewers' lodging and twice enlarged in those same years.
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 12** — *Baile thais grows on the coal road* (Baile thais). At Baile thais the coal road from the central mountains comes down to the Abhainn uaine above the gulf, and the town takes in carters, inns and a ropewalk. Its people double in a decade, and it is given a shire court.
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 12** — *Raiders off Cathair gheal* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Ships that fly no flag, some manned by men who once served the human administration, begin to raid the coast off Cathair gheal in the north-west. The Tuathaich towns suffer first, and no one defends them.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 12** — *The coal line reaches the Sloc Mòr* (Achadh dhomhain). The mended railway is carried up the valley to the pithead at Achadh dhomhain. The first coal train runs from the Sloc Mòr to Cathair dhearg in the kingdom's name, on the humans' rails.

7. ← Follows from *The night-shift kept*, 18 an t-Samhain, SE 11.

8. ← Follows from *The night-shift kept*, 18 an t-Samhain, SE 11.

9. ← Follows from *The night-shift kept*, 18 an t-Samhain, SE 11.

- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 12** — *Iain mac Ruairidh taken on as chainman* (Achadh dhomhain). Iain, a hewer's son of the hills, is taken on by Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin, the Mine Board's surveyor, to carry the chain and keep the faces' book at the Sloc Mòr. He is sworn to no guild, only entered on the Board's roll.¹¹
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 12** — *The druid hall at Muileann dhearg becomes a lodging* (Muileann dhearg). As hungry families from the east crowd into the vein-towns, Muileann dhearg's shut druid hall is opened again, not for its old teaching but for pallets on its floor, and is twice enlarged within a few years to hold them.¹²
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 12** — *Inns and a ropewalk at Baile thais* (Baile thais). The crossing at Baile thais, where the coal road meets the Abhainn uaine, fills with carters who stay the night and then keep families there; inns, stables and a ropewalk making the cages' hauling-rope grow up along the ford within the decade.¹³
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 12** — *The raiders' first season off Cathair gheal*. Flagless ships work the water off Cathair gheal in the north-west; a fishing house is burned on the shore below Cathair gheal and two boats are lost from Cathair gheal's own harbour. The council's word, when it comes the next spring, is four lines asking that the matter be watched.¹⁴
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 12** — *The first coal train runs to the capital* (Achadh dhomhain). On the third of an Dàmhair the mended rail carries the first train, loaded with coal cut that week, from the Sloc Mòr's pithead at Achadh dhomhain down to Cathair dhearg on the humans' own iron, a Tuathaich engineer at the footplate.¹⁵
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 12** — *The Mac Ùisdein quarry-mark first cut* (Achadh dhomhain). The grey, black-veined spoil of the Sloc Mòr's deeper galleries is quarried and dressed for building, and sold south under a stylised wave, the mark of the house of Mac Ùisdein, cut into every squared block.
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, SE 13** — *The quarry at Achadh dhombhain* (Achadh dhomhain). The spoil of the Sloc Mòr, a grey stone veined with black, is cut and sold for building under the quarry-mark of the house of Mac Ùisdein. For forty years after it is used in public buildings across the south.¹⁶
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 13** — *The shunting yards at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The Rail Board lays new sidings at Muileann chrom, where the coal trains from the Sloc Mòr are broken up and made up again for the ports. The families of the yard, who work the small engines that move the wagons, are counted apart by the Board and live apart in rows beside the lines.

10. ← Follows from *The night-shift kept*, 18 an t-Samhain, SE 11.

11. ○ Same place *The pit towns fill*, 14 am Màrt, SE 12.

12. ← Follows from *The pit towns fill*, 14 am Màrt, SE 12.

13. ← Follows from *Baile thais grows on the coal road*, 6 an Lùnastal, SE 12.

14. ← Follows from *Raiders off Cathair gheal*, 4 an t-Sultain, SE 12.

15. ○ Same place *The coal line reaches the Sloc Mòr*, 3 an Dàmhair, SE 12.

16. ○ Same place *The Mac Ùisdein quarry-mark first cut*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, SE 12.

- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 13** — *The western branch* (Seann Bhral). The Rail Board carries a branch of the coal line west from Cathair dhearg to the port of Seann Bhral, with a spur north to the pits at Àth leathan, so that the western workings may send their coal east by rail.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 13** — *The guilds restored*. The old custom of binding apprentices, from the Holy Age, is taken up again in a changed form. It is now kept for Dia-thìrich alone.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 13** — *The Guild of Hewers chartered* (Achadh dhomhain). The first guild under the restored custom, the Guild of Hewers, is chartered at Achadh dhomhain. Its oath is sworn with a hand on a piece of coal. By the charter its rolls are open to Dia-thìrich only.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 13** — *The Rail Board's office raised at Cathair dhearg* (Achadh dhomhain). The Rail Board builds its office at Cathair dhearg, low and of the same grey Mac Ùis-dein stone, and the Board's business, surveys among them, is thereafter kept within its walls.¹⁷
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 13** — *Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin's book of the faces* (Achadh dhomhain). Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin, the Mine Board's surveyor at the Sloc Mòr, keeps a running book of the faces he and his chainman measure, entering each true figure against the hewers who are paid by the fathom driven.¹⁸
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 13** — *The shunting yard at Muileann chrom counted apart* (Muileann chrom). New sidings at Muileann chrom, where the Sloc Mòr's coal trains are broken up and made up for the ports, bring rows of housing for the families who work the small engines. The Board keeps their roll separate from the shire's and houses them apart, beside the lines.¹⁹
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 13** — *The spur to Àth leathan opened* (Àth leathan). The Rail Board lays thirteen miles of new rail off the western branch to Àth leathan, where Tuathaich hewers have long worked the coal, judging the ground poor but the coal cheap to lift and the carters' road worse each winter.²⁰
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 13** — *The Guild of Hewers chartered at Achadh dhombhain* (Achadh dhomhain). The restored custom of binding, kept now for Dia-thìrich alone, is set into the Guild of Hewers' charter and read aloud at Achadh dhomhain. Each hewer taken in lays a hand flat on a lump of coal and swears to keep the guild's custom, take no outside work and teach no craft of it to a hand unsworn.²¹

17. ← Follows from *The quarry at Achadh dhombhain*, 25 an Cèitean, SE 13.

18. ← Follows from *The pit towns fill*, 14 an Màrt, SE 12.

19. ○ Same place *The shunting yards at Muileann chrom*, 8 an t-Iuchar, SE 13.

20. ← Follows from *The shunting yards at Muileann chrom*, 8 an t-Iuchar, SE 13.

21. ○ Same place *The Guild of Hewers chartered*, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 13.

- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 13** — *Iain mac Ruairidh stands outside the oath* (Achadh dhomhain). At the guild's chartering Iain watches his own father sworn among the hewers and understands that the charter's rolls, open to those who cut, haul or timber the coal, hold no place for the Board's chainman who only measures where it lies.²²
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 14** — *The shipwrights of Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). The shipwrights of Ros dhomhain take a guild charter of their own and bind their first thirty apprentices in a single day on the slipway.
- 28 AM MÀRT, SE 14** — *The indentures broken* (Cuan shean). At Cuan shean and Seann Bhrál the Tuathaich boys already bound to Dia-thírich masters are loosed from their indentures under the charter rule. Some go north. Most stay on as day-labourers, outside the guilds and their wages.
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, SE 14** — *The chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). The ship-chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh, on the Abhainn fhionn east of the capital, take a guild charter and the sole right to supply the Crown's patrol boats. The right outlasts the boats.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 14** — *The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, who make the coal lamps of every shaft on the island, are chartered as a guild. Their mark, a flame over a hammer, is stamped on every lamp. Of all the guild marks, the humans' traders copied this one only.
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 14** — *Harry Marlow's indenture torn at Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Seumas Crùbach, shipwright of Cuan shean, takes down and tears the four-year indenture binding Harry Marlow to his yard, the guild court's charter rule having reached the coast that spring. He keeps Harry on the bench as a free hand rather than take a new bound apprentice in his place.²³
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 14** — *The Tuathaich day-wage set at the Cuan shean yard* (Cuan shean). Seumas Crùbach keeps Harry Marlow at half a bound man's wage and no guild standing once the indenture is loosed, a rate other yards along the coast take up that spring for the Tuathaich hands they keep on without a guild's leave to teach them.²⁴
- 18 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 14** — *A Tuathaich boy's plea refused at the Ros dhombhain guild court* (Ros dhomhain). A rope-maker's apprentice of four years' standing at Ros dhomhain brings his case to the newly chartered guild court and is heard and refused in a single sitting, the court ruling that the charter's custom of binding names Dia-thírich hands alone.²⁵
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 14** — *The Moot's letter on the indentures filed* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr writes to the guild court at Cathair dhearg asking what is to become of the Tuathaich indentures already standing when the guilds' charters are read. The letter is filed among that year's business without an answer.²⁶

22. ← Follows from *The Guild of Hewers chartered*, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 13.

23. ← Follows from *The indentures broken*, 28 am Màrt, SE 14.

24. ← Follows from *The indentures broken*, 28 am Màrt, SE 14.

25. ← Follows from *The shipwrights of Ros dhombhain*, 29 am Faoilleach, SE 14.

26. ← Follows from *The indentures broken*, 28 am Màrt, SE 14.

- II AN LÙNASTAL, SE 14** — *The lamp-makers' mark first stamped* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, chartered that winter, set their mark, a flame struck over a hammer, on every coal lamp leaving their sheds from that year on, so that the lamp itself carries the record of where it was made and under what oath.²⁷
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 14** — *The chandlers' patrol-boat right first exercised* (Ceann àrsaidh). The newly chartered chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh fit out the Crown's patrol boats under their sole right that spring, and the fitting-out becomes the guild's yearly show of its charter before the shire's maor.²⁸
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 14** — *Harry Marlow measures the old wreck at Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Freed from bound hours by the loosing of his indenture, Harry Marlow spends the year's stolen hours setting down in his own book the full lines of a derelict human hull left on the Cuan shean hard, learning by his own measure how a hull built plank first and framed after is made to hold together.²⁹
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 14** — *A northern passage offered and refused at Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). A cloth trader out of Seann Vell, putting in at Cuan shean that autumn, tells Harry Marlow a free hand might do better in a northern harbour, where no guild court stands over a craftsman's work. Harry thanks him and stays at his bench.³⁰
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 14** — *Harry Marlow sends his wage north at half rate* (Cuan shean). At the year's end Harry Marlow sends north to his father Joseph Marlow's forge at Doire mhin the sum he has set aside from a free hand's half-wage, a smaller sum than any year of his bound apprenticeship, kept from the same habit regardless.³¹
- 6 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 15** — *The weavers of Baile chiar* (Baile chiar). The weavers of Baile chiar are chartered as a guild. Their cloth of southern wool undersells the northern cloth at the fair, until the mills of Doire ghlas are built.
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 15** — *Agnes Pike's school* (Doire ghlas). Agnes Pike, a Tuathaich teacher, opens a school at Doire ghlas that teaches in the humans' tongue, with the Moot's money and without the council's leave. Within ten years there are nine such schools in the north. The council never licenses them and never shuts them.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 15** — *The Cill ghlas district reopened* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas³²). The mining district shut since the Rending is surveyed and declared safe to work. On the surveyors' word the first new shafts are cut well back from the old fault line.

27. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers of Muileann mbin*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 14.

28. ← Follows from *The chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh*, 26 an Giblean, SE 14.

29. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers of Muileann mbin*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 14.

30. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers of Muileann mbin*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 14.

31. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers of Muileann mbin*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 14.

32. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 15** — *The Leòid circuit in the north* (Ceann mhòr). Eilidh nic Leòid rides the northern circuit for the first time and holds court at Ceann mhòr. Of the nineteen cases brought before her, seventeen are Tuathaich suits over land. In fifteen she finds for the Crown, citing her own ruling.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 15** — *Baile chiar's weavers take a guild charter* (Baile chiar). The council's clerks cut a new seal, a shuttle over a fleece, for the weavers of Baile chiar, entering the grant in a book bound in calf at Cathair dhearg after a fee is paid and a feast given. It is a charter of the ordinary kind: coin changes hands, a form is followed, and a craft already practised becomes a craft the kingdom has agreed to notice.³³
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 15** — *The Moot votes its school purse* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr sets aside money of its own for a schoolroom at Doire ghlas, without asking the council's leave a second time, Walter Hale having judged that a council which says no once will say no as often as it is asked.³⁴
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 15** — *A widow lends her byre at Doire ghlas* (Doire ghlas). Jenny Marrow, whose husband's cattle a fever and a wet spring had thinned to a few head, offers her byre for the winter months in exchange for nothing but a promise that she and the children will be taught to write their names.³⁵
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 15** — *Walter Hale carries the school purse north* (Doire ghlas). Walter Hale rides the coast road himself to bring Agnes Pike the Moot's money the evening before her school opens, and leaves with it a sheet in his own hand setting out that the purse is the Moot's, the room the widow's, and the leave nobody's at all.³⁶
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 15** — *Agnes Pike's school opens on the fourteenth of am Faoilleach* (Doire ghlas). Eleven children come through the byre door at Doire ghlas before the Church bell finishes its stroke, to be taught their letters from the Bible and from a lent volume of the Moot's own minutes, there being no primer printed for the humans' tongue on the island.³⁷
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 15** — *The school's register begun* (Doire ghlas). Agnes Pike opens a register for the byre school in its first week, its first leaf recording eleven scholars and that no leave was asked for the room because none was thought likely to be given.³⁸
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 15** — *Daniel Frayne walks in from Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). A fisherman's son of nine walks the coast path each morning from Muileann leathan to sit on Agnes Pike's benches, and back again in time to help haul his father's nets, a condition he keeps every day the school runs that winter.³⁹

33. ○ Same place *The weavers of Baile chiar*, 6 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

34. ← Follows from *The Moot's schoolhouse petition*, 10 an Gearran, SE 7; → Leads to *Agnes Pike's school*, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

35. ← Follows from *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

36. → Leads to *Agnes Pike's school*, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

37. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school*, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

38. ← Follows from *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

39. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school*, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

15 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 15 — *Daniel Frayne's fair copies pinned to the byre wall* (Doire ghlas). Slower at reading than at writing, the boy is set to copy out each day's psalm or minute a second time, and by the spring his fair copies, stroke for stroke exact, are pinned the length of the byre's one dry wall.⁴⁰

16 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 15 — *The maor visits the byre school and writes nothing* (Doire ghlas). The shire's maor, whose office is to note anything newly opened in it, rides out, watches the children recite a psalm, asks Agnes Pike only after the room's heating and the children's fees, and sends south that season a report of harvest, head-due and bridge that says nothing of the school at all.⁴¹

29 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 15 — *Alice Hale opens a second school at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale's daughter Alice opens a school of her own in a disused net-store behind the harbour at Caol mhòr, on a purse thinner than her father carried north, and writes to Agnes Pike asking what has answered best on the byre's cold mornings.⁴²

4 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 15 — *The Cill ghlas fault line walked and found unmoved* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas⁴³). Lachlann mac Iain Bhàin and his chainman Iain mac Ruairidh trace the old Cill ghlas fault foot by foot with plumb and cord and file a report at Cathair mhòr declaring the district safe to work again so long as new shafts are cut a full chain back from it.⁴⁴

14 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 15 — *The school moves to the church porch for summer* (Doire ghlas). With the widow's cattle wanting the byre back for the warm months, Agnes Pike's school moves into the porch of the Doire ghlas church, a change it makes every summer after.⁴⁵

28 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 15 — *Daniel Frayne copies the minute of the school's own founding* (Doire ghlas). On the last morning before the move to the church porch, Agnes Pike sets her best copyist the Moot's own four-line minute recording the school's opening, and pins his fair copy into the register's first leaf rather than to the drying wall.⁴⁶

2 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 15 — *Eilidh nic Leòid opens the Ceann mhòr assize* (Ceann mhòr). In the heat of an t-Iuchar, with the windows of the old magistrate's house propped open against the fish-yard smell, Eilidh nic Leòid tells the crowded room that she will hear all nineteen causes on the list to their own ends, in their own order, whatever the likeness of one paper to the next, and whatever the weather asks of everyone waiting on the bench.⁴⁷

40. ← Follows from *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

41. ⇌ At the same time *Agnes Pike's school*, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

42. ⇌ At the same time *Agnes Pike's school*, 14 am Faoilleach, SE 15.

43. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

44. ← Follows from *The Cill ghlas district reopened*, 19 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

45. ← Follows from *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

46. ← Follows from *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

47. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 15** — *The Dunlop title read to its end* (Ceann mhòr). Eilidh nic Leòid reads a human grant brown at its folds, and a receipt for seed corn the family thought to bring unasked, and finds as she found seven years before at Seann Bhràl: the ground is the Crown's, the working of it the Dunlops', on the same terms as before and no excusal from any due to come.⁴⁸
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 15** — *Fifteen suits found for the Crown at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). Cause after cause of the seventeen brought on human titles is decided in the words of the Leòid ruling, the ground passing to the Crown and the working of it staying with the family that holds it, until the room has learned, before the week is out, to stop guessing at an ending it already knows.⁴⁹
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 15** — *A custodian's countersign found on the Coombe title* (Ceann mhòr). In the margin of a Tuathaich family's human grant, Eilidh nic Leòid finds the pressed mark of an old land-keeping custodian, witness to the transfer in the humans' own time, and rules that a grant allowed also by an office of the island's own older law stands on ground the crossing never touched.⁵⁰
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 15** — *The Coombes and the Pettifers found for the holders* (Ceann mhòr). Two of the seventeen suits at Ceann mhòr, each carrying a custodian's old countersign on its title, are found whole for the families that hold them, the only two of the assize's nineteen causes decided against the Crown that summer.⁵¹
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 15** — *Walter Hale heard as a witness at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). Having no standing to plead, Walter Hale is called instead to the bench as a witness, and shows Eilidh nic Leòid the Moot's own minute of a family's land divided by agreement and set down in writing years before, which the court accepts over the memory of the parties themselves.⁵²
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 15** — *The Moot's minute-books credited by a Crown bench* (Ceann mhòr). Eilidh nic Leòid rules that a record kept by a body the Crown does not recognise is no less a fact for the hand that wrote it holding no seal, the first time the Moot's own paper is taken as evidence before a circuit justice.⁵³
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 15** — *Hale and Eilidh nic Leòid speak at the Ceann mhòr inn* (Ceann mhòr). Over supper Walter Hale asks Eilidh nic Leòid whether an exact law can also be a fair one; she tells him plainly that she made her ruling to be exact rather than kind, and that she knows whose convenience it was written to serve, a thing she has told no maor and no council chest.⁵⁴

48. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15; ← Follows from *The Leòid ruling*, 10 an t-Sultain, SE 8.

49. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

50. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

51. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

52. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15; ← Follows from *The Moot's schoolhouse petition*, 10 an Gearran, SE 7.

53. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 15 — *Eilidh nic Leòid begins the gathered book* (Cathair dhomhain).

Through the winter after the Ceann mhòr sitting, Eilidh nic Leòid sets down in one book the whole of her nine years' rulings on Tuathaich land, from the Seann Bhràl ruling to the seventeen suits, so that a justice after her need not dig the council's own chests to learn what she already knows.

54. ○ Same place *The Leòid circuit in the north*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 15.

THE YEARS SE 16 – 20

- 2 AN GIBLEAN, SE 16** — *Eilidh nic Leòid dies* (Cathair dhomhain). Eilidh nic Leòid dies at Cathair dhomhain. Her rulings are bound in one book, the first law-book of the restored kingdom, and every circuit justice after her carries a copy.¹
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, SE 16** — *Eilidh nic Leòid sends for Uilleam mac Leòid* (Cathair dhomhain). Failing through am Màrt, Eilidh nic Leòid sends word north to her brother's son Uilleam, a young man who has ridden the northern circuit with her twice as a boy, asking him to take up the circuit she can no longer ride.²
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, SE 16** — *Eilidh nic Leòid dies at Cathair dhomhain* (Cathair dhomhain). Eilidh nic Leòid dies in her own house within sound of the harbour, her clerk Murchadh Clàrc beside her and the gathered book of her rulings finished but not yet bound on the table by the bed.³
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 16** — *Leabhar nam Breith⁴ bound* (Cathair dhomhain). The council's own binder binds Eilidh nic Leòid's gathered rulings in plain calf under the name she chose for it herself, Leabhar nam Breith, and every circuit justice after her is given a copy to carry.⁵
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, SE 16** — *Uilleam mac Leòid named to the northern circuit* (Cathair dhomhain). Uilleam mac Leòid is named circuit justice of the north in his aunt's place, and rides for his first assize with Leabhar nam Breith⁶ strapped behind his clerk's saddle, as the satchel of blank record-books was once strapped behind his aunt's.⁷
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, SE 16** — *Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁸ founded* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol). A great library is founded at Muileann chaol. In time it holds the fullest record of the island's past that has come down.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 16** — *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹). Ailean mac Iain, called Ailean Leabhar, is made the first keeper of Leabharlann Muileann chaol. He brings with him the council's minute-books and what is left of the humans' tithe ledgers, takes in the custodians' rolls kept in the town's cellars since the Severance war, and spends his first years having them read.

1. → Caused by *Eilidh nic Leòid begins the gathered book*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, SE 15.

2. → Leads to *Eilidh nic Leòid dies*, 2 an Giblean, SE 16.

3. ○ Same place *Eilidh nic Leòid dies*, 2 an Giblean, SE 16.

4. the book of rulings

5. ← Follows from *Eilidh nic Leòid dies*, 2 an Giblean, SE 16.

6. the book of rulings

7. ← Follows from *Eilidh nic Leòid dies*, 2 an Giblean, SE 16.

8. the Library at Muileann chaol

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 16** — *A chur san Leabharlann* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁰). Within a few years 'a chur san Leabharlann', to put it in the Library, is said of anything settled beyond dispute. Ailean Leabhar is said to have disliked the phrase, for the Library settles nothing, he said, and only keeps.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 16** — *Ailean mac Iain named first keeper of the Library* (Muileann chaol). By the council's own sentence, Ailean mac Iain is named keeper of the record at Muileann chaol, to receive, to order, and to keep whatever is sent to him. The office has no precedent and the warrant no further words, leaving Ailean to learn from the town itself what a keeper of a record might be.¹¹
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 16** — *The custodians' rolls found under Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The town's own custodians lead Ailean Leabhar down a stair to a wet cellar under the old grain-store, where rolls and bound books have stood on planks above standing water since before the Severance, the lowest tier gone soft as bread. He reads three lines by the light thrown down the stair, then sends for lamps and a table.¹²
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 16** — *Coinneach Clàrc taken on at the Library* (Muileann chaol). A wright's orphaned son of Muileann chaol, thirteen that spring and hired out by his mother for whatever a household could spare, attaches himself to Ailean Leabhar's carts on their first afternoon in the town and is set to fetch and carry, and within the year to read a Mission hand that few south of the guard-line can any longer make out.¹³
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 16** — *The council's minute-books sent east to the Library* (Muileann chaol). Four sacks of the council's own minute-books, and behind them the boxed and charred tithe ledgers of the humans' counting-houses that Ailean boxed unread fourteen years before, are carried east from Cathair dhearg to Muileann chaol, the first of the kingdom's scattered papers to be gathered into one keeping.¹⁴
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 16** — *The Library's first reading room opened* (Muileann chaol). Ailean Leabhar opens a dry chamber above the cellar to any who can show a letter from a shire maor vouching for their errand, on the plain reasoning that a Library nobody can reach is no better kept than a cellar nobody can reach. For the better part of a year it stands empty of anyone but his own copyists.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, SE 17** — *The first readers* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁵). The library's first reading room is opened to any who can show a letter from a shire maor. The first reader written in its book is a shipwright of Ros dhomhain, who asks for the humans' plans of their hulls.¹⁶

10. the Library at Muileann chaol

11. ← Follows from *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16.

12. ← Follows from *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16.

13. ← Follows from *A chur san Leabharlann*, 3 an t-Samhain, SE 16.

14. ← Follows from *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16.

15. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 17** — *The bath-house at the hot springs* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹⁷). A new bath-house is built over the hot springs near Muileann ruadh, paid for by the Guild of Hewers for miners sick with the dust. The guild's sick-roll for its first year names four hundred men by name and shift.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 17** — *The keepers of the five lights* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹⁸). The five lighthouses built under the humans are given Dia-thìrich keepers by royal warrant. At Taigh-solais Baile chrom on the Tuathaich coast the keeper is a Dia-thìreach man lodged in a Tuathaich town, and his warrant bids him report what he sees on land as well as at sea.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 17** — *The Muileann chaol town grows* (Muileann chaol). Copyists, binders and paper-makers settle at Muileann chaol about the library. The town is granted a market charter, and its first market day is held in the library's yard.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 17** — *The Library's copyists turn every date to the civil calendar* (Muileann chaol). Ailean Leabhar sets his copyists to turning every date the cellar and the tithe ledgers hold into the civil calendar the humans brought, disliking the old count of the Diosal, which runs backward into the thousands and names every year after the day the humans' kin went over the water.¹⁹
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 17** — *The Age of Ailean parted from the eldest age* (Muileann chaol). Laying the tellings of Clann na Ceiste²⁰ against the king-lists the custodians' rolls preserve, Ailean Leabhar's reckoners find that nearly half of the copyists' eldest age falls within the single life of Ailean Mòr, and by the consent of all seven copyists that life is counted an age of its own, the first change the Library makes to any reckoning it did not itself invent.²¹
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 17** — *"A chur san Leabharlann" first said at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). A council clerk, told that a boundary query will want weeks of reading before it can be honestly answered, says the matter can simply be put in the Library and left settled. Ailean Leabhar corrects him sharply, and the correction, carried home and retold, is what fixes the phrase in the town's mouth rather than loosening it.²²
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 17** — *Cailean mac Eachainn's Line of Aisling found in the margin* (Muileann chaol). Copying a camp roll of Àth ìseal a third time, Coinneach Clàrc notices a second, later hand in its margin: Cailean mac Eachainn's line of descent, the Line of Aisling, set down a great many years before. Ailean Leabhar has it copied fair within the week.²³

16. ← Leads to *The Library's first reading room opened*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, SE 16.

17. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

18. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

19. ← Follows from *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16.

20. the Children of the Question

21. ← Follows from *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16.

22. ← Follows from *A chur san Leabharlann*, 3 an t-Samhain, SE 16.

23. ← Follows from *The Muileann chaol town grows*, 22 an Dàmhair, SE 17.

- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 17** — *Leabhar nan Sloinnidhean*²⁴ opened (Muileann chaol). Ailean Leabhar begins a book for nothing but lines of descent, naming it Leabhar nan Sloinnidhean, the book of lines, and sets Cailean mac Eachainn's Line of Aisling in it directly after the older Line of the Mason, found wedged behind a shifted course of brick in the same cellar.²⁵
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 17** — *Leabhar nan Aithrisean*²⁶ opened (Muileann chaol). Where the Àth iséal roll's margin also keeps tales set down by firelight rather than by day, the Hollow Man, the white stag, a captain's boast of a wolf and a door held alone, Ailean Leabhar opens a second book, Leabhar nan Aithrisean, the book of tellings, and enters the long years of Ailean Mòr and his children beside them without correction.²⁷
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 17** — *A Ros dhombhain shipwright first signs the reading-book* (Ros dhomhain). A shipwright of Ros dhomhain walks the coast road with a maor's letter to ask whether the humans ever set down the true lines of a hull. Ailean Leabhar finds three drawings folded inside an unrelated survey, and the shipwright copies them out over four days, the first name entered in the Library's reading-book.²⁸
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 17** — *The Guild of Hewers' bath-house built at the warm springs* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁹). The Guild of Hewers builds a bath-house of its own funds over the hot springs below Muileann ruadh, for men the pits have made sick with the dust, and sends the Library its first sick-roll unasked: four hundred men named by shift and by face of the pit that broke them.³⁰
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 17** — *The five lighthouses given Dia-thìreach keepers* (Muileann chaol). By royal warrant the five lighthouses built under the humans are given keepers of the kingdom's own naming. Ailean Leabhar drafts all five, the four southern warrants alike and the fifth, for Baile chrom on the Tuathaich coast, bidding its keeper report what he sees by land as well as by sea.³¹
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 17** — *The keeper's light lit at Baile chrom* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom³²). A Dia-thìreach keeper who asked for the northern posting himself takes up the light at Baile chrom, among a Tuathaich town that has never before had a Dia-thìreach man set to live and watch among it. The southern four lights draw no comment; the fifth draws only silence that first season.³³

24. the book of lines

25. ← Follows from *The Muileann chaol town grows*, 22 an Dàmhair, SE 17.

26. the book of tellings

27. ← Follows from *The Muileann chaol town grows*, 22 an Dàmhair, SE 17.

28. ← Follows from *The first readers*, 30 an Cèitean, SE 17.

29. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

30. ← Follows from *The bath-house at the hot springs*, 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 17.

31. ← Follows from *The keepers of the five lights*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 17.

32. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

33. ← Follows from *The keepers of the five lights*, 25 an Lùnastal, SE 17.

12 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 17 — *Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill sent to inspect the Library at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The council sends its under-clerk Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, four-and-forty, to see and report on the record Ailean Leabhar has kept these four years at Muileann chaol, the errand falling to her only for want of causes on her own desk that month.³⁴

19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 17 — *Muileann chaol granted a market charter* (Muileann chaol). The district's maor writes up, at the keeper's own asking, that a town which has drawn copyists, binders and paper-makers to it in four years without leave might as well be given a charter before its own trade sets its rules instead. The council grants it in the usual form, a fee for every stall and a court to hear the fair's disputes.³⁵

25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 17 — *The first market day held in the Library's yard* (Muileann chaol). Thirty stalls of thread, nails, candles and the district's own produce are set up on trestles against the Library's wall, the stall-fee a penny a table paid into a box the keeper's boy carries, and the fair's own court amounting to the boy's mother settling disputes over table-space in a voice heard the length of the yard.³⁶

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 17 — *The Tobar dhìreach mill's first delivery reaches the Library* (Tobar dhìreach). Forty quires of the new paper-mill's paper are carried up the road on a borrowed cart, better and cheaper, by the copyists' own judgement, than anything the council's stationers at Cathair dhearg have sent north; within the year near enough every sheet the Library uses comes from the one stream.

23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 18 — *The paper-mill at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A paper-mill is built at Tobar dhìreach, a few miles from the library, on the stream below the village. For half a century nearly every page of the royal chronicle is written on its paper.³⁷

20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 18 — *The first royal chronicler appointed* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁸). An office is made to keep the records of the kingdom. From it comes the archive whence these annals are drawn.

20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 18 — *The years counted by the ages* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁹). With the office of chronicler the council orders that the kingdom's records shall count their years no longer by the Diosal but by the ages of the library's table, each age from its own first event: six ages as the table then stands, and seven since the Dubhan Era. The chronicler's first year is entered as the eighteenth of the Severance Era. Thereafter the count of the Diosal is kept only in old books.

34. ← Follows from *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16.

35. → Leads to *The Muileann chaol town grows*, 22 an Dàmhair, SE 17.

36. ← Follows from *The Muileann chaol town grows*, 22 an Dàmhair, SE 17.

37. ← Leads to *The Tobar dhìreach mill's first delivery reaches the Library*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, SE 17.

38. the Library at Muileann chaol

39. the Library at Muileann chaol

19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 18 — *Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴⁰).

The first royal chronicler is Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, a clerk of the council. She keeps her record at Muileann chaol and not at the capital, and writes in her first entry that a record kept beside the throne is kept for the throne.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 18 — *The office of royal chronicler set at Muileann chaol, not the capital* (Muileann chaol). Sworn into the new office at Cathair dhearg and given no instruction as to its seat, Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill writes back within the week that she means to keep the record at Muileann chaol, beside the Library that already holds the rolls and the copyists the work wants, and that a record kept beside the throne is kept for the throne.⁴¹

25 AM MÀRT, SE 19 — *The first chronicle circuit* (Àth àrsaidh). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill sends clerks to every shire to copy parish books, grave-lists and harbour rolls. The returns from the south fill forty chests. The returns from Siorrachd Àth àrsaidh and the other northern shires fill one, for few Tuathaich will speak to the clerks.

2 AN GIBLEAN, SE 19 — *The town arms copied* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴²). The clerks of the first chronicle circuit copy the seal of every town they visit into the roll of arms, and the roll comes to hold the arms of five hundred and five places. In the north most are copied from the humans' old town seals, for few Tuathaich will show the clerks their own.

II AN CÈITEAN, SE 19 — *The chest from Inis bheag* (Inis bheag). At Inis bheag in the north-east the chronicle clerks are shown a parish book that goes back before the coming of the humans, kept in the Seann Spioradan house there. The keeper lets it be copied, and not taken.

28 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 19 — *Boats lost off Cuan bheag* (Cuan bheag). A storm out of the west drowns eleven Tuathaich fishermen off Cuan bheag in the north. The village has no lifeboat. The Moot buys one by subscription and asks the council to pay half; the council pays a third.

13 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 19 — *Tormod mac Sheumais joins the first chronicle circuit* (Muileann chaol). A council under-clerk's son of three-and-thirty, called already Tormod Pinn for the speed of his hand, asks Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill for a place on the first circuit rather than wait to be sent, and rides the northern half of it.⁴³

20 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 19 — *The town arms of five hundred and five burghs copied into one book* (Muileann chaol). The chronicle circuit's southern chests yield the town arms of every burgh that has ever cut a seal, five hundred and five of them, entered by Coinneach Clàrc in the order the chests happen to arrive rather than by rank, on Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill's own ruling that a tidied record forgets how untidy its own arrival was.⁴⁴

40. the Library at Muileann chaol

41. ← Follows from *Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, SE 18; ○ Same place *The first royal chronicler appointed*, 20 an t-Samhain, SE 18.

42. the Library at Muileann chaol

43. ◇ Same person *The first chronicle circuit*, 25 am Màrt, SE 19.

44. ← Follows from *The first chronicle circuit*, 25 am Màrt, SE 19.

27 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 19 — *The chronicle clerks turned away at Doire ghlas* (Doire ghlas).

Tormod mac Sheumais reads the circuit's own warrant twice aloud in the street at the harbour agent's demand before he is let copy a single ledger; eleven of the town's twelve doors stay closed against him, an answer he judges memory rather than unkindness.⁴⁵

II AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 19 — *The Inis bheag keeper lets his parish book be copied and not carried* (Inis bheag). The old keeper of the Seann Spioradan house at Inis bheag hears the circuit's warrant once, without asking it twice, and lets his parish roll be copied at his own table under his own eye, but will not let the book itself travel so much as to the harbour, telling the clerk that a book kept that many generations belongs to the house and not to any seal.⁴⁶

18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 19 — *The northern chest opened: the maor's returns and nothing more* (Muileann chaol). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill opens the one chest the northern shires have filled and finds only the maor of Siorrachd Àth àrsaidh's own tallies and licences, not a line in it written by a Tuathaich hand; she enters the fact plainly and adds no further word to it.

⁴⁷

25 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 19 — *Thomas Coyle drowned off Cuan bheag* (Cuan bheag). A westerly storm on the second night of an t-Sultain drowns eleven Tuathaich fishermen out of Cuan bheag, Thomas Coyle of Caol mhòr among them, one-and-forty and near twenty years married to Mary Coyle. The sea gives back two broken hulls and a stranger's oar; the town buries what it can within the week.⁴⁸

26 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 19 — *Mary Coyle's roll of the eleven dead* (Cuan bheag). Mary Coyle, newly widowed, writes the eleven drowned men's names out on a single sheet for the mason's stones, setting them in the order the boats went out rather than the order the sea gave the bodies back, holding that order the truer one.⁴⁹

17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 19 — *The Moot opens its lifeboat subscription* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale carries the wreck's news to the Moot's own council at Caol mhòr, which votes that same evening to open a subscription for a lifeboat at Cuan bheag; Hale opens the list himself, and it carries near two hundred names by the month's end. The council, asked to bear half the cost, answers four months on that it will bear a third.⁵⁰

18 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 19 — *The tale of the Sea-Watcher told to the chronicler* (Achadh àrsaidh). A fisherman out of Achadh àrsaidh, at the summer bothies below the cold cape, tells the royal chronicler Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill the coast's own tale of a shape seen off the cold cape, seen always at a distance and never named by those who fear it, which she enters in the book that keeps what people said rather than the book that keeps names.

45. ← Follows from *The first chronicle circuit*, 25 am Màrt, SE 19.

46. ← Follows from *The chest from Inis bheag*, 11 an Cèitean, SE 19.

47. ← Follows from *The first chronicle circuit*, 25 am Màrt, SE 19.

48. ← Follows from *Boats lost off Cuan bheag*, 28 an t-Sultain, SE 19.

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 19** — *The raiders' anchorage noted at the cold cape* (Uilebheist na Mara⁵¹). The same fisherman tells Gormshuil that the flagless ships working those waters know the cold cape's currents better than any stranger crew should, and keep some hidden anchorage among its rocks; she writes it apart from the tale and asks that the council's coastal watch be told of it.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 19** — *The flocks of Eilean dhubh counted by their own hands* (Eilean dhubh). A treasury clerk sent to number the flocks of Eilean dhubh for the head-due finds the islanders unwilling to have him count their own pastures, and takes instead their sworn count by tally-stick, on which the island's dues are set that year and every year after.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, SE 20** — *The thing off the north-west cape* (Uilebheist na Mara⁵²). Fishermen out of Achadh àrsaidh tell of a creature longer than their boats in the waters off the north-west cape. Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill writes down the tale, and adds that the raiders shelter in those same waters.⁵³
- 10 AM MÀRT, SE 20** — *The Eilean dhubh sheep-count* (Eilean dhubh). A royal clerk is sent to count the flocks of Eilean dhubh, greatest of the outer isles, to set the island's dues. The islanders count them for him, and the dues are set on their count.⁵⁴
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, SE 20** — *Cathair gheal arms its boats* (Cathair gheal). The Tuathaich fishermen of Cathair gheal arm their own boats and drive the raiders from the bay. Twice they had asked the council for help, and none was sent. Afterwards the council fines the town for bearing arms without licence, and the fine is paid.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 20** — *The market cross at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A market cross is raised at Cathair mhòr at the cost of the house of Mac Ùisdein, with the house's name cut on all four faces. The town's wool and coal markets are moved to its foot.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 20** — *The Cuan bheag lifeboat launched* (Cuan bheag). The lifeboat ordered of the Cuan shean yard comes up the coast in an Cèitean and is set afloat off Cuan bheag's jetty by the hands of that autumn's five widows, no priest of either faith having an agreed form to bless a boat neither had built.⁵⁵
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 20** — *Nell Barrow's first letter for Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). Nell Barrow, a skipper's widow of Cathair gheal who has lost a nephew to the raiders, writes the town's case to the council in am Faoilleach, asking a boat armed at the council's expense or leave to arm the town's own; the maor warns her plain words are as likely filed as answered. No answer comes.⁵⁶

49. ← Follows from *Boats lost off Cuan bheag*, 28 an t-Sultain, SE 19.

50. ← Follows from *Boats lost off Cuan bheag*, 28 an t-Sultain, SE 19.

51. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

52. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

53. ← Leads to *The tale of the Sea-Watcher told to the chronicler*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, SE 19; ← Leads to *The raiders' anchorage noted at the cold cape*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, SE 19.

54. ← Leads to *The flocks of Eilean dhubh counted by their own hands*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, SE 19.

55. ← Follows from *Boats lost off Cuan bheag*, 28 an t-Sultain, SE 19.

56. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 20** — *Nell Barrow's second letter for Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). Two months unanswered, Nell Barrow writes a second letter in am Màrt, shorter and plainer than the first, ending that the town does not think a third asking will find the council less occupied than the first two were. It too goes unanswered.⁵⁷
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 20** — *The black ship run aground in Cathair gheal's bay* (Cathair gheal). On the night of 8 an Giblean three flagless hulls stand into Cathair gheal's bay; the largest raider ship runs her keel onto a shifted bar and is boarded and burned by seven town boats before dawn, the two lesser hulls standing off rather than come to her aid.⁵⁸
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 20** — *Two dead and four hurt in the bay's clearing* (Cathair gheal). The fight for Cathair gheal's bay costs the town two men dead and four hurt, one of whom keeps no further use of a hand; Nell Barrow herself takes a burn from a fallen lantern that scars her the rest of her life, and by first light tells the town the bay is clear.⁵⁹
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 20** — *Cathair gheal fined for bearing arms unlicensed* (Cathair gheal). The council's ruling on the night's fight names no boat sent and no licence granted, only that Cathair gheal bore arms without leave first asked, and fines the town forty pounds in the realm-coin, to be paid at the maor's own office before the year's dues fall due.⁶⁰
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 20** — *Walter Hale carries the Moot's purse north to Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). Hearing the town lacks two-thirds of its fine, Walter Hale carries the difference north from the Moot's own purse, the same purse the Cuan bheag lifeboat has already thinned, and reaches Cathair gheal near the end of an t-Iuchar.⁶¹
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 20** — *The fine paid at the maor's door* (Cathair gheal). Nell Barrow's sum and Hale's together clear the fine in full at the maor's own door, counted coin by coin before his clerk, who enters the sum received and asks nothing of the six years, the two letters, or the boat the town was never sent.⁶²

57. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

58. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

59. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

60. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

61. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

62. ← Follows from *Cathair gheal arms its boats*, 8 an Giblean, SE 20.

THE YEARS SE 21 – 25

- 7 AN CÈITEAN, SE 21** — *The house of the Stone at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The house of Òrd na Cloiche¹ at Caol leathan, greatest of the order, is rebuilt with a tower, and a bell rings the hours from it. The town sets its market and its courts by the bell.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 21** — *Fèill Muileann òg² first held* (Fèill Muileann òg). A fair is held each year at Muileann òg, and it becomes the greatest gathering on the island. Trade comes to it from every province the state holds.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 21** — *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules* (Fèill Muileann òg³). Oighrig nic Mhathain, first toll-mistress of the fair at Muileann òg, sets its rules: a stall-fee in coin, a court of the fair for disputes, and Tuathaich goods to be sold only through Dia-thirich factors. The rules are read aloud at the opening of every fair to this day.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 21** — *The fair's road* (Dùn chrom). The road from Cathair dhearg to Muileann òg is widened and metalled for the carts of the fair. It passes Dùn chrom, which takes a toll at its gate and grows on it. As far as Muileann ghlas it runs on the old coal road; the new stretches are called Rathad na Fèille.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 21** — *The Stone's house at Caol leathan rebuilt* (Caol leathan). The order of the Stone rebuilds its house at Caol leathan at its own cost, raising a bell tower over the western gable; the town sets its market and its two courts by the bell from that year on.⁴
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 21** — *Oighrig nic Mhathain named toll-mistress* (Dùn chrom). Oighrig nic Mhathain, nine years the market clerk of Dùn chrom and one-and-thirty that year, is asked by the council's eastern factor to keep the new fair to be held at the ford by Muileann òg, and takes the post, leaving her own scales to a niece she has trained two summers at her elbow.⁵
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *The fair-field marked out at Muileann òg* (Fèill Muileann òg⁶). Oighrig nic Mhathain walks the ground at Muileann òg with a length of cord and a stick through the summer, marking the stalls, the beast-pens and the corner where a court might sit, before any building has been raised there.⁷
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *The court of the fair roofed* (Fèill Muileann òg⁸). Carpenters of Dùn chrom finish a plain roofed frame, open on three sides, at the field's corner nearest the ford, a fortnight before the fair is to open; it is the only building the state gives the fair in its first year.⁹

1. the order of the Stone

2. the fair at Muileann òg

3. the fair at Muileann òg

4. ← Follows from *The house of the Stone at Caol leathan*, 7 an Cèitean, SE 21.

5. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules*, 14 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

6. the fair at Muileann òg

7. ← Follows from *Fèill Muileann òg first held*, 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21.

8. the fair at Muileann òg

9. ← Follows from *Fèill Muileann òg first held*, 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21.

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *Oighrig writes the fair's three rules* (Fèill Muileann òg¹⁰). Over three evenings by rush-light Oighrig nic Mhathain writes the fair's rules in her own plain hand: a stall-fee in coin, a court of the fair to sit each day of the gathering, and Tuathaich goods to be sold only through licensed Dia-thìreach factors, on the council's own instruction.¹¹
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *The first factors licensed for northern goods* (Fèill Muileann òg¹²). The council licenses four merchant houses of the eastern shires to stand factors' stalls at Muileann òg and sell Tuathaich goods under their own names for a share of the price; Oighrig nic Mhathain enters their names under a heading of her own, Bàillidhean na Fèille¹³.¹⁴
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *The court of the fair's first sitting* (Fèill Muileann òg¹⁵). On the fair's opening morning, 16 an Dàmhair, Oighrig nic Mhathain's court hears its first case, a dispute over a barrel of salt fish, and settles it within the hour by weighing the barrel herself; she writes it into her book as setting the pattern for every case after it.¹⁶
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *The spoil-stone case judged by a smith's eye* (Fèill Muileann òg¹⁷). A Cathair mhòr coal-carter brings a Sloc Mòr merchant's load of spoil-stone dressed to pass for coal-iron before the court of the fair; Oighrig nic Mhathain, having no forge of her own, sends the load to Muileann òg's one smith and fines the merchant by his judgment.¹⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 21** — *David Hale's wool turned away at the gate* (Fèill Muileann òg¹⁹). David Hale of Caol mhòr brings four sacks of his father's wool to the fair's ninth day, the first cart from the Moot's own provinces to try it; Oighrig nic Mhathain reads him her own third clause and turns him to a factor's stall, where his wool sells for some fifth part less than a northern market would have given.²⁰
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 22** — *Dùn chrom's gate-toll* (Dùn chrom). The toll taken at Dùn chrom's gate on the fair road pays for a new wall on the town's southern side. The townsfolk call it the fair's wall. The carters of the fair call it something else.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 22** — *Niall dies; Brìghde crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Niall dies, and his daughter Brìghde follows him without contest: a mortal heir passing to a mortal heir among a nobility some of whom never age. It was thought no wonder then. It was thought one later.

10. the fair at Muileann òg

11. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules*, 14 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

12. the fair at Muileann òg

13. the factors of the fair

14. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules*, 14 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

15. the fair at Muileann òg

16. ← Follows from *Fèill Muileann òg first held*, 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21.

17. the fair at Muileann òg

18. ← Follows from *Fèill Muileann òg first held*, 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21.

19. the fair at Muileann òg

20. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules*, 14 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 22** — *The chronicler's use of the saying* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²¹). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill writes that the succession came 'mar a thàinig Niall'; it is the first time the saying is found in the royal record. In all her years as chronicler she lets no other idiom into the chronicle.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 22** — *The ancestors' hall at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). The Seann Spioradan houses of the east coast build a common hall at Seann Dunn, where each year the living heads of forty families name their ancestors aloud. The next year the list is copied to the library, and it grows by a few names every year after.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 22** — *The fair's road metalled past Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). In am Faoilleach the last stretch of the road from Cathair dhearg to Muileann òg is metalled for the fair's carts; the carters already call it Rathad na Fèille before the state gives it a name of its own.²²
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 22** — *Dùn chrom's gate-toll raises the fair's wall* (Dùn chrom). The toll taken at Dùn chrom's gate on the fair's road pays, that same winter, for a new wall along the town's southern side, finished by an Cèitean; the townsfolk call it the fair's wall, and the carters call the gate by another name.²³
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 22** — *The Moot's letter against the factor rule filed* (Cathair dhearg). Walter Hale writes to the council on the Moot's behalf naming the factor rule a licence laid across a trade the north carried on unaided, and asks it looked at again; the council answers, months on, that the rule stands and will not be reconsidered inside the year, and the letter is filed with the Moot's earlier ones.²⁴
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 22** — *The fair's rules confirmed and read aloud* (Fèill Muileann òg²⁵). In an Lùnastal a council clerk reads Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules aloud before the gathered factors and maoir of the eastern shires, word for word as she wrote them, and asks whether the reading matches her own book; she tells him it does.²⁶
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 22** — *The bells rung for Niall* (Cathair dhearg). The bells of Òrd Mhacha²⁷ at Cathair dhearg are rung a full day and a night for Niall's death, and the capital keeps no market. The crowd that gathers is the largest since his crowning; it stays quiet, and disperses before the second night.²⁸
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *The council's oath sworn afresh* (Cathair dhearg). The council of twelve, sitting on its fixed day within the week of the crowning, swears its oath of service afresh before Brìghde. The minute-book gives it one line among the day's ordinary business and no more.²⁹

21. the Library at Muileann chaol

22. ← Follows from *The fair's road*, 26 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

23. ← Follows from *Dùn chrom's gate-toll*, 2 an Lùnastal, SE 22.

24. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules*, 14 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

25. the fair at Muileann òg

26. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules*, 14 an t-Samhain, SE 21.

27. the order of Macha

28. ← Follows from *Niall dies; Brìghde crowned*, 31 an Lùnastal, SE 22.

- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *The corrected proclamation at Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). A harbour clerk at Ros dhomhain, copying the crowning's proclamation for the gate, writes Niall's name from habit, scores it through, and sets Brighde's above the line. The corrected copy is kept under glass at the gate.³⁰
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *Gormshuil's struck drafts* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³¹). The chronicler writes and rejects three entries for the crowning before any stands: one too bare, one that says more than an office should say first, one left unfinished as an argument rather than a record. All three are struck through in her working book.³²
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *Gormshuil's resolve on the one idiom* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³³). Having let *mar a thàinig Niall* into the royal record, the chronicler resolves to admit no other such phrase for as long as the office is hers, having seen other offices lose their plainness one borrowed ornament at a time.³⁴
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *The hall raised at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Forty households of the Seann Spioradan along the east coast raise a common hall at Seann Dunn in a single season, working the stone by day, and roof it before the first frost. It holds no image or carving, only two hearths.³⁵
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *Gormshuil's visit to the first naming* (Seann Dunn). The chronicler rides east to Seann Dunn to watch the hall's first naming of ancestors, not on the Library's business but her own, her mother's house keeping the same rite at a hearth too small for half its dead.³⁶
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *The Library's offer to Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Asked by an elder of the hall whether the Library keeps such lists of the dead, Gormshuil answers that it does not, but will keep any copy sent to it as carefully as anything else that reaches Muileann chaol.³⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 22** — *The vote for a light at Cuan ruadh* (Cuan ruadh). After two boats are lost on the harbour rocks in a winter fog, the town council of Cuan ruadh votes its own coal money to burn a light on the mole where no Board light has ever reached.
- 25 AN GEARRAN, SE 23** — *Cuan ruadh's harbour light* (Cuan ruadh). Cuan ruadh on the east coast, which has none of the five lighthouses, raises a harbour light of its own on the mole and burns in it coal bought by the town. The Lighthouse Board will not take it on.³⁸

29. ← Follows from *Niall dies; Brighde crowned*, 31 an Lùnastal, SE 22.

30. ← Follows from *Niall dies; Brighde crowned*, 31 an Lùnastal, SE 22.

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. ← Follows from *The chronicler's use of the saying*, 29 an t-Sultain, SE 22.

33. the Library at Muileann chaol

34. ← Follows from *The chronicler's use of the saying*, 29 an t-Sultain, SE 22.

35. ← Follows from *The ancestors' hall at Seann Dunn*, 28 an Dàmhair, SE 22.

36. ← Follows from *The ancestors' hall at Seann Dunn*, 28 an Dàmhair, SE 22.

37. ← Follows from *The ancestors' hall at Seann Dunn*, 28 an Dàmhair, SE 22.

- 4 AM MÀRT, SE 23** — *Còmhrag Ceann leathan*³⁹ *first fought* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan). A fierce melee is first fought at Ceann leathan, and is fought there every year after. It is held to be a martial custom. More and more it is where a people with few other outlets spend their anger.
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 23** — *Calum Ruadh* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁴⁰). The first champion of the Còmhrag whose name is remembered is Calum mac Aonghais, called Calum Ruadh, a hewer of Muileann chrom. Two men die in the melee he wins. The prize is a year's wages and the right to bear arms in any shire.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 23** — *Ceann leathan's inns* (Ceann leathan). Ceann leathan builds four new inns for the crowds of the Còmhrag. The fair-wardens of the town, who take a share of every room, become the Còmhrag's keepers in all but name.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 23** — *The Seann Dunn list first copied to the Library* (Seann Dunn). The hall at Seann Dunn sends the Library the first copy of its naming, and goes on sending one every year after, each a little longer than the last. Gormshuil enters only the day it came and the count of names.⁴¹
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 23** — *The Lighthouse Board's refusal* (Cuan ruadh). The Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁴² writes back to Cuan ruadh that its charter names five lights and no more, and that the town's own light, being no charge on the Crown, may continue as it is. Gormshuil enters the refusal in four lines.⁴³
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 23** — *The rules of the first Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁴⁴). The first Còmhrag at Ceann leathan is fought under rules that run to little more than a fee, a bar on edged weapons, and a purse for the last man standing inside the ropes. Nobody thinks the custom will need more than that.⁴⁵
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 23** — *The dead of the first Còmhrag buried* (Ceann leathan). Two men who do not walk out of the ropes at the first Còmhrag are buried at Ceann leathan within the week. The melee is fought again the following summer regardless, and the record gives their deaths one plain sentence.⁴⁶

38. ← Leads to *The vote for a light at Cuan ruadh*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, SE 22.

39. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

40. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

41. ← Follows from *The ancestors' hall at Seann Dunn*, 28 an Dàmhair, SE 22.

42. the Lighthouse Board

43. ← Follows from *Cuan ruadh's harbour light*, 25 an Gearran, SE 23.

44. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

45. ← Follows from *Còmhrag Ceann leathan first fought*, 4 am Màrt, SE 23.

46. ← Follows from *Còmhrag Ceann leathan first fought*, 4 am Màrt, SE 23; ← Follows from *Calum Ruadh*, 22 an Lùnastal, SE 23.

- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 23** — *Calum Ruadh's purse counted out* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁴⁷). A year's wages are counted out on a trestle table by the fair-wardens' own clerk for Calum mac Aonghais, hewer of Muileann chrom, who wins the first Còmhrag by refusing to stay down.⁴⁸
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 23** — *The right to bear arms entered on the shire's roll* (Ceann leathan). Calum Ruadh's right to bear arms in any shire of the kingdom, the Còmhrag's second prize, is entered that same evening on the shire's roll at Ceann leathan, a right his own father never held.⁴⁹
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 23** — *The fair-wardens' free table* (Ceann leathan). The inn-keepers of Ceann leathan, four of whom built new houses that year for the Còmhrag's crowds, keep Calum Ruadh's table free of charge, a custom nobody formally agrees to but that holds for as long as he comes back to fight.⁵⁰
- 10 AM MÀRT, SE 24** — *The grain-ships of Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Ros gheal on the north-central coast builds a dock for the grain-ships of the Hawk country. The Hawk houses bless the dock and ask a tithe of its dues. The shire gives them a twentieth.
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, SE 24** — *Mary Coyle first speaks in the Moot* (Caol mhòr). Mary Coyle, widowed of the Cuan bheag drowning, stands and speaks her own words in the Moot at Caol mhòr rather than sending a note forward to be read by another. The clerk David Hale sets her speech down whole in the day-book, the first time a woman's words are kept there entire rather than summed in a line.⁵¹
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 24** — *Splatter and Dodge's generation born*. Many children are born in these years to the shunting families of the yard. From them come Seachran and Brean and others of that generation, who grow up to be Dubhan's closest allies.
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 24** — *Seann Bhral in the south* (Seann Bhral). Seann Bhral on the south coast, not the town of that name in the west, becomes the greatest fishing port of the kingdom and lands more fish than Ros dhomhain. Its curing-sheds run the length of the harbour.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 24** — *The widows heard first* (Caol mhòr). The Moot resolves that the widows of the drowned be heard on the same footing as any man who has paid his shilling, and heard first when a matter touches their own dead. The rule is entered as standing, not as a courtesy for one night, on the widow Agnes Tulloch's motion.⁵²

47. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

48. ← Follows from *Calum Ruadh*, 22 an Lùnastal, SE 23.

49. ← Follows from *Calum Ruadh*, 22 an Lùnastal, SE 23.

50. ← Follows from *Ceann leathan's inns*, 30 an Lùnastal, SE 23.

51. ← Follows from *The grain-ships of Ros gheal*, 10 am Màrt, SE 24.

52. ← Follows from *The grain-ships of Ros gheal*, 10 am Màrt, SE 24.

- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 24** — *The Hawk's twentieth first paid* (Ros gheal). Ros gheal's factor pays the Hawk houses their first quarter's twentieth on the dues of the new grain dock, the sum the shire's factor haggled down from a tithe. The due is paid every quarter after, and the clerks of Ros gheal come to call it simply the Hawk's, few remembering why.⁵³
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 25** — *The circus at Seann Chwen* (An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn⁵⁴). The travelling show that calls itself An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn is first recorded, pitched near Seann Chwen on the southern coast. The chronicler's clerk could not say what its acts were meant to show. Nor, he adds, could the crowd, and it came back the next night.
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 25** — *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhrál* (Seann Bhrál). The house of Òrd Mhanannain⁵⁵ at Seann Bhrál, one of the oldest on the west coast, will not admit the Tuathaich from the north who come to its feast of the sea, as their forebears learned to do from the Dia-thìrich harbours. Its keeper says the sea is the same and the house is not.
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 25** — *The Moot votes to send the western crossing* (Caol mhòr). After two hard sittings the Moot agrees to Mary Coyle's asking, that northern boats sail west-about to keep the sea-feast at Seann Bhrál where the Tuathaich forebears once kept it. Many in the room call it a fool's errand for winter, and are not silenced, only outvoted.⁵⁶
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 25** — *Eleven boats sail for Seann Bhrál* (Caol mhòr). Eleven boats out of Caol mhòr, Cuan bheag and Achadh àrsaidh put out on a frozen morning under Mary Coyle, carrying little but themselves, a keg of salt fish apiece, and the Moot's own sheet naming her their word. Ros bheag's harbour will not give them its quay, and sends them to a mooring buoy instead.⁵⁷
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 25** — *A boat nearly lost off the passage*. A squall out of the south-west puts green water over the bow of the smallest boat of the eleven, and its crew bails her clear with whatever will hold water. No one of the fleet is lost on the four days' passage, though more than one aboard call it the hardest going since the Crossing itself.⁵⁸
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 25** — *The house at Seann Bhrál answers Mary Coyle* (Seann Bhrál). The keeper of Manannan's order at Seann Bhrál in the west hears Mary Coyle's asking through to the end and refuses it: the house is kept on tithes of families who hold the rite by blood and the custodian's book, and cannot be opened on a four days' claim, however justly sailed. He tells her the sea is the same; the house is not.⁵⁹

53. ← Follows from *The grain-ships of Ros gheal*, 10 am Màrt, SE 24.

54. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

55. the order of Manannan

56. ← Follows from *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhrál*, 2 an t-Sultain, SE 25.

57. ← Follows from *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhrál*, 2 an t-Sultain, SE 25.

58. ← Follows from *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhrál*, 2 an t-Sultain, SE 25.

59. ← Follows from *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhrál*, 2 an t-Sultain, SE 25.

20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 25 — *Mary Coyle resolves to keep the feast at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). On the passage home Mary Coyle tells the crews the north will keep the feast of the sea itself, in full, at the church above Cnoc ghorm where a thin blessing of the boats is already kept each spring. The decision is made before the eleven boats raise Caol mhòr again.⁶⁰

60. ← Follows from *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhrál*, 2 an t-Sultain, SE 25.

THE YEARS SE 26 – 30

- 11 AN GEARRAN, SE 26** — *The northern sea-feast* (Cnoc ghorm). Turned away at Seann Bhral, the Tuathaich keep the feast at the church at Cnoc ghorm instead, as a blessing of the boats. They keep it there every year after, and within a generation the northern feast is greater than the western.¹
- 15 AN GEARRAN, SE 26** — *The first Fleadh na Mara*² kept in full (Cnoc ghorm). More than fifty boats gather at Cnoc ghorm on the second Sunday of an Gearran, far beyond any year before, and the parish priest blesses each hull in turn with heather dipped in harbour water. Mary Coyle's own boat, which carried her to Seann Bhral and back, is blessed fourth in the row.³
- 10 AM MÀRT, SE 26** — *David Hale counts the boats at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). David Hale keeps a written count of the boats blessed at Cnoc ghorm for the Moot's day-book, the first such count taken of the feast. Word of the gathering's size travels the north coast faster than the crossing to Seann Bhral had, and boats are promised from as far as Inis mhin's country the year after.⁴
- 12 AM MÀRT, SE 26** — *The Depletion first noted*. The survey reports begin to note, without remark, that the vein yields less. For years the state does nothing.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, SE 26** — *Iain Mapa's survey* (Achadh dhomhain). The survey behind the report is the work of Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, of the Mine Board. His measures of the faces of the Sloc Mòr show the vein thinning to east and south. The Board files the survey and shows it to no one, and Iain Mapa is sent to the silver works at Muileann chiar.
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 26** — *Iain Mapa true up the eastern faces* (Achadh dhomhain). Sent into the eastern galleries of the Sloc Mòr to settle a dispute between two overseers over a cutting's bounds, the chainman Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, checks an old survey against the new digging and finds the figures will not lie flat. He walks the faces a second time before he trusts what they tell him.⁵
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 26** — *The vein found thinning east and south* (Achadh dhomhain). A third survey of the faces gives Iain Mapa the same figures as the first two, to within an inch the chain itself can account for: the vein runs narrower to the east than the old maps show, and pinches again to the south. He sets it down in a hand that does not shake, and does not argue.⁶

1. ← Leads to *Mary Coyle resolves to keep the feast at Cnoc ghorm*, 20 an t-Samhain, SE 25.

2. the northern feast of the sea at Cnoc ghorm

3. ← Follows from *The northern sea-feast*, 11 an Gearran, SE 26.

4. ← Follows from *The northern sea-feast*, 11 an Gearran, SE 26.

5. ← Follows from *The Depletion first noted*, 12 am Màrt, SE 26.

6. ← Follows from *The Depletion first noted*, 12 am Màrt, SE 26.

- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 26** — *Iain Mapa walks the survey to Cathair dhearg* (Achadh dhomhain). Rather than trust the carters with a finding he believes the Board should see in his own hand, Iain Mapa rolls and ties his survey and walks the thirty-one miles from the Sloc Mòr to Cathair dhearg in a day and a half, sleeping one night on the road, and tells no one at the mine beforehand what the sheet holds.⁷
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 26** — *The Board leaves the survey unrolled* (Cathair mhòr). Iain Mapa lays his survey before three men of the Mine Board at Cathair dhearg and unties the string himself. None of the three unrolls it. He gives them the finding by mouth, plainly, and is told only, by the one in the middle, that it will be considered.⁸
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 26** — *Ruairidh mac Ailein signs the receipt* (Cathair mhòr). Asked for a receipt for the survey he has carried in, Iain Mapa is given four written lines naming nothing of the finding, only that a survey was received and filed. Ruairidh mac Ailein of the Board signs it, since the man in the middle will not, and Iain Mapa folds it into his pocket-book.⁹
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 26** — *The survey filed and shown to no one* (Cathair mhòr). Within the week Iain Mapa's survey is filed in the Board's own press at Cathair dhearg with the two years' surveys before it, and circulated to no one on the council or in any other office of the state. It lies there unread while the men who might have acted on it go on believing the mountain gives as freely as ever.¹⁰
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 26** — *Iain Mapa posted to Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). Within the month Iain Mapa is told, with little explanation offered and none asked for, that he is wanted at the silver works at Muileann chiar, twenty-four miles east and a little south of the Sloc Mòr, where the Board has need of a man who holds a chain straight and asks no more than the work requires.¹¹
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 26** — *The boat of the field warped into the new harbour* (Cuan dhearg). Of the hulls the Great Wave cast into the fields behind Cuan dhearg two generations before, one is found sound enough to be dragged to the water, caulked and floated, and is warped into the rebuilt harbour ahead of every boat built new for it. The harbour-master keeps it moored at the quay-head as a relic rather than putting it back to work.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 27** — *The Mine Board at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The Mine Board, which has sat at Cathair dhearg since the Sloc Mòr concession, moves its clerks to Cathair mhòr to be nearer the mountain. By the Board's own rule its surveys are kept there and not sent to the library.

7. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey*, 9 an Cèitean, SE 26.

8. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey*, 9 an Cèitean, SE 26.

9. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey*, 9 an Cèitean, SE 26.

10. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey*, 9 an Cèitean, SE 26.

11. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey*, 9 an Cèitean, SE 26.

- 15 AN GEARRAN, SE 27** — *The scent-makers of Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). The glass-houses of the capital shore begin to make small flasks, and in them the women of Seann Vell sell the waters they distil from bog-myrtle, meadowsweet and heather honey. Within a few years scent is sold in every market town, and the towns of the western plain take up the trade.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 27** — *The Grey Night forbidden* (Baile chrom). A Dia-thìreach magistrate at Baile chrom forbids the gatherings of the Grey Night sect as disorderly. Hannah Crane is fined. The vigil goes indoors and goes on.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 27** — *The harbour at Cuan dhearg reopened* (Cuan dhearg). The harbour at Cuan dhearg, lost to the Great Wave, is opened again with a new mole of dressed stone. The first boat in is one of those found in the fields behind the old town, refloated, and kept by the harbour-master as a relic.¹²
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 27** — *The Board's clerks move to Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The Mine Board moves its clerks and its presses the sixteen miles from Cathair dhearg to Cathair mhòr, into leased rooms above the town's wool market, on the stated ground that a board charged with the mountain's business ought to sit nearer the mountain than it had.¹³
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 27** — *Riaghailt a' Bhùird*¹⁴ *set down* (Cathair mhòr). In four lines the Mine Board sets down, for the first time in writing, the rule that its surveyors' work is to be kept at Cathair mhòr in the Board's own presses and not sent to the Library at Muileann chaol as every other office's reports are sent. No one on the council is asked to confirm it.¹⁵
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 27** — *The Moot pays Hannah Crane's fine* (Baile chrom). Word reaches the Moot at Caol mhòr that the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane has been fined at Baile chrom for keeping the Grey Night in the open. The Moot votes the balance of her fine out of its own small chest without much debate, on a councillor's motion that a woman fined for standing on a beach is no threat worth agreeing with.¹⁶
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 27** — *The Grey Night kept indoors* (Baile chrom). Forbidden the open shingle below the light, the vigil of the Grey Night is kept that year in a byre lent by a family who hold the old rite themselves, one night a year, in a silence the magistrate's order cannot reach any better than it reached the shore. Outsiders are still not told which night it falls on.¹⁷
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 28** — *Achadh mhin's old bounds restored* (Achadh mhin). The shire measures the returning households of Achadh mhin back onto the same strips the humans' surveyors once cut, the old plat being the one the families still walk by memory rather than a new line drawn by a Dia-thìreach chain.

12. ← Leads to *The boat of the field warped into the new harbour*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, SE 26.

13. ← Follows from *The Mine Board at Cathair mhòr*, 4 am Faoilleach, SE 27.

14. the rule of the Board

15. ← Follows from *The Mine Board at Cathair mhòr*, 4 am Faoilleach, SE 27.

16. ← Follows from *The Grey Night forbidden*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, SE 27.

17. ← Follows from *The Grey Night forbidden*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, SE 27.

- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 28** — *Achadh mbin resettled* (Achadh mhin). The fields of Achadh mhin bear again, and a few of the families moved away after the Great Wave come back to them. The shire gives them their old bounds from the humans' survey.¹⁸
- 11 AN GEARRAN, SE 28** — *Eòghan crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Brighde dies young, and no cause is made known. Her cousin Eòghan takes the throne, and for the first time the restored kingdom's succession is in dispute.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 28** — *The succession entry* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁹). The royal chronicler's entry for the succession gives the bare fact. The chroniclers after Gormshuil nic Dhùghail have added nothing to it.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *Dissent recorded in council* (Cathair dhearg). For the first time the council's minutes record votes against a succession. They name the councillors who voted, and not their reasons. Two of them do not sit again.
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *The first households return to Achadh mbin* (Achadh mhin). Three households moved off the salted fields after the Great Wave, or their children in their place, ask and are granted their old ground back, the barley coming up along strips long thought lost to the tide.²⁰
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *The twice-sealed packet reaches Muileann chaol* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²¹). Word of Brighde's death and Eòghan's crowning reaches the chronicler's desk in a packet sealed twice, the second hand adding, in a hastier line at the foot, that the council's own sitting on the succession did not pass as quietly as the crowning itself.²²
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *Gormshuil's three struck drafts* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²³). The chronicler writes and rejects three entries for the succession before a fourth stands: one that says more than an office should say first, one so bare it reads as a door shut on purpose, one left unfinished as an argument rather than a record.²⁴
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *The bare entry set down* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁵). Past the second hour of the morning Gormshuil enters the day of Brighde's death, the fact that no cause is made known, and the day of Eòghan's crowning, and nothing more, choosing the silence rather than dressing it as a fullness it is not.²⁶

18. ← Leads to *Achadh mbin's old bounds restored*, 5 am Faoilleach, SE 28.

19. the Library at Muileann chaol

20. ← Follows from *Achadh mbin resettled*, 13 am Faoilleach, SE 28.

21. the Library at Muileann chaol

22. ← Follows from *Eòghan crowned*, 11 an Gearran, SE 28.

23. the Library at Muileann chaol

24. ← Follows from *Eòghan crowned*, 11 an Gearran, SE 28; ← Follows from *The succession entry*, 16 an t-Samhain, SE 28.

25. the Library at Muileann chaol

26. ← Follows from *The succession entry*, 16 an t-Samhain, SE 28.

- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *The council's four lines on the division* (Cathair dhearg). The council's own minute of the sitting names Tormod mac Iain Òig and Sileas nic Artair as the two who stood against seating Eòghan, gives no reason either offered, and closes with the plainest of its four lines: the two do not sit again.²⁷
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *Tormod mac Iain Òig goes home* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod mac Iain Òig returns to his own lands in the western shires and is not named in the chronicle again for some years, his seat on the council closed behind him without further entry.²⁸
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *Sileas nic Artair keeps her own house's rite*. Sileas nic Artair, her council seat lost with Tormod mac Iain Òig's, gives her Old Spirits kin's house more of her time than council business ever left her, and does not sit at Cathair dhearg again.²⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *The council's two seats filled* (Cathair dhearg). Before the year turns the council seats a landed man's son from the western shires and a widow of a coastal house in the two empty places, and neither newcomer is asked in council to account for the vote that opened the seat they now hold.³⁰
- 10 AN GEARRAN, SE 29** — *The warehouse quarter of Inis bhàn burns two days* (Inis bhàn). Fire takes three storehouses and the dwellings above them at Inis bhàn on the Abhainn iséal and burns two days before the town beats it back street by street with buckets and wet sacking; every soul in the burning quarter gets clear, and none dies.
- 12 AM MÀRT, SE 29** — *Inis bhàn's fire* (Inis bhàn). Fire takes the warehouse quarter of Inis bhàn on the Abhainn iséal in the north-central country and burns for two days. The town's Hawk house takes in the homeless. The fire-bell the town buys afterwards is the loudest in the kingdom.³¹
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, SE 29** — *Dubhan born*. Dubhan is born mortal, in the north where the Severance confined his people, decades after the war that shut the island against those from whom his line descends.
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 29** — *The Tuathaich schools counted* (Doire ghlas). The Moot counts eleven schools in the north that teach in the humans' tongue, and three that have begun to teach Dia-thìris as well, at the parents' asking. Agnes Pike's school at Doire ghlas is one of the three.
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 29** — *The Hawk house at Inis bhàn opens its doors* (Inis bhàn). The Hawk house at Inis bhàn, which has never before taken in households outside those sworn to it, shelters every family the fire puts out of a roof, sworn or not, through the worst of the spring cold.³²

27. ← Follows from *Dissent recorded in council*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 28.

28. ← Follows from *Dissent recorded in council*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 28.

29. ← Follows from *Dissent recorded in council*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 28.

30. ← Follows from *Dissent recorded in council*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 28.

31. ← Leads to *The warehouse quarter of Inis bhàn burns two days*, 10 an Gearran, SE 29.

- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 29** — *Inis bhàn's new bell rung on the quay* (Inis bhàn). The council buys Inis bhàn a bell from the founders' yard at Cathair dhearg to stand where the old warehouse bell burned, rung once on the quay before it is hung, and heard, by the town's own telling, further up and down the Abhainn iséal than any bell in the kingdom.³³
- 24 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 29** — *The Moot's letter of the eleven schools* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale writes the Moot's count of the north's schools to Muileann chaol, eleven in all from Agnes Pike's byre at Doire ghlas to a room over a chandler's shop at Ceann àrsaidh opened that same autumn, and Gormshuil enters it whole rather than shortened.³⁴
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 29** — *Three schools begin teaching Dia-thiris*. At three of the north's eleven schools the teachers begin, at the parents' own asking and with no order from the council or leave from any maor, to teach Dia-thiris alongside the humans' letters, so that children may read a proclamation or a boundary-line in the tongue the kingdom writes its business in.³⁵
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 29** — *Agnes Pike's school teaches its first Dia-thiris lesson* (Doire ghlas). Agnes Pike's school at Doire ghlas, one of the three the Moot's letter names, sets its first Dia-thiris lesson beside the Bible and the Moot's own minutes, at the asking of the parents whose children it has taught since its founding.³⁶
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, SE 30** — *The stone house of Mac Ùisdein* (Cathair mhòr). Uisdean mac Ùisdein's house at Cathair mhòr is rebuilt in stone quarried from the spoil of the Sloc Mòr, the greatest private house in the kingdom. The Guild of Hewers holds its feast in the new hall.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 30** — *The Guild of Hewers feasts in the new hall* (Cathair mhòr). The Guild of Hewers holds its feast in the finished stone hall of Uisdean mac Ùisdein at Cathair mhòr, at tables set the length of the room under torches an ironsmith made to no pattern but his own, and Mòrag nic Coinnich attends as the Library's own witness.³⁷
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, SE 30** — *The northern fishing grounds* (Caol mhòr). Licences to fish the waters south and east of Caol mhòr are kept for Dia-thìrich boats. The Tuathaich boats are left the northern grounds, where the raiders also fish.
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 30** — *Doire shean's harbour* (Doire shean). Doire shean in the south-west builds a stone harbour for the fishing boats of the Stone's country, the first new harbour since the Severance not paid for by the Crown. The house of the Stone lends the money and takes the harbour dues.

32. ← Follows from *Inis bhàn's fire*, 12 an Màrt, SE 29.

33. ← Follows from *Inis bhàn's fire*, 12 an Màrt, SE 29.

34. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich schools counted*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, SE 29.

35. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich schools counted*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, SE 29.

36. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich schools counted*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, SE 29.

37. ← Follows from *The stone house of Mac Ùisdein*, 10 an Giblean, SE 30.

- 9 **AN T-IUCHAR, SE 30** — *The mason's letter of the hall he did not sit in* (Cathair mhòr). A mason who dressed the stone of Mac Ùisdein's new hall writes the Library that he was not asked to the guild's own feast in it, his craft holding no sworn place for a cutter of stone, and Ailean Leabhar enters the letter whole rather than in his own shorter hand.³⁸
- 15 **AN DÀMHAIR, SE 30** — *The first licence refused to a Caol mhòr boat* (Caol mhòr). Coll, a Tuathaich master who has fished the southern banks off Caol mhòr eleven years, brings his catch to the maor's scales the day the new licences take force and is told the grounds are not, at present, being papered for boats of his fleet; the Moot enters the day and his name.³⁹
- 3 **AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 30** — *The house of the Stone takes its first quarter's dues* (Doire shean). The house of the Stone at Doire shean takes its first quarter's harbour dues off the new quay before the mole's last course is dry, the sum entered beside what the house first lent the town for the building of it.⁴⁰

38. ← Follows from *The stone house of Mac Ùisdein*, 10 an Giblean, SE 30.

39. ← Follows from *The northern fishing grounds*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 30.

40. ← Follows from *Doire shean's harbour*, 24 an t-Ògmhios, SE 30.

THE YEARS SE 31 – 35

- 3 AN GIBLEAN, SE 31** — *Trenches at Làrach an Dùin*¹ (Làrach an Dùin). Diggers sent by the library open trenches at Làrach an Dùin on the south-east coast. They find walls older than any Dia-thìreach building, and no writing at all. Ailean Leabhar has the finds entered as of the Old Ones, purpose unknown.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, SE 31** — *Beathag asks that the temple's ground be left* (Làrach an Teampaill²). Beathag, eldest of three Seann Spioradan elders of the district, meets Ailean Leabhar at Làrach an Teampaill and asks that the Library measure the ruin rather than open it, since whatever lies under the stone is neither hers to claim nor his.
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 31** — *Làrach an Teampaill*³ *measured* (Làrach an Teampaill). The library's diggers measure the ruin called Làrach an Teampaill in the east and do not dig it, at the asking of the Seann Spioradan houses of the district. The keeper enters it as measured and let be.⁴
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 31** — *The diggers' camp opens at Làrach an Dùin*⁵ (Làrach an Dùin). Four diggers under a foreman named Cailean cut trenches through the spring above the headland at Làrach an Dùin, following the line of a coursed wall sunk deeper than any footing they have found the bottom of.⁶
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 31** — *Ailean Leabhar rides to the trenches* (Làrach an Dùin⁷). The keeper of the Library goes down himself to Làrach an Dùin on the diggers' word that the wall they have found is older than any ruin the Library holds a record of, and spends four days at the trench's edge with a lamp and a notebook.⁸
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 31** — *The finds laid in the Library* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹). Ailean Leabhar carries the season's three findings, the wall's short entry, the measure of Làrach an Teampaill¹⁰, and the copied obelisk, into the Library's own presses himself, filing the not-knowing of each as carefully as a certainty.¹¹

1. the fortress ruin

2. the temple ruin

3. the temple ruin

4. ← Leads to *Beathag asks that the temple's ground be left*, 25 an Giblean, SE 31.

5. the fortress ruin

6. ← Follows from *Trenches at Làrach an Dùin*, 3 an Giblean, SE 31.

7. the fortress ruin

8. ← Follows from *Trenches at Làrach an Dùin*, 3 an Giblean, SE 31.

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

10. the temple ruin

11. ← Follows from *Trenches at Làrach an Dùin*, 3 an Giblean, SE 31; ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill measured*, 7 an Dàmhair, SE 31.

- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 31** — *Ailean measures the temple with a chain, not a spade* (Làrach an Teampaill¹²). Ailean Leabhar spends two days at Làrach an Teampaill setting down the line of the fallen wall and the fall of the ground with a chain and a level, and enters the ruin as measured, and let be.¹³
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 31** — *Una copies the obelisk stroke by stroke* (Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁴). Una, a scribe trained under Ailean Leabhar in copying the Library's most damaged leaves, spends three weeks of fair days at the foot of the obelisk near Cnoc bheag setting down every stroke of its unread script exactly as the stone gives it, worn gap for worn gap.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 31** — *The council pays for a fence at the obelisk* (Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁵). On the keeper's word that a stone unread for longer than the kingdom's whole span deserves at least a fence against the cattle, the council finds the money for four posts and a rail set well back from the obelisk's foot.
- 29 AM MÀRT, SE 32** — *The obelisk at Cnoc bheag copied* (Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁶). A scribe of the library copies the writing on the obelisk near Cnoc bheag, stroke by stroke. It is like no script known on the island. The copy is filed and the obelisk fenced.¹⁷
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, SE 32** — *The keeper of Baile chrom's lighthouse reports the vigil* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹⁸). A Dia-thìrich keeper new to the lighthouse at Baile chrom reports the Grey Night sect's yearly vigil kept silent in the tower's own shadow, and makes no move against it, having no order that names a silent watch on open ground his business.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 32** — *A lighthouse on the Tuathaich coast* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹⁹). The Dia-thìreach keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom reports to the council that the Grey Night sect keeps its vigil in the dark of the lighthouse's own shadow. The council does nothing.²⁰
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, SE 32** — *Salt-pans of Àth bheag* (Àth bheag). Salt-pans are dug on the flats below Àth bheag on the east coast, and within a few years the town supplies the whole eastern seaboard. The salt goes inland by the old drove road past Baile iséal.
- 22 AN T-IÚCHAR, SE 32** — *The council answers the keeper's report with nothing* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²¹). No order reaches the keeper of Baile chrom's lighthouse, and no word reaches the magistrate who had once fined the vigil in the open, and Ailean Leabhar enters the council's silence into the Library's register as plainly as any finding.²²

12. the temple ruin

13. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill measured*, 7 an Dàmhair, SE 31.

14. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

15. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

16. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

17. ← Leads to *The finds laid in the Library*, 22 an t-Samhain, SE 31; ← Leads to *Una copies the obelisk stroke by stroke*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, SE 31; ← Leads to *The council pays for a fence at the obelisk*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, SE 31.

18. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

19. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

20. ← Leads to *The keeper of Baile chrom's lighthouse reports the vigil*, 23 an Giblean, SE 32.

21. the Library at Muileann chaol

22. ← Follows from *A lighthouse on the Tuathaich coast*, 27 an Giblean, SE 32.

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 32** — *Mòrag nic Coinnich made Ailean's deputy* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²³). On the road home from Àth bheag, Ailean Leabhar asks Mòrag nic Coinnich to stand as the Library's deputy after a season that has taught him one keeper alone is a Library one bad season from having nobody who can speak for it; she agrees, on the condition that the register always name her deputy and never keeper.²⁴
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 33** — *Cathair fhada's grain-store* (Cathair fhada). Cathair fhada on the southern plain builds a Crown grain-store great enough to feed the south for a season. It is filled from the south's own harvests, and first opened in the dry years at Achadh shean.
- 10 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 33** — *The grain-store at Cathair fhada opens its doors* (Cathair fhada). In the dry weeks of a poor season the keeper of the new Crown grain-store walks out to the road and tells the first cart that passes that the south will eat that year whatever the sky withholds, and word of the opened doors outruns, by an evening, word of how bad the year will prove.²⁵
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 33** — *The second census after the Severance*. The second census measures for the first time how far the Tuathaich live below the Dia-thìrich; until now it was only seen. The report is not made public.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, SE 33** — *Walter Hale dies* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale, first speaker of the Moot, dies at Caol mhòr. The Moot chooses Mary Coyle, a fisherman's widow, to follow him, the first woman to hold the chair.
- 4 AM MÀRT, SE 33** — *The second census rides the shire roads*. Clerks sent out a second time from Cathair dhearg tally hearth against hearth as before, but with a new column set beside the first, a figure for what a Dia-thìreach household holds and one for what its Tuathach neighbour holds, so that the count for once measures the gap rather than only setting the numbers side by side.²⁶
- 9 AM MÀRT, SE 33** — *The council locks the second census away* (Cathair dhearg). The sums the shire clerks carry back to Cathair dhearg go onto a stack in the council's own keeping-room and no further; no proclamation, no minute copied to the Library, no word to any shire clerk who might have carried it on, and the twelve who asked for the count give out only that the figures want study before they want airing.²⁷
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, SE 33** — *Walter Hale settles a carter's toll dispute* (Caol mhòr). Keeping the thirty-year habit of hearing the furthest-travelled petitioner before the day's set business, Walter Hale hears out a carter from beyond Àth fhada over a wrongly charged toll and settles it in the carter's favour himself, his voice unhurried though the sitting leaves him more spent than harder business had the winter before.²⁸

23. the Library at Muileann chaol

24. ← Follows from *Salt-pans of Àth bheag*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 32.

25. ← Follows from *Cathair fhada's grain-store*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 33.

26. ← Follows from *The second census after the Severance*, 30 am Faoilleach, SE 33.

27. ← Follows from *The second census after the Severance*, 30 am Faoilleach, SE 33.

28. ← Follows from *Walter Hale dies*, 28 an Gearran, SE 33.

- 28 AN GIBLEAN, SE 33** — *Walter Hale dies at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale, first speaker of the Moot, dies in his own bed at Caol mhòr on the twenty-eighth of an Gearran, seventy-six years old, David beside him and Alice sent for but not in time; the Moot's business stops three days without a vote taken to stop it.²⁹
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, SE 33** — *The north walks to Hale's burial* (Caol mhòr). Fishermen, carters and shepherds from every part of the north crowd the roads into Caol mhòr for Walter Hale's burial, more feet on the road that week than the fair itself drew the autumn before, and he is laid in sight of the Moot's own house where he sat thirty-one years.³⁰
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 33** — *The Moot names Mary Coyle speaker* (Caol mhòr). On the fourth day after Hale's burial the Moot sets aside a factor's son and a shire clerk both spoken for the chair and names Mary Coyle, a fisherman's widow of Caol mhòr, the first woman to hold it, by a count nobody in the room troubles to call close.³¹
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 33** — *David Hale keeps the books under Mary Coyle* (Caol mhòr). David Hale, who kept his father's minute-books through the years of the first fair, sets Mary Coyle's seal at her own place beside the one his father's hand had set to thirty-one years of letters, and stays on at her asking to keep the rough book as he always has.³²
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 33** — *Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire asks to see the report* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire, who rode her own shire's tally in for the second census, asks a council clerk at Cathair dhearg to let her see the island's whole sum, on the ground that she carried the figures herself and has a right to know their total.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 33** — *Seonag writes the refusal into her own book*. Refused the report with no reason beyond the plain fact of the refusal, Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire writes the asking and the answer that same evening into a private book she keeps for herself and shows to no one, for a record's own sake rather than any purpose she could name.
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 33** — *Ruth Ashby and Clara Tulloch begin under Eachann mac Rath* (Àth àrsaidh). Two women of the shunting country north of Caol mhòr, Ruth Ashby and Clara Tulloch, come to the surgery of Eachann mac Rath at Àth àrsaidh, who takes them without his guild's leave to be taught by watching him set bones and mix poultices through a hard, fever-crowded season.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 33** — *The guild's men find Eachann's surgery out* (Àth àrsaidh). Word from a factor's wife reaches the physicians' guild that Eachann mac Rath's two new pupils handle a lancet as steady as he does, and two of the guild's own men ride to Àth àrsaidh and watch Ruth Ashby set a child's wrist unwatched before they leave without a word to either woman.

29. ← Follows from *Walter Hale dies*, 28 an Gearran, SE 33.

30. ← Follows from *Walter Hale dies*, 28 an Gearran, SE 33.

31. ← Follows from *Walter Hale dies*, 28 an Gearran, SE 33.

32. ← Follows from *Walter Hale dies*, 28 an Gearran, SE 33.

15 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 33 — *Eachann mac Rath struck from the physicians' guild* (Àth àrsaidh). The guild strikes Eachann mac Rath from its rolls before an Cèitean is out, its letter naming no fault in his physic, only that he taught outside its leave and to hands its charter does not recognise, and he sets the letter aside and keeps his surgery open all the same.

30 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 34 — *The census clerks' private note* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³³). Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire, one of the census clerks, leaves among her papers a note that she asked to see the report on the gap and was refused. The note came to the library with her papers after her death. It is the only mention of the report outside the council.³⁴

II AN GEARRAN, SE 34 — *The Tuathaich doctors* (Àth àrsaidh). The Moot pays for two Tuathaich women to be taught medicine by a Dia-thireach physician at Àth àrsaidh, who takes them against the will of his guild. He is struck from its rolls. They practise in the north for forty years.³⁵

26 AN GEARRAN, SE 34 — *The Abhainn ìseal takes three bridges and the embankment* (Abhainn ìseal). Three days of hard rain in am Màrt bring the Abhainn ìseal over its lower banks, and the flood carries away three bridges and a long stretch of the coal line's embankment, a carter losing his cart on the middle span but no soul drowned along that reach.

12 AM MÀRT, SE 34 — *The Abhainn ìseal floods* (Abhainn ìseal). The Abhainn ìseal, longest river of the island, breaks its banks along its lower reach and carries away three bridges and a stretch of the coal line's embankment. The line is shut most of a year, and the ports live on stored coal.³⁶

28 AN GIBLEAN, SE 34 — *The coal line shuts and the ports live on stored coal* (Abhainn ìseal). With a mile of embankment gone under the Abhainn ìseal's flood the coal line shuts for want of ground to run on, and the ports that lived on what it carried, Cuan ruadh and Muileann chrom among them, turn to whatever coal they had laid by against a leaner week rather than a whole season.³⁷

24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 34 — *Mary Coyle gives her first order as speaker* (Caol mhòr). Not yet a month in the chair, Mary Coyle calls the Moot together the evening word of the washed embankment reaches Caol mhòr and orders every port on the coal line's reach to open its own store and share it by the shire's count of hearths, the north sending south to Muileann chrom until the line can be mended.³⁸

33. the Library at Muileann chaol

34. ← Leads to *Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire asks to see the report*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, SE 33; ← Leads to *Seonag writes the refusal into her own book*, 28 an t-Iuchar, SE 33.

35. ← Leads to *Ruth Asbby and Clara Tulloch begin under Eachann mac Rath*, 16 an Lùnastal, SE 33; ← Leads to *The guild's men find Eachann's surgery out*, 21 an t-Sultain, SE 33; ← Leads to *Eachann mac Rath struck from the physicians' guild*, 15 an t-Samhain, SE 33.

36. ← Leads to *The Abhainn ìseal takes three bridges and the embankment*, 26 an Gearran, SE 34.

37. ← Follows from *The Abhainn ìseal floods*, 12 am Màrt, SE 34.

38. ← Follows from *The Abhainn ìseal floods*, 12 am Màrt, SE 34.

- 26 AN CÈITEAN, SE 35** — *The Hawk houses' own custodian* (Inis ìseal). The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag name a custodian of their own, Raonaid nic Iain, and seat her at Inis ìseal. The high custodian at Seann Skell will not own her. The houses carry on as if he had.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 35** — *The Hawk houses gather at Inis ìseal to name a custodian* (Inis ìseal). Witnesses of every Hawk house in Siorrachd Cnoc bheag crowd the hall at Inis ìseal and name Raonaid nic Iain custodian by a standing vote, each house setting meal, wool or honey on the altar's step before the hall breaks.³⁹
- 11 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 35** — *Murchadh Ruadh gives Raonaid the kept feather* (Inis ìseal). Murchadh Ruadh of Baile fhraoich sets a white feather kept three generations in his own house into Raonaid nic Iain's hand at her naming, and she wears it pinned at her collar from that day.⁴⁰
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 35** — *The Hawk houses speak of a hawk for the shire's arms* (Cnoc bheag). Witnesses leaving Raonaid nic Iain's naming say openly that Siorrachd Cnoc bheag's white billet, the roll's mark for two ages, ought to be struck for a hawk, though no house yet carries the saying south.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 35** — *Seann Skell's letter refusing Raonaid reaches Inis ìseal* (Inis ìseal). A three-line letter from the high custodian's house at Seann Skell in the south reaches Inis ìseal, naming no fault in Raonaid nic Iain but saying the Rite's own order of worship knows no office of a Hawk custodian and so cannot own her.⁴¹
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 35** — *The Hawk houses carry on as if the custodian had been owned* (Inis ìseal). The Hawk houses fold the southern letter away unanswered and keep bringing their vigils and disputes to Raonaid nic Iain exactly as before, burying and marrying their own under no rite but hers.⁴²
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 35** — *Raonaid nic Iain at Inis ìseal* (Inis ìseal). Raonaid nic Iain, custodian of the Hawk houses, writes out the Hawk's order of worship, which until now was spoken and never written. The Hawk houses read it aloud once a year and keep the written copy locked away.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 35** — *Raonaid begins setting the Hawk's order into a farm account-book* (Inis ìseal). Raonaid nic Iain starts writing the Hawk's spoken order of worship, till then carried only in a custodian's memory, into a farmer's account-book, sounding each line against the altar to match her own mother's mother's telling of it.⁴³
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 35** — *The order finished and locked in the altar's oil-box* (Inis ìseal). Raonaid nic Iain finishes the written order at the turn of the year, reads it aloud once to the gathered houses, ties it with a strip of white feather and locks it into the iron box that once held the altar's lamp-oil.⁴⁴

39. ← Follows from *The Hawk houses' own custodian*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 35.

40. ← Follows from *The Hawk houses' own custodian*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 35.

41. ← Follows from *The Hawk houses' own custodian*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 35.

42. ← Follows from *The Hawk houses' own custodian*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 35.

43. ← Follows from *Raonaid nic Iain at Inis ìseal*, 23 an t-Samhain, SE 35.

29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 35 — *A hawk for Siorrachd Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag ask the council to set a hawk on the shire's arms in place of the white billet the roll gave it. The council grants it, and the maor's seal is recut with a white hawk among its twelve crescents. It is the first change made to the roll at the asking of an order.⁴⁵

44. ← Follows from *Raonaid nic Iain at Inis iséal*, 23 an t-Samhain, SE 35.

45. ← Leads to *The Hawk houses speak of a hawk for the shire's arms*, 12 an t-Iuchar, SE 35.

THE YEARS SE 36 – 40

- 6 AM MÀRT, SE 36** — *A delegation from Inis ìseal asks the council for a hawk on the shire's seal* (Cathair mhòr). Five witnesses from the Hawk houses, Raonaid nic Iain among them, ride to Cathair dhearg to ask the council that Siorrachd Cnoc bheag's white billet be struck and a hawk set on the shire's arms in its place.¹
- 27 AM MÀRT, SE 36** — *The maor breaks the old die and presses the new seal* (Cnoc bheag). The maor of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag breaks the shire's old die before its assembled clerks and presses the recut seal, a white hawk among twelve crescents, into wax for the first time.²
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 36** — *Six dead at the Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan³). Six fighters die at the Còmhrag, the most in any year yet. The custodians of the Rite petition for its ending. The fair-wardens of Ceann leathan, whose town lives off the crowds, refuse.
- 2 AN CÈITEAN, SE 36** — *Six die at that year's Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁴). Six fighters, the most in any year yet, die on the trampled ground at Ceann leathan before that year's Còmhrag is called, one of them a boy of Baile ghlas not yet twenty.⁵
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 36** — *The custodians' petition against the Còmhrag is refused* (Ceann leathan). The custodians of the southern Rite petition the fair-wardens of Ceann leathan in writing to end the Còmhrag after six deaths; the wardens read it and refuse within the hour, on the ground the town lives off the melee's crowds.⁶
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 36** — *The circus at Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). In the year of the six dead An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn⁷ pitches at Ceann leathan and plays to the crowds who stay on after the melee. It is said the fair-wardens paid it to come.
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 36** — *The circus pitches at Ceann leathan after the six burials* (Ceann leathan). An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn⁸ pitches its tents on the melee's own trampled ground within a week of the six burials, and it is said, though never proved, that the fair-wardens paid it to come.⁹
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 36** — *The coal line reaches Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). The railway is carried through to the port of Ceann leathan, so that coal may be shipped from a second harbour. The quays of Ceann leathan are rebuilt for coal-ships, and the town outgrows its walls.

1. ← Follows from *A hawk for Siorrachd Cnoc bheag*, 29 an t-Samhain, SE 35.

2. ← Follows from *A hawk for Siorrachd Cnoc bheag*, 29 an t-Samhain, SE 35.

3. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

4. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

5. ← Follows from *Six dead at the Còmhrag*, 27 an Giblean, SE 36.

6. ← Follows from *Six dead at the Còmhrag*, 27 an Giblean, SE 36.

7. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

8. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

9. ← Follows from *The circus at Ceann leathan*, 6 an Dàmhair, SE 36.

- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 36** — *The first coal-ship loads by lamplight at Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). The first coal-ship out of Ceann leathan's rebuilt quays loads by lamplight on a winter tide, the harbour clerk noting only the hour, the tonnage and the shore gang's complaint of the cold.¹⁰
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 36** — *Ros bheag's shipyard* (Ros bheag). Ros bheag on the west coast opens a yard for coal-ships, and the western ports need no longer send to Ros dhomhain for hulls. The shipwrights of Ros dhomhain protest to the guild court and lose.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 36** — *Ros dhomhain's masters lose their protest at the guild court* (Cathair mhòr). The eldest masters of Ros dhomhain carry their protest against Ros bheag's new coal-ship yard to the guild court at Cathair dhearg and lose it in a single sitting, the court ruling a guild's charter binds no yard to a monopoly of the coast.¹¹
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 37** — *Iain Mapa proves the deep gallery* (Muileann chiar). Sent to measure a new shaft cut on a guild captain's thirty-year hunch, Iain mac Ruairidh finds the silver at Muileann chiar running richer with depth rather than thinner, the ore darker and heavier the further the gallery goes. He checks the figures three times before he writes them fair.¹²
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 37** — *The silver at depth* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver seam at Muileann chiar, which the Dia-thìrich kept in their own hands through the humans' time, is found richer at depth than any had looked for. The town's old silver guild takes a charter under the restored custom. Iain Mapa, working there since the Board sent him, measures the new faces.¹³
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 37** — *The eastern blank-houses* (Baile dhìreach). More silver comes up from Muileann chiar than the mint at Cathair dhearg can refine. The Crown gives the villages of the eastern hills the refining of the guild's bar, with the gold washed from the stream below Baile dhìreach, into blanks for the realm-coin. The mint strikes them. The villages are paid by weight.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 37** — *Dùn thais in the west* (Dùn thais). Dùn thais on the west coast is granted a court of the sea of its own, to judge salvage and wreck along its shore. At its first sitting it awards a raider's hulk to the fishermen who drove it aground.
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 37** — *The guild masters read the survey entire* (Muileann chiar). Iain carries the deep gallery's figures to the guild hall himself and unrolls them before three masters who argue over the timbering a new shaft will need. He tells them plainly it will hold only if timbered as he has drawn it, and not an inch cheaper.¹⁴

10. ← Follows from *The coal line reaches Ceann leathan*, 4 an t-Samhain, SE 36.

11. ← Follows from *Ros bheag's shipyard*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, SE 36.

12. ← Follows from *The silver at depth*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37.

13. ← Leads to *Iain Mapa proves the deep gallery*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37.

14. ← Follows from *The silver at depth*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37.

- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 37** — *The silver guild of Muileann chiar chartered anew* (Muileann chiar). On the strength of the deep gallery's yield the council renews under the restored custom the charter the humans' own Administration had let stand and then let lapse, binding the guild's captains to the Crown's tithe on every bar struck and giving the guild the courts' weight behind its bindings.¹⁵
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 37** — *Gold found in the stream below Baile dhìreach* (Baile dhìreach). A village smith washing his pan of an evening finds fine gold in the gravel of the stream that turns his forge's own wheel, and tells a maor's clerk the plain truth when the coin he has put by draws the clerk's question rather than invent a lie he would have to keep.¹⁶
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 37** — *The first blanks struck for the mint* (Baile dhìreach). More silver comes up from Muileann chiar than the mint at Cathair dhearg can refine, and the council gives the eastern hill villages the refining of the guild's bar, with the gold washed below Baile dhìreach, into blanks for the realm-coin, paid by weight; the first blanks go north in am Faoilleach.¹⁷
- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 38** — *Dùn thais in the east* (Dùn thais). The other Dùn thais, in the east, seat of its own shire, builds a covered market for the hill farms. For ten years the royal record confuses the courts of the two towns, until Tormod Pinn marks them west and east.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 38** — *Siorrachd Doire chaol* (Doire chaol). Doire chaol, the village laid out south of the capital for the families of the royal household, has grown too great for the maor of Baile chiar to govern from his seat. The council cuts it out as a shire of its own, the only shire made since the drawing.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 38** — *Iain Mapa marries Mòr nic Dhòmbnaill* (Muileann chiar). Iain marries Mòr, a refiner's daughter of Muileann chiar who first proved his own scale a hair off true in front of three of the guild's captains. They are married at the guild hall in am Faoilleach, her father giving her hand and the guild's captains standing witness in place of Iain's own western kin.¹⁸
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 38** — *Dùn thais in the west granted a sea court* (Dùn thais). The western Dùn thais is granted a court of the sea to judge salvage and wreck along its shore, after a wrecked hulk driven ashore proves too rich a prize for custom alone to divide. The court's first sitting, held on the strand, awards the wreck whole to the crews who drove it aground.¹⁹
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 38** — *Dùn thais in the east opens its covered market* (Dùn thais). The eastern Dùn thais raises a covered market at its own shire's charge for the hill farms that had traded in its square uncovered since the town was walled, its first trading held under a roof that smells more of new-cut wood than of the produce it shelters.²⁰

15. ← Follows from *The silver at depth*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37.

16. ← Follows from *The eastern blank-houses*, 19 an t-Sultain, SE 37.

17. ← Follows from *The eastern blank-houses*, 19 an t-Sultain, SE 37.

18. ← Follows from *The silver at depth*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37.

19. ← Follows from *Dùn thais in the west*, 3 an Dàmhair, SE 37.

20. ← Follows from *Dùn thais in the east*, 2 an Gearran, SE 38.

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 38** — *The royal record confuses the two Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). A clerk at Cathair dhearg files the western court's petition and the eastern market's petition against the one town's name, both signed only "Dùn thais", and a second clerk's hand-correction holds only until the next season's post brings the same confusion again.²¹
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 38** — *Baile chiar's maor petitions to cut out Doire chaol* (Baile chiar). The maor of Baile chiar writes plainly that Doire chaol, grown from a scattering of household-clerks' houses into a town proper, has outgrown a seat five miles distant, and asks that it be given a maor of its own rather than go on being governed badly at second hand.²²
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 38** — *Siorrachd Doire chaol cut from Baile chiar* (Doire chaol). The council grants the petition before the summer is old, the only shire cut new from an older one since the original drawing, Doire chaol entered onto the roll with its own arms, its own dues, and a maor of its own choosing.²³
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 39** — *The dead and not dead of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò²⁴ Doire uaine). Herders near Doire uaine will not graze the hills above the town, where old writings tell of a thing that is dead and does not rest. A shepherd is lost there. The magistrate enters wolves.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 39** — *The fall at Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). A gallery of the reopened Cill ghlas district gives way under Muileann dhearg, along a line the surveyors had marked as sound. Thirty-one hewers die. It is small beside the Rending. It is the same fault.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 39** — *Iain Mapa rides through the night to Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). Word of the fall reaches Muileann chiar by a rider sent without urgency, and Iain Mapa, two seasons into the silver works and no longer reckoned a mine matter by the Board, rides the thirty miles through the night rather than wait for morning, and goes down on the second rope with a lamp and a level.²⁵
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 39** — *Iain Mapa lays his own old maps against the new fault* (Muileann dhearg). With maps sent up from the silver guild's own store, older and truer than anything the Board keeps at Cathair mhòr, Iain Mapa finds the broken ground under the fallen gallery runs exactly where the Rending's own line ran three ages before, marked by an older hand with a single word: left, let be.²⁶
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 39** — *The thirty-one are buried in a single ground* (Muileann dhearg). The dead of the fall are buried at the edge of Muileann dhearg's own burying-yard, thirty-one graves broken in two days by every man in the town not needed underground, the district's custodian reading over each grave in turn at the families' own asking, and Iain Mapa standing the whole of it with his hat in his hand.²⁷

21. ← Follows from *Dùn thais in the east*, 2 an Gearran, SE 38.

22. ← Follows from *Siorrachd Doire chaol*, 18 an Dàmhair, SE 38.

23. ← Follows from *Siorrachd Doire chaol*, 18 an Dàmhair, SE 38.

24. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

25. ← Follows from *The fall at Muileann dhearg*, 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 39.

26. ← Follows from *The fall at Muileann dhearg*, 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 39.

27. ← Follows from *The fall at Muileann dhearg*, 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 39.

18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 39 — *Iain Mapa writes a letter naming the fault, and does not send it.*

At his own table at Muileann chiar, Iain Mapa writes to the Board naming the fault at Cill ghlas by its true line and setting it beside the survey the Board filed and never circulated three years before; he reads it through twice, folds it, and puts it unsealed in the drawer that holds his old receipt.²⁸

19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39 — *The rules of the shafts.* After this lesser echo of the old fall of Scàineadh Cill ghlas²⁹, new rules for digging are made. They are for Dia-thìrich workers. In the workings where Tuathaich labour they are kept loosely, and by intent.³⁰

27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39 — *The timber at Àth leathan (Àth leathan).* At the pits about Àth leathan, where Dia-thìrich overseers work Tuathaich hands, the new rules of timbering are posted and not paid for. The overseers' books, which came later to the library, show the timber ordered and never delivered.

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39 — *A shepherd lost above Doire uaine (Doire uaine).* A shepherd new to the country puts his flock to the one shoulder of hill the town's shepherds will not graze, where the old writings tell of the Marbh-bheò³¹, and does not come down. His dog returns alone; the town finds only his crook, driven upright into the turf.³²

29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39 — *The magistrate enters wolves at Doire uaine (Doire uaine).* The magistrate writes wolves as the cause in the shire's own book, a finding no shepherd argues and none believes, since no wolf has been seen on that hill in living memory. He tells the shepherd's mother the book wanted a cause it could hold.³³

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39 — *Iain Mapa keeps a second copy of the guild's charter (Muileann chiar).* Iain writes the silver guild's new charter into his own private book beside the receipt he carried from the Sloc Mòr and the deep gallery's own figures, telling Mòr at last that the Board never once told him his first survey of the thinning vein had proved true.

³⁴

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39 — *Mary Coyle writes to the Board naming Àth leathan's undelivered timber (Caol mhòr).* Reading a copy of the Board's new digging rules brought north by a carter, Mary Coyle writes in the Moot's own hand asking that the rules be kept in fact at the western pits as well as in the posting, and names Àth leathan and the ordered timber that never left the yard at Ceann mhòr.³⁵

28. ← Follows from *The fall at Muileann dhearg*, 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 39.

29. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

30. ← Leads to *Iain Mapa lays his own old maps against the new fault*, 3 an Lùnastal, SE 39.

31. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

32. ← Follows from *The dead and not dead of Doire uaine*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 39.

33. ← Follows from *The dead and not dead of Doire uaine*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 39.

34. ← Follows from *The silver at depth*, 1 am Faoilleach, SE 37; ← Follows from *The dead and not dead of Doire uaine*, 23 an t-Ògmhios, SE 39.

35. ← Follows from *The timber at Àth leathan*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, SE 39.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39** — *The Board answers the Moot in three lines and files the matter* (Àth leathan). The Board thanks the Moot for its concern and states that Àth leathan's timber has been referred to the district overseer for his report; no report is ever filed, and Mary Coyle's letter is kept, unanswered further, in the press at Cathair mhòr where papers go that the Board has no further use for.³⁶
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 40** — *Ailean Leabhar is found dead at his own desk* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁷). On the third day of an t-Sultain, Mòrag nic Coinnich finds Ailean Leabhar at his desk at Muileann chaol, the harvest returns for Siorrachd Doire chaol open under his hand and his pen laid down beside them rather than dropped, so that he seems, she says after, to have finished the line he was writing before he stopped.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 40** — *Mòrag nic Coinnich, keeper* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁸). Ailean Leabhar dies at Muileann chaol, and Mòrag nic Coinnich becomes keeper of the library. She begins the custom, kept ever since, of writing beside each item whence it came.³⁹
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 40** — *Ailean Leabhar is buried in the ground behind the Library* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴⁰). Ailean Leabhar is buried two days after at Muileann chaol, in a small ground behind the Library itself where no keeper had been buried before him, the town turning out near to the last household, and Mòrag nic Coinnich reads over him only his own words, that the Library settles nothing and only keeps.⁴¹
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 40** — *Mòrag nic Coinnich finds an unfinished note among Ailean Leabhar's papers* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴²). Going through the old keeper's desk in her first month as keeper, Mòrag nic Coinnich finds one sheet in his own hand, undated beyond an old year, reading only that what the Library is not sent it cannot keep, and to ask the shires again; she cannot say whether it was a note to himself or the start of a letter, and keeps it unfiled in her own drawer.⁴³
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 40** — *The pit families of Achadh dhomhain* (Achadh dhomhain). After the fall at Muileann dhearg forty hewers' families leave Achadh dhomhain for the fishing ports of the south. The Guild of Hewers binds sixty apprentices to fill its rolls. None of them are Tuathaich.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 40** — *Sixty apprentices are bound at Achadh dhomhain, and not one is Tuathaich* (Achadh dhomhain). The Guild of Hewers binds sixty boys in its own hall at Achadh dhomhain to fill the rolls the fall thinned by thirty-one, each swearing with a hand laid on a lump of coal while his father stands behind him in a line the length of the hall, and the charter that reserves the oath to Dia-threach applicants is kept to the letter.⁴⁴

36. ← Follows from *The timber at Àth leathan*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, SE 39.

37. the Library at Muileann chaol

38. the Library at Muileann chaol

39. ← Leads to *Ailean Leabhar is found dead at his own desk*, 23 an t-Iuchar, SE 40.

40. the Library at Muileann chaol

41. ← Follows from *Mòrag nic Coinnich, keeper*, 3 an t-Sultain, SE 40.

42. the Library at Muileann chaol

43. ← Follows from *Mòrag nic Coinnich, keeper*, 3 an t-Sultain, SE 40.

- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 40** — *A family with no dead in the fall leaves Achadh dhombain regardless* (Achadh dhomhain). Among the forty households that quit Achadh dhomhain for the southern ports that autumn are families who buried no one in the fall, saying to whoever asks that a town may grieve its thirty-one and go on living beside their graves, but a household does not choose to raise its own sons under ground a survey has already misjudged once.⁴⁵
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 40** — *Fire at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg⁴⁶). On the eve of Samhain fire runs through the stalls of the fair at Muileann òg. The next day the fair's court sits in a field, and the fair goes on. Oighrig nic Mhathain, toll-mistress since the first fair, dies of her burns.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 40** — *Oighrig nic Mhathain is burned beating back the fire with her own cloak* (Fèill Muileann òg⁴⁷). Caught in the fairground when the fire runs on Samhain eve, Oighrig nic Mhathain beats at the burning canvas with her own cloak until the worst of it is turned from the stalls that hold a dozen towns' whole trade, and does not leave the ground until the last flame along the weavers' row has burned itself out.⁴⁸
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 40** — *The Tuathaich wool carts* (Muileann leathan). The Rail Board will not carry goods sent by the Moot, pleading the fair's rule on factors. The wool of the north goes south to Muileann òg by cart, five days on the road, and is sold by factors when it comes.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 40** — *Mary Coyle asks the Board whether its reading of the factor rule is new* (Caol mhòr). When the Rail Board refuses to carry the north's wool on the strength of the fair's own rule on factors, Mary Coyle writes a second, shorter letter asking only whether the reading is new or has simply never before been turned against the north's own goods; the Board does not answer it, and a clerk files it beside the first.⁴⁹

44. ← Follows from *The pit families of Achadh dhombain*, 2 an Dàmhair, SE 40.

45. ← Follows from *The pit families of Achadh dhombain*, 2 an Dàmhair, SE 40.

46. the fair at Muileann òg

47. the fair at Muileann òg

48. ← Follows from *Fire at the fair*, 31 an Dàmhair, SE 40.

49. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich wool carts*, 29 an t-Samhain, SE 40.

THE YEARS SE 41 – 45

- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 41** — *The Tuathaich carters' road* (Àth fhada). The carters of the northern wool go to the fair by Cnoc ghorm, Àth fhada and the old road down to Inis àrsaidh, and the Tuathaich villages on the way open inns for them. In the north the road is called the Carters' Road. In the south it has no name.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, SE 41** — *Daniel Frayne rides the wool carts south* (Muileann leathan). With the Rail Board still refusing the Moot's goods, the north's wool goes south by cart, and Daniel Frayne asks leave to ride with the second train, five days on the old way by Cnoc ghorm, Àth fhada and Inis àrsaidh to the fair at Muileann òg.¹
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 41** — *Dubhan's childhood*. Dubhan grows up watching a caste that does not age hold every true advantage on an island where his own forebears were pushed to the edge. The coal was never his to inherit.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *The Moot's pit register* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr begins a register of Tuathaich hewers killed or maimed in the western pits, for no Dia-thireach book counts them. Mary Coyle's clerks enter the first year's names on the families' own word. The register is kept to this day and has never been sent south.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *The first lamp lit at Àth fhada* (Àth fhada). A widow of Àth fhada who has fed carters at her own table for two winters begins taking payment for it, keeping a lamp lit past every other house's hour. Two more households on the road do the same within the season, and carters find their beds by the lights alone.²
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *The north's name and the south's silence* (Àth fhada). Frayne asks the widow at Àth fhada what the carters call their road and learns it has long been called the Carters' Road in the north, its name simply grown to fit the wool's going by cart. He learns too that no map south of Cnoc ghorm troubles to name the road at all, and writes both facts down.³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *A season's wages weighed against the road* (Inis àrsaidh). Waiting out a flood at a crossing short of Inis àrsaidh, Frayne hears from a shunting family how the road's five days are reckoned against a season's whole earning, a toll no southern ledger is ever asked to set against the fair's own profit. He writes the figure down.⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *Mary Coyle opens the register of the hurt* (Caol mhòr). Mary Coyle tells the Moot's clerks that the Board keeps no true count of the Tuathaich dead and maimed of the western pits, and that the Moot will begin a book naming them on the families' own word, since no other word will be offered.⁵

1. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich wool carts*, 29 an t-Samhain, SE 40; ← Follows from *The Tuathaich carters' road*, 26 am Faoilleach, SE 41.

2. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich carters' road*, 26 am Faoilleach, SE 41.

3. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich carters' road*, 26 am Faoilleach, SE 41.

4. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich carters' road*, 26 am Faoilleach, SE 41.

5. ← Follows from *The Moot's pit register*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, SE 41.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *The first name entered in Clàr nan Leòn*⁶ (Caol mhòr). The widow of Àth fhada's husband, lost under the western pits, is the first name Daniel Frayne writes into the new register, carried south by a neighbour rather than wait on the widow's own journey. Frayne sets the pen down before the ink is dry.⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *The keel laid at Ros mhòr* (Ros mhòr). Shipwrights turned out of the southern guild yards gather enough coin and timber at last to lay a keel of their own at Ros mhòr. Harry Marlow, grey now, cuts it to the humans' old lines, low and full in the bow, that the southern guilds no longer let a Tuathaich hand build.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, SE 42** — *Ros mhòr's boatyard* (Ros mhòr). Tuathaich boatbuilders turned out of the guild yards open a boatyard at Ros mhòr in the north. Its boats are built to the humans' old lines and are swifter than anything in the south.⁸
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 42** — *Tormod Pinn* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill lays down the office of royal chronicler. Tormod mac Sheumais follows her, called Tormod Pinn for the speed of his hand. He keeps the record for more than twenty years and writes more of it than any before or since.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 42** — *A second copy of the register kept apart* (Muileann leathan). By the year's end the register holds above thirty names. A second copy is made against fire or flood and kept at a house in Muileann leathan, so that no single hand's slipping can lose the names a second time.¹⁰
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 42** — *Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill's last entry* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹¹). Feeling her hand begin to shake on a long day's writing, Gormshuil lays down the office of royal chronicler after four and twenty years, her final entry a plain list of what the chronicle under her hand had never held: the northern towns' own accounts, the humans' old treaties, and the Board's surveys left unrolled.¹²
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 42** — *Tormod Pinn copies the list of gaps* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹³). Tormod mac Sheumais, called Tormod Pinn for the speed of his hand, succeeds Gormshuil as royal chronicler and opens his own first book by copying her last list whole, striking nothing from it, so it is not lost to be rewritten by a less patient hand.¹⁴

6. the register of the wounded

7. ← Follows from *The Moot's pit register*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, SE 41.

8. ← Leads to *The keel laid at Ros mhòr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, SE 41.

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

10. ← Follows from *The Moot's pit register*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, SE 41.

11. the Library at Muileann chaol

12. ← Follows from *Tormod Pinn*, 31 an t-Iuchar, SE 42.

13. the Library at Muileann chaol

14. ← Follows from *Tormod Pinn*, 31 an t-Iuchar, SE 42.

- 10 AN DÙHLACHD, SE 42** — *The first Ros mhòr hull launched* (Ros mhòr). Built on evenings and Sabbaths through a year, the yard's first hull takes the water clean at Ros mhòr, swifter than anything the southern yards have launched in a long season. Harry Marlow tells the men beside him he means to live to see the north sail hulls built with no southern guild's leave.¹⁵
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, SE 43** — *Gormsbuil nic Dhùghaill's last entry* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁶). Tormod Pinn copies into the front of his first book the last entry Gormsbuil nic Dhùghaill made as chronicler, a list of what the record lacks: the northern towns' own accounts, the humans' treaties in their own tongue, and the Board's surveys. He adds nothing to it.
- 2 AN CÈITEAN, SE 43** — *Tormod Pinn adds his own line to the list of gaps* (Muileann chaol). Riding the southern circuit his predecessor once rode, Tormod Pinn adds beneath Gormsbuil nic Dhùghaill's list of what the chronicle lacks a line of his own, that a gap named is worth more than a gap forgotten, and copies both into the chest that goes to the Library.¹⁷
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, SE 43** — *Dry years at Achadh shean* (Tiormachd Achadh shean¹⁸). Dry years come again to the country about Achadh shean, where the Long Drought settled in the humans' time. This time the council sends grain up the coal line and pays for it out of the Sloc Mòr's share. No one in the shire dies of hunger, and the chronicler records it.
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 43** — *The maor of Achadh shean petitions early* (Achadh shean). With three wells of the drove road gone brackish and a fourth dry to the stone, the maor of Siorrachd Achadh shean writes south before the second month of the dry is out rather than wait for the harvest itself to fail, and asks that a man argues with a poor harvest but a well gone to stone argues with no one.¹⁹
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 43** — *The wells of Siorrachd Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). The maor of Siorrachd Achadh shean has twelve wells dug to the rock along the drove road, each marked with the name of the shire and of the council. Water is drawn from four of them still.
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 44** — *A fifth well dug dry on a dowser's word* (Achadh shean). Of the twelve wells the maor of Achadh shean has cut along the drove road, one stands dry from the day it is dug, sited on a dowser's hazel rather than any surveyor's word, and the well-diggers own the fact afterward without much shame in the owning.²⁰
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 44** — *Grain by the coal line* (Achadh shean). The grain for Achadh shean comes from the store at Cathair fhada, and for the first time it goes by the coal line. The Rail Board charges the council for the carriage.

15. ← Follows from *Ros mhòr's boatyard*, 5 an Cèitean, SE 42.

16. the Library at Muileann chaol

17. ← Follows from *Gormsbuil nic Dhùghaill's last entry*, 25 an Giblean, SE 43.

18. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

19. ← Follows from *Dry years at Achadh shean*, 3 an Cèitean, SE 43.

20. ← Follows from *The wells of Siorrachd Achadh shean*, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 43.

- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 44** — *The first wagons reach Achadh shean in the rain* (Achadh shean). The Cathair fhada store's grain reaches the sidings at Achadh shean by the coal line on the morning the season's first proper rain falls at last, and the maor, standing in the mud he had prayed six weeks for, tells the carters the grain waited on the roof to prove it was not wanted.²¹
- 7 AN GEARRAN, SE 44** — *Raiders at Baile ìseal* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Raiders land near Baile ìseal on the far east coast and burn the salt-sheds of Àth bheag. The kingdom's patrol boats come two days later and find the sheds cold.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, SE 44** — *The salt-sheds of Àth bheag rebuilt* (Àth bheag). The burned salt-sheds of Àth bheag are raised again within the year, the Crown paying a third of the cost as it once paid a third of Cuan dhearg's relief, and the salt trade limps through the interval on what the barrels spared from the fire can carry.²²
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 44** — *The patrol captain's report on the two days* (Àth bheag). Called to answer before the shire's maor, the patrol's captain writes a report naming the distance, the wind and the hour the alarm reached his harbour; the Board judges it honest, and the households of Àth bheag, hearing it read at the market cross, judge it an accounting that answers every question but the one that matters.²³
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 44** — *Murchadh mac Coinnich's log* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal²⁴). Murchadh mac Coinnich, keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal, begins to enter in the lighthouse log every unlit ship he sees, with her heading and the hour. His logs, kept most of his life, are the fullest record of the eastern raiders in the library.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 44** — *The Board's inspector calls the Baile ìseal log the emptiest on the round* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal²⁵). The Lighthouse Board's own inspector, checking oil against entries at Taigh-solais Baile ìseal, tells Murchadh mac Coinnich that his log is the tidiest on the eastern round and the emptiest, a remark Murchadh takes for a compliment until he comes, within the year, to hear it differently.²⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 44** — *Murchadh buys a second book at his own coin* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal²⁷). Murchadh mac Coinnich buys, from a Muileann leathan binder a carter brings up the coast, a book of his own beside the Board's, in which he means to set down what the Board's own log has no line for: every ship that crosses under his light showing no lamp.²⁸

21. ← Follows from *Grain by the coal line*, 9 am Faoilleach, SE 44.

22. ← Follows from *Raiders at Baile ìseal*, 7 an Gearran, SE 44.

23. ← Follows from *Raiders at Baile ìseal*, 7 an Gearran, SE 44.

24. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

25. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

26. ← Follows from *Murchadh mac Coinnich's log*, 12 an t-Samhain, SE 44.

27. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

28. ← Follows from *Murchadh mac Coinnich's log*, 12 an t-Samhain, SE 44.

9 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 45 — *The pirates' names* (Àth bheag). The raiders fly no flag, and Murchadh mac Coinnich's log names their ships as the fishermen of Àth bheag name them. From his log the names pass into the royal record.

24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 45 — *The salt-carrier names the raiders' hulls* (Àth bheag). An old salt-carrier at the Àth bheag quay gives Murchadh mac Coinnich the coast's own names for two dark hulls that have crossed under his light unlit, An Ròn Dubh²⁹ for her low black run and An Fhaoileag³⁰ for a habit of standing off by day and closing only with the dark.³¹

23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 45 — *Murchadh's book copied fair for the royal chronicle* (Muileann chaol). A Library clerk carries Murchadh mac Coinnich's private log south, and Tormod Pinn draws the names An Ròn Dubh³² and An Fhaoileag³³ into the royal record from it, crediting no better source than a keeper's own ledger and the salt-carriers of a coast the patrol once answered two days late.³⁴

II AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 45 — *The Còmhrag at its height* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan³⁵). The Còmhrag draws its greatest crowd yet to Ceann leathan, and the fair-wardens build timber stands along three sides of the field. The champion is Ealasaid nic Coinnich of Àth ghlas, the first woman to win it. She does not fight again.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 45 — *Ealasaid nic Coinnich declines to defend the year's honour* (Àth ghlas). Asked by the fair-wardens whether she will defend the champion's honour the following year, Ealasaid nic Coinnich tells them a thing won once stays won whether or not she stands the field a second year, and returns to her family's trade at Àth ghlas.³⁶

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 45 — *Murchadh's first full year of the unlit ships* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal³⁷). By the second an Dùbhlachd of his own keeping, Murchadh mac Coinnich's private book holds above thirty crossings, most nameless still, ruled by a straight-edge and set on the shelf beside the Board's own log as the truer account of what sails the eastern water dark.³⁸

29. the black seal

30. the gull

31. ← Follows from *The pirates' names*, 9 am Faoilleach, SE 45.

32. the black seal

33. the gull

34. ← Follows from *The pirates' names*, 9 am Faoilleach, SE 45.

35. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

36. ← Follows from *The Còmhrag at its height*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, SE 45.

37. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

38. ← Follows from *Murchadh mac Coinnich's log*, 12 an t-Samhain, SE 44; ← Follows from *The pirates' names*, 9 am Faoilleach, SE 45.

THE YEARS SE 46 – 50

- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 46** — *The Hawk river port of Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Cnoc bheag, greatest town of the Hawk country, passes Cathair mhòr in its numbers. Its river quays take the grain of the north-central country, and its Hawk house is the richest of any order outside the capital.
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 46** — *Scoiltean nan Draoidhean*¹ *revived*. The druid schools of Flidais, silent since the humans ruled, open again. Their first question, why the vein answers some and not others, presses hard once more, for the vein itself is failing.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 46** — *Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's lectures* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²). The first teacher of the revived school is Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain. She lectures in the sacred wood of Flidais near Muileann chiar in the east, where the druids last met under the humans, and opens with the school's oldest question, plainly put: why the vein answers some hands and not others.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 46** — *The old druid houses mended before the teaching* (Muileann chiar). Before a single lecture is given, villagers near Muileann chiar mend the doors and sills of the long-shut druid house with green timber and their own hands, asking no wage beyond a bench kept for them once the teaching begins.³
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 46** — *An old cutter's son questions Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain* (Muileann chiar). After her first lecture in the sacred wood, an old man whose father kept the Holy Age strike-books asks Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain whether she means to answer her own question before she finishes teaching it. She tells him plainly that she does not.⁴
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 47** — *The druid schools in Siorrachd Baile gharbh* (Baile gharbh). The houses of the druid schools in Siorrachd Baile gharbh in the north-east, silent since the humans' time, open again at Baile gharbh and Àth fhada. Their teachers walk to the sacred wood to hear Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain, and walk back.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The school at Caol shean* (Caol shean). The druid school takes a house at Caol shean, one of the great druid towns of the east, and teaches there in the wet months, when the wood is too sodden for lectures. Its students copy the census note on the coal-touched and dispute it openly.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The Hawk given a place* (Cnoc bheag). A council of the Rite at Seann Skell offers the Hawk houses of Cnoc bheag a place under the high custodian with their own order of worship. The Hawk houses take the place and keep their order. After this the quarrel is quieter. It does not end.

1. the druid schools

2. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

3. ← Follows from *Scoiltean nan Draoidhean revived*, 12 an t-Samhain, SE 46.

4. ← Follows from *Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's lectures*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, SE 46.

- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The Baile gharbh teachers' first walk south* (Baile gharbh). Teachers of the reopened druid houses in Siorrachd Baile gharbh walk the better part of a week to hear Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain teach in the sacred wood before daring to open the question in their own halls, and do not miss a winter's walk after.⁵
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The census line argued by lamplight at Caol shean* (Caol shean). In the wet-house at Caol shean a miller's son newly come to the school asks why the census line for the coal-touched should be a matter no one may question, when the vein itself is questioned daily under the same roof; the argument runs past the hour the hearth is banked.⁶
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The Muileann dhearg hall given back to the school* (Muileann dhearg). The Guild of Hewers' captains give the school the hall at Muileann dhearg, shut since a gallery there closed three years before, on the one condition that nothing taught in it name a living captain or gallery; the school keeps to it gladly.⁷
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The Hawk's terms read a seventh time* (Seann Skell). At a council of the Rite at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the high custodian's clerks read the Hawk houses of Cnoc bheag the same settlement offered six times before; this time no witness raises the old objection, and the terms stand.⁸
- 7 AN GEARRAN, SE 48** — *The north-eastern harbours* (Caol chrom). Caol chrom and Caol gharbh on the north-east coast join their harbour dues to pay for a breakwater across the strait between them. It is eight years in the building and is the longest on the island yet.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, SE 48** — *Daniel Frayne's copying school* (Muileann leathan). At Muileann leathan in the north Daniel Frayne, a clerk of the Moot, teaches young Tuathaich to copy and bind books, since the guilds of that craft in the south will not take them. The bindings of Muileann leathan are found afterwards in Dia-thìrich libraries without their makers' names.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, SE 48** — *The Abhainn uaine ferries* (Cidhe Beag). The boat-landing at Cidhe Beag on the Abhainn uaine is licensed as a ferry, to carry passengers and small freight down the river toward the coast. The first to hold the licence is an old boatman who had worked the landing without one for forty years.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 48** — *Daniel Frayne opens his bindery at Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). Daniel Frayne builds a press from a mended cider-press and teaches young Tuathaich hands to fold, sew and board a book, a craft the southern guilds have never let a Tuathaich learn under their own mark; he asks no guild's leave to teach it.⁹

5. ← Follows from *The druid schools in Siorrachd Baile gharbh*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, SE 47.

6. ← Follows from *The school at Caol shean*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, SE 47.

7. ← Follows from *The school at Caol shean*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, SE 47.

8. ← Follows from *The Hawk given a place*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, SE 47.

9. ← Follows from *Daniel Frayne's copying school*, 23 an Giblean, SE 48.

- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 48** — *Frayne's first bindings sold south without his name* (Muileann leathan). The bindery's first plain-calf volumes, carrying no maker's name, are carried south with the wool carts and sold to Dia-threach households who praise the binding's neatness to Frayne's own face, none of them knowing whose pupils' hands had actually sewn the spine they hold.¹⁰
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 48** — *The first stone of the Caol chrom breakwater* (Caol chrom). Caol chrom and its neighbour across the strait lay the first stone of a shared breakwater, the longest yet built on the island, meant to close a strait that has drowned more boats in a hard winter than either shire's harbour dues could bear alone.¹¹
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 48** — *The old boatman's licence at Cidhe Beag* (Baile thais). The boatman who has rowed the crossing at Cidhe Beag on the Abhainn uaine for forty years without leave asked or given is granted a licence at last by the shire's maor, more for the shire's own records than for any change in how he rows or reckons his fare.¹²
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 48** — *Tormod Pinn marks the two Dùn thais west and east* (Dùn thais). Finding the Crown's returns beginning to run its two towns of one name together, Tormod Pinn rules a fresh line across the royal record marking Dùn thais in the west against Dùn thais in the east, and sends word to both shires' clerks to take more care.¹³
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 49** — *Loch chrom* (Loch chrom). The fishermen of Loch chrom, the only great lake of the island, are licensed to net its trout, which was kept for the Crown's table. Each year the Crown's table is served first.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, SE 49** — *The pillar at Cnoc chiar* (Colbh Cnoc chiar¹⁴). Students of the druid schools try to read the pillar near Cnoc chiar by setting it beside the obelisk at Cnoc bheag and the column at Cnoc ghorm. They find signs in common and no meaning. Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain writes that the Old Ones were here and said so, and that none living can hear it.
- 27 AN CÈITEAN, SE 49** — *Three slates carried to Caol shean* (Cnoc chiar). Three of Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's students ride from the sacred wood to copy the pillar near Cnoc chiar, the obelisk over Cnoc bheag's quays and the column at Cnoc ghorm onto separate slates, and carry them back through the rain to lay side by side.¹⁵
- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 49** — *A mark in common on three stones* (Caol shean). Comparing the three copied slates by lamplight, the students of Caol shean find a mark like a bent reed and a straight double stroke cut on all three stones and nowhere else known to them, and no meaning in either that any among them can bring out.¹⁶

10. ← Follows from *Daniel Frayne's copying school*, 23 an Giblean, SE 48.

11. ← Follows from *The north-eastern harbours*, 7 an Gearran, SE 48.

12. ← Follows from *The Abhainn uaine ferries*, 22 an Cèitean, SE 48.

13. ← Follows from *The Hawk given a place*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, SE 47.

14. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

15. ← Follows from *The pillar at Cnoc chiar*, 22 an Gearran, SE 49.

16. ← Follows from *The pillar at Cnoc chiar*, 22 an Gearran, SE 49.

- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 49** — *Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain writes the Old Ones' sentence* (Caol shean). Reading the three slates laid together at Caol shean, Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain writes that the Old Ones were here and said so, and that none living can hear what they said; her students copy the sentence into every school's minute-book after her.¹⁷
- 23 AM MÀRT, SE 50** — *Flood at Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). A storm tide floods the lower town of Inis chrom on the south-west coast and drowns the net-lofts and the rope-walk. The town builds both again on piles, and so they stand now.
- 26 AM MÀRT, SE 50** — *Inis chrom's lofts rebuilt on piles* (Inis chrom). After the storm tide drowns its net-lofts and rope-walk, Inis chrom does not ask the Crown for its rebuilding. Its own carpenters raise both a second time on driven piles a fathom above the old floor, timber floated down the Abhainn ghorm from the woods above Àth gharbh, the work finished before the autumn herring.¹⁸
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, SE 50** — *Cnoc leathan's schools* (Cnoc leathan). Cnoc leathan in the east opens a school in every one of its six parishes, paid from the shire's dues, the first shire to do so. The council asks how it paid for them and is shown the accounts.
- 13 AN CÈITEAN, SE 50** — *Cnoc leathan's sixth parish school* (Cnoc leathan). The last and smallest of Cnoc leathan's six new parish schools opens with eleven children on its benches and a teacher hired from Baile chiar. The council's clerk, sent to ask how the shire paid for six schools at once, is shown plain accounts and asks nothing further.¹⁹
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, SE 50** — *Alasdair mac Ùisdein's loan* (Cathair mhòr). Alasdair mac Ùisdein, grandson of the first holder of the Sloc Mòr concession, borrows against his house's share to pay for a search for a second vein. The Mine Board lends its surveyors. The Crown lends its name.
- 27 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 50** — *Catriona nic Neacail lent to the search* (Cathair mhòr). The Mine Board names eleven surveyors to Alasdair mac Ùisdein's search for a second vein. Catriona nic Neacail, thirty-two, a chain-hand risen through the vein-towns, is one of them, and tells a senior surveyor riding out with her that she would rather walk ground and find nothing than be told years on that nobody looked.²⁰

17. ← Follows from *The pillar at Cnoc chiar*, 22 an Gearran, SE 49.

18. ← Follows from *Flood at Inis chrom*, 23 am Màrt, SE 50.

19. ← Follows from *Cnoc leathan's schools*, 21 an Giblean, SE 50.

20. ← Follows from *Alasdair mac Ùisdein's loan*, 20 an Cèitean, SE 50.

THE YEARS SE 51 – 55

- 13 AN GIBLEAN, SE 51** — *The druid school on the search* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹). Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain writes to the Mine Board that the search asks the wrong question. The school has always asked why the vein answers some hands, she says, and no one has asked why there is one vein. The Board files the letter.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, SE 51** — *Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's letter read a second time* (Cathair mhòr). A Board clerk sorting the year's correspondence finds Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's letter on the search, filed unread when it was first sent, and carries it to Catrìona nic Neacail along with Mòrag nic Coinnich's. Catrìona keeps a copy of both beside her own last entry, though she judges the school's question and the Board's chain answer to different masters.²
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, SE 51** — *The search for a second vein*. The search for a second seam of the coloured coal elsewhere on the island is costly, and finds nothing. The same search had been made in the Age of Ailean, thousands of years before, and had failed in the same way; it had been forgotten.³
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, SE 51** — *The first shaft above Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). The search's first shaft goes down above Dùn dhearg in stone that gives every hopeful sign, the diggers wagering small coin among themselves on the day the vein will show. It is judged barren within the fortnight, the first entry in a tally that will run to forty-one.⁴
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 51** — *Forty-one dry shafts* (Dùn dhearg). The borings of the search run from the hills above Dùn dhearg to the moors south of Baile ruadh. Forty-one shafts are sunk, and none strikes the vein. Afterwards Mòrag nic Coinnich finds in a list of the Holy Age at the library the same hills named as searched and barren.⁵
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 51** — *The moor's own name, am Fearann Falamh*⁶ (Dùn dhearg). An old digger of Dùn dhearg tells Catrìona nic Neacail the moor's shepherds have long called the search's ground am Fearann Falamh, the empty ground, meaning only that no shepherd ever found a spring there worth the digging. The name outlasts the search's own hope of it.⁷
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 51** — *The forty-first shaft struck dry* (Baile ruadh). The last shaft of the search, sunk on the moor south of Baile ruadh through the hardest weather any of the forty had asked, strikes water at a depth no vein has ever answered. Catrìona nic Neacail writes the word barren in her own field-book a forty-first time and sits a while on the spoil-heap before riding to report it.⁸

1. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

2. ← Follows from *The druid school on the search*, 13 an Giblean, SE 51.

3. ← Leads to *Catrìona nic Neacail lent to the search*, 27 an Lùnastal, SE 50.

4. ← Follows from *The search for a second vein*, 21 an Giblean, SE 51.

5. ← Leads to *The first shaft above Dùn dhearg*, 18 an Cèitean, SE 51.

6. the empty ground

7. ← Follows from *Forty-one dry shafts*, 17 an Dàmhair, SE 51.

- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 51** — *Mòrag nic Coinnich finds the Holy Age roll* (Muileann chaol). Cataloguing the Library's lower room, Mòrag nic Coinnich finds a Holy Age survey naming the same hills above Dùn dhearg and moors south of Baile ruadh, searched once and found barren ages before, the surveyors' own names worn from the roll. She sends Catriona nic Neacail word the same week the forty-first shaft is closed.⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 51** — *The Library's copy of the old survey promised south* (Cathair mhòr). Catriona nic Neacail copies Mòrag nic Coinnich's letter into her own field-book beside her last entry and resolves to see the Holy Age roll sent south in copy, so that any surveyor sent to the same ground again will not have to wait on a keeper's own cataloguing to learn what the last search cost.¹⁰
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 52** — *Dùn dhearg's claim* (Dùn dhearg). The town of Dùn dhearg, whose hills held a dozen of the dry shafts, claims damages from the house of Mac Ùisdein for spoiled grazing. The circuit court awards them. The house pays a third before it sells.
- 12 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 52** — *Dùn dhearg's shepherds testify at the circuit court* (Dùn dhearg). At the circuit court's hearing of Dùn dhearg's claim, two shepherds swear that grazing spoiled by the search's spoil-heaps is lost longer than any digger reckoned, one saying he lost more lambs to the search's own open ground in two years than to wolves in ten. The court finds for the town.¹¹
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 52** — *The house of Mac Ùisdein sells half* (Cathair mhòr). To meet its debts the house of Mac Ùisdein sells half its share in the Sloc Mòr back to the Crown. Its stone house at Cathair mhòr is let to the Mine Board, which moves its offices there.
- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 52** — *The Mac Ùisdein stone house let to the Board* (Cathair mhòr). Its coin thinned by the search and Dùn dhearg's damages, the house of Mac Ùisdein lets its stone house at Cathair mhòr, kept in the family since the first holder's day, to the Mine Board, which moves its offices into it the following spring.¹²
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 52** — *The shafts at Baile ruadh left open* (Baile ruadh). The dry shafts of the search are left open on the moors near Baile ruadh. Sheep fall into them, and one child, before the shire fences them at its own cost. The shire's claim on the house of Mac Ùisdein for the fencing is never paid.
- 1 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 52** — *The child of Baile ruadh lost to an open shaft* (Baile ruadh). A child of Baile ruadh, out after a stray lamb on ground she has walked without harm a hundred times, falls into one of the search's uncovered shafts and is not found until the day after. The parish's own book holds her name and the day, and nothing more.¹³

8. ← Follows from *Forty-one dry shafts*, 17 an Dàmhair, SE 51.

9. ← Follows from *The search for a second vein*, 21 an Giblean, SE 51; ← Follows from *Forty-one dry shafts*, 17 an Dàmhair, SE 51.

10. ← Follows from *Forty-one dry shafts*, 17 an Dàmhair, SE 51.

11. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg's claim*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 52.

12. ← Follows from *The house of Mac Ùisdein sells half*, 5 an t-Iuchar, SE 52.

13. ← Follows from *The shafts at Baile ruadh left open*, 3 an Lùnastal, SE 52.

- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 52** — *Baile ruadh votes to fence the forty-one shafts* (Baile ruadh). The shire of Baile ruadh votes to fence every one of the search's forty-one shafts at its own cost rather than wait on the Crown, and enters a claim against the house of Mac Ùisdein for the fencing's cost that is never paid. The fencing goes up through the summer, post and wire round every covered mouth.¹⁴
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, SE 53** — *The Muileann dhombhain mills* (Muileann dhomhain). The mills of Muileann dhomhain in the south-east ground grain for the vein-towns. When the vein-towns' orders fall they turn to grinding bark for the tanners. The miller-families of the town keep their mark and change their trade.
- II AN GIBLEAN, SE 53** — *Muileann dhombhain's mills turn to bark* (Muileann dhomhain). With the vein-towns' grain orders thinned by scarce coin, the mills of Muileann dhomhain begin grinding bark for the coast's tanners instead of grain. The miller-families keep the mark cut into their stone before any shire held a charter to license it, and change the trade under it without asking the Board's leave.¹⁵
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, SE 53** — *A Muileann dhombhain miller answers a Board clerk* (Muileann dhomhain). Asked by a passing clerk whether it troubles her to grind bark at a wheel her family has ground grain at for four generations, the eldest of the Muileann dhomhain millers answers that a wheel does not know what is under it, and the grain will come back once the vein-towns have coin to buy it with again.¹⁶
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 53** — *The rope-makers of Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The rope-makers of Seann Tarr on the north-east coast are chartered as a guild, the last guild the restored custom makes for a trade the humans had not touched. Their hemp comes from the fields about Doire uaine and Achadh naomh.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 53** — *The rope-makers of Seann Tarr chartered* (Seann Tarr). The restored custom charters the rope-walks of Seann Tarr as a guild, the last trade the humans never touched to be given a charter of its own. Its hemp is carted down from the fields about Doire uaine and Achadh naomh by roads older than the survey lines that have tried more than once to straighten them.¹⁷
- I AN T-SULTAIN, SE 53** — *Seann Tarr's chest remembered* (Seann Tarr). By the shire's own rule the rope-makers' charter at Seann Tarr is kept in the shire's chest and not sent to Cathair dhearg. The shire keeper of Seann Tarr keeps a list of what the chest holds and sends the list alone.
- 15 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 53** — *Seann Tarr's chest sends only its list* (Seann Tarr). Asked to send the new rope-makers' charter south to the Board's own files, the shire keeper of Seann Tarr answers that the charter will stay in the shire's own chest, and sends a rider south with a list of what the chest holds and no more. No second rider is sent to ask again.¹⁸

14. ← Follows from *The shafts at Baile ruadh left open*, 3 an Lùnastal, SE 52.

15. ← Follows from *The Muileann dhombhain mills*, 9 an Giblean, SE 53.

16. ← Follows from *The Muileann dhombhain mills*, 9 an Giblean, SE 53.

17. ← Follows from *The rope-makers of Seann Tarr*, 5 an t-Iuchar, SE 53.

- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 53** — *The Circus at Inis àrsaidh* (An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn¹⁹). An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn is recorded again, pitched this time on the common near Inis àrsaidh in the west. The magistrate who licenses it enters the acts as 'various' and the fee as paid.
- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 53** — *The circus at Inis àrsaidh licensed as 'various'* (Inis àrsaidh). An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn²⁰ pitches again on the common near Inis àrsaidh. The magistrate who licenses its acts, unable to put a name to half of what he has watched, enters the whole of it in his book as various and the fee as paid, an entry the Library's copyists find hardest of the year to gloss.²¹
- 11 AM MÀRT, SE 54** — *Ceann mbin's fish-market* (Ceann mhin). Ceann mhin, the great port south-east of the capital, opens a covered fish-market over the old strand. Fish from Seann Bhral and the eastern grounds is sold there for the capital.
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, SE 54** — *Ceann mbin roofs its fish-market* (Ceann mhin). Ceann mhin opens a covered market over its old strand for fish carried up from Seann Bhral and the eastern grounds, the first roof the port has raised over the trade. The strand's old traders grumble at first, and grumble less once a wet winter lets them keep a fire by the scales.²²
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, SE 54** — *Edged tools banned from the Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan²³). A fighter is killed with a hewer's pick, and the fair-wardens of Ceann leathan ban edged tools from the Còmhrag. Staves and fists are still allowed, and so the deaths go on, fewer.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, SE 54** — *Edged iron banned from the Còmhrag* (Ceann leathan). After a fighter is killed at Ceann leathan with a hewer's pick carried in under a borrowed coat, the fair-wardens ban edged iron from the ring. Staves and fists are still allowed, and the dying goes on, slower, which a warden of long standing calls the whole of what the ban was ever meant to promise.²⁴
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 54** — *The drowned lighthouse keeper* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg²⁵). The keeper of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg on the south coast drowns going out to a boat aground on the reef below the light. The boat's crew are saved by his daughter, Ciorstaidh nic Artair, and she is given the keeper's warrant in his place.

18. ← Follows from *Seann Tarr's chest remembered*, 1 an t-Sultain, SE 53.

19. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

20. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

21. ← Follows from *The Circus at Inis àrsaidh*, 30 an t-Sultain, SE 53.

22. ← Follows from *Ceann mbin's fish-market*, 11 am Màrt, SE 54.

23. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

24. ← Follows from *Edged tools banned from the Còmhrag*, 8 an Cèitean, SE 54.

25. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 54** — *Artair mac Mhurchaidh drowns off Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg*²⁶ (Tobar dhearg). When a Doire shean fishing boat strikes the reef below the light in a hard south-west wind, keeper Artair mac Mhurchaidh, fifty-three, goes out alone with a rope and brings two of the four crew ashore, then goes back for the other two and does not return the third time, after above thirty years keeping that light.²⁷
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 54** — *Ciorstaidh nic Artair brings in the last of the crew* (Tobar dhearg). Waking to find her father's boat gone, Ciorstaidh nic Artair, three-and-twenty, takes the second boat out along his own rope's line and finds the wreck, her father's rope still fast to it. She rows the last two of the Doire shean crew ashore herself, a boat built for a lighter woman than she then is.²⁸
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 54** — *Artair mac Mhurchaidh buried above the light* (Tobar dhearg). Artair mac Mhurchaidh's body comes ashore three days after the wreck and is carried back to Tobar dhearg, to the ground above the light where every keeper before him lies. The parish register enters against his name the day, the manner, and the single word every drowning of that water is given: drowned.²⁹
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 54** — *The Board confirms Ciorstaidh nic Artair's warrant* (Cathair dhearg). Asked by the shire's own maor whether the daughter of a keeper who died bringing in four lives with two boats and one rope may keep the light he kept, the Board at Cathair dhearg writes back within the month that she may, and enters the warrant in her name without recorded debate.³⁰
- 11 AM MÀRT, SE 55** — *Ciorstaidh nic Artair's reef mark* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg³¹). Ciorstaidh nic Artair has an iron post set on the reef below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg, painted and hung with a bell. While she keeps the light no boat goes aground there.
- 22 AM MÀRT, SE 55** — *The reef post raised by subscription* (Tobar dhearg). Ciorstaidh nic Artair has an iron post sunk into the reef at low water, painted the red of danger marked and known, and hung with a bell cast at Muileann chiar. Half the cost comes from the Board's purse and half from a purse the fishing families of Doire shean and Tobar dhearg make up between them.³²
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, SE 55** — *The Board's engineer approves the reef bell* (Tobar dhearg). The Board's engineer walks the reef at low water and pronounces the post sound and the casting good. Asked whether she means to add clockwork to strike the hour as well as the danger, Ciorstaidh nic Artair answers that a man wanting the hour has a tide table and two eyes, and needs neither bell nor clockwork for that.³³

26. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

27. ← Follows from *The drowned lighthouse keeper*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 54.

28. ← Follows from *The drowned lighthouse keeper*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 54.

29. ← Follows from *The drowned lighthouse keeper*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 54.

30. ← Follows from *The drowned lighthouse keeper*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 54.

31. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

32. ← Follows from *Ciorstaidh nic Artair's reef mark*, 11 am Màrt, SE 55.

33. ← Follows from *Ciorstaidh nic Artair's reef mark*, 11 am Màrt, SE 55.

- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 55** — *Mary Coyle lays down the chair* (Caol mhòr). Mary Coyle lays down the chair of the Moot at Caol mhòr. Daniel Frayne of Muileann leathan follows her, the first speaker born after the Severance.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 55** — *The reef bell first rings in fog* (Tobar dhearg). In a fog thick enough to hide the light itself, the bell on its post rings of its own weight as the sea moves it, and every boat working that stretch of coast steers home by the sound alone. No boat goes aground on the reef below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg³⁴ that year, nor in any year Ciorstaidh nic Artair keeps the light after.³⁵
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 55** — *Mary Coyle lays down the chair of the Moot* (Caol mhòr). After two-and-twenty years in the chair, Mary Coyle lays it down at Caol mhòr, speaking of the register of the western pits' dead and maimed her hand began and the coal line her petitions never once moved south of Àth leathan, and names before the Moot rises the man she asks it to choose after her.³⁶
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 55** — *Daniel Frayne chosen speaker of the Moot* (Caol mhòr). Daniel Frayne of Muileann leathan, who bound books for the north's schools when the southern guilds would not take a Tuathaich name, is chosen speaker without a voice raised against him: the first to have been born after the Severance closed, and Mary Coyle's own right hand in the chair for above ten years before it.³⁷
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 55** — *The Fèill's northern day* (Fèill Muileann òg³⁸). The court of the fair at Muileann òg sets aside one day of the fair for goods from the northern shires. They are still sold through Dia-thìrich factors, but under the northern makers' own marks. It is the first time a Tuathaich name is written on anything sold there.

34. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

35. ← Follows from *Mary Coyle lays down the chair*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, SE 55.

36. ← Follows from *Mary Coyle lays down the chair*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, SE 55.

37. ← Follows from *Mary Coyle lays down the chair*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, SE 55.

38. the fair at Muileann òg

THE YEARS SE 56 – 60

- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 56** — *The Tuathaich marks at the fair* (Baile chiar). The first northern mark sold under its own name at the fair is the cloth of the weavers of Doire ghlais, a grey twill with a white thread at the selvedge. The southern weavers of Baile chiar begin to weave a white thread into their own.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 56** — *The Doire ghlais weaver's daughter sews by lantern* (Achadh mhin). At the fair's close on its first northern day, a Doire ghlais weaver's daughter left minding her mother's stall sews a second white thread into an unsold bolt after the buyers have gone. Asked why she troubles with it unwatched, she says the mark goes in whether anyone buys it or not, since a thread sewn only for show is no mark at all.¹
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 56** — *Baile chiar's weavers name their own thread pale* (Baile chiar). Rather than claim the white thread already spoken for, the weavers of Baile chiar work a grey scarcely darker than the wool into the selvedge of their own finer bolts. An old weaver tells Daniel Frayne, who asks why the south troubles to copy a northern habit, that she has woven forty years without her name on a bolt and does not mean to die without it.²
- 11 AM MÀRT, SE 56** — *The Depletion laid bare*. The quiet note of the survey in SE 26 is now an open trouble. The last unworked stretches of the vein are found, and they are smaller than any wish to own.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 56** — *Catrìona nic Neacail begins the one sheet* (Cathair mhòr). Catrìona nic Neacail, a Board surveyor sixteen years standing, begins drawing every stretch of the true vein still unopened onto a single leaf, working outward through the Board's own scattered rolls a shire at a time and riding to settle every ground the rolls disagree on.³
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 56** — *Catrìona nic Neacail's map* (Achadh dhomhain). Catrìona nic Neacail, surveyor-general of the Mine Board, publishes the map of the vein's last unworked stretches. It fits on one sheet. Within the year she gives up her post and goes to teach at the druid school at Caol shean.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 56** — *A concession-holder asks the sheet a plain question* (Cathair mhòr). A concession-holder of four generations' standing stands before the finished sheet the better part of an hour, then asks Catrìona nic Neacail plainly whether the red marked over his own family's ground means ten years or thirty, having daughters to settle and no wish to be told later that the Board had always known and never troubled to colour it in.⁴

1. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich marks at the fair*, 12 am Faoilleach, SE 56.

2. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich marks at the fair*, 12 am Faoilleach, SE 56.

3. ← Follows from *The Depletion laid bare*, 11 am Màrt, SE 56.

4. ← Follows from *The Depletion laid bare*, 11 am Màrt, SE 56; ← Follows from *Catrìona nic Neacail's map*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, SE 56.

- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 56** — *Catriona nic Neacail named surveyor-general* (Cathair mhòr). The Board names Catriona nic Neacail surveyor-general, an office left empty three years for want of anyone troubling to ask what it was for, until her one-sheet map of the vein's last unworked stretches made plain that somebody ought to answer for the whole of what it showed. She is the youngest to hold it in living memory.⁵
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, SE 57** — *Iain Mapa's survey found* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁶). Among the Board's files Catriona nic Neacail finds Iain Mapa's survey of thirty years before, which shows the same thinning she has just measured. She sends a copy to the library, with a note of when the Board received it.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, SE 57** — *Two surveys read side by side* (Cathair mhòr). Catriona nic Neacail sits late at the Board's own table beneath her own sheet, reading her map and Iain Mapa's thirty-year-old survey side by side by lamplight, the same failing ground marked out in the same terms three decades apart, and cannot say which survey troubles her more, the one that found the truth or the one believed too late to matter.⁷
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, SE 57** — *Catriona nic Neacail's visit to Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). Catriona nic Neacail rides east to Muileann chiar and sits with Iain mac Ruairidh, three-and-sixty and failing, in what proves his last spring. He shows her his own copy of his old survey with the Board's receipt still pinned to it, and asks whether the school at Caol shean still keeps its old question about the vein.⁸
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, SE 57** — *Iain Mapa dies* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, dies at Muileann chiar, where the Board sent him. His own copy of his survey is found among his papers with the Board's receipt pinned to it.⁹
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, SE 57** — *Iain Mapa buried by the silver guild* (Muileann chiar). The silver guild of Muileann chiar, which had paid Iain mac Ruairidh's small pension ten years, buries him with an ounce of its own refined silver laid beside him, its master saying over him that he had gone into more of the mountain's dark than any three men living and had never once come up lying about what he found there.¹⁰
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 57** — *Mòr nic Dhòmhnaill sends her husband's papers south* (Muileann chiar). Going through her husband's papers, Mòr nic Dhòmhnaill finds the folded survey with the Board's old receipt still pinned to it and sends the whole of it to the Library at Muileann chaol, writing only that he had asked more than once it not be lost a second time, and that she knew no safer place to send it.¹¹

5. ← Follows from *Catriona nic Neacail's map*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, SE 56.

6. the Library at Muileann chaol

7. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey found*, 9 an Giblean, SE 57.

8. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey found*, 9 an Giblean, SE 57.

9. ← Leads to *Catriona nic Neacail's visit to Muileann chiar*, 28 an Giblean, SE 57.

10. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa dies*, 8 an Cèitean, SE 57.

11. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa dies*, 8 an Cèitean, SE 57.

- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 57 — *Muileann dhearg empties* (Muileann dhearg). In a few years Muileann dhearg loses a third of its households to the ports. Its druid hall is shut, and its bell sold to the school at Caol shean, where it rings for lectures still.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 57 — *Muileann dhearg's maor counts the empty houses* (Muileann dhearg). Muileann dhearg's maor keeps a count of houses left empty as families leave for the ports and the southern yards, a tally kept at first from ordinary habit and then from something nearer alarm, running within three years to above sixty within the shire's own walls.¹²
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 57 — *The Fèidh ball's last teacher locks its door* (Muileann dhearg). The last teacher of Muileann dhearg's Fèidh hall, given back to the druid school not ten years before, locks its door herself for want of a congregation left to keep it and carries the key to the maor's own house rather than leave it with no one.¹³
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 57 — *Ceann leathan's coal quays idle* (Ceann leathan). Coal-ships wait at Ceann leathan for cargoes that come in half-loads. The harbour dues fall by half, and the fair-wardens raise the gate-price of the Còmhrag to make it up.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 57 — *Ruairidh the cellar boy* (Cathair mhòr). A clerk's boy of twelve who has fetched bundles in the Board's own cellar at Cathair mhòr for three years tells Catriona nic Neacail she is the first to ask him to read a label aloud rather than simply hand a bundle across. He helps her keep the tally of the week's search among the old presses.¹⁴
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 57 — *Catriona nic Neacail resigns the surveyor-general's office* (Cathair mhòr). Within the year of finding Iain Mapa's old survey, Catriona nic Neacail resigns as surveyor-general, the Board's own minute recording it in four flat lines, and asks a place teaching at the druid school at Caol shean, judging the mountain's own answers now the only lesson in her trade worth the passing on.¹⁵
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 57 — *Ceann leathan raises the Còmhrag's gate-price* (Ceann leathan). With the harbour dues at Ceann leathan fallen by half as coal-ships wait for cargoes that come in half loaded, the fair-wardens, whose town lives as much off the coal trade as off the yearly melee, raise the gate-price of the Còmhrag to make up what the quay no longer earns.¹⁶
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 57 — *The Muileann dhearg bell rings Catriona's first lecture* (Caol shean). Catriona nic Neacail gives her first lecture at Caol shean in the same wood where Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain once first put the old question to her students, and the bell taken down from Muileann dhearg's shut hall, hung now in the school's own tower, is rung for the first time to call the school in.¹⁷

12. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg empties*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 57.

13. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg empties*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 57.

14. ← Follows from *Iain Mapa's survey found*, 9 an Giblean, SE 57.

15. ← Follows from *Catriona nic Neacail's map*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, SE 56.

16. ← Follows from *Ceann leathan's coal quays idle*, 5 an t-Iuchar, SE 57.

- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 58** — *Baile Mòr dbombain's market* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). As the trade of the coal-towns falls away, Baile Mòr dhomhain in the northern hills becomes the market for the wool and hides of the hill country. For two years together its market day draws more carts than the fair at Muileann òg.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 58** — *Daniel Frayne notes the gaps at Muileann òg* (Fèill Muileann òg¹⁸). A wool-buyer at the Moot's own table tells Daniel Frayne that the fair at Muileann òg now stands with gaps between its tents where none stood before, the fair's own wardens filling them each year with a wider aisle rather than own that the crowd has thinned.¹⁹
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 58** — *Mairead crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Eòghan's reign ends in the decade that the Depletion becomes known to all. Mairead inherits a kingdom whose founding wealth is plainly failing, for the first time since the restoration.
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 58** — *The old die broken at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). With Mairead crowned, the die that struck Eòghan's own likeness on the realm-coin is broken at Cathair dhearg by the mint's custom, the old coin kept good until the new is struck in number enough to answer for it.²⁰
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 58** — *The Hewers bind no apprentices* (Achadh dhomhain). For the first time since its charter the Guild of Hewers binds no new apprentices. Its masters vote to keep the rolls open to the sons and daughters of members only.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, SE 59** — *Muileann shean's school of hewers* (Muileann shean). Muileann shean in the north opens a school for the sons and daughters of hewers who will not be bound, and teaches them to read, reckon and survey. Most of its first pupils go to the ports.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, SE 59** — *Daniel Frayne binds primers for Muileann shean* (Muileann leathan). Asked for primers by Muileann shean's own maor, Daniel Frayne binds forty copies of a reading-book at his own bench at Muileann leathan and sends them north on the first cart with room, the forms unchanged since he first set the type twenty years before.²¹
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, SE 59** — *Muileann shean's benches pass thirty* (Muileann shean). The school Muileann shean opened for hewers' children the Guild will not bind grows within the year from eleven pupils to above thirty, though three of the first eleven have already gone south to hire themselves out as chain-hands in the ports.²²
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 59** — *The Doire ghlas mills* (Doire ghlas). Wool mills are built at Doire ghlas with the Moot's money, the first works in the north that owe nothing to the vein. The Rail Board refuses their cloth, until a ruling of the circuit court at Seann Bhral compels it to carry any goods that pay the rate.

17. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg empties*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, SE 57.

18. the fair at Muileann òg

19. ← Follows from *Baile Mòr dbombain's market*, 30 an t-Sultain, SE 58.

20. ← Follows from *Mairead crowned*, 29 an Dàmhair, SE 58.

21. ← Follows from *Muileann shean's school of hewers*, 19 an Giblean, SE 59.

- 7 AN CÈITEAN, SE 59** — *The first bolt off the Doire ghlàs looms* (Doire ghlàs). The wool mills raised at Doire ghlàs with the Moot's own coin turn their first bolt, a grey twill with a white thread at the selvedge, and the overseer writes to Caol mhòr that it is better cloth than the south's own factors reckoned a northern loom could turn out.²³
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 59** — *The Rail Board refuses the first wagon* (Muileann leathan). The Rail Board's factors at Muileann leathan refuse to carry the Doire ghlàs mill's first wagon-load south to Muileann òg, giving no reason beyond the Board's own long custom of judging for itself what the line will carry.²⁴
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 59** — *The Moot brings its suit to Seann Bhral* (Seann Bhral). Daniel Frayne rides west to the circuit court at Seann Bhral with the mill's ledgers and the Board's letter of refusal, asking Ruairidh mac Phàdraig to rule whether a carrier chartered by the Crown may refuse one people's cargo and take another's.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 59** — *The Seann Bhral ruling* (Seann Bhral). Ruairidh mac Phàdraig, circuit justice at Seann Bhral, rules that the Rail Board is a carrier of the Crown and must carry for any who pay. It is the first ruling the Moot wins in a Dia-thìreach court. The Board appeals, and the council lets the appeal lapse.²⁵
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 60** — *The Crown's share of the Sloc Mòr* (Achadh dhomhain). The Crown buys the last working shafts of the house of Mac Ùisdein at the Sloc Mòr and leaves the house its share in the spoil and the quarry. Thenceforth the Board works the vein in the Crown's name alone.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 60** — *Word of Catriona nic Neacail's going* (Achadh dhomhain). A Board clerk's notice of the Mac Ùisdein sale reaches Caol mhòr with a passing word that the surveyor who drew the search's last sheet has resigned her post to teach at Caol shean, a name Daniel Frayne knows only at second hand.²⁶
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 60** — *The copper at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). Copper is found in the hills behind Àth fhiadhaich in the eastern hills. The Board opens a working with men laid off from the Sloc Mòr. It pays wages. It is not the vein, and the town's Seann Spioradan house gives it no blessing.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 60** — *The first Doire ghlàs bale rides the coal line* (Muileann leathan). A year after the ruling, the Rail Board's own factor at Muileann leathan weighs the first Doire ghlàs bale onto the wagon without comment, the same weight given any cargo that pays the rate, and Daniel Frayne rides down to see it loaded.²⁷

22. ← Follows from *Muileann shean's school of brewers*, 19 an Giblean, SE 59.

23. ← Follows from *The Doire ghlàs mills*, 27 an Giblean, SE 59.

24. ← Follows from *The Doire ghlàs mills*, 27 an Giblean, SE 59.

25. ← Leads to *The Moot brings its suit to Seann Bhral*, 23 an t-Sultain, SE 59.

26. ← Follows from *The Crown's share of the Sloc Mòr*, 30 an t-Iuchar, SE 60.

27. ← Follows from *The Seann Bhral ruling*, 31 an Dàmhair, SE 59; ← Follows from *The Doire ghlàs mills*, 27 an Giblean, SE 59.

THE YEARS SE 61 – 65

- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 61** — *Àth fhiadhaich's copper-town* (Àth fhiadhaich). The copper workings at Àth fhiadhaich draw miners from the failing vein-towns. The town builds a new street for them and names it for the Sloc Mòr, and the Seann Spioradan house there speaks against the name.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 61** — *The street named for the Sloc Mòr* (Àth fhiadhaich). Miners settled on Àth fhiadhaich's new street carry small lumps of coal from the Sloc Mòr's own upper galleries among their goods, keeping them for the plain fact of the carrying rather than for any use, while the Old Spirits' keeper tells the council a street named for another town's mountain risks forgetting the ground it stands on.¹
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 61** — *Dubhan begins his experiments*. Dubhan makes his first attempts to draw a fuel to stand in the coal's place from the waste of the mines. They fail, and little is set down of them.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 61** — *Dubhan's first working set down*. Tormod Pinn enters a single sentence in the day-book on a report from the north, that a young man there has made trials at drawing a fuel from the waste of the mines and that they have come to nothing; he writes no more of it.²
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 61** — *The Sloc Mòr's pumps* (Achadh dhomhain). The lowest galleries of the Sloc Mòr are let flood, for the pumps cost more to run than the coal beneath is worth. The Board's minute calls it a pause.
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 61** — *The last pump drawn out* (Achadh dhomhain). Tormod Pinn rides to Achadh dhomhain and finds the Sloc Mòr's lowest galleries eleven fathoms under water, the pumps cold on the Board's own order; the overseer there has kept the order's own slip folded in his coat since the turn of the season, as though he expected someday to need to prove it.³
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 61** — *The first pump goes down the coal line* (Achadh dhomhain). The first of the Sloc Mòr's three great pumps goes south under canvas on a flat wagon from a siding above Achadh dhomhain, bound for the new dry dock at Seann Bhral in the south; Tormod Pinn watches it pass and sets down that a pump goes where the water is and cares no more for the ground it served than a bolt of cloth.⁴
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, SE 62** — *The pumps sold* (Seann Bhral). The Board sells the great pumps of the Sloc Mòr to the harbour at Seann Bhral in the south, where they drain the new dry dock. In the next generation they are the only engines of the vein still at work.⁵

1. ← Follows from *Àth fhiadhaich's copper-town*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 61.

2. ← Follows from *Dubhan begins his experiments*, 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 61.

3. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr's pumps*, 13 an t-Iuchar, SE 61.

4. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr's pumps*, 13 an t-Iuchar, SE 61.

- 26 AN GIBLEAN, SE 62** — *The third pump follows and six men are found other work* (Achadh dhomhain). The overseer at Achadh dhomhain writes that the third and last pump has gone to Seann Bhral in the south after the second, and that the six men who tended the three between them have been found work on the galleries still above water, a thing the Board's own notice calls no loss to any household.⁶
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, SE 62** — *The maor of Baile dhombhain writes of the crossing* (Imrich nam Pantar⁷). A shire's maor writes to the Board of stock lost along Imrich nam Pantar near Baile dhomhain, a loss too large for wolves and weather; the Board's clerk, having no ledger fit to hold it, sends the letter on to the Library.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, SE 62** — *The panthers cross the south-west* (Imrich nam Pantar⁸). A great host of panthers crosses the south-west near Baile dhomhain. For a month the herders lose stock. Tormod Pinn writes it down as a thing named in the lists of the Holy Age and not seen in living memory.⁹
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 62** — *The old list of An Aois Naomh¹⁰ opened again* (Imrich nam Pantar¹¹). Tormod Pinn sets the maor's letter beside a Library list from the days of An Aois Naomh naming the years the panthers crossed before, an interval longer than any living herder's working life, and writes the crossing's entry longer than any other that year.¹²
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 62** — *The herders keep the crossing days* (Imrich nam Pantar¹³). The herders of the south-west drive their flocks off the old road beforehand and keep the crossing as a season of watching, losing fewer beasts in the end than the first week's count had feared, though more than an ordinary year costs them.¹⁴
- 13 AN T-IÚCHAR, SE 62** — *The hides of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Tanners at Baile ghorm on the south-west coast buy the hides of the panthers the herders kill, and their trade outlasts the crossing by ten years. Saddles of panther-skin from Baile ghorm are sold at the fair at Muileann òg under the town's mark.
- 18 AN T-IÚCHAR, SE 62** — *Baile ghorm's tanners buy the hides* (Baile ghorm). Buyers from Baile ghorm ride up into the hills within the fortnight to take the hides of panthers the herders' dogs and spears have brought down, paying a price the herders judge fair for a skin they have no other use for.¹⁵

5. ← Leads to *The first pump goes down the coal line*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, SE 61.

6. ← Follows from *The pumps sold*, 17 an Giblean, SE 62.

7. the panthers' crossing

8. the panthers' crossing

9. ← Leads to *The maor of Baile dhombhain writes of the crossing*, 5 an Cèitean, SE 62.

10. the Holy Age

11. the panthers' crossing

12. ← Follows from *The panthers cross the south-west*, 16 an Cèitean, SE 62.

13. the panthers' crossing

14. ← Follows from *The panthers cross the south-west*, 16 an Cèitean, SE 62.

- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 62** — *Panther-skins first at the fair* (Baile ghorm). The fair at Muileann òg sees, for the first time in any chronicler's memory, saddles and belts of panther-hide sold under the Baile ghorm mark, the southern buyers taken by surprise enough that the mark's own price doubles twice before the fair's ten days are out.¹⁶
- II AN LÙNASTAL, SE 62** — *Imrich nam Pantar*¹⁷ *in the chronicle* (Imrich nam Pantar). Tormod Pinn's entry on the panthers is the longest in his book for that year. He sets it beside the list of the Holy Age, and notes that the old list names the year after the panthers as a hungry one.¹⁸
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 62** — *Muileann mhin halves its lamp-making* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin halve their making for want of coal to fire their forges properly, the coal reaching the town thinner and dearer each season the Sloc Mòr's galleries give less of it up.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, SE 63** — *The coal-lamp shortage* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin halve their making, for want of coal to burn in the lamps they make. Shaft-lamps are lent from pit to pit, and the guild's minute-book records who lent to whom.¹⁹
- 14 AN GEARRAN, SE 63** — *The Guild's lending-book*. The Guild of Hewers keeps a plain minute-book at its hall for shaft-lamps lent from pit to pit, and Tormod Pinn, sending for a copy of its first year, finds more names entered against debts than against repayments, a dry column that tells the vein's own thinning more plainly than any Board letter.²⁰
- 16 AN GEARRAN, SE 63** — *The yard families stop the trains* (Muileann chrom). The yard families at Muileann chrom stop the coal trains for three days over a cut wage, putting forward as their spokesman Dòmhnall Ruadh mac Ailein, one-and-forty, whose father laid the yard's first rail; a Tuathaich minister there keeps his own book of the families' grievances.
- 18 AN GEARRAN, SE 63** — *Unrest at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The yard families at Muileann chrom stop the coal trains for three days over cut wages. On the fourth day the Rail Board settles; on the fifth it dismisses eleven men.²¹
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, SE 63** — *The Board settles and dismisses eleven* (Muileann chrom). The Board's factor restores the old wage on the third day and the trains run again on the fourth; on the fifth the Board's own notice names eleven men dismissed for their part in the stopping, Dòmhnall Ruadh mac Ailein among them, the settlement and the dismissal arriving from the same hand in the same week.²²

15. ← Follows from *The hides of Baile ghorm*, 13 an t-Iuchar, SE 62.

16. ← Follows from *The hides of Baile ghorm*, 13 an t-Iuchar, SE 62.

17. the panthers' crossing

18. ← Leads to *The old list of An Aois Naomb opened again*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, SE 62.

19. ← Leads to *Muileann mhin halves its lamp-making*, 25 an t-Samhain, SE 62.

20. ← Follows from *The coal-lamp shortage*, 10 an Gearran, SE 63.

21. ← Leads to *The yard families stop the trains*, 16 an Gearran, SE 63.

22. ← Follows from *Unrest at Muileann chrom*, 18 an Gearran, SE 63.

- 29 AN CÈITEAN, SE 63** — *Cathair fhada's granaries want a second storey* (Cathair fhada). The maor of Cathair fhada writes to Muileann chaol that the year's harvest has proved thicker than any since before the search for a second vein was spoken of, granaries built for a lean year now wanting a second storey to hold it.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 63** — *The hungry year that was not* (Cathair fhada). The harvest after the panthers' crossing is good across the south. Tormod Pinn records it and strikes through his own note of the year before.²³
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 63** — *Tormod strikes through his own note*. Tormod Pinn draws a line through his own entry naming a hungry year to follow the panthers' crossing, leaving the words legible beneath it and writing that the harvest proved thick rather than thin, since a chronicle owes its readers its wrong guesses as plainly as its right ones.²⁴
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 64** — *The third census after the Severance*. For the first time in the Rìoghachd the numbers of the people are published openly. It is a small token of openness, and nothing else is changed.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 64** — *Census clerks come north for a count* (Caol mhòr). Two census clerks ride to Caol mhòr, the first southern office to ask the Moot for its own count of its own people rather than take none, the shire's own maor having told the surveyor-general no clerk had yet gone north.²⁵
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 64** — *The Moot's figures given to the census clerks* (Caol mhòr). Daniel Frayne gives the visiting clerks the Moot's own count, kept every third year since the room was opened, along with the school and vigil registers, and offers to swear to the figures before a justice if the council should ask it.²⁶
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 64** — *Frayne's private book notes the asking* (Caol mhòr). Daniel Frayne writes the day's giving into his own private book, judging it worth the keeping that the Moot had, for once, been asked for its figures rather than merely tolerated in the giving of them.²⁷
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 64** — *The figures read at the Moot* (Caol mhòr). The published figures are read aloud at the Moot at Caol mhòr. They show the northern towns at about half the Dia-thìrich measure in every column the clerks chose to take. The Moot's minute says only: 'Now written.'
- 2 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 65** — *A young clerk asks what the two words mean* (Caol mhòr). Walking out of the room into the frost, a junior clerk asks Daniel Frayne whether the minute's two words oblige the south to answer for what it has printed; Frayne tells him a fact set down is not a promise kept, but cannot be unprinted either.²⁸

23. ← Leads to *Cathair fhada's granaries want a second storey*, 29 an Cèitean, SE 63.

24. ← Follows from *The hungry year that was not*, 7 an Lùnastal, SE 63; ← Follows from *Imrich nam Pantar in the chronicle*, 11 an Lùnastal, SE 62.

25. ← Follows from *The third census after the Severance*, 8 an Dàmhair, SE 64.

26. ← Follows from *The third census after the Severance*, 8 an Dàmhair, SE 64.

27. ← Follows from *The third census after the Severance*, 8 an Dàmhair, SE 64.

- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 65** — *The count of the touched* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁹). The published census, like the first, has a line for the coal-touched. It gives a number and nothing more. Tormod Pinn copies it into the chronicle without comment, as Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill did for the first.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 65** — *The census in the Stone's shires* (Doire shean). In the shires of Òrd na Cloiche³⁰ in the south-west the houses of the Stone publish for the first time their own count of their people beside the kingdom's. The two agree within a hundred.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 65** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³¹). Tormod Pinn dies at his desk at Muileann chaol. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh becomes royal chronicler. She is the first to add at the foot of each year a note of what the record could not learn.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 65** — *Tormod Pinn buried at Muileann chaol* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³²). Tormod Pinn, chronicler nine-and-seventy years old, is buried in the small ground behind the Library among every keeper and chronicler the house has kept since Ailean Leabhar; Mòrag nic Coinnich speaks over him that he kept the list honest and struck nothing from it unearned.³³
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 65** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first morning at the desk* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁴). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, chosen from the Library's own senior clerks, tells the house on her first morning as chronicler that she means to change nothing of the desk's hours, only its habit of silence where the record itself keeps none.³⁵
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 65** — *The Hawk houses' registers* (Ros gheal). The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Ros gheal send their birth-rolls to the library for the first time, on condition that they be filed under Òrd an t-Seabhaig³⁶ and not under Òrd Bhrìde³⁷. Mòrag nic Coinnich agrees.

28. ← Follows from *The figures read at the Moot*, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 64.

29. the Library at Muileann chaol

30. the order of the Stone

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. the Library at Muileann chaol

33. ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh*, 26 an t-Sultain, SE 65.

34. the Library at Muileann chaol

35. ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh*, 26 an t-Sultain, SE 65.

36. the Hawk order

37. the order of Bride's flame

THE YEARS SE 66 – 70

- 6 AN GEARRAN, SE 66** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first foot-note* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first note of what the record could not learn concerns the northern shires: the census clerks were told the figures and did not count them, and the figures they were told were the Moot's.²
- 8 AN GEARRAN, SE 66** — *Beathag's note sent north to Frayne* (Caol mhòr). A Library clerk sends Daniel Frayne a copy of Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first foot-note, naming the census clerks' reliance on the Moot's own figures; Frayne keeps it in his private book beside the day he gave them, judging her a chronicler the north may trust.³
- 7 AM MÀRT, SE 66** — *The record-chests called in* (Seann Tarr). Mòrag nic Coinnich's clerks go to thirty shire towns to bring their record-chests to Muileann chaol. At Seann Tarr the shire's keeper burns the chest sooner than send it, saying that the shire's record belongs in the shire. He is fined; the chest is lost.
- 8 AM MÀRT, SE 66** — *Mòrag nic Coinnich calls the shire chests in* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴). Mòrag nic Coinnich sends her own clerks along the roll to bring every shire's record-chest to Muileann chaol, judging a history kept in forty scattered chests no history at all but forty separate hopes of one day being read together.⁵
- 27 AM MÀRT, SE 66** — *The Seann Tarr keeper meets the clerks at the gate* (Seann Tarr). The shire keeper who burned his own chest at Seann Tarr meets Mòrag's clerks at the gate the next morning, his coat still smelling of the smoke, and repeats to them plainly that the shire's record belongs in the shire.⁶
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, SE 66** — *Cathair naomh sends its rolls* (Cathair naomh). The keeper of Cathair naomh in the north sends her shire's rolls to the library in two carts, with the town's own chronicle, kept by one family for four generations. Mòrag nic Coinnich enters it as the best-kept shire record received.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 66** — *Cathair naomh's chronicle carried south by its own keeper* (Cathair naomh). The eldest daughter of the family that has kept Cathair naomh's town chronicle four generations rides the two carts south herself and unpacks them at Mòrag nic Coinnich's own table, the chronicle begun by her great-grandmother on the back of an unused rent-roll.⁷
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 67** — *The Seann Toll chest* (Seann Toll). Seann Toll in the north sends its chest willingly and asks for a copy of all that is in it. Mòrag nic Coinnich's clerks make the copy, and the shire's copy is the pattern for every copy the library has made since.

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. ← Leads to *The Moot's figures given to the census clerks*, 14 an Dàmhair, SE 64.

3. ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first foot-note*, 6 an Gearran, SE 66.

4. the Library at Muileann chaol

5. ← Follows from *The record-chests called in*, 7 am Màrt, SE 66.

6. ← Follows from *The record-chests called in*, 7 am Màrt, SE 66.

7. ← Follows from *Cathair naomh sends its rolls*, 5 an Giblean, SE 66.

- 26 AN GEARRAN, SE 67** — *Seann Toll's copy becomes the pattern* (Seann Toll). The full transcription Mòrag's clerks make for Seann Toll, bound and set beside the original before either leaves the shire's hall, becomes the pattern every later shire's copy is cut to.⁸
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 67** — *The library enlarged* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹). Leabharlann Muileann chaol doubles its holdings and takes several lesser archives of the provinces into one record. From this time the history of Dia-thir is kept in one place and not in many.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 67** — *Frayne puts the calling-in to the Moot's own room* (Caol mhòr). Reading the notice of the calling-in, Daniel Frayne calls the room at Caol mhòr together and asks it plainly whether the Moot should offer its own books south now that the council has shown a wish to gather every shire's record.¹⁰
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 67** — *No northern chest* (Caol mhòr). No Tuathaich record is called in. The Moot's minute-books, the schools' registers, the churches' registers and the vigil-books of Baile chrom stay in the north, in private keeping, as they always have.¹¹
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 67** — *The Moot's minute declining to send its books* (Caol mhòr). After an evening's debate, the room's minute at Caol mhòr records no vote by count and no reason beyond two words its clerk sets down at the close of the sitting: *kept north*. No cart of the Moot's own books goes south that year or after.¹²
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 68** — *The library's new wing* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹³). The enlarged library is housed in a new wing at Muileann chaol, built of the grey stone of the Sloc Mòr's spoil. The chests of the provinces fill three floors. The fourth is left empty for what was not sent.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 68** — *The new wing's three floors and the empty fourth* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁴). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh walks the new wing at Muileann chaol before its chests are carried up, and finds three floors built to hold the provinces' returns, town chronicles and vigil-books, and a fourth, raised to the same measure, left empty for a record that has not been sent.¹⁵
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 68** — *Beathag's first foot-note on the empty floor* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁶). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh keeps Tormod Pinn's list at the front of the year's book unchanged and adds, beneath it, her own foot-note that the fourth floor stands ready and that no cart has come, judging the sentence plainer than any she could set beside it.¹⁷

8. ← Follows from *The Seann Toll chest*, 29 am Faoilleach, SE 67.

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

10. ← Follows from *The library enlarged*, 26 an t-Iuchar, SE 67.

11. ← Leads to *Frayne puts the calling-in to the Moot's own room*, 28 an t-Iuchar, SE 67.

12. ← Follows from *No northern chest*, 3 an Lùnastal, SE 67.

13. the Library at Muileann chaol

14. the Library at Muileann chaol

15. ← Follows from *The library's new wing*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 68.

16. the Library at Muileann chaol

17. ← Follows from *The library's new wing*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 68.

- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 68** — *The tally of the calling-in read floor by floor* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁸). Reading the whole tally of the calling-in set out floor by floor for the first time, Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh finds that every shire the council's roll accounted for sent something, willing or not, and that the one record never asked for is the one never received.¹⁹
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 68** — *The branch line to Àth leathan closed* (Àth leathan). The Rail Board shuts the branch line to Àth leathan, pleading the falling yield of the western pits. The Tuathaich pits go on working, and their coal goes by cart to the western ports and by boat from there.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 68** — *The Àth leathan branch shut for falling yield* (Àth leathan). The Mine Board withdraws its overseers from Àth leathan along with the branch line, its own wages no longer answering for the western pits' falling yield, and the pits pass, without any charter forbidding it, into the keeping of the hewers who work them.²⁰
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 68** — *The Moot's hewers take the pits* (Àth leathan). The Board's overseers are withdrawn from Àth leathan, and the Tuathaich hewers there go on working the pits under their own pit captains, paying the Crown's fifth under the Leòid ruling. The Board takes the payments and enters them as arrears.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 68** — *The Àth leathan hewers pay the fifth and are entered in arrears* (Àth leathan). The pit captains the Àth leathan hewers choose from their own number weigh every cart and set by the Crown's fifth under the Leòid ruling, sending word south each season; the Board takes the payments when a carrier brings them and enters them in its own books as arrears.²¹
- 18 AN GEARRAN, SE 69** — *The first Àth leathan coal carted to Seann Bhrál* (Àth leathan). The pit captains at Àth leathan send the season's first coal south by cart rather than by rail, three days slower on the road but loaded and sent on the hewers' own choosing, down to the coal factors' yards at Seann Bhrál in the west.²²
- 7 AM MÀRT, SE 69** — *Cnoc thais in the western hills* (Cnoc thais). At Cnoc thais in the western hills the Tuathaich pits pass to their hewers when the Board's overseers leave, and the father of the pit captain Tom Varley is chosen to keep the accounts. Here the town's own register of the pits begins.
- 9 AM MÀRT, SE 69** — *Sam Varley opens the pit's own book at Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). When the Board's overseer leaves Cnoc thais, Sam Varley, who has kept a private tally beside the Board's own scale for eleven years, opens a book of the pit's own accounts headed only with the day and the pit's name, the earliest page the town's register still keeps.²³

18. the Library at Muileann chaol

19. ← Follows from *The library's new wing*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 68.

20. ← Follows from *The branch line to Àth leathan closed*, 30 an t-Iuchar, SE 68.

21. ← Follows from *The Moot's hewers take the pits*, 28 an Lùnastal, SE 68.

22. ← Follows from *The Moot's hewers take the pits*, 28 an Lùnastal, SE 68.

23. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais in the western hills*, 7 am Màrt, SE 69.

- 18 AM MÀRT, SE 69** — *Tom Varley runs the book's errands* (Cnoc thais). Sam Varley's small son Tom, not yet old enough for the pit, carries the figures the book wants between the scale-house and his father's table; told that a book kept honest for nobody outlasts one kept honest only for someone watching, he carries them straight all the same.²⁴
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, SE 69** — *The Sligeanach's great year* (An Sligeanach Fad' às²⁵). An Sligeanach Fad' às, the roadside tavern by Ceann bhàn on the southern road, is sold to a family of drovers from Achadh mhòr, who build a second hall for the drove trade. It becomes the greatest house on the old mining roads.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, SE 69** — *An Sligeanach Fad' às²⁶ sold to a family of drovers* (An Sligeanach Fad' às). The family that kept An Sligeanach Fad' às three generations sells it to drovers new to the trade, who raise a second hall beside the first; within a few years it is the largest house on the old mining roads, grown fat on the drove trade as the coal roads empty.²⁷
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, SE 69** — *The eastern fishing grounds fail* (Seann Dunn). For the second year together the herring do not come to the grounds off the mouth of the Abhainn chaol below Seann Dunn. The east-coast boats go north to fish the grounds off Caol mhòr, which the licence law keeps for them, and the Tuathaich boats are pushed farther out.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 69** — *The herring fail a second year off Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). The herring do not return, a second season together, to the grounds off Seann Dunn, and the east-coast boats, finding their own waters empty, take to fishing the grounds off Caol mhòr that the licence law has long kept for the northern boats.²⁸
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 70** — *Inis mhin's boats* (Inis mhin). Pushed from their grounds by the eastern boats, the Tuathaich boats of Inis mhin fish the deep water beyond the northern isles. Two are lost in the first year and none after, and the catch of Inis mhin passes that of Caol mhòr.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 70** — *Inis mhin's boats pass Caol mhòr's own catch* (Inis mhin). Pushed from their nearer grounds by the crowding of east-coast boats, the boats of Inis mhin take the deep water beyond the northern isles; two are lost the first year and none after, and within three years the catch they bring in passes what Caol mhòr itself takes from the grounds the law still calls its own.²⁹
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 70** — *Raghnall mac Mhuirich, keeper* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁰). Mòrag nic Coinnich lays down the keepership after some thirty years. Raghnall mac Mhuirich, her deputy, becomes keeper of Leabharlann Muileann chaol.

24. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais in the western hills*, 7 am Màrt, SE 69.

25. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

26. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

27. ← Follows from *The Sligeanach's great year*, 5 an Giblean, SE 69.

28. ← Follows from *The eastern fishing grounds fail*, 4 an Cèitean, SE 69.

29. ← Follows from *Inis mhin's boats*, 30 an t-Iuchar, SE 70.

12 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 70 — *Mòrag nic Coinnich lays down the keepership* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³¹). Mòrag nic Coinnich, two-and-seventy and thirty years and more in the chair, lays down the keepership of the Library, walking the fourth floor once more with Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh and saying only that she built the room and leaves the asking to whoever holds the chair after her.³²

14 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 70 — *Raghnall mac Mhuirich made keeper* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³³). Raghnall mac Mhuirich, fifty that year, takes the chair Mòrag nic Coinnich lays down and changes nothing of the Library's hours or custom in his first year, a steadiness the clerks under him come to value in a season when little else about the kingdom's coal holds steady.³⁴

26 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 70 — *The coal price at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg³⁵). The Board cuts its sales, and the price of coal-fuel at the fair at Muileann òg doubles. The fair's court fixes a ceiling price and cannot hold it.

29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 70 — *The fair's ceiling set on coal and broken in every stall* (Muileann òg). When the Board cuts its sales and the price of coal-fuel at Muileann òg doubles, the fair's court sets a ceiling price by its long custom; within a season no factor sells at it, the coal not reaching the stalls at the named price, and the wardens do not cry the ceiling's breaking.

³⁶

30. the Library at Muileann chaol

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. ← Follows from *Raghnall mac Mhuirich, keeper*, 28 an Lùnastal, SE 70.

33. the Library at Muileann chaol

34. ← Follows from *Raghnall mac Mhuirich, keeper*, 28 an Lùnastal, SE 70.

35. the fair at Muileann òg

36. ← Follows from *The coal price at the fair*, 26 an t-Sultain, SE 70.

THE YEARS SE 71 – 71

21 AM MÀRT, SE 71 — *Beathag's foot-note on the capital's cold* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's foot-note for the year names what the record cannot learn: how many grates in the capital's poorer wards went unlit for want of coal, a count no census asked for and no shire kept, so that the Library holds no reckoning of its own kingdom's cold.²

26 AN CÈITEAN, SE 71 — *Coal thieves at Cnoc fhiadhaich* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). Households of Cnoc fhiadhaich are found picking coal from the spoil-heaps to burn, and the Board posts watchmen there. The watchmen are men of the town, and see nothing.

10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 71 — *The watchmen at Cnoc fhiadhaich see nothing* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The Board posts watchmen of the town itself over the spoil-heaps at Cnoc fhiadhaich against households picking coal to burn; every winter of the posting the watchmen see nothing, though the heaps grow lower and the poorer grates burn warmer than the fair's price could otherwise buy.³

17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 71 — *The capital's poorer streets burn short hours* (Cathair dhearg). In the capital's poorer wards the street lamps burn shorter hours than the council's lighting order requires, the keepers no longer able to afford in full an order written for coal at half the price it now costs; the council's own notice calls the shortening a saving.⁴

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. ← Follows from *The coal price at the fair*, 26 an t-Sultain, SE 70.

3. ← Follows from *Coal thieves at Cnoc fhiadhaich*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 71.

4. ← Follows from *Coal thieves at Cnoc fhiadhaich*, 26 an Cèitean, SE 71.

PART EIGHT

A Gazetteer of the Age

A

Achadh dhomhain (Muileann chrom). Founded 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 272. The pit town under the Sloc Mòr, at the head of the coal line. The line was mended through to its pithead in the twelfth year, and the first train out of it had its blessing said over the coal in the first wagon, the old custodian from Muileann dhearg being unwilling to walk the footplate. A quarry was cut above it in the thirteenth year and its dressed stone went south under the Mac Ùisdein wave-mark. The Guild of Hewers was chartered in the yard before its pithead on a cold day of an t-Samhain in the thirteenth year, each Dia-thìreach hewer swearing on a lump of coal, its Tuathaich families kept at their work. The guild bound sixty apprentices in its hall after the fall at Muileann dhearg, none of them Tuathaich, and forty households left for the ports that autumn. In the sixty-first year its lowest galleries lay eleven fathoms under water and its three great pumps went south by rail to Seann Bhral's new dry dock. Known for the Sloc Mòr's pithead, the hewers' oath, and the pumps.

Achadh gharbh (Caol shean). Founded 13 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,597. A village on the eastern road where the walkers to the holy well of Allt an Àigh¹ lodge on their way. In the tenth year it was raising a long hall for them, and in the eleventh the hall stood; its keeper, an old woman, wrote each walker's name and shire in a cracked-spined ledger, which held travellers from better than twenty shires that first summer and from fifty by the end of the decade, north and south and east and west of the island together on the one road. The under-clerk Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill lodged here a night with her mother, of an Old Spirits house, on their walk to the well in the tenth year, and thought of the ledger growing a name longer every year while the wall the council had talked of went undrawn. The cairn at the well itself, the keeper told them, grows a little taller every year. Known for the walkers' hall and its ledger.

Achadh mhin (Cnoc naomh). Founded 1 an Lùnastal, FE 738. A township a little way inland on the south coast, on fields the sea had never in living memory reached, until the Great Wave of the fourth year ran over its low ground and salted in one night what three generations had ploughed. The council moved its survivors to higher ground a mile inland before the winter closed the roads and paid for their seed from the treasury without a due asked, the first relief the restored kingdom granted anyone. The fields lay under salt for a generation. In the twenty-eighth year they bore again, and three households moved away after the wave, or their children in their place, asked for their old ground and were given it; the shire measured them back onto the same strips the humans' surveyors had cut, since those were the bounds the families still walked by memory. The chronicler entered its barley the night before word came of Brighde's death. Known for the first relief, and the fields that bore again.

1. the stream of the healing water

Achadh shean (Achadh shean). Founded 21 an Giblean, GE 3,125. A shire of the drove road where the ground failed once before in the humans' time and was given a name for it that its people never forgot, *Tiormachd Achadh shean*², the drought of the old field. In the forty-third year the rains of am Màrt held off into an Cèitean and the wells of the drove road went brackish and then, three of them, dry to the stone. Its maor, a careful man who kept his own tally, wrote south before the second month of the dry was out, holding that a man argues with a poor harvest but a well gone to stone argues with no one, and cut twelve new wells along the road, one of them dry from the day it was dug on a dowser's word. The council answered faster than the north had ever known it to answer: grain from the Crown store at Cathair fhada reached the town's sidings by the coal line on the morning the first proper rain fell. Known for the dry years and the grain by rail.

Àth àrsaidh (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 12 an t-Samhain, GE 3,458. A town an easy day's ride from Caol mhòr, seat of a northern shire. Its maor's chest was the one the northern shires filled for the first chronicle circuit in the nineteenth year, and Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill found in it the maor's returns and nothing more, not a line in a Tuathaich hand, and wrote the fact down without a further word. Eachann mac Rath practised physic here twenty years under his guild's charter. In the thirty-fourth year he took Ruth Ashby and Clara Tulloch, two women of the fishing country, to learn by watching him set bones and mix poultices through a fever season; a factor's wife let slip at a fair stall that his new girls handled a lancet as steady as he did, and the guild struck him from its rolls. He kept his surgery open all the same. Known for the Tuathaich doctors.

Àth bheag (Àth bheag). Founded 26 an Cèitean, GE 4,347. A salt town on the tidal flats of the east coast below Taigh-solais Baile ìseal³, worked by Dia-thireach ford-keepers, its boats crewed as often by Tuathaich hands as not. Its flats were dug for salt-pans in the thirty-second year and it was soon supplying salt up the coast. In an Gearran of the forty-fourth year flagless ships came in under cloud and burned its three salt-sheds; the patrol came two days late, and the households judged the captain's honest report an accounting that answered every question but the one that mattered. The sheds were raised again within the year, the Crown paying a third. An old salt-carrier on its quay gave Murchadh mac Coinnich the coast's names for the raiders' hulls, An Ròn Dubh⁴ and An Fhaoileag⁵, which the royal chronicle took from the keeper's own log. Mòrag nic Coinnich was made the Library's deputy on the road home from it. Known for the salt-sheds burned, and the raiders named.

2. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

3. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

4. the black seal

5. the gull

Àth fhada (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 18 am Màrt, LE 908. A Tuathaich village on the old road the north calls the Carters' Road, between Cnoc ghorm and the low ground short of Inis àrsaidh. When the Rail Board would not carry the north's wool in the fortieth and forty-first years, the carts went south through it five days to the fair at Muileann òg, and a widow of the village who had fed carters at her own table for two winters, her husband lost under the western pits, began to take payment and keep a lamp lit past every other house's hour; it was the first inn on the road, and two more households lit lamps within the season. Daniel Frayne lodged under her lamp and learned from her the road's northern name, and her husband was the first name entered in Clàr nan Leòn⁶. A carter from beyond it brought Walter Hale the last grievance he settled. Its druid house opened again in the forty-seventh year with Baile gharbh's. Known for the first lamp on the Carters' Road.

Àth fhiadhaich (Àth fhiadhaich). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,325. A town of the eastern hills by a ford where its river fishers still bless their nets, whose Seann Spioradan house keeps the oldest folk rite on the island. Copper was found in the hills behind it in the sixtieth year, and the Board opened a working within the season with men laid off from the Sloc Mòr's thinning galleries. The house gave the copper no blessing, its keeper telling the Board's factor that copper dug for a wage was copper dug like any other stone. By the second summer the town had built a street of new stone houses for the miners on the slope above the ford and named it, before the last house had a roof, for the pit they had come from, Sràid an t-Sluic⁷; the miners kept small lumps of the Sloc Mòr's coal among their goods, and the house's keeper told the council a street named for another town's mountain risked forgetting the ground it stood on. Known for the copper, and the street of the pit.

Àth leathan (Seann Skell). Founded 8 am Màrt, LE 1,303. A gathering of pits and shanties in the western hills where Tuathaich hewers had worked the coal since before the kingdom drew a road to them. In the thirteenth year the Rail Board built a spur of thirteen miles to it off the western branch, because the coal was cheap to lift and the carters' road worse each winter. After the fall at Muileann dhearg the Board's new timbering rule was posted on its pit-head door and the timber ordered from Ceann mhòr, and the timber never came; the hewers went on under the old props, and Mary Coyle named the town in her letter to the Board. In the sixty-eighth year the Board withdrew its overseers and the branch together, and the pits passed to the hewers, who chose captains, weighed every cart and set by the Crown's fifth under the Ledid ruling; the Board entered the payments as arrears. From the sixty-ninth year its coal went to Seann Bhràl by cart. Known for the pits the hewers kept.

6. the register of the wounded

7. the street of the pit

B

Baile chlar (Baile chlar). Founded 1 an Gearran, FE 869. A weaving town of the south whose weavers took a guild charter in the fifteenth year: the council's clerks cut them a seal of a shuttle over a fleece and entered the grant in a calf-bound book at Cathair dhearg after a fee and a feast, and the guild barred any weaver who had not served seven years under a master. Its pipers played for coin at the first fair at Muileann òg, and its cloth came to that fair from its looms. A drought at the town went into the royal chronicle in the twenty-eighth year beside Brighde's death. Its maor petitioned in the thirty-eighth year that Doire chaol, five miles off, had outgrown being governed at second hand, and the new shire was cut from his, the only shire cut new since the drawing; he sent its first dues south with a note wishing its maor better luck. In the fifty-fifth year its weavers began a grey thread of their own in the selvedge of their finer bolts. A teacher from the town kept the smallest of Cnoc leathan's six schools. Known for the weavers' seal, and the cutting of Doire chaol.

Baile chrom (Baile chrom). Founded 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464. A scatter of grey houses above a shingle beach where the coast turns, its nets strung to dry on frames mended every spring with the fathers' twine. It kept one of the five beacons on the capes, whose keeper wrote on the first morning of the age that no ship came. Its small church in a net-store answered to the same distant bishops as the great one at Cnoc ghorm. In the ninth year the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane kept the Mystery of the Grey Night in the open on the headland below the old light, as no keeper had kept it before; the bishops called it irregular in a letter that stayed folded behind the altar-cloth. The magistrate fined her for it in the twenty-seventh year, the Moot paid the fine, and the vigil went into a lent byre. In the seventeenth year the town's light was given a Dia-threach keeper under a warrant bidding him report what he saw by land as well as by sea, and in the thirty-second year he reported the vigil kept silent in the tower's shadow; the council answered nothing. Known for the Grey Night on the headland, and the fifth light.

Baile gharbh (Baile gharbh). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 2,662. The seat of a north-eastern shire whose old druid houses had stood roofless and silent since the humans first ruled there. Within half a year of Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's first lecture in the sacred wood, in the forty-seventh year, the houses of the shire at the town and at Àth fhada opened their doors on the old question again, and their teachers walked the better part of a week south to hear her before daring to teach it in their own halls, and did not miss a winter's walk after. The youngest of them, a woman not yet twenty on her first journey south, wrote of it in the school's own minute-book. Seonaid's sentence on the three stones was copied into every school's minute-book from Muileann chlar to this town. Known for the druid houses reopened.

Baile ghorm (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 622. A tanning town of the south-west coast. When the panthers crossed the hill country near Baile dhomhain by Imrich nam Pantar¹ in the sixty-second year, its tanners heard of it before the herders had finished counting their losses and sent buyers up into the hills within the fortnight for the hides of the cats the herders' dogs and spears brought down, at a price the herders judged fair. They cured the skins through the summer, and the next year's fair at Muileann òg saw saddles and belts of panther-hide sold under the town's mark for the first time in any chronicler's memory; the price of the mark doubled twice before the fair's ten days were out. Known for panther-hide under the town's mark.

Baile Mòr dhomhain (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 24 an t-Samhain, FE 101. A market town on the deep river in the northern hill country. As the coal-towns' trade fell away its market became the market for the wool and hides of the hills, and in the fifty-seventh and fifty-eighth years its market day drew more carts than the fair at Muileann òg, a thing no one living could remember any market doing. A wool-buyer from its hills told Daniel Frayne of it at the Moot's table, and Frayne entered it in the room's ledger under no heading that fit, since it was not Moot business and yet seemed to him to be. Known for the market that passed the fair.

Baile Mòr fhionn (Caol leathan). Founded 6 an t-Samhain, FE 584. A town of the south-west, seat of houses of Òrd na Cloiche², the Stone, whose Clach is the Lia Fàil³ and not Crom's stone. In the seventh year its houses were bidden to send witnesses to the settling of the Rite at Seann Skell; they sent none, and a letter wishing the Rite well and promising nothing further, which Dòmhnall mac Thor-moid copied onto the first page of his ledger of letters. The Stone kept its own houses, its own mark cut plain over its doors, and its own dealings through the age: it lent coin against a town's dues where a town's need outran a maor's patience, and its paper stood for coin at Inis thais until the coin came. Known for the Stone standing aside.

Baile Mòr mhòr (Baile Mòr mhòr). Founded 13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616. The market town of the middle country, seat of its own shire. Its courthouse burned in the last summer of the war, and when Coinneach mac Ailein, a custodian's younger son, came as its first maor in the fourth year he held his court under the market roof among the fish-scales. When a new courthouse was raised two years on he sat in it for exactly one sitting and moved back to the market hall the week after, and the two maor who followed him did the same, until holding court under the scales became simply how justice was done in the town and no one thought to write down why. Ailean mac Iain had ridden no further north than its market before the Severance, and he rode its letters to it again when the maor were named. Its roll of arms and its dues were entered in the fourth year with the rest of the kingdom's. Known for the court held under the market roof.

1. the panthers' crossing

2. the order of the Stone

3. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

Baile ruadh (Baile ruadh). Founded 3 an Dàmhair, FE 971. A town of red-earth fields in the east, where the barley fails on the thin soils every few years; in the hungry year of the twelfth, families walked from it to the pit towns for wages paid in coin. The search for a second vein ended on the moor south of it in the fifty-first year, the forty-first shaft striking water at a depth no vein had ever answered. The shafts were left uncovered; sheep fell into them the first winter, and before the next summer was out a child of the town fell into one and was not found until the day after. The parish book holds her name and the day. The shire met in the same low room where it had argued its dues and voted to fence every shaft on its ground at its own cost, post and wire round every mouth, and entered a claim against the house of Mac Ùisdein for the fencing that was never paid. Known for the fenced shafts.

Baile thais (Muileann dhearg). Founded 5 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,086. The town where the coal road from the central mountains comes down to the Abhainn uaine above the gulf. It grew a different way from the pit towns in the twelfth year, taking in carters, inns and a ropewalk, doubling its people within a decade and being given a shire court. Its carters carried the news of the coast south; it was from a carter of the town that Iain Mapa first heard of the raiders off Cathair gheal, third-hand and late. A quarryman of the town put Calum Ruadh down twice in the first hour of the first Còmhrag, and stood over him laughing the second time. Known for the coal road's river crossing.

C

Caol chrom (Caol gharbh). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,275. A harbour of the north-east coast, facing Caol gharbh across a strait that had drowned more boats in a hard winter than either town's harbour dues could bear. In the forty-eighth year the two shires joined their dues to pay for a breakwater across the strait between them, and laid its first stone that spring. It was eight years in the building and is the longest yet built on the island. Known for the shared breakwater.

Caol leathan (Caol leathan). Founded 12 am Faoilleach, GE 1,560. A small harbour town and the seat of the greatest house of Òrd na Cloiche¹, a low stone hall behind the harbour with the Stone's own mark cut plain over the door and nothing of the state's arms on it. In the twenty-first year the order rebuilt the house at its own cost and raised a low tower over its western gable, and hung in it a bell cast, the priests said, from coin given by every ship that had put in at the harbour and come home again. It is not a large bell, nor heard much past the town walls, but the town needed nothing heard past them: from that year the bell rang the hours, the market opened by it, and the harbour court and the fair court both sat by it, until within a year nobody in the town reckoned the time any other way. Known for the Stone's bell that rings the hours.

1. the order of the Stone

Caol mhòr (Caol mhòr). Founded 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462. The harbour town where the council's word fixing the Tuathaich homeland was read aloud on the twenty-second of am Màrt in the first year, and where Walter Hale rendered it into the humans' tongue. In the second year the households met in the long room behind the harbour and opened the Moot's book, and the Moot sat here for the rest of the age: it voted grain against the winter, petitioned for the exchange of the cried-down coin, opened lifeboat and school purses, paid Cathair gheal's fine and Hannah Crane's, and kept its own minutes, counts and registers in the north. Walter Hale sat as its first speaker for thirty-one years and was buried in sight of its house in the thirty-third year; Mary Coyle followed him, the first woman in the chair, and Daniel Frayne after her. Its fishermen lost the southern grounds to the licence law of the thirtieth year. In the sixty-seventh year the room declined to send its books south to the Library, and the clerk entered two words, kept north. Known for the Moot, and the two words kept north.

Caol shean (Caol shean). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 4,196. A town near the stag's grove of Muileann chiar, where the druid school kept a wet-house for the months when the grove stood ankle-deep and no fire would stay lit under the bare oaks. Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain took the house after her first winter's teaching, and in it her students argued the census line for the coal-touched by lamplight past the banking of the hearth. Three of them laid on its long table in the forty-ninth year slates copied from the pillar near Cnoc chiar, the obelisk at Cnoc bheag and the column at Cnoc ghorm, and found a mark like a bent reed and a straight double stroke on all three, which none could read. Catriona nic Neacail came to teach here in the fifty-seventh year after resigning as surveyor-general, and the bell from Muileann dhearg's shut hall, bought on that shire's vote, rang in the school's tower to call her first lecture. Known for the druid school's wet-house, and the three slates.

Cathair dhearg (Cathair dhearg). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18. The capital held the council of twelve from the second year of the age, seated at a table too large for the room that held it, and every warrant, ruling and refusal of the kingdom went out from it. In the first summer the disbanded companies waited in its market square to be stood down, and sixty-one company rolls were carried into the vaults under the counting-house and bricked in. Niall was crowned here in the third year, Brighde in the twenty-second and Eòghan in the twenty-eighth, and Mairead in the fifty-eighth; the bells of Òrd Mhacha² rang a day and a night for Niall's death. The mint struck the realm-coin here from the fifth year, the Rail Board kept its low grey office here, and the Mine Board sat here until the twenty-seventh year, when it went to Cathair mhòr. The guild court heard the indentures and the yards' protests in its chambers. A second census was locked in the council's keeping-room in the thirty-third year and never aired. By the end of the age the lamps of its poorer wards burned shorter hours than the council's lighting order required, for want of coal at the price the order was written for. Known for the council's table, the mint, and the crownings.

Cathair dhomhain (Cathair dhomhain). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634. A harbour town of the south-west, where the custody-book of the old vein-house on the hill above the harbour was kept until the house closed it. Eilidh nic Leòid was born here and spent her whole working life in its counting-house and harbour court, copyist, recorder and at last justice in all but name. In the eighth year she was made circuit justice of the south-west and held her first assize here before she had properly left the town, measuring an orchard boundary with knotted cord. She set out from it with Murchadh Clàrc and a satchel of blank record-books, and it was here, within sound of the harbour, that she died in the sixteenth year with the gathered book of her rulings finished on the table by her bed. The fishing villages that feed its market lie along the coast road south from Seann Bhràl. Known for Eilidh nic Leòid's town.

Cathair fhada (Cathair fhada). Founded 13 an Cèitean, GE 2,523. A town of the southern plain. In the thirty-third year the Crown's grain-store here was finished, two winters building and one summer roofing, a hall of dressed stone long enough that a loaded cart could turn inside it, great enough to feed the south a season, filled from the south's own harvests. It opened its doors first in a poor season that same year, and in the forty-third it fed the dry country about Achadh shean, its grain reaching the sidings there by the coal line on the morning of the first rain. In the sixty-third year the harvest came in so thick that the maor wrote to Muileann chaol of granaries built for a lean year wanting a second storey, and Tormod Pinn struck through his own note of a hungry year to come. Known for the Crown's grain-store.

2. the order of Macha

Cathair gheal (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 5 an Màrt, GE 1,378. A walled town of the north-west coast, its harbour a shallow bay below the town wall. In the second year its people loosed the humans' locked loft of nets to every boat in the harbour on a single tide. From the twelfth year ships flying no flag worked its waters; a fishing house was burned below the town and two boats taken, and the council's minute asked that the matter be watched. In the twentieth year Nell Barrow, a skipper's widow, wrote twice to the council for a boat or leave to arm its own and was answered by neither letter. On the night of 8 an Giblean three flagless hulls stood into the bay; the largest ran onto a shifted bar and was boarded and burned by seven town boats before dawn, at a cost of two dead and four hurt. The council fined the town four purses of the realm-coin for bearing arms without leave, and Walter Hale carried the Moot's share of it north; the fine was counted out at the maor's door. Known for the bay cleared, and the fine paid.

Cathair mhòr (Cathair mhòr). Founded 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847. The mountain town of the house of Mac Ùisdein, whose family had held an overseer's post under the humans at the Sloc Mòr. Uisdean mac Ùisdein came from it to the capital in the eleventh year to take the Sloc Mòr concession, and in the twentieth year the house raised a market cross at its own cost, cut on all four faces with its name, and moved the wool and coal markets to its foot. The Mine Board moved its clerks here in the twenty-seventh year, into rooms above the wool market, and set down that its surveys should be kept in its own presses and not sent to the Library. The house built its stone hall of spoil-stone in the thirtieth year and feasted the Guild of Hewers in it. After the search for a second vein the house let the hall to the Board in the fifty-second year, and Catriona nic Neacail hung her one sheet of the vein on its chamber wall in the fifty-sixth. Known for the house of Mac Ùisdein, and the Board's presses.

Cathair naomh (Seann Toll). Founded 22 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,162. A town of the north whose chronicle has been kept by one family through four generations without a council's asking, begun by a great-grandmother on the back of an unused rent-roll. When Mòrag nic Coinnich called in the shire chests in the sixty-sixth year, the family's eldest daughter packed the town's rolls and chronicle into two carts herself and rode them south rather than trust a hired carter, and unpacked them at Mòrag's own table. Mòrag entered it as the best-kept shire record the Library received. Known for the family chronicle of four generations.

Ceann àrsaidh (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 17 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328. A town on the Abhainn fhionn east of the capital, seat of custodian houses of the east. Its ship-chandlers took a guild charter in the fourteenth year and with it the sole right to fit out the Crown's patrol boats, and the yearly fitting-out became the guild's show of its charter before the shire's maor. Seumas mac Coinnich Ghlais, who sat for the eastern custodian houses at the council's table, was a man of the town, and it was he who brought a map to the council in the tenth year and proposed the border wall, and saw it die without a vote. Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill's mother lived in a village by it, and the two parted here on the eastern road after the walk to Allt an Àigh³. A room over a chandler's shop here was the last of the eleven northern schools the Moot counted in the twenty-ninth year. Known for the chandlers and the patrol boats.

Ceann leathan (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, GE 2,061. A town of the south where the droves from Muileann fhionn came down to market and where the fair-wardens grazed the fair's horses on rising ground outside the walls. In the twenty-third year the wardens called an old custom of arms the Còmhrag, the melee, and fought it on that field, drawing men from every vein-town within two days' walk; Calum Ruadh of Muileann chrom won it, took a year's wages and the right to bear arms, and four inn-keepers who had built new houses for the crowd kept his table free. Two men died in the first and six in the thirty-sixth year, and the wardens refused the custodians' petition to end it within the hour; the circus pitched on the trampled ground a week after the six burials. The coal line reached the town the same season and its quays spread half a mile past the old gate. Ealasaid nic Coinnich of Àth ghlas won it in the forty-fifth year and did not fight again; edged iron was banned from the ring in the fifty-fourth. By the fifty-seventh year its coal quays stood half idle and the wardens raised the gate-price. Known for the Còmhrag.

Ceann mhin (Ceann mhin). Founded 18 an Lùnastal, FE 745. The great port south-east of the capital. In the ninth year its shire closed the old burial ground at Cnoc dhireach to new graves, the vines having split so many stones that no clear plot could be found without turning up someone else's dead. In the fifty-fourth year it opened a covered market over its old strand for the fish that came up from Seann Bhrál in the south and from the eastern grounds, the first roof the port had raised over that trade, so that the buyers of the capital could stand dry-shod while they haggled; the strand's old traders grumbled at first and less once a wet winter let them keep a fire by the scales. Known for the covered fish-market.

Ceann mhòr (Ceann mhòr). Founded 6 an Cèitean, FE 163. The harbour of the north-west where a fisherman with a hammer and a bad temper broke the lock of the humans' harbour store in the second year, and the town, not the man, shared out rope, canvas and salt by the same rough justice that had shared a thin catch at Caol mhòr. Its fishermen traded in the broken store for two years on their own custom, and in the third year the council granted them a market right for the north-west coast, the smallest clause on Ailean's map of the shires and the one thing on it the town had already made true. Its first maor took the old human magistrate's house, which the town went on calling by its old name. In the fifteenth year Eilidh nic Leòid held her assize here in the heat of an t-Iuchar, heard nineteen causes to their ends and found fifteen for the Crown; the Coombes and the Pettifers kept their ground on a custodian's countersign. Its timber yard took the order for Àth leathan's props in the thirty-ninth year. Known for the broken lock, and the seventeen suits.

Cnoc bheag (Cnoc bheag). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908. A river town of the north-central country, heart of the Hawk's houses, whose altars answered to no custodian above them. In the sixth year the houses round it wrote to Seann Skell that the Rite's written order was handsome and not needed. The shire's arms carried a plain white billet from the fourth year for no reason any clerk could give, until the thirty-sixth, when a delegation of the Hawk houses asked for a hawk, and the maor broke the old die and pressed a white hawk among twelve crescents. An obelisk of unread script stands near it, which Una copied stroke by stroke in the thirty-second year and the council fenced against the cattle; its marks were laid beside those of the pillar at Cnoc chlar and the column at Cnoc ghorm by the students of Caol shean. By the forty-sixth year its river quays took in more grain in a season than the granaries of Cathair mhòr showed for a year. Known for the Hawk's country, the hawk on the seal, and the obelisk.

Cnoc chaol (Seann Vell). Founded 23 am Faoilleach, LE 167. A small town low on its shingle on the south coast, which gave its name to the Great Wave of the fourth year, Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol⁴. The water broke it in a single night before running on to Cuan dhearg and Achadh mhin. It was built again the following spring on the slope behind its old ground, high enough that the sea would have to climb a hill to trouble it a second time, and the old site was left as the water left it; the townsfolk call it an Tràigh Bhàthte⁵, the drowned strand, and do not build there. Its shepherds and those of Ros gharbh had summered their flocks time out of mind on the low island of Eilean mhin offshore, over which the wave also passed. Its houses were raised again faster than Ros gharbh's boats, a house wanting only hands and a boat wanting a builder. Known for the wave's name, and the drowned strand.

Cnoc fhiadhaich (Muileann chrom). Founded 17 am Màrt, LE 488. A town below the spoil-heaps of old coal galleries, never levelled, on the mountain where the council would not end the working of the vein by day and night. When coal-fuel doubled in price at the fair in the seventieth year, households of the town took to picking coal off the heaps to burn in their own grates, and in the seventy-first year the Board posted watchmen over the heaps. The watchmen were men of the town, and every night of the posting they saw nothing, though the heaps grew lower and the poorer grates burned warmer than the fair's price could have bought. Known for the watchmen who saw nothing.

Cnoc ghorm (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 15 am Dàmhair, GE 1,362. A market town of the northern coast, nearer the shire's seat than Baile chrom and twelve miles from it. In the ninth year the north raised here the largest church it had built since the crossing closed, its stone hauled from a quarry two shires south on carts the Moot paid for by subscription, and in its tower hung the bell of the old chapel at Ros bheag, crated in a barn since the first spring; it rang first on a market morning and carried to the shore road. The next year the church opened a school for its priests, with a master from Seann Skell. A thin blessing of the boats was kept here each spring, and after Seann Bhrall refused the north in the twenty-fifth year Mary Coyle made it the full Fleadh na Mara⁶: more than fifty boats came on the second Sunday of an Gearran in the twenty-sixth year, blessed with heather dipped in harbour water, and David Hale counted them. The Carters' Road runs through it south to Àth fhada. Known for the church of the Ros bheag bell, and Fleadh na Mara.

4. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

5. the drowned strand at old Cnoc chaol

6. the northern feast of the sea at Cnoc ghorm

Cnoc leathan (Cnoc leathan). Founded 11 am Màrt, FE 172. A shire of the east. On the twenty-first day of an Giblean in the fiftieth year it opened a school in every one of its six parishes, the first shire on the island to do so entire and out of its own dues rather than the Moot's purse or a guild's charity. The last and smallest opened with eleven children and a teacher hired from Baile Chiar, who had never taught so few; within two years the benches held twenty and she stayed past her term. The council sent a clerk to ask how a shire so far from its notice had found the coin, and was shown plain accounts in a plain hand, the dues that would have gone to a road never built turned to six rooms and six teachers, and asked nothing further. Known for the six parish schools.

Cnoc thais (Cnoc thais). Founded 19 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328. A pit town of the western hills, where Tuathaich hewers worked under the Board's overseers and scales. When the overseers left in the sixty-eighth year with the closing of the Àth leathan branch, the pits passed to the hewers, and they chose to keep the accounts Sam Varley, four-and-fifty, who had kept a private tally beside the Board's scale for eleven years. He opened a book of the pit's own accounts headed only with the day and the pit's name, the earliest page of the town's register of its pits, and his small son Tom carried the figures between the scale-house and his table. The carters who took Àth leathan's first coal to Seann Bhral by road passed through it. Known for the register of the pits.

Cuan bheag (Caol mhòr). Founded 10 am Màrt, SE 17. A Tuathaich fishing harbour of the north coast. On the second night of an t-Sultain in the nineteenth year a westerly drowned eleven men of seven of its boats, Thomas Coyle of Caol mhòr among them; the sea gave back two broken hulls and a stranger's oar. The town had no lifeboat. Mary Coyle wrote the eleven names on one sheet for the mason in the order the boats went out, and the Moot opened a subscription the same week; the lifeboat, white-painted with cork along her gunwales, came up the coast from Cuan shean in an Cèitean of the twentieth year and was put into the water off the town's jetty by that autumn's five widows. Its boats sailed with Mary Coyle to Seann Bhral in the twenty-fifth year, and its fishermen walked to Walter Hale's burial. Known for the eleven drowned, and the lifeboat.

Cuan dhearg (Seann Vell). Founded 31 am Faoilleach, FE 1,384. The larger harbour of the south coast struck by Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol⁷ in the fourth year. The wave broke its mole and carried its boats inland, so that when Ailean mac Iain came with the relief party the boats of the town lay among the barley and the harbour was gone. Its dead were carried up onto the rise behind the town, above the old harbour line, and buried through that first fortnight in ground the sea had not reached. The Crown paid a third of the relief, the first time it had paid for anyone's loss. The town righted what boats it could and went back to fishing before the winter closed in. A generation later, in the twenty-seventh year, the harbour was opened again behind a new mole of dressed stone, and of the hulls the wave had cast into the fields one was found sound, caulked, and warped into the new harbour ahead of every boat built for it; the harbour-master keeps it moored at the quay-head as a relic. Known for the boats in the barley, and the boat kept for a relic.

7. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

Cuan ruadh (Cuan ruadh). Founded 1 an t-Sultain, GE 2,387. A town far up the eastern coast, past even Seann Dunn, which had none of the five lighthouses the humans left the kingdom to keep. It had a mole built in the humans' time for a fleet larger than the one that used it. After two boats were lost on the harbour rocks in a winter fog, its council voted in the twenty-third year to burn a light on the end of the mole with coal bought out of the town's own purse. It asked the Lighthouse Board to take the light on, and the Board wrote back that its charter named five lights and no more, and that the town's light, being no charge on the Crown, might continue as it was; the chronicler entered the refusal in four lines. The light burned on the town's coal. When the coal line shut in the thirty-fourth year the town lived on its stored coal. Known for the light on the mole.

Cuan shean (Cuan shean). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,755. The harbour of the west coast where the first humans came ashore generations before; a stone laid into the quay near the harbour-master's steps, worn nearly smooth, is still touched by children for luck. Households were walked north out of it under guard in the first year. An Sireadh⁸ sailed from it on the eleventh of an t-Ògmhios in the third year under Aonghas mac Mhurchaidh, a Cuan shean man, to seek the crossing north-about. Seumas Crùbach kept his shipwright's yard here, building frame first, and took Harry Marlow of Doire mhin on as a bound apprentice; when the guild charter reached the coast in the fourteenth year he tore the boy's indenture and kept him as a free hand at half wage, and other yards took up the rate. Harry measured a derelict human hull on the hard in his own book. The Cuan bheag lifeboat was built in its yard. Known for the first landing-stone, and Harry Marlow's torn indenture.



Doire ghlas (Doire ghlas). Founded 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470. An inland town of the northern moss, on rush pasture the settled households were given because the better land nearer the coast was claimed. It buried more of its own in the first hungry winter than any town of the north, and its dead were named on a sheet in the church porch before the Moot had a book to name them in. Meal was carried to it from Caol mhòr on carts that sank to the hubs. In the fifteenth year Agnes Pike opened her school in a widow's byre here, with eleven scholars and no primer but the psalms and the Moot's minutes, and moved it to the church porch each summer; Daniel Frayne walked in to it daily from Muileann leathan. Its weavers wove An Snàthainn Geal¹, the white thread, into their cloth, and sold under their own mark from the fifty-fifth year. The wool mills raised here with the Moot's coin turned their first bolt in the fifty-ninth year, and the Rail Board's refusal to carry it brought the suit at Seann Bhrál. Known for Agnes Pike's byre school and the white thread.

8. the seeking

1. the white thread

Doire mhin (Caol mhòr). Founded 3 an Giblean, FE 2,743. A small inland town of the north, where the Pike family had ground grain since before the Severance and the smith Joseph Marlow kept his forge. When the humans' coin was cried down in the fifth year, half the town brought its dead coin to Marlow, and he melted it and cast it into ploughshares and sold them back at the cost of the charcoal; the first furrow of that spring was cut with one of them by the last day of am Màrt. Walter Hale walked ten miles through snow to see it. The Tuathaich sang of Marlow after, that he turned the king's silence into iron and the iron into bread. The Moot took seed oats from the town's mill on credit in the first hungry year. Marlow's son Harry went from the forge to a shipwright's yard at Cuan shean, and sent his wage home each year; Agnes Pike, who opened the byre school at Doire ghlas, was a miller's daughter of the town. Known for Joseph Marlow's ploughshares.

Doire shean (Doire shean). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 695. A harbour town of the south-west on the road between Cathair dhomhain and Seann Bhrál, where Eilidh nic Leòid's circuit passed. A grave-list from the town was among the first papers the chronicler copied fair, and a wedding there went into the chronicle beside Brighde's death. In the thirtieth year it built its own harbour, the first raised anywhere in the kingdom since the Severance without a coin of the Crown's in it, the house of the Stone lending against the town's dues and the masons building the mole to the Stone's measure; the house took its first quarter's dues off the quay before the last course was dry. A fishing boat of the town struck the reef below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg² in the fifty-fourth year, and the keeper Artair mac Mhurchaidh drowned bringing in her crew; the town's fishing families paid half the reef bell that followed. Known for the harbour built on the Stone's loan.

Dùn chrom (Dùn chrom). Founded 7 am Faoilleach, GE 2,801. A walled town of some size on the road east out of Cathair dhearg, its citadel old and its market square older. Oighrig nic Mhathain kept the weighing-scales of its market nine years and caught short weight better-paid men missed, until in the twenty-first year the council's eastern factor made her tollmistress of the new fair at Muileann òg; she left her scales to a niece she had trained two summers. The carpenters of the town roofed the fair's court, a plain frame open on three sides, a fortnight before the first fair. In am Faoilleach of the twenty-second year the last stretch of the fair's road was metalled past the town, and the toll taken at its gate built a new wall along its southern side by an Lùnastal, which the townsfolk called the fair's wall and the carters called by their own name for the gate. Known for Oighrig's scales, and the fair's wall.

Dùn dhearg (Dùn dhearg). Founded 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274. A town of the hill and moor country where the search for a second vein began. In the fifty-first year the first of Alasdair mac Ùisdein's shafts went down on the rise above it in stone that gave every hopeful sign, and was judged barren within the fortnight; a dozen of the forty-one dry shafts were sunk on its hills. An old digger of the town, who had cut peat there as a boy, told Catrìona nic Neacail that the shepherds called the ground am Fearann Falamh³, the empty ground. In the fifty-second year the town brought its claim for spoiled grazing to the circuit court, two shepherds swearing that the search cost them more lambs in two years than wolves had in ten, and the court found for the town; the house of Mac Ùisdein let its stone hall to meet the damages. A Holy Age survey in the Library had named the same hills searched and barren long before. Known for the first of the forty-one shafts.

2. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

3. the empty ground

Dùn thais (Dùn thais). Founded 28 am Màrt, GE 2,473. The Dùn thais of the east, seat of its own shire and its own dues; the other town of the name lies on the west coast. In the thirty-eighth year it raised at the shire's own charge a long timbered covered market for the hill farms that had traded in its square uncovered since the town was walled, and its first trading was held under a roof that smelled more of new-cut wood than of the grain it sheltered. A clerk at Cathair dhearg filed its petition and the western town's against the one name, and the royal record confused the two for ten years until Tormod Pinn ruled a line through the record marking them west and east. Known for the covered market.

Dùn thais (Ros bheag). Founded 23 an Gearran, FE 2,142. The Dùn thais of the west coast, within a morning's ride of Ros bheag; there are two towns of the name, and the record keeps them apart as west and east. Its fishermen settled salvage among themselves by custom until a wrecked raider's hulk driven ashore proved too rich a prize for custom to divide, and in the thirty-seventh year the town was granted a court of the sea of its own to judge salvage and wreck along its shore. At its first sitting, held on the strand, the court awarded the hulk whole to the crews who drove it aground. For ten years the royal record confused its court with the eastern town's market, until Tormod Pinn marked the two west and east in the forty-eighth year. Known for the court of the sea.

I

Inis àrsaidh (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 28 an t-Sultain, FE 242. A town of the north-western coast whose harbour officers sailed with the last ships and took their keys with them. In the second year its people opened the locked harbour store after Ceann mhòr and Cathair gheal did, and it is told that three women of the town drew up a reckoning of what was taken and by whom, so that the sharing could be answered for if anyone ever came to ask; no maor came. The old Carters' Road runs down to it from Cnoc ghorm and Àth fhada, and the wool trains of the forty-first year crossed the flooded low ground short of it in a cold rain, the carts finding their own way round the water. A household at a crossing near it kept one of the three lamps that lit the road by night. In the fifty-third year An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn¹ pitched on the common near the town, and its magistrate licensed the acts as various, the fee paid. Known for the three women's reckoning, and the circus licensed as various.

1. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

Inis bhàn (Inis bhàn). Founded 16 an Giblean, GE 3,916. A town on the Abhainn iséal in the north-central country, a river port of store-houses. In the twenty-ninth year fire took its warehouse quarter, three storehouses and a dozen dwellings above them, and burned two days before the town beat it back street by street with buckets and wet sacking and a chain of hands to the river; no one died. The town's Hawk house, which had never taken in households outside those sworn to it, sheltered every family the fire put out of a roof, sworn or not, through the spring cold. The council bought the town a bell from the founders' yard at Cathair dhearg to stand where the old warehouse bell burned, and rang it once on the quay before it was hung; by the town's own telling it is heard further up and down the river than any bell in the kingdom. Known for the fire and the loudest bell.

Inis bheag (Inis bheag). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,435. A parish of the island's north-east, whose Seann Spioradan house keeps a parish roll that names its households back before the coming of the humans, older than any book the south's forty chests gave up to the first chronicle circuit. In the nineteenth year the old keeper heard the circuit clerks' warrant once, without asking it twice, and let the roll be copied at his own table under his own eye, but would not let the book travel so much as to the harbour, telling them a book kept that many generations belonged to the house and not to any seal. The copy went to Muileann chaol; the book stayed. Known for the parish roll copied and not carried.

Inis chrom (Inis chrom). Founded 25 an Giblean, FE 1,601. A harbour town of the south-west coast. On the twenty-third day of am Màrt in the fiftieth year a storm tide came into its lower town and drowned the net-lofts and the rope-walk. The town did not ask the Crown for the rebuilding: its own carpenters raised both a second time on driven piles a fathom above the old floor, with timber floated down the Abhainn ghorm from the woods above Àth gharbh, and the work was finished before the autumn herring. The lofts stand so now, and the town's own telling of it is that the sea taught it once what it would not trouble to teach twice. Known for the lofts on piles.

Inis iséal (Cnoc bheag). Founded 9 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,060. A town of the Hawk country in Siorrachd Cnoc bheag, whose altar Raonaid nic Iain's mother's mother kept before her. In an Cèitean of the thirty-fifth year the Hawk houses met in its hall and named Raonaid custodian of their own by standing up house by house, and Murchadh Ruadh gave her a white feather kept three generations in his house. The letter from Seann Skell refusing to own her was read once in the hall and put away, not burned. Here she wrote the Hawk's spoken order into a farm account-book, read it aloud once at the full moon of an t-Samhain, and locked it in the iron box that had held the altar's lamp-oil, wearing the key on a cord under her shawl. The shire's new seal of a white hawk was brought to it in the thirty-sixth year. Known for the Hawk's own custodian.

Inis mhin (Inis mhin). Founded 5 an Lùnastal, FE 2,644. A Tuathaich fishing harbour of the far north coast; boats were promised from its country to the second Fleadh na Mara² at Cnoc ghorm. In the seventieth year, when the east-coast boats came north to the grounds the licence law kept for them and crowded the Tuathaich boats off the grounds nearest home, its boats took to the deep water beyond the northern isles, which no boat of that coast had fished in living memory for its roughness and the distance a crew had to keep from land. Two were lost the first year and none after, and before the next season was out its catch had passed Caol mhòr's. Known for the deep water beyond the northern isles.

Inis thais (Inis thais). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 2,408. A harbour town of the south-west coast, where the new coin was slower to come than almost anywhere in the kingdom. Its merchants did not wait on the mint: through the sixth year they traded in chits written on the paper of the house of the Stone, whose name was old enough and trusted enough to stand in for coin, and when the coin came the chits were redeemed at the house's door, the house keeping back a tenth. A Ros bheag trader told Walter Hale that a tenth kept back by a name a man trusted was cheaper than a savings box kept by a name he did not. A Stone priest of the town heard the first reading of the Rite's written order. Its harbour court was well enough kept that the circuit justice's sitting there in the eighth year was brief. Known for the Stone's chits.



Muileann chaol (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,218. A town east of the mountain, where the town's own custodians had kept rolls and bound books since before the Severance on planks above standing water in a cellar under the old grain-store. In the sixteenth year the council founded the Library here and named Ailean mac Iain, Ailean Leabhar, its first keeper; the council's minute-books and the humans' tithe ledgers came east to it, the copyists turned its dates into the civil calendar, and its keepers opened Leabhar nan Sloinnidhean¹, Leabhar nan Aithrisean² and the table of the ages, counting the Age of Ailean apart. The royal chronicler kept her seat here from the eighteenth year rather than at the capital. The town was given a market charter in the seventeenth year, its first fair held in the Library's yard. Ailean was buried in a small ground behind the Library in the fortieth year, and Mòrag nic Coinnich kept it thirty years after, calling in the shire chests and building the new wing with its empty fourth floor. A chur san Leabharlann, to put it in the Library, was first said here. Known for the Library.

2. the northern feast of the sea at Cnoc ghorm

1. the book of lines

2. the book of tellings

Muileann chrom (Muileann chrom). Founded 11 an Gearran, FE 1,556. The shunting town where the line from the Sloc Mòr meets the older line down to the ports. The council mended the coal line as far as it in the eighth year and no further, and the humans' own timetable, copied fair, was hung on a board at its terminus. The Rail Board laid new sidings here in the thirteenth year, and the shunting families, who had worked the humans' small engines, were counted apart on a roll of their own and housed in the rows nearest the lines; in the twenty-fourth year the rows had more children born than they had cradles for, among them Seachran and Breatan. Calum mac Aonghais, called Calum Ruadh, a hewer of the town, won the first Còmhrag. When the Abhainn iséal took the embankment in the thirty-fourth year the Moot sent it coal from the north. In the sixty-third year its yard families stopped the coal trains three days over a cut wage, with Dòmhnall Ruadh mac Ailein as their spokesman; the wage was restored and eleven men dismissed. Known for the shunting rows and the stopped trains.

Muileann dhearg (Muileann dhearg). Founded 30 an t-Sultain, LE 2. A town of narrow streets and spoil-stone chapels five miles from the great shaft, grown fat on the Sloc Mòr's overflow and working its own pits to keep the greater mine's yield steady. It took the most of the hungry families who came to the vein in the twelfth year, and its old druid hall was cut into lodgings over ground the Board had to mark as sound or not. The Rite's house here sent the old custodian who blessed the first train. It sent the largest company to the first Còmhrag. The Cill ghlas district under it, shut since the Rending of the humans' time, was reopened by the Board; on the first day of an t-Iuchar in the thirty-ninth year its galleries fell and thirty-one men died, and they were buried in a single ground at the edge of the town's yard, the custodian reading over each grave. By the fifty-seventh year its maor counted above sixty houses empty; its Fèidh hall, given back to the druid school, was locked by its last teacher, and its bell sold to Caol shean. Known for the fall of the thirty-one.

Muileann dhomhain (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,747. A mill town south-east of the capital, where the grain of three shires had gone to be ground since before the humans came, its miller-families' mark cut into a millstone before any shire kept a chest for a charter. In the fifty-third year, with the vein-towns' grain orders thinned by scarce coin, the mills began for the first time in any keeper's memory to grind bark for the tanners of the coast instead of grain, and the families kept their mark and changed the trade under it without asking the Board's leave. The eldest miller, a woman near seventy, told a passing clerk that a wheel does not know what is under it, and that the grain would come back once the vein-towns had coin to buy it. Known for the mills that turned to bark.

Muileann fhionn (Caol mhòr). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, AE 23. The mill-town the humans built to watch the northern landing and left to whoever wanted the keeping of it. In the ninth year it was granted a market right for the inland country of the north-west, the second such right any northern town had been given, and the carpenters spent most of a month laying hurdles on the old common green, where mill hands had played ball, to pen the first market's beasts. The Tuathaich drovers of the hill farms, who had walked their stock the long way south, brought them here on set days instead, and from here the droves went on south by the old tracks to Ceann leathan; by midsummer the green stood full every market day and the innkeepers let every room. The vigil-keepers of the Grey Night answered to nobody south of it, and carters driving in from it heard the Cnoc ghorm bell before they saw the tower. Known for the cattle-market on the green.

Muileann leathan (Muileann leathan). Founded 24 an Giblean, GE 1,610. A weaving town of the northern moss, close enough across the moor from Doire ghlas that a boy could walk it before the school bell finished. Its householders came to the first sitting of the Moot. Daniel Frayne was a fisherman's son of the town and walked from it daily to Agnes Pike's byre in the fifteenth year; he kept a bindery here from the forty-eighth year on a mended cider-press, teaching young Tuathaich hands a craft the southern guilds would not, and bound the Moot's registers and Muileann shean's primers at his bench. The wool trains of the forty-first year set out from it for Muileann òg by the Carters' Road. The register of the hurt was bound here, and its second copy kept at a house in the town that no southern search ever troubled. The Rail Board's factors here refused the Doire ghlas mill's wagon in the fifty-ninth year and weighed its first bale onto the line in the sixtieth. Known for Daniel Frayne's bindery.

Muileann mhin (Muileann mhin). Founded 20 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,458. The lamp-making town of the vein country, whose forges turned out the greater part of every shaft-lamp the pits burned. Its lamp-makers were chartered as a guild in the fourteenth year, and set their mark, a flame struck over a hammer, on every lamp that left their sheds, so that the lamp carried the record of where it was made and under what oath; of all the guild marks the humans' traders had copied this one only. The carters of the coal line complained at every siding between it and Muileann chaol when, in the sixty-second year, the lamp-makers halved their making for want of coal to fire their forges, the coal reaching the town thinner and dearer each season. Shaft-lamps were lent from pit to pit after that, and the Guild of Hewers kept a minute-book of who lent to whom. Known for the flame over the hammer.

Muileann naomh (Muileann naomh). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, GE 2,986. The southernmost of the Hawk's houses, close by the coast and far south of Cnoc bheag. It did not wait on the reading: in the sixth year it sent word to Seann Skell that it would take the Rite's written order entire, whatever it proved to be, and hung in its doorway a bell cast new for the purpose, the first bell any hawk-house had hung, to ring at the Rite's measured burnings. It rang it that summer at the burning of the year before a small crowd in the lane. Dòmhnall mac Thor-moid wrote to it in his own hand, the first letter of thanks he composed in his office, and sent it a last copy of the order made with more care than any other. It became a house of Òrd Bhrìde³, the one hawk-house of its kind. Known for the first bell hung in a hawk-house.

3. the order of Bride's flame

Muileann shean (Muileann shean). Founded 1 an t-Samhain, FE 1,093. A town of the northern pits. In the fifty-ninth year, when the Guild of Hewers had bound no apprentices for two years, its maor opened a school for the sons and daughters of hewers the guild would not bind, to teach them to read, to reckon and to survey, reasoning that a hewer's child shut out of the pit might follow his father's trade from the surface with a chain in place of a pick. He wrote for primers to Daniel Frayne, who bound forty copies at his own bench and sent them north on the first cart. The benches passed thirty within the year, though several of the first pupils had already gone south to the ports to hire as chain-hands. Known for the school of hewers' children.

R

Ros bheag (Ros bheag). Founded 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274. A harbour of the west coast where Walter Hale clerked the humans' harbour office twenty years before the crossing closed. In the first year the council shut the humans' chapel here for good and carted its bell north, and households were walked north out of the town under guard; the bell hung at last in Cnoc ghorm's tower. Agnes Pike copied herding and salt tallies in its harbour agent's office for a dozen years. Its harbour would not give Mary Coyle's eleven boats its quay in the twenty-fifth year and sent them to a mooring buoy off the point. In the thirty-sixth year a coal-ship yard was opened here, and the eldest masters of Ros dhomhain lost their protest against it before the guild court. Known for Walter Hale's harbour, and the chapel bell.

Ros dhomhain (Ros dhomhain). Founded 19 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,694. The harbour below the capital on the lake shore, whose counting-house had come through the war with its shelves whole and whose garrison marched out under terms. In the third year Dùghall mac Iain took the humans' harbour-houses into the kingdom's keeping, and Ailean mac Iain spent eight months copying the humans' tariff out of eleven bound ledgers into Dia-thiris, saying exactly the old thing in the new tongue; the old tariff stood until the mint gave the council coin to take dues in. Its shipwrights took a guild charter in the fourteenth year and its guild court refused a Tuathaich rope-maker's plea in a single sitting. A shipwright of the town was the first name in the Library's reading-book. Its harbour clerk's corrected copy of Brighde's crowning proclamation, Niall's name scored through, hangs under glass at the gate. In the thirty-sixth year its eldest masters lost their protest against Ros bheag's coal-ship yard before the guild court. Known for the tariff copied fair, and the proclamation under glass.

Ros gheal (Ros gheal). Founded 29 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,009. A fishing town of the north-central coast. In the twenty-fourth year it gave over its whole spring to a dock long enough to take three grain-ships abreast, for the Hawk country had begun to send its barley and oats down by water rather than by cart. The Hawk houses blessed the dock and asked a tithe of its dues; the shire's factor haggled them down to a twentieth and paid it, and has paid it every quarter since, so that the clerks of the town call the due simply the Hawk's and few of them can say why a fishing town owes a grain due to a bird that flies inland. Northern boats that landed fish at the new dock paid the same twentieth out of the Moot's harbour purse, which Mary Coyle raised in the Moot the first night she stood up to speak. Known for the grain dock and the Hawk's twentieth.

Ros mhòr (Caol mhòr). Founded 15 an t-Ògmhios, LE 432. A harbour of the northern coast, deep enough for a hull of any size the north was likely to want and far enough from the southern yards that no guild master troubled to ride up and ask under what charter it worked. Its boats sailed with Mary Coyle to Seann Bhral in the twenty-fifth year, and its fishermen walked to Walter Hale's burial. In am Faoilleach of the forty-first year the Tuathaich shipwrights turned out of the southern guild yards came together here to lay a keel on the open strand, Harry Marlow cutting it to the humans' old lines, low and full in the bow; the hull went up on evenings and Sabbaths, and by an Cèitean of the forty-second year there was a shed over the slip and the place was called a yard. Its first hull took the water clean, swifter than anything the south had launched in a long season. Known for the northern boatyard.

S

Seann Bhral (Seann Bhral). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, VE 1,005. The Seann Bhral of the southern coast, not the older town of the name in the west, which is a different town and always has been. In the twenty-fourth year it passed Ros dhomhain in the weight of fish landed and became the greatest fishing port of the kingdom; its curing-sheds, which had been four, became eleven and ran the whole length of the harbour, so that a stranger walking it after dark could follow the smell of the smoke from end to end. Fish from it went up to the capital through Ceann mhin's covered market. In the sixty-first and sixty-second years the three great pumps of the Sloc Mòr came to it by rail from above Achadh dhomhain to drain its new dry dock. Known for the curing-sheds, and the Sloc Mòr's pumps.

Seann Bhral (Baile àrsaigh). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, VE 196. The Seann Bhral of the west, on its harbour with the mud flats grey below the town wall and a scorpion carved over the old counting-house door that no one living can account for. Here on the ninth of an t-Sultain in the eighth year Eilidh nic Leòid gave the Leòid ruling, that land held under human title passes to the Crown and the working of it stays with the holders; it was cited in nearly every land case after. The western branch of the coal line was carried to it in the thirteenth year. Its house of Manannan, reckoned the oldest on the coast, turned away Mary Coyle's eleven boats in the twenty-fifth year: the sea was the same, the house was not. Ruairidh mac Phàdraig ruled here in the fifty-ninth year that the Rail Board is a carrier of the Crown and must carry for any who pay, the first ruling the Moot won. Àth leathan's hewers sent their coal to its factors by cart from the sixty-ninth year. Known for the Leòid ruling, and the ruling on the Rail Board.

Seann Dunn (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 5 an Cèitean, VE 642. A town of the east coast, past the last of the shires the Crown garrisoned closely, below which the Abhainn chaol meets the sea. The houses of the Seann Spioradan there had never had a hall of their own, only the hearth of whichever family kept the year's rite. In the twenty-second year forty households raised a common hall in a single season, working the stone by day, and roofed it before the first frost; it holds no image or carving, only two hearths. At its first naming forty heads of houses spoke the names of their dead, one old woman of the town reciting nine generations before her son finished the tenth, and the chronicler Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill rode east to watch. From the next year the hall sent the Library a copy of its naming every year, a little longer each time. In the sixty-eighth and sixty-ninth years the herring did not come to the grounds off the river mouth, and the town's boats went north. Known for the ancestors' hall.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 29 am Faoilleach, GE 2,664. The Seann Skell of the southern coast, not the harbour of the west, where the Rite's greatest house stands in a hall with blackened beams. In the sixth year Dòmhnall mac Thormoid was seated here as the first high custodian of Òrd Bhrìde¹, and here he wrote the Rite's first order of worship, read aloud near the end of am Faoilleach to eleven custodians and a scattering of hearth-keepers and a Stone priest; he kept every letter the Rite sent or received in a plain ledger. From here went the copies of the order, and the refusals came back to it: the Hawk houses' letter of the sixth year and, in the thirty-fifth, the three-line letter refusing to own Raonaid nic Iain. In the forty-seventh year its council read the Hawk houses of Cnoc bheag their terms a seventh time, and they stood. Known for the high custodian's house and the order of worship.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173. The humans' great harbour of the west, on the coast below the capes, where the fishing fleets still came in under a flag they had never learned to read and the old harbour bell rang the hours by a humans' clock. In the second year Ailean mac Iain found in its counting-house eleven district surveys behind a locked grating, every field about the town walked and numbered, and boxed them apart for the council; from them the shires were drawn. An Sireadh² came home to its quay in the third year after sixteen days north-about and no land, and the priests of Manannan said over her return the prayer they had said over her going, that the sea be kept shut. Its innkeeper told Ailean of Niall's crowning. The ship lay careened here that winter. It is not the Seann Skell of the southern coast, where the Rite's high custodian sits, and the record keeps the two apart as west and south. Known for the district surveys, and An Sireadh's berth.

Seann Tarr (Muileann bheag). Founded 30 an Cèitean, VE 884. A town of the northern coast where the coal line does not run, whose ropewalks take their hemp from the fields about Doire uaine and Achadh naomh by cart roads older than the survey lines. In the fifty-third year the restored custom chartered its ropemakers as a guild, the last trade the humans never touched to be given a charter of its own. Asked to send the charter south to be filed, the shire keeper answered that it would stay in the shire's own chest, as every paper of the shire had stayed since the chest was locked, and sent south a list of what the chest held and no more. When the Library called in the shire chests in the sixty-sixth year the old keeper, who had held the key since before Mòrag nic Coinnich was born, burned the chest rather than send it, met the clerks at the gate the next morning with the smoke still on his coat, and paid the council's fine without argument or apology. It is the one shire record of the calling-in the Library never read. Known for the chest that was burned.

Seann Toll (Seann Toll). Founded 8 an t-Samhain, VE 1,033. A town of the north that sent its chest to the Library willingly in the sixty-seventh year and asked, as no shire before it had, for a copy of everything the chest held to be returned. Mòrag nic Coinnich's clerks made the copy, a full transcription bound in the same hand and set beside the original before either left the shire's hall, and the shire's copy became the pattern every later copy the Library made was cut to. Known for the pattern copy.

1. the order of Brìde's flame

2. the seeking

Seann Vell (Ros dhomhain). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, GE 3,560. A town of the capital shore. In the twenty-seventh year its glass-houses, which had lately begun blowing small flasks, found a trade no one had planned for them: the women of the town filled the flasks with waters they distilled themselves from bog-myrtle and meadowsweet and heather honey and sold them by the dozen, and within a few years scent was sold in every market town. A cloth trader out of the town, putting in at Cuan shean, offered Harry Marlow a northern passage in the fourteenth year, which Harry refused. Two of its masons drove and cemented the iron reef post at Tobar dhearg for Ciorstaidh nic Artair in the fifty-fifth year, working only the hour either side of the ebb. The glass-houses still stand, and the scent trade still runs from them. Known for the scent-makers' flasks.

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Tobar dhìreach (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 42. A village a few miles from the Library, on the stream below it. In the eighteenth year a family of millers who had not grain enough to keep three wheels busy built a paper-mill here instead, and the Library's copyists spoke of its first sheets before they had them in hand. Forty quires of its paper went up to Muileann chaol on a borrowed cart, better and cheaper, the copyists judged, than anything the council's stationers had sent, and within the year near enough every sheet the Library used came from the one stream; nearly every page of the royal chronicle in this age is written on its paper. The road east past it smells of wet paper before the mill comes in sight. Known for the paper-mill.